Fire Lily

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Fire Lily

by EtherealBeing

Summary

There he was: sitting splay-legged on the altar, one muddy combat boot propped up on the edge, with a self-satisfied grin on his face and a relaxed aura, in spite of the war raging outside.

Izuku wasn't sure what he'd expected to see his first day evacuating humans from the Rapture zone, but it sure as hell wasn't a *Demon* with the same goal.

A story about falling, in more ways than one.

Podfic

- Translation into Русский available: [Restricted Work] by Dnt_Strv

Chapter 1: Red Light

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Beneath the early morning sun, the church exterior was a treasure. The orange light remade the structure in rich, golden shades, with stained glass windows like glittering gems. Once he'd landed, Izuku stopped for a moment to gaze at the building in awe, silently cataloging each detail. It was truly magnificent. The top of the steeple had been broken off in all the chaos, but Izuku was sure that, had it still been there, it could've pierced straight through to Heaven.

The sound of an explosion from the east broke him out of his reverie, and Izuku hastily moved toward the church, folding his wings down against his back as he went. As much as he'd like to take his time admiring the building's architecture, he had a job to do, one he'd sworn to carry out. Still, as Izuku brushed his fingers along the engravings of the church's vast, arched doorway, he couldn't help but feel a sense of loss. In all likelihood, this was the last time he'd get to see it. The church, like all beautiful things, would be engulfed in flames soon enough.

Izuku put his hand on the doorknob and took one last breath before entering the building.

Inside the church, dozens of heads immediately popped up from behind the pews, their eyes widening as they looked at him. After the initial shock, many of them bowed their heads in silent reverence, though most still seemed tense, like they weren't quite sure what the appropriate protocol was, when in the presence of an Angel.

Izuku offered a reassuring smile. "Don't be afraid." He said. "I'm Dekiriel, a servant of God. I'm here to escort you all to the Kingdom of—"

"—Dekiriel?" A rough voice interjected. Izuku tensed. "The fuck kinda name is that? Sounds like one of those drugs they give to human kids to force 'em to sit still and pay attention."

Izuku quickly turned around, and paled at what he found.

Across the room, sitting splay-legged on the altar with one muddy combat boot proper up on the edge, was a Demon. *A freaking Demon.* Spiky blond hair, angular features and deep, red eyes that appeared luminescent even in the morning light. He wasn't fully shifted. Sharp, black horns peaked through his hair, a thin, pointed tail whipping around behind him. The Demon looked back at him and grinned, putting sharp, white canines on display. "You seem like you could use something like that."

For a moment, he simply gaped. This was not supposed to happen, or if it was, no one had told him about it. What the hell was he supposed to *do?* He couldn't fight him; he wasn't certified for that, yet. And even if he *could* fight him, what good would it do? The Demon was clearly above his level. It didn't take a genius to figure that out.

Izuku shook himself. *The humans.* He thought, *Remember the humans.* He steeled his expression and turned to face him head on.

“What business do you have here, Demon?” He asked, voice steady, yet cautious.

“I don’t have to answer that.” He shot back. “And don’t call me fuckin’ *Demon,* asshole, it’s *Katsuki.”*

“You *do* have to answer that. You’re trespassing on God’s property.”

“Trespassing? What’re you, a fuckin’ *cop?* “ He said, glaring. Then the expression dropped and he looked up in thought. “Well, actually yeah, guess you basically are.”

“What did you do to these people?” Izuku demanded.

“Do to them? I didn’t do *shit.”* The Demon hopped off the altar, and Izuku instinctively put his barrier up. “It’s *your* fault they’re scared. You’re the ones who fed them all that fucking fear-mongering bullshit about us.” He went down the steps and began a leisurely stroll down the aisle.

“Just tell me why you’re here!”

The Demon, Katsuki, rolled his eyes.

“Same reason you’re here, Deku.”

“It’s *Dekiriel.”* Izuku sternly replied. “And I *highly* doubt that.”

“God, you assholes never change.” He muttered. “Look, if y’don’t believe me, why don’t you just do your little magic trick and see for yourself, huh? You *can* do that, right? I doubt God’s so big an idiot that he’d send some incompetent little dweeb down here.”

Izuku stared back at him for a moment.

“Well? Are you gonna fucking do it, or what?” Katsuki asked. “Here, I’ll even repeat myself for you. I’m here for the same reason you are, Deku. Evacuation.”

Izuku activated his Persentiscence as he met the Demon’s eyes.

He was telling the truth.

Izuku gaped at him, not quite able to believe it. He must’ve screwed things up. He was still a rookie, after all; he’d never attempted to use the power on a Demon before.

“Y’still don’t believe me, do you?” Katsuki said, monotone. He sighed. “You get your power from God, right?” He said, stepping closer, until there were only about three feet between them. “You really have so little faith in him?”

“It’s not that.” Izuku said. “I just… I mean, I thought—“

“What, you thought your powers were malfunctioning?” He snorted. “Y’wanna try turning it off and on again?”

Izuku stared at him for a moment. He loathed to admit it, but he was right. For whatever reason, Katsuki was, indeed, telling the truth. Izuku wasn’t foolish enough to believe his intentions to be benevolent, of course, but so long as he wasn’t interfering with his duties, he figured it’d be best not to press him any further.

He sighed.

“I have a job to do.” He said. “I’ll deal with *you* later.”

The Demon raised his eyebrows mockingly. “Sure,” he snorted. “We’ll see how that goes.”

Izuku narrowed his eyes, but proceeded nonetheless. Turning back to the humans, he smiled reassuringly as he told them, “You have nothing to worry about. As long as I’m here, you’re safe.” The humans seemed to visibly relax. “Now, then.” He began again, “As I was saying before, I’m here to escort you all to the Kingdom of God. In return, I only need one thing from you.” He paced down the aisle. “When I reach you, I ask that you look me in the eyes and repeat the phrase I tell you, and when I offer my hand to you, you take it. Understand?” Everyone nodded.

Izuku then directed his attention toward a woman with dark hair, huddled up with two small children under her arms. He knelt in front of a girl no more than six years old, and offered a warm smile as she seemed to give him her full intention.

“Look into my eyes and repeat after me.” He said. “‘I am a child of God.’”

She looked up at him with big, blue eyes, and Izuku activated his Persentiscence. “I am a child of God.” She said.

And she was.

So Izuku extended his hand and waited for her to take it, and wrapped his fingers around her small hand with a grip both gentle and firm.

And within seconds, all that remained of her on this Earth was a pile of clothing on the floor.

Izuku proceeded in this manner, and remained quietly baffled at the fact that the Demon had been silent throughout the process, leaning against one of the pews somewhere off to the side. He didn’t dare question it, lest he jinx the whole thing, but he still kept an eye on him throughout the ritual, in case he were to try something. It wasn’t until the very end that the Demon finally decided to break his silence. By then only one man remained: A kind-faced man in his late forties.

Izuku smiled at him. “Repeat after me.” He said. “‘I am a man of God.’”

“I am a man of God.” He said.

And he was.

So Izuku held his hand out toward him, only to falter with the sound of the Demon's voice cut through the peaceful atmosphere.

"Him? *Really?"* He asked incredulously, strolling over with his hands shoved in his pockets. He clicked his tongue. "Yeah, I'd rethink that one, if I were you."

Izuku's eyes widened. "What on Earth are you talking about?"

"He's not a good person." Katsuki stated, as though it were the most obvious thing in the world.

Izuku gaped at him, but after a moment, he felt a sense of anger steadily beginning to bubble to the surface.

"And just what do you suppose makes you an authority on that?"

Katsuki quirked an eyebrow.

"Damn, they really don't teach you guys shit, huh?"

"About *what?"*

"Uh, basic Demonic abilities?" He sneered. "The term "insidious cryptospection" ring a bell? Or as I call it, the *shame* detector?"

"This man is not lying."

"I never said he was."

"Then I fail to see the issue, here." Izuku said, narrowing his eyes. "This man is a man of God. That's all there is to it."

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

"Seriously, is that *really* all that matters to you assholes? Obedience?" He scoffed. "So, what? Do you think believing in God and being a piece of shit are, like, fuckin' mutually exclusive properties?"

Izuku opened his mouth to respond, but no words came out.

Katsuki smirked, and took it as a cue to continue, beginning a casual stroll, slowly circling the man.

"Again, feel free to use your little magic trick on me if you don't believe me, but I'm not kidding. This guy's a piece of shit."

"You're gonna have to be more specific than that." Izuku spat.

"He beats his wife and kids." Katsuki announced. "Used to, anyway. Probably would still be doin' it, if not for the— well." He gestured toward a window, where towers of smoke could

be seen billowing on the horizon.

Izuku stared at him for what felt like hours, frozen in shock, unsure how to proceed. He activated his Persentiscence and looked the Demon in the eye.

He wasn't lying.

But he *had* to be, didn't he?

He turned his attention toward the man again.

"Sir, I'm going to need you to repeat after me, again." He said. "Say, 'I am a man of God.'"

"I am a man on God!" He replied emphatically, gazing into Izuku's eyes imploringly.

"You're an abusive piece of shit, actually." Katsuki interjected, and for a moment, Izuku saw a spark of fear in the man's eyes just before he turned toward Katsuki

"No, I'm a man of God! I'm a man of *faith!"*

"And you're *also* an abusive piece of shit, and not just to your family." Katsuki snarled, a dangerous glint in his eye as he stepped closer, towering over the man. His pointed tail whipped around behind him, cat-like pupils contracting to mere slits, exuding a perilous aura as he stared down at the man with a look that Izuku could only describe as complete and utter *revulsion.* "You think you deserve to be with them, now? That *they* deserve to be with *you?"* He sneered. "Why? One lifetime wasn't enough?"

The man abruptly turned back to Izuku.

"Please, he's lying!" He cried, face pale and panic-stricken. "I went to church every Sunday!"

That was true.

"I'm a man of God!"

That was true.

"I've lived a proper life!"

Izuku tensed.

"I've been good to others!"

That…

"I'm a good person!"

That was a lie.

Izuku stared at the man in silence, and deactivated his Persentiscence.

He didn’t need to hear any more from him.

He took a deep breath and exhaled slowly, trying to clear his head enough to consider his options. He almost wanted to laugh at the dry, cynical feeling rising inside him, because of course. Of *course* his very first time carrying out duties alone in the Rapture Zone he’d be forced to make a decision like this — because of a Demon, no less! The bitter irony of the situation hit him like the downpour of rain, soaking through his robes, so the mess would follow him wherever he went. Of course it had to happen this way, but Izuku was careful to keep his expression neutral.

As far as he knew, there weren't any explicit rules about refusing passage to a true believer, but the consequences for *any* failure to adhere to the guidelines, if discovered, could be severe.

Still, when he thought about the man’s wife and children, about the pain he’d be exposing them to if he were to let the man through… he couldn’t do it. Maybe there was something wrong with his Persentiscence, and this man wasn’t actually a man of God at all. It certainly seemed more likely than what the Demon was suggesting. But in either case, he still couldn’t do it, not in good conscience.

Izuku looked around the church, checking to make sure it was really just him, the man and Katsuki. It was.

No one would have to know.

Steeling himself, he turned toward Katsuki again.

“What will you do with him if I leave him here?” He asked carefully.

Both the man and the Demon seemed shocked. The man dropped to his knees and began pleading for mercy, but Izuku clenched his teeth and ignored it, staring into the Demon’s wide, glowing, red eyes, awaiting his response.

“Well?” He prompted.

Katsuki cleared his throat. “I mean, I’d just take him with me. It’s not my area really, but I can transport a few people on my own.”

Izuku nodded, side-eying the man, and suddenly realizing just how transparent he truly was as he knelt there, looking up at him with his hands clasped together, spewing empty words and promises he should’ve never had to make.

He couldn’t bare to look at him any longer.

“Alright.” He said, meeting Katsuki’s eyes. “I’ll leave that to you, then.”

“Seriously?” Katsuki raised his eyebrows.

“Yes.” Izuku nodded. “Believer or not, Heaven has no place for those who would seek to make it unsafe for others.”

Katsuki seemed speechless for a moment, but after a while, a grin spread across his face, and he laughed.

“You’re really somethin’ else, aren’tcha, Deku?”

“Not really.” Izuku muttered. “I would think anyone else would do the same, given the situation.

“That’s cute.” Katsuki shot back, sticking his hands in his pockets again as he strolled over to the man, now kneeling on the floor in shock. He lightly kicked him in his side. “Get up, dipshit. You’re comin’ with me.” The man didn’t move, just sat there with his head bowed, staring dejectedly at the floor. After a moment, Katsuki clicked his tongue and grabbed the back of the man’s shirt collar, yanking him up off the floor. “God, I gotta do fuckin’ everything around here.”

“No, please…” The man said, quiet and broken.

He scoffed. “Shut the fuck up, you heard the nerd.”

Nerd?

Izuku blinked several times in confusion, but opted not to say anything as Katsuki began dragging the man toward the door. It was only when he was turning the handle that Izuku gathered his thoughts enough to get one last word in.

“Wait!” He called out.

“What?”

“What…” He hesitated. “What’ll you do after this?”

Katsuki stared at him for a moment, then smirked.

“I don’t have to answer that.” He replied.

The sound of the door falling shut echoed within the church, and he was gone.

At the shrill cry of the whistle, Izuku shot into the air. With his arms firmly at his sides, he kept his gaze locked on the center of the first hoop, ensuring a clean goal as he cleared it. It was all muscle memory at this point. His body knew exactly what to do, those subtle shifts in his center of gravity which had once confounded him were now second nature. The wind whipped his hair as he picked up speed, body twisting and turning as he zigzagged through each ring. The last ones were always the trickiest, at least as far as accuracy was concerned. With ten hoops stacked vertically from the ground up, they sent you into a nose dive from start to finish, only made more intimidating due to the rings’ decreasing diameter, which forced you to pull your wings inward. As Izuku’s body torpedoed through those final hoops, he silently cursed himself as he felt the tips of his wings hit the last few rings, but he still managed to make the final, crucial landing, extending his wings as soon as he cleared the last hoop and twisting his body upright just before his feet touched the ground.

“Thirty-six-point-eight seconds,” The instructor announced. “Forty-six out of fifty. Up next, Iida!”

Izuku quickly stumbled off the landing block, panting as he moved to rejoin Uraraka on the sidelines.

“You beat your record,” she said, patting his shoulder.

Izuku offered a small, sheepish smile. “Only by a second, though. And last week I had forty-seven out of fifty.”

She shrugged. “Accuracy isn’t everything.”

Izuku laughed. “Says the girl who’s gotten fifty out of fifty every week for the past two months.”

She rolled her eyes and grinned. “At a minimum time of *forty-four seconds,* Izuku.”

“Yeah, well—“ He began, but stopped at the sound of the instructor’s booming voice.

“Thirty-one seconds, even!” He shouted. “Forty-nine out of fifty!”

Panting slightly, Iida made his way toward them.

“Congratulations, Iida!” Izuku beamed.

“That last hoop,” Iida muttered. “It’s always that *last hoop…”*

Uraraka smirked, waving her hand in front of his his face. “Hello? Anyone there?”

“Ah— my apologies!” He sputtered. “Thank you, Midoriya.” He smiled.

Izuku shook his head and grinned. “You really are your own worst critic, Iida. You have the best record in the class!”

He averted his eyes. “Other than Todoroki, you mean.”

“Oh, for—“ Uraraka scoffed. “Todoroki’s not in this class, anymore!”

“That’s why he was the first to ascend.” Izuku chimed in. “And that’s why you’ll be the second!”

“Well, I don’t know about *that.”* He replied, cheeks dusted red. “We’re all passing with flying colors…”

“Up next, Shinsou!” The instructor shouted.

“Ah. You might’ve spoken too soon.”

Izuku winced. “Uraraka, don’t say that.” He chided.

But she wasn't wrong, as was made evident by the way Shinsou clumsily landed, almost a full minute later.

"Fifty-eight seconds." The instructor said. "Twenty-six out of fifty."

Shinsou made his way over to them with a sour look on his face. Izuku patted his arm.

"You'll get the hang of it. You've only been here two months." He consoled him. "It took me almost three just to get to twenty-five."

Shinsou smiled slightly, rubbing the back of his neck sheepishly.

It was early evening by the time class ended, and Izuku resisted the urge to yawn as he stared into space, doing his best to keep his eyes open while All Might passed out their weekly progress reports. He perked up slightly when he received his, looking over it silently at his desk. There wasn't anything incredibly novel about it — mostly the same suggestions he'd been receiving for the past few months, more or less. Defensive flying, weight training, logging progress. He slid the paper into his bag after a minute and stood, bowing and offering his thanks to All Might as he prepared to leave, only to stop in his tracks upon feeling a heavy hand on his shoulder.

"Ah!" All Might said, suddenly reaching into his pocket and retrieving a scrap of paper. "Sorry to trouble you, Midoriya, but would you mind dropping by the library? There's this book I really need for tomorrow. I'd go there myself, but the administration has called a meeting this evening."

Izuku accepted the piece of paper, smiling. "Of course, All Might. It's no trouble at all, though…" Izuku glanced down at the paper, squinting at the hastily scrawled directions. "Which level is it?"

"Six." All Might replied, with an air of apology. "You shouldn't have any trouble carrying it, though."

He nodded. "I'll go right away!"

"Thank you," he said, putting his hands together. "I really appreciate it. You can just leave it in my office in the morning, if that works."

"No problem!" He smiled.

"I might go with you, actually." Shinsou then said. "I'd like to see if I can find any useful books on flight control. If that's alright."

"Of course, Shinsou." He beamed.

Shinsou averted his eyes.

The trek to the library was never a very long one.

Though the four concentric, circular walls of heaven kept the different classes of Angels divided, the library was one of the few truly communal spaces, unless one counted the outermost ring, wherein all were welcome, but only the lowest would typically live. Still, although the walk was objectively short, the cold bite of the December air made it feel like an eternity. Izuku shivered, rubbing his arms as he shuffled down the stone pathway.

“Are you alright?” Shinsou asked. “You didn’t bring a coat, did you?”

Izuku laughed. “I didn’t. Guess I just didn’t expect it to get this cold, tonight.”

He hummed, pushing the fur-lined hood of his coat off his head. “You could wear mine, if you want.” He offered.

“Oh!” Izuku squeaked. “No, no, that’s okay. We’re almost there, anyway. Thank you, though!” He said.

He shrugged. “If you’re sure.”

“Thank you,” Izuku repeated, before looking up at the lavender sky, the color fading as the night creeped closer. He could see the library up ahead, the vast walls stretching far in both directions, forming a perpendicular intersection with the second ring, and indeed, all the others. As they grew closer, he picked up his pace until they stood before the massive entryway, and breathed a sigh of relief once they were out of the cold.

“He said it was level six, didn’t he?”

“Yeah. Don’t worry, though. I know where to find it. You said you wanted to look at flight books, right?”

Shinsou smiled lightly, and nodded. “See you in a bit, then.” He said, and with that, the two of them parted ways into the labyrinth of bookshelves.

Izuku paced down the aisles between the vast rows of books, though he didn’t pay them any mind, instead focused on the sparse furniture surrounding him. He searched until he found a potted plant with silver-tipped leaves and lavender flowers, and after a quick glance over his shoulder, he reached down into the corner behind it. Sure enough, there was a book stashed away there, and though it was a bit heavy, it was nothing he couldn’t handle. Izuku shook his head, smiling nostalgically as he recalled the first time he’d been asked to do this. “It’s to keep other people from taking it if I need it!” All Might had said. “You’ll understand when you’re at my level, Midoriya. Everyone does it!”

He laughed softly, leaning back against one of the shelves, examining the cover. He narrowed his eyes a bit. *Selected Fairytales,* it read.

He blinked.

This** is level **six?

With a slight frown, Izuku tried to open the book, but sure enough, the cover remained firmly closed, and on the spine, a large number six began to glow in response to his attempt. He

pursed his lips, turning the book over in his hands. There wasn't any sort of description on the back, though he couldn't say he was surprised.

*Just what kind of fairytales **are** these?* He wondered, but after a moment, he sighed, sliding the book into his bag. *Maybe I'll ask All Might about it later.*

Glancing around the aisle, Izuku yawned as the exhaustion started to catch up to him again.

I should probably go find Shinsou, he thought, but he made no move to follow through with it. Leaning back against the shelves, he instead allowed his gaze to wander lazily over the rows of books until a flash of red caught his eye. It was a pretty hefty book, and he leaned forward slightly as he read the bold lettering.

The Demonic Code: Morality and Ethics for the Godless

Izuku's breath hitched. He looked around nervously, confirming he was alone before reaching out toward it, his hand trembling slightly as he grabbed the spine and pulled. But it wouldn't budge. As if it were a permanent fixture on the shelf, it remained exactly as it was. As Izuku retracted his hand, he squinted at the number that illuminated the spine.

Nine.

He frowned.

Well, I guess I won't be reading that one anytime soon. Or ever.

Izuku sighed—

"Midoriya?"

—then nearly jumped out of his skin. Quickly turning around, he found Shinsou standing about five feet away.

"Ah, sorry about that." He said. "I didn't mean to scare you."

"No, no, you're fine!" He replied, though his heart was still racing. Shinsou looked him up and down.

"Did you find it?"

It took a second for Izuku to remember what he was talking about.

"Y-Yeah!" He eventually replied. "Yeah, it's, um, it's in my bag." He laughed awkwardly. "Did you… uhh, find what you were looking for?"

He nodded toward the small stack of books in his arms. "Found a couple. Figured I'd try them all out, see what works."

"Makes sense. You ready to head out, then?"

Shinsou nodded again.

The walk back to the school was mostly quiet. Izuku shifted his bag a few times from shoulder to shoulder, trying to ease the burden. Shinsou offered to carry it for him, but Izuku insisted it was alright, staring down at his feet as he walked.

Eventually, against his better judgement, he spoke.

“Um…” He murmured. “So, I know this is kind of out of the blue, but… have you even seen a Demon, Shinsou?”

He turned to him and stared as though Izuku had spontaneously grown three heads.

“No.” He said, firmly. “I haven’t gone on any missions in war zones yet, so I’m not sure how I would have, anyway.”

“Right! Right,” Izuku said, internally hitting himself. “Of course. Sorry.”

For a few seconds, it was silent.

“Have you?” Shinsou asked.

Izuku looked at him, blinking rapidly. “Have I what?”

“Seen a Demon.” He supplied, raising an eyebrow.

“Oh!” Izuku laughed, eyes darting around. He already regretted saying anything. “Y-Yeah, I mean… once.” He replied.

“And you got away unscathed?” He incredulously asked.

Izuku laughed nervously again. “Yeah, uhm. It was… strange.”

“Strange how?”

“He didn’t try to attack me.”

“So it saw you, too.” He stated. “Must’ve been a pretty close encounter.”

“Yeah.”

“...What was it like?”

“Um…” Izuku hesitated. “He was…” *Surprisingly decent,* he wanted to say. But he couldn’t say that, so instead he said, “…Crass.”

Shinsou snorted. “Guess I’m not too surprised.” He said, pausing. “Be careful, Midoriya. Don’t let them fool you. Even if they seem non-combative, don’t turn your back on them. They’ll try to trick you, catch you off guard.”

“Oh, of course. I’m always very cautious, don’t worry!” He assured him. “It was an isolated incident, anyway.”

Shinsou hummed. “To think they’d even dare to speak to you. Bastards. Can’t let them get close to you.” He muttered. “Can’t let them out of your sight.”

As they passed in front of the gates to the third circle, the lanterns on either side automatically glowed red in the darkness, denying them entry, despite them not seeking it. The lanterns returned to their regular, golden glow as soon as they moved out of range, but for a moment, he felt the glow of red bleed through his skin, revealing, like a paper doll pressed up against the window.

After a couple of relatively uneventful rescue missions, Izuku was beginning to think he’d truly seen the last of Katsuki.

He’d settled into a routine, more or less. Every other day, Izuku would wake up before dawn, get dressed and make his way outside. He’d walk from the dormitory in Heaven’s second circle to the golden gate on the edge of the first, where he’d be given a map marked with all the churches he would be tasked with evacuating that day. He’d then fly down to the surface and get to work, and, if he acted efficiently, he’d finish by around six o’clock in the evening, at which point he’d return the exact same way he’d come, and then promptly pass out in exhaustion.

It wasn’t that Izuku was bored, per se. He enjoyed what he did — he was helping people! But still, every time he sent up someone who seemed just a *little* too reluctant to look him in the eye, he couldn’t help but think of the Demon. That sense that there was something there, some dark secret hiding behind that well-kept exterior lingered long after the clothes hit the floor, and he wanted to ask what exactly they’d done to cause it, but he wouldn’t know what to ask.

It was a fantastic ability, insidious cryptospection. To be able to see into the souls of humans and instantly know each and every shameful thing they had ever done. It made sense for Demons to have such an ability, but Izuku had to wonder why he’d never heard of such a thing among Angels. It’d certainly make the job much easier, make the screening process far more comprehensive.

These were the thoughts that populated Izuku’s mind one Sunday, as he wandered from place to place in a daze, his exhaustion gradually getting the better of him. He wasn’t sure why they’d assigned him so many locations that day. Frankly, it was sort of unreasonable, and he would’ve been angry about it, had the work not been so important. Maybe it was because things had gotten worse on Earth, or maybe it was because they’d noticed him working hard and elected to give him extra work as a result. Either way, it was an unfortunate situation, but he didn’t know how to be upset about it without feeling bad for being upset.

By the time Izuku finished clearing out the last church, it was nighttime. The stars above lit the sky up brightly, but the hulking structure of the buildings around him cut deep, jagged shadows into the cityscape.

He was tired, yawning as he flapped his wings, preparing to take off, only to be harshly jerked back into full-alertness at a sudden flash of red light in his peripheral. He sharply turned around, searching for the source, but found nothing.

Then he took a step back, and his wings collided with something solid.

“Such a hard worker.” A familiar voice said, deep and husky and *right behind him.*

Izuku almost choked, viscerally aware, yet frozen in place.

Close.

*Really, **really** close.*

That same voice chuckled.

“Let me know if you ever feel like takin’ a dive,” he rasped, before leaning in further, his breath hot against the side of his face, sending shivers down his spine as he whispered, *“Deku.”*

Izuku moved quickly, his heart pounding as he spun around on his heel.

But by the time he'd made the turn, he was gone.

Chapter End Notes

so uhhhh hope ur ready to watch izuku's entire worldview get wrecked by ~~[redacted]-coded~~ demon katsuki. He's kind of a mess at the beginning here (through no real fault of his own), but things get better

I know I've been very inconsistent with updates lately, but for what it's worth, I've actually planned out this entire fic already in extreme detail, which is something I haven't actually done before. Like, By Design is loosely planned out. Bluebird was even looser. Icebreaker is just straight flying-by-the-seat-of-ur-pants shit lmao. But this one really had to be planned out, given the whole political plot and shit. Don't let that scare you away, btw. I mean, this is an angel/demon AU. There's gonna be a lot of dumb banter ~~and a fucking obscene amount of sexual tension.~~

Chapter 2: Immutable Orchard

Chapter Summary

> Katsuki rolled his eyes, then smirked. “Better be careful, Deku. You keep this shit up and daddy’s gonna clip your wings.”
>
> “I’m not breaking any *rules* by being here.”
>
> “You’re not following any *instructions,* either.” He fired back, holding his gaze. “Don’t kid yourself. We both know that’s just as bad.”

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“It sounds like he’s trying to tempt you.” All Might told him, easy and nonchalant.

It was a Saturday morning. They were sitting on a bench on the side of a gravel track in the outermost circle, and Izuku had been blotting sweat from his forehead at the time. His hand froze as the words left his mentor’s lips, blood draining from his face as his eyes went wide. He opened his mouth to speak, but before he could get a word in, All Might continued.

“No, no!” He hastily exclaimed, waving his hands. “It’s not a *bad* thing— well, unless it *worked,* but…”

Izuku’s throat made some noise, strangled and involuntary.

“—But that’s not the point I’m trying to make!” He went on. “You have nothing to be concerned about, Midoriya. In fact, this could be a great opportunity!”

Izuku halted, turning to look at him with a bewildered expression.

“…H-How do you mean?”

“Well…” He made some vague, meaningless gesture. “You’re in a very unique situation. Not a lot of first-tier Angels come in contact with Demons, you know, let alone the same one multiple times.” He explained. “If you can show yourself to be capable of resisting temptation, that’s *sure* to make you stand out when the council reviews you for ascension.”

Izuku blinked a few times rapidly.

“You really think so?” He asked, narrowing his eyes.

“I *know* so.” He held eye contact with him for a while, then looked away.

“Isn’t it sort of dangerous, though?” He followed. “I mean, what if he attacks me?”

All Might hummed, brows pinching together for a moment.

“I can understand your concern.” He said, then sighed, leaning back on the bench. “It’s a shame they don’t allow us to give combat instruction to Angels below the second tier.”

Izuku was silent for a moment. He stared at his feet, shuffling them idly against the gravel.

“It’s… not just that. I just…” He bit his lip, fingers tangling with the fabric of his pants as he debated whether or not he should even voice his concerns. “I feel like…” He sighed, “Like there’s just… so much I don’t know about Demons.” He finally said, then released an awkward laugh. “Even *he* seemed surprised.”

All Might hummed again. “The curriculum as far as that is concerned *does* leave a lot to be desired.”

He felt some of the tension ease from his shoulders.

“Why won’t they teach us this stuff?” Izuku pressed. “I mean, it just seems so… I don’t know.” He exhaled harshly, raking his fingers through his sweat-damp hair. “I’m sure there are good reasons for it, of course. It’s just, from *my* perspective, it kind of feels… unnecessarily risky.”

“It’s… complicated.” All Might replied. “The *official* reason is that they want to avoid sensitive information falling into the wrong hands. But honestly, even as someone who’s actually worked closely with the higher-ups, some of the restrictions do still seem sort of arbitrary.” He said, then shrugged. “I’ll be the first to admit that it can be quite frustrating. But that’s society.”

Izuku nodded, and for a while, remained silent. A couple of women strolled by, chatting animatedly. He waited until their voices receded into the distance.

“Are you…” He started, then cleared his throat, speaking quietly. “Do you know about a thing called ‘insidious cryptospection’?”

For several seconds, All Might didn’t respond. Izuku was sure that if he were to glance at him, he’d find him staring back at him with his mouth agape, but he kept his gaze trained on the gravel beneath his feet.

“I… do.” All Might eventually answered, leaning in a bit further. “It’s a fairly typical, innate Demonic ability.”

Izuku nodded silently.

“Can it, uhm…” He swallowed. “Can it be used on Angels?”

“It can’t.” He replied.

Emboldened by the ease and immediacy of his answer, Izuku turned to look at him.

“What if—“

“Midoriya.” He interjected. Staring intently at him, All Might then raised his hand up. Izuku’s eyes followed the slow movement of his finger as he proceeded to point at his eyes, then his ears, before finally tapping his wrist twice.

Izuku could count the number of times he’d seen the gesture on one hand, but he knew what it meant.

Others watching. Others listening. Now is not the time.

Izuku’s mouth snapped shut, and he turned away, again, staring down at his shoes in silence. He swallowed, a cool, prickling sensation making the hair on the back of his neck stand up.

Eventually, All Might cleared his throat.

“Listen, there’s…” He hesitated. “There’s not a lot I can tell you, but what I *can* say is this: I don’t think you need to worry *too* much about him attacking you without warning.”

Izuku looked up again, meeting All Might’s eyes. He had a million questions racing through his head, but he didn’t dare voice them, instead letting the quizzical look on his face speak for itself.

“But — and I’m telling you this as your instructor, for your own safety. Because this demon has clearly taken an interest in you, which makes the probability of you seeing him again sufficiently high.” He prefaced. Something told Izuku the disclaimer wasn’t really meant for *him.* “If… If he ever *shifts.* You know, fully.” He continued, stumbling slightly. “By which I mean, if you ever see *wings.”* He paused. “Then you need to run away as fast as you can.”

Izuku stared at him for a while longer, turning the words over in his head. He eventually sighed, offering a soft smile.

“Thanks, All Might.” He said. “I’ll be sure to remember that.” He laughed a bit, trying to diffuse the tension. “Who knows, though? Maybe he’ll get bored, and I’ll never see him again.”

All Might smiled, but didn’t say anything.

Izuku shivered, stuffing his hands into his pockets and wrapping his wings around his body as he walked against the wind. He’d only been walking for around ten minutes, but his legs already felt heavy, and his toes were beginning to feel numb. Spotting the entrance to the library over the top of his wings, Izuku pushed forced his legs to move quicker. He ducked inside, and breathed a sigh of relief.

The entrance from the first circle led directly into the study space. Weaving between tables and desks, Izuku made a beeline for the fireplace and took a seat on the hearth, closing his eyes as the crackling fire breathed heat into his body. It had been around noon when he’d left

the park, and he looked around the room idly, noting how sparsely populated it was. Then, he saw something that made his eyes light up.

Not wanting to shout in the library, Izuku quickly began walking toward where a familiar head of red and white hair was. He put his hand on his shoulder, only to jump and release a small '*eep'* when half the books laid out on the table before him abruptly snapped shut.

"Ah! I'm so sorry!" He whisper-shouted, meeting mismatched eyes sheepishly. "I just wanted to say hi." He muttered, rubbing the back of his neck sheepishly. "I hope I didn't make you lose your place…"

Todoroki's lips quirked up slightly, and he shook his head. "It's no big deal. I was finished with most of those, anyway."

Izuku smiled meekly. "That's good, I suppose…" He said, sighing. "How've you been, though?" He asked, leaning against the desk. "It feels like forever since I last saw you. How're you liking tier two?"

"It's alright." Todoroki replied. "It has been a while, though, hasn't it?" He looked away, and muttered, "Wish they didn't make us live in the third circle."

Izuku laughed lightly, nodding in understanding. His eyes darted over to the books in front of Todoroki. "Uhm," he began hesitantly. "What're you reading about? If you don't mind me asking, that is."

"Mostly battle strategy," he shrugged.

"Ah! Are they putting you in soon?"

"That's what they say." He answered. "Within the next week, if I pass the exam."

"That's so exciting!" Izuku gushed, a wide grin stretching across his face. "I hope I can join you soon!"

"Yeah," Todoroki replied, his volume a bit lower. "It'd be nice to get to see all of you, again."

"Well, I'll be sure to work hard and ascend as soon as possible."

Todoroki offered a tight, awkward smile, and averted his eyes.

There were never too many people inside the churches — a couple dozen, perhaps, at the most. Izuku often wondered where the others had gone, if anywhere. Though he liked to think that they were acting efficiently, the simple truth was that rate at which they were currently evacuating people just couldn't account for the sheer the level of desertion Izuku consistently found as he worked. *Surely* there were more believers around than what his missions would have one think.

These were the thoughts that bounced around inside Izuku's head late into the afternoon, as he wandered down stone-paved roads on the outskirts of a desolate city, gazing at the

wreckage of a once-lively area. He'd already finished clearing out his last assigned location for the day, though it was nothing to brag about. After all, there were only five people inside.

Izuku sighed, raking a hand through his hair as he turned a corner. He kicked up rocks and dust and allowed his eyes to roam, only to freeze up when something caught his eye. *Movement.*

Up ahead, there stood a large, dilapidated building. He stayed still for a moment, staring at the half-boarded up windows before slowly beginning to approach it. Upon closer inspection, Izuku realized it was a small, girls' boarding school.

He paused, glancing up at the sky. Based on the position of the sun, he figured it was probably around six o'clock. He had already evacuated all the churches he'd been assigned to. Surely there'd be no harm in investigating.

Right?

Projecting confidence, he strode up toward the front door, grabbing the heavy handle and entering. He took a deep breath as he opened his mouth and prepared to announce his presence, but, in the end—

"Someone's breaking the rules."

—all that came out was an embarrassing shriek.

Izuku bristled, quickly whirling around, meeting glowing red eyes.

"You!"

"Me." The Demon said, lips curling up in amusement.

Izuku took a staggering step back and looked him up and down. His horns and tail were nowhere in sight. Had it not been for his eyes, he might have passed for human. All Might's warning suddenly came back to him, echoing inside his mind.

If you see wings, run away.

"What're *you* doing here?!"

"I could ask you the same question. Aren't you supposed to be at a church somewhere?" Katsuki snorted, grinning as he leaned back against the door.

"I was just—" he sputtered, somehow embarrassed. "I was just passing through—"

"Yeah?" Katsuki quirked an eyebrow, and something about his tone grated on Izuku's nerves.

"Yeah." He clenched his jaw. "I saw movement in here. I came to see if anyone needed help."

"Aww," he cooed, an amused smirk plastered across his face. "How *altruistic* of you."

“Well, obviously.” Izuku narrowed his eyes. “What do you think an Angel’s job *is* if not to help people?”

Katsuki stilled, and for a few seconds, just stared at him. He maintained the same grin, though it was noticeably strained, as though he were barely holding back the urge to laugh. Eventually, Katsuki slowly lowered his chin, his brow raised.

“Do you…” His eyes narrowed, *“Really* want me to answer that?”

“Oh, by all—“ Izuku started, only to stop abruptly, biting his tongue as he thought better of it. He clenched his jaw, and after a moment, simply shook his head, forcing his curiosity out of his mind. “You still haven’t told me what you’re doing here.”

“Because I don’t have to.” He replied easily. “And honestly, it shouldn’t even be necessary, either. I’d hope that past experience would be enough for you to figure that shit out for yourself.” He gazed at Izuku, eyes half-lidded, his tone shifting to condescension. “C’mon, Deku, think about it. Try not to hurt yourself, but do your best, yeah? See if you can crack the code.”

Izuku felt the vein on the side of his head throb.

He took a deep breath.

“Whatever.” He muttered, rough and short. “Just stay out of my way and let me do my job, okay, *Demon?”*

“Your *job?”* He snorted. “Yeah, whatever you’re doing here, it sure as hell ain’t your goddamn *job.”* He rolled his eyes, then smirked. “Better be careful, Deku. You keep this shit up and daddy’s gonna clip your wings.”

“I’m not breaking any *rules* by being here.”

“You’re not following any *instructions,* either.” He fired back, holding his gaze. “Don’t kid yourself. We both know that’s just as bad.”

Izuku narrowed his eyes.

“So, what? Are you gonna tell on me, then?” He challenged, and for a moment, Katsuki seemed taken aback. After a few seconds of staring, he stood upright again.

“Nah.” He said, sighing. “Not a fuckin’ narc. ‘Sides,” he paused for a moment to look him up and down, glowing eyes roaming over his body in a way Izuku wasn’t quite sure how to interpret. “Things’re more interesting this way.”

For several seconds, Izuku just glared up at him, green eyes meeting red as he attempted to gather his thoughts.

“What do you even *do* here, anyway?” He blurted. “If you can’t actually transport more than a few people, what’s the point of you being here?”

“What do you think’s keeping this place from burning to the ground?”

Izuku froze, brow furrowing.

“What? Did you think it was a *coincidence* that the inferno hasn’t reached this part of town yet?” He snorted.

Now that he thought about it, it *was* rather strange. Other Angels had occasionally spoken of close calls during evacuations, when they had traveled a little too close to the combat zone. They always returned with singed clothing, and the sort of rattled demeanor one could only expect of a person who had just narrowly escaped the complete destruction of their soul. They said that Hellfire surged into the streets with all the vengeance of a flash flood, burning everything in its path indiscriminately. Izuku had always thought himself lucky to have made it this far without encountering it, but up until that moment, that's all he had assumed it was: luck.

"So you…”

“Redirect the flow of Hellfire until someone else can get here.” He supplied. “Y’know, you oughtta be thankin’ me, nerd. I’m makin’ your job *way* easier.”

He opened his mouth to speak, but closed it upon thinking better of it. Though he hated to acknowledge it, he couldn’t help but feel intrigued by the demon. Izuku found himself thinking back to his conversation with All Might, again.

You should work with him, he’d said.

Izuku bit his tongue, mind racing. There were a million things he wanted to ask Katsuki, but if there were ever a time for them, it certainly wasn’t this one.

Izuku sighed.

“Look, just… where are the girls?” He asked. “Can you tell me that?”

“Oh, they’re all in the mess hall.” He said, gesturing toward a large set of double doors at the far end of the hall. “Would probably be in the dorms right now, but of course you clumsy *assholes* blew that shit up.”

He faltered for a moment, unsure how to respond. Eventually he just looked away and mumbled, “It’s a war,” before turning to walk swiftly down the hall. Katsuki followed.

“Against *kids?”*

“Things happen.”

The Demon snorted, but didn’t otherwise respond, trailing a few steps behind him as they approached the doors. Izuku pushed them open and entered upon a large group of girls, most sitting around the tables with books, and a few on the floor in sleeping bags. They immediately looked up.

“This is Deku—”

“—Dekiriel.” Izuku interjected, much louder than he intended. He flushed in embarrassment, quickly fixing his posture before offering a nervous smile. He cleared his throat. “Sorry about that.” He said.

Izuku did his best to ignore Katsuki as he went through his usual spiel, before proceeding to approach each girl individually.

Distantly, he knew it was quite possible that some of the girls might not be true believers. Children were wildcards when it came to faith. On the one hand, with them being so young, many of them weren’t at the point where they’d begun to have doubts, yet. On the other hand, considering most of them came from religious families, there was always the possibility that they were merely going along with their parents’ wishes, and never truly believed to begin with.

It was a rough situation, but not incredibly uncommon, so they received training on how to handle it gracefully. Still, no amount of instruction could truly prepare one to confront it in real life.

The girl was perhaps eleven years old, with long, red hair and freckles. Izuku could already tell by the look on her face that something was wrong. Her voice quivered as she looked into his eyes, tears already welling up. “I-I’m a child of God,” she told him.

And it hit him like a heavy boulder dropping deep in the pit of his stomach.

Because she wasn’t.

Izuku stared at her a moment longer, then offered a smile he hoped would be comforting, though his voice still shook when he spoke. “S-Sit tight. Everything’s going to be okay.” He told her, and moved on to the next person.

Izuku did his best to appear calm. Schooling his features, he carried out his duties with the rest of the girls. Every once in a while, he’d glance over at the red-headed girl, only to find her in the exact same position again and again: knees pulled up against her chest, head ducked down between them.

Frozen and desolate.

After a few minutes, he reached another girl with red hair, though this one couldn’t have been more than seven years old.

“I’m a child of God,” she said, with a slight lisp.

And she was.

So, Izuku reached his hands out toward her, only to halt at the sound of a sudden, desperate cry from across the room.

“Wait!” The other girl shouted, scrambling to stand and run toward them. She practically tackled the younger girl, wrapping her arms around her protectively. *“P-Please.”* She whimpered. “She’s my little sister. *Please* don’t take her away!”

Izuku gaped, tense and pale and at a loss as to what to do; his training never covered this. He hesitantly tried to reach out toward them, but the girls recoiled, heels squeaking against the floor as they frantically scooted back into the wall. The younger of the two began to cry into her sister’s shirt, while the older had tears in her eyes, only barely holding it together.

“Please don’t separate us. *Please!* She’s—She’s all I have!”

Izuku stared at them, lowering his hand and taking a step back.

“I—“ He swallowed “I-I’m not—“

“I can take them.” Katsuki suddenly interjected. Izuku’s head whipped around, and he jumped slightly at the sight of him a mere two feet away.

“You… You’ll *what?”*

“I can take them both with me.” He shrugged. “If it’s just them, it’s no big deal.”

Izuku stared at him in shock for a while, something hot bubbling up inside him until it burst.

And suddenly, he was *furious.*

Keeping his barrier up, Izuku grabbed his wrist in a harsh grip and stormed out of the room, offering only a clipped *“be right back”* for the girls as he dragged him out with him. Once out, Katsuki snatched his hand away, right as Izuku was slamming the door shut behind him.

“Jesus *Christ,* Deku! The *hell’s* your—“

Izuku spun around sharply.

“I’m *not* letting you take those girls to Hell.” He snarled.

Katsuki stopped rubbing his wrist, looking up at Izuku with narrowed eyes.

“And why the fuck not?”

“That should be obvious.”

Katsuki stared at him for a moment, blinking slowly before it finally seemed to dawn on him. “Oh for fuckssake— how fucking *brainwashed* are you?!” He shouted, throwing his hands up dramatically.

“No way.”

“What the fuck do you think Hell *is,* Deku?” He asked incredulously. “Do you think we just throw people on the fire and use their flesh for *fuel?”*

“Not happening.” He hissed.

“You’re not even *listening* to me!”

“I don’t *care,* you’re not taking them! I won’t let you!”

“And how exactly do you intend to stop me?” Katsuki shot back, taking quick strides toward him, until they were mere inches apart, and he could glare down at him menacingly. *“Huh?* What the fuck are you gonna do? I could snap your fucking wings in two right now, if I felt like it. You have *zero* say over what I can and can’t do, Deku.”

Izuku winced, leaning away slightly. He clenched his fists at his sides and gritted his teeth.

“So do it, then.” He challenged. “I don’t care. You’re still not taking them.”

Katsuki stared down at him in disbelief. Then, he released a loud groan of frustration, and raked his hands through his hair. As Izuku watched him, he noted that he appeared to be shifting a bit, seemingly involuntarily, because when he pulled his hands out of his hair, the tips of his fingers had morphed into sharp, black claws, and his horns were beginning to peak through his blond hair.

“Swear to fuckin’ *God,* it’s like you assholes *thrive* on cognitive dissonance. What’s it gonna take, huh?” He demanded. “What the fuck’s it gonna take to get it through your shitty head that I’m not secretly planning to fucking *torture* those girls, Deku?”

“You know, if you *insist* on not referring to me by my Holy name, the least you could do is call me by my *actual* name!” Izuku hissed.

“Oh?” Katsuki’s eyebrows nearly reached his hairline as he barked a short, sardonic laugh. “Okay, no problem. What’s your name, then, *huh?* Gonna *tell* me?”

“Izuku Midoriya.” He snapped.

Katsuki stared at him for a moment, eyes wide, mouth gaping in what looked to be nothing short of pure, genuine shock. Then, he sighed, dropping his head down into his hands.

“You just— Oh my *god.”* He groaned, then laughed with some mixture of derision and disbelief. “Y’know, I expected them to be withholding *some* information in order to keep you fuckers in line, but *this?* This is just fuckin’ negligence. This is gonna get someone *killed.”*

Izuku stared at him, his glare faltering. “Wh—“

“You’re not supposed to tell me your fucking name, *genius!”* Katsuki interjected, head snapping up again. “Why d’you think they make you choose Holy names, in the first place? For fucking *fun?!”*

Izuku’s mouth fell open, the color draining out of his face.

Oh.

He really screwed up, didn't he?

"Christ!" Katsuki exasperated. "You're *real* lucky I'm not out tryin' to fuckin' kill you, 'cuz if I was, you'd be dead the *second* that shit came outta your mouth."

Izuku swallowed, steeling himself before offering what little leverage he had at this point. "I wouldn't go down without a fight."

"There wouldn't *be* a fight." Katsuki deadpanned, marching right up to him, Izuku matching his steps until he was backed up against the wall. He activated his shield as the demon reached out, poking him in the chest, the tip of his claw pressing against him threateningly. "That pathetic little shield of yours? Your fuckin' spiritual condom? That doesn't mean shit. " He spat. "I'd slice through your sternum and squeeze the life outta your heart before you even knew what the fuck was happening."

Izuku took a shuddering breath, the full reality of his mistake settling in like a cold weight deep inside him. He clenched his jaw and forced himself to meet the demon's gaze.

"So, why haven't you, then?"

Katsuki smiled — a mocking, borderline cruel smile. His claws receded as he took a step back, sliding his hands into his pockets. He shrugged. "Guess I just don't feel like it," he replied cryptically. Izuku looked him up and down warily, and squeezed his fists at his sides. He remained silent for a moment, reaching up to rub his temples as he took a few deep breaths.

"What happens to the girls," He began, slow and steady, "If I let you take them."

He looked up, activating his Persentiscence as he met the demon's gaze. Katsuki leaned back against the wall across from him and sighed.

"Can't say for sure," he replied. "But they'll be fine. If Hell was as terrible as you assholes wished it was, we wouldn't live there. I mean, weather's kinda shit, but they'll have everything they need to live a happy existence."

Izuku released a breath he didn't realize he was holding.

Katsuki was telling the truth.

After a moment, he nodded. The movement made him feel nauseous.

"Okay." He said. "Okay, alright…"

Katsuki stared at him a few seconds longer, his eyes calculating.

"You serious?"

"Yes." Izuku answered, chewing his lip. He averted his gaze for a moment, before returning. The corridor was dim, the Demon's body slightly backlit as the sunset filtered through the

window behind him. Izuku looked up into those glowing, red eyes of his and kept his tone even. “Please don’t make me regret it,” he said.

Katsuki offered only a tilt of his head and a slow-spreading grin, and started toward the door, again.

Izuku stood on the rooftop, his nails digging into his palms as he watched Katsuki take the girls away. The younger of the two sat propped up on his bicep, the older holding his hand and walking alongside him as he made his way down the cobblestone path. He took a left turn where the main road ended and started uphill, moving at a leisurely pace, on a dirt road that stretched out to the horizon.

If anyone asked him about it, he’d say he did it in the practice of extreme caution. That the girls’ safety was his motivation for quietly moving from the roof and trailing after them beneath the violet light of sunset.

At first, he’d been content to just observe from a distance, but when Katsuki took a turn into what appeared to be a forest, Izuku found himself moving before he consciously realized it, hastily flapping his wings as he took flight, gliding over the road to where he thought he’d seen them turn, and landing as silently as possible.

There, at the side of the road, there was a path paved with gravel and surrounded by trees, and if he held his breath, he could still hear the sound of leaves crunching in the distance. Izuku cautiously started down the path, instinctively hunching over as he walked.

After around ten minutes or so, the trees began to thin out. Up ahead Izuku could see a tall, black fence, with an iron gate left wide open, and the road more or less faded away into the depths of what, upon getting closer, Izuku realized was an apple orchard. He blinked in confusion as he passed through the gate, looking back and forth and pausing to listen for any footsteps, but there was no discernible movement, and the orchard was completely silent.

Sighing, Izuku wandered between the trees, noting with no small amount of confusion that they appeared to be flourishing, in spite of the mayhem outside. The leaves were green, and from the branches hung blood-red apples. It was as though this orchard, for whatever reason, had been suspended in its own little universe — one where the war simply didn’t exist.

As the sky began to darken, the shade of the trees pushed the space surrounding him into a deeper night. Izuku wasn’t sure when he’d given up searching for Katsuki, just that at some point he’d turned his attention toward one of the trees and stopped thinking. He inched closer and reached up, fingers brushing against one shiny, red apple, gently, as though it were some illusion he could expect to vanish at any second. But the fruit was as real as Izuku was. It sat there in the palm of his hand, as big as one of his fists, and as heavy as he would’ve expected.

After a while, Izuku sighed and stepped away. His idle curiosities still buzzed inside his mind, but the sky above had gone dark, and he knew he needed to be getting back. Izuku walked back the same way he’d entered, and, with one last glance over his shoulder, took flight.

That night, Izuku laid awake in bed for what might've been a few hours, or a few minutes. He stared up at the ceiling as his mind darted from place to place, never quite settling into any particular thought. He wondered what would happen to the girls, if he'd made the right choice. He wondered what Katsuki's motives were, if they truly did align with his own. He wondered if All Might was right.

For whatever reason, the orchard became a permanent fixture in his mind. He wondered what it meant, what Katsuki was doing there. Whether he was just passing through, or if…

A splash of cold air washed over him.

…if there was actually a path to Hell within the orchard itself.

He wondered why the trees looked so well-cared for. If the apples tasted as good as they looked, and it was then that he realized, somewhat strangely, that he couldn't actually *remember* what apples tasted like.

He racked his brain, rolling flavorless saliva over his tongue as he tried to remember, but couldn't. Though he knew it should come as no surprise, it was… frustrating, nonetheless.

Because Izuku loved being an Angel.

They were a rare breed; fewer than one out of every five-million believers were offered the chance to become one. It was a massive honor just to be selected, and despite the things he'd left behind, he couldn't imagine wanting to spend eternity any other way.

But for the first time in his afterlife, Izuku found himself longing for the memories he'd forfeited. It was stupid, and it made no difference in terms of how he lived, now, but the desire remained, saturating his late night thoughts until there was nothing left.

He wished he could remember what apples tasted like, or if he had liked the flavor, or if he would still like it, now. The thought circulated inside his head, polluting his thoughts to a degree as perverse as it was pointless. He knew, in his heart, that he wouldn't change his life for anything in the world. But he just couldn't help it.

He wished he could remember the person he was, back when he was still human.

Chapter End Notes

yooooo. so, this chapter's been mostly written for a while, but I didn't get to finish it til today bc I was working on a zine piece, and then after that I just fell into academia hell, so here we are.

Anyway, thank you guys so much for all your amazing support, I'm so thrilled at just the idea that anyone might be as excited about reading this fic as i am about writing it ksdjfkjdf, so again, thank you!! I love and appreciate all of u very much. I'm really

excited for the next chapter! I'm planning to reveal a fair amount of really interesting (well, to me) stuff about the demons, so that'll be fun. Until then, consider leaving a comment if u enjoyed this. I will inject them straight into my fuckin soul

Chapter 3: Pick Your Battles

Chapter Summary

> Izuku stared at him for a moment, blinking slowly in disbelief. “Did you just call Heaven a *‘shit hole’?”*

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“I’m sorry, All Might, I didn't—“

“No.” He shook his head. “No, I’m the one who should apologize. As your mentor, it’s my duty to teach you what you need to know in order to be safe. I didn’t provide you with adequate information, and that’s a failure on my part, not yours.” All Might sighed, leaning back in his arm chair.

It was around seven or so in the evening, and Izuku was wringing his wrists, staring down at the hardwood floor of All Might’s study.

“Honestly, I just didn’t expect you to run into him again so soon.” All Might mumbled sheepishly.

“It was a surprise to me, too…” He trailed off.

“Well,” All Might continued. “I suppose all I can really say is… we’re lucky nothing bad happened.”

Izuku nodded mutely, eyes still locked on his feet.

Time passed by, and for a while, neither of them spoke.

All Might was the first to break the silence. “Whelp,” He clapped his hands together. “I think it’s time for a little *‘Demons 101.’* Wouldn’t you agree?”

Izuku’s head snapped up.

“Wait, seriously?” He squeaked, waving his hands around meaninglessly. “I-I mean, are you *sure?* C-Couldn’t you get in, uhm, some pretty *major* trouble for that?”

“You’re correct, but…”All Might smiled softly, and looked away. “I’ve already put you in unnecessary danger by withholding information.” He met his eyes again. “If risking a strongly-worded letter from the Council is what I need to do to protect you, then I’m more than happy to take that risk.”

Izuku stared back at him for a few seconds, his brows pinched together in worry. Eventually, he relented.

“If you’re sure…” He said, then smiled. “Thank you, All Might.”

After a moment of silence, All Might stood, and Izuku watched as he made his way to the far end of the room, opening the closet door. From there, he grabbed and wheeled out a large chalkboard, wincing at the way the wheels creaked. “Sorry about that.” He said. Izuku shook his head.

Once he had the board where he wanted it, All Might sighed. “Alright,” he said, picking up a piece of chalk, before pausing again to think. “I suppose the first thing you should know is this: Demons come in different *types*, but regardless of variety, there are four innate abilities that all of them share.” All Might made a numbered list on the board, and continued to write as he spoke. “The first,” he said, “Is their corruptive touch, as I’m sure you’re aware; it’s why we need a barrier in place.” He paused for a moment, then went on. “Second is insidious cryptospection. Third: the ability to feed off of sinful emotions. Finally, fourth: a mildly hypnotic gaze, at least for lower level Demons.” He turned and looked at Izuku. “Any questions?”

“…Am I allowed to write this down?”

“Oh! Yes, of course!” All Might replied, laughing slightly. “Go right ahead. I know it’s a lot to take in.”

Izuku quickly reached into his bag, grabbing a notebook and pen.

“Anything else?”

Izuku shook his head, leaning forward eagerly. All Might smiled.

“Then let’s address the elephant in the room, eh?” He went on, setting the chalk down as he began pacing back and forth, his hands clasped behind his back. “The *reason* you’re not supposed to tell Demons your real name is because it opens up a number of offensive capabilities that wouldn’t otherwise be available to them.” He explained. “What you need to understand is that your real name is your *human* name. If a Demon learns an Angel’s true name, the theory is that there are certain ways in which that Angel is rendered no different than humans, at least as far as their magic is concerned.”

Izuku blinked. “What do you mean by *‘theory’?”*

“Well,” he sighed. “Truthfully, there’s a lot we still don’t know about it, because honestly, it just doesn’t come up very much.” He shrugged. “What we know is that, if you give a Demon your name, the efficacy of your barrier is more or less at their mercy. There’s some evidence that it also makes you more susceptible to hypnosis, but the main issue concerns your barrier. If the Demon chooses to do so, they can break through it.”

Izuku felt his blood run cold, Katsuki’s snide, vulgar words suddenly ringing in his ears.

That pathetic little shield of yours? Your fuckin' spiritual condom? That doesn't mean shit, he'd said. *I'd slice through your sternum and squeeze the life outta your heart before you even knew what the fuck was happening.*

He released a shuddering breath.

All Might offered an empathetic smile. "I take it you understand, then—the gravity of the situation."

Izuku nodded mutely, his body feeling numb, hands cold and clammy.

All Might approached the blackboard again.

"Those are the basics." He said. "The next thing you ought to know is that, as I alluded to earlier, there are different *types* of Demons. Generally speaking, Demons will fall into one of seven different categories, where each category is named after one of the seven deadly sins. When I was still on active duty, we had long, arduous training sessions on this, because knowing how to figure out what type of Demon you're dealing with is a seriously important skill. It gives you a framework for what sort of tactics you can expect from them." He explained, picking up the chalk again. "Types aren't set in stone, exactly. They're interconnected. You can imagine it a bit like a seven-point clock."

All Might drew a circle on the board, placing a notch at the top, and moving clockwise to place six more notches at equidistant points on the circle. Izuku did his best to replicate it in his notes.

"It doesn't actually matter where we start, so… let's say the first type is envy." He labeled the first notch. "These are Demons whose abilities are primarily based around mimicry, which extends to stealth-related things."

On the second notch, he wrote *pride.*

"Pride Demons are the most well-rounded Demons, which makes them highly unpredictable, and difficult to classify. They tend to fight in teams."

At the third notch, he wrote *greed.*

"Greed Demons are the second most powerful in terms of raw strength." He said. "Their fighting style primarily relies on exploiting their environment."

Next, he wrote *sloth.*

"In contrast, sloth Demons are generally the weakest, at least from a brute force standpoint. I've never actually seen one fighting close-range on the frontlines. Most of their abilities are better suited for sit-and-wait traps, so they'll usually be involved in ambushes, if anything."

The fifth notch was *gluttony.*

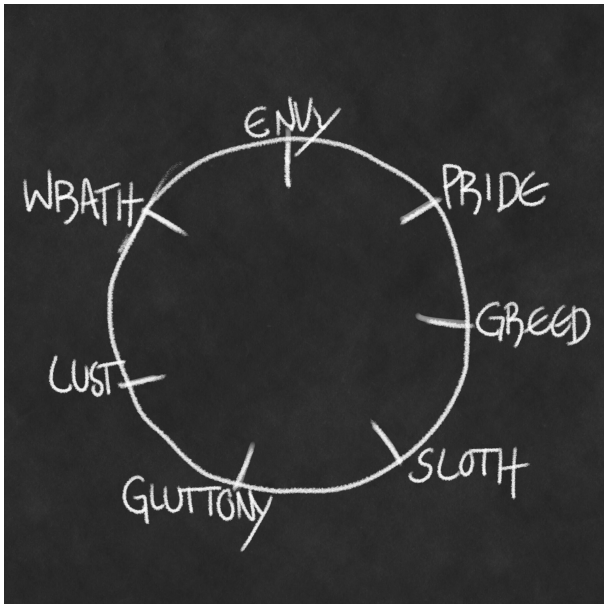
"Gluttony Demons aren't particularly strong physically, either, but they make up for it through speed and endurance. They're often sent in as a first line of attack, with the hope of

wearing you down before a stronger Demon deals the final blow."

Sixth was *lust.*

"Like sloth Demons, lust Demons are a bit less common on the frontlines, though the more powerful ones can be *extremely* strong. They're capable of hypnosis far beyond that of any other type. Finally…"

At the seventh tick mark, All Might wrote *wrath,* thus completing the circle.



"…There are wrath Demons—by far the strongest among the Demons, as far as sheer physical power is concerned." He said, setting down the chalk before turning toward Izuku again. "Based on what you've told me so far, I would say you're probably dealing with a Wrath Demon."

"Really?"

All Might nodded. "Repelling Hellfire is a relatively advanced ability native to Wrath Demons. It also means he can likely manipulate or manifest it to some degree, as well."

Izuku felt a bead of sweat roll down his neck.

"So what you're saying is…" He gulped. "If he were to attack me, I… pretty much wouldn't stand a chance."

"Well, yes, but—to be fair—as things stand, you probably wouldn't stand a chance against *any* Demon, regardless of type."

Izuku clenched his jaw. "I-I see…"

All Might sighed, moving to sit down once again.

"Honestly, I don't feel you're in too much danger."

“Why’s that?”

“See, Wrath Demons… well, yes, they’re powerful. In terms of raw strength, they’re unmatched. I know that probably doesn’t sound very reassuring, but what I’m trying to say here is that if he wanted to kill you… I think he would’ve done it already. Though that’s not to say there’s nothing else worrisome he could do.”

“What do you mean?”

“Well,” he rubbed the back of his neck. “This is where the adjacency circle comes into play. Wrath demons are positioned between Envy and Lust, you see. That means they can learn abilities from those classes, too. I’m not sure if there’s a limit on it, but in any case, it sounds like Katsuki already has some cross-typical abilities.”

“Like…?”

“The night you said he snuck up behind you and then disappeared?” All Might said. “That, to me, sounds like an Envy trait. Moving in complete silence is a pretty basic ability for Envy Demons. It’s the same with traveling through shadows, though I think that’s considered to be more intermediate.”

“I see, but… what’s worrisome about this?”

“Well, the thing is, even if he’s not planning to kill you, there are still bad things that could happen. If he’s learned any Lust abilities… that could be problematic.”

Izuku felt his face heat up. “H-How so?”

“Lust Demons… Well, they’re a special kind of dangerous.” He said. “Because most of the time, they’re not out to kill you.”

“What do you mean?”

“Well… maybe an anecdote would explain things better.” He said.

All Might paused, taking a deep breath before speaking.

“Once, when I was younger, a couple of people from my squadron were involved in a fight against a very powerful Lust Demon.” He began. “They managed to win, but when they came back,” He hesitated for a moment, “things weren’t the same. It was like they weren’t all there, mentally; they didn’t talk much, just… stared into the distance.”

Izuku’s brows pinched together.

“There were five of them, all level seven, but against a Demon of that caliber, it was a close call.” He looked down, and rubbed the back of his neck. “At the time, we all just assumed they were a bit traumatized by the experience—understandably so, but, four days later…” A beat of silence. “They Fell—every single one of them.” Izuku paled. “Mass Falls are *extremely* uncommon, especially in the third tier, so this was quite devastating. Things were never quite the same, after that.”

For several seconds, it was quiet.

“Lust Demons…*”* All Might eventually went on, sighing. “They specialize in a particularly insidious kind of psychological warfare. They can plant ideas in your head, little seeds of doubt—things so small you might not even be aware of it happening. But even when they’re gone, even after they’re *dead,* those seeds still remain. And they can sprout and grow into something you can’t fight against.” He explained. “We call it weaponized self-corruption.”

Izuku didn’t speak — couldn’t speak. He just stared straight ahead, rattled and numb.

“Honestly, when you first told me about this… *Katsuki* fellow, I pegged him as a mid-range Envy Demon.” He said, chuckling slightly. “Of course, all Demons can be dangerous, but Envy demons, even ones who’ve learned attributes from their adjacent classes, wrath and pride, are relatively harmless psychologically. I might not’ve been… *quite* so emphatic about this had I known he was a Wrath Demon earlier.” After a second, he hastily waved his hands. “But let me be clear! I’m not saying this to deter you from working with him. I just want you to be prepared.” All Might said. “And frankly, the story I told you was an extreme case. As a wrath Demon, it’s *very* unlikely that he’d be capable of anything more than a couple of mid-range lust abilities. Again, I *just* want you to be prepared.”

Izuku nodded, though he was still tense. It was silent. The ticking of the clock above All Might’s desk, which he had until then tuned out, came into focus, again, and for a few minutes, that was all Izuku could hear.

After a while, All Might cleared his throat.

“If it would help you feel safer, we could do some… private training.”

Izuku did a double take.

“What?”

“Probably not anything *too* in-depth,” he preemptively clarified, “But… I don’t want you feeling defenseless.”

“Are you *sure?”*

“I mean, I’ve already broken the rules,” All Might said, laughing. “What’s a few more? So long as you don’t mention it to anyone, it should be alright. What do you say?”

“That would be *incredible,”* Izuku replied, nodding effusively. “Thank you so much!”

All Might grinned. “Well, then it’s settled,” He said, “We can start tonight. No time like the present.” He stood up and held his hand out. Izuku took it, beaming, practically vibrating in excitement.

“Oh, one last thing—“ All Might said. “When you get to the second tier and start learning this stuff officially, do your best to act surprised, and pretend to be bad at the techniques for at least a few weeks!”

Izuku laughed, “Alright, I’ll be sure to do that, All Might.”

After a moment, Izuku sighed, raking a hand through his hair.

“Is something wrong?” All Might asked.

“Oh, no,” He stumbled, “I mean, I don’t know, just…” he hesitated, chewing his lip. “All of this sounds good in theory, but… what if he doesn’t want to work with me?” He asked. “Like, it’s one thing to talk about all of this. It’s another thing to actually *convince* him. What incentive would he even have to agree to this?”

All Might was quiet for a moment, then chuckled. Izuku looked up at him, confused.

“Oh, Midoriya,” he said, shaking his head. “If anything, he has even greater incentive to work with you than you do with him. The greatest incentive of all.”

Izuku’s brow furrowed.

“Which is…?”

All Might grinned. *“You.”*

Izuku flushed.

“Don’t forget, this *is* a test of strength on your part.” He went on. “Katsuki has *every* reason to want to work with you; you’re offering him a rare opportunity: the chance to corrupt an Angel.”

Izuku left the next morning with jitters running through his limbs and nerves prickling the back of his neck as he took flight. The wind whipped through his hair as he soared across the sky, drawing closer to the source of the chaos. All Might had ensured that he wouldn’t have nearly as much work to do, that day. After all, he had a higher calling.

Today, he was going to convince Katsuki to work with him.

…He just needed to find him first.

Up above, the combat zone looked like Hell on Earth. Vast, billowing smoke stacks stretched out to the sky, dwarfing the buildings surrounding them as Hellfire filled the streets, surging like white water rapids. The sight alone made Izuku uneasy.

He scanned the area for any disruption of the flow, places where the Hellfire appeared to be unnaturally disrupted, but after half an hour of searching, he still couldn’t spot any signs of him. Izuku landed on the roof of an old shop and sighed. It was hopeless. Who knew if Katsuki was still in the city? For all he knew, he might not be in the country. He might not even be on *Earth.*

That thought gave him pause. *Wait.*

The orchard.

It was a bit of a longshot, but it was better than nothing.

His heartbeat picking up, Izuku set off once more, gliding across the morning sky until he came upon a familiar Victorian-style schoolhouse. From there, he retraced the path up the dirt road, wind whipping his hair, and landed at the turning point. Izuku entered the forest, making quick strides down the gravel path. He continued on in his single-minded pursuit, following the trail deeper and deeper into the forest, but after about fifteen minutes, the forest was still as dense as ever. He stubbornly continued for another ten minutes, but slowed to a stop as he approached a point where the path split in two different directions.

I don't remember there being a fork in the road… he thought.

Confused, Izuku peered down the paths, squinting."Where'd it go…?" He mumbled to himself.

"You're not gonna find it."

Izuku released a rather unbecoming shriek. He spun around, head turning this way and that.

"Up here, nerd." That rough voice called, and finally, Izuku looked up and saw him. Katsuki was sitting on a thick branch, his muddy combat boots dangling about ten feet over his head. He was holding something in his right hand, roughly the size of a grapefruit. Izuku wasn't sure what it was, but the outside was black, and when the Demon brought it to his lips, he maintained eye contact as he sunk his teeth into it. He lowered his hand as he chewed, and Izuku noticed his lips were covered in a strange, almost blood-like substance. Katsuki wiped his mouth on the back of his hand.

"It's not here anymore." He continued. "Not right now, anyway."

"How do you keep finding me?" Izuku blurted out.

"I don't have to answer that." Katsuki replied, sounding bored. "But what I *will* tell you is that you make yourself very easy to find." He paused, taking another bite of his… *whatever* it was. Izuku watched the bob of his Adam's apple as he swallowed. "It's pretty fucking stupid, actually. You should cut it out." He said, then amended, "Which is not to say I think you'd actually know *how,* but y'know."

Izuku's eyes followed his movements as Katsuki finished the last of his snack, oddly entranced by the sight. The clawed tips of his fingers were left coated in that same bizarre, carmine juice. Katsuki maintained eye contact as he shoved each of them into his mouth, sucking the liquid from his fingers, one by one. He then hopped down from the branch, landing gracefully, like a cat.

"So?" Katsuki prompted, strolling toward him. "Y'gonna tell me what you want, or what?"

"I…" Izuku trailed off, his face feeling warm for some incomprehensible reason. It took a moment for his brain to come back online. "I've been looking for you."

“That much is obvious.” Katsuki shot back, taking another step toward him. “The question is *why.”*

“W-Well,” Izuku swallowed his nerves. “I was, uhm… actually going to ask if you would be interested in… working together?”

Katsuki stared at him for a moment, then snorted.

“What?” He laughed. “You’re fucking joking, right?”

“I’m not!”

Katsuki evidently didn’t believe him, if the increasing mirth of his laughter was any indication.

“I’m serious!” Izuku whined, his brow furrowed. “I really mean it! I want to work with you! Why would I spend all this time looking for you if I was joking?”

Katsuki chuckled a bit more, but it began to patter out the longer Izuku kept that insistent, imploring look on his face. Slowly, the amused grin began to fade away, and in its place arose a distinctly guarded demeanor. Katsuki’s relaxed aura gradually froze over, and he regarded Izuku with a cold, calculating expression.

“Why.” He spat.

“I think we could accomplish a lot to—“

“—Lying’s a sin, Deku.” Katsuki interjected, his tone patronizingly sweet, contrasting the cool look on his face.

“I’m not—“

“—You *are.”* Katsuki clipped, his expression morphing into a disgusted sneer. “And frankly, I see no reason for me to trust you if you don’t even have the decency to be transparent about it.” With that, Katsuki brushed past him, his shoulder bumping hard against Izuku’s as he strode away. It took a second for Izuku’s brain to recover from the initial shock, but as soon as it did, he was whirling around, heart rate picking up as he followed.

“Wait, I’m sorry!” He called out. “I’ll tell you the truth!”

Katsuki briskly turned around, walking backwards as he stared at Izuku, an expectant look on his face.

“I—“ Izuku fumbled. “My mentor suggested it.” He eventually said. “He said—He said it would look good to the Council, y’know… when they review me for ascension.”

Katsuki slowed to a stop, and stared at him for a moment before snorting, with some mixture of amusement and derision.

“Oh, so I’m your extracurricular, huh?” He scoffed. “You think *I’m* your path to a promotion.”

“I mean…” Izuku looked away sheepishly. “Maybe…?”

“And why the fuck would I help you?” Katsuki spat, his expression something along the line of disgust. “What’s in it for me, huh? What *exactly* do *I* stand to gain from helping *you* move up the hierarchy, Deku?”

Izuku sputtered, nearly tripping over his feet.

Katsuki huffed a dry, humorless laugh, and shoved his hands into his pockets. “Goodbye, Deku.” He spat, turning on his heel, with the clear intent of making a swift escape.

Izuku heard his heartbeat pounding in his ears, and in his state of panic, moved without thinking.

“Wait!” Izuku shouted. He leapt forward, closing the distance just enough for him to reach out and grab Katsuki’s hand. He felt the Demon’s skin against his, the subtle, pleasant difference in the transfer of heat, and immediately knew he’d screwed up. He hastily put his shield up, but there was no reversing the damage he had likely already sustained. Izuku yanked his hand away, squeezing his own wrist, and the look in Katsuki’s eyes told him he knew what had happened, too—that he could somehow *feel* him slipping up.

Izuku quickly looked away, his face feeling unbearably warm.

“You—I mean… you said it yourself. That night.” He mumbled. “You said to me, ‘let me know if you every feel like taking a dive.’” He chanced a glance at Katsuki’s face, and watched his expression grow even more incredulous as the words left his mouth. “A-And, well, I *don’t,* of course, but… you could try to convince me?” He said, then quickly added, “Of course I don’t think—well, I *know* it won’t work. But you can still at least try, uh, to…” He trailed off, clenching his fists at his sides.

“Make you Fall.” Katsuki finished for him, his voice deep, resonant, with some combination of disbelief and reverence. Izuku stared down at the forest floor, and nodded.

He heard the shuffle of gravel and leaves as Katsuki moved toward him again.

“You’re telling me…” He began, circling him slowly. “That you *want* me to try and tempt you?”

Izuku swallowed.

“I mean, it wouldn’t say much about my ability to resist it if you didn’t…”

Katsuki scoffed, laughing deep under his breath as he came to stand before him again. Izuku looked up hesitantly and found himself pinned beneath a glowing gaze. Katsuki smirked.

“You’re so fucking weird.” He said, his tone almost affectionate. “Who the hell is your mentor?”

Izuku hesitated, taken a bit off guard by the question. “Uhm,” he started, “I’m not sure if you’d know him.”

“Try me.”

Izuku blinked. “All Might.” He said, watching Katsuki’s face carefully. The Demon’s eyebrows seemed to raise a bit, but apart from that, his expression betrayed little more than a vague sense of recognition that Izuku could’ve just as easily imagined.

After a moment, Katsuki turned his back on him again.

“Fine.” He said, beginning to walk away, albeit at a more leisurely pace.

“Really?” Izuku gasped, trailing a few steps behind.

Katsuki grunted in response, then suddenly whirled around again, fixing Izuku with a stern gaze.

“But let’s get one thing straight.” He said. “You,” he poked Izuku in the sternum with his forefinger, “don’t know what the fuck you’re doing.” The statement came out so direct and harsh that Izuku almost didn’t know how to react. He opened his mouth to retort, but Katsuki beat him to it.

“You *don’t.”* He aggressively declared. “So if I fucking tell you to do something, even if you don’t exactly understand it, even if it makes absolutely no fucking sense to you, if I say it’s *important*, you do it, and ask questions later. You got that?” He said, staring Izuku down, glowing, red eyes boring into his soul. Izuku swallowed nervously, and—in the spirit of picking one’s battles—opted to simply nod in agreement, without complaint.

Katsuki seemed to relax slightly, and after a beat of silence, turned around again, prompting Izuku to follow him.

“We’re taking care of my shit first.” He muttered. “I’ll talk to the others later and work something out, but at least for today, I think it’s only fair that my shit takes precedence.”

“Of course,” Izuku agreed. “I appreciate you, ah, humoring me.”

Katsuki just sighed, before proceeding to reach under his jacket and apparently grab his upper arm. “Oi, baldy. It’s me.” He grunted. “You’re not gonna fuckin’ believe this shit, but…”

They arrived some fifteen minutes later at what was evidently Katsuki’s assigned spot: a large community center with boarded up windows. As they cleared the front entrance, they approached a set of double doors with a sign that said *gymnasium,* and Izuku could already hear the rumble of chatter within. Just before they entered, Katsuki stopped and turned to him, one eyebrow raised.

“Since this was your idea, I’m assuming you’ve got some sorta plan for how you think this should work.” He stated. “Spill it. I’ll let you know if I think it’s shit.”

“Well…” Izuku hesitated at first. “I was thinking that maybe we could start by telling everyone to find their families, so no one gets split up.” He explained. “Then, I could start checking people, and maybe we could have some kind of signal. Like, if you see someone you think is a bad person, you could just give me the signal so I’ll know not to send them up.”

“So you’re makin’ me take all the assholes, huh?” Katsuki snorted. “I see how it is.”

“I-I didn’t—“

“—I’m just fucking with you, Deku. It’s fine.” He cut in, exasperated. “I mean, fuck knows your shit hole *‘paradise’* doesn’t have the systems or infrastructure to handle the baddies.”

Izuku stared at him for a moment, blinking slowly in disbelief. “Did you just call Heaven a *‘shit hole’?”*

“Yep.” He replied, matter-of-factly. “And if God didn’t want me to call it a shit hole, he should’ve tried making it less of a shit hole.”

Izuku continued staring at him for a while longer, but eventually, he just sighed.

Pick your battles. Pick your battles. He told himself. So, he gritted his teeth, mumbled a *‘whatever’,* and forced himself to let it go.

“So is that it?” Katsuki then asked.

“Well, no.” Izuku said. “Not quite. I mean, I don’t know how long it’ll take for your ‘support’ to get here, but depending on how long we’ll need to wait, I could run out to some of my churches and bring them over here. It might be easier to process people that way.”

Katsuki hummed. “Usually doesn’t take that long.”He said, shrugging. “Longest I’ve ever had to wait is an hour, but generally it’s around thirty minutes or so.”

Izuku nodded. “I guess that’s not too bad.”

Katsuki grunted an acknowledgement, and meandered toward the entrance to the gymnasium. He threw a glance over his shoulder. “Oh!” He said, as though he’d only just remembered something. “There’s just one issue with your plan, Deku.”

Izuku’s brow furrowed. “…What’s that?”

Katsuki turned toward him, his back pressing against the crash bar, opening the door a sliver, just enough to let the noise out. Katsuki grinned, putting sharp, white teeth on display.

“It only works if you assume that my definition of a ‘bad person’ is the same as yours.”

Izuku stared at him for a few seconds, processing. When the implication finally hit him, he felt a spike of cold air rush over him. “Wait, what do you—?!”

“—Let’s do this.” Katsuki declared.

He opened the door.

If Izuku were to guess, he'd estimate there had been around two hundred people inside the community center to start with, though by the time they'd gotten through everyone, that number had fallen to around a hundred and twenty or so. It was around ten-thirty when Katsuki suddenly seemed to tense, his posture straightening as he reached under his jacket and grabbed his arm, much like he had done earlier.

"Yeah?" He grunted, then fell silent for a moment. "Alright."

Izuku gave him a quizzical look.

Katsuki raked a hand through his hair. "Big guy's here," he said, then sighed. "Brace yourself."

Izuku didn't even have time to comprehend those words before the gymnasium doors suddenly burst open, and with them came the sound of a booming voice, resounding throughout the room.

"Hello!" He shouted, grinning from ear to ear as he quickly strode up to them. Izuku's eyes nearly popped out of his head. Katsuki was pretty tall, but this guy was *huge*. Izuku just barely had time to activate his shield before the Demon suddenly grabbed his hand and proceeded to shake it with enough vigor to yank his shoulder up and down. "You must be Deku! It's nice to meet you! I've never met an Angel who wasn't trying to kill me!" He leaned toward him, and Izuku reflexively leaned away.

"Oi, baldy." Katsuki growled. "Calm the fuck down. You're gonna spook him."

"Right! Sorry!" He said, without any loss of enthusiasm. The Demon stood up straight again. "My name's Inasa!"

"H-Hello!" Izuku squeaked, gently extricating his hand from Inasa's grip. "Uh-Uhm, it's nice to meet you, too?" He tried, glancing at Katsuki from the corner of his eye. Katsuki just snorted.

"Don't worry. He's always like that." Katsuki said, rolling his eyes. "Absolutely no concept of an 'indoor voice.'"

"I'm still here, you know!" Inasa said.

"I'm *well* aware." Katsuki scoffed. "Anyway, everyone's over there," He said, gesturing toward the large group of people. "Well, most of 'em. There's some kids playing across the hall. I'll round 'em up." Katsuki turned and started toward the entrance to the north hall. He threw one last glance over his shoulder. "Try not to make him shit himself while I'm gone, baldy."

"I'll try!" He shouted, his tone cheerful. The sound of the door closing echoed throughout the gym. Inasa grinned. "Katsuki's told me so much about you!"

Izuku did a double take. *"R-Really?"* Inasa nodded enthusiastically. Izuku looked away, a nervous smile on his face. "Good things, I hope…?"

"Yeah! Well, I mean— other than the part where he called you an idiot and guessed that you had at most three months before Falling. That's just how he is, though."

"I see." Izuku pursed his lips. "Well, I'm not going to Fall."

"That's what everyone says before they Fall."

"I feel like that's what most Angels would say in general."

"You've got me there!"

Izuku paused for a moment. Out in the hall, he thought he could hear children laughing.

"…How often do Angels fall?" He eventually asked.

Inasa raised his eyebrows. "Hmm. Not very often," he said. "They say it usually averages out at around once every eighty years, but that's during times of peace, when we just don't have very much contact with Angels." He shrugged.

Izuku nodded. "And I take it you think it'll happen more, now?" He asked, then added, "because of the war…?"

"Well, yeah. I know it will," Inasa replied, "Because it has."

Izuku was quiet for a while.

"You know," He hesitantly began. "I enjoy being an Angel. I get to help people." Izuku rubbed the back of his neck. "It's hard work, but that's part of why I love it."

"I do respect you guys' passion!" Inasa said. "If nothing else, I'll give you that; you're really passionate about what you do."

Izuku smiled, looking down at his feet.

"Can I ask you kind of a weird question?"

Izuku glanced up again. "Um, sure…?"

"Do you trust Katsuki?"

That caught him off guard.

"I…" Izuku fumbled. "I mean, I *guess?*" He paused, then added, "I can tell when he's lying."

"Oh wow, cool!" Inasa exclaimed. "But would you still trust him if you couldn't do that?"

Izuku blinked. "No."

Inasa laughed.

“Very blunt, I like that! You remind me of—“

A muffled shout from across the hall cut him off, and Izuku jolted in alarm, looking in that direction with concern.

“I should probably…”

“Yeah,” Inasa agreed. “Go on! Can’t have him dying on us!” He said, laughing. “I should be getting things ready in here, anyway.”

Izuku nodded before jogging over to the door, yanking it open and entering the hall. He glanced in both directions, quickly zeroing in on one room a few doors down, from where the sound of high-pitched screeching appeared to originate. He quickly made his way over to it, and opened the door to the sound of shrill laughter and deep, aggravated groans.

The scene within nearly caused his eyes to pop out of his head.

“Oi, quit fu—*fudging* pulling on them!”

There was a young boy sitting on Katsuki’s shoulders, no older than four years old. Katsuki, as it happened, was partially shifted, and the boy had both hands on his horns, leaning back and pulling. Izuku leaned against the doorframe, his hand covering his mouth as he watched.

“Why do you have kitty ears?” He asked. “Are you a cat?”

“What? No, they’re clearly not—“

“—He’s got a tail, too!” A little girl exclaimed.

“Katsuki’s a kitty-cat!” The boy on his shoulders yelled, giggling. “Cat-chan!”

“I *just* said—!”

“Kacchan! Kacchan!” The kids chorused, drowning out his protests.

Izuku cleared his throat.

“Hey, kids?” He finally said, prompting Katsuki to look up at him, wide-eyed. Izuku was grinning from ear to ear, barely holding back the urge to laugh. “C’mon, give it a rest. It’s time to go.”

“Awww!” They seemed to collectively cry.

The boy on Katsuki’s shoulder’s frowned. “But—but—“

“—And it’s not nice to pull on a kitty-cat’s ears,” he chided, waving his finger. “You’re gonna make *Kacchan* upset.” He snorted. Katsuki glared at him rather intensely, but the kids seemed to get the message. Izuku stepped to the side and ushered them all out into the hall,

then propped open the door to the gymnasium. It took a minute, but eventually they managed to herd everyone back inside.

“Fucking gremlins,” Katsuki hissed, horns and tail receding as he entered.

“Aw, they’re just kids.” Izuku cooed, side-eyeing him. “Don’t be so mean… *Kacchan.”*

“Oh my fucking *god—“*

“What’s wrong, *Kacchan?”*

“You’re *never* gonna let that shit go, are you?”

“Kacchan!” He singsonged.

“I’m gonna *fucking* hurt you.”

Izuku opened his mouth to retort, but before he could get a word out, Inasa’s booming voice filled the room.

“Alright, everyone!” He shouted. “Since you’re all here, now, let me introduce myself! My name’s Inasa! I’ll be helping you evacuate, today. If you would be so kind as to come gather around in the center of the room, it will make the trip much smoother! Thank you!”

There was a bit of a commotion as people shuffled around, doing their best to fit closely together in the center of the gymnasium. After a few minutes, Inasa spoke up again.“Ready, everyone?” He shouted, right as Izuku felt Katsuki’s hand grip the back of his shirt, yanking him away from the crowd. He sputtered indignantly as Katsuki dragged him to the edge of the room, pushing his back against the wall. Inasa looked over at them and grinned.

“It was nice to meet you, Deku! I wish I could stay longer. If I’m around long enough to meet you again, I’d love to get to know you better!”

Izuku’s brow furrowed, but he didn’t get a chance to say anything before Inasa began yelling again.

“All right! Here we go!”

The air inside began to swirl, slowly at first, but soon picking up speed until what appeared to be a tornado formed at the center of the gymnasium. Izuku watched in half-terrified awe as the rapid winds became opaque, and he heard a loud crack from within, which, when he noticed the tornado beginning to sink in to the ground, he realized had come from the floor. It took around ten seconds before the winds began to slow and disperse. In their absence, all that remained was a massive pit at the center of the gymnasium and Izuku’s dropped jaw.

“Fuckin’ show off.” Katsuki muttered, then sighed, stretching his arms above his head. “Well, guess we should head out. Where’s your closest place?”

Izuku didn’t respond at first.

“Oi, Earth to Deku.”

Izuku jolted. “Ah, sorry!” He shook himself, and went to follow Katsuki as he grunted, opening the door to the hall. “It’s just, uhm, around two blocks east. But…“ Izuku bit his lip. “Just now, what did he *mean* by that? About being *around* long enough to meet me again?”

“Oh, yeah.” Katsuki clicked his tongue. “Fucker’s on combat duty starting tomorrow.” He said, then shrugged. “Not too concerned about him, though. You saw that shit he just pulled; he’ll be fine. He’ll be back to annoy me soon enough.” He waved his hand dismissively.

“Oh. I see.” Izuku muttered. He followed Katsuki outside, and for a moment, neither of them spoke. Then Katsuki turned a corner to head east, and for whatever reason, something came back to him.

“Hey, Kacchan… remember earlier…?” He trailed off.

“Earlier when *what?”* Katsuki grunted. “Are you asking if I’m capable of remembering past events *in general,* or something specific?”

“Ah, s-sorry.” He sputtered. “I meant earlier when you, ah, said that stuff about me assuming you, uhm, have the same…”

“Oh, the shit about your plan?” Katsuki said. “What I think defines a bad person?”

“Yeah.” Izuku nodded. “What… did you mean by that, exactly?”

Katsuki shrugged. “I just think it’s real cute how you’re just assuming my definition of a bad person is the same as yours.”

Izuku did his best to ignore the *‘cute’* part of that statement.

“Yes, but, I mean—“ he looked away. “You wouldn’t let me send up anyone *dangerous,* would you?”

“Depends how you define dangerous.” Katsuki answered. “If you mean people who’ve committed violent crimes, then no. But my ability just lets me see the stuff humans don’t want other humans to know about. That includes a lot of pretty benign shit.”

Izuku blinked. “Such as…?”

“Eh, drug addictions, unusual fetishes, shit like that.” He said, then snorted. “I *honestly* could not give *less* of a fuck about ninety percent of the secrets humans keep.”

“Oh.” Izuku mumbled. “So, what you’re saying is… You wouldn’t tell me about any of those people.”

“Absolutely fucking not.” He replied, his tone joyous. “Pretty sure Heaven would be damn near empty if I did, anyway. I mean, do you have *any* idea how many religious people are actually kinky as shit? Like, at *least* fifty percent.”

"Excuse me?"

"You heard me." Katsuki snorted. "It's all that repression, y'know? That *'leave room for the holy spirit when you slow dance'* type shit, or pamphlets sayin' you'll burn for eternity if you jack off." Katsuki made a vulgar gesture, and all Izuku could do was stare at him, mortified, as he continued his rant. "It's just what happens when you attach feelings of shame to natural desires. The desires don't go away; they just get fucking *weirder."* He rattled on. "I mean, *fuck,* the day I met you, you sent up a woman who almost *exclusively* fantasized about getting pissed on by, like, thirty-plus people, or something, and I just sat there and watched it happen 'cause, frankly, *'what makes you horny'* isn't my litmus test for moral character."

Izuku just gaped at him, eyes wide and cheeks burning.

How can he just say stuff like that aloud?

"So, you still wanna work with me?" Katsuki snorted.

Izuku opened his mouth, closed it, then opened it again.

"I-I mean, it's still better than nothing, I guess." He scratched his head. "But… there's really nothing I can say to convince you otherwise?"

"Not a goddamn thing." Katsuki said, grinning. "Sorry, Deku. You're just gonna have to make peace with the fact that at least half the people you send up are gonna be into some *things."*

Izuku sighed, turning his head away, his cheeks heated. "I guess… some sins *are* worse than others."

"Damn right," Katsuki said. "And I mean, shit, if Heaven's gonna be full of people who've got a stick up their ass, might as well let in the people who're already into that, anyway."

Izuku felt something bubble up inside of him, bursting out in the form of an abrupt laugh that surprised even him. He reflexively smacked his hands over his mouth to stifle it, but the grin on Katsuki's face let him know that it was too late.

Chapter End Notes

what kinda demon are you? i think I'd prrrrrobably be a pride demon, as I, too, am decent at most things but not particularly talented in any one area lmao
The interconnectedness of the type system is somewhat inspired by Nen in HxH. There's actually a fair amount more to it than what All Might mentioned here, but those things will reveal themselves over time. Oh, and I hope the image embedding fucking worked lol. Never tried to do that before, but then, this is the only fic I've written where I feel that having diagrams would probably be helpful at some points. Kinda scared tho i really hope the image isn't fucked up. android users pls let me know if ur okay

ANYWAY. Thanks for reading! Hope y'all enjoyed this chapter as much as i enjoyed writing it. If you did, pls consider leaving a comment. I know i don't often reply (I never know how to thank people in a way that's proportional to the nice things they say. also anxiety. at this point i'm afraid that if i reply to anyone (who isn't asking a question), people i don't reply to will think i'm ignoring them) but please know that i do read every comment and i sincerely appreciate all of them. I think i mentioned this at the end of Bluebird, but i actually fucking print out all the comments i get and put them in a Very Embarrassing binder, and uhhhhh yeah i'm gonna stop talking now.

Anyway. Lots of fun shit and suggestive banter ahead lol. Until next time, my dudes!

Chapter 4: Second Sunset

Chapter Summary

> “So… you think I have a *moral* imperative to join you?”
>
> “I *know* you do.”
>
> Izuku scoffed. “I find that very hard to believe.”
>
> And then Katsuki smiled, in this slow, off-color way that immediately put Izuku on guard.

Chapter Notes

> back on my bullshit lmao

See the end of the chapter for more notes

In the end, they managed to evacuate everyone with time left to spare. As the last set of clothes fell to the floor, Katsuki breathed a sigh of relief and took a seat on the altar. Izuku watched, wincing, as the Demon leaned back on his hands and propped a foot up on the edge, his muddy combat boots leaving filthy marks on the pristine, white fabric.

“Can’t you at least *try* to show a little respect?” He grumbled.

“I’ve got none to give.” Katsuki shot back, staring vacantly at the ceiling.

For a moment, Izuku was taken aback, his jaw clenching as he stared at the irreverent Demon, anger bubbling up inside him. He opened his mouth to retort, but the words died on his tongue.

“Okay, that was kinda harsh.” Katsuki said, grimacing, as though the act of admitting it caused him physical pain. “It’s… It’s not *you* I hate. It’s just, y’know, what you stand for.”

Izuku’s anger calmed down, but only slightly.

“Isn’t that functionally the same as hating me?”

Katsuki laughed, finally tearing his eyes away from the ceiling and looking at him. “You tell me, Deku. I’m taking a page out of your book, after all. The phrase ‘love the sinner, hate the sin’ ring any bells?” He asked. “Like, I can see why you’d think that, but no, it's really not.”

Izuku stared at him for a while, eyes narrowing. “Okay…?”

“Look, let’s put it like this.” He said, sighing again. “I hate the shit they make you *do,* Deku. I hate that you help prop up their bullshit, and I hate that you’re brainwashed into thinking it makes sense.” He said, pausing for a moment. “But I don’t hate *you*.” He eventually continued. “If I truly hated you, I wouldn’t want you to Fall.”

Izuku held eye contact with him for a while.

“So what you’re saying is,” he lowered his chin slightly, squinting. “You want me to Fall because you… *like* me?” He raised an eyebrow.

Katsuki snorted. “No, not particularly.” He replied, leaning forward a bit. “You’re actually really fucking annoying, honestly. But it’s kinda like dealing with a kid, y’know. You do dumb shit because you don’t know any better.” He shrugged. “It’s irritating, but I’m not, like, *mad* at you ‘cuz of it.”

Izuku clenched his jaw. “I really don’t see how insulting me lends itself to your goal.”

Katsuki laughed again, pushing himself onto his feet. “Yeah, maybe it doesn’t.” He took a few steps down the aisle, until he stood just a few feet away from him, smirking. “Then again, the last angel I got this close to didn’t make it out alive, so y’know,” he shrugged again. “Compared to my past interactions with you fucks, I might as well be sucking your fucking cock right now.”

“Oh, for—“ Izuku face-palmed, his cheeks heating up. “Would it *kill* you to tone down the vulgarity?”

“Hmm.” Katsuki paused, pursing his lips, as if contemplating it. “No, maybe not.” He finally replied. “But you’re the one who wanted to be tempted. You signed up for this shit, Deku.” He said, snorting.

Izuku groaned, averting his eyes and nodding. A begrudging agreement.

After a few seconds, Katsuki spoke up again. “Seriously, though, Deku—think *real* carefully about if this is what you truly want.” He said. “‘Cuz frankly, if I end up having to clear my fuckin’ schedule only for your wishy-washy, birdbrained ass to back out, I swear I’ll break your stupid halo over my knee. You’re really, *really* sure?”

Izuku turned, meeting his eye again. “I’m sure.”

For a long moment, Katsuki maintained the eye-contact, his gaze calculating. Eventually, he sighed and brushed past him. “In that case, when’re you scheduled next?”

“I, ahh—“ He fumbled for a moment as he moved to follow him. “Wednesday.”

Katsuki nodded, opening the door. “Alright.” He said. “Guess I’ll see you then.” Katsuki started down the street.

“W-Wait!” Izuku called out. “How will I find you again?”

Katsuki stopped, turning around. He squinted up at the sky, then looked at him again. "Y'know what? Don't even worry about it. I'll find *you."* With that, he began walking away again.

"Oh. Okay…" He mumbled. "Um. But how…?"

Katsuki snorted, ducking into an alleyway cast in shadow. "Same way I always do."

"Which is…?" Izuku called out.

But Katsuki was already gone.

The following morning, Izuku awoke to an odd pulsating sensation in his right hand. Sluggishly, he pulled his arm from under his pillow to look at it. He was still half-asleep, and his vision was blurry, but the vague, fuzzy sight of *black markings* on his hand was enough to shock him into cognizance.

Izuku shot upright in bed, his eyes quickly focusing in, and for several seconds, he was just dumbstruck. There, on his right hand, was what looked to be a black, tree-like scar. It stemmed from his palm and wrapped around the back of his hand like lighting, branching out in an intricate, almost fractal-like pattern. He ran his fingers over it, but nothing happened. Izuku's heart rate picked up as he thought back to the day before, the memory of himself reaching out and grabbing Katsuki's hand replaying endlessly in his mind. Without a second thought, he flung himself out of bed, ripping open the top drawer of his dresser. He pawed through it frantically, carelessly tossing hats and scarves over his shoulder until he found a pair of gloves. He then proceeded to throw on the first vaguely presentable outfit he found before sliding the gloves on and heading out.

It was roughly six o'clock in the morning, on a Saturday. All Might wouldn't be at the school, but Izuku knew the path to his first circle residence like the back of his hand.

Well, perhaps that wasn't the best comparison. After all, he didn't exactly know the back of his hand *anymore.*

Izuku ran all the way to All Might's doorstep, and proceeded to knock on the front door insistently and continuously until his knuckles were met with empty space.

"Midoriya?" All Might was still in his sleep clothes, and looked as if he'd just rolled out of bed.

"All Might, I-I—" Izuku stammered. "I'm so sorry to bother you so early, I just—"

"No, no," All Might shook his head, stepping aside. "Come in, my boy."

Izuku interrupted his panicked expression with an appreciative, if strained, smile, as he came in, toeing off his shoes as his mentor shut the door behind him.

"I'm really, *really* sorry." He repeated.

“It’s quite alright, Midoriya.” All Might said. “Just tell me what’s going on.”

“Well, it’s—“ Izuku quickly slid off the glove on his right hand, lifting it so All Might could see. “I just—I just woke up and this was there, a-and,” he swallowed, voice wavering. “I think it’s because I accidentally touched him yesterday, w-without my shield up.”

All Might placed a heavy hand on his shoulder and smiled. “Oh, Midoriya, it’s nothing to worry about.” He said, laughing. “Just a stint of corruption damage is all. It should go away on its own.”

Izuku lowered his hand a bit. “Oh…”

“I understand why you’d be alarmed, though.” He said. “I know I was the first time it happened to me. It’s really quite something, isn’t it?”

Izuku smiled weakly, nodding. “Y-Yeah, it really is…” He leaned back against the door, sighing. “That’s a relief, though. I was, um... pretty scared.”

“A smart reaction, if you ask me.”

Izuku laughed slightly. “Um, so… how long will it take to go away?”

All Might pursed his lips. “It should start to fade in a few days. Might take a couple of weeks to completely disappear, though.”

“Weeks?”

All Might nodded, smiling apologetically. “Well, you know. Your body needs time to clean itself up.” He said. “I do have something that should help, though. It’s called fire tea. I believe I’ve got some left over from when I was on active duty…” He said, beginning to shuffle toward the kitchen.

“O-Oh!” Izuku said, trailing behind him. “Thank you, All Might!”

All Might waved his hand, as if to say, ‘of course.’ He opened up the pantry and began searching, pushing various things aside until he found a large box near the back. “Ah, here we are.” He said. “I can give you some to take with you, too, if you’d like.”

“Really?” Izuku said. “That would be wonderful. Thank you so much!”

“It’s really no problem.” All Might said, pulling out a kettle and filling it up, before setting it on the stove. “Since you’re already here though, how about you go ahead and tell me how it went, eh?” He grinned. “I want to hear every detail.”

Izuku smiled, and pulled out a chair at the kitchen table.

The surface on Wednesday morning was mostly quiet, apart from the sound of birds chirping, and the rumble of the ongoing battle a couple miles out, which Izuku had long since learned to tune out. He landed near his first destination, and spent a moment just looking around,

half-expecting Katsuki to simply materialize in front of him. After a minute, he sighed and began walking slowly down the sidewalk.

Katsuki hadn't given him much information on how he intended to find him, if there was anything he could do to make it easier, or even how long it would take. It was sort of aggravating, when he thought about it. The Demon was almost pathologically cryptic when it came to things like this. Izuku sighed as he meandered into an alley, stopping to lean back against an old dumpster. He closed his eyes and wondered if it'd be petty for him to count the minutes until Katsuki got there. His lips quirked up at the thought, and—

"Hey."

Izuku shrieked, the feathers on his wings ruffling as he leapt forward and turned around. And there he was, sitting on the lid of the dumpster, his legs spread out, tail flicking around behind him.

"Why do you always do that?!" Izuku shouted.

"Do what." He deadpanned. Izuku stared into his glowing eyes, glaring. After a drawn-out moment, Katsuki's expression morphed into one of performative realization. "Ohh, you mean sneaking up on you?" He said, leaning forward. "Yeah, see, the thing about that is… it's fucking funny."

"Hilarious." Izuku rolled his eyes.

"Yeah," Katsuki grinned, hopping off the dumpster. He brushed off the back of his pants. "That, but unironically."

Izuku sighed, taking quick strides out of the alley. Katsuki trailed behind him.

"Talked it over with the others." Katsuki said, conversationally. "As of today, I'm on 'special assignment.'"

Izuku slowed, looking over his shoulder. "What does that mean?"

Katsuki shrugged. "Whatever the fuck we want it to mean." He said. "But in this case, it means we've decided you're worth the effort of trying to tempt."

Izuku blinked a few times. "Um. Good? Ahhh…" He glanced away. "I'm not really sure how to feel about that."

Katsuki snickered as they approached the front entrance to the church.

By the time they had finished everything, it was around an hour before sunset. The two of them decided to check some buildings in the surrounding area for any remaining stragglers. Izuku was peering through the dark, dusty window of a dilapidated motel when he heard him.

"What happens if a bug flies into your halo?"

Izuku was so bewildered by the question that somehow, his instincts managed to bypass an entire spectrum of confused reactions, and he wound up defaulting back to something mundane. He turned and looked at Katsuki over his shoulder. “Sorry, what?”

The Demon shrugged, his gaze drifting off to the side, as if bored. “Just wondering. Like, does it get zapped? Become a little bug angel?” He asked, smirking. “Does it go to bug-heaven?”

“…Where did this even come from?”

“S’crossed my mind a couple times. So?”

“Uhh,” Izuku squinted. “I mean, I don’t really know? As far as I’m aware, nothing really happens.” He said, shuffling over to try the door. It seemed to be jammed. He kept trying it, and his voice was strained as he continued, “Which I suppose would make sense, if you think about it. I fly at pretty high speeds sometimes, so if that were the case I would expect to have noticed by now.”

Izuku’s muscles tensed and cramped as he continued to fight with the door, wiggling the knob and mumbling under his breath. After a second, he spotted Katsuki approaching in his periphery, and took it as a cue to step aside. Taking his place, Katsuki grabbed the doorknob and, without so much as a grunt, proceeded to shove the door open in one sharp, efficient movement.

“Oh.” Izuku said, surprised, and not quite sure how to react. When Katsuki took his hand off, he noticed that the doorknob had been deformed, as though partially melted. “Uh… wow.”

Katsuki grinned. “And for the low, low price of your soul, you too could have powers with actual practical applications, Deku.”

Izuku rolled his eyes, brushing past him. It was only after he stepped inside that he realized the door had actually been boarded shut from the inside, though all that remained now were splintered planks and loose nails.

The room itself appeared to be the motel’s lobby, though as far as he could tell, it was vacant. Most of the furniture was hidden beneath dusty sheets, as though it had been abandoned months ago.

But you never know.

“…I guess we should check the rooms.” Izuku said. Katsuki hummed, and went on ahead of him.

One by one, they knocked on doors, and one by one, Katsuki would force them open with an unsettling ease that had All Might’s words echoing inside Izuku’s mind.

“Wrath Demons— by far the strongest among the Demons, as far as sheer physical power is concerned.”

Izuku felt uneasy, his pulse picking up each time Katsuki showed him the proof of this fact. Whether or not the Demon was doing it as a deliberate show of strength, Izuku couldn't tell, but if he was, he'd certainly achieved his goal.

He watched as Katsuki took his hand off one of the doorknobs, and in the dim light, he could see that the metal was actually glowing slightly. He swallowed.

Izuku always knew Katsuki was stronger than him. And it wasn't even that there was anything unique about Katsuki; as things stood, most Demons on the surface were probably stronger than him. But it was one thing to be passively aware of the power imbalance and quite another to actually observe the consequences of it. To watch this man, this *Demon,* and be viscerally aware that if he wanted to kill him, he could. If he tried to do it, he would succeed.

Izuku was at his mercy.

Katsuki could do *anything* to him.

It was terrifying, yet strangely entrancing, like a tornado wreaking havoc on a city, or hellfire swallowing a skyscraper. He felt the desire to keep watching out of something like morbid fascination.

At least that's when Izuku assumed it was.

"Oi, Deku. *Deku!"*

Izuku jumped.

"Finally," Katsuki clicked his tongue. "Been tryin' to get your attention for like a thousand years, dipshit."

Izuku blinked, his eyes wide."Oh. Um." He winced.

They were back in the lobby again, he realized. Katsuki was leaning against the edge of the front desk, looking at him like he'd grown a second head.

"The hell's up with you?" Katsuki asked, leaning in closer, an eyebrow raised.

"I was just, uhh…" Izuku's eyes darted around. His mind felt scattered, but he needed to find a way out of the situation. Any longer, and Katsuki might begin extrapolating things that weren't there. Izuku opened his mouth and blurted out the first thing he thought of. "Can you pick things up with your tail?"

"What?" Katsuki seemed dumbstruck for a moment, but after a second, he snorted. Izuku took it as a sign that his diversion had worked, and the tension melted away as Katsuki continued, "Well, duh. Of course I can." He proceeded to demonstrate, the tip of his tail wrapping around a nearby lamp and flinging it across the room. It hit the wall, and the glass base shattered upon impact with the floor. "What would even be the point if I couldn't?"

Izuku shrugged, looking away. "Aren't tails usually for balance?" He laughed awkwardly.

Katsuki hummed. “Yeah, guess so.” He muttered, wandering over to the other side of the room, where the lamp had shattered. He kicked the shards around idly, and after a second, looked back at Izuku. “But I mean, strictly speaking, if you wanna know the *real* reason Demons have tails, then I’m pretty sure it’s ‘cuz God wanted us to be, like, repulsive or some shit, so he gave us traits he thought would achieve that.” He paused, then smirked, all sharp teeth and hooded eyes. His pitch dropped. “But obviously that plan backfired pretty substantially, since most humans associate us with sex to some degree.”

Izuku had no idea how he was supposed to respond to a statement like that.

He opened his mouth, closed it, and then tried again. He managed to keep his voice even when he said, “Well, lust *is* a sin, so it kind of makes sense for people to associate you with it.”

Katsuki laughed, low and breathy. “I think it’s a bit deeper than that, but sure.” After a pause, he added, “Don’t worry, though. There’re plenty of people out there who wanna fuck Angels, too.”

Izuku frowned, his cheeks burning. “O-Okay…?” He averted his eyes. “You know, I wasn’t actually worried before, but now I kind of am.”

“Oh yeah?” Katsuki asked. Izuku heard his footfalls as the Demon approached him again, stopping just short of a foot away, leaning against the front desk again. “Why? Afraid someone might try and make a pass at you?”

Izuku shuddered, looking at the floor. He mumbled, “Don’t understand why they’d even…”

“Want to?” Katsuki finished, and let it hang for a moment before pressing on. “It’s really not that hard to figure out, Deku. You *seriously* don’t know?”

“I don’t *want* to know.” Izuku said, trying his best to sound firm about it. “Can we talk about something else?”

“Why?” Katsuki asked, the corners of his lips curling up. “Gettin’ nervous?”

“I’m not nervous.”

Katsuki snickered, looking Izuku up and down. “Uh-huh. *Sure—”*

“—What did you mean earlier?” Izuku cut in. “About me being ‘worth’ trying to tempt.”

Katsuki rolled his eyes, his mischievous expression fading to boredom. He sighed. “What d’you mean?”

“Just, is there…” Izuku waved his hands around meaninglessly. “…I don’t know, some sort of *criteria* for that?”

The Demon hummed, scratching his head. “Not exactly,” He eventually replied. “It’s not really a common enough occurrence for there to be, like, a standard way to figure it out. As

things are, we mostly just judge shit on a case-by-case basis. Y'know, like, *'does the Angel seem like they can be swayed morally?'* Stuff like that."

Izuku blinked. "And you think *I* can be convinced to give up my morals?" He asked, more than a little incensed at the thought.

"What? No." Katsuki spat, scowling. "That's the *opposite* of what I was trying to say. Christ."

"Then what—"

"—Some Angels," He interrupted, pausing before continuing, "are loyal to God above all else. It's like…" He gestured vaguely. "They don't really have, like… coherent ethical principles. They kinda just do what they're told. And yeah, they *think* they're doing the right thing, but it's very dogmatic, y'know. It's like, 'this is right because God says so,' and that's the end of it."

He stopped to take a breath.

"But there're some Angels who actually *do* have strong morals." He went on. "They usually just follow God 'cuz they think that's the best way to uphold their value system. So, at least in theory, if someone could convince them there's a more effective way to do that…" He trailed off. After a moment, he shrugged and said, "Well, anyway, those are the ones worth trying to tempt: the ones who actually want to do good."

"So… you think I have a *moral* imperative to join you?"

"I *know* you do."

Izuku scoffed. "I find that very hard to believe."

And then Katsuki smiled, in this slow, off-color way that immediately put Izuku on guard.

"Oh, but there's one other type, though." He then said. "Sometimes, once in a blue moon, you'll meet an Angel who just *really* wants to sin. And like, it's *painfully* obvious. You see them and you just fucking *know."*

Izuku swallowed.

"Ah."

"Yeah. Not a lot of 'em, but they're out there." Katsuki drummed his fingers on the countertop. "So, once we've decided that someone's worth trying to tempt, the next thing we have to ask is who's up to the task. And it's a holistic thing, y'know. Usually, if we're dealing with someone who could be swayed if you just present 'em with the right information in the right way, we'll ask someone who's particularly good at rhetoric. If it's someone who just wants to sin, or some combination of the two, it gets more personal."

"I'm guessing you've done this a lot, then."

Katsuki grinned. “Nope,” he shook his head. “Not once. It’s not even remotely my area.” With his elbow on the counter, Katsuki tucked his chin into his palm, staring at Izuku with this smug, knowing look in his eyes. “Frankly, I’m not really the talking type. I’m more…” He trailed off for a moment, humming, *“...physical,* you could say.” He laughed darkly. “If someone calls *me* in to help deal with an Angel… Well, let’s just say they’re definitely not trying to *de*-escalate things.”

Katsuki stood up straight, turning to face Izuku head-on. “But despite that, everyone still thought I’d be a good fit for this, at least for *you*.” He murmured, leaning forward, just a hair’s breadth too far into Izuku’s space. “Funny how that works.” He said, hypnotic, glowing red eyes pinning Izuku in place, until eventually he sighed and broke eye contact. “Course, I didn’t come in here blind. I’ve got some plans. Got a couple tricks up my sleeve.”

Izuku swallowed. His throat felt dry, and his voice came out hoarse as he asked, “Such as…?”

“Wouldn’t you like to know.” Katsuki retorted. A second later, his eyes widened slightly and his demeanor shifted. “Ah, but that reminds me…” He opened up his rucksack, pulling out a thick, leather-bound book. “I’ve also got this.” He said, handing it to Izuku.

“What…” Izuku trailed off as he accepted it and opened it up, flipping through the pages. They were all blank. “Kacchan, is this just a blank book?”

“It’s a memo.” He said. “Y’know, a memorandor.”

“A what?”

Katsuki gave him an odd look. “Wait, seriously? You *really* don’t know?” After a second, he groaned, rolling his eyes. “Guess I shouldn’t be surprised.”

“What do you mean?” Izuku pressed. “What is it?”

“It’s a type of communication device.”

Izuku stared at the unassuming book for a few seconds.

“…Explain.”

Katsuki sighed. “D’you know about the double agent defector incident?”

“Oh!” Izuku chirped. “Faux-Fallen Angels, right? Izaiya and Setsuko?” He asked. “The spies who rejected God?”

“Historical inaccuracy aside, yeah.” Katsuki replied. “When they were still trying to keep tabs on us, they needed a way to communicate. So, they made these.” He gestured toward the book. “Trick is that each memo has a twin. It’s basically like a two-way diary. Whatever one person writes in their book will also appear in the other.”

“So…” Izuku said. “You’re giving me this to communicate with you?”

“What? No.” Katsuki said, taking the book out of his hand. “This one’s mine. You’ve gotta find your own.”

Izuku blinked. “Uhhh…”

“Now that you’ve touched it, it should be in Heaven somewhere.”

“That’s really not very specific.”

“It doesn’t need to be.” Katsuki said, shrugging. “Just trust me, Deku; it might take a few days, but if you’re patient, it’ll find its way to you.”

“What’s up with you?” Uraraka suddenly asked.

The four of them—Izuku, Uraraka, Shinsou and Iida—were sitting on the stone wall that framed the flying field.

“Um. What do you mean?” Izuku asked.

She shrugged. “You just seem happy.”

Izuku tensed. “Oh,” He muttered. “Wait, do I usually seem unhappy to you…?”

“Oh, no, I didn’t mean it like that!” She said, waving her hands. “I just meant—“

“—You’ve been smiling this whole time.” Shinsou interjected, and the sound of his low, monotonous voice made Izuku jump as he reflexively looked at him. Somehow, he didn’t expect him to have been paying attention.

Swallowing, Izuku turned away, facing forward. “Well, that’s… news to me.” He said, laughing awkwardly.

“How are things going on your missions?” Iida chimed in.

“Fine!” Izuku replied, perhaps a bit too quickly. “I-I mean, it’s challenging work, but it’s rewarding, so…”

“That Demon hasn’t given you any more trouble, then?” Shinsou asked.

“Wh-what?”

“The Demon.” Shinsou side-eyed him. “The one you said you met.”

“You met a *Demon?!”* Uraraka exclaimed.

“Midoriya?!” Iida shouted, almost simultaneously.

“Wait, you didn’t *tell* them?” Shinsou frowned, finally turning to look at him fully.

Izuku rubbed the back of his neck sheepishly. “It, uhh… It didn’t really come up?”

Uraraka snorted. "'Didn't come up'?" She repeated incredulously. *"Izuku."*

"I'm sorry, okay?" He shot back, holding his hands up defensively. "I-I just didn't think it was such a huge deal, is all! I mean… nothing *bad* happened."

"Oh, thank goodness," Iida said, his hand over his heart.

"So you haven't seen him again, then?" Shinsou probed.

Izuku's fingers turned white as he gripped the edge of the cold stone wall.

"…Midoriya?"

"Oh, ah… no," Izuku fumbled, laughing nervously. "I guess he must've lost interest…"

Izuku could feel Shinsou's eyes on him, but he kept his gaze fixed on his shoes.

"…Really?"

"Really!" Izuku replied, a foul, sour taste blooming on his tongue that he tried to swallow down before he tacked on, "I promise."

"Well, that's good." Uraraka said, still sounding a bit exasperated. Iida hummed in agreement.

Izuku waited for a response from Shinsou. It never came.

All Might entered his study with one hand wrapped around the handle of a large bucket. He set it down beside the chalkboard before turning toward Izuku. "So, tell me, my boy—how much do you know about the soul?"

Izuku tensed, caught off guard by the question. "Um…"

"It's not a trick question, don't worry." All Might said, chuckling. "Just tell me anything—anything at all."

Izuku relaxed slightly, his face scrunching up as his eyes fixated on the wooden floor. "Well… I know that when I put up a barrier, what I'm *really* doing is hardening my soul so that it can't be corrupted through touch." He said, then shrugged. "But I think that's all I've been explicitly told. Everything else is sort of just a jumble of contradictory rumors…"

All Might hummed. "Yes, that's fairly typical for someone at your level." He said. "I should say, though—the part about barriers isn't quite right. It'd be more accurate to say you're *flexing* it."

"Flexing, huh…" Izuku mumbled. "I wonder why they didn't say that before, then."

"As you mentioned before, there's a lot of misconceptions floating around." He said. "But that's what's technically happening. You're just flexing the outer layer of your soul so that it's

impermeable."

"Outer… layer?" Izuku blinked, scratching his head. "I didn't even know souls *had* layers."

"Oh?" All Might said, seeming genuinely surprised. "That's interesting. I think I knew that at your level, but perhaps things have gotten stricter." He paused for a moment, rubbing his chin. "Well, to give you the abridged version—essentially, your soul has two main parts." He held up one finger. "The outer shell," he raised a second finger, "and a fluid-like substance contained within it."

"Fluid?"

"Yes." He said. "It's called serthus; it generates the power Angels use to fight, and the outer shell protects it."

"So this… *serthus* is the source of our power?"

"No. Almost, but not quite. It *generates* power." He replied. "It's important to be precise about this, because although an Angel can temporarily run out of power, the serthus remains exactly the same in both form and volume, at least under typical circumstances."

"Oh," Izuku said, squinting. "Wait, so there're times when it *wouldn't* stay the same?"

All Might smiled. "Well, sure. What do you think corruption damage does?"

Izuku glanced down at his hand, where the dark, lightning-like scar remained, albeit faded. "I…"

"The main difference between Angels and Demons, at least on a physiological level, is the resting state of their soul."

"…Demons have souls?"

"Oh, yes. Corrupted ones, but souls nonetheless." He explained. "Essentially, when an Angel sustains corruption damage, the serthus becomes partially coagulated." He said. "In those cases, given time, the serthus will circulate and return to its liquid state. But if an Angel's serthus completely coagulates, then there's no going back. That's what happens when an Angel Falls."

Izuku hummed, nodding reverently. Absent-mindedly, he rubbed the spot when the scar was more prominent.

"There are other circumstances where things can happen to the serthus, but for now, let's focus on how one actually utilizes this power."

Izuku looked up, eyes sparkling with excitement just as All Might was turning around. He pulled open a drawer on the far side of the room, taking out something Izuku couldn't quite see. He dusted it off with his hands, and then turned toward Izuku again.

“If you want to use your power, you’ll need a vessel to channel it through. That’s where these come in.” All Might handed him something that Izuku quickly recognized as a pair of gloves of some sort. They were an off-white, cream color, and the embroidery on the back formed a large, golden sun, the rays of which extended toward the fingertips.

“These are technically training gauntlets,” All Might said. “I wish I could offer you a more substantial weapon, like a sword, or a bow, once you’ve gotten a hang of the basics, but that would attract too much attention. You can still pack quite a punch with just these, though.”

Izuku smiled. “Well, hopefully by then I’ll be up for ascension.”

“Oh, I’m sure you will be.” All Might said. “I’ve already submitted your application, actually.”

Izuku tore his gaze away from the gauntlets, his face lighting up. “Really?!”

“Really!” All Might replied. “It’ll be a few weeks before the Council gets around to reviewing it, but… fingers crossed!” He said, grinning. “Now, then!” He clapped his hands together. “Shall we get started?”

Izuku nodded, eagerly slipping the gauntlets on, pleased to find that they fit him well.

“Ah,” All Might held up a finger. “One last thing you should know—well, two, actually.” He said. “Firstly, there is generally a pretty steep learning curve. I’m not saying this to intimidate you, I just want you to know that you probably won’t figure everything out on the first try, and that’s perfectly alright.”

Izuku hummed. “Well, okay. No problem. What’s the other thing?”

“This is probably going to hurt.”

He blinked. “Sorry, what?”

All Might shrugged, offering a tight, sympathetic smile. “It’s just something every Angel has to deal with in the beginning, unfortunately.” He explained. “Although these powers are innate, your body isn’t accustomed to using them, yet. The damage won’t be irreparable, of course, but…” His eyes drifted toward the floor, “Well, there’s a chance you’ll throw up.”

Izuku gulped.

“…So that’s what the bucket was for.”

All Might laughed awkwardly. “Listen, try not to focus on it too much. Just be prepared.”

“A-Alright,” Izuku replied. “I’ll do my best?”

“That’s what I like to hear!” All Might said, grabbing the bucket and setting it down a bit closer to where Izuku stood. “Are you ready?”

“I hope so.”

All Might laughed.

“In that case, close your eyes.”

Izuku returned to his room that night with the taste of bile on his tongue and an ache deep inside his chest.

As he shed his clothes and prepared to step under the shower spray, the sight of his reflection gave him pause. He stood there for a while, eyes fixated on his chest. Bruises like nebulas bloomed from his sternum, and from there, sprawled out across his upper body. They stretched out all the way to his shoulders and to the bottom of his ribcage, colors gradually blending into his natural complexion like watercolors.

Izuku was never one to give up on… well, pretty much anything, really, but even he had to admit: searching for the memo was really trying his patience.

It’d been five days.

Five days since Katsuki first introduced him to the concept of a memorandor before flippantly sending him on his way without so much as a hint about where he ought to look for the damn thing. He’d spent more time at the library in the past few days than he had in almost his entire afterlife, and the longer his search went on, the more questions people asked. Just the other day, he nearly launched out of his skin, feathers standing on end as he reflexively extended his wings, like some kind of cornered animal, and all this because someone tapped him on the shoulder at some indeterminate point during the nth hour of his search.

“Woah, hey.” Shinsou said, putting his hands up. “It’s just me, Midoriya.”

Izuku relaxed slightly, his bulging eyes receding back into their rightful position.

“Shinsou,” He said, exhaling.

“Yeah.” He blinked. “What’s gotten into you? Are you alright?”

Izuku’s mouth open, and for a while, no sound came out. Eventually, he managed to offer a small, shaky, “Wh-what do you mean…?”

Shinsou arched an eyebrow. “How long have you been here?”

“I, uhh…” He paused, glancing out the window. He arrived sometime around noon, and it was now what appeared to be early evening. “…Awhile?” He replied, laughing nervously.

“I figured.” Shinsou deadpanned. “I’ve been here three times in the past week, and every single time, you’ve been here.” He said, frowning. “I know we don’t have an exam coming up.”

Izuku bit his lip, averting his gaze. He knew this would happen. His friends were far too perceptive for their own good—especially Shinsou. Izuku had spent a considerable amount of his time these last few days contemplating ways he could respond to such questions without having to outright lie again. But in his exhausted state, he just couldn't seem to gather his thoughts enough to form a strategic response.

After some length of silence, he sighed. "It's… I'm sorry," He mumbled, looking down at his shoes. "It's nothing to worry about. Promise. It's just…" He glanced briefly at Shinsou's face, his violet eyes narrowed in some mixture of concern and suspicion. Izuku swallowed, and looked away again. "Just something I'm working on." He quickly said. "There's nothing wrong, I just kind of… lost track of time, I guess."

Shinsou stared at him for a while. Beneath the weight of his gaze, Izuku felt naked, the cool air creating pin pricks on his exposed flesh. "I suppose that would be in character for you."

Izuku laughed, but it was sharp, short, and much louder than what would normally be considered suitable for a library. He quickly slammed his palms over his mouth, looking around anxiously. Fortunately, there weren't too many people in the library at that hour, but a cursory glance across the room yielded the sight of a withering glare from one of the librarians, which had Izuku slinking back beneath the cover of his wings, like a turtle into its shell.

When he finally looked at Shinsou again, he was smiling slightly, though it faded as the librarian briskly moved out of sight.

"There's something you're not telling me, though." He said—not a question, but a statement of fact.

Izuku sighed, and, maintaining eye contact, replied, "…Yes."

Shinsou held his gaze for a while afterward, most likely waiting for some kind of explanation, but as seconds ticked by in silence, his eyes seemed to dull, and eventually, broke away. He glanced down, eyes lingering on the floor for a moment before looking up again, hazily settling on some indistinct nothingness behind Izuku.

Shinsou was never one to give voice to his insecurities, at least as far as things like these were concerned, but Izuku had known him long enough to recognize them when they appeared.

"I'd tell you if something was seriously wrong." Izuku said, speaking softly, his brows pinching together. "You know that, right?"

Shinsou blinked a few times, the fog dissipating as his eyes focused on Izuku's again. Izuku offered a small smile. A consolation prize. Shinsou tensed slightly, and then relaxed.

"Yeah." He said. "Yeah, that's—I know."

"I appreciate you worrying about me, though." Izuku said. "It's really sweet of you."

Shinsou's eyes widened slightly, and he quickly turned around, moving toward the door.

"It's getting late. I should probably head back." He muttered, and in a slightly more stern tone, he added, "So should you."

Izuku deflated slightly, but he knew he had a point.

"You're right." He sighed, hastily returning the small pile of books to the shelf, moving as quickly as he could while still keeping everything in order, because Shinsou was waiting for him. He didn't ask him to, but he was.

After a minute, he stood up again, jogging after Shinsou, catching the door as he followed behind him. He panted slightly, his breath visible in the cold air.

"Hey, um. I mean it. I really do appreciate it." He reiterated. "It's very kind of you to be, um, concerned about me."

Shinsou sighed, stuffing his hands into his pockets.

And Izuku couldn't be sure, exactly, but as he trailed behind his friend in the cold, rapidly deepening night, he could've sworn he heard him reply:

"You say that as though it was a decision I made."

Katsuki stood on the roof of an old schoolhouse, leaning back against the railing, devouring another one of those fruits he liked—the ones that evoked some disconcerting image of violence. Izuku had just finished lamenting his struggle to find the memo.

"What the fuck?" He said, speaking with his mouth full. "Deku, what part of *'be patient and wait*' did you not understand?"

"Excuse me?"

"What, you don't remember?" He said, licking his lips. "I said *it* would find its way to *you,* dipshit."

Izuku stared at him for a while, mouth agape, blinking rapidly. "W-Well, you could've been more *clear!"*

Katsuki gave a mirthless laugh. "What, did you want me to give you a checklist of shit *not* to do?"

"It might have *helped!*"

Katsuki glowered as he licked the blood-red juice off his fingers, one by one. "Literally all you had to do was just go about your daily routine or whatever." He said, his lips stained red. "Don't know how you managed to fuck up doing *nothing.* It's almost impressive."

Izuku frowned, looking away, his face beginning to feel very hot. Katsuki's brash attitude certainly wasn't making him feel *less* embarrassed. "I just wanted to make sure I found it before someone else did." He mumbled, rubbing the back of his neck. "Give me a break."

Katsuki's expression seemed to soften slightly. He shuffled closer, exhaling. "That's not something you need to worry about."

"What makes you so sure?"

Katsuki shrugged. "I've never heard of it happening before."

"Kacchan…" Izuku sighed, and in his sleep deprived state, he spoke without forethought. "I don't think you understand how much trouble I could get in if the wrong person finds it." He said, anxiety saturating his tone. "I-I mean, with all due respect, it doesn't sound like you're very familiar with these things, and I mean, it would've been *nice* if you could've told me what it was before you had me touch it and, and—"

"Hey."

Izuku could feel the heat of Katsuki's hand, fingers partially shifted into claws and hovering just beneath his chin, as close as possible without actually touching him. Izuku put his barrier up and held his breath.

"Look at me, Deku."

Izuku released a shuddering breath, and when he turned his head, Katsuki was much closer than he expected him to be, his red eyes glowing like a second sunset against the orange sky.

"You've been stayin' up late for this shit, haven't you."

Izuku's face heated up slightly. "…Sometimes."

Katsuki scoffed. "Fuckin' idiot. You look like hell."

Despite himself, Izuku smiled at the irony of that statement.

After a moment, Katsuki sighed. "Look," he said. "You're right. I should've told you what it was first."

Izuku blinked a few times. He hadn't expected the Demon to admit fault so easily.

"...But." He continued, his tone firm. "I really mean it when I say this isn't something you should freak out over." He said, the tip of his claws still just a phantom presence against Izuku's skin. "I have it on good authority that what you're worried about is, at the very least, rare. Even if someone does find it, odds are, they won't know what it is."

"Okay, but—"

"I'm not finished." He interjected, claws finally making contact with his skin. "Listen. On the off chance that whoever finds it *does* know what it is, finding out who it's linked to is not a

trivial thing to do, Deku. It's possible, but it'll take awhile." His claws lightly tapped against the underside of Izuku's chin. Katsuki smirked. "And here's the kicker: if someone else opens it, I'll *know.* And all I need to do is sever the connection. Past that point, there's nothing they can do. Got it?"

Izuku swallowed. The movement of his throat made Katsuki's knuckles brush up against it. "And you're sure you can do that in time?"

Katsuki grinned. "All I gotta do is destroy my own." He said, and out of the corner of Izuku's eye, he spotted Katsuki's other hand resting on the metal railing. He watched as his fingers gradually started to sink into the bar, the surrounding metal glowing red as it collapsed, liquifying beneath his touch. Katsuki licked his lips. "I'm pretty good at destroying things."

Izuku could feel the heat radiating off the molten metal as Katsuki slowly pulled away, his hands sliding into his pockets.

"Don't over-think it." He said, beginning to walk away. He approached a spot behind where the school's stairwell would've been—the only part of the roof cast in shadow. He threw one last look over his shoulder. "Oh, and get some fucking sleep, while you're at it." After that, he stepped into the shadows and dissipated into the darkness. Izuku spent a good few minutes just standing there, staring at the place where Katsuki used to be. Eventually, he sat down.

He stayed there for around half an hour before he finally gathered the will to get up and fly home.

It'd been two days since Izuku had stopped his search, and though he felt better physically, it'd be a lie to say that the anxiety hadn't gotten to him.

It wasn't that he didn't believe Katsuki. He knew for a fact that the Demon was telling the truth, at least to the best of his knowledge. Still, the waiting game fostered a strong sense of unease within him that he just couldn't seem to shake.

After around two hours spent lying awake in his bed, Izuku decided to get up. He paced around for a few minutes, silently warring with the temptation to just go back to the library and continue his search. There were only a few sections he hadn't been through, after all. Surely it wouldn't take more than a couple of hours.

But eventually, the memory of Katsuki's words echoing inside his mind won out, and with a sigh, he forced himself to sit at his desk, switching his study lamp on and wincing at the sudden light.

He just needed to get his mind off of it, he decided. Mumbling under his breath, Izuku begun searching through his school bag. He had an assignment due in a couple of days, and figured he might as well get started.

Izuku grabbed his notebook and the assigned text—some book called *The Economics of Faith* that he'd admittedly been putting off reading for a little while now, due to lack of interest.

Better late than never, he figured, sighing as he cracked it open.

Except there was nothing there.

Literally nothing. The pages were completely blank. Izuku flipped to the next page, but that one was blank, too.

And the next one.

And the next.

He glanced at the cover just to make sure he'd grabbed the correct book, and then a flash of some irregularity caught his eye. He turned to a page near the beginning, and it felt as though his entire world just clicked into place.

There, he found a single sentence in surprisingly elegant script:

Looks like you finally found it, nerd.

He stared at it for a long time, his hands shaking. The ink was so red it almost looked as though the words had been cut into the flesh of something living.

Eventually, he shook himself out of his trance long enough to pick up a pen.

Kacchan, I needed this book for an assignment!!

Writing in the book felt different, somehow. As though his pen was sinking deeper into the parchment, transcending a barrier he never knew existed. After a second, he added:

It's due in two days, what am I supposed to do?!

After that, he forced himself to put the pen down, and stared at the page. A minute went by, and suddenly he felt the book warm up in his hands, the pages bowing outward before relaxing again, almost as though it truly were a living, breathing thing. He watched as, stroke by stroke, the words appeared right there before his eyes, until the book went cold in his hands, reverting back into its inanimate state as if to signal the message's end. And his eyes scanned over it a few times.

Not my fault you left that shit to the last minute, dumbass.

Despite the insult, he found himself smiling.

Izuku imagined him somewhere far away, where the skies were dark and the environment unforgiving. A place where ash fell like snow and embers drifted across the sky in a parody of starlight. And somewhere in that vast expanse, Katsuki's long, clawed fingers wrapped around the spine of the book as he walked alone, his glowing, red eyes just passing lanterns in the perpetual night.

Chapter End Notes

lol sorry this took so fuckin long. I've spent most of the past year either getting my ass kicked by school or working on the absolutely unhinged fucking math dissertation known as chapter 8 of By Design, with some moments in between spent working on a bkdk visual novel, yknow, just to spice things up i guess. Anyway it took a while for me to fully immerse myself in the worldbuilding of this fic again so i could make sure i wasn't unintentionally fucking up any of my plans, but yeah, we're back in business babieeeee.

Anyway, if ur still here, I love and appreciate u. if you enjoyed this, leave a comment if u feel so inclined. all comments will be given as offerings to the motivation gods lol. so yeah, see y'all next time! next chapter will come out in like a reasonable amount of time i promise lmao

Chapter 5: Mind Games

Chapter Summary

Eventually, Izuku sighed, and gave in. “Sure, why not.”

This was inevitable, anyway, he told himself.

But then Katsuki gave him one of those *damn smiles* of his—the slow-spreading, mischievous ones that always seemed to precede dangerous interactions of one sort or another. Izuku’s stomach instantly filled with regret.

Chapter Notes

Welcome to sexual tension hell

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Though the memo was originally intended as a way for them to coordinate meeting locations, it wasn’t long before it turned into something more. It was mostly Izuku’s fault, really. He just couldn’t resist the urge to ask Katsuki questions, knowing that the answers were right at his fingertips.

do demons still make contracts with humans?

no

not for like 1500 years

oh

what happened 1500 years ago?

lots of shit

main thing is we figured out how to make agriculture work for us

agriculture?

don't demons feed off of sinful emotions?

that's what I meant by making it work

basically we figured out how grow food enriched with sin

oh wow

is that what that fruit you're always eating is?

the black ones with the red juice

yep.

it's called an embrite

they're full of wrath

…and also gluttony, but all our food has some amount of that in there

go figure

that's really interesting!

what do they taste like??

I'm curious

spicy

very spicy

like the kind of spicy that would make you wanna rip your tongue out

and you… ENJOY that?

hell yeah I do

is that all you ever eat?

nah

that's just what I like to eat around you

why?

I can tell it makes you unsettled

and that is extremely funny to me

oh. uhhh.

that's… weird

Do you go out of your way to make EVERYONE you interact with uncomfortable?

no

only the ones I'm trying to tempt

It was around an hour before sunset. Izuku found himself standing on the roof of an old, abandoned convenience store, his gaze sky bound. He watched in awe as the thrones led the Holy Army, smoke billowing in the distance as they blasted away swaths of Demons in their path.

"So, that's really your dream, huh?" Katsuki chimed in, his voice monotone and coming from somewhere behind him. "You wanna be a fucking ring of fire covered in eyes?"

Izuku glanced over his shoulder. “Well, no, I mean—it’d be an honor, of course! But right now, I’m just working on getting to the second sphere. I want to be on the front lines. It’s hard to imagine being as powerful as the third sphere Angels.”

Katsuki hummed, raising an eyebrow as he looked out at the horizon. “So, Angels get creepier as they become more powerful? Weird. Demons just get sexier.”

“Wha—really?”

“Yeah.” He said. “I mean, shit—have you *seen* Lucifer?” Katsuki whistled. “Dude’s like, the personification of sex.”

Izuku hesitated. “I guess that’s probably why he’s so good at corrupting others.”

Katsuki repeated his words in a high-pitched, mocking tone.

“Well, I’m not wrong!”

“Yeah, well here’s the thing, Deku. Temptation isn’t inherently bad. If you’re about to piss your fucking pants and I turn on a faucet, I mean—“ He gesticulated widely. *“Yeah,* it’s kinda mean, but also, maybe you should just use the fucking toilet?”

Izuku stared at him for a while, attempting to extrapolate some sort of underlying argument from that statement, but to no avail.

“That’s…” He squinted. “That’s a really weird analogy, Kacchan.” He said, articulating each syllable carefully. “Are you trying to frame *bullying someone into peeing their pants* as some sort of round-about form of *altruism?”* He shook his head. “I don’t know how to explain to you how fundamentally bizarre that is.”

Katsuki stared at him a moment. “Okay, yeah. Fine. I’ll give you that.”

“Is this your way of trying to tempt me?”

“Well, it’s not exactly my fucking *department,* asshole.” He said, glaring at him, but blushing slightly.

Izuku started laughing. “But I don’t—” he snorted, shoulders shaking. “I don’t even know what *point* you were trying to make just now.”

“Fuck you!” Katsuki shouted back, face turning redder. “I don’t need to hear that shit from you. Your *entire belief system* is incoherent!”

Izuku just laughed harder, clutching his stomach.

“Okay,” He wheezed, “Okay, but now I’m curious. What exactly were you trying to argue just now?”

Katsuki sighed, closing his eyes and clenching his fists. Izuku wiped the tears from his eyes and watched as he slowly counted to ten, mouthing the numbers, and then took a deep breath.

“Look, honestly? *Temptation* isn’t really even the right word for it.” He said, raking a hand through his hair. “It’s not like some kind of carnal process where the only thing pulling you in is the promise of frivolous pleasure, or some shit. I mean,” He threw his hands up, “*Are* there things like that I can capitalize on? Hell yeah. But it’s way more effective to just convince you my side’s better, and there’s more than enough evidence to back that up.”

Izuku raised an eyebrow. “Such as?”

Katsuki stared at him for a moment, looking him up and down. He crossed his arms and smirked. “Do you really wanna know?”

Izuku opened his mouth for a second, then closed it again.

Maybe this is a bad idea, he thought.

But eventually, he sighed, and gave in. “Sure, why not.”

This was inevitable, anyway, he told himself.

But then Katsuki gave him one of those *damn smiles* of his—the slow-spreading, mischievous ones that always seemed to precede dangerous interactions of one sort or another. Izuku’s stomach instantly filled with regret.

“Well, in that case…” Katsuki proceeded to reach into his rucksack and pull out a thick book. Dozens of tabs of various colors stuck out from the pages.

“Um… What is that?”

“Just something I picked up a few weeks ago.” Katsuki replied, shrugging casually. “Been tempted for a while, but I finally caved a couple days after I had to explain to you what a *fucking* memorandor was.”

Izuku squinted, trying to read the cover, but Katsuki’s hands were in the way.

“Okay…?” He said. “But what *is* it?”

“Oh, you know—just a brief little synopsis of the sociopolitical clusterfuck you call Heaven.” He replied off-handedly, beginning to flip through the tabbed pages. After a moment, Katsuki grinned, seeming to have found what he was looking for.

“Alright, so here’s what we’ll do.” He said. “As far as I know, this book’s still up-to-date, but I’m not positive. So, I’m gonna read off an excerpt. When I’m done, I’ll pause and let you tell me whether or not it’s still true, and we’ll go from there. Got it?”

“Uh, sure.” Izuku replied. “Go ahead.”

Katsuki smiled curtly, and began to read aloud.

“‘An Angel’s ability to obtain accurate information is contingent on their position within the hierarchy. Depending on the level of their students, instructors may be forbidden from

teaching certain subjects, and curious Angels are barred from so much as opening books covering topics deemed to be inappropriate for an Angel of their status.

“Most telling, however, are the places where the lines are drawn. In the first sphere, which encompasses Angels from levels one through three, books covering both combat and Angel physiology are almost entirely forbidden. While these are allowed in the second sphere, which includes levels four through six, in most cases, books which cover the history of conflict between Heaven and Hell are still off limits. Books which look at Demonic culture and government, to the extent that they exist in Heaven, are generally only available to level nine Angels.”

Katsuki stopped, and looked up at him expectantly.

After a second, Izuku nodded. “That’s… true, I suppose.”

Katsuki closed the book with a pointed *snap*, and gave a tight smile. *“Deku.”*

Izuku frowned, crossing his arms. “What?”

“You *know* what.”

“I don’t!”

“Well—!“ Katsuki stopped abruptly, closing his eyes and taking a few deep breaths. When he looked at Izuku again, his smile was still notably strained, but the manic glint in his eye had mostly disappeared.

Enunciating each word slowly and deliberately, Katsuki then asked, “Would you like to know how I got this book?”

When Izuku didn’t say anything, he seemed to take it as a cue to continue.

“I walked to the library, and I asked the librarian where I could find current information about the structure of you fucks’ society. She lead me to an aisle, and recommended this book in particular. And it looked pretty good to me, so I checked it out. And I went home.” He pinched the bridge of his nose. “I mean, fucking Christ, Deku—you do realize this shit ain’t normal, right? Like, you’re aware of that?”

Izuku rolled his eyes. “And who made *you* the judge of what is and isn’t normal?”

Katsuki groaned, shoving the book back into his bag. He closed his eyes, rubbing his temples in small circles. When he finally opened them again, he looked at Izuku, and began speaking in a patronizingly sweet tone.

“Deku, *baby,”* He said. “You’re getting *fucked.* You’re getting fucked by some asshole you’ve never even spoken to—“ He suddenly pointed at Izuku, as if to preemptively rebut some response he’d anticipated. “Because *yes,* the book mentioned that, too, Deku. *I know.* I fucking know that the *vast* majority of Angels never even get the chance to *speak* to God.”

Izuku scoffed. ”Well, when’s the last time you spoke to Lucifer?”

“Last week, in a public bathroom.” Katsuki shot back, with a wide grin. “He asked about the recipe for a dish I brought to a mutual friend’s birthday party last month and then took the most toxic dump I’ve ever had the displeasure of smelling.”

Izuku stared back at him for a while, unsure how to respond. Unnecessary details aside, that was far from the response he’d been expecting.

“We’re talking about the same person, right?” He finally asked. “Lucifer, as in…?”

“The so-called ‘*Prince of Darkness”*?” Katsuki snorted. “Yeah, Deku. *That* Lucifer.”

Izuku blinked several times, trying to recalibrate his brain. He was beginning to wonder whether Katsuki had found a way to lie to him undetected. But then, out of nowhere, it suddenly occurred to him that, although he’d always known that Katsuki was powerful, he’d never actually stopped to ask where exactly he sat within the hierarchy.

The epiphany sent a cold shock through him, as though he had just awoken to the realization that he’d slept through a flight exam. Izuku tensed, and without really meaning to, his stance shifted to something a bit more defensive.

“Kacchan…” He cautiously said. “Just how high-ranking *are* you, anyway…?”

“Ra—“ Katsuki started, then stopped, staring at him for just a split second before bursting out into a fit of laughter. He clutched his sides, looking at Izuku as though he’d said something absurd. “Deku,” He wheezed. “Holy *shit.”*

“What?” Izuku demanded, suddenly embarrassed for reasons he couldn’t understand. His face felt hotter the longer Katsuki’s fit went on, but eventually, he calmed down enough to speak normally.

“Deku, that’s not how this works.”

“How *what* works?”

“Our society.” He said. “This might come as a shock to you, but not every society is, like, a totalitarian surveillance state. Lucifer’s just a guy.” Katsuki kicked a can off the rooftop. “A strong guy? Hell yeah. Arguably the strongest, even. But he’s still just a guy.

“Like, don’t get me wrong, his strength is no fucking joke. Being so damn old, he’s had time to master just about every type of magic that exists. Occasionally that expertise might give his opinions more weight—y’know, when it’s relevant—but he’s not like, categorically *important,* or some shit.”

Izuku frowned. “But… he’s one of the original Demons, isn’t he?”

“Yeah, but who the fuck cares?” Katsuki snorted. “Like, I don’t know about you, Deku, but ‘finders keepers’ doesn’t seem like a very logical ideal to build an entire fucking society off of.”

“Well, a lot of *human* societies were created like that.”

“Yeah, Deku. And the vast majority of people were fucking miserable.”

For a long while, Izuku just stared at him, his mouth open slightly. He wasn’t sure what he was feeling. There was a part of him that was angry, and on an instinctual level, he felt that he knew why. But for whatever reason, he just had no idea what to *do* with the feeling. It was there, churning deep inside him—he just didn’t have the vocabulary to express it.

After what felt like an eternity, Izuku tore his eyes away. He went and sat on the ledge, looking down at the vacant street below. A moment later, Katsuki sighed, and came to sit beside him.

“Deku, what the hell are you doing?” He asked, his tone soft, almost… affectionate.

“What do you mean?”

“I mean—“ He gestured toward the skyline, where the war raged on. “Why do you want to be like *them?”*

After a moment of thought, Izuku exhaled. “Kacchan, there are a finite number of people on Earth.” He pulled his knees up toward his chest. “Eventually, our job here will be done, you know. I want to keep helping, even after that time comes.”

“And you think fighting in the war will… *help*… people?” Katsuki asked, cocking his head, frowning. “Have you considered just, like…” He gestured vaguely. “I dunno, maybe starting a community garden or some shit?”

Izuku laughed softly, under his breath. He shook his head. “Kacchan, that’s not enough… I want to be able to *protect* people.”

“From what?” Katsuki asked, and the question hung in the air for a bit. Then, a little softer, he added, “People like me?”

Izuku’s breath caught, and for several seconds, he didn’t respond. He could feel Katsuki’s eyes on him, pinning him in place. The silence stretched between them, only interrupted by the muffled sound of explosions and impact in the distance that both had long since learned to tune out.

After a while, Katsuki hummed. “Maybe I’m just the exception.”

Izuku smiled slightly, despite himself. “The exception that proves the rule.”

Katsuki sighed, looking out on the horizon. “You know,” he said, “I’ve never really understood that phrase…”

“I just feel… strange.” Izuku said, staring down at his cup of fire tea, stirring it idly. “I don’t know. I feel like I’ve gotten too comfortable around him. I keep trying to remind myself how easily he could hurt me, if he felt like it.” He paused, releasing the spoon. Izuku watched as the amber liquid gradually settled, his murky reflection gently rippling in the mug, and

shrugged. “Maybe that’s *why* I feel this way. Because he could do it, but just… chooses not to.”

When Izuku finally looked up from his tea, he found All Might seated across from him, elbows on the table, fingers laced beneath the chin of his frowning face. Under his scrutiny, Izuku suddenly felt embarrassed.

“S-Sorry, maybe I said too—“

“No, no.” All Might assured him, waving his hands. “Apologies—this is just my thinking face.”

Izuku relaxed a bit, nodding as he looked down at his lap, where his hands were folded. His gloves sat discarded on the table. The corruption mark was barely visible at that point, but he still wore them around others, just to be safe.

“However,” All Might continued, sighing. “I’d be lying if I said this wasn’t an issue. Frankly, based on some of the ways you’ve described him, I sort of didn’t expect this to be a major concern, but perhaps the boy is more charming than I gave him credit for.” All Might chuckled softly, and Izuku smiled.

“Charming definitely isn’t the word I’d describe him with.” Izuku lightly replied, carefully raising his mug to his lips, blowing on it before taking a sip. “Half the time he’s insulting me, and the other half he’s just excessively crude—probably on purpose, to try and make me feel unsettled.”

Izuku glanced up, and the grave look on All Might’s face gave him pause.

“All Might…?”

All Might took a deep breath, regarding him carefully. “Midoriya… Are you *certain* he hasn’t been using his abilities on you?”

He blinked a few times. “Um… what do you mean, exactly?” He frowned. “He hasn’t *hurt* me, or anything—“

“Not his Wrath abilities, Midoriya.” All Might said, shaking his head. “I’m talking about his *Lust* abilities. Are you certain he hasn’t been hypnotizing you?”

Izuku paled, mouth falling open slightly. After a second, he swallowed. “I mean… would I know it if he did?”

All Might hesitated, lowering his chin slightly. “Given that he’s a Wrath Demon primarily, I would say *probably*... but not necessarily.”

Izuku’s palms began to sweat. He wiped them on his robe.

“Ah.” He said, voice jumping an octave. “Well… great.”

All Might stood up. “You need to ask him,” he said, pushing his chair in. “And be sure to get a straight answer; don’t allow him to dodge the question. Understand? This is very important.”

Izuku gulped, nodding silently. Then the kettle screamed, and he nearly jumped out of his skin.

The sunset filtered through the stained glass windows at around five in the afternoon, stretching colorful lights over the altar and pews. As the last set of clothes fell to the floor, Katsuki sighed, shoving his hands into his pockets and wandering down the aisle. Izuku braced himself, trying not to look quite as nervous as he *definitely was.*

He cleared his throat, and Katsuki looked at him, seeming bored.

“Kacchan, are you…” He winced, looking away from Katsuki’s glowing eyes. *“...Doing something* to me?”

When Katsuki didn’t respond immediately, Izuku glanced up, and found him staring at him with his head cocked, a bewildered look on his face. “‘Doing something’?” He repeated. “The hell are you talking about?”

“I mean, like…” He gestured vaguely, his cheeks growing redder under his attention. “You know, t-to my head… or something.”

For several seconds, Katsuki just kept staring at him, his confusion now tainted by a growing look of irritation.

Eventually, Izuku sighed, trying to subtly wipe his clammy hands on his robes. “Look, you’re… you’re a Wrath Demon, right?”

Katsuki blinked a few times, then threw him a small smirk. “I don’t have to answer that.”

Izuku scoffed. “I’ll take that as a yes.” He said, then took a deep breath. “My mentor told me about Demon types. He… he said that every type has two adjacent classes, and uhh…” He swallowed, watching Katsuki’s realization in real time as he stammered through the explanation. He started speaking faster, as if he could outrun the Demon’s comprehension, but it just lead to him tripping over his words even more. “Th-That one of yours, uhm, specializes in…” He looked away, blushing. “Uh, m-manipulating people’s—“

“—Ohh, I get it.” Katsuki cut in, suddenly much closer than before. He loomed over Izuku, his grin downright predatory. “So you think I’m pulling some kinda Lust shit on you, huh?”

Izuku kept his eyes fixated on the ground, watching Katsuki’s shoes as he moved further into his space. There was a certain spring in his step when he started to circle around him that made Izuku wish he could take it all back.

“What if I told you m’not?” He playfully asked, hot breath wafting against his ear. “What if I told you it’s all just you, huh?” Katsuki laughed, circling around to speak into Izuku’s other

ear. “Would ’ya even believe me?”

For a good while, Izuku found himself unable to say anything at all.

“Hmm?” Izuku swore he could feel the timbre of his voice reverberating inside him. “What’s wrong? Tongue-tied?”

As Katsuki looped around his right, Izuku took a decisive step to his left, putting space between the two of them.

“I asked you first.” He said, forcing himself to look up and meet the Demon’s eyes.

Some of that playfulness melted away as Katsuki frowned, looking him up and down, an eyebrow arched. Izuku held his ground, fists clenching behind his back, and eventually Katsuki scoffed, glancing away. “Fuckin’ amateur,” he muttered, rolling his eyes.

“Excuse me?”

Katsuki turned toward him again, hands stuffed into his pockets. He widened his stance and leaned forward. “Look,” he said, his tone patronizing. “It’s real cute that you think I’m doin’ some kinda funky shit with your feelings right now, but I’m not.”

Keyword being ‘right now’, Izuku’s mind supplied. He narrowed his eyes.

“I’m not sure if I—“

“—Believe me?” Katsuki completed, tilting his head, both eyebrows raised. After a moment, he sighed and took a step closer, looming over him again. “Tell ‘ya what,” He said. “How ‘bout I just *show* you how it feels?”

Izuku blinked a few times, his mind going blank. “I… don’t follow.”

Katsuki rolled his eyes. “I’m saying, instead of you speculating about whether or not I’ve found some clever way to hack your lie-detector bullshit, how ‘bout I just settle this right now by *showing* you how it feels when those abilities *actually* get used on you.” He said, shrugging. “Probably save us both a fuck load of time.”

Izuku froze, his whole body tensing up.

To say that idea made him nervous would be a *gross* understatement.

“Uhh…”

“I won’t do anything bad, Deku. Promise. It’s purely so you can see how it feels.”

And he was telling the truth; Izuku checked.

But still.

“I… I don’t know, Kacchan,” he said, laughing anxiously.

“You wanna be on the battlefield someday, right?” Katsuki said, red eyes studying him carefully. “Doncha think it might be useful to know how it feels beforehand?”

Izuku opened his mouth for a second, and then closed it again. Katsuki leaned in just the slightest bit closer, and raised an eyebrow.

“Y’know, the next time this happens to you, it ain’t gonna be for educational purposes, Deku.”

Izuku swallowed, eyes downcast. He hated to admit it, but the Demon made a pretty good point.

And really—how many Angels got the opportunity to experience the effects of a Demon’s powers in a non-hostile setting?

There was a little voice in the back of his mind, now only a shadow of what it used to be. *What makes you so certain this is a non-hostile setting?*

Izuku smothered the doubt within himself. It’d been a long time since it’d done him any good.

With a sigh, he nodded. “Okay, fine… but you *promise* you won’t do anything bad?”

“Promise.”

Izuku released a shuddering breath.

“…Alright.”

Katsuki hummed. “In that case… look into my eyes.”

Izuku did as he was told, turning to meet the Demon’s gaze. The innate, entrancing quality of his eyes made it all too easy to get lost in them—a feeling he was well accustomed to. But after a moment, he felt something new. Something clicked inside his head, like a door he never knew existed. Then, all at once, his mind felt heavier, and his vision grew hazy.

Katsuki smirked, slow and dangerous.

“Get on your knees.”

Izuku’s body seemed to move before the words even reached his consciousness. Everything was slow, muted, like he was immersed in warm molasses. Before he even knew what was happening, Izuku’s knees were on the floor, pressing into the faded red carpet.

But then, just as quickly as it had come, he felt that extra weight leave him, exiting his mind with a second click, as though locking the door behind it.

And just like that, he was himself again.

Izuku blinked a few times, clearing the fog as he stared at Katsuki's black combat boots, mere inches away from where his knees were situated. He looked up at Katsuki, and found the Demon staring back down at him, an amused look on his face. Katsuki offered him a hand. Izuku stood up on his own.

"You get it now?" Katsuki asked.

Izuku dusted off the front of his robe, his mind still feeling a bit off-balance. "Yeah, it's…" he hesitated, trying to find the right word for it, but nothing particularly descriptive came to mind. "…Pretty distinctive, I suppose."

"Mhmm," Katsuki hummed, low and rumbly. "So you believe me now?

Izuku nodded quietly.

"Good." He said, sliding his hands back into his pockets, and beginning to walk circles around him again. "So…" He began, "What *exactly* did you think I was making you feel, anyway, hmm?"

Oh, dear.

"I-I mean," Izuku sputtered. "My mentor's the one who wanted me to ask. It's not what you think."

Katsuki snorted. "Yeah? And what do I think, Deku?"

"I don't know!" Izuku exclaimed, voice raising in pitch. "But I'm sure it's very inappropriate!"

He cackled. "*Inappropriate?* For fuck's sake, Deku, we're both adults, and—" He suddenly came to a stop in front of him, turning to face him fully, his eyes narrowing. "Wait, they let you guys *fuck,* right?"

Izuku face-palmed, turning sharply on his heel. "Oh my *God,* Kacchan!"

"But they do, right?" Katsuki asked, matching his movements to try and stay in front of him. "*Right?"*

Izuku's feathers ruffled. He was about to *scream.*

"…Oh fuck, they *don't."* Katsuki said, grim realization evident in his tone. "What's even the point of—"

Izuku covered his ears. *"La la la la la—"*

Katsuki knocked his hands away from his ears with his wrists, using the sleeves of his leather jacket as a buffer. "What are you, *five?"*

Izuku stuck his tongue out at him… only for Katsuki to suddenly reach up and try to grab it. He lurched back, just barely dodging his fingers. Somehow, Izuku's cheeks burned brighter.

“What the—*Kacchan!* What’s *wrong* with you?!”

“What’s the *point* of going to Heaven if you can’t even indulge in all the shit you weren’t allowed to when you were alive?” He threw his hands up.

Izuku threw his hands up higher.

“Why did you try to grab my tongue just now?!”

“You were acting like a child, so I figured you’d lost tongue privileges!”

“What does that even mean?!”

“Whatever the fuck I decide it means!”

“Why are you yelling?!”

“I don’t know, why are *you—!”*

Katsuki suddenly tensed, and then a sour expression overtook his features. “Seriously? *Now?”* He grumbled, unzipping the front of his jacket. “This better be fuckin’ important.”

Izuku could do nothing but look at him in confusion, shuffling back as Katsuki proceeded to shed his leather jacket. Underneath, he wore a simple, black tank top.

The first thing that caught Izuku’s attention was the size of his biceps—physical proof of the strength the Demon had demonstrated many times over.

The second thing he noticed was the intricate tattoo adorning his left arm and shoulder. Katsuki placed his hand over it, and it began to glow—the black ink lighting up orange.

“What d’you want?” He said, speaking through gritted teeth, though as time went by and Katsuki remained silent, the irritation faded. After a minute, he said, “Okay, but why are you telling *me* this?” Another minute went by, and he sighed. “Fuck. Alright, fine. See you there, I guess.” His hand fell away from the marking, and he slouched, arms hanging limply in front of him.

“Um…” Izuku said. “Is everything okay?”

“Yeah, s’fine.” Katsuki muttered, raking a hand through his hair. “Apparently Baldy got into some shit, though.”

“Inasa?” He frowned. “Is he okay?”

“Terminally stupid, but he’ll be fine.”

“Oh. Well, that’s good.”

Katsuki shrugged, projecting apathy, but somehow, Izuku could sense that he was relieved. He wondered when exactly he’d learned to read the Demon so well.

“Well, I should probably head back, anyway.” Izuku eventually said, rubbing the back of his neck. “Um, tell him I said hi, I guess.”

Katsuki grunted, throwing his jacket back on again. Izuku’s eyes followed the movement of his arms.

The two of them parted ways beneath a cloudy, pink sky.

Just beyond the gates of Heaven, there was a dispatch station. The station contained six platforms, each serviced by a shuttle, and all of which were designed to take passengers to one distinct, unchanging location.

The first platform was the largest, as its shuttle was bound for the most populous portion of God’s Kingdom: the mainland, where virtuous humans spent their afterlives. The car had been temporarily disabled as a precaution during the war, though, in order to keep civilians safe. It’d been a long time since Izuku last saw it running.

The next three platforms were entry points for the inner circles, where working Angels like Izuku lived. Of the remaining two, one went directly to the hospital, while the other went to the High Tower, where God resided, along with his Council. This platform was rarely used, as the only ones authorized to use it were Councilmen, their Acolytes, and theoretically, God himself—though the idea of God needing to rely on shuttle transport seemed almost laughable to Izuku.

In all his years, Izuku had never actually seen anyone use that shuttle. Perhaps that’s why it caught his attention, when he noticed a tall figure standing alone on the platform, waiting.

But then again, it was also just generally difficult *not* to notice when one was in the presence of such a person.

The Councilmen’s Acolyte was an odd sight to behold, standing just fifteen feet away in his white and gold robes, which flowed and billowed out around him unusually, as if hiding some writhing mass within. Only one set of wings was visible, though Izuku was sure he had more hidden beneath the robe.

The strangest part was the crimson scarf covering his eyes. It wrapped around the entire upper portion of his head, which was itself mostly hidden beneath a white cowl. Izuku still wasn’t sure why exactly the Acolytes wore blindfolds, or how they managed to see in spite of them.

He didn’t mean to stare; he really didn’t. It was just difficult not to. The few times he had seen Acolytes before, they always seemed to have a bizarre sort of gravitational pull about them, as though thousands of souls lived within their bodies. All high-level Angels felt like that to some extent, but even among them, the Acolytes were in a league of their own—a de facto tenth level beyond the normal ninth.

His vision went out of focus as he continued to gaze at the man, but it wasn’t until the Acolyte turned toward him that Izuku really became aware of what he was doing. His head

turned slowly, and tilted to the side. Somehow, Izuku knew he was watching him, despite the blindfold, and felt a cold rush travel down his spine as he hastily turned away, a metallic taste on his tongue.

A moment later, the shuttle car arrived, and Izuku boarded alongside a couple other Angels, his heart racing.

He had to be more careful. The powers of the Acolytes were not fully understood. He'd heard rumors which claimed that they could see into the minds of Angels. Although it was just hearsay, Izuku knew he'd do well to be a bit more cautious, should he ever run into one again.

As the shuttle car doors closed, Izuku worked up the nerve to throw the Acolyte one last glance. He was relieved to find the man standing in the same spot as before, his head facing forward, and remaining as such as the car began to move.

His heart continued to pound in his ears for the duration of the trip.

Before even setting foot inside the dorm building, Izuku already knew something had happened. Uraraka was in the common area, pacing back and forth while Iida spoke animatedly. Shinsou, who seldom hung around the common room, stood leaning back against the wall, listening and occasionally nodding.

When Izuku opened the door, Uraraka stopped and looked at him.

"Izuku!" She shouted.

"Um. Yes…?" He said, eyes darting between the three. "What's going on?"

"Todoroki's hurt!" She said.

Iida nodded. "He's in the hospital. We only just found out."

"What?" Izuku said, a cold weight settling in his stomach. "What happened? Is he going to be okay? How bad is it?"

"We don't know." Shinsou replied.

Uraraka shook her head. "They haven't told us anything else. We tried to figure out more, but that's all they would say. Just that he's been admitted."

Izuku frowned, his brow wrinkling.

"We were about to head over there," Shinsou said. "See if maybe they'll let us in to see him."

Izuku nodded, gripping the strap of his messenger bag.

"Did you want to put that in your room, first?"

“No, that’s okay.” Izuku replied, shaking his head. “I’ll just bring it with me.”

Shinsou shrugged, while the others nodded. And without further delay, they all left the building the same way Izuku had entered.

The four of them sat in the waiting room for a what felt like several hours, but was probably around twenty minutes in actuality. Izuku zoned out, staring at the *‘No talking’* sign as he waited, listening to the steady sound of the click ticking above his head. Eventually, the door to the emergency wing opened up, and a single nurse emerged, greeting them pleasantly before gesturing for them to follow her. They all stood up, thanked her and hastily trailed behind, barely avoiding stepping on each others’ ankles on the way down.

A minute later, they arrived at a door near the end of the hall, at which point the nurse bid them farewell. The four of them piled inside, and Izuku braced himself for the worst.

There, Todoroki sat upright in bed, a cast on his left arm, and gauze wrapped around his neck and left shoulder. Izuku felt the tension inside him melt away almost instantly.

“Oh,” Todoroki said, looking up. “Hello. I wasn’t expecting you guys.”

Uraraka spoke first. “Sorry, we were just worried.”

“We heard you were injured, but we didn’t know how bad it was.” Iida added.

“Are you feeling alright?” Izuku asked.

Todoroki gestured toward his left arm and shoulder. “Not in ideal condition, but nothing they won’t be able to heal in a few days.”

“Oh, thank goodness.” Uraraka said. “We were terrified!”

“Sorry to make you worry.”

“No, no!” She waved her hands. “It’s not your fault, Todoroki.”

“We’re just glad you’re alright.” Shinsou said, speaking for the first time.

Todoroki smiled. “I was lucky. It could’ve been a lot worse.”

“If you don’t mind me asking, what happened?” Iida asked.

“Oh,” Todoroki shrugged. “Just had a close run in with a Demon. It was sort of my fault, I guess. I let hi—“ He cleared his throat. “It caught me off guard. I need to learn not to let… *that* happen.”

“I imagine everyone slips up sometimes.” Iida said.

“Yeah,” Izuku agreed. “Don’t be too hard on yourself. This was only your…” Izuku trailed off. “Uh, third battle, was it?”

“Second.”

“Oh, wow.” Izuku said. “Well, that just makes my point stronger, then. You’re new at this, Todoroki. You’re bound to make some mistakes.”

“Hopefully none of them will be fatal.” Todoroki said.

The room fell silent for a moment, apart from the sound of humming machinery, and the steady beep of the heart monitor.

“Well, I wish I could stay longer, but I had plans to study with Tsuyu later. We’ve got a test coming up.”

Iida cleared his throat. “I should probably be getting back, too.” He said. “I’m relieved to see that you’re alright, though, Todoroki.”

“Same here!” Uraraka said. “Please stay safe out there!”

“Yeah.” He said. “Ah, good luck on your test.”

“Thanks,” Uraraka chirped.

Uraraka and Iida headed for the door, and Shinsou trailed behind them. Izuku, however, remained in place.

“Midoriya?” Shinsou called, looking over his shoulder.

“Um. You guys go on ahead.” Izuku said. “I think I’ll stay for a few more minutes,” He looked over at Todoroki. “If that’s okay with you, I mean.”

Todoroki nodded.

Shinsou paused for a moment, then shrugged. “Alright. Well, I guess I’ll see you later, then.”

“See you later!”

The door closed quietly behind Shinsou, muffling the sound of their footsteps as the three of them walked away. With no one else around, Izuku opted to sit in the chair beside Todoroki’s bed—it had been left vacant up until then; Izuku figured none of them wanted to be the one person who sat while all the others had to stand.

“So…” Izuku said, fidgeting with the hem of one of his gloves—the one that covered his corruption damage, or at least what remained of it. “Are those… physical injuries?”

Todoroki seemed a bit surprised by the question, but after a second, he gestured toward his left arm. “It’s a mix. My arm is broken, and I have some bruises, but the rest is corruption damage.”

Izuku nodded, chewing his lip. “I’m guessing that’s pretty common.” He muttered. “Corruption damage, I mean.”

“Yeah, I’d say so. It seems to happen less often the more experienced you are.” He blinked. “Holding a barrier while fighting is harder than you would think. I don’t even remember when it slipped. There was a lot going on.” After a moment of silence, Todoroki added. “And even for the more experienced Angels, there are some Demons who can get around barriers.”

Lust demons, Izuku’s mind supplied. He swallowed.

“Do you think it was one of those?”

“No. They teach us to determine that sort of thing based on the way they fight. This one didn’t really match up with what you’d expect from a Demon like that.”

Izuku nodded, biting his lip. “So it was just one, then.”

“Yeah. Just one.”

“…Did the Demon survive?”

“Yes,” he said. “And I don’t think I could’ve beaten this one. Too strong. But I got in a few good hits.”

Izuku hummed, and silence fell between them.

Both of them, Izuku assumed, knew what the other was doing. Carefully structured sentences designed to avoid referencing Demons with any particular pronoun. It wasn’t something Izuku usually thought about. He didn’t bat an eye when others referred to a Demon as ‘it.’ Most of the books he read which mentioned them did the same. Likewise, most didn’t really seem to care when Izuku referred to them with words like ‘he’ or ‘she.’ Many switched back and forth between the two modes, depending on context.

But in that moment, as he sat there beside Todoroki in that sterile hospital room, for whatever reason, it seemed to matter. The avoidance felt like a signal of some kind, though whether it was meant to be between the two of them or… something else, Izuku couldn’t say.

“That’s where most of the corruption damage came from.” Todoroki paused. “The broken arm is sort of embarrassing, though, because it’s not even related to fighting. I just tripped and fell while I was running, and I ended up breaking my fall with it… on a large rock.” He smiled softly. “So next time I go down there, I’m wearing bracers.”

Izuku laughed lightly. “That sounds like something I’d probably do.”

“I do still remember that time you fractured a wing on one of the hoops in the flying field.”

“It was dark!”

“Which is why they don’t have us practice after sunset.”

“Yeah… I learned that lesson the hard way.” Izuku said, smiling. After a long pause, he asked, “So… did they say how long they’re planning to keep you for?”

“Just a couple more hours. I have to come back every morning for the next few days for treatment, but after that, I should be pretty much completely healed.”

“Well, that’s good news.” Izuku said. “You should drop by the dorms sometime soon, Todoroki. We all miss you.”

Todoroki averted his eyes awkwardly, and sighed. “I know. It’s been hard to get away, but maybe after what happened they’ll give me a bit more free time.”

Izuku hummed. “I mean, I’m sure we’ll all understand if you can’t make time.”

“No, I’ll figure something out.”

Another long silence stretched between them. Izuku was preparing to excuse himself, but then Todoroki said something, a bit too quiet for him to make out.

“…Sorry?”

“I just said it’s… funny.”

Izuku blinked, leaning in closer to hear him better. “What is?”

Todoroki hesitated for a moment. He kept his eyes fixed on his hands. “Just that…” He frowned. “I’m still not sure if the Demon was… actually trying to *kill* me.”

Izuku’s brow furrowed. “Um… why do you say that?”

Todoroki shrugged. “It was weird. The Demon didn’t really try to hurt me. Just grabbed my arm and wouldn’t let go.”

“…Like the Demon was trying to force a Fall?”

Todoroki shook his head. “The Demon let me go after a minute.”

“That’s… very strange.” Izuku leaned in a bit further. “Any guesses as to what, uhh…” He trailed off.

“I think…” He said, voice barely a whisper. “I think he just wanted my attention.”

He.

Somehow, hearing him utter that word held a sort of reverence in the quiet room. It hung in the air for a moment before Izuku spoke.

“Did he say anything to you?”

Todoroki nodded. “I think so.” He replied. “But it was too loud. I couldn’t hear anything.”

“Are you sure it wasn’t some kind of trap…?”

“It wasn’t.”

Izuku blinked, momentarily dumbstruck at the immediacy of his answer. After a beat, he asked, “What makes you so sure…?”

Todoroki didn’t say anything, at first. For a moment, the only response was in the steady beeping of the heart monitor, the muted sound of footsteps outside, and the subtle creaking of the walls as the wind blew against them.

But after a while, Todoroki spoke once more.

“I don’t know.” He murmured. “That’s what I’m trying to figure out.”

Chapter End Notes

the 5th horseman of the apocalypse is me updating a fic in under a week lmao

hope y'all enjoyed this clusterfuck. Things are definitely heating up. many firsts here: first real hints at the structure of demonic society, first time deku's seen katsuki without a jacket on/seen his tattoo (lol), first Acolyte "encounter," first.... actually idk why i'm listing all of these, y'all read the chapter lol

anyway i hope you guys enjoyed this!! pls leave a comment if you did, for u see, as a member of gen Z, i have grown up on the internet and therefore my dopamine receptors are Fucked, and receiving comment notification emails reminds me that i am, in fact, a real person. nah lmao i'm just fucking around. they do make me happy and help motivate me to Be Consistent tho

anyway anyway, again, hope you liked this shit. lots of wild shit coming soon, so stay tuned my dudes lol

Chapter 6: Eve

Chapter Summary

> “Anything Ashido could do to you is nothing a little therapy couldn’t fix—“
>
> “—This is the *opposite* of reassurance!”

Chapter Notes

> back at it again

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A typical day with Katsuki looked something like this:

Izuku would meet up with him in the morning, at the first church he’d been assigned to. As one might expect of humans who chose to gather in a church in midst of a global catastrophe, the vast majority of them were true believers. Once in a while, Katsuki would discover a bad apple or two in the bunch, but most people were basically decent.

On the occasions when stragglers remained, their numbers were almost always under five. At this point, Katsuki would take over, escorting them to Hell personally before meeting up with Izuku once again at the next church.

But today…

The two of them sat at the front of a large cathedral near the center of what used to be a major city, and for the first time, there were too many non-believers for Katsuki to handle on his own.

After a moment of silent deliberation, Katsuki groaned, shedding his jacket and activating whatever it was on his arm which allowed him to communicate with other Demons.

“Oi, Pinky. It’s me. Need some backup over here.” After a moment of silence, he side-eyed Izuku. “Yeah… he’s here.” He cautiously said, eyes narrowing. *“Why?”* A few more seconds went by, and Katsuki took his hand off the tattoo. “Fuck, she’s closer than I thought.”

“Um… who?”

“Our transport Demon.” He replied, standing up straight and heading toward the door. “C’mon, it’s probably best you meet her somewhere…” He gestured vaguely toward the

group of stragglers. “Y’know, *not* in front of fifteen people.”

Izuku frowned, an ominous weight settling upon him. He hesitantly followed the Demon, and as the ornate door closed behind them, Katsuki tensed, seeming to have remembered something. His hand smacked over the mark, and it began to glow once more.

“Me again.” He barked. “Listen, I really shouldn’t fucking need to tell you this, but do *not* touch him without warning.” A pause. “I *know* you know. I’m telling you so you won’t *forget.* That’s all.” He dropped his hand, and the tattoo returned to its normal, black state.

To say Izuku was nervous would be a vast understatement.

“Fuck, she’s close. I can feel it.” Katsuki muttered, turning to look at Izuku for the first time in a while. “Woah, hey.” He raised his eyebrows. “Calm down, Deku. It’s okay.”

“Are you *sure?”* Izuku shot back. “Because everything you’ve said and done these past few minutes seems to imply the opposite.”

“Deku, I mean it.” The Demon rolled his eyes. “Like, yeah, she’s fucking *weird,* but she’s harmless.”

“See, but that’s the problem.” Izuku pointed at him. “You’ve said it yourself. I don’t know if your definition of ‘*harmless’* is the same as mine.”

“Anything Ashido could do to you is nothing a little therapy couldn’t fix—“

“—This is the *opposite* of reassurance!”

“Hey, hey!” A feminine voice called out. Izuku jumped, and found her standing about ten feet away, a wide grin on her face. Her hair was wild and pink, almost matching her complexion, her eyes colored black, with glowing golden irises. Like Katsuki, she was only partially shifted, but despite bearing similar characteristics as Katsuki—horns, tail, sharp teeth—she looked much closer to what one might have expected a Demon to look like.

“Bakugou, didn’t anyone ever teach you it’s not nice to talk about people behind their back?”

“I could kill you with my bare hands, Pinky.” He deadpanned.

“Thanks, but I’m already seeing someone.” She winked, grinning from ear to ear as she jogged up the steps. She came to a stop a few feet from Izuku. “And who’s this?”

“You already know that.”

She puffed her cheeks out. “Humor me.”

Katsuki sighed, stepping closer and wrapping an arm around him. Izuku stiffened. His hand fell a bit lower than he'd expected, resting on his hip. He could feel the heat of it through the fabric of his robe. In a sarcastically sweet tone, Katsuki said, “This is Deku, he’s my pet Angel. Y’know, one of those weird bird things that fear God.”

“Kacchan, what—“

“‘Kacchan’?!” Ashido interjected.

“Fuck.” Katsuki groaned. He removed his hand. It brushed along Izuku’s lower back as he moved it.

“Oh my god, that’s so *cute!”* She exclaimed, jumping up and down. “You guys have pet names!”

“They’re not pet names.” Katsuki glared at her. “They’re insults we got used to somehow.”

At that, Izuku laughed.

Ashido gasped, freezing as she looked at him. He reflexively put up his barrier.

“I’m gonna pinch your cheeks.” She said.

Izuku blinked. “You’re go—w-wait—“ But it was too late. She was already in his space, and he winced as she did just as she said she would.

“Oh, you even have freckles, that’s so precious!” She said, tugging on his pinched cheeks. She winked at Katsuki. “You picked a good one, Bakugou.”

Katsuki sighed. “I think Deku would like you to stop touching his face, Pinky.”

“Ah, right,” her expression morphed into one of faux-seriousness. She removed her hands and cleared her throat performatively as she took a step back, speaking with a deepened voice. “Of course, yes. Nice to meet you, Deku. You can call me Mina.” She held her hand out. It took a second for Izuku’s brain to catch up, but he eventually reached out and accepted the handshake, careful to maintain his barrier. She gripped his hand so hard, it felt like it was being crushed.

Afterward, she took a step back, rubbing her chin as she looked him up and down with a discerning gaze.

“You look like you’d make a *great* Pride Demon.”

Katsuki snorted. “You’re just saying that ‘cuz that’s what *you* are.”

“Nah, he looks like the type who’d want to go for something well-rounded,” She said. “Unlike *someone* I know.” She winked at Izuku. “I could teach you some sick moves.”

“You just want an excuse to harass him more.” Katsuki rolled his eyes. “Pride doesn’t really fit him, anyway.”

She frowned. “Well, what does he look like to *you,* then?”

Katsuki paused, looking Izuku up and down in a way that made him feel oddly exposed. He flushed, crossing his arms and ankles as he averted his eyes.

"…Envy, maybe?" Mina offered.

"Nah." Katsuki shook his head. "He sucks at lying, and his mumbling habit would give him away."

"Um." Izuku finally piped up. "So, is this like… something Demons are born with?"

"What? No." Katsuki shook his head. "You can pick any path you want, we're just try'na figure out what you'd be good at."

"Gluttony?" Mina said.

"I could see that." Katsuki replied, nodding thoughtfully. "Gluttony, or…" He paused, tilting his head, humming. "Lust."

It hit him like a shock of lightning.

"Oh, really?" Mina said, grinning.

"Yeah, the more I think about it, the more sense it makes."

"Fallen Angels *do* tend to take faster to Lust magic." Mina said.

Katsuki shrugged. "Sure, but even *without* the advantage, it just seems… right, somehow."

Izuku swallowed. "You think I'd be a *Lust* Demon?"

Mina waved her hand. "Oh, calm down, cutie." She said. "It's just a name. Lust Demons aren't any hornier than other Demons."

"I dunno, Pinky." Katsuki said, snickering. "They can be pretty fuckin' horny."

Mina jabbed him in the side with her elbow.

"Ow! What the *fuck—"*

"—I'm trying to make him feel better!" She shouted. "He looks like he's about to explode!"

Katsuki's eyes darted up to his face. He studied him for a moment, and then shrugged. "Ehh. He's been redder."

"Bakugou."

Katsuki rolled his eyes. "Look, it doesn't matter, anyway. Whatever Deku picks is what he picks."

Izuku frowned.

They seem way too confident about me Falling.

"We are." Mina said.

Izuku jumped.

I said that out loud?

“You did.” Katsuki said. “And that’s why I recommend scratching Envy off the list.”

“Ahh, I see.” Mina said, nodding slowly. “Well,” she slapped Katsuki’s shoulder. “Good luck to you, Bakugou. He’s the cutest egg I’ve ever met.”

Izuku blinked. “…Egg?”

“Oh!” Mina said. “Sorry—it’s slang. It just means an Angel who’s expected to Fall.”

“Wow, I… uh,” Izuku frowned. “Don’t really like that.”

“I won’t call you that if you don’t like it.” She said, shrugging. “It *is* one of the, uhh… *kinder* words for Angels, though.” Katsuki snorted, and Mina side-eyed him. “I’m sure Bakugou could tell you about some of the others.”

“Where would I even start?” He asked, grinning.

“I would prefer that you didn’t.” Izuku replied.

Katsuki snorted. “Anyway, there’s about fifteen people inside.”

Mina nodded. “Right. Guess it’s time to get this show on the road!”

The three of them filed back inside, and Izuku and Katsuki stood back as the stragglers gathered around Mina. Many of them seemed a bit skeptical about following her, but Izuku did his best to assure them that they were headed someplace safe.

He hoped that was true.

Once everyone was accounted for, Mina jumped up from within the center of the small crowd, waving at Izuku. “Nice meeting you, Deku!”

“Uh, y-you too!” He awkwardly waved.

“Alright, everyone!” She sung. “Next stop, the ACH!”

And then, Izuku watched in awe as the floor began to cave in beneath the groups’ feet, as though melting. It was slow at first, but soon picked up speed, and before he knew it, all that remained was a gaping chasm, toward which all furniture seemed to deform, like a surrealist painting. After a moment, Izuku carefully inched over to it, peering over the edge, gulping as he realized he couldn’t see the bottom.

“You’ll probably wanna back away from that.” Katsuki said.

“…Why?” Izuku asked.

But then he heard it. A rumbling noise, soft at first, but quickly getting louder. Izuku hastily backed away as the chasm rapidly decreased in depth, until the floor snapped back into place like a trampoline. Izuku was thrown off his feet, landing on his butt a good five feet away as the floor settled.

Had he been any closer, that likely would've shot him straight into the ceiling.

He turned and looked at Katsuki, his eyes wide. But Katsuki just grinned.

"Hey—don't say I didn't warn 'ya."

What would've happened if someone jumped into that pit?

presumably death

Kacchan.

If you're asking whether they'd end up in hell, then no

Other than dying, the only way to get to hell if you're not a demon is to have a demon take you there.

One who knows how to expand their soul

Expand their soul?

yep

That's what pride demons do

just expand their souls til they engulf everyone/thing around them

it's how they're able to transport large groups

So inasa's a pride demon too?

basically all transport demons are

Wait, then how do YOU transport people?

We all learn the basics of each branch before we specialize

I can expand my soul too

just not to like the size of a fuckin gymnasium

I see

then are all branches like that?

if some demons can make their souls big, does that mean some can make them small?

The closest thing to what you're thinking of is compression and it's about half of what I do

Wrath is compression + heat

Oh wow

Why'd you choose that?

you ever looked at someone and thought to yourself :

"i wanna hit them, but I also wanna set them on fire"?

Wrath demons don't have to choose

We can do both those things simultaneously

I'm quietly pathologizing this

Weird considering you can't seem to shut the fuck up

It just seems like an oddly specific reason

that obviously wasn't the only thing dumbass

if you really want the real reason, it's cuz I was fuckin stubborn

I went with wrath cuz everybody kept tellin me not to

Oh

Yeah that sounds like you

But why were they telling you that?

basically wrath usually has the steepest learning curve just cuz it's really fuckin hard on your body

other branches are hard in other ways, I guess

envy and greed are very technical

pride takes sustained concentration

those are all challenging in some way

but wrath is the only one that literally just fuckin hurts

So they didn't want you to do it because it was painful?

That's it?

No. It's always painful

But it's particularly bad for someone like me

I learn faster, but the physical consequences are worse

People kept saying I'd be lucky not to end up passed out in a puddle of my own vomit after each session

Which turned out to be true

I got through it, but it fuckin sucked for a while

You're actually pretty fuckin lucky, deku

fallen angels have it easy

what do you mean "someone like you" though?

You're different somehow?

yes.

In what way?

And Izuku waited, but Katsuki never responded.

It happened first in a dream.

In the dream, Izuku had been walking through the streets of a vacant, rural-looking town. The sun beat down on his skin, and his shoes kicked dust into the air. And then he blinked, and suddenly, All Might was standing in front of him.

He looked angry.

"You haven't been practicing, have you." He stated, rather than asked.

Izuku gulped, but his throat was dry. It was uncomfortable.

"S-Sorry? I'm not sure what you—"

"I see no reason to continue putting my position in jeopardy for a student who does not appreciate it."

With that, All Might turned on his heel and began to walk away, throwing Izuku into a confused panic. "Wait!" He nearly fell over himself as he scrambled to catch up to him. "I've been practicing, I swear!"

All Might sharply turned around, tossing something at him. Izuku looked down, and realized they were the training gloves. "Then prove it." The man said.

Izuku tried to swallow again, but his throat was too dry for it. He felt like he could taste the dust on his tongue—but he did it, anyway. He put on the gloves, his body tense as he cautiously glanced up at All Might, who was now standing there with his arms crossed, waiting.

He put everything he had into focusing, and soon, he felt the power flowing through him, like electricity in his veins. Izuku turned toward a tree that had not existed prior to that moment, and following a deep breath, he swung his fist at it. He heard it crack, and—

Izuku opened his eyes just as he tumbled out of his bed, hitting the wood floor beneath in a way that had him gasping in shock and pain. He sat up quickly, looking around his room, disoriented. He stayed there, eyes wide, panting, for a few moments more before his brain fully adjusted to reality again. And it was only then that he noticed the pain radiating from his right hand. He looked down, doing a double take at his bloody, discolored knuckles.

"What the…" He mumbled.

What happened?

Izuku carefully stood up and looked around, and that's when he saw it. The headboard of his bed was broken, the wood splintered.

Did I…?

Izuku looked down at his hand, and then back at the headboard. He did this a couple of times.

After the initial shock wore off, Izuku padded over to his bathroom. His body moved on autopilot, turning on the sink and watching off his knuckles under the cold water. It was only then, as he stood there, watching the blood wash down the drain, that the true realization hit him.

There's no way I could've done that on my own. He thought. *I must've used power.*

He tensed.

While I was asleep.

His blood ran cold.

And I wasn't wearing the training gloves.

All of a sudden, All Might's words from their first real training session were in his head, echoing endlessly.

"If you want to use your power, you'll need a vessel to channel it through."

I need to talk to All Might.

Izuku's throat felt tight.

But… I can't. he suddenly remembered. All Might was teaching a seminar in the third circle, and wouldn't be due back until the next day. He'd just have to wait.

Izuku gripped the edge of the sink with his uninjured hand, his vision swirling like the water going down the drain. An overwhelming sense of dread settled within him.

This is going to be a very long day.

Turning off the tap, Izuku gently wiped his knuckles off and bandaged them, and sighed.

He briefly considered going back to sleep, but he worried that if he did, it might happen again. And even if he wanted to sleep, Izuku doubted he'd be able to, what with how anxious he was. So with nothing left to do, Izuku sat at his desk, and spent the next few minutes quietly ruminating on it.

He wasn't sure if this was a good thing or a bad thing, but based on what All Might had said, Izuku could deduce that it was, at the very least, a *strange* thing.

And strange things drew attention. And Attention lead to… Izuku gulped, and only then realized just how dry his throat was.

That explains the setting of the dream, at least.

He stood up and got a glass of water, and then sat down again and sipped it. He felt jittery, tense and unable to keep himself from fidgeting. Releasing a shaky breath, Izuku reached into his bag and pulled out one of his upcoming assignments. He tried to read over it, but his was mind too anxious to absorb any of the information. Eventually, he gave up, and shoved it back into his bag.

He glanced at the clock. It was about half-past four in the morning.

The library opens at five, Izuku thought.

And he was already putting on his shoes.

The library at five o'clock in the morning was a vacant chasm, save for the lone librarian dozing behind her desk. Izuku shut the door quietly behind him, gripping the straps of his bag as he scurried over to the medical section. After confirming that he was out of the librarian's sight, he set his bag down with a sigh, and started at the top.

Truth be told, Izuku wasn't entirely sure what he was looking for. All he had to go off of was the vague hope that he'd know the right book when he saw it, and he wound up scanning the spines of well over a hundred books before something finally gave him a speck of hope.

Abnormal Souls

He pulled it from the shelf. To his relief, it opened for him, but as he began to flip through, his hope quickly waned. The book he held wasn't a medical book. It wasn't even non-fiction. It was a novel, which had evidently been misplaced by one of the librarians. Izuku considered

notifying them of the mistake, but he didn't want to call attention to himself. He put the book back where he found it.

Izuku continued to search, and after some fifty or sixty more titles, he once more happened across one that caught his interest.

Beyond Corruption: Cataloging Conditions of the Soul, Both Common and Rare

Izuku's pulse picked up as he reached for the book, but as soon as his fingers touched its spine, it began to glow, and his heart dropped into his stomach.

Eight.

"Of course." Izuku said under his breath, his tone cynical. He shook his head.

Maybe All Might could transcribe it, Izuku thought. *He peaked at level eight. He might still have clearance. Maybe if I can just…*

Izuku grabbed the book by the spine, testing the weight. It wasn't moving, so he took hold with both hands, and pulled as hard as he could. He clenched his jaw, muscles straining in protest. But the book would not budge. It was as though it had been cemented in place, a permanent fixture on the shelf.

Izuku sighed, exasperated. He adjusted his grip and looked around himself, ensuring he was still alone. Then, he put one foot up on a lower shelf, using it for leverage as he tried again. Still, nothing. He put his other foot on the lower shelf as well, trying to use his body weight to drag it out. But in his struggle, his hands became sweaty, and it was only a matter of time before his grip slipped. Izuku fell, landing on his butt, wincing as his tailbone hit the edge of the shelf behind him. The impact caused a couple of books to come loose, falling and hitting him over the head.

Izuku sat there silently for a moment, his body tense. He stared up at the book, the glowing, red *'eight'* still illuminating the spine, and scowled.

He wiped his hands off on his robe, and then clenched his fists around the fabric. The book seemed to glow brighter, as if to taunt him.

And then, out of nowhere, a thought entered his mind, like a cold weight in the pit of his stomach.

What if I was seriously sick?

Angels didn't get sick very often, and when they did, it was usually fairly minor. Severe illnesses were rare, but not completely unheard of.

He thought back to his first days in training, when one of his classmates fell ill. Nobody really took it seriously at the time, but in retrospect, Izuku could trace the path of his decline that he should've noticed back then. He grew increasingly lethargic over the course of a few days. Looking back, the rate at which it progressed was quite alarming, but it wasn't until they found him under the stairwell that they realized their mistake.

He never found out what happened to the boy from level one, and he never saw him again.

There had been other instances, as well. Though he could count the number of times a classmate had fallen seriously ill on one hand, they all seemed to follow that basic pattern.

An Angels' work was important, and as such, they seldom took sick days, or even reported their symptoms at all. Part of it, Izuku supposed, was due to social expectations. No one wanted to be seen as whiny. The other part was simply failing to recognize when something was seriously wrong. Apart from obvious things like pain and discomfort, Angels weren't really taught to watch out for warning signs of developing conditions.

As Izuku sat there, zoning out at the glowing book, he imagined the Angel from level one.

He could almost see it: the phantom image of him sifting through this exact same aisle, searching for answers, yet finding most of it to be inaccessible. Izuku's eyes panned across the vast wealth of knowledge sitting idly before him.

He wondered if any of it could've saved him.

Izuku finally caught himself, squeezing his eyes shut as he banished the thought from his head. In its absence, however, there came a heavy sense of unease, like the shadow of a panic attack. Because Izuku didn't normally think like this. He wasn't so—

"—Midoriya?"

Izuku jolted, heart pounding in his chest, biting his lip hard to avoid shrieking. His head snapped up. There, standing a couple of feet away, was Todoroki, his frown and slightly widened eyes betraying his surprise.

"Woah. Are you okay?" He asked.

"Y-Yeah!" Izuku scrambled to stand up, brushing off the back of his robe. He then dropped to a squat, gathering up all the books that had fallen, shoving them onto the shelf behind him at random. "Sorry, I was just—"

"That?"

"Huh?" Izuku spun around. Todoroki was pointing at the book Izuku had been trying to pick up, its spine still glowing. "Oh, um…"

To his surprise, Todoroki reached up, grabbing the book and giving it a try himself. He grunted quietly, his body straining. It began to tip outward slightly, only to snap right back into place. Todoroki sighed.

"Well, I tried." He said, then shrugged. "Even if we could get it off the shelf, we probably wouldn't be able to carry it out of here."

Izuku stood there for a while, his fingertips cold, his body tense.

Why would Todoroki try to help me with this?

Shouldn't he be getting the librarian to kick me out, or at the very least, lecture me?

Izuku cleared his throat. "Um… Thanks anyway."

Todoroki turned toward him. "You're sure you're alright?"

Izuku gaped at him for a moment. "I…"

Todoroki blinked. "We could talk outside, if you want."

After a second of hesitation, Izuku nodded, standing up straight and following him out the side door. It was still dark out, but it wouldn't be for much longer. Izuku quietly cursed himself for losing track of time.

The two of them stood beneath an oak tree. Todoroki looked at him, raising an eyebrow. "You can tell me if you're sick, you know." He said. "I wouldn't tell anyone else."

Izuku smiled, laughing nervously. "Thanks, but I…" He sighed. "I don't know. I feel… fine. Physically, anyway."

"Well, I assume there's a reason you wanted a book about conditions of the soul."

"…Yes"

Todoroki stared at him for a while, and Izuku uncomfortably stared back. After a moment, Todoroki tilted his head. "Are you doing something you aren't supposed to?"

He tensed, his whole body freezing. He couldn't drag his eyes away from Todoroki's face, despite every instinct inside him telling him he should.

When Izuku didn't respond, Todoroki sighed. "You know I wouldn't judge you if you were." He stated. "I wouldn't tell anyone either. I'm not *that* desperate to ascend—"

"—S-Sorry, I just…" Izuku stuttered, voice cracking. He wiped his sweaty palms on his robe.

Why do I feel so… scared?

Todoroki frowned.

"This is big, isn't it?" He said quietly.

Izuku gulped. In lieu of a verbal response, he nodded.

"…Is it something that could get you killed?"

Izuku froze.

He'd never quite thought about it in those terms before. Angels can't really die—not in a normal sense. They can be destroyed, their souls obliterated by hellfire, or some other unholy force. But beyond that, the only alternative was—

The face of the boy from level one barged into his head again, the memory of his vacant eyes as he lay catatonic beneath the stairwell sending shivers down his spine.

“Midoriya?” Todoroki probed, his tone becoming increasingly worried.

“No, it’s…” Izuku stumbled. “I… I don’t think I’m in danger.”

Todoroki stared at him for a while, still frowning, but eventually his expression melted back into neutrality. “Well, if you ever feel like talking about it, let me know.” He said, shrugging.

“…Thank you,” Izuku said, his smile wobbly, but genuine.

Izuku returned to his dorm room some twenty minutes later, his hands still shaking as he packed his bag and prepared to head down to the surface.

Izuku waited until the first church was clear before broaching the subject.

He still wasn’t sure about it. Most of the time, when Izuku asked Katsuki questions, he did so through the memo. And generally, the things he would ask about would be little more than inane curiosities—the sort of things Katsuki wouldn’t have much incentive to lie about. That was primarily because Izuku wouldn’t able to detect whether Katsuki was lying through writing, but it still created a precedent.

So Izuku wouldn’t normally ask the Demon to answer something so important. But paradoxically, its importance meant he couldn’t afford *not* to.

Katsuki stood with his back turned toward him, standing before a stained glass window depicting the Garden of Eden, the light from outside creating a halo around his body. Izuku cleared his throat, the sound echoing in the large, decadent chamber, and Katsuki turned his head slightly.

“There’s, um… something I wanted to ask you,” Izuku said. “I don’t know if you’ll know, but…” He exhaled. “Well, I don’t really have any other options right now, so…”

Katsuki finally turned toward him fully, his curiosity evidently piqued.

“Okay.” He raised an eyebrow. “Shoot.”

Izuku swallowed. Fidgeting with the hem of his sleeves, he did his best to explain what had happened, avoiding eye contact until he was finished. When he eventually glanced at Katsuki’s face again, he looked almost as bewildered as Izuku felt.

“So you used power, as in *Angel magic,* while you were asleep?” Katsuki narrowed his eyes. “I’m assuming you don’t sleep in enchanted gloves.”

Izuku frowned. “Of course not.”

Katsuki took a deep breath. “Well, that’s *definitely* not normal.”

“I know that.” Izuku snapped. “I’m asking if you have any idea *why* this could happen.”

“Okay, first of all: chill.”

Izuku looked away sheepishly. Katsuki sighed, and moved closer.

“Here’s the thing, Deku.” He said. “For the most part, I know about shit that it’s *useful* for me to know about. If you’re looking for a diagnosis, I’m not the guy to go to.”

“But you’re the only—“

“—I’m not fucking finished.” He interjected, exasperated. “Look, I’ll cut to the chase: I don’t know what’s happening to you, Deku. I *don’t.* The only explanation I can think of would be if you had something like a divinity implant put in, but that’d raise way more questions than it would answer.”

Izuku cocked his head. “Divinity implant?”

“Yeah. Back in the day, they used to give Angels these implants that let ‘em use power without any special equipment.” He explained. “They stopped using ‘em around three-hundred years ago.”

“…Why?”

“I don’t know. I wasn’t around back then. From what I’ve heard, they never actually explained it.” Katsuki shrugged. “If you wanna know what Demons believe, most of us assume it was ‘cuz having an armed populace made ‘em nervous, so they switched to enchanted weapons and armor ‘cuz they were easier to control.”

“Oh.” Izuku frowned. “Is that what you think?”

“Well, yeah. I mean, I think it was a bit more complicated.” He muttered, scratching his head. “Probably a combination of that and the fact that the implants made their soldiers too vulnerable. If a Demon could figure out where the implant was, all they’d have to do is rip it out, and then that Angel’s basically useless. Having layers of enchanted armor and weapons is just more practical.”

“I guess that makes sense…” Izuku mumbled. “But… I feel like I’d probably know if it was something like that.”

“Probably, yeah.” Katsuki said. “I didn’t bring it up ‘cuz I thought it was plausible; it was just all I could think of. Y’know, just ‘cuz I know more than you doesn’t mean I’ve got all the fuckin’ answers. ‘Specially when it comes to shit that God would have a strong incentive to keep secret.” He shoved his hands into his pockets, meandering down the aisle. “I’m sure there’s like ten other possible explanations buried in the secret archives of God’s sex dungeon, or wherever the fuck.”

"Katsuki opened the door with his back, allowing golden light to spill into the church. He looked at Izuku and arched an eyebrow. “Anyway, you comin’ or what?”

Izuku sat before All Might, wringing his hands as he fumbled through the explanation, despite having spent nearly every second leading up to that moment rehearsing it in his mind. When he finally got through with it, he paused, a cold sweat clinging to the back of his neck. “All Might… am I going to die?”

“No, no! Of course not, my boy.” He replied. Izuku relaxed slightly, but then— “You can’t die, because you’re already dead.”

Izuku blinked, his mouth hanging open slightly.

“All Might,” He said, taking a deep, shaky breath. “With all due respect, I’m *really* not in the mood for jokes.”

“I apologize,” All Might said, sighing. “I was just trying to lighten the mood. I really do mean that, though—you’re going to be fine.”

Izuku nodded, releasing the breath he’d been holding.

“However, this is… *highly* irregular.” All Might continued. “And I’m afraid I don’t have the answer.”

“I see…” Izuku frowned. “Well… maybe there’s a book about this somewhere?”

“It’s… possible, I suppose. But I highly doubt it.”

Izuku cocked his head. “But why? I mean, I saw a book about soul irregularities in the library yesterday. It was level eight, you could—“

“—Midoriya,” he interjected, putting a hand up. “I guess now is the part where I need to tell you that some of the information I gave you regarding the soul was… well, not exactly *standard.”*

“What do you mean?”

“Put simply, you probably won’t find any information about your situation, because what you’re experiencing presupposes that your soul generates power independently.”

“But…” He blinked. “Doesn’t it? That’s what you told me…”

“But that’s not what the textbooks will tell you.” All Might replied. “The accepted narrative is that souls can’t generate power, but rather that God endows Angels with it.”

“So, you… lied?”

“No.” All Might was quick to say. “What I told you is accurate to the best of my knowledge. More accurate than the official facts, anyway.” He shrugged. “After all, if what the Council said was true, you wouldn’t have been able to use power at all.”

“But why would the Council lie about something like that?”

“The Council lies about quite a lot of things.”

Izuku gaped.

“All Might, that’s—“

“—Not as blasphemous as you might think.” All Might cut in, chuckling. “The Council lies, but they have real reasons to do it.”

“…Like what?”

“Well, you have to understand that Heaven is at a large disadvantage when it comes to keeping secrets.” All Might explained. “A Demon can never become an Angel, but an Angel can quite easily become a Demon. The Council disseminates misinformation about certain things in order to protect sensitive information when Angels inevitably Fall.”

“So they lie... to protect us?”

“In a sense, yes.”

For a while, Izuku remained silent.

He could understand the rationale. It seemed like a reasonable decision to him, at least in the abstract, but somehow, it still just didn’t sit right with him.

It doesn’t have to, he tried to remind himself. *It doesn’t have to make sense to you, so long as it makes sense to God.*

“Well…” He bit his lip. “I’m sure God and his Council know best.” After a moment, he shook his head, his attention shifting back to the issue at hand. “But… I’m worried. What if I use power in my sleep again, and someone actually hears it this time? Or what if I accidentally use it in public?”

All Might hummed. “That *is* the main concern, I would agree.” He said, rubbing his chin. “I may be able to find something that will help you keep that from happening, but it will take a few days.”

Days?

Although nothing had happened the last night, Izuku still paled at the thought of going multiple nights without some sort of safeguard.

“But as for the next few nights…” All Might said. “Well, I can offer you a short-term solution, but you won’t like it.”

Izuku shook his head. “I’ll do whatever I need to do.”

All Might nodded, and stood up, leaving the room. He returned a couple minutes later, holding a pair of handcuffs and ankle shackles. Izuku’s heart sunk.

“It won’t be comfortable, but it should prevent you from destroying the dorm building.”

Four.

That’s how many nights Izuku had spent sleeping—trying to, anyway—in shackles, and it was beginning to take a toll on him, to put it lightly.

It was like there was this perpetual fog in his head, obscuring and blurring all sensory information into one indistinguishable experience-blob. If you asked Izuku to elaborate on what that meant, he wouldn’t have a response, but he felt it, deep in his bones.

That morning, he woke to discover fresh bruises on his wrists, evidence of him straining against the cuffs in his sleep. It was a bittersweet realization. It proved that the cuffs had done their job, but it also proved that they were necessary.

And he wasn’t the only one who noticed the bruises. Katsuki commented on them when they met up on the surface that morning.

“What happened there?”

“Oh,” Izuku said, eyes glazed over as he stared down at his wrists and shrugged. “I’ve been wearing hand and ankle cuffs to bed these past few days, so I won’t destroy anything in my sleep by accident.”

Katsuki hummed. “Huh. That’s kinda kinky, Deku.”

Izuku had barely even registered the comment.

For most of the day, he was just moving through space, carrying out his duties like an emotionless automaton. All his reactions were delayed as he weakly fought against the haze of sleep deprivation and emotional exhaustion. At one point, Katsuki even asked if he needed to go home and rest.

Things went on this way for the rest of the day—up until the last stop, anyway.

The two of them had temporarily parted after the last church, so Katsuki could escort the three remaining stragglers to Hell, and when Izuku entered the church, he was surprised to find it empty.

Well, almost empty.

“I think this one got cleared out by one of our people about a week ago.”

Izuku didn’t see him at first. He spun around, looking in all directions, before he finally thought to look up. And that’s where he found him: leaning over the railing of an indoor balcony. It seemed he’d foregone the jacket for his return, wearing just a dark red tank top. A second later, Katsuki hopped over the railing, landing in front of Izuku. It was only then that he realized, with slight confusion, that Katsuki was holding an apple.

“I actually like this one alright.” Katsuki said, gesturing at their surroundings. “Usually I find church architecture kind of obnoxious, but this one’s decent. Clear color-scheme, not too over-the-top.” He took a bite out of the apple, sharp teeth cutting through its red skin.

“Isn’t that just… a regular apple?” Izuku asked.

Katsuki looked at him. “Yeah,” he said. “Never said I couldn’t eat human food. Just that I don’t need to. I still like it sometimes.” He took another bite, the sound sharp in the otherwise quiet space.

“Oh.” Izuku said. “What’s it taste like?”

Katsuki blinked, staring at him blankly. “Like an apple, Deku. The fuck do you think?”

Izuku frowned, averting his eyes. “I don’t know.” He mumbled. “I was just asking…”

A beat of silence.

“Wait.” Katsuki said. “Do you… do you not *know* what an apple tastes like?”

Izuku laughed nervously. “Well, I don’t know what *most* things taste like, uhh… you know. Because I don’t remember anything from when I was human, Kacchan.”

“Okay…” Katsuki narrowed his eyes. “But you can still eat, can’t you?”

Izuku nodded. “Sure, I mean, technically. I usually don’t, though.”

“Why not?”

He shrugged. “No one really mentions it out loud, but it’s sort of… frowned upon.” He said. “Angels are supposed to be above human desire. There’s no stigma around drinking water or tea or things like that, but eating… well, no one wants to look like a glutton, I guess.”

Izuku wasn’t sure why he decided to tell him all of that. It felt like he’d just opened his mouth and dumped his thoughts out onto his tongue, but he was too mentally worn out to really think about it.

“That’s so stupid.” Katsuki flatly stated.

Izuku just shrugged again. “It is what it is.”

“And what it *is* is dumb.” Katsuki said, taking a step toward him. “I mean, what’s the point of existing if you can’t even *enjoy* it?”

Izuku sighed, rubbing his eyes with his hands. For several seconds, he was quiet, racking his brain for a response. But the fog was too thick. “You know, maybe if my head was a bit clearer, I’d be able to answer that question.” He said, shaking his head. “But at least for now, all I can say is… I don’t know. But there’s probably a reason.”

For a long moment, Katsuki just stood there, staring at him silently.

“Do you wanna try it?” He asked. Izuku looked up, meeting his eyes. Red, entrancing, glowing in the dim light. Katsuki took a step toward him. Izuku took a step back.

“You mean…?”

“Yeah. There’s no one else here,” Katsuki said, shrugging. “No one around to judge you for doing some shit that doesn’t affect them.”

He took another step toward him. Izuku tried to take another one back, but his foot hit the wall instead. Izuku found himself backed up against a stained glass window. His eyes darted back and forth between Katsuki’s face and the apple in his hand.

But it was strange.

Kacchan should be smiling, Izuku thought. *He should be smirking at me, speaking in that condescending tone of voice.*

Everything about the situation matched up with the times Katsuki had teased him before, except for the way the Demon was acting.

With Katsuki, everything was loaded until proven otherwise. Izuku had gotten better at recognizing when he made a statement with strings attached, but in that moment, Katsuki’s demeanor revealed nothing. He just looked at him, regarding him casually. Katsuki was in his space, but it wasn’t like the other times. It didn’t *feel* like he was trying to evoke a reaction.

It felt almost… *normal,* somehow. But perhaps that was just the sleep deprivation talking.

“One bite can’t hurt.” Katsuki said, his tone calm, conversational. “Aren’t you curious?”

He was.

But Izuku didn’t trust his voice. So instead, he just nodded slowly.

Bracing one hand against the wall beside his head, Katsuki leaned in a bit closer, raising the apple to his lips. He quirked an eyebrow. “Well, go on then. Open.”

He did, and felt his teeth touch the skin.

“Bite down.”

Izuku tried, tentatively at first—not quite sure how solid it would be. But the flesh gave way easily enough.

“Close.”

He did.

“Chew.”

He did, and immediately, a sweet taste covered his tongue.

After a couple of seconds, Katsuki said, “Swallow.”

And just like all the times before it, Izuku did as he was told.

“There you go.” Katsuki said, his voice low and rumbly, and he could almost feel it in his chest.

Izuku’s knees felt weak. He glanced down at the ground, at the placement of their feet. One of Katsuki’s shoes was positioned between his own, and his vision darkened at the edges. He looked up, and—

Ah, there it is. Izuku thought, almost relieved. Katsuki’s signature smirk was back, coupled with that dangerous glint in his eye the suggested he knew something Izuku didn’t. The air between them felt hot. Izuku’s eyes followed the movement of his tongue as Katsuki licked his lips.

“How is it?” He asked.

Izuku gulped. “Tastes… sweet.”

“Do you like sweet things?”

After a second, Izuku nodded slightly. “Yeah,” He said. “Yeah, I… I do.”

“Good,” Katsuki whispered, raising the apple to his own lips and taking a bite. Izuku watched, transfixed as the Demon’s sharp, white teeth sunk into the flesh. He licked the juice off his lips and chewed slowly, his Adam’s apple bobbing as he swallowed, and then rose it to Izuku’s lips again.

He didn’t need to be told this time. Izuku took a bite, his eyes locked with Katsuki’s.

Close.

Chew.

Swallow.

Katsuki’s smile grew slightly, as if to congratulate him for getting it right on his own.

It was intoxicating, somehow. Izuku felt as though he were floating in space, and all that existed was the man in front of him. Katsuki gazed down at him, his eyes half-lidded, cat-like pupils blown wide.

“You know, you look good when you do that.” Katsuki whispered, warm breath wafting against his face.

Izuku shuddered. It took a second for his brain to catch up.

“…Do what?” He asked.

Izuku held his breath as Katsuki leaned in closer, their faces now just millimeters apart. He reached up, his hand hovering just over his neck, radiating heat, but never quite touching.

And then Izuku leaned into it.

And for a brief moment, he felt Katsuki’s fingers caress his neck. His eyes fluttered.

Katsuki grinned, sharp and dangerous.

“Take what you want.”

Chapter End Notes

lol Izuku's fucked. hope u enjoyed reading this. i guess this is sort of the first chapter where we really see izuku beginning to question things in like a sorta meaningful way. also todoroki bein weirdly fine with breaking the law. also extremely obvious symbolism
FYI, based on my current outline, I'm expecting this to be somewhere around 15 chapters, give or take. the next one's gonna be.... oh boy. it's. it's gonna be wild.

anyway as always, thanks for reading, and considering commenting if u enjoyed it. this will make the fucked up zoomer reward centers in my brain light up, and then idk, i'll use that light to write? something like that lmao

until next time my dudes

Chapter 7: Echoing Violence

Chapter Summary

Izuku had always wondered what Katsuki would look like when he was fully shifted.

He just wished he could've found out under different circumstances.

Chapter Notes

Welcome to the angst portion of the story

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izuku couldn't move, and when he opened his eyes, he saw nothing but darkness. A spotlight shone down on him and him alone, and as he looked around himself, he mind sluggishly put together the pieces that spelled out his predicament. He was trapped, strung up at the center of a vast web, his body ensnared in spider silk. He pulled at the restraints, but they would not give.

He squinted, searching for shapes in the darkness, but it was far too dense.

Izuku gulped. "H-Hello?" He called out. "Is there anybody out there?"

"Oh, you're awake." He heard a voice say. The void shifted, and a form materialized before him.

Katsuki.

He looked different somehow, but Izuku couldn't quite discern why.

"Kacchan, what's going on?"

Katsuki shrugged, strolling closer. "Your guess is as good as mine."

Izuku frowned, looking around in vain. "Where are we?"

"If I knew, I'd tell you."

"Well, can you help me out, here?" He asked, wriggling against his bonds.

"Sure." He replied. "That's kinda why I'm here. Probably gonna take a while, though."

“That’s fine.” Izuku said, sighing. And then he glanced down at his body and gasped.

Was he always naked?

And were the bonds always… like this?

As things were, the spider silk wasn’t wrapped around him like a cocoon, but rather in a strange, complex network of knots which left much of his skin exposed.

“W-Wait,” Izuku squeaked, his face burning.

“What?”

“I didn’t realize… th-that I was…”

Katsuki rolled his eyes. “Look, do you want me to untie you or not?”

Izuku whined, his blush only intensifying as he reluctantly nodded. With that, Katsuki got to work, starting first on his right arm, moving up from his hand. Izuku’s breath caught at the sensation of his fingers brushing against his skin, dipping beneath the ropes to test their tightness. Izuku’s eyes darted around, looking at everything except Katsuki.

“Did you put me here?”

Out of the corner of his eye, Izuku saw him shake his head. “Think you’ve always been here.”

“Oh…” Izuku frowned. “What does that mean?”

Katsuki exhaled, working his claws into one of the knots and carefully massaging it loose. “Who knows?” He said. “Seems like there’s lots of others in the same boat, though.”

“...Really?”

Katsuki grunted a vague affirmative. “You’re one of the luckier ones, I think. There’re a couple whose bonds ain’t as bad, but there’re a lot more tied up way worse.” He said. “Sometimes it’s so bad, you can’t even see ‘em.”

Izuku’s brows pinched together. “Can’t we help them?”

Katsuki hummed. “Maybe.” He shrugged. “But you gotta be careful, I think. Some of ‘em are wrapped up in so many layers, they can’t even see. If you’re not careful, they’ll just get scared.”

That didn’t really make sense to Izuku, but his mind was too scattered to ponder it for long.

He felt the rope around his wrist loosen, and sighed as it fell away. He rotated the joint as Katsuki moved up his arm.

They both fell silent for a while, and Izuku relaxed beneath the careful attention of Katsuki’s fingers. So much so that, when he spoke next, he didn’t even realize he’d said anything until

he heard Katsuki's reaction.

"Your hands feel… nice." Izuku said, his right arm finally coming free.

He smirked, looking at Izuku beneath his lashes. "Oh yeah?"

Izuku's cheeks lit up again, and he sputtered. "S-Sorry, that was—"

"—S'okay," Katsuki purred, sliding his hands up to his cheeks, forcing Izuku to look at him as he leaned in close. "Don't be afraid of what you feel, Izuku."

Izuku wrapped his arms around Katsuki's neck.

Wait, ***arms?***

"When did my left arm…?"

"Hmm?" Katsuki's thumb rubbed against his lower lip.

"I… never mind."

Katsuki ran his hands down his body and started to work on one of his legs.

"Kacchan?"

"Yeah?"

Izuku hesitated, his mind foggy. "What happens after this?"

"What d'you mean?"

He chewed his lip, not quite sure himself. "Just… where do we go from here?"

Katsuki slid his hand up to his inner thigh, working his fingers beneath a knot tied there, and stood up straight. He leaned in close, pressed his lips against his ear, and whispered something deep and rumbly that Izuku felt thrumming beneath his skin like a second pulse.

Izuku opened his mouth, and—

Izuku sat up in bed with a start, gasping for breath as he looked around frantically, his body drenched in sweat. Though the familiar environment of his dorm room eventually grounded him in reality, it took much longer than it usually did.

With a sigh, Izuku shifted on the mattress, moving to sit on the edge as he reached for the keys on his bedside table. He groggily unlocked the handcuffs, before leaning over to do the ankle cuffs.

And that's when he saw it—something white at the edge of his field of vision. He looked, just as it was settling on the hardwood floor.

A single, white feather.

Izuku stared at it for a moment, frozen with the key still in the lock. After a moment, he hastily removed the ankle cuffs and stood, leaning over to grab the feather.

And as the events of the dream rapidly dissipated, the events of the previous night gradually began to return.

But… this is just a coincidence, right?

Izuku sat down on his bed again, and two more feathers fell out, drifting elegantly to the floor.

Izuku's throat tightened, a rush of cold swallowing his entire body. His heart lurched against the wall of his chest.

"No." Izuku whispered.

Suddenly, the specifics of the encounter came rushing back into his consciousness in full, vivid detail. The taste of the apple, Katsuki's closeness, the sensation of his warm fingertips on his neck—

Oh no.

Izuku sprung out of bed, nearly slipping on the wood floor as he scrambled to the bathroom, wincing as he turned on the light and looked in the mirror.

He froze.

Sure enough, there, on the side of his neck, he found a small, black mark. A lightning-like formation roughly two inches in diameter, stemming from the spot where Katsuki had touched him.

*Where I **let** him touch me.*

Izuku gripped the edge of the sink as he stared at the mark. His breathing began to pick up, his chest rising and falling almost painfully as he leaned in, tentatively running his fingers over the mark, swallowing the metallic taste on his tongue.

And then, in a flash, he spun around and marched over to his shower, sharply turning it on, and barely managing to get his sleep clothes off before he climbed inside, cold water cutting into him like shards of ice.

Izuku planted his hands against the tile wall for stability, but before long, he started to slip, anyway. Slowly, Izuku's palms slid down the wall, and he fell to his knees, curling up into a ball as the freezing water continued to beat down on his head, soaking his bangs and dripping into his eyes, the sound of it hitting him drowned out by the ringing in his ears.

This wasn't happening to him.

It couldn't be.

Not to *him,* not to *Izuku.*

These were problems that happened to other people. Angels of different levels, in different classes—people who existed at the fringes of Izuku's awareness, at best. These were stories that Izuku heard in passing. Things people would speak of in the space between small talk and the main conversation. Izuku would hear about them, and his heart would ache for them, but he was always able to move on from it. It was a footnote in his life and nothing more.

Izuku shivered beneath the onslaught of freezing water, the tips of his fingers turning blue and his muscles growing stiff as his body temperature started to drop. It took him twenty minutes before he finally gathered the will to shut off the water, and ten more before he actually moved.

He stumbled out of the shower, sluggishly pulling his towel off the rack. He dried his hair, and then the rest of his body.

Another feather fell out.

Izuku tensed for a moment, and then picked it up off the floor. He leaned against the sink and stared at it for a minute, before closing his fist around it and squeezing. He slowly lifted his head to look at his reflection. At the black mark on his neck, and the feather in his fist.

And then it shattered around the force of his punch. Izuku dug his knuckles deeper into the broken mirror, green lightning crackling around his arm. It didn't really register for him that he'd been using power until the pain finally caught up with him.

And it was around this time that Izuku heard a knock at his door.

"Midoriya?" A muffled voice called. *Shinsou.* "Are you alright in there?"

Izuku hurried to grab his bathrobe, hastily throwing it on and tying it around his waist. He nearly tripped over his feet on his way to the door. He heard another knock just before he ripped it open, finding a very concerned-looking Shinsou standing on the other side, his knuckles hovering right over where the door used to be.

His expression only grew more shocked as he took in his appearance. Shinsou looked him up and down, frowning as his eyes settled on—

"—Midoriya, your hand."

Izuku blinked, looking down, and—*Ah.*

His knuckles were bloody. Of course.

"What happened to your hand—and your… wrist?" Shinsou asked, evidently noticing the bruises the handcuffs had left.

Izuku's heart raced as he racked his mind for an explanation, only to come back empty-handed. As things were, he probably wouldn't even be able to articulate the *truth*—how on Earth could he be expected to craft anything resembling an *excuse?*

And so Izuku didn't respond. For around half a minute, he just stood there, eyes glued to his bloody knuckles while his other hand still clutched the doorknob, his palm slipping against the metal as it became sweaty.

"Um… can I come in?"

Izuku nodded mutely, and Shinsou took a step forward, but then—

The feathers.

"Wait!" Izuku shouted, holding his bloody hand up. Shinsou stopped in his tracks, his brow furrowing. "I-I'm… I'm s-sorry," Izuku stammered, his voice squeaky. "I can't… can't…" He hesitated, squeezing his eyes shut. "I have to go!"

He slammed the door. He lunged to the floor, grabbing the three feathers near his bed before heading to the bathroom to retrieve the other. All the while, Shinsou continued to pound on his door.

"Midoriya! Hey!" He shouted. "What's going on? *Please* open the door!"

Izuku yanked open a drawer under the sink, shoving the feathers to the back of it before turning on the sink and hastily rinsing his hand off. He gently patted it dry, and let that be enough for the time being. The blood was oozing out slowly, anyway.

Izuku took a deep breath and went to check his reflection, only to remember that the mirror was broken. He mumbled under his breath, squinting as he leaned to the side, awkwardly looking into one of the larger shards. He sighed in relief when he confirmed that the mark on his neck was hidden by to robe, as long as he didn't move around too much.

Taking a couple more measured breaths, he schooled his features and left the bathroom, going toward the door once again. When he got there, both Shinsou and Monoma—whose room was across the hall—were standing there. Shinsou looked worried still, but Monoma just seemed confused.

"S-Sorry about that." Izuku said, doing his best to look Shinsou in the eyes. He was still trembling slightly. He gripped the edge of the door harder.

"What's going on?" Monoma asked, yawning. "You guys woke me up."

"I'm sorry," Izuku repeated. "It's not as big a deal as it… well, as I was acting," He smiled sheepishly. "I overreacted. That's all. Sorry for making you worried."

"But what *happened?"* Shinsou asked.

"I…" Izuku hesitated for a second. "I had a nightmare." He said. "I've been having a lot lately, and this one just shook me up, and—"

"—How does that relate to your hand and wrist being injured?" Shinsou interjected.

"Well," Izuku looked away, flushing. "The thing is, I've been uhhh…" He swallowed, and suddenly, it came to him. He kept his eyes fixed on the ground, trying to play up his embarrassment. "Lately, I've been having this problem where I move around in my sleep. I've been sleeping in handcuffs to try to limit it, so I won't, uhh, knock things over. This morning, though, I wound up falling out of bed, and, uh, my cuffs got caught on the edge of my night stand, so when I woke up, I freaked out and ended up pulling one of my hands free by force, which is how it got cut up like this."

As soon as Izuku said it, he realized how many holes there were in that story.

Shinsou frowned. "Then why's your hair wet?"

Izuku tensed. "…I sweat a lot when I have nightmares."

Monoma nodded, smiling in that weird, vacant way of his. "Gross," He said, before turning around and heading for his room. "Try to keep it down, alright?"

"R-Right, sorry." Izuku said.

Shinsou still looked uncertain, but it seemed Monoma's acceptance was enough to sway him into dropping it himself.

"Okay, well… be careful," He told him, shrugging. "And let me know if there's anything you want to talk about, I guess."

"Of course!" Izuku said, nodding quickly.

With that, Shinsou turned and walked away. Izuku closed the door softly, leaning against it with a sigh.

All Might, he thought. *I need to talk to All Might.*

But first…

Izuku padded over to the closet, grabbing the box of fire tea All Might had given him, along with his electric kettle. He waited, tapping his foot as it brewed, then poured himself a cup that he started to drink just a bit too soon.

Still, it calmed him, and helped him think a bit more clearly.

Four feathers wasn't the end of the world, but it was disconcerting in a way that regular corruption marks were not. All Might had talked about it in the past, albeit not in great detail.

Contact-based corruption damage always appeared at the site where the contact occurred. It would take very extensive tactile contact before feathers began to fall out, so given Izuku's situation, the fact that his feathers were falling out pointed to a deeper issue. Something in his heart and mind, translated into his soul.

This wasn't the result of some accidental contact.

This was Katsuki's plan *working*.

To an extent, at least.

Izuku sighed, finishing off his tea. He got dressed, picking a shirt with a high collar and slipping on his shoes. But before he left, he paused, and slowly reached back toward his wings. Though he was terrified at the prospect of discovering more loose feathers, it would be so much worse if they fell out in public. Izuku carefully tested each one, pulling gently to ensure they were secure. He sighed in relief. None of them were loose.

With that, he headed out.

All Might walked in with an unmarked, black jar and what looked like a paintbrush. He set them down on the kitchen table before Izuku. He stared at them for a while over his steaming cup of tea—his second that day—before finally looking up at his mentor.

"What's that?"

"It's glue."

Izuku furrowed his brow, staring back at All Might for a second. Then it hit him. "Wait, you're *serious?"*

All Might chuckled, sitting down across from him. "I am! They have this at the hospital, but one doesn't make it to the third sphere without at some point acquiring a supply of their own." He said, grinning. "Feathers can fall out for internal reasons, but they can also fall out as a result of just normal corruption damage caused by a Demon touching one's wings. Naturally, because the wings are one of the least armored spots on Angels, they're also one of the most common places for corruption damage to occur. And since soldiers can't have our feathers falling out willy-nilly…" He gestured to the jar. "Well, feather glue!"

Izuku smiled, laughing slightly. It was such a simple solution, he hadn't even considered it.

But after a moment, his face fell.

"But in my case, it *wasn't* normal corruption damage," he quietly said.

All Might exhaled. "…Yes."

Izuku put his head in his hands.

"I'm such an idiot," He said, muffled. "I mean, I was tired. I haven't been sleeping well, so I guess I was more susceptible, but… still. I should've never let him get that close."

Whether Izuku was referring to physical or emotional proximity, he wasn't sure.

"All things considered, I think you've been doing quite well up to this point."

Izuku gave a mirthless laugh.

“No, I mean it!” All Might said. “I know third tier Angels who would’ve crumbled in under a month, and you’ve been at this for nearly four.”

Izuku flushed, looking at him through the gaps in his fingers. “…You’re just saying that to make me feel better.”

All Might sighed. “If I may be frank, Midoriya, I wouldn’t have put myself in such a… risky situation for a student I didn’t consider to be extraordinary.”

For a while, Izuku was quiet. He mumbled something under his breath.

“What was that?”

Izuku cleared his throat. “Just… would you still feel that way if I *did* Fall?”

All Might hesitated for a moment. Izuku was too scared to check his expression.

“It’s no use worrying over things like that.”

“But I’m *scared.”*

“I understand that.” He said. “But… Midoriya, Falling is the result of a lapse in faith.”

“Yes, but lately—“

All Might reached across the table, placing his hand over Izuku’s injured one. Izuku fell silent.

“Faith doesn’t just mean faith in God, my boy.” He said. “You also need to have faith in yourself. This is just a trial. You can make it through, but you need to trust yourself.”

After a long moment, Izuku nodded. “Okay.” He said, softly. “I’ll… I’ll do my best.”

All Might smiled, standing up. “Great!” He reached for the jar. “Now, let me show you how to do this. There’s a bit of a trick to it…”

As wonderful of a mentor as All Might was, there were limits to the things Izuku felt comfortable telling him. Despite how much he trusted the man, some things were just too awkward to discuss. Like the specific things Katsuki had said to him.

Or the specific… *feelings* Katsuki had dug up in him.

He flushed, clutching the straps of his bag as he hurried back to the dorms. He entered as discreetly as he could manage, and took the stairs up to his room. Once inside, he locked the door behind him. He dropped his bag next to the door, and collapsed on his bed.

All Might was like a father to him, he supposed. He trusted him a great deal, and they were fairly close. But no matter how close one was with one's father, there were certain things you just… did not talk about.

And unfortunately, the volume of things Izuku couldn't tell All Might seemed to be piling up more and more each day.

Izuku sometimes wondered if All Might might not have been quite so optimistic had he known the extent to which Izuku had fallen for Katsuki's… charms.

He frowned into his pillow.

That word didn't seem right. Katsuki wasn't charming. In a lot of ways, he seemed to embody the antithesis of charm. He had his moments sometimes, in his own, unconventional way, but it was far from being enough to categorize him as charming on the whole.

No, Katsuki wasn't charming. In fact, he was actually quite rude. Obnoxious. Arrogant.

…But the arrogance seemed to be backed up by genuine skill, at least from what Izuku had seen. It was justified arrogance. Maybe that made it confidence. But it seemed to carry over into everything he did.

Izuku rolled over on the mattress and sighed, staring up at the ceiling.

Katsuki's looks probably helped, he supposed. Say what you will about his demeanor, but it was hard to deny that he was, in fact, quite handsome.

Izuku shook himself.

Why am I thinking about this?

Izuku never used to pay attention to Katsuki's looks. Sure, he was aware, he figured, on some level, that Katsuki would probably be considered quite attractive by most people. But the same could be said about Uraraka and Todoroki, and he never caught himself ruminating on *that.*

Izuku groaned, restlessly turning over onto his side and staring at the wall. The more he thought about Katsuki, the more unstable his heart became. He felt he was moving toward something he couldn't control, and though he suppressed the feeling as best he could, it was moments like these where it really hit him, shaking him to his core. It was terrifying, plain and simple.

He glanced at the memo, sitting innocently atop his dresser, then closed his eyes.

Maybe it would be best if he just kept his distance for a while.

The following day, Izuku was preparing to rush back to his room when someone grabbed his wrist. He yelped, and instinctively tried to break free until he saw who it was.

“Oh! Apologies,” All Might said. “I didn’t mean to scare you.”

Izuku shook his head, his face heating up. “N-No, it’s no big deal, All Might. I’ve just been, ahh…” He rubbed his neck. “Tense, lately.”

All Might nodded. “Well, do you have a moment to spare before you head out?”

“I… Sure.”

All Might led him to his office, a small room at the end of the hall, with a desk covered in papers and books stacked up under the desk. Izuku sat in a chair on the opposite side of the desk, gripping his backpack in both arms.

“What’s going on?” He asked, as All Might closed the door behind them. He turned to look at him with a grin.

“Well, I’m pleased to inform you that you’ll no longer be needing to sleep in handcuffs.”

Izuku perked up. He could almost feel his dark circles fading at the thought. All Might opened his desk drawer, and pulled out a small box, which he set down in front of Izuku.

He glanced up at All Might, quietly asking for permission. All Might nodded, and Izuku opened the box.

Inside, he found what looked to be two rings, crafted from some sort of black stone.

“Obsidian rings.” All Might said. “So long as you wear them, they should prevent you from using power in your sleep.”

“Wow.” Izuku picked one of the rings up and examined it. “How do they work?”

“It’s…” All Might cringed. “It’s complicated.” He said. “It’s sort of like a distraction.”

“A distraction?”

“Yes. The rings themselves are harmless, but the material is similar to certain substances that aren’t.” He explained. “Your body falsely anticipates harm, and prepares to allocate power toward counteracting it. Does that make sense?”

Izuku hesitated. “Um… Not really.”

All Might smiled sheepishly. “Well, I tried. As I mentioned, it’s complicated.”

Izuku hummed. “So is there, ahh… any sort of *danger* to wearing them for long periods of time?”

“Not that I’m aware of, but…” He trailed off for a moment. “Well, I’d advise against wearing them outside of sleeping, just to be safe.” He paused, looking around the messy room with a frown. “You know, I know have a note from the supplier that talks about all of this somewhere around here, but I can’t seem to find it…”

“Supplier?” Izuku said, putting the rings back in the box with care.

“Well, perhaps that’s too official of a term.” All Might said, chuckling. “I called in a favor from an old friend. Let’s leave it at that.”

Wake up. Get dressed. Go to class, or to the surface; whichever he was scheduled for that day. Return to the dorms. Lock the door. Alone.

It’d been ten days since Izuku had last opened the memo.

He did not know if Katsuki had tried to contact him, though he assumed that he must have. After all, under normal circumstances, they would have met twice during that timeframe.

Izuku did his best to keep a low profile on the surface, and it had worked so far. All Might had taught him the basics of dulling his presence, so his soul wouldn’t be so easy to detect, at least beyond a one-mile radius.

Apart from his missions, Izuku spent most of his time locked up in his room. He’d been sleeping better, thanks to the rings, but the anxiety was still very much present.

Every day, Shinsou would knock on his door, and every day, Izuku would make some excuse not to come out, until he just… stopped responding altogether, and pretended to be asleep instead.

He just couldn’t take it. Couldn’t face the questions, couldn’t keep lying to his friends. It was tearing him up almost as much as his feelings for Katsuki had been.

Izuku was finding it easier to be alone, these days. But it was harder to pretend everything was okay.

It was late at night as he sat awake at his desk, staring at the memorandor sitting atop his dresser. It was beginning to collect dust.

Sighing, Izuku stood, heading over to his closet and grabbing his stash of fire tea along with his kettle, only to find that the thing wouldn’t turn on.

Izuku frowned, and tried turning it off and on again, but nothing seemed to be working. He glanced at the clock. Three in the morning.

Now’s probably a safe time, he figured. So he grabbed the tea and headed downstairs quietly. The kitchen was empty.

It usually was.

Izuku found the kettle underneath the stove, dropped the tea infuser in and filled it with water. He turned on the stove and set it down with a sigh, wandering out into the common area.

“Midoriya?”

Izuku jumped, looking to his right. And there he saw the person he least wanted to see—well, after Katsuki, anyway.

That thought made him feel ashamed. Why did he have to avoid his friends like this?

“Shinsou…” He said, blushing.

He was sitting in a chair near the corner, his feet up on an ottoman, reading a book—the one Izuku was supposed to be reading for class, but had yet to start. Another thing for him to feel guilty about.

“I wasn’t sure if I’d ever see you come out of your room again.” He said, laying the open book down across his lap.

Izuku laughed nervously. “Yeah… um… sorry about that.”

Shinsou blinked. “Uraraka and Iida are getting worried.” He said, looking away. “And I’ve been worried for a while.”

“Oh.” Izuku awkwardly mumbled. “I’m… really sorry. I don’t want to make anyone worry about me.”

Shinsou shrugged. “It’s not really something you can control. Just something that happens when you…” He trailed off, but Izuku could guess where he might have been going with it.

When you act so strangely for months on end.

When you suddenly start acting like a hermit, and never answer your door.

When you make a habit of lying to the people you’re supposed to trust the most.

Izuku frowned, his shoulders hunching, ankles crossing. He wanted nothing more than to disappear. He felt so… slimy. So unbelievably inconsiderate. But he didn’t know what to tell him. Didn’t know what he could say that would make things better.

Izuku slunk over, sitting in the chair beside him. Shinsou still wasn’t looking at him, but he hadn’t returned to his book, either.

For a minute, they just sat there, the silence stretching uncomfortably between them. Izuku was afraid to speak. He didn’t know if he’d be able to keep it together. Not with the growing tightness in his throat.

“…Please forgive me,” He managed to say. That got Shinsou to look at him.

“What is there to forgive?”

Izuku shook his head, his lip quivering. Just barely hanging on. “I’ve been a bad friend.”

Shinsou set the book on the side table and leaned forward.

“No, you haven’t.” He said. “If anything, *I* have, because I haven’t been able to help you.”

“Only because I haven’t been honest with you.” Izuku said, voice breaking.

Shinsou looked at him for a while, his brow furrowed. He looked so *worried.*

“Midoriya, please don’t cry.”

But of course, that set him off. A sob broke free from his throat, and Izuku keeled over, trying to hide his face in his hands. He felt the chair dip beside him, and he stiffened when he felt an arm wrap around him.

“Is this okay?”

Izuku nodded quietly. Shinsou sighed, awkwardly rubbing his shoulder.

“Is there *anything* I can do that’ll help?”

Izuku sniffled. “I don’t know… probably not.”

For a while, they just sat there like that. Eventually, Shinsou broke the silence.

“…You’ve been acting off ever since you met that Demon.”

Izuku tensed.

“Midoriya?”

“That’s…” Izuku swallowed. “I—“

The kettle whistled, and Izuku jumped up, his posture ramrod straight.

“S-Sorry,” he said, wiping his nose on his sleeve. He hurried to the kitchen and turned off the stove, pouring himself a cup of tea.

When he returned to the common room, Shinsou was sitting in the same place. Izuku couldn’t meet his eyes.

“I… I should go to bed.” Izuku said, eyes darting around. For a moment, Shinsou said nothing.

“…You’re scheduled for tomorrow morning, right?”

Izuku nodded. “Technically this morning…” he weakly joked. Shinsou didn’t acknowledge it. He didn’t say anything at all. “Um, well… good night, Shinsou.” Izuku said, heading back to his room.

He didn’t hear him say it back.

Deep down, Izuku had always known he wouldn’t be able to avoid Katsuki forever.

And so it happened that following morning, when he was walking down an alleyway beneath a cloudy sky, puddles from the previous night's rain splashing beneath his feet. He saw it, a flash of movement out of the corner of his eye, of luminescent red.

"Well, if it isn't God's favorite little *liar."*

Izuku spun around. Experience had taught him to look for Katsuki in the shadows first. He found him leaning back against a nearby wall, his fiery eyes glowing in the relative darkness.

"K-Kacchan!" Izuku said, stumbling back.

"D-Deku." He mocked, stepping toward him, into the light. There was a smile on his face, but his eyes were cold. Izuku swallowed the lump in his throat, immediately breaking into a sweat.

"S-Sorry, I was just…" Izuku sputtered. "I just, uhh, didn't—"

"—What?" Katsuki interjected, cocking his head. "Didn't think I'd *find* you? Thought you could get away with fuckin' avoiding me forever?"

"Kacchan, it's not what you think."

"Oh yeah?" Katsuki snorted. "So you're telling me you *didn't* just drop off the face of the fucking Earth and ignore all my attempts to contact you."

"I've just… had a lot on my plate, and—"

"—Bullshit!" Katsuki snarled, and in a flash, shoved Izuku up against a brick wall, the front of his cloak balled up in the Demon's fist. "Do you have any *fucking* idea what it looks like when you pull a stunt like this? Huh? For fuck's sake, Deku, I thought you'd gotten fucking *black-bagged!"*

"I'm sorry!" Izuku cried. "I didn't—I wasn't—"

"What, tryna make it look like your shitty government *disappeared* you?" Katsuki yelled, tightening his grip and shaking him. "I thought you were a fuckin' goner, but now here you are, just walkin' down the street like nothing happened. Y'know, I don't see any injuries, Deku, but I'd be *more* than happy to give you some!"

"That's quite enough, Demon."

Izuku froze, a shock of icy fear rushing through him.

He'd know that voice anywhere.

Oh no.

It felt as if time had slowed down. Izuku turned his head, all the dust and litter and mysterious stains on the ground coming into sharp detail as they traveled through his field of

vision, but his perception narrowed as his gaze fell upon the figure standing at the center of the alley, just ten feet away.

Shinsou.

He stared at Katsuki with a stone-cold look in his eyes, his fists clenched at his sides.

“Let him go.” Shinsou said.

Oh no. Oh no, no, no, God no—

“Shut the fuck up, nerd.” Katsuki hissed, before throwing Shinsou an incredulous look. “Who the *fuck* are you?” Shinsou slowly moved closer. Katsuki looked him up and down with a derisive sneer. “Christ, you look like you haven’t slept since you *died.”*

“Who I am is none of your concern, Demon.”

“And *this* is none of your goddamn business, *Ambien.”*

“Sh-Shinsou, you…” Izuku swallowed, but his throat was too dry, and it hurt. “Did you… *follow* me here?”

Shinsou averted his eyes. “I’m sorry, Midoriya. I just… was worried. And you wouldn’t say anything.” He sighed. “I wouldn’t have done this if I thought I had any other choice.”

Katsuki snorted.

Shinsou glared at him. “Something funny, Demon?”

“*’No other choice,’* you say.” Katsuki rolled his eyes. “You could’ve made the *choice* to stay out of other peoples’ business, but I guess you bastards have *always* struggled with that…”

Shinsou narrowed his eyes. “He’s my friend. I’m not going to just stand by and let some pathetic *creature* like you hurt him.”

Katsuki tensed, and Izuku’s breath caught in his throat.

“Shinsou…” He said, his voice just a shaky whisper.

After a second, Katsuki finally released the front of Izuku’s robe, slowly turning to face Shinsou fully, sliding his hands into his pockets casually. They stood about five feet apart, and Katsuki still seemed to loom over him, despite being only a few inches taller than Shinsou.

“Deku,” Katsuki said, his tone eerily calm, almost *sweet.* “Is that true? This asshole’s your friend?”

Izuku nodded at first, before he remembered Katsuki wasn’t looking at him anymore. He cleared his throat. “Y-Yes, he is.”

Katsuki hummed, cocking his head. “Well, you’re really fucking lucky then, Ambien.” Katsuki said. “‘Cuz if it weren’t for that, I’d’ve killed you where you stand.”

Shinsou’s jaw clenched.

“Just leave him alone.”

“Hmm, no.” Katsuki narrowed his eyes. “No, I don’t think I will. But you’ll leave *us* alone, if you know what’s good for you.”

“I’m not asking, *Demon.”*

“Shinsou,” Izuku said softly. He met his eyes, shaking his head quickly. “Please don’t. *Please,* it’s not worth it.”

Shinsou seemed to think about it for a moment, and then shrugged. “Okay, well if *it* won’t leave—“ Katsuki’s eye twitched, “—then you can just come with me.”

After a second of hesitation, Izuku nodded, moving to follow him.

Katsuki grabbed him by the back of his robe and yanked him back.

“Oh, no you don’t.” Katsuki said, his tone low and dark. “You’re not going fucking *anywhere,* Deku. Not ’til you give me a goddamn explanation.”

“Release him.” Shinsou hissed.

“Fuck off before my good will runs out, *Ambien.”*

Shinsou snorted, crossing his arms. *“‘Good will’?* That’s a good one.”

Katsuki raised an eyebrow. “Did you *want* me to kill you on sight?”

“I just think it’s funny how you’re trying to act as though you have any morals at all.”

“How’s that cognitive dissonance workin’ out for ‘ya?” Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“Let Midoriya go, or *else.”*

Katsuki laughed sharply. “Or else *what?”*

“Shinsou,” Izuku said. “Please, I’ll be okay. Please, *please* just go. I don’t want you to get hurt.”

Shinsou’s expression softened for a moment as he seemed to consider it, but then he shook his head.

“I can’t. I’m… I’m not leaving you alone here.”

Katsuki looked back and forth between the two of him, and then grinned. “Oh, I get it.” He said, releasing his hold on Izuku with a shove. Izuku stumbled a few feet behind Katsuki. The

Demon took a few steps forward, looming over Shinsou. “It all makes sense, now. Deku’s not just a friend to you, is he? Not in your head, at least.”

“I don’t need *you* telling me—“

“—You want him, doncha?” Katsuki said, leaning forward. “That’s what this is really about. You just want him all for yourself, huh?” His grin only grew wider. “Perfectly understandable, of course—but do you really think Deku would go for someone like *you?* Really think he’s gonna spread his fuckin’ legs for some pathetic little—“

Thwack!

Shinsou punched Katsuki in the jaw, and time stood still.

The force made Katsuki turn his head to the side, caught off guard by the surprise attack. Izuku held his breath, paralyzed as he watched Katsuki slowly turn back toward Shinsou. The hit must have caused him to accidentally bite down on his lip, as it was now bleeding.

“Shinsou…” Izuku said, quiet and shaky.

“Aw, fuck.” Katsuki said, touching his bloody lip and looking at his fingers, confirming that it was bleeding. He started laughing, but Izuku could see the anger in his eyes. “Oh, man. You’re pretty fuckin’ stupid, aren’t ‘ya? You know, you can’t fuck Deku if I kill y—”

Shinsou swung again, but this time Katsuki was ready for it. He easily dodged, stepping back into a shadow, only to emerge from another just behind Shinsou. “They really don’t teach you fuckers *any* survival skills, do they? Almost like they see you as disposable little—”

“—I don’t *care* what you think!” Shinsou shouted, spinning around and swinging again. And again, Katsuki dodged with ease, vanishing and reappearing from another shadow, like a game of whack-a-mole.

“Aw, why not? Y’know, I think there’s a nuanced conversation to be had there.”

“I am not concerned with the thoughts of disgusting things like you.”

Katsuki stilled, standing in front of Shinsou. He threw Izuku a glance. “See, this is why I prefer to kill Angels *before* they get a chance to speak.”

Shinsou swung again. Katsuki grabbed his wrist midair and held it in a tight grip.

“Look, let me be blunt, *Ambien.”* He said, grabbing Shinsou’s other wrist before he could try anything. “You’ve got two options right now. You either get the fuck out of my sight right this second, or you end up hospitalized for the next six months, minimum. S’your choice.”

Shinshou snorted. “You expect me to just leave you alone with him?”

“I’m not gonna do anything to Deku.” Katsuki said, rolling his eyes. “Well,” He side-eyed Izuku, smirking. “Nothing he won’t enjoy, anyway.”

Shinsou tried to knee Katsuki in the crotch, but Katsuki leapt back just in time. He landed atop a dumpster a couple feet away.

“Oh, for fuck’s sake,” Katsuki groaned. “Y’know, m’not exactly *dressed* for this shit, but if you really, truly *insist* on being a fucking idiot…” Katsuki reached for the hem of his tank top, sighing. “You’ve got five seconds, Ambien.” Izuku watched, frozen in place as he proceeded to pull it over his head. “Five.” The garment hit the asphalt.

Izuku’s vision darkened at the edges as Katsuki rolled his shoulders, muscles flexing beneath the morning sun. In any other context, he might’ve thought the sight incredible, but in that moment, it just left a sinking feeling in the pit of his stomach.

Because he could sense where this was headed, even before Katsuki’s body began to change.

“Four.”

Katsuki’s horns began to elongate, claws appearing on his fingertips, and Izuku’s throat tightened.

“Shinsou, *go.”*

“Three.”

As his horns grew, they began to twist, curving like the horns of a ram. At the same time, Katsuki’s hands enlarged, and the obsidian black of his claws began to spread up his fingers, hands, and arms.

The panic kicked in.

“Shinsou, go!” He clenched his jaw. “I’m *serious!”*

“Two.”

Katsuki’s hands were black, the color continuing up his forearms in a gradient that ended right around his elbows. Izuku watched the odd roll of his shoulder blades as they begun to stick out, the skin there darkening.

All Might’s words from many months ago came to him, then.

If you see wings…

Izuku tasted blood as he turned to Shinsou, looking at him with wild eyes.

“Run!” He screamed.

Katsuki jumped off the dumpster, and as he landed in front of Shinsou, large, bat-like wings extended outward, blocking Shinsou from view for a moment before he folded them in again.

"One."

Izuku had always wondered what Katsuki would look like when he was fully shifted.

He just wished he could've found out under different circumstances.

"You're a real fuckin' idiot, you know that?"

Shinsou scowled, but Izuku could see his hands shaking. "I said I don't *care* what you—"

Katsuki swung, his fist connecting with Shinsou's sternum, sending him flying right into a wall about twenty feet back. He slid down to the ground, clutching his chest and coughing.

"Shinsou!" Izuku cried, launching toward him, only to be caught once again by the back of his robe. Katsuki shoved him away. "Kacchan, *stop!"*

"Just stay out of my way, Deku." He said, shooting him a stern look before approaching Shinsou at a leisurely pace. After a moment, Shinsou stood up, wincing.

Katsuki cracked his neck. "What do you think, Ambien? Still think you're tough shit?"

Shinsou glared, wheezing. Then he lunged, aiming for Katsuki's stomach. Katsuki side-stepped it, grabbing his leg to knock him off balance before kneeing him in the gut. Shinsou hit the ground and rolled, finally coming to a stop a few feet away from Izuku.

"Shinsou!" Izuku ran to his side as he shakily forced himself up on his hands and knees, hacking and heaving, drops of blood hitting the asphalt.

Izuku looked up and saw Katsuki approaching again. He hastily stood up, putting his body between the two of them.

"Kacchan, stop!" He cried. *"Please,* you'll *kill* him!"

Holding his barrier, Izuku grabbed Katsuki's shoulders, shaking him slightly, tears beginning to blur his vision. Katsuki clicked his tongue, grabbing Izuku's wrists in those large, inhuman hands. "He's fine, see?" He said, gently pushing Izuku aside as Shinsou shakily stood up. Katsuki looked him up and down. "You fuckers are a lot more durable than you look, unfortunately."

Katsuki swung his fist at Shinsou's jaw.

With a surge of adrenaline and crackling electricity, Izuku grabbed his fist, stopping him just in time. Katsuki looked at him, one eyebrow raised, and then promptly gathered both his wrists into a single hand and shoved Izuku against the wall, pinning them above his head. Izuku squirmed in his grip, but even with power, Katsuki's hold was like steel.

"Kacchan, just stop! *Please!"*

Katsuki groaned. "I'm not gonna fuckin' kill him, Deku." He said. "I'm just teaching him about consequences."

"But he means well!"

“Most people do.”

“Get away from him.” Shinsou said, still wheezing. Katsuki turned and looked over his shoulder, raising an eyebrow, unimpressed.

“Don’t touch him with your filthy hands, you *monster.”* Shinsou hissed.

Katsuki’s hand tightened around Izuku’s wrists.

He gave a mirthless laugh. “You think I’m a monster, huh?” He said quietly.

“You’re *all* monsters. All of you.” He said, grinding his teeth. “You’re a plague. A vermin infesting this planet.” Shinsou grabbed Katsuki’s wrist. Katsuki didn’t move, or even look at him. He kept his eyes locked with Izuku’s. “Now get your filthy hands off of Midoriya and crawl back into whatever hole you came from, you subhuman piece of *shit.”*

With every word, Izuku watched Katsuki’s eyes grow more and more cold. For a moment, it seemed as though the glow had extinguished.

Katsuki wasn’t hypnotizing him, but he could still feel him, could see inside him through those hollow eyes.

And it hit him like a bullet carving through his chest.

Shinsou is going to die, he thought.

And the worst part was, Izuku could no longer say with certainty that such a fate would not have been earned.

But then, suddenly, Katsuki released his wrists, stepped back, and began to laugh. It was quiet at first, but quickly gained momentum, until he was bent over, clutching his stomach.

“Ah… You know, it’s actually pretty funny, in a fucked up sort of way—the way you fuckers talk about my people.” Katsuki said, wiping away fake tears. “It’s the absurdity of it, I guess. I mean, Christ, feels like I’m looking at a carbon copy of the worst parts of human history over here.”

Shinsou scowled, adopting a defensive stance as Katsuki began approaching him again.

“Filthy. Vermin. Subhuman.” He spat. “You say that shit so easily. You either don’t know the history of words like that, or you do, but just don’t care. It’s so fucking *weird.* I actually can’t tell which one it is.”

“What the hell are you—“

In a flash, Katsuki had him by the neck. He held him in the air, claws biting into his skin.

“The enemy is not like us. The enemy is subhuman.” Shinsou gasped—or tried to—and clawed at his hand. “The enemy is weak, but the enemy is strong, and the enemy will getcha unless you do as our fucking *perfect leader* says.” Katsuki tightened his grip, claws drawing

blood. “We are pure; they are filthy. We are superior; they are inferior. The enemy will destroy us, so we *must destroy them first.”* Katsuki threw him against the wall. Shinsou fell to the ground, clutching his throat, heaving.

Katsuki dropped to a squat beside him.

“Y’know, the humans had a name for this particular phenomenon.” He drawled. “They’ve seen this shit many times. But at least humanity had the decency to feel fucking *ashamed* each time and treat it like the fucking *stain* on their history that it was.”

Katsuki slowly stood, turned on his heel, and began to walk away. After a few paces, he stopped and looked over his shoulder. “You’re probably gonna wanna take him to the hospital.”

Izuku gulped, still shaking. “R-Right…”

Katsuki continued walking.

This time, he didn’t look back.

The trip to the dispatch station was challenging, but when they finally arrived, they were able to board the hospital shuttle. Shinsou was placed on a gurney upon arrival, and Izuku took a moment to breathe.

“Midoriya…” He said, voice hoarse.

“Yes?”

Shinsou said something, but Izuku couldn’t quite make it out. He leaned down, angling his ear toward him.

“I saw…”

Izuku frowned. “What do you…?”

Shinsou looked away from him, his eyes sorrowful. “I saw the way you looked at him.”

Izuku tensed. He opened his mouth to respond, but the words just didn’t come.

He just stood there, paralyzed as the nurses wheeled Shinsou away. The doors to the emergency wing closed heavily behind them, and Izuku was alone.

Chapter End Notes

...Alright, uhhhhhh....
Okay first of all, sorry Shinsou stans lmao. I always feel bad when I have to cast a non-

villain canon character as the Bad Guy, even if just for a scene. I promise Shinsou will not always be... like this... but indoctrination is a one hell of a drug. He's not REALLY a bad guy, he's just... well, y'know. Propaganda. I mean the real point here isn't about shinsou being individually an asshole, but rather that this is kind of just... how MOST angels are about demons. People like all might and todoroki are the exception, not the rule.You could argue that Katsuki's not completely innocent either, I guess. After all, if he really wanted to, he could've just thrown Izuku over his shoulder and run lmao. Idk what else to say except that Katsuki has... err, complicated feelings about Angels. Anyway, idk why I'm tryna explain myself here?? I would hope that Shinsou's behavior there makes sense in this story given the way he's talked about Demons in the past, along with his... feelings... for Izuku. Listen, Angels are fucked up dude idk what to tell you
Also, guess what word katsuki was referring to at the end there. hint: it starts with an f. Anyway, enough about that fucking scene lol

I hope y'all enjoyed this, err... as much as I guess you can? Idk I still kinda feel the need to apologize, but uhhh. thanks for reading this, as always. idk if or when this streak of weekly updates will end, but your comments have been really helping to motivate me, so thank you guys!

Chapter 8: Look Both Ways

Chapter Summary

> Todoroki paused, then sighed. “I guess, for me at least, the world becomes a much scarier place once I decide that there are large groups of people who are just categorically evil for no coherent reason."

Chapter Notes

> angst hell 2: electric boogaloo
>
> CONTENT WARNING: character describes an event in which animal abuse is implied to have happened (that's probably unnecessarily verbose but i wanna be precise)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The steady beeping of the heart monitor cut the silence in the small hospital room. It’d been about two hours since they had arrived, though for most of it, Shinsou had been sedated.

Being Angels, few, if any, physical injuries were actually fatal. Their bodies were merely vessels for their souls, and so long as their souls were not destroyed, Angels could generally recover, given time. But of course, that didn’t make the symptoms any less uncomfortable.

Izuku was dozing in the chair beside Shinsou’s bed when an odd sensation pulled him back to himself. It was unnerving, as though the air itself was pressing against him on all sides. He looked toward the door seconds before the knob turned, and his heart thumped against his chest as his fight-or-flight instinct immediately kicked in.

The door opened. There, standing in the doorway, was a single Acolyte. His hands were clasped behind his back, and his cloak billowed strangely as he entered the room.

Izuku found himself unable to tear his eyes away from the powerful figure, even as the pressure against his skin began to increase. Then the Acolyte turned and looked at him, despite the red blindfold over his eyes.

“Izuku Midoriya.”

It didn’t really sound like a question, but Izuku nodded anyway.

“Y-Yes, that’s me.” He stammered.

The Acolyte tilted his head. “And I take it this is Shinsou Hitoshi.”

“Yes, sir.” He replied. “Um… how may I assist you?”

He turned toward Shinsou, walking slowly around the bed, shoes clacking against the tile like a metronome. “I understand you and your colleague here had a confrontation with a Demon. I came to inquire about the circumstances under which two first-sphere Angels found themselves in such a predicament.”

Izuku gulped.

He knew this would happen. But that didn’t make it any less terrifying.

“I see. Of course, sir.” Izuku cleared his throat. “So, we—“

Beside him, Shinsou groaned, stirring in his sleep.

“Shinsou!” Izuku gasped, leaning forward as the other Angel’s eyes fluttered open.

“What’s going on…?” He slurred, wincing as he looked around. His eyes soon settled on the Acolyte, who stood at the foot of his bed like a sleep paralysis hallucination.

The heart monitor immediately sped up.

The Acolyte smiled slowly. “Ah, you’re awake.” He said. “Good. I was just asking your colleague here about the circumstances leading up to your confrontation with the Demon.” He gestured toward Izuku, giving him a short but clear view of his hands. The ends of his fingers were white, like fresh snow, as though all the color had been sucked out of them. The odd bleaching effect gradually faded into a more natural skin tone around his knuckles, though even that looked a bit off, as though he were afflicted with some human disease, like jaundice.

Izuku finally forced himself to look away, but he couldn’t stop the thoughts from entering his mind.

It was normal for higher level Angels to undergo physical transformations of one kind or another, but there was usually some resemblance from one level to the next. Acolytes didn’t really resemble *anything* closely, except… well, other Acolytes.

He felt a chill run down his spine. *What **happens** to them?*

Izuku shook himself, looking up at Shinsou again. He was nodding, the hazy look in his eyes now long gone. He cleared his throat. “W-Well, I was attacked, essentially. If it weren’t for Midoriya, I probably would not have survived, sir.”

No lies so far, at least technically.

The Acolyte hummed. “And where were you two scheduled today?”

Shinsou’s breath caught, and he looked down. “…Florence.”

The Acolyte looked toward Izuku. “And you?”

“Ah, Paris, sir.”

“And where did this confrontation occur?”

Shinsou sighed. “…Paris.”

“Interesting.” The Acolyte leaned forward. “Might I ask just *what* you were doing so far from your assigned area?”

Shinsou hesitated, glancing at Izuku. Then, he sighed.

“I… followed him.”

“Why?”

“I was worried about him. I… wanted to make sure he’d be safe.”

All true so far.

“From what, exactly?”

“From the Demons, sir. I had reason to believe he might run into one.”

“Paris is a war zone, Shinsou Hitoshi. There is always a small chance of running into Demons when one works near a battlefield. But Midoriya Izuku has evacuated such areas plenty of times before.” He cocked his head. “What was different this time?”

Shinsou opened his mouth, but hesitated. Izuku dug his nails into his palms, a bead of sweat rolling down his neck.

Every second felt like an eternity.

Izuku watched Shinsou’s throat bob as he swallowed.

“…Midoriya has not been sleeping well, sir.” He said. “As his friend, I was just concerned that he wouldn’t be able to react in time if he *did* run into a Demon.” He looked down. “I’ve heard rumors about Paris being… particularly hazardous.”

Izuku held his breath.

Is that true? He wondered. Parts of it were, at least, but if he had to make a guess, he’d say the statement on the whole was really only half-true. Would that be enough?

Calm down, Izuku told himself. *You don’t know if he can detect lies from other Angels. That’s just a rumor.*

But as seconds ticked by and the Acolyte remained standing there, still as a statue, Izuku’s heart rate accelerated, a horrible, ominous feeling creeping just beneath his skin.

He knows. He's caught Shinsou in a lie. Oh God, he knows.

Izuku's vision darkened at the edges. He could taste blood on his tongue.

I need to do something!

He opened his mouth, and—

"—Very well." The Acolyte said. The sound of his voice after nearly a full minute of total silence sent a shock through Izuku. "I take it that you did not complete your assignment in Florence, then?"

Shinsou visibly shuddered. "N-No, sir."

"It does not look like you will be able to do so anytime soon." He lowered his chin. "There will be consequences, of course."

Shinsou nodded. "…Yes, sir."

Without thinking, Izuku blurted out, "But sir, Shinsou meant well. He was just trying to protect me!" And as the Acolyte slowly turned toward him, he immediately started to regret it.

After a moment of sustained staring, the Acolyte said, "I suggest you get going."

Izuku blinked. "Sir…?"

"I am assuming this disruption kept you from completing your assignment, as well."

"Oh!" Izuku quickly stood. "Yes, right—of course."

"While you are at it, see to it that Shinsou Hitoshi's assignment is taken care of, as well."

Izuku's heart dropped into the pit of his stomach.

"Y-You mean… Florence?" Izuku said. "You want me to do both…?"

"The world does not stop turning when an Angel breaks." He said. The corners of his mouth tilted up. "If what Shinsou Hitoshi says about your insomnia is correct, you should have no issue completing both."

"…Right," Izuku clenched his fists behind his back. "Of course, sir!"

He chanced a glance at Shinsou, and found him pale and wide-eyed.

"Midoriya, I'm so—"

"—You are excused, Midoriya Izuku."

Izuku froze for a second, looking back and forth between the two of them, and swallowed.

He really, *really* did not want to leave Shinsou alone with the Acolyte.

But as his eyes settled on his friend one last time, and he watched him mouth the words, “Just go, it’s okay,” he swallowed the despair and let it fill his stomach.

“Yes, sir.” He said, then turned around and stiffly headed for the door. As he twisted the knob, he pause for one last moment to look over his shoulder. “I’ll talk to you later, Shinsou.” He told him, as though it were a magic spell. A prayer, one might say.

This is not the last time I’ll see you, it promised.

This is not the last time we’ll speak.

By the time Izuku had gotten down to the surface again, it was nearly half-past eleven. He’d decided to start with Shinsou’s assignment, since it was shorter. It still took him nearly seven hours to get through it all, though, and by the time he’d made it to Paris, it was dark. He was pleasantly surprised to find that nearly half his assigned locations had already been evacuated.

Maybe Kacchan swept the area before he left?

It was a relief, but it still took until nearly three in the morning for him to finish everything. When he arrived at the dispatch station, he was the only person there.

He never did run into Katsuki again. Perhaps that was deliberate, or perhaps Katsuki simply wasn’t around. It was always hard to say, with him.

When he eventually returned to his room, he decided to forgo showering in favor of simply collapsing on his bed, and in doing so, his eyes fell upon the memorandor, still sitting on his dresser, untouched. He’s not sure why he decided to pick it up then, apart from the simple fact that it was within arm’s reach, while the light switch was not.

He turned onto his side and opened it up, thumbing through until he found a note he hadn’t seen before. There were a couple pages worth of those. The memo itself had no mechanism for indicating when a message had been written. All Izuku had to go off of was the reasonable assumption that the messages were written chronologically.

He started at the top.

When are you scheduled next?

—

Oi, nerd.

Where are we meeting?

Deku?

—

Is this about what happened last time?

It better fucking not be

—

Listen, asshole.

I did not come this fucking far with you just so you could lose your shit over something stupid like that.

Izuku snorted softly, and turned the page.

But you're okay though

right?

—

Deku this isn't funny.

Are you okay??

—

Hey

Dipshit

Answer me

You fucking coward

—

Deku, I'm serious

Izuku frowned, the guilt taking root inside him. He turned the page.

Okay, FINE. Maybe I was a bit too pushy.

You seemed alright with it at the time, though?

Fuck. Shit.

I'm sorry, okay?

I'll fucking tone it down

promise

Is that what you wanted to hear?

—

Deku seriously I need you to fucking respond so I'll know you aren't dead

Can you PLEASE stop ruminating on your weird purity angst or whatever the fuck for like two seconds?

I just wanna make sure you didn't get black bagged or some shit.

—

Hey fucker

I'm looking for you on earth

If I find out you've just been ignoring me this whole time you're in for a world of hurt, asshole

—

DEKU

—

Okay, fuck this.

Do you have any idea how fucking idea how worried this is making me?

What the hell am I supposed to think??

I keep FUCKING looking for you

WHERE ARE YOU

Izuku's brow furrowed. Katsuki seemed to be oscillating between feelings of worry, anger, and remorse. *Maybe this is just how he acts when he's scared,* Izuku thought, watering the guilt sprouting inside him. He turned the page.

Hey nerd

ya know I never mentioned it but

there's actually two different kinds of hypnotism

Well there're more but there are two main kinds

Active hypnotism and passive hypnotism

What I used on you a while back was active hypnotism

Basically means I was controlling you without really messing with your head

Wanna guess what passive hypnosis does?

Well, that's different. Izuku noted. *It's like he's trying to see if he can bait me into responding.*

Well?

—

Here.

I'll tell you a bit more about wrath magic

Maybe that'll get your shitty nerd ass to respond

anyway

already mentioned the part about it being compression + heat, but that's just part of it

it's also about movement

basically I compress my soul into a dense ball, and I use that density to hit harder by throwing it with my movements

That's why wrath is so hard at the beginning

for a while it feels kinda like having a cannon fired at your insides all the time

then just when you think you're getting used to it, you finally figure out how to superheat it and then you've got basically the same issue except now the cannon ball is like a small, very dense star

the only good part is that it cauterizes the wounds it creates

I'm obviously used to it now but damn if it wasn't a fucking bitch for a while

I bet you'd fucking cry

fallen angels still struggle with it ya know

just not as much as regular demons

or demons like me.

So there you have it.

Any questions, nerd?

Comments? Concerns?

Any last words before I kick your ass?

Despite his exhausted state, the part of Izuku's mind that craved knowledge lit up as he absorbed the information. He *did* have questions. But it was probably too late to ask them. At the bottom of the page, Katsuki had written:

You're either dead or not reading these and honestly I don't know which one would piss me off more.

Izuku turned the page, and was met with a giant "***FUCK YOU"*** spread out across two entire pages.

He turned the page again.

Hey I'll tell you a story, asshole

so one time I fought this angel

I wanna say they were like level 7? Somewhere around there

anyway

thing about angels is that their power from level to level sorta increases by orders of magnitude

So if you're level 3 and they were level 7, that'd make them about 10,000 times stronger than you

they had 3 pairs of wings, but by the time I was through with them they had 0

I repeat: 10,000 times stronger than you

Now you may be thinking to yourself, "gee kacchan, that sure sounds like a threat"

And you'd be correct. I am absolutely threatening you, asshole

So you better FUCKING respond

You absolute

Piece

Of

SHIT

—

Deku

Deku

Deku

God you're such an asshole

If you're not already dead, I'll fucking kill you myself

—

Ya know deku this shit's really fucked me up

Cuz I wanna hurt you now

Which isn't exactly new

But most of the time when I wanna hurt you it's cuz I'm horny or something

(Side note: I hope you spend the next few days ruminating on the implications of that statement and I sincerely hope that it causes you great distress)

But right now I just kinda wanna kick your ass just for the sake of it

Any thoughts on that you wanna share?

Any fucking opinions?

Ya FUCK??

—

Deku if I ever see you again someone's getting their ass kicked and it aint gonna be me

Well, he was right about that, Izuku thought. Probably not in the way he was expecting, though. Izuku turned the page. At the very top, there was one last message. A single word.

Please.

And for some reason, that made Izuku's heart ache more than anything else. With a sigh, he reached for a pen. He didn't have time to respond to all the things Katsuki had said, but he had time for *this*.

I'm sorry, Kacchan.

I messed up. I was wrong.

And I'm really sorry.

He was about to close the memo when suddenly it grew warm in his hands, and he watched as new letters formed, bleeding through the page.

Fuck you.

You're such a fucking asshole, holy shit deku

FUCK YOU

SO MUCH

For a moment, that's all there was. Izuku's heart sped up, and he was about to try to write something else, but before his pen could even touch the page, new words started to appear, and put his mind at ease.

When are you fucking scheduled next?

The following morning, Izuku woke to the sound of someone knocking on his door. He groaned, rolling over onto his stomach, covering his ears.

"Not now, Shinsou…" he grumbled into the pillow, half asleep. He didn't actually plan on responding. He was just waiting for the knocking to stop.

It didn't.

Izuku frowned. Shinsou usually gave up somewhere around the third knock. What was making him so persistent this time?

And then he remembered.

Oh. Right.

Shinsou's in the hospital.

His body tensed.

Then who…?

Izuku forced himself out of bed. He shuffled over to the door, opening it slightly and peering through the crack.

"…Todoroki?"

Todoroki looked him up and down. "Sorry. Did I wake you?"

"What? No…" Izuku reflexively said. Then he glanced down at his pajamas and faltered. "Well… maybe, but I probably needed to get up, anyway." He laughed sheepishly. "Um, did you want to come in?"

"If that's alright."

Izuku nodded, unhooking the chain latch. Todoroki entered, and stood awkwardly near the corner.

Izuku pulled out his desk chair. "Here, you can sit!"

He muttered a soft *thanks* and sat. As he looked around, Izuku sat down cross-legged on his bed, wringing his wrists. He hadn't really taken note of it when he saw him in the library, but

Todoroki seemed to have made a full recovery. Even the corruption damage appeared to be but a faint shadow upon his skin. Izuku subconsciously touched the small, flesh-colored bandage on his neck.

“So… How’ve you been?” Izuku asked.

“Alright.” Todoroki replied. “Iida told me what happened.”

Izuku paled slightly. “I…” He stumbled. “What *exactly* did he say?”

“Just that Shinsou got into a fight with a Demon, and you were there.”

Izuku blinked. “Well, that’s… true.”

“I also heard that you somehow protected him.”

Izuku chewed his lip. “I guess so, sure.”

Todoroki cocked his head. “With all due respect, Midoriya, that seems very far-fetched.”

“I…” He hesitated. “What makes you say that?”

“Even the weakest Demons on the surface are still stronger than a lot of level four Angels. It takes a certain amount of skill to travel between Hell and Earth, and Demons tend not to send out anyone who wouldn’t be able to return on their own, if they needed to.” Todoroki explained, drumming his fingers on the surface of Izuku’s desk. “That’s what I’ve been taught, anyway.”

Izuku stared back at him for a while, then slowly looked away. “Well, maybe this one wasn’t there to fight.”

Todoroki arched an eyebrow. “What other reason would a Demon have to be on Earth?”

Izuku opened his mouth, but stopped short of actually speaking.

I have to be careful, He reminded himself. *If I tell him Demons evacuate people too, he’ll just have more questions.*

Izuku bit his lip.

When he looked up, he noticed Todoroki looking around.

“Does anyone else have access to this room?”

Izuku frowned. “Um. No, not that I know of. Why?”

“Just wanted to make sure this conversation was actually private.”

Izuku’s mouth fell open a bit.

"…Oh." He swallowed nervously, looking around at his surroundings. It was a relatively sparse room. Not a lot of places to hide any sort of recording device, at least not as far as Izuku could tell. "I mean… is there a way to check?"

He shook his head. "If someone my level could detect something like that so easily, they wouldn't use it."

"R-Right." Izuku cleared his throat, still scanning the room for anything out of the ordinary. "Well, for what it's worth, I don't see anything I don't recognize."

Todoroki remained silent.

"If it would make you feel better… we could talk in the bathroom?" Izuku offered.

"Good idea." He said, standing up. Izuku followed just behind him. By the time he remembered the state of his bathroom, it was too late.

"Midoriya, what happened to your mirror?"

"Oh, that…" Izuku said, his voice about two octaves higher than normal. He laughed nervously, and it made him sound deranged. Izuku cleared his throat. "The thing is, uhhh…" He thought about it for a moment, but truthfully, he just didn't have the energy to come up with a lie. "Actually, to be honest? I'd… rather not talk about it, if that's alright."

To his relief, Todoroki seemed completely unbothered, shrugging without so much as a word. Izuku closed the door behind them, and went to sit on the edge of the bathtub. Todoroki put the lid of the toilet down, and sat there. For a moment, it was silent again.

"Midoriya, can I be blunt?"

Are you ever not? Izuku thought. "Sure," He said instead.

"Even together, you and Shinsou would not survive a hostile encounter with a Demon on the surface, even with every other variable in your favor." Todoroki said. "Fighting a Demon without magic is like trying to win a fist fight against someone standing fifteen feet away with an assault rifle."

Izuku winced.

"We weren't trying to fight him, though. We just needed to escape."

"The idea that you could get away from a fully-shifted Demon while carrying someone else without any use of magic is patently ridiculous." He shot back, monotone. "You can't hide from them without training, either."

"Sure, but—" Izuku hesitated, his mouth hanging open for a moment before he closed it. He thought over his options. There were very few. Eventually, he sighed. "Okay. I lied." He admitted. "We got away because the Demon allowed us to. Because he didn't want to kill us."

Izuku carefully watched Todoroki's face, searching for signs of disbelief or hostility, but his expression remained neutral.

"Alright. That makes a lot more sense."

Izuku did a double take. "Uhhh… *Really?"*

Todoroki shrugged. "Demons aren't mindless killing machines." He said. "I guess it's a bit weird to imagine a situation where a Demon would be hostile enough to attack you, but not want to *kill* you. It's not that absurd, though. And people can change their mind."

People.

Izuku's heart rate picked up.

Now's the time. He thought. *If I'm ever going to ask him, it should be now.*

"Todoroki…" He swallowed. "What exactly do you *think* of Demons…?"

Todoroki blinked. "They're our opponents in the war. That's it." He replied. "If you're asking whether I think they're all inherently evil, then the answer would be no. I'm fairly certain they just tell us that so we'll feel more comfortable killing them."

For several seconds, Izuku was dumbstruck. Todoroki never minced words, but somehow, it still came as a shock to hear him put it so bluntly. But despite his normally calm exterior, as the silence stretched on, Todoroki seemed to grow increasingly uncomfortable, if the way he was fidgeting was any indication. He opened his mouth, but Izuku spoke first.

"Sorry." He said. "I… agree, basically. I've just… never heard someone say it so…" He gestured meaninglessly.

Todoroki seemed to relax. "Well, it's not the most legal opinion."

Izuku could almost hear Katsuki in his head, snorting at the very notion of a *'legal opinion.'*

"Have you always felt that way?"

"I've always been skeptical, I guess." He replied, shrugging. "I think most people who buy into it do it because it's simple, and I guess that makes them feel safer. For me, it's the opposite, though."

Izuku blinked. "You mean it makes you feel… *less* safe?"

Todoroki nodded.

"How so?"

For a little while, he was silent, staring at the floor, his brows pinched together ever so slightly.

“I… don’t know.“ He then said. “Personally, I just like to think that most people’s actions follow some kind of internal logic that can be understood, even if I don’t agree.” Todoroki paused, then sighed. “I guess, for me at least, the world becomes a much scarier place once I decide that there are large groups of people who are just categorically evil for no coherent reason. But I don’t know if that makes sense, really.”

“No, no, it does, um… I think.” Izuku said. “I can see where you’re coming from, at least.”

Todoroki smiled slightly, and silence stretched between them.

Izuku cleared his throat. “Ah, when are you headed back to the battlefield, by the way?” He asked. “I mean, if you haven’t already…?”

“I haven’t. If plans don’t change, though, I think it’ll be sometime next week.” Todoroki stood up then, and stretched. “I guess I should get back soon. They’re probably wondering where I am.”

Izuku nodded, standing as well. “It was nice getting to talk to you.”

Todoroki gave a small smile, and started heading for the door. Then, he stopped. “One more thing before I go, actually.” He said. “I guess it’s only fair that I come clean about something, since you did, too.”

Izuku raised his eyebrows. “Okay…?”

“The story I told you in the hospital, about how I got all that corruption damage… it wasn’t entirely true.”

“Oh.” Izuku frowned. “Well, what—“

“—My shield never slipped. It was up the whole time; it just didn’t matter. He bypassed it.” Todoroki reached for the doorknob. “The Demon knew my full name, Midoriya.”

Izuku blinked a few times, staring at his back. “Oh. That’s… *wait—“*

“—Don’t tell anyone.” Todoroki cut in. “I know you won’t, but… *don’t.”*

Izuku faltered. “Of course. Your secret’s safe with me, Todoroki.” He said, then swallowed. “But *please,* be careful out there.”

“I will.” He said. “If I see him again, I’ll get out of there. After last time…” He paused, sighing. “Well, who knows what could happen.”

And with that, he bid him farewell.

That night, Izuku fell asleep in his bed with the obsidian rings on, and had dreams about the floor collapsing beneath him.

He was called into All Might's office at the end of class three days later, and the room looked messier since the last time he'd been there.

"What's this about?" Izuku asked.

All Might shut the door, and sighed. For a moment, he didn't speak.

"All Might…?"

"It's… bad news, I'm afraid."

Izuku immediately tensed. All Might shuffled over to his desk, picking up a large, open envelope.

"I'm sorry, but… your application for ascension was denied."

Izuku's heart dropped into the pit of his stomach. He looked down at the floor, his throat growing tight. "Oh…"

"But it's not the end of the world!" All Might was quick to say, but then hesitated. "Well, it's the rapture, so I suppose it technically *is,* but…"

Izuku was already sniffling, his vision beginning to blur. All Might sighed.

"I'm sorry. Now's probably not the time for jokes, I suppose." He said sheepishly. "What I meant to say just now is… Well, this is just a minor setback. I can resubmit your application, once the waiting period is over."

"Right…" Izuku said. The reminder made him feel better, but not by much. "How long is that, exactly?"

"One year."

Izuku felt a churning sensation in his gut, nausea rising up his throat. *A whole year?*

A chill ran down his spine, leaving goose bumps all across his body. Memories of his bloody fist clenched around one of his own feathers came rushing to the surface, and he lost control of the trajectory of his thoughts.

Will I still be an Angel a year from now? He clenched his jaw. *I feel like I'm hanging by a thread already, and it's only been four and a half months since Kacchan and I…*

His breathing became shallow, and an abrupt sound made him nearly jump out of his seat. His eyes refocused, and he realized All Might had just snapped his fingers in front of his face.

"Midoriya…?" He said, enunciating slowly, his brows knitted together.

Izuku swallowed. "S-Sorry," He cleared his throat. "I… I understand."

After a pause, All Might exhaled, and reached across the desk, placing his hand over Izuku's."Midoriya, please don't take this as a reflection of your abilities or potential."

"But isn't that *exactly* what it is?"

"That's what it's supposed to be, but that doesn't mean it's always fair." All Might replied. "Sometimes, whether an Angel gets approved or denied just depends on whose hands the application falls into, and what sort of mood they're in that day."

Izuku grimaced. "But that's so… *arbitrary."*

All Might chuckled. "You'd be in good company feeling that way!" He said. "Midoriya, really—a *lot* of students don't get accepted the first time they apply."

"You did."

All Might faltered. "Well… yes. But I was a bit of a special case. And it was easier back then, anyway. The standards weren't as high."

Izuku reached up, wiping tears off his cheeks.

"Deep breaths." All Might murmured, giving his hand a squeeze. Izuku nodded, taking a few long, shuddering breaths. "Stay strong. This too shall pass, Midoriya."

But despite All Might's comforting words, the darkness still wormed its way inside him—a vile weight that writhed just beneath the surface.

He found out the next day, as he was on his way to class. The wound of rejection was still fresh on his mind, but he put on a brave face and stuffed the emotions deep down inside him. It took him a while to even notice that something was happening, but the halls were abuzz with gossip, and based on the bits and pieces he'd gathered from various conversations, it wasn't too hard to piece together what happened.

Someone else had been approved for ascension.

Izuku didn't know who it was until he walked in, and found a crowd of people surrounding…

...Monoma?

"Congratulations, Monoma!" Asui told him.

"Yeah, that's amazing!" Uraraka added, jumping up and down. "Hope we can all join you soon!"

Izuku stood frozen in the doorway, just staring at the group in bewilderment.

Monoma…? He thought. *Wait, really?*

Izuku wanted to be happy for him, but it was difficult to ignore how… *strange* it was.

He's not even in the top fifty percent of our class. How did he get approved if I—

Someone tapped his shoulder, and he quickly apologized and moved out of the doorway. He headed to his desk and set his bag down beside it. Then, forcing his uneasy thoughts to the back of his mind, Izuku made his way over to Monoma.

"You're the one who ascended?" He asked.

"Of course I am." Monoma replied, grinning.

It took every bit of control Izuku had not to cringe.

"Well, congratulations! I'm sure…" Izuku cleared his throat. "Well, I *know* you must have worked very hard for this."

He shrugged. "It was long overdue, really."

Izuku laughed awkwardly, looking away. "Yeah, I feel the same about, um. Iida, and Uraraka…" He trailed off. "Uh, anyway—again, congrats!" Izuku spun around and hurried back to his seat.

Be happy for him. Be happy for him. Izuku told himself, clenching his jaw. *There are a million reasons why your application might have been rejected while his wasn't. Just be happy for him, damn it! This shouldn't be difficult!*

But no matter what he did, he just couldn't quite rid himself of the foul taste on his tongue.

Later that day, Izuku found himself walking toward All Might's office without really thinking about it. He still had mixed feelings about his classmate's ascension. Perhaps in the back of his mind, he was hoping his mentor could provide some form of explanation, but mostly, he just needed to vent to someone who wouldn't judge him.

Upon arrival, he was relieved to see that the light was on inside. He knocked on the door, and waited.

And waited.

Izuku frowned, knocking once again. Still, nothing.

Maybe he went to the bathroom or something? Izuku thought, glancing down the hall.

But… no. He shook his head. All Might always turned the lights off in his office, even when he was only away for a short period of time.

Beginning to get a bit worried, Izuku knocked once more, louder this time.

Finally, All Might answered.

The door cracked open, a sliver of light leaking out into the hall. Then All Might poked his head out and looked both ways, before quickly ushering Izuku inside. As he looked around, he was baffled to find that the room was somehow even more messy than it had been the previous day.

“All Might… is everything okay?”

All Might shushed him as he closed the door. With his back still turned toward him, he took a couple deep breaths before turning around. Izuku’s brows pinched together as he took in his mentor’s appearance. He looked disheveled, the dark circles beneath his eyes somehow deeper than usual.

“Sorry, Midoriya.” He whispered.

“What’s going on?”

“Nothing.” All Might was quick to say, only to then tack on, “Nothing you need to worry about, at least.”

That just made Izuku even more concerned.

All Might sighed, drudging over to his desk and sitting down. “I meant to send you a note, but I got so busy I just couldn’t find the time.”

Izuku swallowed, leaning forward. “All Might… what’s this about?”

For a few seconds, he was silent, staring down at his desk, his expression conflicted.

“I… I really shouldn’t tell you.” He finally said. “Not here, at least. Apologies.”

The subtext of the situation was more than a little disconcerting, and Izuku’s curiosity only increased, but out of respect, he simply nodded, and stayed silent.

After a pause, All Might spoke again. “Is there a reason for your visit?”

“Ah.” Izuku said, rubbing the back of his neck. “It’s, um…”

Should I tell him? Izuku wondered, chewing his lip. *He seems so stressed out, already… Do I really want to add my feelings about Monoma’s ascension onto that?*

After a moment, he shook his head. “Sorry. It’s nothing, really.”

All Might took a deep breath.

“Well, for your own safety, I must ask that from here on out, you refrain from visiting unless it’s a scheduled meeting or an emergency.”

Izuku’s stomach dropped. “What?”

“Sorry. I really don’t mean to be harsh. I just don’t want you to get mixed up in…” He trailed off, then exhaled. “I really do mean it when I say this is for your own safety, Midoriya.”

Izuku wrung his wrists. “I… see.” He mumbled. “W-Well, in that case, I guess I’ll see you in a few days?”

All Might nodded, standing to open the door. He paused as he was turning it, and threw Izuku another look. “Please try to stay out of trouble.”

Izuku tensed. “Wait.” He said. “This isn’t… This isn’t about what happened with Shinsou, is it?”

All Might shook his head. “No, it isn’t. That much, at least, I can tell you.”

He nodded slowly, some of the tension melting away, though only a little.

All Might opened the door just enough to poke his head out.

“What are you doing?” Izuku asked.

“Looking both ways.” All Might replied. Then he stepped aside and ushered Izuku out of the small office.

The door shut behind him, resonating like a gunshot in the quiet hallway.

Izuku left earlier than usual the next time he set out for the surface, but when he arrived at the first church, Katsuki didn’t seem too interested in talking. They went about their respective duties in relative silence, and it wasn’t until the last person’s clothes hit the floor that Katsuki finally broached the subject.

They were still inside the church, and Katsuki was leaning against the altar, fidgeting with the white linen cloth laid draped over it.

“So, how is he?” He asked. “Still in the hospital, I’m guessing?”

Izuku was so surprised, it took a moment for him to respond. “Y-Yeah. He is.” He said. “As part of his punishment, they’re not using magic to accelerate his healing, so I think it’ll probably be another month, at least.”

“Damn,” Katsuki sighed. “Y’know, I really was shooting for six months. Guess I’m just not used to using restraint.”

Izuku scowled. “If anything, you should’ve used *more* restraint.”

Katsuki arched a brow. “Deku, sweetie, with all due respect—go fuck yourself. Frankly, considering the kinda shit he was saying, you oughta be on your knees thanking me for not fucking *killing* that asshole.”

He grimaced. “Shinsou was wrong to say those things.” He replied carefully, crossing his arms. “But that’s just… I mean, that’s what we’re *taught,* Kacchan. You *know* that.”

“Is that supposed to make me feel better?” He snorted. “Guy basically opens with, ‘Hi, I think you’re subhuman,’ and you want me to take his fuckin’ tragic backstory into account? Fuck all the way off with *that* shit. I’m not tolerating it. Had enough of that *before* I died.”

Izuku frowned. *What’s that supposed to mean?* He shook his head. *Doesn’t matter.*

“Well, fine, but that’s not going to make him stop thinking of you that way.”

Katsuki scoffed. “Do you think me being polite would’ve changed his mind?” He rolled his eyes. “Hate to break it to you, Deku, but that really ain’t how it works. And anyway, none of this shit would’ve even *happened* if you didn’t fucking avoid me for two weeks. What the fuck was that about, huh? I *still* don’t fucking know.”

“I was just—” Izuku faltered, looking down. “I mean… I don’t know.”

“Bullshit.”

Izuku winced. “It’s complicated, okay?”

“More complicated than me shoving my foot up your ass, or *less?”*

Izuku flushed, clenching his fists. “Look, if you really need to know, I was afraid, *okay?* There’s your answer. I was *scared.”*

“Of *what?”*

Izuku narrowed his eyes, scoffing. “Don’t act like you don’t remember, Kacchan. You *know.”*

“So you went out of your way to avoid me over a goddamn apple?” He spat, almost laughing. “That’s it? *Seriously?”*

“Of course that’s not *it!”*

“Then what the fuck is it?!”

“My feathers started falling out!” Izuku shouted, his body tense, fists clenched. “I woke up the next day and four feathers fell out, even though I know you never touched my wings.” He rattled on, venom on his tongue. “So there you go, Kacchan. Your plan is working, congratulations! I’m *terrified!* Is that what you wanted to hear?!”

For a long while, Katsuki just stared at him, his eyes wide, speechless in the aftermath of his outburst. Izuku stood there, his body tense, chest rising and falling rapidly with his heavy breathing. It was only after the first tear finally slipped down his cheek that Katsuki broke eye contact.

“Oh.” He said.

“I just…” Izuku’s voice broke, tears welling up. “I… What if this was all for *nothing?”*

Katsuki frowned. “The hell are you talking about?”

“I got *rejected,* Kacchan!” Izuku snapped. “Even after all these months with you, my application to ascend was *still* denied!”

The Demon stared at him for a moment, his expression slowly morphing into one of incredulity.

“Is that *really* all you care about?” Katsuki asked, with a mirthless laugh. “Fucking *seriously,* Deku? After all this time?”

“Of *course* not, but that’s the only thing that made this *okay,* Kacchan! Don’t you *understand* that?” He cried, forcefully wiping tears from his cheeks. “I’ve spent all these months with you, clinging to that one thing that made this whole thing acceptable, and now it’s just—just gone!” He gritted his teeth painfully. “What the hell am I supposed to do, now?! I have to wait a year before I can reapply, and—and at this rate, by then, I don’t even know if…” He choked on a sob, shaking his head. He couldn’t bring himself to say it out loud.

Katsuki was just a blurry form standing silently before him, and Izuku was too far gone to gauge his reactions.

“And I know I shouldn’t have bet so much on getting approved the first time. I just…” He sniffled. “I really thought this would work…” He wiped his nose on his sleeve.

“But despite all this time I’ve spent with you,” Izuku continued, “despite how *hard* I’ve been working, I *still* got rejected, and—and *freaking Monoma,* a person who *barely even shows up to class,* gets to ascend?” Izuku tugged at the roots of his hair. “It doesn’t make any *sense!* He’s—I—“ Izuku cut himself off with a frustrated scream that had Katsuki staring at him, his eyes wide, his mouth open.

“You just don’t get it!” He cried. “You have *no idea* what it’s like to be in my position. I work *so hard* and *everything* I do gets scrutinized. Everything! I’m doing everything I’m supposed to, but they still—still—“

Izuku crumpled to the floor, curled up against the wall, sobbing. He was exhausted, both physically and mentally. His emotions felt too big for his body.

A minute later, he felt a hand brush against his back, and he tensed. He hadn’t heard Katsuki approaching, but when he peaked up over his arms, he found him sitting on the floor beside him, his expression calm. Izuku relaxed slightly, choosing to let Katsuki’s hand stay there, rubbing gentle circles on his back.

Several minutes went by before Izuku managed to calm down enough to speak.

He wiped his nose on his sleeve. “I’m… I’m sorry.” He said softly. “I-I know that one day my work will be recognized. Right? I’ll… eventually, but…” He trailed off, and released a shuddering exhale. “Maybe I’m wrong. Maybe I’m just… not working hard enough.” Izuku

curled into himself further, ducking his head between his knees, and quietly whimpered, “Or maybe I’m just not good enough…”

After a long pause, Katsuki sighed.

“Deku, can I tell you a story?”

Izuku didn’t hear him at first. After a second, he raised his head slightly, confused, but nodding.

Katsuki scooted a bit closer. “So, there’s this preacher who lives in a tiny little mountain town, right? One night, a mysterious woman appears in his dreams. Nine months later, this screaming brat shows up on his doorstep.”

Izuku frowned. *Where’s he going with this?*

“He takes the kid in, raises him as his own.” Katsuki continued. “Teaches him all about God and shit, tells him what he’s gotta do to get into heaven, all that stuff. He lets him call him ‘dad.’ But…”

He hesitated, the hand on Izuku’s back going still for a moment.

“…But there’s something wrong with the kid.” He finally said. “He’s just not… normal. Both of ‘em can sense it, they just don’t know why. At that point, it’s just a feeling, but over time, shit starts to get weirder.

“The kid starts to feel it—I mean *really* feel it—around when he starts hanging around other kids. He just knows he’s not like them. He’s trying to keep it hidden, ‘cuz it’s scary, but it’s hard to hide a problem when you can’t even pin down the source.” Katsuki took a deep breath. “But it bothers him—actively, y’know? He has weird dreams. And sometimes he just gets this… *feeling,* like everyone’s hiding somethin’ from him…” He picked a piece of lint off his pants. “His dad’s church is always too cold. He prays every night, but no one ever answers.”

Izuku’s brow furrowed. “Kacchan…”

“And it just gets worse, ‘cuz by the time he’s seven, the townspeople have started to feel it, too.” He said. “The adults are polite enough to at least *try* to hide it, but... the other kids don’t wanna play with him anymore. They say his presence makes them feel weird. Y’know. They don’t like the way he looks at them. In the beginning, the kid lashes out, but that doesn’t work out too well—just seems to prove them right.” Katsuki winced, pausing for a moment. “So he just does what his dad always told him to do. Y’know, pray. He prays his fuckin’ heart out every day, begging for some unseen power to just… make things normal. Whatever *that* would mean.”

Katsuki sighed.

“It’s not long before the whole town just becomes pretty much openly afraid of him.” Katsuki snorted. “Wild, huh? Whole buncha so-called *adults,* fuckin’ terrified of some little kid just

‘cuz he gives ‘em weird vibes. Fuckin’ pathetic.” He spat. “But anyway, after a certain point, he just has to avoid going outside most of the time. Which is shitty, ‘cuz it means he can’t help his dad with errands, but…” Katsuki shrugged.

“He’s just so fucking *isolated.* He has no friends, except…” He paused, taking a deep breath. “There’s this stray cat that always comes to his window. A black cat. She...” He faltered, voice sounding tight. “She lets him pet her, and he feeds her sometimes, when he can manage it. He starts calling her Twin, ‘cuz, being a black cat, he figured she was just like him, y’know? People were afraid of both of ‘em for no reason.”

Katsuki fell silent for a moment, fidgeting with the hem of his pants.

“Anyway, by the time he’s, like…” He squinted. “Ehh, twelve, I guess… he’s got a pretty good idea of what might be wrong with him, but he’s still too scared to think too much about it. He’s just in denial, so he doubles down on his studies, memorizes scripture and prays, because his dad always told him that’s all he had to do. You know, *‘Just keep praying, God loves you. God loves all his children, this is simply a test of faith. You’ll get through it, and one day you’ll live in eternal bliss in God’s kingdom. Just have faith.’”* Katsuki laughed bitterly.

“Some nights, he’ll go out to fetch a pail of water, when no one’s around, and he’s thirteen years old when it happens. He goes out that night, minding his own business…” He hesitated. “But he hears something strange, and goes to investigate. Rounds a corner and catches a boy about his age hunched over in the alley, but as soon as the bastard realizes he’s been caught, he fuckin’ *bolts.* He thinks about chasing after him, but then… he sees…”

Katsuki grimaced. For several seconds, he did not speak, and all Izuku could do was sit there and stare at him. The look on his face was weary, a mixture of exhaustion and numb sadness, as though he were trying to resurrect a part of himself long after coming to terms with its death.

Eventually, he sighed.

“Twin’s alive, but she won’t be much longer if he can’t find help.” He mumbled. “So he panics, obviously. Rushes over, scoops her up in his arms, and fucking books it. Heads straight for the town clinic, ‘cuz, y’know, what the fuck *else* is he supposed to do?” Katsuki shrugged. “Anyway, he starts banging on the door, yelling for help. There’s light inside, but no one answers. And here’s the fucked up part—a few seconds later, the light goes out.”

“What?” Izuku whispered.

“Right?” Katsuki scoffed. “And the kid’s just… fucking *losing* it. He’s *never* felt this way before. And he’s screaming at them, *begging* for help, but no one fucking *listens* to him. And it’s too late, anyway. So he just… sits on the doorstep, crying. Still cradling her. Takes him a moment to actually realize that Twin just isn’t… *there* anymore. She’s gone, and he’s alone again.”

Katsuki clenched his jaw, pausing for a moment.

“Gets worse, though. ‘Cuz a few minutes later, he hears footsteps. Hears a woman gasp. He looks up and sees her face, but it’s cold. And she asks him, *‘what did you do to it?’”*

Izuku tensed. Anger flared up inside him, but all he could do was stare back at Katsuki, speechless.

“Yeah… So, by morning, the news has spread. *‘Oh, did ‘ya hear the preacher’s kid killed a cat? How fucked up is that?’”* He said, his tone mocking. “‘Course he tells his dad he didn’t do it, and his dad *says* he believes him, but honestly? Who the fuck *knows* what his dad thinks at this point. He sure doesn’t. The kid doesn’t leave the house after that. Not for a while, at least.

“But then, when he’s seventeen, his dad goes out of town to visit his aunt and asks him to take care of shit ’til he gets back. He’s nervous, but he agrees. Y’know, it’s been a few years. Figures maybe it’s time to try again. And he just wants to fuckin’ *help,* y’know? He wants to do good, wants to get into heaven. So he does everything his dad tells him to, as best he can with the town turned against him, of course.”

The hand on Izuku’s back began to move again, Katsuki’s fingers tracing patterns across his spine.

“It’s fine for a bit, but of course it doesn’t stay that way.” He continued. “One night, just when he’s startin’ to think things’ll be okay, he comes back and finds his dad’s church on fucking *fire.* He’s so shocked, he doesn’t even know how to react at first. But he eventually goes for help, tries to explain what’s going on. You can probably guess how *that* goes.” Katsuki said, snorting. “They basically chase him out of town, and… well, that’s it. He’s gone. Never sees his dad again.” He took a deep breath, and exhaled.

“Anyway, for a few years, he just wanders from place to place, doing whatever he can to survive. He still prays, still tries to be a good person, even though just about everyone he meets assumes the worst of him. He kinda knows what he is, but he’s still trying to overcome it. Every day he gets a little less hopeful.

“And then one day… he runs into him again. The piece of *shit* who killed her, and he fucking *loses it.* Ends up on top of him, fucking strangling the asshole. ‘Course, he’s making a lot of noise, so he gets caught before he can actually kill the fucker. Guy comes rushing over and swings an axe at him, misses once, backs him into a corner. He screams, *‘go back to Hell, devil!’* and you know what his last thought is before he dies?” Katsuki laughed mirthlessly. “‘*I’m already there.’”*

For a while, Katsuki was silent. He stared into space as he traced lines across Izuku’s back.

“When he opens his eyes next, he’s lying in a field, lookin’ up at a red sky. He learns the full truth about himself. Half-Demons are even more rare than Fallen Angels, ‘specially these days.

“It reminds him of a conversation he had with his dad once. He asked him if a Demon could ever earn their way into Heaven. His dad said no. The souls of Demons are far too filthy, you

see.” He arched a brow. “Even if they’re born that way, even if they never asked for it, that cannot change. There is no repentance strong enough to make their souls come clean.”

Izuku frowned, felt a pulling sensation in his chest, a tightness in his throat. “Kacchan…” He said softly, then swallowed. “That’s… I’m so sorry.”

Katsuki looked at him then, his sharp, red eyes glowing in the low light. “It was two hundred years ago.” He shrugged. “Point is, sometimes, hard work just ain’t enough. You don’t live in a meritocracy, Deku. That’s just a lie they tell you to keep you subservient.” Katsuki sighed. “The first step to breaking those chains is to accept that they exist.” He murmured, his voice a low rumble resonating in his bones.

Izuku held his breath as the Demon caught a rogue lock of hair between his fingertips and carefully brushed it behind his ear.

“The next step's easy.” Katsuki smirked. “*Get fuckin' angry.”*

Chapter End Notes

eyyyyyyyy, back at it again.
y'know as i was editing this chapter i realized there're a lot of unintentional similarities to certain events in Bluebird lmao. Like kacchan's low key unhinged messages in the memo are a bit like deku's voicemails, except Not Sad. And both Kacchans had a childhood pet who they lost under Unfortunate Circumstances, but somehow this is way less sad despite being like... objectively more fucked up lmao. Probably because this Kacchan's actually processed those emotions unlike the kacchan in bluebird. and also instead of the perpetrator being his parents, it's just, y'know, ur local future serial killer lol. But anyway
as always, pls consider leaving a comment if you enjoyed this so i can get some of that sweet, sweet dopamine in my fucked up zoomer brain lmao
so yeah, thanks for reading y'all. Next chapter we'll return to some of our regularly scheduled sexual tension before plunging right into the fucking deep end again.

Chapter 9: Armor

Chapter Summary

> Izuku blinked a few times. “Kacchan, are those…” He tilted his head, *“...Opera gloves?”*
>
> “No.” Katsuki scoffed. “I’ll have you know these are *fetish* gloves, thank you very much.”

Chapter Notes

> figured y'all deserved break from all the angst lmao
> welcome back to sexual tension hell

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The council must be acting against God’s wishes, he decided. *And that's not blasphemous, because God gave us free will. If those who God trusted could never betray him, Lucifer would have never Fallen.*

That was how Izuku was rationalizing things, anyway. Admittedly, even *that* felt a bit dangerous, but at that point, it was one of the few things he had left to cling to.

Every few days, Izuku redid the glue on his feathers, and prayed that God would root out the false confidants among his inner group. He convinced himself that one day, things would be better. That one day, stories like Katsuki’s would no longer exist.

Katsuki.

It’d been about two weeks since that day when Izuku broke down in front of him, and Katsuki told him about his past. Things had more or less returned to normal since then—better than normal, really.

Or worse, depending on how one looked at the situation.

Izuku could never quite escape the persistent feeling of unease as far as their relationship was concerned. It was a bit of a catch-22. Being comfortable around Katsuki made Izuku uncomfortable. But if nothing else, he enjoyed those easy-going moments as they happened. It was a welcome distraction from all the stress and uncertainty that seemed to saturate the rest of his existence.

Still, his willingness to trust Katsuki alarmed him at times. He no longer regularly checked to see whether he was telling the truth. He just took it for granted. And he was probably getting a little too comfortable venting to Katsuki. There were times when he had to stop himself from saying too much, lest he give away some sensitive information by mistake.

There was this cynical voice in the back of his mind that he could never quite tamp down. *As if there was anything useful you could tell him that he didn't already know about,* it said. *Kacchan probably knows more about Heaven than you do, anyway.*

But he digressed.

Perhaps the most alarming instance occurred during their last meeting, when, in order to satiate his curiosity, Izuku volunteered to let Katsuki hypnotize him again.

It started with a simple question.

"Kacchan… is there anything hypnotism *can't* do?"

They were walking down an empty side road at sunset, checking for any signs of stragglers.

Katsuki grunted an affirmative. "Couple things." He said, peering through an cracked window. "You can't manipulate emotions with it, 'least not directly. And you can't use it to force someone to tell the truth. Those are the big ones."

"Oh." Izuku said. "That second one's a bit surprising…" Having found no one, Katsuki returned to his side, and they continued walking. "I kind of assumed hypnotism would be mostly used for interrogation, but…" He trailed off.

"It still can be. There's a couple ways to get around it." Katsuki shrugged. "Like, Y'can't make someone tell the truth about something, but you can force them to talk continuously." He explained. "If you give 'em enough time, the truth'll probably come out eventually."

"Ah, I see." Izuku nodded. Katsuki peered around the corner, confirming it was clear before proceeding.

"'Course, if *you* ever got held up by a Lust Demon, I'd tell them not to bother." He said, smirking. "That fucking mumbling habit of yours has the same effect."

Izuku glared lightly, and rolled his eyes. He stopped as they came upon a small, abandoned bakery, where the door had been left open. Glass crunching beneath his shoes, Izuku stepped inside. "Hello?" He called out. No answer.

They continued on.

"So, there aren't any physical limits?" Izuku said. "I mean, what would happen if you just told a random person to tap-dance?"

"Well, yeah, obviously you're limited by what the target's capable of. It's mind control, not puppetry. If 'ya can't do it, 'ya can't do it."

“But is that all? As long as the person can do it, you can make them?”

“Well, technically.” Katsuki squinted. “It gets harder the more complex the task is.” He kicked a can off the sidewalk. “There’s also some shit that’s, like, *practically* impossible. Shit like telling someone to kill themself. Far as I know, the only Demon who’s ever actually pulled that off was Asmodeus.” He shrugged. “A lot of this shit just depends on how skilled the Demon doing the hypnosis is.” After a moment, he added, “And what kinda hypnotism it is, obviously.”

Katsuki forced open the door to an old middle school, looking around before gesturing for Izuku to follow.

“Ah, that’s right.” Izuku said. “You mentioned that there were different kinds.”

Katsuki grunted. “Active and passive.” He said. “There’re some other, kinda more niche hybrids, but those are the two major ones.”

“So, what’s the difference?”

“Essentially, during active hypnotism, you’re being *actively controlled.* That’s what I used on you a while back. It’s what you’d kinda expect hypnosis to be, y’know? Basically removes your free will.” He explained. “Under passive hypnotism, you’re not being directly controlled, but the way you perceive the world is. So it’s like a type of illusion. You’re making someone hallucinate.”

“Huh.” Izuku said, staring down at his shoes. Their footsteps echoed in the quiet hallway. “Is there any way to break out of it?”

Katsuki snorted. “Well, for one thing, you could just not get fuckin’ hypnotized to begin with.” He replied. “Just don’t make eye contact with hostile Demons, full stop. And for fuckssake, if you think you’re dealing with a Lust Demon, don’t let them *fucking* touch you.”

Izuku frowned, brow furrowing. “I thought they needed eye contact…?”

Katsuki shook his head. “Deku, eye contact is a pretty high bar to clear if you’re fighting an opponent who knows better.” He said. “Sure, if you’re a Wrath or Gluttony Demon, it’s pretty unlikely you’ve delved deep enough into Lust magic to do it, but learning hypnotism without eye contact is, like, one of the main objectives for Lust. S’like hellfire manifestation for Wrath, or light bending for Envy.”

Izuku suppressed the urge to ask for more information about that last bit. *One thing at a time.*

“Okay, but,” Izuku held his hands up. “Let’s say you’ve *already* been hypnotized. What could you do at *that* point?”

“Regret.”

“Kacchan.”

He rolled his eyes. “Again, depends on the type of hypnotism. With active, it’s kinda just, like, a willpower thing.” He gestured vaguely. “It’s tough to break outta it if you’re dealing with someone stronger, but that type of hypnosis is harder to maintain, anyway. Takes more focus.” He explained. “Under passive hypnosis, you can *always* break out of it, even if you’re a lot weaker than your opponent. At least in theory, anyway. You just have to figure out what’s wrong with the illusion.”

“What’s… wrong?”

Katsuki nodded. “You ever had a dream where you saw something so jarring you realized it was a dream?” He arched an eyebrow. “Passive hypnosis can be broken in a similar way. There’s no such thing as a perfect illusion. Find the thing that doesn’t belong, and you’ll break the spell.”

He backed up into a door that led the two of them into the cafeteria. There were chairs scattered around, but no humans in sight, at least as far as Izuku could tell.

“Huh…” Izuku rubbed his chin. “Can *you* do that?”

Katsuki blinked a few times. “On you, sure. But you’re a really easy target.”

“…Well, would you?”

At that, Katsuki actually laughed.

“You’re *askin’* me to hypnotize you?” He grinned. “Seriously, Deku?”

Izuku blushed, averting his eyes. “I mean… I just want to know what it’s like. I’m curious, is all…”

“I just think you should maybe think more critically about givin’ me the power to make you hallucinate literally anything I want.” Katsuki said, taking a few steps closer. “There’s a lotta nasty shit I could do with that power, Deku.”

Izuku frowned. “But… you *won’t,* right?”

Katsuki stared back at him for a moment. Then, he looked away. “Well, no.” After a moment, he shrugged and turned back toward him, red eyes glowing bright in the dimly lit room. “Alright.” He said. “Look into my eyes, dipshit.”

Izuku scowled, but nonetheless did as he was told. Within seconds, he felt a familiar click within his mind, only this time, instead of being followed by a sense of weight inside his head, his surroundings began to ripple, and he was no longer in the cafeteria.

Izuku’s vision cleared, and he realized he was standing in an apple orchard.

He spun around a few times, searching. “Kacchan?” He called out, but there was no response. After a moment, he began to walk around. Every direction looked the same.

“Could’ve been a bit more specific about what to look for…” Izuku grumbled, frowning as he did his best to study his surroundings. He was getting ready to shout into the sky when he noticed something unusual out of the corner of his eye—a glint of something… *gold?*

Izuku turned toward it, approaching a nearby tree. Like all the others, this one bore large, red apples. Except for one. On a low-hanging branch to his right, there hung a single golden apple. Izuku put his hand beneath it, and felt its weight in his palm. Unsure what else to do, he picked it.

And immediately, the trees around him started to dissolve, and he was back in the cafeteria again. He turned and looked at Katsuki, glaring slightly. “You could’ve given me a bit more instruction.”

“Whatever, nerd.” He scoffed. “You get the idea. It’s not always that easy to break out of, though. There’s always an out, but it can be a real bitch to find, sometimes. ‘Specially if you don’t know it’s an illusion.” Katsuki shrugged. “As always, the best way to deal with it is to avoid letting it happen to begin with.”

Katsuki cast one last glance around the room and then turned on his heel. “Anyway, I think this one’s empty.”

“Yeah.” Izuku nodded. “Let’s move on.”

“I am sorry to have to do this twice in a row,” the note read, *“but I’m afraid I’ll need to reschedule our regular meeting again. Things are rather hectic right now, and I’ll need at least a few more days to get things settled.*

“Would Thursday or Saturday next week work for you? I could perhaps do Sunday as well. Please write down your availability and slip this note back under my office door when you get the chance. Again, I apologize for pushing our meeting back again. I hope you are doing well.

“All Might.”

Izuku sighed, folding up the note and placing his head on his desk. It’d been two weeks since his last scheduled meeting with All Might, and his mentor’s sudden flakiness was worrisome to say the least. He knew All Might wouldn’t do something like this if he didn’t believe it to be necessary, but he couldn’t help but feel a slight bit of resentment over it.

Worse still, it was feeding into a conspiratorial part of his mind which, up until recently, Izuku hadn’t even known existed. In his longing for answers, Izuku’s brain started to draw connections where they weren’t.

Like Monoma’s ascension, for example. Wasn’t it *curious* how he got approved right around the same time All Might started acting so strangely? His impulses wanted him to believe that the two events were related, but his rational mind knew it was unlikely, at best. Monoma didn’t interact with All Might outside of class, like Izuku did, and he didn’t seem to the type to go searching for incriminating information. For every such scenario he could conjure up in

his head, there were a million more plausible scenarios in which Monoma could've been approved on the basis of skill. Academic performance wasn't everything, after all.

Izuku unfolded the note and wrote down the word *'Saturday,'* and then folded it up again just as class was ending. He veered off from the rest of the group and down the hallway, quickly slipping the note underneath All Might's door, and heading home soon after.

It was cloudy outside, and the sun had just dipped beneath the horizon, leaving the world outside a murky grey. Izuku took a seat in the frontmost pew, leaning forward, his chin in his hands. He stared straight ahead, looking at nothing in particular.

"What's up with you?" Katsuki asked, his mouth still full as he finished off the last of one of those disturbing fruits he liked—an embrite, if Izuku recalled correctly.

Izuku sighed. "I'm fine, really." He said. "I just have a lot on my mind, I guess."

He listened to the quiet sound of Katsuki sucking the juice off his fingertips. Katsuki went to sit down beside him, the wood creaking, but Izuku kept his gaze locked in front of him.

"Okay…?" Katsuki said, throwing his arm over the back of the bench. "Kinda seems like something's wrong."

Izuku finally managed to tear his eyes from the void before him. He sat back against the uncomfortable wooden backing and and exhaled. "I'm just stressed out. It's complicated." He said, pausing for a moment. "My mentor postponed our meeting again. It's the second time he's done it."

"Oh. That sucks. He didn't tell you why?"

Izuku shook his head. "He's been acting kind of strange lately, but that's…" He bit his lip. "That's probably not worth delving into. There's too much I don't know. Speculating about it is useless." It was the same line Izuku had been telling himself for the past few weeks, whenever his mind got a bit too close to the deep end. Saying it aloud, the statement sounded canned, even to him.

Katsuki drummed his fingertips on the back of the pew.

"Huh." He said. "You're doing the whole training thing under the table, right?"

Izuku shrugged. "Guess that's one way to put it."

"How's that going?"

"I mean, it *was* going well." Izuku replied. "But I haven't been able to train for two weeks. I'm starting to worry I might forget what I've learned…"

Katsuki frowned. "There's no way for you to train on your own?"

Izuku shook his head. “My dorm room’s too small for me to do much more than stretching. And it’s risky, anyway. Thin walls.”

“Damn.” He muttered. A moment went by, and Katsuki reached up, stretching his arms above his head, and then sighed. “Well, if you want, I could help ‘ya out.”

Izuku glanced at him, blinked once, and did a double take. “Wait, *what?”*

“You heard me.” Katsuki grunted. “I dunno, why not? Like, m’not an Angel, but I’ve fought a fuck ton of ‘em. Could probably give you some useful tips, at least.” He stood up, walking over to the altar. “Nothing about magic, obviously. More just fighting in general.”

Izuku stared at his back for a while. He wanted to say yes, but then that voice in his head piped up.

You’re just going to accept this offer uncritically? Seriously? It said.

Izuku swallowed.

“Okay, but…” He began. “How do I know you won’t give me bad advice on purpose to sabotage my progress?”

Katsuki looked over his shoulder and scoffed. “That’s the dumbest shit I’ve ever heard.”

“I mean, I think it’s a reasonable concern!” Izuku said, though even he wasn’t too sure whether he believed it or not.

When Katsuki finally turned around, he was holding a candle in one hand, deforming the wax like dough beneath his heated touch.

“Deku.” He looked at him under his lashes, and spoke with a patronizing lilt. “I wish there was a nicer way to put this, but frankly, I do not see your *‘progress,’”* he used air quotes, “as a threat in any meaningful sense.” He started rolling the warm candle wax between his palms, gradually molding it into a ball. “It doesn’t even matter who you’re training under. Could be God himself, for all I care. You’re still not going to learn fast enough to become a problem for me, or probably *any* Demon, for that matter.”

Katsuki stopped molding the wax, setting his sights on the large, stained glass window about twenty feet behind the altar. In a flash, he chucked the deformed candle at it, striking the window right at the center, where it flattened like a pancake upon impact, and stuck.

“Damn it.” He muttered. “Should’ve waited for it to cool down, I guess…”

Katsuki reached for another candle, and Izuku cleared his throat.

“If I concede your point, will you stop doing…” He squinted, eyes flitting between the Demon’s face and the malformed candle in his hand. “Y’know, *that?”*

Katsuki snorted, “I could be *persuaded* to stop doing it where you can see. No promises, though.” He set the candle back down on the altar, and brushed flakes of dried wax off his

palms.

Izuku rolled his eyes, then sighed. “Well… I mean, how would this work, then? Where would we start?”

Katsuki hummed, looking up in thought. After a moment, he roughly picked up the altar and hauled it off to the side, causing several items to fall over in the process. The sight made Izuku frown, but he held his tongue.

At least he didn’t kick it over, I guess. He thought. *This is probably his version of courteousness.*

After a second, Katsuki returned to the now-cleared area, and stood in the center, where the altar used to be. Then he looked at Izuku and said, “Hit me with your best shot.”

Izuku’s mouth fell open. “Excuse me?”

“You fuckin’ heard me.” He said. “Just fuckin’ come at me with your best move—kick, punch, whatever—and we’ll go from there.”

Izuku continued to gape at him for a moment. “But *why?”*

Katsuki shrugged. “I just wanna get an idea of where your skills are at,” He said. “It’ll help me figure out what you’re good at, and what you’re not.”

Izuku frowned. “I still haven’t agreed to train with you.”

“This isn’t training, Deku; it’s a consultation.” He replied, monotone. “Look, just fuckin’ do it. You’ve got nothin’ to lose.”

“Um…” Izuku gulped. “Well, okay, then… I guess.”

“And don’t you dare go easy on me, Deku.” Katsuki snapped. “I want you to fuckin’ hit me with all you’ve got.”

“R-Right.” Izuku said, nodding. He took a few steps closer and paused, taking a some deep breaths. He closed his eyes, and allowed the power to run through his veins as he adjusted his stance.

Then, he charged.

Izuku came at him straight on, landing a clean punch right at the center of his chest. Katsuki slid back across the wooden floor with the slightest of grunts, and came to a stop a couple feet from where he started.

He raised an eyebrow. “Not bad.”

“Kacchan, you barely even *reacted.”*

“Deku,” He rolled his eyes, “I’ve been training for a hell of a lot longer than you have. All things considered, that’s pretty impressive.” He said. “So shut the fuck up and quit whining.”

“Um.” Izuku blushed lightly. “Th-Thanks, I guess?”

“Mm.” Katsuki slid his hands into his pockets, walking toward him at a leisurely pace. “Anyway, your form seems fine. No major complaints there. But obviously, in an actual fight, you probably wouldn’t have the chance to throw a punch like that.”

“Well, sure.” Izuku blinked. “That’s what you told me to do, though.”

“I know what I fuckin’ said,” Katsuki scoffed. “I had to make sure you wouldn’t do somethin’ fuckin’ stupid, like throw a punch with you thumb inside your fist.”

Izuku crossed his arms. “Well, okay. But now what?”

Katsuki was quiet for a moment, and then sighed. “Here, how ‘bout this.” He said. “You just fuckin’ attack me, and—“ He shrugged, “—I dunno. We’ll see how it goes, I guess.”

Izuku’s eyes widened. “Attack… you…?”

“Yup. And do it like you fuckin’ mean it, too.” He scowled. “M’not gonna fight back. I’ll just block and dodge.”

“Um. Well…” He tried to think of a reason not to do it, but nothing came to mind. Izuku swallowed. “Alright, I guess…?”

Katsuki nodded. “Whenever you’re ready.”

Izuku took a deep breath, and lunged. Electricity dancing across his skin, he aimed his first punch at Katsuki’s jaw, and the Demon blocked it with his forearm. At the same time, Izuku’s other fist swung toward his ribs, and with a swift bump to his wrist, Katsuki knocked the hit off course. Clenching his jaw, Izuku went for his face again, his fist meeting air as Katsuki side-stepped it. Izuku ducked down low and grabbed his ankle before he could set it down, but Katsuki twisted out of his grip, sending Izuku off balance. He winced as his knees hit the hardwood floor first, his palms soon after.

With a frustrated sigh, Izuku stood up again, looking up at Katsuki with a mildly irritated expression.

Katsuki hummed, stuffing his hands back into his pockets. “Alright, so right off the bat, you’re kind of shit at maintaining a steady center of gravity.” He told him. “You know how to move in a controlled situation, but your form gets fucked up once you have to respond to a moving target.” He cocked his head. “I’m guessing you’ve been training with a punching bag most of the time?”

“…Mostly,” he said. “My mentor has been focusing mainly on the power aspect…”

“Figured.” Katsuki said. “Magic is fine, but it won’t do you much good if you can’t use it effectively in an actual fight. You need to get to a point where those movements feel natural.”

Izuku nodded, brow furrowing.

“That said, y’got pretty fast reflexes, and your instincts are decent.” Katsuki continued. “I like that you tried to grab my foot and knock me off balance. ‘Course, problem there was you were already off balance, yourself.”

“Right,” Izuku said. “Yeah, that makes sense.”

“Anyway, I’d say your mentor gave you a pretty good foundation.” He shrugged. “You mainly just need more practice applying the shit you already know.”

Izuku bit his lip, quietly cataloging the critique. “I see…”

A moment of silence.

“I could help you with that part, if you want.” Katsuki said. “It’s somethin’ to do, I guess.”He walked over to the altar and picked up a long candle. He spun it around in his hand, and began tossing it in the air, each time catching it with one hand.

“Right…” Izuku said, eyes instinctively following the candle. “I just, um…”

Kacchan gives pretty good advice, he noted. *But…*

Katsuki caught the candle, and looked at him. “What?”

Izuku laughed nervously. “It just seems a little strange, I guess.” He said. “I mean, my mentor started training me specifically because I was going to be spending so much time around *you.* He didn’t want me to feel totally defenseless if something happened.” He rubbed the back of his neck. “I’m… not quite sure how I should feel about you being the one to teach me how to stay safe from… well, *you.”*

Katsuki stared at him for a long time, one eyebrow raised. After a moment, he closed his eyes and exhaled. “Deku, baby.” He said, opening his eyes. “Put your shield up.”

“S-Sorry?”

“Now.”

And then he was gone. Izuku only barely managed to put his barrier up before he felt a warm body pressing against his back. Katsuki’s arms ensnared him, one locking Izuku’s arms against his sides while the other held the candle to his neck, as though it were a knife.

Izuku gulped. He both heard and felt Katsuki taking a deep breath behind him. And then he leaned in, hot breath wafting against his neck.

“Don’t let a couple months’ training go to your head, Deku.” Katsuki whispered. “The reason I haven’t killed you is because I don’t *want* to. Frankly, as things stand, me being around probably makes you *more* safe, not less. You’d be surprised how much shit out there could kill you.”

Izuku squirmed out of his hold with a scoff. “I’m not some damsel in distress, Kacchan. I don’t *want* other people to have to protect me.”

“So train with me, then.” Katsuki shot back. “I’ll teach you how to fight for real. Can’t promise you’ll be able to beat *me* anytime soon, but at least you’ll know what the fuck you’re doing.”

Izuku sighed, chewing his lip.

A Demon teaching an Angel to fight, huh? It was such a bizarre concept to him. The same could be said about their existing arrangement, though, of course, that was a bit different, since it was set up to be mutually—

Izuku tensed as it suddenly occurred to him. The only reason Katsuki was working with him in the first place was so he could try to make him Fall.

So the question you need to be asking is…

Izuku narrowed his eyes.

…What does he stand to gain from this?

“Kacchan,” He slowly said. “What *exactly* would you be getting out of this deal?”

Katsuki stared at him for a moment, his face twisted up in confusion. “Not everything’s a fucking transaction, Deku.” Izuku narrowed his eyes even further. “Maybe I just think it’d be fun. You ever consider that?”

Izuku continued staring at him, and Katsuki groaned.

“Oh, for—“ He glared. “Look, if you *really* want an explanation that plays into this weird-ass marketplace mentality, *fine.”* He threw his hands up. “I fucking *guess* you could argue that, because I am betting on you Falling, the act of training you now is simply an investment in your future utility.” Katsuki widened his eyes, and gave a tight smile. “I am offering my services now so that your skills will be stronger, so that your labour will be *worth* more, so that your existence will *matter* more.”

His arms fell limp, hands smacking against his legs as they dropped. “There. Was that *soulless* enough for you? D’you need me to put on a top hat and monocle? Maybe crush your windpipe under my boot? Fucking *Christ.”*

“I get it, I get it.” Izuku sighed, exasperated. He rubbed the back of his neck, looking off to the side. “Look, I’ll… I’ll ask my mentor about it and see what he thinks, okay?”

After a moment, Katsuki shrugged. “Whatever.”

“All Might?” Izuku said, staring at his mentors face, at the faraway look in his eyes. He waved his hand in front of his face. *“All Might?”*

All Might jumped. “Yes! Sorry, um. What were you saying…?”

Izuku frowned. “I was telling you about Kacchan’s offer.” He said. “You know. His offer to help me learn to fight.” He tilted his head. “I… wanted your opinion on it?”

“Oh! Right, right. Sorry.” All Might looked around nervously. “I… Yes. Yes, I think that should be alright. He’s proven himself to be trustworthy enough.”

Izuku nodded slowly. “Are you alright?”

He blinked a few times. “Yes, of course, why wouldn’t I be?”

Izuku gave him a *look.* All Might turned his head away sheepishly.

“Sorry. It’s nothing you need to be concerned about.”

Izuku sighed. “I’m *already* concerned, though, All Might.” He said. “You… you haven’t been acting like yourself recently, and… and all the cancellations…”

All Might was quiet, staring down at the floor.

Izuku’s throat felt tight. “Please don’t tell me not to be concerned. Everything about these past few weeks has been nothing *but* concerning.” His voice broke a bit. “I’m… worried about you.”

For several seconds, it was silent.

Then, All Might laughed softly. “Ah. I’ve really messed up, haven’t I? Making my own student worry about me.”

Izuku waited, his vision growing more and more blurry.

All Might sighed. “I will tell you everything, Midoriya.” He murmured. “Just… not right now.”

Izuku’s shoulders slumped.

“Please, trust me. I know this is hard on you. It’s hard on me, too. But I need you to trust me.”

“Isn’t there *anything* you can tell me?” Izuku asked. “Anything. Anything at all.”

All Might fell silent for a moment that seemed to stretch on for an eternity. But eventually, he took a deep breath, and whispered:

“Someone has gone missing.”

Izuku paled. He opened his mouth to respond, but—

“—No.” All Might was quick to say. “No, it is not someone you know. I cannot tell you anything more than that.” He leaned back in his chair, and for long time, the two of them just

sat there, stewing in the silence.

'Gone missing' could mean a lot of things. Izuku yearned to ask for something more precise, but he didn't. He couldn't. The words hung in the air like a noose around someone's neck.

Izuku cleared his throat.

"So, then, um…" He took a moment to breathe, get his emotions under control. "So… Kacchan. You really think it's a good idea? I mean, *really?"*

All Might smiled. "I do. Katsuki…" He trailed off for a moment, then took a deep breath. "Katsuki is a good man, I believe. In his heart."

Izuku nearly choked on his own saliva. *"All Might?!"*

"Yes?"

"You—You just," He stammered. "I-I mean—"

All Might chuckled, but there was something melancholic about it, his eyes downcast. "Midoriya, I'm old. I'm tired." He said. "There comes a time when one must say the quiet part out loud."

Izuku remained frozen in place, his mouth hanging open.

"Katsuki knows your full name," All Might noted. "He could have forced you to Fall a long time ago, but chose not to. I think that says more than enough about his character." After a long pause, All Might sighed. "I'm not defecting, of course. I still think you should be careful. The road to Hell is paved with good intentions, as they say. Just be sure to wear protective gear if you're planning to work on anything more hands-on."

Izuku forced his jaw shut, and swallowed, nodding stiffly. "G-Got it."

All Might stood up slowly, joints popping as he stretched. "Anyway. I believe next Friday should work fine for me." He said. "I'm compiling some notes and things for you that I hope you'll find useful. I should be able to finish by then."

"Oh," He blinked, mind still reeling. "R-Really? Um, what are they about?"

"A number of things." All Might shrugged. "I can't tell you much right now, but I'm looking forward to showing you."

Izuku forced a smile, and thanked him, despite the ominous feeling in his gut.

My mentor said it's okay for me to train with you.

cool

I'll have my mentor call your mentor and we'll schedule a playdate

Kacchan…

oh!

one thing though

he said to make sure we use protection

Suddenly, tiny droplets of some blood-red substance began appearing all over the page.

what's happening?

Kacchan? uhhh

there's red stuff all over the page.

…

ew, it's all sticky??

Kacchan, what IS this???

I am drinking a smoothie

I spat it out all over the page

didn't expect that to actually go through, though

Huh.

Wonder what else this thing could transfer…

why did you spit your smoothie onto the memo??

is it even safe for me to touch this???

gross

not important

but on a related note, are you allergic to latex?

?

no, of course not

I don't think that's even a thing for angels…

why?

Several minutes went by.

Kacchan?

At the street corner, Katsuki ascended the steps and forced open a boarded up door. Izuku waited a moment for the dust to settle before following him inside, and it was only then that he realized where they were. It was an old, vacant gym. Most of the equipment had been covered with sheets haphazardly, and whatever wasn't was coated in a layer of dust.

Izuku trailed behind Katsuki as he strode down the hallway, peering into each of the rooms until he seemed to find what he was looking for.

"What are we doing here?" Izuku asked, right as Katsuki was opening the door.

"We're gonna fight." He replied, entering what Izuku now recognized as a training room of some kind, the floor cushioned with thin, squishy material that extended from wall to wall. Katsuki set his bag down in the corner, and started fumbling with it. Izuku was still standing in the doorway, his body tense.

"…Excuse me?"

"You heard me, nerd." He said. "I said I'd help train you. What the hell did y'think that meant?" He pulled something out of his bag that Izuku couldn't see.

"But—but *how?"*

“With these.” Katsuki said, standing up and turning toward him, showing Izuku what he was holding. It was a pair of long gloves, made from some shiny, black material, like vinyl or latex. Katsuki slid one of the gloves on, the top of the garment ending around his upper arm. He pulled on the material and snapped it against his skin, then looked at Izuku. “Y’know. *Protection.”* He smirked, beginning to slide the other glove on.

Izuku blinked a few times. “Kacchan, are those…” He tilted his head, *“...Opera gloves?”*

“No.” Katsuki scoffed. “I’ll have you know these are *fetish* gloves, thank you very much.” Izuku’s eyes widened slightly, heat creeping up his neck. Once both gloves were on, Katsuki smoothed out the latex, and tested the movement of his arms in them. ”Honestly, I’m mad at myself for not thinkin’ of this shit earlier,” he said, licking his lips.

When Izuku looked closer, he realized that there were metallic caps on each of the fingers, solid and slightly pointed.

Probably so that the gloves won’t get ruined if he starts to shift on accident, Izuku’s mind supplied.

He gulped.

“What…” Izuku wrung his wrists. “What *exactly* are you planning…?”

Katsuki shrugged, walking toward him at a leisurely pace. “Nothing much, really. We’re just gonna spar. And this way you don’t have to worry about accidental contact so much.” He cracked his neck. “M’not gonna use magic, ‘least not today. This is more about teaching you how to move in an actual fight.”

Izuku chewed his lip, looking Katsuki up and down. “I… okay.” Without taking his eyes off him, he set his own bag down and shed his over-cloak, leaving him in just his tunic and pants. He hesitantly stepped onto the mat.

Katsuki arched an eyebrow. “You nervous?”

“…A bit.”

“Y’know, m’not gonna hurt ‘ya, Deku.” He said, then smirked, his eyes darkening. “Unless you want me to.”

Izuku frowned. He’d heard him say things like that before, and he still wasn’t really sure what he meant, but the look on his face gave enough information for him to know that asking for clarification probably wasn’t a good idea. Shaking his head, Izuku sighed. “Where do we start?”

“Wherever.” He said. “Just get ready, and I’ll start whenever you do.”

Katsuki shifted into a fighting stance, and Izuku did the same. He locked eyes with Katsuki, who nodded, and after a deep breath, Izuku launched toward him.

It was over almost as soon as it started.

With his right hand, Izuku threw a punch, and with *his* right hand, Katsuki grabbed his wrist. Tightening his grip, Katsuki spun around, briefly showing Izuku his back before immediately launching him over his shoulder. Izuku choked on spit as his body hit the mat with a heavy smack. He'd landed on his side, coughing as he squirmed, his wrist still locked in Katsuki's grip. He tapped the mat, and Katsuki released him.

"You said you weren't going to hurt me!"

"Oh, did that hurt?" He asked, feigning surprise, but Izuku could see the amusement in his eyes. *"Whoops."*

He mumbled under his breath as Katsuki fell to a squat beside him.

"You good?" He asked, offering a hand. Izuku glared, and stood up on his own, brushing off his clothes.

"You mean apart from the whole right side of my body being bruised?" He scoffed. *"Sure."*

Katsuki rolled his eyes, rising to his full height again. "Deku, we're *sparring*. Hate to break it to 'ya, but if you wanna get better at this, you're gonna have to get used to getting a little beat up. If you're not bruised, you're not trying hard enough."

Izuku scoffed, but he knew the Demon was right, even if he had a rather annoying way of proving his point. After a moment of silence, Izuku grumbled, "Show me how you did what you just did."

Katsuki nodded, beckoning him closer. "Kay. So, let's say I'm throwing a punch with my right arm." He imitated the move in slow motion. "You're gonna grab my wrist with your right hand, and hold it tight." Izuku did as he said, fingers squeaking slightly against the black latex.

"Now what?"

"Hold tight and turn around, back to me." Izuku started turning to his left. "Not to your left, to your right. When your opponent punches with his right, everything's gonna be to the right, 'least for this."

Izuku nodded, returning to his starting position to try again. He spun to his right, his shoulders making contact with Katsuki's chest. He could feel the heat radiating off his body. He swallowed, and his throat felt dry.

"From here, you wanna hold your arm up, and then *sharply* pull down." He continued. "At the same time, you're bending forward to give yourself some extra force." Izuku nodded, adjusting his grip. "Don't do it from here. You need the turn to give yourself momentum."

He bit his lip. "Right."

"Wanna try it?"

"…Sure." Izuku released his wrist and turned around to face him again.

“Alright.” Katsuki took a few paces back. “Ready?”

“Uhh—you’re not going to do this at full speed, are you?”

Katsuki shook his head. “No, but m’not doin’ it in slow motion, either. Moves like this don’t really work if you do ‘em *too* slow.”

Izuku bit his lip. “Well, okay then…” He took a deep breath. “Ready.”

Katsuki came at him with a right hand punch. Izuku’s fingers couldn’t quite wrap all the way around his wrist, so it was awkward, but he did his best to compensate with a tight grip as he spun around, his back bumping against Katsuki’s chest as he bent over and thrust his arm down with him. Katsuki followed the movement, flipping over Izuku’s shoulder and smacking against the mat.

He didn’t seem to hit the floor as hard as Izuku did, despite weighing more. Izuku wondered if there was some sort of technique behind it.

“Not bad.” He said, wrist still locked in Izuku’s hand.

“Tha—“ Suddenly, Katsuki thrust his hips up and around, catching Izuku’s legs between his own like a pair of scissors. Izuku toppled to the floor, ending up face down, his right arm pinned behind his back while Katsuki straddled his thighs. Izuku hissed as he twisted his arm uncomfortably. Katsuki then leaned forward, left hand wrapping lightly around his neck, tilting his head up, and his breath was hot against his ear.

Katsuki rasped, “And that’s a particularly fun way to get outta it,” And Izuku could practically *hear* the smirk on his face.

Katsuki lingered for a moment before he released him, and it wasn’t until that heavy weight on his body was gone that Izuku realized he’d completely forgotten to tap out. After a moment, Izuku stood up, dusted himself off, and prepared to go again.

The next hour was largely more of the same, though Katsuki did start to go easier on him, once he seemed to get over the sadistic joy of hitting Izuku with outlandish finishing moves that left him pinned before he could even process what had happened.

Izuku still lost every match, but he found it difficult to be too mad about it. He was learning, after all—every time Katsuki pulled an interesting move, every time he evaded an attack with some novel footwork or blocked a hit in an unconventional way, he was always more than happy to slow down and show him just how it worked, and coach Izuku through his fumbling execution. He still laughed when Izuku tripped over his own feet, but not as much as Izuku expected him to.

It was… *fun.*

Izuku grinned as he wiped sweat off his forehead. He ducked under a kick aimed at his head and managed to land a punch on Katsuki’s ribs, and even though the end result was him lying on the floor face down, Katsuki twisting one arm painfully as he frantically tapped the mat

with the other, he still enjoyed it, somehow. The way Katsuki moved so smoothly made the whole thing feel like a strange, elaborate dance.

Izuku wasn't really sure what he was feeling until the very end.

It happened right as Katsuki was preparing to flip him over his shoulder again, only this time, Izuku knew what was coming.

As Katsuki turned around, Izuku quickly jumped up, locking his free arm around Katsuki's neck, causing him to release his other wrist. He went to tighten the chokehold, but before he could lock it in, Katsuki spun back around, grabbing his legs in either hand as they both toppled to the floor. Izuku pushed at his chest, but Katsuki just grabbed his wrists, pinning them on either side of his head. With his hands immobilized, Izuku tried to use his legs to flip them, but Katsuki dropped his body into him harder, keeping Izuku's hips trapped against the mat, preventing him from gaining any momentum.

They stayed there for a moment, panting, and then Izuku groaned, hitting his head lightly against the mat.

"I really thought that would work..."

Katsuki laughed. "It might've, but you gotta be faster than that, nerd."

A couple seconds went by. Katsuki was still holding his wrists, preventing him from tapping out. Izuku shifted against the mat. "Um…"

"Yeah?"

"Are you gonna, you know… let me up?"

"Hmm, I dunno." He smirked, leaning in closer, their faces just inches apart. "I think I kinda like you like this."

Izuku frowned, momentarily confused.

And then he looked down.

"Oh… *Oh."* His eyes widened, cheeks burning as he finally registered the position they were in. Katsuki's hips pressed against him, Izuku's ankles slung over his back. Izuku sputtered, his voice coming out an octave higher than normal. "Um. R-Right, uh, th-this is a little…"

"What?" Katsuki leaned in just a little bit closer, his hands tightening around his wrists. Up close, Katsuki smelled a little like smoke, a little bit sweet. It filled Izuku's nose until he could taste it.

Izuku opened his mouth, but no sound would come out. Katsuki hummed, and he felt the vibrations resonating through his body.

"See, the nice thing about this is it gives me a whole lotta control." He murmured, eyes darkening. He shifted Izuku's wrists into one hand above his head, and Izuku shivered as he

trailed the cool, metal tips of the gloves up his neck. Katsuki traced his thumb across Izuku's bottom lip, the rounded point pressing lightly against it.

There was a voice somewhere in Izuku's mind, screaming at him to struggle. But as he stared into Katsuki's eyes, he felt himself being transported further and further away from it, until it was just an unintelligible murmur in the distance.

Kacchan is… very attractive, he realized. And it was far from the first time he'd noticed this fact, but in that moment, it felt… *different,* somehow.

Strong. Clever. Handsome.

Close.

Katsuki was at the center of everything, his body eclipsing the world around him.

"I mean, just think about it." His voice was hushed, deep. He could feel it in his bones. "From here, I could do all *sorts* of things to you, Deku."

Izuku swallowed. He felt hot, and the immovable weight of Katsuki's body against his own only made the feeling more pronounced.

He wasn't sure what exactly compelled him to say it. It was like there was something emerging from a place very deep inside him, rising to the surface. He couldn't say for certain what it was, but somehow, he knew it had always been there.

"…Like what?" Izuku whispered.

Katsuki's eyes widened slightly, his brows raising. As the initial surprise melted away, that signature smirk of his returned.

He licked his lips, his eyes half-lidded, and hummed. Then, to his confusion, Katsuki slid his hand over Izuku's mouth, sealing it shut. Izuku watched hazily as the Demon's face drew closer, *closer,* until finally, his lips met the back of the glove, right where Izuku's mouth would have been.

Izuku's eyes fluttered shut as Katsuki lingered, lips moving sensuously against the black latex, as though there were nothing in between. As though he was actually, truly kissing him. Izuku arched up off the mat slightly, a small, involuntary sound breaking free of his throat, his own lips mindlessly moving against his palm.

It was the sound that did it, he thought. The subtle, slightly wet sound of Katsuki's lips breaking away from the surface of the latex. Something clicked into place then, sent a wave of heat through his system that left everything scorched.

Oh.

Katsuki pulled back, placing some small amount of space between their bodies. He removed his hand from his mouth, and as he turned it over, laughed softly at what he saw. Izuku frowned, but then Katsuki turned his palm toward him, allowing him to see the distinct, wet mark Izuku had left there, and blood rushed to his cheeks. Then, all while maintaining eye contact, Katsuki brought the hand to his lips… *and slowly dragged his tongue across his palm.*

Oh.

A soft, aborted sound escaped Izuku's mouth. Holding his gaze, Katsuki smirked, in that slow, cocky, *devious* way of his. Like he wanted to eat him alive. Terrifying. *Gorgeous.*

Oh.

He sat back on his heels, glowing eyes roaming over his body at a leisurely pace. Taking stock of the wreckage, Katsuki licked his lips.

Oh.

"I'd say that's a good place to start."

Chapter End Notes

ah yes, the "oh no he's hot" moment, baby's first gay panic lmao
well, consciously at least.
anyway, i suppose we've reached the "i feel close to kacchan emotionally and i don't know how to deal with that i kind of like it and i trust him but i need to be careful and i keep forgetting to be careful and oh god oh god oh no he makes me feel tHINGS" portion of the story. fuckin sweet
lol as always, thanks for reading! If you liked this, pls consider leaving a comment because reading comments reminds me that i do, in fact, exist

next chapter shit's gonna hit the fan with at least one major thing in the story, so i hope u will enjoy that moment when it comes. there are a select few scenes that have been very

specifically planned out since before i even started writing this, and that's one of 'em lol.
until next time my dudes

Chapter 10: Just World

Chapter Summary

“What just God would allow this to happen?”

Chapter Notes

this chapter's a tad longer than usual at 9.2k words, but given what happens in it, i suppose it makes sense lol

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izuku didn’t think too much about the event after it occurred.

On the rare occasions when the memory crossed his mind, he was generally quick to shut it down, though over time, the aggregate of all those tiny thoughts still synthesized into something more. Because Izuku wasn’t ignorant. Although he’d never experienced feelings like he had that night with Katsuki, he knew how to put two and two together.

Still, he felt conflicted about it. There was a part of him that wanted to make excuses, the most common of which being the general idea that, because he had nothing to compare it to, it was impossible for him to know what he had felt back then with certainty. But it was a shallow rationalization—a chair he could wedge against the door if ever the thought tried to break into his consciousness. It only worked because his concerns were unprocessed, underdeveloped. It worked because they were *weak,* and so that was how they needed to remain.

So he didn’t think about it. Thinking about it gave it strength. Thinking about it made it *real.* Thinking about it fed into the filth that already tainted his soul. He knew this to be true; it was even codified in conventional medical knowledge. When Angels sustained critical amounts of corruption damage, it was not uncommon for them to be sedated for prolonged periods of time, in order to give their souls a chance to recover without the risk of blasphemous thoughts tipping the scales.

It was impossible for Izuku to know just where he fell on the continuum of corruption, but as long as he kept consistent with the feather glue, as long as he kept his mind far away from it, the consequences would not exist prior to the point of no return.

Izuku wasn’t sure whether he found that thought comforting or terrifying.

It was just another thing he didn't want to think about.

All Might's study was quiet, apart from the subtle squeaking of the ceiling fan spinning overhead. Izuku sat at the desk, twiddling his thumbs as he waited on his mentor. After a minute, he returned with a tray that held two cups of tea, and a thick, leather-bound book resting in between them. He set the tray down in front of Izuku.

"What's that?" Izuku pointed at the book.

"Notes on magic and battle strategy, for the most part." All Might said, shrugging. "It's what I wanted to give you. I've been compiling it for some time."

"Oh," He perked up. "Really? Thank you!"

He smiled and nodded, but Izuku did not miss the tension in his shoulders. All Might pulled up a chair and sat down, resting his elbows on the edge of the desk.

"This isn't a normal journal, however. There's a very specific way it needs to be read." He gestured toward it. "Open it up. Take a look at the inside of the cover."

Izuku did as he said, feeling smooth leather between his fingertips as he flipped it open. There, he found what looked to be a long list of dates.

"I'm… confused."

"That's the schedule." All Might said. "The days when you'll be able to read each successive entry."

"Oh…" His brow furrowed as he scanned the list. "Uhh. Why, though? What would happen if I didn't follow it?"

"That's not something you'll need to worry about."

Izuku blinked a few times. "I don't understand."

"The book is enchanted." He said, picking up his teacup and sipping it. "It's set on a progressive time-locked schedule. You wouldn't be able to read entries prematurely, even if you wanted to."

That, for whatever reason, made Izuku's gut twist up in a rather unpleasant way.

All Might set his cup down. "It's not that I don't trust you, Midoriya. It's just that this is…" He trailed off, his eyes drifting away. After a moment, he closed his eyes and sighed. "Well, it's just too important for me to rely on trust alone." All Might looked up at him. "Please try to understand."

Izuku nodded slowly, and after a pause, asked, "What would happen if—*theoretically*—I just waited until the last date and read the whole thing at once?"

All Might frowned. “Well, it’s impossible to really predict, but it certainly wouldn’t be good.” He chuckled softly. “I’m sort of banking on your insatiable curiosity preventing that from being an issue.”

Izuku gave a small smile, in spite of his anxiety. “But…” He swallowed. “Why would it be an issue at *all?”*

“Midoriya,” All Might exhaled. “What you have to understand is that—among other things—these notes contain a lot of information transcribed from books beyond your level. Information you would normally acquire over the course of *decades* of training.” He leaned forward, lacing his fingers together. “I’m really just trying to be cautious, here. It’s impossible for me to predict what will happen, but Angels have a history of responding poorly to sudden influxes of dense information. I just don’t want you to get overwhelmed.”

You didn’t seem too concerned about that when you were teaching me about anything else, he thought, narrowing his eyes slightly.

“What sort of information is in here, exactly?”

All Might stared at him for a while, and then raised an eyebrow.

“You’ve been unusually obstinate lately.”

Izuku tensed.

Have I…?

He watched, opening and closing his mouth a few times, as All Might reached for his teacup again, taking a small sip.

“I… I’m sorry, All Might.”

Izuku looked down, wiping his sweaty palms on his robe.

Maybe I’ve just gotten too used to having all my questions answered immediately.

“It’s alright.” He replied lightly. Then his tone shifted to something more serious. “But you should be careful to remember where you are, Midoriya. I’m sure you’re already quite aware of this, but the way you act around me at times could get you into a lot of trouble if you did it around anyone else.”

“I apologize.” Izuku said, his voice coming out a bit higher. He swallowed. “I… really don’t mean to be disrespectful.”

All Might shook his head, offering a reassuring smile. “It’s really not about me, Midoriya.” He said. “We know each other, and that inherently means that things will be less formal between us.” He shrugged. “I’m only saying something because I’ve been noticing this trend for a while now, and it’s crucial that you remain conscious of it.”

He paused to set his cup down.

“Things like asking pressing questions, speaking out of turn or back-talk may be alright with *me,* but those same behaviors could garner a lot of suspicion if you allowed them to slip out around, say, an Acolyte, for instance.”

Izuku tensed, his eyes widening as he stared down at his lap, memories rushing back to the surface.

“But sir, Shinsou meant well. He was just trying to protect me!”

He felt the phantom weight of the Acolyte’s attention, and a wave of nausea swept over him.

“Midoriya?” All Might said, frowning. “Are you alright?”

“Y-Yes,” He stammered. “I’m alright. Sorry.”

“Are you sure? You look… ill.”

Izuku forced himself to swallow the bile rising in his throat, and looked up at All Might with a wobbly smile. “I’m sure. Don’t worry.”

All Might stared at him a while longer, his brows pinched together, though eventually, he simply sighed. “Anyway, I’m sure that’s nothing you weren’t already aware of, but I figured it’d be good to remind you.”

“Of course.” Izuku nodded. “Thank you for that.”

All Might regarded him quietly, a faint look of worry still marring his features. After a moment, he stood. “Well, then. Shall we get on with your training? Or do you need a moment to…”

Izuku picked up the cup of tea, downing the whole thing in one go before setting the cup down with an, *‘Ahh.’*

“I’m ready.”

Izuku heard the news as he was returning from All Might’s house.

Shinsou had been released from the hospital, after nearly five weeks of treatment. Despite his exhaustion, he headed straight for Shinsou’s room, not even bothering to drop off his things.

He knocked on the door, a tight feeling in his chest betraying both excitement and worry. After that first day, the hospital hadn’t allowed Shinsou any more visitors, as per his punishment, and the inability to check on him had left Izuku with a persistent feeling of unease.

After a moment, Shinsou opened the door. Izuku made no attempt at subtlety as he looked him up and down, studying his condition. For the most part, he looked alright—his arm was in a sling, and there was a gash on his forehead that had been sewn shut with stitches. But all in all, he looked much better than when Izuku had seen him last.

It was a relief, though it probably shouldn't have been.

There was a part of him, something small and quiet in the back of his mind, that worried Shinsou would look worse, somehow. He didn't want to think about what that would mean.

"Oh, Midoriya." He said. "Hello."

"It's good to see you, Shinsou." Izuku smiled. "I've missed you."

Shinsou blinked, averting his eyes. "Do you want to come in?"

Izuku nodded, thanking him as he ducked under his arm, setting his bag down in the corner. Shinsou's room was a bit dark. He always kept the blinds shut, and there were only a couple of small lamps scattered around the room, most of which were off.

"Sorry it's so messy," He said. "I haven't really had a chance to clean, yet."

Izuku laughed softly, taking a seat at his cluttered desk. "It's okay. It almost makes it cozier."

Shinsou smiled slightly, and sat at the edge of his bed, sighing.

"So… How're you doing?"

"Hmm? Oh." Shinsou's back straightened a bit. "Alright, I guess. My arm still hurts, but they say I should be more or less back to normal within a month."

Izuku chewed his lip, the guilt stirring up inside him. "I'm sorry…" He swallowed. "About everything."

For a long while, Shinsou didn't speak. Then, he exhaled, shoulders slumping a bit.

"It's… not your fault." He murmured, shaking his head. "I was in over my head. I should've realized it, but…" He looked down, eyes fixating on Izuku's bag in the corner. "I just… wasn't thinking straight."

"I know you did it because you care about me."

Shinsou blinked. "…Yes. But still, I…" He closed his eyes, and sighed. "I shouldn't have followed you. I knew that even before then. But…" He hesitated. "Well, I'm not sure what would've happened to you if I *hadn't."*

Izuku was quiet for a bit, turning the words over in his mind as he debated how he ought to respond. It didn't take long for him to decide, but gathering the nerve to actually speak was another thing.

But still.

I've lied to Shinsou far too much already, he thought. *He deserves the truth.*

"I-I mean…" He gulped. "Well… if you want the t*ruth*... probably nothing."

Shockingly, Shinsou didn't seem surprised. In fact, he didn't really visibly react at all. For a while, the room was void of all forms of communication, the air still and lifeless. Izuku found himself thinking back to what Shinsou had said to him, as he was being carted away at the hospital.

"I saw the way you looked at him."

He swallowed.

"He… definitely went overboard." Izuku finally said, speaking quietly, eyes fixated on his feet. "I-If it makes you feel any better, I yelled at him about it." He laughed awkwardly.

When he looked up, Shinsou was staring at him.

"Midoriya…" He murmured. And Izuku could feel the weight of all the words left unsaid. He nodded slowly, eyes downcast.

It's time to tell him.

"Kacch—Um, Katsuki," he stammered, blushing slightly. He took a deep breath. "Katsuki's sort of like… my partner, I guess. It was All Might's idea."

At that, Shinsou's eyebrows shot up. "Your *mentor's?"*

"Y-Yeah." He said, eyes darting around. "Um. After I ran into him around five months ago, All Might suggested that I work with him as an…" He squinted, "Uhh, extracurricular, of sorts?"

He rubbed the back of his neck, chancing a glance at Shinsou again. The look of disbelief on his face caused Izuku to break into a sweat.

"B-Basically, um, his rationale was that spending time around a Demon would make my application stand out by showing that I'm capable of resisting temptation. Essentially."

Forcing himself to look at Shinsou again, he found him sitting there stock-still, looking at him with an incredulous expression. "That seems…" He looked off to the side, then back at Izuku. "Unlikely."

Izuku frowned. "I'm telling the truth! All Might really—"

"—Not that." He shook his head. "I'm not doubting you're telling the truth about what your mentor said, I'm just… skeptical about whether he'd be correct."

Izuku looked down at the floor, smiling sadly. "Well, you'd be right to think so." He said. "Almost immediately after you were admitted, I found out my application had been denied."

Shinsou faltered, his mouth hanging open. "I'm sorry to hear that," he then said, his tone soft. "I know you've been working very hard, Midoriya."

Izuku nodded, swallowing around the dull ache of sadness that still lurked within him. He gave a limp shrug. “It’s alright. I’m… I’m sure I’ll get there eventually.” He murmured, ignoring the bitter taste on his tongue.

After a long moment of silence, Shinsou spoke again. “That wasn’t really what I meant, though.” He said. “I mean… I don’t know, I’m sure your mentor knows best, but…”

Izuku looked up, brow furrowed. “What?”

“I just… I feel like what you’re doing would be more likely to just get you in trouble.”

“Ah.”

It’d be a lie to claim the thought hadn’t crossed his mind. His trust in All Might’s judgement always quelled his concerns in the end, but there were times when he still wondered. And the more he learned about Demons, the more he questioned it.

“I’ve thought about that before,” Izuku said. “But I guess if they were going to punish me, they would’ve done it when they read the application.”

Shinsou blinked. “…Did *you* read the application?”

“Well, no. All Might submitted it on my behalf.” He cocked his head. “Why?”

Shinsou held eye contact for a while, and then looked away, shrugging. “No reason, I guess.”

More silence.

“So…” Izuku began. “What happened? You know, after I left that day.”

Shinsou tensed, his fingers clenching around the bed sheets. “You mean…?”

Izuku nodded.

“I…” He squinted. “He asked me questions, I think. He wanted a physical description of the Demon. I described it—um.” He hesitated. *“Him,* I mean, as best I could, and then…” He clenched his jaw. “I don’t know. I think he just left.”

Him.

A small sensation of warmth bloomed somewhere in Izuku’s chest, though it was overshadowed by more pressing emotions.

Izuku swallowed. “You sound… unsure.”

“Well, I was pretty heavily sedated. At some point, I think I fell asleep. But it was after he left, I think.” After a moment, he quietly tacked on, “It *must’ve* been.”

Izuku stared at him for a while, a dark feeling burgeoning within him. Shinsou spoke as though he were trying to convince himself as much as Izuku, if not more.

“Falling asleep *before* wouldn’t have made sense.” Shinsou muttered, fidgeting with his arm sling. “His presence *alone* woke me up the first time…” He grimaced.

“Shinsou…” He trailed off. Shinsou looked up then, meeting his concerned gaze, only to look away quickly.

“Sorry. I’m fine, I just…” He chewed his lip a bit, and then sighed. “I don’t know. Acolytes are… strange.” He grimaced. “They don’t… act like *normal* Angels, you know?” He laughed awkwardly—tried to, at least. It didn’t really work; he wasn’t smiling. “The whole thing made me feel sort of nauseous. I had a lot of weird dreams afterward…”

Izuku frowned. “You had nightmares?”

Shinsou hesitated. “Not… *really.* I don’t feel like they were strongly good or bad, just… *weird.”* He said, wincing. “I can’t distinctly remember anything about them, though, so…” He went silent, then shrugged.

“I suppose it’s possible it could’ve just been a side effect of whatever sedatives they had you on.” Izuku offered.

“Oh,” Shinsou’s eyes got minutely wider. “I hadn’t thought about it, but now that you mention it, yeah, that *would* make more sense.” His lips turned up slightly, and the tension in his body seemed to melt away.

“Well, I’m glad nothing *too* traumatic happened.” He said, chuckling softly. “I was really scared to leave you there alone. Part of me was worried that…” He trailed off, but Shinsou seemed to understand where he was going, as he nodded, gazing down at the floor, a kind look on his face.

“I’m glad, as well. Um…” He hesitated, blinking a few times. “Thanks…” He said. “You know, for being…” He shifted on the mattress. “Well, you know.”

“Of course.” Izuku replied, a bright smile on his face. “That’s what friends are for.”

Despite Izuku’s expectations, the first few entries were actually fairly mundane. They mostly consisted of transcribed segments from various manuals on battle strategy which were inaccessible to Izuku, and though the information was certainly useful, there was nothing really groundbreaking about it.

He’d been keeping up with the schedule, but there was something peculiar about it that Izuku hadn’t initially noticed—namely, the time intervals between entries were not always equal.

The first four entries were all set up to be read at a rate of one per day. The fifth entry, however, was set for three days after the fourth. Izuku wasn’t sure what that meant, exactly, but he was equal parts anxious and eager to find out.

When the day finally came, Izuku was surprised by how short the entry ended up being. But as he began to read, he very quickly discovered that it was not like the other ones.

Commander,

We write to inform you that the Sinners have not been punished.

It is really quite bizarre, the 'society' these creatures have apparently formed. When asked why they insist on subverting God's will, the Demons simply told us that His will 'serves no purpose.'

Further investigation will be required, but the Council should be prepared to intervene in the near future.

Regards,

I & S

"'I and S'?" Izuku muttered under his breath.

He stared at the signature for several seconds, his mind blank before it suddenly clicked into place.

Izaiya and Setsuko! He realized. *The spies who betrayed God! This must be an excerpt from the original memorandor.*

His initial excitement was soon tempered as the implications of the situation began to set in.

...But why would All Might have something like this to begin with? He wondered. *And...*

He read over the entry a few more times.

'The sinners have not been punished.'

...What exactly do they mean?

"Exactly what it sounds like, dipshit."

Katsuki was leaning over the altar, his hands hovering above a small goblet filled with holy water. His brows pinched together as he concentrated on heating it up gradually, and a triumphant grin spread across his face when the water started to boil over. Like most

sacrilege Katsuki idly took part in, Izuku opted to ignore it, if only to avoid getting side-tracked.

"…So you just have sinners wandering around *unchecked?"*

"Depends what you mean by *'sinner.'"* He rounded the altar, the goblet of steaming holy water forgotten as he hopped off the platform. "Most people in Hell didn't actually do anything bad while they were alive. Majority just didn't believe in God—or didn't believe in the *right* God."

Izuku resisted the urge to point out that not believing in God was, in fact, a bad thing, at least by his standards.

He sighed, pinching the bridge of his nose. "Okay, but what about the ones who did *other* bad things? You're telling me you just let them do whatever they want?"

Katsuki scowled. "Never said *that."* He scoffed. "Deku, I don't know if you realize this, but this ain't an either-or situation. There're ways to handle this kinda shit that *don't* involve eternal fucking torment."

At that, Izuku looked up. "Oh...?" he said, and after a second, followed, "Well, like what?"

"Eh," Katsuki shrugged. "It's a case-by-case sorta thing. Lotta human violence is pretty much just a byproduct of people's material conditions, which are obviously completely fuckin' different in Hell." He paused, stretching his arms above his head, yawning. "Most of 'em don't end up being a real threat."

"So you just… don't punish those people? Like, *at all?"*

"Why would we?" Katsuki asked, deadpan. "What purpose would that serve?"

In lieu of a response, Izuku just stared at him, his mouth gaping. After a while, Katsuki groaned.

"Deku, y'know punishment isn't like, the fuckin' end-all-be-all of dealing with shit like this, right?" He raised an eyebrow. "Frankly, I think we must be doin' *somethin'* right, given that Hell doesn't really have much of a problem with, like, antisocial behavior, or whatever."

Izuku scoffed. "I find that very hard to believe."

"Oh, I'm sure you do." He said, snorting. "But fortunately, reality is not contingent on whether or not it fits into your worldview." Katsuki shoved his hands into his pockets and strolled down the aisle, headed toward the front door of the chapel. He backed up into the door, allowing a slice of light to leak in. "You comin'?"

Izuku nodded, hurrying over to him and shutting the door behind them. As they walked side by side, Katsuki spoke up again.

"It's honestly not that weird, if you think about it." He said, squinting up at the sky. "Societies with weird conditions have to evolve to accommodate weird needs, otherwise

they'll fall apart." He shrugged. "Hell gets a lot of violent people, 'least compared to Heaven, which means we basically had two choices, we either…" He held up a finger. *"One,* come to terms with the idea of havin' a permanently massive carceral class, or *two,"* He raised a second finger, "figure out how to integrate those people into society. The second one just happened to align better with the ideals we were workin' toward."

"Ideals?" Izuku arched an eyebrow. "What *ideals* were those?"

Katsuki hummed, pursing his lips. "I guess the simplest way I can think to put it is…" he trailed off for a moment. "Well, Hell, at least as it currently exists, was basically designed to function sorta like a scaled-up version of the way people already interact." After a second, he added, "Y'know, *without* the influence of any sort of outside power, or institutions, or whatever."

"…What do you mean?"

"I guess a good way to imagine how Hell approaches problems is to try and imagine how you and your friends would handle an analogous problem."

"O…kay?" Izuku squinted. "Could you… maybe give an example, or…?"

"Yeah, sure. Uhh…" They turned a corner, and made their way down a side road. "Well, let's take the whole *'handling antisocial behavior'* issue." He eventually said. "So, imagine you live in a house with all your friends, and there's two of 'em named…" He squinted. "Ehh, let's call 'em *Cool Katsuki* and *Chaos Katsuki."*

"Why are you inserting *yourself* into this hypothetical?"

"Not important." He clipped. "Anyway, so everything's fine at first, but at some point, you catch both *Coolsuki* and *Chaosuki* pissing in *your* potted tomato plant. What is the *first thing* you say to them?"

Izuku stopped in his tracks. After a few paces, Katsuki stopped, too, and looked over his shoulder.

"I… Excuse me, *what?"*

"It's really pretty simple." He said. "Coolsuki and Chaosuki are pissing in your potted tomato plant."

"But *why* are they doing that?"

"I don't know, Deku." Katsuki replied, his tone patronizingly sweet. "That sounds like a great question to ask *them."*

After several seconds, Izuku sighed, giving in. He started walking again, catching up to Katsuki before responding. "Okay, *fine.* I'd ask them why they're doing…" He cringed, "*that."*

"'Kay." Katsuki nodded. "So, you ask, and let's say they give you two different responses." He held up two fingers for emphasis. "Coolsuki says he's sorry. He didn't wanna do it. He just couldn't find the bathroom, so he panicked." Katsuki lowered his chin. "How do you respond?"

Izuku frowned. "But I thought he lived there?"

"Never said it was a perfect hypothetical." Katsuki shrugged. "I don't know. Maybe he just moved in, or something. Whatever. It doesn't *matter.* Just—fuckin'—assuming that's a reasonable excuse, *how would you respond?"*

"I, uhh." Izuku's brow furrowed. "I guess I would, um…" He scratched his head. "W-Well, I'd *definitely* show him where the bathroom is, that's for sure."

"And you'd forgive him?"

"I… Sure, I guess?" Izuku shook his head. "Kacchan, I still don't know what point you're trying to make."

"We'll fuckin' get there. Lemme finish the damn hypothetical." When Izuku didn't protest, he took a breath and continued. "Alright, anyway… So, that's Coolsuki. Great. But Chaosuki," He snorted, "that fucker's a different story. When you ask *him* why he did it, he just fuckin' shrugs and tells you he just enjoys pissing in other people's potted tomato plants. It, like, gets him hard or something." He cocked his head, smiling. "Your move, Deku."

"Um." Izuku's eyes widened, his cheeks dusted pink. "Sorry, he *what?"*

"You heard me, nerd. It gets him off." Katsuki grinned wider, looking at him with a crazed glint in his eyes, gesticulating wildly as they walked. "The mere knowledge that *your* tomato plant is nourishing itself with *his* piss, using it to produce sweet, *succulent* tomatoes for *your* consumption, makes him cum harder than anything else. The sheer amount of sexual pleasure he can derive from the simple act of urinating on that *Solanum lycopersicum* is fucking beyond comprehension." He shrugged. "Those are the parameters of this hypothetical, Deku. *Your fucking move."*

Izuku glared at him, but it lost a lot of its bite thanks to the overpowering strength of his blush. "I think you're having *way* too much fun with this."

"And *I* think that's none of your goddamn business," Katsuki shot back, still grinning like a madman. "I repeat: *Your. Fucking. Move."*

He stared at Katsuki for a while, still scowling, though the muscles in his face were quickly losing strength. Eventually, he squeezed his eyes shut and released an aggravated groan.

"I mean…" He sighed. "I don't *know,* Kacchan. I'd probably just—just tell him to *leave."*

"What about your other friends?"

"I guess I'd have to explain it to them afterward."

After a pause, Katsuki said, “Okay, yeah. Guess that’s fair enough, since you caught ‘im in the act and all.” He shrugged. “What if you didn’t, though? What if you found out he’d just been doing this for like, a *while*, and you just discovered it after the fact, somehow?”

“Uhhh…” Izuku looked at the ground. “I mean, I guess I’d probably talk to my friends first, so they’d know what was going on.” He muttered. “Maybe we could confront him as a group, and then figure out what to do after that.”

“Makes sense. And in any case, you’ll probably wanna keep him away from your tomato plants.”

Izuku nodded emphatically.

“What if it gets worse, though?” Katsuki asked. “What if he starts pissing on *other* things, like your clothes, or your food?”

Izuku grimaced. “Well, isn’t that kind of a safety hazard? I mean… if we haven’t already kicked him out, we *definitely* would, then.”

“Cool, Cool. And you’re probably not gonna want him around, even as a guest, right?”

“Absolutely not.”

He paused for a moment, humming.

“Okay, *but…”* Katsuki sped up a bit, and began walking backwards in front of Izuku. “Let’s say, one day Chaosuki calls you all up and apologizes. He says,” Katsuki held his hand beside his ear, proceeding to speak into it like a phone. *“‘Hey, it’s me, Chaosuki. I wanted to apologize for pissing all over you guys’ things. It was fucked up, and I’m sorry. Since then, I’ve started seeing a therapist and we’ve been working on getting my paraphilias under control. I’m in a much better place these days, and will now only piss on things that consent to being pissed on.’”* His hand fell away from his ear, and he cocked his head. “What do you think, Deku? Does he deserve a second chance?”

Izuku blinked a few times, slowing down a little as he thought it over. “I mean…” He cringed. “If it seems like he means it, then I… guess so…?” He rubbed his neck, eyes darting around uncomfortably. “I mean, maybe he can come over, if everyone’s okay with it? Whether or not he can actually move back in, though…”

“…Would probably depend on a few things.” Katsuki completed. “Like how long it’s been, how your roommates feel about it. Maybe whether you can verify that he actually *is* in therapy. That sorta thing.”

Izuku nodded quietly, then sighed, coming to a stop. “Will you *please* just tell me what your point is?”

“It’s pretty straightforward. Hell tries to follow that same logic, just on a larger scale.” Katsuki said, shrugging. “Now, if this analogy worked the way *Heaven* does, whichever roommate had the most power by whatever arbitrary metric would’ve simply forced both

Coolsuki and Chaosuki down into the basement at gunpoint, where they would then be waterboarded with their own piss for some indeterminate amount of time."

Izuku cringed. "You really didn't need to be *that* detailed."

"Yeah, but I wanted to be." He said, grinning. "You might get flashbacks to this conversation next time you see a tomato plant, but at least I know you won't forget about it."

Izuku rolled his eyes, prompting Katsuki to laugh. As it pattered out, Katsuki moved to walk beside him again. Izuku peered up ahead, spotting the steeple of the next church on his list. For a moment, neither of them spoke.

"So…" Izuku murmured, breaking the silence. "Exile, then…?"

Katsuki glanced at him, and sighed. "In serious cases." He said, a bit softer. "There's places outside the cities where people can go to get professional help. Y'know. If they want it. If they wanna come back fast…" He trailed off, and then shrugged. "Some people just choose to brave the Wilds on their own, but not a lot. Thing about people is we usually need other people to survive."

Izuku nodded.

"After a while, if they can demonstrate that they're no longer a threat, we'll negotiate."

Izuku frowned, looking up at him. "What if they can't change?"

Katsuki exhaled quietly, shielding his eyes as he peered up at the sky, where the sun peeked out behind the clouds.

"Y'know, humans got it pretty rough." He murmured. "When you're human, depending on how fucked up you are, the amount of time it takes to get better could be longer than you've got left to live."

Katsuki's lips quirked up a bit.

"But y'know, I've been dead two-hundred years. I'm sure as fuck not the same person I was when I died." He said, and laughed quietly. "That's the great thing about eternity, Deku. *Everyone* can change." Katsuki slid his hands back into his pockets. "Might take a thousand years, but immortality means you've got all the time in the world to save yourself."

Izuku's breath caught as he stared up at him, taking in the softness of his expression. A few seconds later, he began to laugh.

Katsuki blinked, glancing down at him. "What?"

"I don't know. It's just funny," Izuku said, smiling. They were approaching the front entrance of the last chapel. "You're framing a direct contradiction of God's wishes in a way that makes it sound… weirdly *christ-like."*

Katsuki shot him a look with a raised eyebrow, and turned to look straight ahead.

Then, with absolutely no intonation: “We’ve also got this massive stadium called the Amphilux where people can go to watch or participate in massive orgies twenty-four hours a day.”

“What?”

“Yep. It’s sort of a relic of the past, but it’s still in use.”

“Kacchan.”

“Also, I live across the street from a sex dungeon. We’ve got a lot of those—real convenient. It’s where I got those gloves, actually. I pass it every night when I get home, and oh man, Deku, you would not *believe* the kinda *sounds* I’ve heard comin’ outta that place, I could go on about it for *fuckin’—”*

“—Kacchan!”

Later that day, Izuku was lying on his back, fingertips pressed against the mat. Katsuki knelt at his side, holding his right leg up at a little bit beyond a ninety-degree angle, one hand wrapped around his ankle, the other resting on his thigh as he counted aloud.

“…Fifty-eight, fifty-nine, sixty.” With that, he released his leg, then scooted around to the other side to do the same with the left. Keeping Izuku’s knee straight, he slowly eased his leg higher and higher as he counted.

“Twenty-one, twenty-two—keep your hips down—“ He snapped, shoving Izuku’s hip back down against the mat with one hand before returning it to his thigh. Izuku winced slightly, clenching his jaw. “Relax.” Katsuki muttered, and Izuku took a deep breath, trying his best to release the tension from his muscles.

Nothing too extreme had happened since the first time they’d sparred. It was always a bit tense, and Katsuki *did* seem to have an affinity for pinning Izuku down in compromising positions, though Izuku might’ve been reading a bit too far into it.

Katsuki’s face hovered above him, red eyes glowing in the dim training room, soft lips forming around the syllables of numbers as he counted up to sixty. His latex-clad fingers shifted slightly as he eased his leg a little higher. Izuku straightened his head, fixing his gaze on the ceiling, his cheeks dusted red.

Fortunately, exertion was a decent enough excuse for that.

It happened as Izuku was on his way back.

His mind was still a bit foggy from his time spent with Katsuki, and he wasn’t really paying attention to his surroundings. As he approached the platform, he noticed an unfamiliar scuff mark on one of his shoes, and in his distraction, he wound up bumping right into someone’s back.

“Oh my goodness, I’m so—“ Izuku stopped, cutting himself off with a gasp. The sensation hit him like a ton of bricks, even before the stranger turned around. Izuku stumbled back a few feet, breaking into a cold sweat as he finally, *finally* registered the tell-tale pressure that seemed to weigh down the air itself.

How could I be so oblivious?!

The Acolyte turned around, a frown affixed to his face, and despite the presence of that typical red blindfold, Izuku could still feel the blunt force of the Acolyte’s gaze on him. He felt like he was choking on his own tongue.

“I-I’m,” He stammered, voice two octaves higher. “I’m s-so sorry, Sir. I was… w-wasn’t looking where I was going. I’m sorry. I’m *really* sorry.” He looked away, a jagged chill running down his spine as the Acolyte continued to stare at him, *into* him. Izuku shuffled uncomfortably beneath his gaze. This went on for several seconds before the sound of someone shouting dragged his attention away.

Izuku looked up, and despite the darkness lining the edges of his vision, his brain managed to make sense of the information. A gurney was being rushed down the breezeway, and this, on its own, would not have been particularly unusual; Angels get injured on the battlefield all the time.

What set this instance apart was the brief flash of red and white, caught for just seconds between the bodies and limbs of the surrounding medics. Just like that, the spell broke, and Izuku gasped, craning his neck to try and see over them. He looked at the Acolyte, hands still shaking.

“E-Excuse me, sir. That’s my friend over there. I should…” Izuku gulped, hesitating. Then, he shook his head. “Sorry!” He yelped, bolting toward the hospital platform, following the medics as they lifted the gurney over the lip.

“Who are you?” One of them snapped.

“I’m sorry!” Izuku waved his hands. “He’s my friend!”

The medic looked him up and down, and then sighed. “Well, fine, but stay out of our way, okay?”

“Of course!” Izuku nodded quickly.

He boarded the shuttle after them, and stood back on his tiptoes, trying to see over their shoulders without disrupting them. All he could see were scraps of bruised flesh and bandages. Izuku clenched his jaw and attempted to calm his breathing, but it was difficult.

Upon arrival, they wheeled Todoroki inside, Izuku trailing behind him. One of the medics shouted something too technical for Izuku to grasp, but it made the on-duty nurses spring into action. The double doors of the emergency wing parted as they wheeled Todoroki through, shutting heavily behind them.

And then he was alone.

The wait wound up being well over four hours.

During that time, Izuku would occasionally get up and pace around a bit, maybe get a cup of water. But that was all he could do. The clock mounted on the wall in front of him ticked steadily, the sound seeping into him, melding with his heart beat until he could no longer differentiate between the two.

He nearly jumped out of his skin at the sharp sound of a doorknob turning, hinges creaking as a nurse emerged, with a clipboard in her hands and bags beneath her eyes. “You’re here for Todoroki Shouto?”

Izuku immediately stood, nodding.

“Well, he’s stable. You’re welcome to come see him now, if you'd like, but he probably won’t be conscious.”

“That’s okay. Thank you.”

With that, he followed her down the hall. When they reached his room, she opened the door for him, and he thanked her once more, stepping inside. The door shut behind him, and Izuku gulped at what he saw. Todoroki was lying unconscious in bed.

This time, the injuries were clearly much worse.

Izuku sat in the chair at his bedside, trying to calm his heart rate. Still, he couldn’t help the tears that slipped free from his eyes.

Then, as if on cue, Todoroki began to stir, his eyelids twitching until they fluttered open. Izuku held his breath.

Should I get the doctor…?

He remained still, quietly waiting for Todoroki to say something, but for a long while, he just lay there, staring up at the ceiling. Eventually Izuku opened his mouth to speak. Todoroki beat him to it.

“Midoriya.” He said, gaze still fixated on the ceiling.

Izuku felt something cold settle in the pit of his stomach, sending shivers down his spine. His pulse picked up speed, a shot of adrenaline charging through his veins.

He wasn’t sure why, though.

This wasn’t a dire situation.

This was just Todoroki.

Swallowing despite the tightness in his throat, Izuku leaned in closer. “Todoroki, you’re awake!” After a moment, he added, “Should I get the—?“

“No.”

Izuku froze, his mouth still open. He blinked several times, trying to reset himself. Trying to correct the surely misplaced feelings lurking within him. It didn’t work. “I… why not?”

After a pause, Todoroki moved to sit up. It was clearly a difficult task, given his injuries, but he managed it eventually. He settled down with a sigh, still not looking at Izuku. “They’ll just put me to sleep again.” He muttered.

Izuku frowned. *What’s that supposed to mean?*

Todoroki’s heart monitor beeped at a steady, resting pace. Izuku felt a cold bead of sweat roll down the back of his neck, a metallic taste polluting his tongue.

Something’s wrong.

“W-Well I mean,” He stammered. “If you need the rest, then maybe I should just—“

His head snapped toward Izuku.

“No.” Todoroki spat, a wild look in his eyes. “I’m *fine.”*

For several seconds, Izuku just stared back into his eyes, paralyzed. But eventually, he looked down at the ground, nodding quietly.

His hands started shaking in his lap. The room was cold. Bleach white. Sterile. Like they were the only living things that had ever been there.

“What happened?” Izuku finally asked. “What’s going *on?”*

Todoroki sighed, his gaze still empty as he looked himself over. He glanced over his shoulder, at the bandages around his wings, and picked at them, just a little at first.

Then, Izuku watched, frozen in shock, as he proceeded to grab the edge of one bandage and *pull.* His mouth fell open, but he did not speak. His mind was a blank slate.

Todoroki began to unravel the bandages around his wings, occasionally wincing as he worked. Gradually, what remained of his patchy wings became visible. With one sharp yank, he revealed a piece where a large chunk of feathers were missing, and Izuku finally found the nerve to speak up.

“I really don’t think you should be doing that—”

“—It doesn’t matter.” Todoroki interjected, calm. “Don’t worry. It doesn’t matter, anyway.”

Doesn’t matter? He gulped. *This is getting out of hand.*

Izuku gripped the arms of the chair.

“Todoroki, I…” He hesitated. “I *really* think I should get the—“

“No.” Todoroki snapped, halting his movements to look at him with a stern glare that melted away a second later. *“Please,* Midoriya.”

Izuku’s throat felt tight. He opened and closed his mouth a few times.

“W-Well, at least tell me why you’re doing that.”

Todoroki looked away, exhaling as he moved on to his other wing. Izuku watched his Adam’s apple bob as he swallowed.

“It hurts,” he mumbled. “They put the bandages on too tightly.”

It sounded like a lie, but Izuku wasn’t prepared to fight him on it. The situation felt volatile in ways he couldn’t fully understand. So he just sat there, watching uneasily as Todoroki continued to strip the bindings off his wings. The silence was filled by the sound of adhesive bandages being ripped away, until eventually, both wings were completely free of them. Todoroki rolled his shoulders, stretching his wings with a slight grimace. Izuku bit the inside of his cheek as he took in the mangled state of them.

There were a decent number of feathers missing from both—more than enough to impede flight—and there were a few places where the skin beneath was visible. Raw, and still a bit bloody, like the feathers there had been ripped out.

After resting a moment, he moved onto his arms, beginning to work on the bandages there as well. And Izuku noticed that, as time went on, Todoroki’s movements became jerkier, more harsh and frantic. He was clenching his jaw, his facial muscles tight. Each bandage he tore away revealed more and more skin, showing the extent of the corruption damage he’d sustained. And for far too long, Izuku just sat there, paralyzed, his heart in his throat. He stared at the black static scars covering his arms, barely an inch of flesh left unmarred.

“T-Todoroki—”

“I figured it out, Midoriya.” He said, his tone void of affect.

Izuku’s breath caught.

“What?”

“I figured out what was going on.” He replied. Then, a bit softer, “With the Demon.”

Izuku held his breath. He knew, somewhere in the back of his mind, that this was coming. But somehow, he still wasn’t prepared for it.

Having freed his left arm, he moved onto his right.

“I figured out what he wants.” He paused, and then his lips pulled up into a tight, cynical sort of smile. “Or maybe it’s more appropriate to say I *remembered.”*

A chill shot down Izuku’s spine.

“What…” He swallowed. He didn’t *want* to ask. “What do you mean, exactly…?”

Todoroki’s movements slowed, and he gradually came to a stop, allowing the last bandage to hang off of his upper arm loosely. He stared down at the hospital bed, his expression unreadable—or perhaps it was more accurate to say it was *inconsistent.* As Izuku studied him, his sadness remained a constant presence, but the undertone seemed to shift. One moment he looked grief-stricken, the next he seemed almost nostalgic.

Izuku wasn’t sure how much time had passed. It must have been several minutes, at least.

Then, with a small, hoarse voice, Todoroki broke the silence.

“We knew each other.”

Izuku tensed.

“Sorry?”

Todoroki swallowed audibly.

“We knew each other, Midoriya.” He whispered, a faraway look in his eyes. “When we were alive, when we…”

A pause.

“When we were human.”

Izuku gawked at him for a while, cold, shaky hands covering his mouth. He lowered them. “You’re *sure?”*

Todoroki nodded slowly. “I am.” He murmured. “I remember, Midoriya. I remember…” His eyes grew a bit wider as he stared into space, gripping the thin hospital sheets between his injured fingers. Izuku slowly registered the shine in his eyes as he began to tear up, and he wished, more than anything else, that he could’ve done something for him. That there was something he could say to Todoroki in that moment that could’ve eased the pain of whatever unknown Hell raged inside his mind.

But there was nothing, and this was happening. He was powerless.

“Everything,” Todoroki finished. Then, sucking a sharp breath through his teeth, he ripped the rest of the last bandage off, and with it, the temperature in the room dropped. Izuku clasped his hands together, trying to make them stop shaking. Slowly, Todoroki turned his head toward him, his jaw tight, eyes unfocused.

“It’s all a lie, Midoriya.” He said, voice cracking as a tear finally slipped down his cheek. “Everything we’ve been taught. Every *goddamn* thing.”

He could hear the sound of threads popping as Todoroki gripped and pulled at the sheets.

And then, a single feather fell from his right wing, unnoticed by him.

Izuku watched it drift elegantly down, but his heart hit the floor first. A tiny event, in the grand scheme of things, but in that moment, the implications were all-encompassing, suffocating.

Izuku stood up, the legs of the chair squealing as it slid back. He looked at Todoroki, his vision darkening at the edges. “Todoroki, you need to *calm—“*

“—Lock the door.”

Izuku faltered. *“What?”*

“Lock the door.” He repeated, teeth gritted, eyes hidden behind his bangs.

Izuku just gawked at him, blinking dumbly.

“T-Todoroki, I can’t just—“

“—Lock the *fucking* door, Midoriya!” His head snapped up. Izuku saw the tail-end of his rage before his expression morphed into something far more desperate. “Please.” He said, voice cracking. *“Please.”*

Izuku couldn’t breathe.

“Okay,” he barely managed to say. *“Okay.”* Then he stumbled over to the door, his joints locking, and turned the deadbolt before ambling over to him again, just in time to see another feather fall. He felt like his throat was closing up, but at the very least, Todoroki seemed less overtly panicked. As he closed his eyes, more tears slipped free.

Izuku sat down, and waited. It was all he could do. Just exist beside him.

How pathetic.

“I heard that your application was rejected.” Todoroki said, voice hoarse.

There was a dull twinge of pain, but his mind was too far away for him to truly feel it. “I… I was, yes.”

“Well, you’ll be relieved to know it had nothing to do with your abilities.” He forcefully wiped the tears from his cheeks, jaw clenching. “Just like my acceptance had nothing to do with mine.”

Izuku’s brow furrowed. “What are you talking about? Todoroki, you’re *very* talent—“

“—It doesn’t matter!” Another feather fell out. “It doesn’t *matter,* Midoriya. It *never* mattered. All of this—” He started to make a gesture, but seemed to give up partway through, his arms falling limply into his lap. He shook his head. “There’s only two types of Angels who ascend, Midoriya. Those who are willing to sell out their friends, and those with connections in high places.”

After a moment of shock, Izuku pushed back. “Todoroki, I don’t think that’s—“

“—It’s my fucking *father,* Midoriya!” He ripped the IV needle out of his arm in a way that made Izuku cringe. “My *asshole father* is a level nine Angel. He’s the next in line to become an Acolyte. He’s the *real* reason I ascended.”

“How could you possibly *know* that’s the reason?”

“I just *know.”* He spat. Another feather fell. *That makes four.* “That’s the secret to ascending. You either know someone important, or you prove yourself to be so mindlessly loyal that you’ll keep all the Council’s horrible secrets. And… And the Demon…”

One more feather slipped free, and then a couple seconds later, another followed. *It’s getting faster,* Izuku realized, with a wave of nausea.

“Todoroki, please, you *have* to calm down!”

“He saved my life, Midoriya.” He said. “When I was human. That’s how we met, when I was about to…” Another feather fell. Izuku’s head was swimming. “A-And now’s he’s…” His voice broke as he keeled over in bed, tears staining the hospital sheets. “It doesn’t make *sense!”*

Izuku was shaking, his chest painfully tight. “P-Please, Todoroki. *Please,* we—we can figure this out, we can—“

“I *loved* him!” He shouted. His voice was mangled, so far from anything he’d heard from Todoroki before. And it shattered the veil of isolation they had enjoyed up to that moment.

There was a knock on the door, followed by a muffled voice. “Sir? Are you alright?”

Izuku’s blood ran cold, but Todoroki seemed unfazed, as though he hadn’t even noticed. He sat there, tears slipping down his stained cheeks, shoulders shaking. Izuku heard the doorknob jiggle, followed by more muffled voices outside.

Todoroki harshly wiped his cheeks with his palms, wiped his nose on the sleeve of the hospital gown.

By then, the feathers were falling steadily, around one every five seconds or so. Todoroki’s wings were mostly bare, less than half of his feathers remaining.

“He was better than me.” Todoroki whispered. “But he went to Hell. I went to Heaven. My fucking *father* went to Heaven, but he went to *Hell.”* His lips were tight, brow furrowed. “I… *I don’t get it.* In what reality does that make *sense?”*

Izuku opened and closed his mouth, like a fish out of water.

What could he possibly tell him?

Feathers cascaded like snow onto the cold hospital floor.

What could he say that would make *any* of this better?

“I just… what the fuck are we even *doing?* What am *I* doing?” He said, shaky hands gravitating toward his head to grip the roots of his hair. “What am I even fighting for? This… This isn’t *justice!”* He shouted. “If someone like my shitty *father* can get into Heaven, but he *can’t*—what…”

The last feather fell, leaving his wings naked, trembling with his sobs. The banging on the door became more insistent. Izuku raised a shaky hand, reaching out toward him.

And then, all the feathers on the floor abruptly turned black. Izuku’s breath caught in his throat. Seconds later, they all burst into flames, burning up rapidly, leaving behind only ash.

When he looked up, he noticed that two bumps were beginning to appear on Todoroki’s head, growing until they emerged through his hair.

Horns, he realized.

...No.

Around the same time, the hands cradling his face began to grow larger, the skin there becoming darker as his nails morphed into something resembling claws.

This isn’t happening.

As his naked wings began to shrink, the horns on the sides of his head started to twist, finalizing their form. And Todoroki’s shoulders shook as he continued to cry, though his voice was beginning to sound distorted.

No, God—please.

The banging on the door became louder.

“Todoroki!”

In a last-ditch effort to put a stop to it all, Izuku clamored onto the bed, tears streaming down his cheeks as he desperately called out his name. His hands on Todoroki’s knees, fingers digging in as he cried frantic, *hollow* words of placation, garbled promises and reassuring lies that likely didn’t even make sense. It was all he had left.

It wasn’t enough.

Suddenly, two large, black wings shot out from his back, curling protectively around his body, casting them both in relative darkness.

Izuku could hear the sound of the wooden door cracking, of people screaming out in the hall. And then, wiping his tears away, Todoroki lifted his head.

He looked at Izuku. His eyes were glowing, now—highlighting the red, puffy skin around them.

“Todoroki,” He sobbed. Begging. Pleading for a lost cause.

But Todoroki just gazed at him, a quiet despair etched into his features. As though he’d already accepted it. Already *given up.*

“Todoroki!” Izuku cried, grabbing his shoulders, shaking him.

He simply shook his head.

And then, as he stared mournfully into Izuku’s eyes, Todoroki whispered:

“What just God would allow this to happen?”

And suddenly, the mattress began to dip inward, forcing Izuku to scramble away as it caved in. He stumbled back, tripping over his own feet, falling down. The tile beneath the bed creaked and cracked just seconds before it crumbled, and the space itself collapsed inward, taking Todoroki with it.

And then it was over.

He was gone.

“No.” Izuku whispered. "No, *please."*

The door burst open, several doctors and nurses piling in.

“What’s going—!” One shouted, but they all froze as they witnessed the scene before them. The gaping chasm in the floor remained for only a brief moment longer before it began to reverse itself, the bed returning as the tiles flew back into place, solidifying. Everything was as it was before.

Except Todoroki was no longer there.

“Oh... Oh my—“ One of the nurses whispered, placing her hands over her mouth. Izuku was still slumped on the floor, sobbing. She turned toward him, a look of concern on her face.

“Hey, are you—“

The act of her addressing him set him off. Izuku tensed up, shaking his head, and bolted. He rushed past them into the hallway, hastily wiping his tears away. They just kept coming.

He needed to get out. He needed to be somewhere where he could scream. Normally, he would’ve gone to All Might, but of course, that was a no-go.

It was nearing midnight as Izuku burst out beneath a starry sky. He looked around anxiously, searching for a place to hide, but the hospital exterior was far too sparse.

He didn't really think too much about it when he ducked back into the vacant hospital shuttle, sitting down in the darkest corner he could find before he reached into his bag and grabbed the spine of a familiar book.

Can you meet me on the surface?

It took a minute for Katsuki to respond.

What?

Deku, I'm at home right now

I'm about to go to BED

Please

I'm sorry

PLEASE

What the hell?

What's wrong?

Izuku's fist clenched around the pen, teardrops falling onto the page. There was a sharp, mechanical sound as the car jerkily began to move, carrying him toward the dispatch station.

I watched my friend fall just now

More teardrops fell, staining the parchment. He wondered if Katsuki would receive those, too. He figured he must have, because no sooner after the memo breathed to life did he see his response appear.

I'm on my way.

Chapter End Notes

i'm afraid endeavor has not had his redemption arc in this AU, lol sorry

this chapter took a bit longer for me to finish because i just started a five week long biology course and every week there's a test and it fuckin sucks, but it's the last thing i need to complete my math degree (for some fucking reason). I'm gonna try my best to keep updating fairly consistently, but if I don't, that would be why lol

anyway, damn. fucking angst, huh? yeeeeahhhh. dw tho, todoroki will be way happier ultimately. we've also got even more obvious hints that hell is, in fact, [REDACTED]—COUGH COUGH anyway,,,

djfhdj as always, pls consider leaving a comment if you enjoyed this, as they will serve as sustenance as i attempt to write while struggling through this class lmao. I'm actually extremely nervous about posting this chapter for a variety of reasons but that's neither here nor there. anyway, thanks for reading y'all. next chapter will pick up where this one leaves off, with Izuku meeting Katsuki on the surface. So tune in next time for some of that good, uhhh *gestures vaguely*??? kdjfkdj

Chapter 11: Graduation

Chapter Summary

> One of these days, Katsuki was going to lay it all out for him. Drag him down to Hell and make him look, make it *real.*
>
> Izuku didn't know if he'd be the same person if he found out the grass was greener there.

Chapter Notes

> me, writing chapter 10: no more 9k chapters because i don't wanna set the bar there for future chapters
> me, when i realize chapter 11 is 10.2k words: FUCK
>
> Also, CONTENT WARNING: There are some journal entries in this chapter. Some of them are kinda disturbing. The one labeled #10 in particular, though, contains moderately graphic descriptions of gore/bodily injury. If this is something that bothers you, you might wanna consider just reading like, the beginning and end of that one, skipping the third paragraph, or skipping that entry altogether. IDK up to you, take care of urself friend

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Katsuki stood beside an old, dried up fountain at the center of what used to be a vibrant city, and based on the way he was dressed, Izuku could tell he meant it when he said he was about to go to bed. He was wearing a simple, grey hoodie and what looked to be a pair of black pajama pants, haphazardly stuffed into the tops of his boots. And Izuku didn't think it was possible, but his hair somehow managed to look even more disheveled than usual.

As he approached, Katsuki turned, his posture straightening a bit, tail swaying gently behind him. He looked him up and down, and Izuku could tell from his expression that he looked like a mess.

"Deku…" He murmured.

And for whatever reason, that set him off. The tears began welling up again as the tightness in his throat mounted. Izuku sniffled, eyes downcast as Katsuki closed the distance, removing his hands from his pockets. In the face of his distress, he still felt the passing shadow of

something warm when he noted that, despite his chaotic state of dress, he still remembered to wear gloves.

Katsuki wrapped his arms around him as his sniffles devolved into sobs, tears soaking into the material of his hoodie. Izuku's shoulders shook, Katsuki's gloved hands patting and rubbing his back with a gentleness he had seldom seen in him before. They stayed that way for a while, until Izuku's cries began to wane, and he started to pull back.

"What happened?" He quietly asked. Izuku wiped his eyes on his sleeve, and then his nose. Took deep breaths until he could get himself under control.

It took a few tries before he was able to fully explain the event, and all the while, the Demon kept his hands on his shoulders, gently smoothing up and down his arms.

When he finally got through the full story, Katsuki exhaled softly.

"What's his name?"

"Todoroki." Izuku swallowed. "Todoroki Shouto."

The hands on his arms went still. "Wait, no shit?"

Izuku frowned. "Yeah?" He said. "Why?"

"Baldy's been moaning about that guy for *months,* Deku."

He blinked a few times, brows knitted together. *"Inasa?"*

Katsuki nodded. "He's been moping around fucking *constantly,* cryin' about how the *'love of his life'* doesn't remember him. He's been absolutely fuckin' insufferable." He grinned. "I guess he'll be happy to hear about this…"

He felt a spark of anger inside of him, and clenched his jaw. "Well, that makes one of us."

Katsuki looked back at him again, his smile disappearing. He opened his mouth, but hesitated, as though he were trying to choose his words very carefully. After a moment, he sighed, taking Izuku's hand and coaxing him to come sit beside him on the ledge of the fountain.

"Listen, Deku…" He began. "I know what you just experienced was probably pretty fuckin' upsetting, but it's not like he's fuckin' dead, he's just…" He shrugged. "Y'know. In a different place. He's *safe,* if that's what you're worried about."

"But how do you *know?"*

"Because Hell has a system for dealing with Fallen Angels." He replied. "People don't just spawn randomly in Hell. Not anymore, at least. When an Angel falls from Heaven, they can end up in a couple of places, but they're all well-equipped to handle 'em."

"What does that mean, though?" Izuku asked. *"'Handling them.'"*

“Eh, depends on the person.” He said. “Therapy, usually. But overall, it’s mostly just a place for support and re-education.”

Izuku tensed. “Re-*what?”*

Katsuki gave him an odd look. “Re-education?”

“So you’re going to *brainwash* him?”

“What? No.” He glared, hand tightening around Izuku’s. “It’s *deprogramming,* Deku. Literally the *opposite of brainwashing.”*

Izuku maintained his scowl.

“Deku, I know this might be difficult for you to comprehend, but Fallen Angels are kind of a fucking disaster when they first arrive.” He deadpanned. “We used to not do anything, but after a certain number of attempted coups we realized we kinda fuckin’ had to.”

“Coups?”

“If they can even be called that.” He scoffed.

Izuku frowned, and Katsuki sighed.

“See, the thing about Hell is,” He squinted, gesturing vaguely. “Well, the way shit’s set up in Hell doesn’t really leave room for individuals to gain the upper hand over the rest of us.

“I died after the system was already in place, but according to our records, most of those *‘coups’* were really just self-righteous dipshits standing on rooftops and loudly declaring themselves God-emperor, as though people were supposed to, like—fucking *care,* or something?”

“Why’s that an issue, then? The way you’re describing it just makes it sound like a minor annoyance.”

“It wasn’t an issue, but it could’ve become one.” He said. “Deku, this mindset ain’t an isolated thing. A lot of Angels just have some really fucking weird ideas about, like, power and shit. At some point, you gotta deal with it—preferably *before* there’re enough of ‘em to pose an actual threat.”

Izuku pursed his lips, staring back at Katsuki. Eventually, he dragged his eyes away. He didn’t say it out loud, but he could kind of see where he was coming from. “Whatever…” He mumbled, then took a deep breath. “Look, just… tell me how long he’ll be there.”

“I can’t. It varies. I mean, he can technically leave whenever he wants, but…” Katsuki shrugged. “Well, if what baldy says about their past is true, it probably won’t be long. It’s generally way easier for Fallen Angels to adjust if they’ve got someone in Hell that they care about.” His tone softened. “Deku, trust me. He’s going to be okay.”

“I…” Izuku opened and closed his mouth a few times. “W-Well, even if that’s true…” He bit his lip. “Still…”

He swallowed around the lump in his throat, eyes beginning to water again. Izuku wanted to believe that Todoroki would be alright. He really did. But there was this writhing, jagged feeling in his chest, this weight on his heart that wouldn’t give up. No matter what he did, he couldn’t force himself to believe that this was *good.*

Katsuki sighed, roughly throwing an arm over his shoulder.

“Deku, y’know you’re allowed to just *be upset,* right?” He grumbled. “You don’t have to introduce ethics or fuckin’… *value judgements,* or whatever. You can just *feel sad.”*

Izuku froze, then curled further into his chest. “But… But it’s…”

“I know.”

“It’s—“

“—I know.” He repeated, pulling him closer. A small sob escaped from Izuku’s throat. He gripped the fabric of Katsuki’s hoodie, like it was the only thing keeping him grounded.

After several minutes, he spoke, his voice muffled.

“Kacchan… I’ll never see him again.”

Katsuki was silent for a moment.

“You don’t know that.”

Izuku tensed, and after a second, pulled away. He clenched his jaw, glaring at Katsuki.

“Kacchan, *I’m not going to Fall.”* He spoke through gritted teeth. “And I’m *really* not in the mood to hear about how much you think I will.”

“You don’t have to Fall to see him again.”

Izuku was briefly puzzled.

Then it hit him.

“You mean, like… bringing him to the surface?”

“Well, no. Not exactly.” He said, looking away. “I was thinking more along the lines of bringing *you* to see *him.”* He sat up straight, and stretched his arms above his head. “As in, *bringing you to Hell.”*

Izuku stared at him for a long time, his eyes wide. *“Excuse me?”*

“You heard me.” Katsuki scoffed, side-eying him. “Are there any laws forbidding you from visiting Hell?”

“I-I mean… I don’t *think* so, but—”

“—Then why not?”

Izuku faltered, swallowing. “Why can’t you just bring him to the surface?”

Katsuki paused, licking his lips. “Well, I could possibly pull that off, sure.” He admitted. “But if I’m being completely honest, I have other motives here.”

He narrowed his eyes, “Such as…?”

“Such as *showing you what Hell is actually like,* Deku.” He said, finally turning to look at him fully. “I know you’ve still got a fuck load of internalized ideas about it. You should see for yourself why you’re wrong.”

Ah. Should’ve known.

Izuku scoffed, and mumbled, “Of course…”

“Of course *what?”* He snapped. “Of course I want to show you that my *home,* which you seem to be *so* fucking fond of making unsubstantiated assumptions about, isn’t what you think it is?”

Izuku winced, averting his eyes. Hearing it put like that made him feel a bit guilty.

“I just… I don’t know if I…”

“What?”

Izuku shook his head, and didn’t respond.

Katsuki exhaled, standing up.

“Look, just…” He raked a hand through his messy hair. “Just fuckin’ think about it, alright?”

Izuku stared down at the ground, gripping the fabric of his cloak. It’d be a lie to say he wasn’t at least curious.

Just like it’d be a lie to say the thought didn’t terrify him.

In his exhausted state, he couldn’t tell which feeling outweighed the other. After a moment, he gathered the will to reply.

“Alright.” Izuku quietly told him. “I’ll… I’ll think about it.”

That night, Izuku returned to his room in a daze. Collapsed in his bed and stared at the ceiling, his mind paradoxically both numb and anxious.

Sometimes he wondered if free will actually existed.

Although he did his best not to think about it too much, he could never quite rid himself of that persistent sense of inevitability. It was as though he were on a conveyer belt, and it was slowly but surely carrying him toward this singular end.

Because there were two distinct, irreconcilable images of Hell inside his mind: the version he'd been taught, and the version Katsuki's words had constructed. On some level, he'd convinced himself that these were separate places. It wasn't rational, of course, but it was something he could get behind emotionally, at least for now.

The fact of the matter was, there were certain foundational ideas he'd been taught early on—ideas about the way the world works, about what's right and what's wrong. And just like all people, Izuku had built his belief system off of that groundwork.

There were times when talking to Katsuki made his worldview feel like a game of Jenga.

'Demons are capable of altruism' was the first block pulled. *'Individual Demons can be good people'* was the second. *'Demons, like humans, are probably mostly decent,'* was the third.

None of these were critical. It was entirely possible for groups of mostly well-meaning people to enact evil. Humanity had proven that fact many times over.

He knew that the things Katsuki said about Hell were true for him, but that didn't make them *real.*

Katsuki was real. His relationship with Izuku was real. The fact that, despite knowing his real name, Katsuki never actually used it against him, never forced him to Fall, even though Izuku Falling was his ultimate goal—all of that was real, because he'd seen it. He'd experienced it.

But Hell wasn't real. Or at least, it didn't *have* to be. And sure, his concept of Hell wasn't exactly *foundational,* but it was deep enough in his hierarchy of beliefs to have the potential to destabilize things. Hell was the place where he stored his reservations. It represented the ideas he was too afraid to examine, and too afraid to give up. It both was *and* wasn't the place where Katsuki lived. Hell was the evil built from billions of shards of good, an abstract structure that kept Izuku oriented in a world of ethical ambiguity.

Heaven never needed to be perfect. It didn't even need to be *good.*

It just needed to be *better.*

And as long as Izuku didn't have to see it, he could convince himself that somehow, in some way, Hell was worse.

But then there was that fear, again. That relentless inevitability, underscoring Izuku's existence like an ominous rumble emanating from the tectonics of his reality.

Because one of these days, Katsuki was going to lay it all out for him. Drag him down to Hell and make him look, make it *real.*

Izuku didn't know if he'd be the same person if he found out the grass was greener there.

Two days after the incident, Izuku was lying in bed, holding the journal up in both hands. The overhead light backlit the book and made it a challenge to read, but Izuku was too tired to do anything about it. He stayed still, squinted and dealt with it.

#6

> I'm not really sure how to describe it. I think it's just one of those "know it when you feel it" sort of things. All I can really say is that one moment, I was doubled over in pain with an obsidian spear impaled through my abdomen, and the next moment, I couldn't feel it at all.
>
> I don't mean that in the sense that it was numb. It felt like the wound had healed somehow. I vaguely recall a sort of rush of relief, but after that, it gets fuzzy. I do remember Nana looking very scared when she saw me. She pulled the spear out of me before the wound could heal around it. I didn't even realize it was closing up until then.
>
> I'm still not certain how she knew. I never got the chance to ask, since… well, you know.
>
> Anyway, I suppose I'm one of the lucky ones. It certainly doesn't feel like it, but I acknowledge that it could have been a lot worse. Please be careful out there. If you have *any* reason to suspect soul bleed, get yourself to a medic immediately, consequences be damned.
>
> It's taken me a few months, but I've come to terms with the fact that I won't be able to fight anymore. I'm looking into teaching, and I'm feeling a bit more optimistic these days. Perhaps in some ways this was for the best.

Izuku frowned, staring at the page, reading over it a second time.

Soul bleed?

What is that supposed to mean?

He got his answer the following day, after a firm knock on the door nearly made him jump out of his skin.

After a minute of deliberation, Izuku forced himself out of bed and shuffled over to answer. He slowly opened the door, peering through the crack. To say he was surprised at who he found would be a massive understatement.

"All Might?" Izuku opened the door further.

"May I come in?"

Izuku nodded, stepping aside.

“Oh, uhhh. Sorry it’s so messy, I’ve just been…” Izuku trailed off.

All Might laughed. “My office looks like this on a good day.” He said. “If this is how your room looks on a *bad* day, I think you’re doing just fine, Midoriya.”

Bad day.

“Is that what this is about?”

All Might smiled. “I wanted to check to make sure you’re doing alright.”

“I’m… fine.” Saying it made Izuku wince. He averted his eyes, fidgeting with the hems of his sleeves. “I thought we couldn’t see each other outside of scheduled times, though.”

All Might opened his mouth to respond, but hesitated. “Well, when I heard what had happened, I figured I ought to make an exception.” He finally said.

“But what if you get in trouble?”

He shrugged. “If I do, then it’s my own fault. Nothing for you to worry yourself over, Midoriya.”

Izuku’s brows pinched together, and he looked down at the ground. As seconds ticked by, his eyes began to tear up, a fact which surprised even himself.

“But… how can I *not?* All Might, I—“ His voice broke. “I can’t lose you, too.”

He wiped his tears away, covering his face.

All Might didn’t say anything for a while. When Izuku glanced up at him, he found him sitting there with his mouth open, an odd, almost pained look on his face. He looked down at the floor.

“I don’t… want you to have to bear the burden of thoughts like that.” He eventually said. “I know it’s a moot point, but a student shouldn’t have to worry about their teacher’s safety.”

“But you’re not *just* my teacher, All Might. You’re…” Izuku trailed off, sniffling. All Might stood up, and gently pulled him into a hug.

“I know,” He murmured. “I know.”

Izuku tried to get himself under control, but his shoulders still shook.

“Deep breaths.”

Izuku nodded.

Deep, shuddering inhales. Slow, shaky exhales.

After a few minutes, he managed to reign himself in enough to pull back.

“I’m sorry…” Izuku murmured.

“No, no!” He waved his hands. “Please, don’t apologize. I understand completely. It’s normal for you to feel this way.”

Izuku nodded, staring at his feet.

All Might sighed. “I’m sorry for getting you wrapped up in all of this.”

Izuku looked up. “Wh-What do you mean?”

“Well, uhh…” He gestured vaguely. After a pause, he simply shook his head, chuckling softly. “I wish I knew how to answer that. Lately, it’s felt like being caught up in a maelstrom.”

Izuku offered a weak smile, taking a seat on the edge of his bed again. All Might pulled the desk chair closer, and sat in it backwards, resting his arms on the back.

“Have you been keeping up with the journal entries?”

Izuku blinked. “I, uh—yes. I have.” His brow furrowed. “It’s… All Might, what was that last one? *Soul bleed?”*

“Ah.” His posture straightened. “Right, yes. That was a part of a letter I wrote to a friend a while back, after I retired.”

Izuku tensed. “Wait, that was *you?”* He frowned. “All Might, I thought your injuries came from Hellfire.”

“Some of them did!” He quickly clarified. “But that’s… Well, it’s not the real reason I retired. It was…”

A pause.

“Soul bleed.” Izuku quietly finished. “All Might… what *is* that?”

“Uhh…” He scratched his head, brows pinching together. “Well, you know how Angels are generally considered to be indestructible? At least when it comes to regular physical damage.”

Izuku nodded.

“That’s… not exactly true.” He stated. “There *is* actually a limit to how much physical damage one can sustain.”

“…What’s the limit?”

“It’s…” He squinted. “Well, I can’t really give you an *exact* answer. Like I mentioned in the letter, it’s really more of a *‘know it when you feel it’* sort of thing.”

“What do you mean?” Izuku asked. “What exactly do you *feel?”*

“Let me just start at the beginning.” He sighed. “Essentially, when an Angel crosses a certain threshold of physical damage, the serthus—the fluid inside your soul—begins to leak out into the rest of your body, where it’s used to heal your injuries. This is called soul bleed.

“It’s a physiological phenomenon. A last-resort sort of defense mechanism.” He drummed his fingers on the back of the chair. “The point of this is supposed to be to allow you a chance to escape an aggressor when your injuries would otherwise prevent you from doing so. That’s the idea, in theory.”

“Oh…” Izuku mumbled. “I mean, that sounds like it’d be useful…?”

All Might squinted. “Well, in some ways, I suppose that it is.” He said. “But there are issues. For one, it’s not clear what conditions need to be met to initiate it. Not all severe injuries result in immobilization, but soul bleed has been known to occur regardless.”

“But… is that really a problem?” Izuku blinked. “I mean, if it’s healing you, I don’t really see what the downside could be.”

“Ah,” All Might grinned. “Remember what I told you a few months ago?” He asked. “Midoriya, the problem is that *serthus does not regenerate.”*

Izuku opened his mouth to respond, but nothing came to him.

“Part of what makes soul bleed so dangerous is how quickly it happens.” He went on. “Once it starts, you really only have around fifteen minutes before it’s too late. And even if you manage to get medical assistance in time, it almost *guarantees* you won’t be able to fight anymore.”

“Why not?”

“Well, I’m not an expert, but essentially, it’s actually very important that the soul’s *entire volume* be filled with serthus.” He replied. “If it isn’t, the parts that aren’t in contact with it will dry out and become inflexible, which keeps energy from being able to move through properly.

“I can still use power, but it’s nowhere near as strong. And I have to be extremely careful not to overdo it.” He smiled. “For most Angels, overdoing it isn’t really possible. But when parts of the lining dry out, they become brittle.” He shrugged. “If I’m not careful, my soul could rupture, causing the whole thing to start up again—only this time, I’d have even *less* time to get help before it was too late.”

Izuku frowned. “What do you mean by *‘too late’?”* He asked. “What happens if it all drains out?” His voice fell to a whisper. “Do you… *die?”*

All Might chuckled. “Oh, I wish.”

Izuku's eyes went wide.

"Ah, sorry—" he rubbed his neck sheepishly. "That was a bit morbid, wasn't it?"

"All Might…"

"Let me start over." He said, waving his hands. "When the serthus completely drains from an Angel's soul, they become what is known as a *husk."*

"A… husk?"

"It technically refers to the fact that your soul is, quite literally, an empty shell. But the meaning runs deeper than that." He chewed his lip, hesitating. "It's…" He trailed off, and after a second, he sighed. "What you need to understand is that your soul is… well, it's what makes you, *you.* Without it, you're just…"

A moment of silence.

"An empty husk." Izuku whispered.

All Might looked up at him.

"Yes." He said. "There's an entry in the journal which goes into this in more… detail. The next one, I believe. So…"

He nodded slowly, and for nearly a full minute, neither of them spoke.

Izuku eventually broke the silence.

"All Might…who is 'Nana'?"

"Ah! She was my mentor." He replied. "Your grand-mentor, if you will."

"She saved you, didn't she." It wasn't really a question.

All Might looked down, a sad smile on his face. "Indeed, she did. At the cost of her own soul."

Izuku frowned. "You mean…"

"Yes." He sighed. After a moment, he began to speak again, his tone soft. "Midoriya, I know how it feels to watch someone you care for Fall. It's… a special kind of helplessness."

Izuku swallowed, his throat becoming tight. "Did you ever see her again?"

He shook his head. "Even if I could, finding someone after they Fall can be challenging. Not *impossible,* but…" He shrugged.

"Right." Izuku paused. "Kacchan… actually offered to help me with that."

"Oh, you told him?"

He nodded. “The night it happened. I would’ve gone to you, but because of… Well, you know, I went to him instead.”

“In person?”

“Yes. He, uh, comforted me,” Izuku winced. “Kind of?”

When All Might didn’t immediately respond, he looked up and found him grinning. The embarrassment hit him like a freight train.

“I—I mean, it’s not like,” He sputtered. “Um, y’know, I just didn’t—“

All Might waved his hands. “It’s alright, it’s alright.” He assured him. “Midoriya, I’m happy you’ve found such a good friend in him. A bit surprised, yes, but happy nonetheless.”

Izuku’s face still felt far too hot for his liking. He averted his eyes and muttered a squeaky *‘thanks.’*

“So, he offered to bring him to the surface?”

“Oh! Um, not quite.” Izuku laughed nervously. “He… actually offered to take me to Hell to see him.”

All Might froze, staring at him for a moment.

Then he burst out laughing.

“*All Might?”* Izuku squeaked, embarrassment coming back full force. “What’s so—“

“Sorry, sorry,” he wheezed. “It’s just… Ahh. It’s just funny.”

“What is?!”

“Nothing bad, I promise!”

“Then—!“

All Might raised a hand, putting a stop to Izuku’s incoming anxiety monologue.

“Midoriya, do you know how…” He gestured vaguely. *“Protective*, I should say, Demons are of Hell?”

Izuku frowned. “What do you mean?”

“As someone who’s been around a lot of high-ranking Angels, I can tell you, the few times when we actually tried to negotiate with Demons, it’s always been quite challenging.” He shook his head. *“Everything* needed to be on Earth—which is easy for them, of course, since they can pass as Humans. Not so easy for us, however.” He gestured pointedly back at his wings, and sighed.

“Anyway, the point I’m trying to make is, Demons actually have a surprisingly strong sense of collective responsibility. As a consequence, they’re usually reluctant to do anything that could cause others in their community to feel unsafe.”

“Okay…?” He said. “I still don’t—“

“Midoriya, for Katsuki to simply *offer to bring you to Hell…”* All Might chuckled, shaking his head. “It almost sounds like a marriage proposal of some kind.”

Izuku’s blush flared up again.

“I-It’s—he’s not—“

“I don’t mean that literally, of course!” He put his hands up. “I’m quite certain Demons despise the very concept of marriage, anyway.”

Somehow, that didn’t make Izuku less embarrassed.

They ended up talking for nearly two hours, and when All Might finally excused himself, it was with evident reluctance.

Izuku was happy, though. Despite the ostensibly dark nature of certain parts of their conversation, the lighthearted portions left him feeling alright in the end, and it was nice just to be able to speak with All Might this way. At least for a little while, it was almost as though things were back to normal again.

It was almost enough to convince Izuku that things would be okay.

The next journal entry unlocked at the stroke of midnight, and Izuku was on it almost as quickly.

#7

> I do not like the husks. They have a certain unsettling quality to them—somehow alive, yet simultaneously not. We’ve tried everything we can, but they don’t respond. No talking, no movement, no response to stimuli whatsoever. They just stare into space, breathing slowly, blinking occasionally. It’s not clear whether their minds are still intact, or whether they can hear what we say to them. We haven’t been able to prove it either way.
>
> I try not to think about it too much, but lately, it’s been bothering me. There are times when I look into their eyes, and I just *know* that these Angels are gone. That there’s

nothing left behind that hollow gaze—at least nothing we can recognize.

But then I see that shine in their eyes during the tests, and I start to wonder. The pain sensitivity tests seem to be the only thing that promotes a response, albeit an involuntary one. Thankfully, due to their volatility, the pain inflicted during these tests is necessarily very minor, which is a relief, I suppose. Even this much bothers me, sometimes. I feel like I can feel their pain. Sometimes I wonder if the Councilmen forget that these are still Angels.

The hypothesis the others seem to operate under is that the husks aren't conscious.

I hope they're right about that.

For a few minutes, Izuku just stared at the page in shock. And suddenly, his mind flooded with memories of the boy from level one—the one who'd fallen ill, but by the time that was known, it was already too late. That vacant stare of his still haunted him, even to this day.

Is this what became of him? He wondered. *But… I thought soul bleed only happened after sustaining severe damage…*

Maybe there are other conditions that can cause it?

Izuku shook his head, and sighed.

Well, I suppose I'll just have to wait until our next meeting to ask All Might about it…

All Might wasn't in class the next day.

At first, Izuku didn't think too much of it. All Might was absent more than most teachers. His status as a retired high-level Angel meant that he would occasionally be asked to travel to the innermost circles for the purpose of things like special training events and teaching seminars. It wasn't all that unusual for him to disappear for one or two days every other month or so. The fact that Izuku didn't know about it ahead of time made him a bit anxious, but it was easy enough to dismiss. Given the infrequency of their meetings as of late, it'd be reasonable for All Might to simply forget to mention it to him.

The second day made him a bit more nervous, but he still managed to remain calm enough to put his mind off of it.

And then the third day rolled around, and the sight of the substitute teacher strolling in made Izuku's heart lurch against his chest. He could barely focus for most of the day. He slammed his wings against the edge of one of the rings on the flying field, dislocating it, and wound up having to sit out for the rest of the session.

He'd been too afraid to ask where All Might was. Rationally, he knew that doing so wouldn't raise suspicion, that it was normal for a student to wonder about something like that. But the paranoid thoughts in his mind all seemed to meld together in his state of panic.

Izuku cried out in pain as Uraraka popped his wing back into place. He wiped the tears from his eyes and did his best to regulate his breathing as she sat down beside him with a sigh.

“How are you doing, Izuku?” She asked, after a moment. “I heard All Might was out sick.”

Izuku tensed. “Oh, really?” He said. “Um, where’d you hear that?”

“I asked this morning. It seemed strange for him to be gone more than two days in a row, I guess.” She shrugged. “I don’t want to jump to conclusions, but it seemed kind of…” She bit her lip. “Well, *serious.”*

Izuku felt a rush of cold run through his veins. “I… see.” He gulped. “Well… I hope that’s not the case.”

She hummed in agreement. “Same here.”

“Do you, uh, have any idea what he’s sick with?”

She shook her head. “Sorry. I didn’t really think to ask.” She nodded toward the substitute, who was standing on the sidelines, a whistle held close to his lips. “You could, though. They might know.”

Izuku gulped, anxiety twisting up inside him.

“I think maybe I’ll just go to his house. See for myself.”

“Alright.” Uraraka smiled. “Well, be careful. He might be contagious.”

Izuku forced a returning smile, and that was that.

All Might’s house was a short walk from campus, but that day, it felt like it took an eternity. As he approached, he scanned over the windows, noting that out of all of them, only one light was on—the one in the study. Despite the circumstances, it made him smile. *Typical All Might.* He thought fondly. *He hates wasting energy.*

Izuku ran up the steps to the porch and stopped at the door, taking a deep breath before ringing the bell. He waited. And waited.

And waited.

Nothing.

Izuku frowned, felt a wave of nausea in his stomach.

Don’t panic, he told himself. *If he’s sick, it would make sense for him not to answer.*

After a minute, he tried again. He rang the bell, knocked, even called out, “All Might?”

But still, nothing.

A bead of sweat rolled down the back of his neck.

Either he's not here, or he's too sick to get out of bed, Izuku thought, with a spike of panic.

He managed to reel himself in a moment later.

Or he's just sleeping, he reminded himself. *Stop jumping to conclusions.*

He lingered on the doorstep for a little while longer, but ultimately, he just had to head home.

#8

> Things have been tense lately. It's been a while since any of us last spoke to God. The Council won't tell us anything, though, and it'd be a lie to say I didn't feel frustrated by it. It's just that I don't really understand it. It's such a departure from how things used to be. And I know that things are tense right now. I know that the Council likely feels paranoid. But frankly, if their fear is that transparency could be a detriment if more third spheres Fell, then I'm afraid it might be a self-fulfilling prophecy. Already, I can sense my fellow level nines growing agitated and restless in the silence.
>
> There's a rumor going around that the Council is looking into ways to modify Angels in order to prevent them from Falling. I choose not to believe them, mostly because I'm not sure how I'd feel if this were the case.

Izuku stopped by All Might's house again the next day, and the day after that.

Nothing changed.

Even the light in the study was still on.

#9

> It's hard for me to say whether it's better or worse than Hell at this point. Maybe it's the proximity of it, but I'm inclined to say it's worse. I know it's useless to dwell on it, but I

> wish the Demons could've at least tried to be a bit more flexible. If they'd been willing to negotiate on this, maybe Operation Lacuna wouldn't have been necessary.
>
> I opened the hatch the other day. The fumes inside the place are truly something else—quite literally a misery agent. I'm still not sure if it's chemical, magical, or both, but it's potent stuff. It's supposed to be airtight, but I still hold my breath if I'm within fifteen feet of it. Last time I got a whiff of that stuff, I tried to go in. That's probably the worst part of it. When you're enveloped in it, you stop caring.

He was just doing it as a gesture. Because All Might was absolutely in there. He just wasn't well enough for visitors.

That's what he told himself. It left a bitter taste on his tongue.

It was the fifth day since he'd first visited, and the seventh since All Might's first sick day.

It was a Sunday, so Izuku took the opportunity to prepare a basket, and a nice, soft blanket.

He wasn't much of a chef, as one would expect of an Angel, but he did his best. He got up early in the morning and dusted off the cookbook, opening it up to a recipe for a simple soup. It took a while for him to get it right. His hands weren't steady, and he had to throw it out the first time after accidentally pouring in an entire container of salt.

It took a few hours, but once he was satisfied that it was sufficiently edible, he put the soup into an airtight thermos and placed it in the basket, buried under the blanket.

Though it was generally more socially acceptable for Angels to eat when they were ill, the fact that illness occurred so infrequently meant that most casual observers weren't likely to assume sickness when an Angel was caught eating. When in doubt, it was usually best to keep such things out of sight.

Izuku wrote a simple, unsigned note which read, 'get well soon,' tied a red ribbon around the handle of the basket, and was on his way.

It was still quite early when he arrived, so he didn't ring the bell. He simply set the basket on the doorstep and hoped that All Might would find it.

He crossed his arms, digging his fingernails into the flesh of his upper arms as he strode away.

The light in the study was still on.

#10

I sat in to view the results of the first test, and I've decided to distance myself from this particular project. I know they're sinners, but that doesn't make it any less upsetting. I find it hard to watch people suffer, even when they deserve it.

The gas does more than I originally thought. Apparently, if you spend more than five minutes in there, your senses start to dull. By ten minutes, you can't sense anything at all. Not even orientation, or where your limbs are located in space.

The subjects were fished out after about an hour. It was… disturbing. Neither of them reacted when they were dropped onto the floor. They were shaking and twitching a lot. One of them—the woman—had bitten off the tips of her fingers. The man was worse. When he came out, his chest and throat were spasming, and the lower half of his face was bloody. It took a moment for them to realize he was choking. When they managed to get him to cough the obstruction up, it turned out to be a large portion of his tongue. After washing his mouth out, it was discovered that most of his teeth were broken, supposedly as a result of him grinding them.

I guess this is what happens when someone loses the ability to sense their own strength.

It took a few minutes for the two of them to start regaining their senses. I've never heard a person make a sound like that, and I hope I never will again.

I don't know. I know that punishing sinners is necessary. I'm just not used to having it at the forefront like this. I know that this is God's will. I don't need to understand it. But I can't help it. It keeps me up at night.

When I heard those two screaming, nothing about it felt holy.

The basket was still on the doorstep on Monday.

Tuesday, as well.

The roof of the porch kept it safe from the rain, but Izuku knew the soup would be spoiled. Like a sacred item, however, he couldn't bring himself to move it.

The light in the study was still on.

#11

I can't do this anymore.

I've been afraid to even think it until now, but things have gotten to a point where I can no longer stay silent. The Council is absolutely, unequivocally out of line.

I could tolerate the idea when it was just the sinners being punished, but this expansion is just grotesque. I know that preventing the leaking of intelligence is important, but not every Angel who experiences high levels of corruption is a traitor, and to punish them as though they were is morally repugnant.

I've had enough. I need to find some way to speak with God directly. I need to hear him condemn what they're doing here, for the sake of my friends and my own soul. Because honestly, I'm scared. These thoughts I've been having lately make me feel like a different person. I'm not sure how much the corruption has progressed. I'm too afraid to wash the glue off. Not even fire tea really takes the edge off anymore.

I'll be on a mission tomorrow. We're not expecting the fight to last long, but I need to be careful. I need to hold on, at least until I have a chance to speak with God. If things turn ugly, who knows what might happen.

On Friday, the basket was no longer alone.

Izuku noticed almost as soon as the house was in sight. The house was located in a cul-de-sac a few blocks from the corner where Izuku always turned.

He was too far away to actually feel anything, but the fear that ramped up inside him was still quite real.

The Acolyte stood still on the doorstep. He was facing away, but Izuku would know the look of that white cloak anywhere. Luckily, being so far away meant that the Acolyte didn't seem to notice his presence, but Izuku wasn't looking to push his luck. After a moment of shock, he turned on his heel and marched right back the way he came.

The whole way back, Izuku couldn't walk five steps without checking over his shoulder.

Izuku didn't get a chance to open the journal until later that night.

He didn't even realize it was the last entry until he checked the back cover, and realized that there was nothing written after it. It was odd, considering the fact that the listed page number was only around halfway through the total thickness of the journal.

He was nervous as he turned to the listed page. The past few entries had shaken him nearly enough to overtake his curiosity, and he felt a bead of sweat roll down his temple when he found it.

A cursory glance at the heading left him with an odd mixture of relief and fear, however.

Because unlike all the others, this one was addressed to him, specifically.

#12

Midoriya,

It's difficult to know where to start with this, but you've waited long enough.

First of all, I would like to apologize. I want you to know that I never meant for things to turn out this way. It wasn't part of any sort of grandiose plan. Like you, I am fallible, but that does not excuse my getting you caught in the crosshairs. Six months ago, I did not have all the facts. I was not aware of the extent of the Council's actions, and my greatest regret is involving you before I had everything figured out.

I'm sure you're confused about some of the previous entries. The contents of this journal come from various sources. Some come from my own mentor's notes, others from those of my mentor's mentor. I transcribed them for you because I don't want the information I've gathered to go to waste if something happens, and because I think it's important that you know what I know.

The short of it is, my mentor Fell in order to save me. I witnessed it myself. When an Angel Falls, unless a Demon specifically prevents it, they are automatically transported to Hell. However, a few months ago, I managed to confirm that there is no record of her soul ever having appeared in Hell. This suggests that the magic was intercepted. The list of those capable of doing such a thing is very, very short.

At this point, I need to come clean about one thing in particular.

When I originally suggested you work with Katsuki, I told you it was because I thought demonstrating an ability to resist temptation would make your application for ascension stand out.

This was a lie.

The real reason was far more selfish.

Back then, I was still searching for a way to confirm whether or not my mentor was in Hell. Due to the nature of my retirement, I am unable to leave Heaven, and in the beginning, I had hoped that your connection to Katsuki might allow me to circumvent those restrictions in order to achieve that goal. Of course, I wound up confirming it independently shortly after your partnership with him begun. It was only then that I really started to put the pieces together.

I know that an apology for a mistake of this scale will probably fall flat, but I want you to know that I am deeply sorry. I'm sorry for deceiving you, and I'm sorry for all the suffering that my choice has caused you. I could not have predicted how this would

unfold, but that is no excuse. As your mentor, part of my job is to protect you. I have failed to do so, and that is something I will regret for the rest of my days.

As for this journal, please believe me when I say that I did not decide to tell you all of this out of a desire to cause distress, or put you in danger of Falling. In fact, I think that you may be one of the only Angels capable of processing this information without succumbing to despair. Let me explain what I mean.

What you need to understand is that Falling is a physiological process: the dissolution of the soul's outer shell, which is held together by faith. It's an event which is triggered by either tactile corruption damage, or specific emotional experiences. Experiences which trigger the release of certain chemicals. For the vast majority of Angels, this can only occur under one specific circumstance: losing faith in God. When an Angel loses this, everything else comes crashing down. However, this does not seem to be the case for you.

Over the course of the past six months, I've watched you grow to care deeply for Katsuki. He has become a friend to you, someone you can trust, *despite* what he is rather than *because* of it. Your trust in him does not rely on your trust in God. It is wholly independent. And though I obviously cannot know for certain, it is my belief that, as strange as it may sound, your relationship with him might be the reason you've managed to hold on for so long. Even if you lost every last shred of faith in God, you would still have something to believe in. Of course, this is all just a hypothesis, and so I've done my best to remain cautious.

Now is the part where the "good news" ends. Because if you are reading this, I am already gone. I ask that you do not come looking for me. I ask that you do not attempt to rescue me. I'm painfully aware of the hypocrisy of this request. After all, I got myself into this mess in an attempt to save my own mentor, but I need to at least try to deter you from doing something incredibly brave and stupid.

Of course, I know you well enough to know that you're probably already crafting a plan to save me, even as you're reading this. Fortunately, I've planned for this. As I'm sure you've noticed, this is not the last page of this book. There is quite a bit after this. I did not lock it, but I strongly suggest that you do not read any of it, as much of it is upsetting, and not particularly useful for you to know.

It would be extremely useful to the Demons, however.

Make of that what you will.

The most important thing I need to tell you is this: though I have done everything in my power to cleanse the situation of your involvement, it is still only a matter of time before they come for you, too. I've procured a serum that will wipe my memories to an extent, but no form of memory erasure, even that which God uses on his Angels, is completely infallible. Persistent and sufficient probing will eventually lead to you being implicated.

If there's one thing I've learned from all of this, it is this: Falling is not the worst fate an Angel can meet. On the contrary, compared to the alternatives, it's quite merciful. I

realize this is probably very shocking to read, but please try to understand that I would not be saying all of this if I thought there was a better way.

Midoriya, for your own safety, you need to Fall. Please. Before it is too late. Trust me when I say that, if they get to you first, it will be much, much worse.

Midoriya, I love you as though you were my own son. I'm so proud of everything you've achieved, and I want you to continue thriving. It is ultimately up to you, but I can't stress enough the importance of this choice. I will buy you as much time as I possibly can, but there are many variables beyond my control.

I do not know how long it will have been by the time you read this. I tried to time it so that this entry would unlock a few days after my disappearance, while still allowing you time to process each entry. If it's been under seven days, you have some time to think. I can probably hold out a bit longer than that, but there are no guarantees.

In the unlikely event that it has been more than twelve days, you need to operate under the assumption that you are in ***immediate danger.***

At a minimum, you need to get out of Heaven. In the long run, though… it pains me to say this, but I cannot think of any other option. I know the idea of Falling is scary, but please think about it. I want you to make that choice before someone else makes it for you.

I'm sure you don't need me to tell you this, but it is worth emphasizing:

When the Council takes you, they do not allow you to Fall.

Please take care of yourself.

Toshinori Yagi

Izuku stared at the page for a very long time.

Twelve days, he had said.

He froze.

The day All Might came over was a Sunday. He was gone the next day, which would make Monday the first day, so that's…

Izuku mouthed the days as he counted on his fingers.

He felt a chill run through him, like a block of ice dropping straight into his gut.

"Twelve days." He whispered.

He glanced at the clock.

Thirty minutes to midnight.

Thirty minutes until the thirteenth day.

For a minute, he just sat there, paralyzed. And then the hyperventilation began. Izuku gripped the edge of his desk, black spots appearing in his vision as his mind struggled to come to grips with it all.

They have All Might. They're doing something to him. Some sort of interrogation. Is he okay? Are they hurting him? What if they've turned him into a husk? They wouldn't do that. They wouldn't. Not if they want information from him.

His breath caught in his throat.

That place the journal described. What if he's in there?

Izuku's heart slammed against his chest.

They wouldn't—would they? All Might is susceptible to soul bleed. If they put him down there, he could hurt himself. Unless they restrain him. Unless something has changed.

It felt as if all the blood had been drained from his body, and he could hear it rushing out through his ears. Izuku was shaking.

What do I do? What do I do? He told me to Fall. But if I Fall, I won't be able to return. I won't be able to save him. I need to save him, but… is it even safe to leave now? What if they catch me? Maybe I could—no, that wouldn't work. Maybe—wait, no.

What if they're already outside?

He felt his throat starting to close up, tears blurring his vision.

Think, think, you idiot! You're running out of time! There has to be—

Knock knock.

Izuku screamed. He fell out of his chair, scrambling backward on the floor.

Oh God, this is it. It's over. I'm going to die. I'm going to die. I'm going—

"Midoriya?"

Izuku didn't process it at first.

"Hey, Midoriya? Are you okay?"

Shinsou. Oh, thank God.

Izuku struggled to stand up, nearly tripping over his feat as he went to open the door. Shinsou stood on the other side, looking at him with an almost fearful expression. Before he could even speak, Izuku yanked him inside.

“Woah, hey!” Izuku shut the door, nearly catching Shinsou’s cloak in the process. “Midoriya, what the hell is going on?”

How do I answer that? Why did I let him in. Oh God, this was a mistake, wasn’t it? I made a mistake, this will just—

Shinsou grabbed his shoulders. “Midoriya?” He studied him for a moment. “Crap.” He muttered. “Midoriya, I think you might be having a panic attack. You should probably sit—”

“No.” Izuku reflexively shook his head. “Can’t. I need to go.”

“What?”

“I need to go.” He repeated. “I need to get out of heaven.”

Shinsou’s brow furrowed. “Why do you say that?”

“It’s not safe.”

“What isn’t?”

“Staying here.”

Shinsou faltered. “What makes you think that?”

Izuku looked at the journal, still open on his desk. Shinsou followed the path of his eyes, and started moving toward it.

“No!” Izuku shouted. Shinsou froze. “You can’t! If you read it, you’ll Fall!”

To say Shinsou seemed alarmed would be an understatement.

“I—Okay,” Shinsou nodded, putting his hands up. “It’s okay. I won’t read it.”

Izuku relaxed slightly.

After a moment of uncertainty, Shinsou began speaking again. It was slow, careful, as though he were treading a verbal minefield.

“Midoriya,” he said. “Regardless of what that book says, you are safe right now, in this room. You need to calm down. Take deep breaths. Can you do that?”

After a moment of hesitation, Izuku nodded, but the tightness in his throat made it a challenge.

“Don’t force it.” Shinsou told him. “Go slow.”

Izuku nodded again, and did his best to focus on that alone.

After a couple of minutes, he gradually started to feel normal again. Shinsou handed him a glass of water.

“Thank you,” he mumbled, pressing the cool glass against his forehead.

Shinsou sat on the floor in front of him. “Are you able to talk about it?”

Izuku paused, the edge of the glass pressed against his lip. He wasn’t sure how to explain it in a way that would make sense while still being safe for Shinsou to hear.

He didn’t know what to tell him, so he decided to just say that, or something to that effect. Shinsou hummed, apparently thinking it over.

“Well, if you really don’t think you can tell me everything, then tell me the version that doesn’t make sense.”

“You’ll think I’m crazy.”

“I’ve always thought you were a *bit* crazy.” Shinsou deadpanned. “But I still trust your judgement. Mostly.”

Izuku hesitated. “Uh, let me just—“

He went to take a sip of water, and then wound up downing the entire glass. Shinsou stared at him, one eyebrow raised. Izuku set the glass down gingerly.

He took a deep breath.

“The Council has All Might and they’re coming for me next and if I don’t leave soon the Acolytes will take me and I don’t have a lot of time.”

Shinsou stared at him for a long time, expressionless.

“Well, that’s definitely crazy.”

Izuku’s shoulders slumped. “I *knew* you’d—“

“—I didn’t say I didn’t believe you.”

Izuku faltered.

“So you…” He squinted, *“Do* believe me?”

“I didn’t say that either,” He replied, with a small smile. He dropped it a moment later. “That said, I can tell *you* really believe what you’re saying.”

“So you think I’m crazy.”

“Maybe. That doesn’t necessarily mean you’re wrong, though.” He shrugged. “What’s that quote? I think I saw it in a book, once.” He used air quotes. “’Just cause you’re paranoid doesn’t mean they’re *not* after you,’ or something like that.”

That actually got Izuku to laugh.

“In all seriousness, I don’t know if I believe you or not, but I guess it doesn’t exactly matter.” He said. “You’re going to leave whether I help you or not, so I guess I will.”

“Wait, what?”

“I said I’ll help you.” He stated flatly.

“Shinsou.” Izuku spoke slowly. “I’m pretty sure that’s treason.”

“Actually, it’s only treason if I believe you.”

Izuku held eye contact with him for a while, analyzing Shinsou’s oddly lighthearted expression. It wasn’t that he didn’t think he could count on Shinsou to help him if it came down to it. But for him to offer so readily, without even bothering to try and talk Izuku out of it, was… unexpected.

“Listen, Midoriya.” He sighed. “I had a lot of time to think while I was in the hospital. It’s not like I’ve had some massive change of heart, but I’m trying to be less…” He trailed off, wincing. He paused, closing his eyes and taking a deep breath. “Anyway. All of that aside, if there’s even the slightest chance you might get caught by the Acolytes, then yeah, I would rather do too much than too little.”

“I… Thank you, Shinsou.” Izuku said, smiling softly. Shinsou quickly looked away.

“…Do you have a plan for where to go once you leave?”

Izuku started to say no, but then—

Just fuckin’ think about it, alright?

Katsuki’s words echoed in his mind, and he bit his tongue. After a minute, he cleared his throat.

“…Yes, actually. I do, uh, have a place in mind.”

Shinsou looked at him expectantly. Izuku grimaced.

“Are you going to tell me?”

“I, uhh… I mean, do you *really* want to know?”

He continued to stare at him for a while afterward, blinking slowly. Pointedly. If Izuku didn’t know better, he’d think the dark circles under his eyes had gotten deeper.

“It’s Hell, isn’t it.”

Izuku tensed. “Uhh, no comment…?”

“Midoriya…” Shinsou pinched the bridge of his nose. “You know, I knew you were crazy, but… *wow.”*

“It’s not *that* crazy.” He muttered. “Kacchan will protect me.”

Shinsou scoffed. *“Uh-huh.”*

Izuku frowned. “I’m serious, Shinsou. He really would.”

“Uh-huh, yeah, I know.” He said, with a bizarre, sarcastically sweet cadence. Izuku watched as Shinsou began massaging his temples, his eyes closed, and realized he was quietly counting up to ten under his breath.

Shinsou exhaled, looking up at Izuku. “I know,” he repeated, only this time, it sounded genuine. “I just don’t like it, is all. Which is fine. I’m *allowed* to not like it. *Anyway,”* he suddenly stood. “Do you own anything with like, a hood? Something dark, preferably.”

“Uhh.” Izuku noticed that Shinsou was moving toward the door, as though he already knew the answer. “No? Nothing I can think of anyway.”

“Well, I have something you can wear.”

“Oh!” Izuku stood. “Um, are you sure? I mean…” He trailed off. “You know, it’s possible you won’t see it again.”

“Oh, don’t worry.” Shinsou said. “From what I can tell about that guy’s personality, I would expect nothing less. Be right back.”

Izuku opened his mouth to retort, but the door shut behind Shinsou before he got the chance.

It was around two in the morning by the time Izuku reached the surface. He ducked into the first intact building he saw, which turned out to be an old, abandoned tavern. He held the edges of the dark blue cloak Shinsou had lent him, trying to keep it from dragging through the piles of dust, broken glass, and God knows what else. He set down his bag, took a seat on a barstool, and placed the memo on the dusty countertop.

He found his pen, and set it down beside the memo. He didn’t open it yet. Instead, he took a deep breath and sighed, his elbows on the counter, his head in his hands.

There were too many thoughts swirling around inside his head, too many things he had yet to truly process. Even before the last journal entry, Izuku’s mind had been a mess. He had no reason to doubt the authenticity of any of the journal entries, but that didn’t make it any easier to digest. It was like all those horrific things he’d read about weren’t quite real until he was hit with the possibility of All Might falling victim to them.

All Might’s letter was a tangled ball of emotions and fears lodged in the back of his throat. Izuku hadn’t even allowed himself to look at it again after the first time, as though he were afraid it might unravel and reveal something new, something even more terrifying.

Everything. The lies, the stories, the implications of Nana’s Fall. The not-so-subtle endorsement of treason. The theories regarding Izuku’s resistance to Falling, and the explicit push for him to Fall regardless. There was a part of him that couldn’t wait to hand the journal

over to the Demons, and yet another that wanted to clutch it tight to his chest and never let go.

Izuku was not going to Fall. Not tonight, anyway, and probably not tomorrow. There was still so much he needed to think about. There was still so much he could do. But though he might make it through this stage with his wings and halo intact, he knew, on some deeper level, that this would change things. When he emerged from the depths of Hell, Izuku might still be an Angel. But he wouldn't be the same person.

Izuku opened the memo, and turned to a fresh page. He picked up his pen and pulled the cap off with his teeth. Clutched his wrist with his left hand to try and keep it steady.

Something ends tonight.

Izuku put pen to paper, knowing this could very well be the last thing he ever wrote in the memo. And as he penned the message, he wondered, with the sort of humor one can only engage in under dire circumstances, what a passive observer might think if they were to read it. If someone—with no additional context—were to pick up the memo, read through all of it up to this final point, Izuku wondered what sort of story it would tell.

Maybe they'd read it as a tragedy. Or perhaps just the start of something new.

I need you to take me to Hell.

Izuku closed the memo, and waited to see who he'd become.

Chapter End Notes

aw shit here we go
deku really can't catch a break lately, huh
This chapter was really hard to write, because it's sort of the point of no return. I really had to stop and just make sure that I had all the details for some of the background shit fully hammered out, otherwise it would've been very easy to accidentally throw something in here that just fucked everything up lmao. I'm still extremely nervous about this one, though. There were many choices made here that I spent a long time going back and forth on, ESPECIALLY in All Might's letter. Keep in mind that All Might isn't telling izuku EVERYTHING in that letter, like yknow, the details of how he managed to confirm that Nana never wound up in Hell. You could probably make some guesses about that based on some of the stuff way back in chapter 1, tho. anyway sjdfksjf I hope it turned out okay

Anyway, man i’m so FUCKIGN excited about the next few chapters. I call it "the hell arc" in my head, though "arc" is probably not the right word, because it's like,,, two chapters, lmao. still, it’s gonna be. so fucking fun i am STOKED kdjfkdj

as always, pls leave a comment if you enjoyed these to appease fucked up zoomer brain. This one's scary to post. anyway, tune in next time for part 1 of deku’s inferno i guess lol

Chapter 12: Inferno I: No Gods

Chapter Summary

"Welcome to Hell, Deku."

Chapter Notes

This is 15.2k
fucking asdkjfk jfUCK
pls enjoy

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izuku knew that the likelihood of Katsuki responding soon was slim, given how late it was, so he opted to find a place to stay the night. He ended up in a small motel near the tavern; the covers were a bit dusty, but once he'd pulled back the comforter, it was tolerable. Unfortunately, sleep did not come easily.

Every time Izuku closed his eyes, it was like his mind just flooded with millions of what-if scenarios. He didn't know where this path would lead him, or how things would play out once he got to Hell. There was a part of him that wondered if it might be best for him to just stay on the surface, give Katsuki the journal and let him handle it. But that would be dangerous. Although Acolytes weren't involved in combat, that did not preclude them from traveling to the surface. There was a real possibility, albeit a slim one, that they could track Izuku down, and the probability of that happening only increased the longer he stayed there. Anyway you sliced it, the surface just wasn't a very safe place to stay long term.

Of course, whether or not Hell would actually be *safer* was a whole other question. Sure, he might be safe from the Acolytes, but what of the other Demons? Izuku remembered what All Might had told him during their last meeting, about how difficult it was for Angels to arrange diplomatic meetings in Hell. Who knew how long it'd been since the last time an Angel had been allowed in? Sure, Izuku could *get there*—Katsuki had already offered—but what would happen once he arrived? How would people react to his presence? Would they distrust him? Is there a chance things could turn violent?

Izuku smacked himself. He understood that there was no use pondering that which was currently unknowable, but no matter how much he tried to clear his head, something always dragged him back. He just laid there, staring at the water-damaged ceiling of the abandoned motel room. He was beginning to wonder if he'd ever sleep again.

He wasn't sure how many hours passed, only that by the time he managed to drift off, the light from outside had begun to bleed into the dark room.

He woke to the sound of heavy boots hitting the floor, and sat up with a start.

"Couldn't have waited 'til a reasonable hour to drop that bomb on me?"

The tension eased away once he saw him. Katsuki was standing in front of the window, which he'd evidently melted a hole into on the way in, and he looked almost as tired as Izuku felt.

"Kacchan."

"Don't *'Kacchan'* me," He grumbled, striding over to him. He leaned forward and flicked Izuku's forehead with gloved hands. "Your little message made me choke on my fucking coffee, y'know. What's with the sudden change of heart, *huh?"*

Izuku opened his mouth, and then the memories of the previous day all came rushing back to him. He felt a heavy weight sink into the pit of his stomach. For a while, he just sat there, his mouth hanging open. Katsuki's brow wrinkled, and he moved a bit closer, looking Izuku up and down.

"Fuck, Deku." He said, his tone softer. "You look like you haven't slept in fuckin' *days.* What's goin' on?"

He took a deep breath, sitting up properly. And to the best of his ability, he explained the situation to Katsuki.

When he finally got through the whole thing, Katsuki took a deep breath and exhaled, leaning back against the wall, his arms crossed.

"…Well, that's certainly somethin'," Katsuki muttered. "You got the journal with you, I assume." Izuku nodded. "Can I see?"

Izuku gestured toward his bag. "It's in there."

He opened the rucksack up and pulled out the leather-bound notebook, took a seat on the edge of the bed and started to flip through it. Izuku watched his expression carefully as he read. There were times where Katsuki seemed completely unfazed, and others when he seemed somewhat surprised.

Once he reached the latter half of the journal, however, that surprise became a lot more consistent. After only a few pages, Katsuki closed the journal, and looked at Izuku seriously.

"You're sure the info in here is correct?"

"I can't think of any reason why it wouldn't be, at least to the best of All Might's knowledge."

Katsuki nodded, putting the journal away. “Well, I know the others will at the very least be interested in this.” He stood, and started to say something else before he stopped himself, regarding Izuku critically. “Was about to ask if you were ready, but you look like you’re about to drop dead.”

Izuku was quick to push back, shaking his head. “I’m fine, I promise!”

Katsuki scoffed. “Did you even fucking *sleep?”*

“I did!”

“How long?”

Izuku opened his mouth, but stopped himself. He bit his lip and averted his eyes.

“Deku.”

“I’ll… I’ll make up for it tonight!”

“Look, Deku.” He sighed. “The process of getting an Angel to Hell? Bit more complicated than getting a human there. I don’t wanna have to carry your ass after you fuckin’ pass out. Just go back to sleep for a few hours and we’ll—”

“—No!” Izuku interrupted him, much louder than he intended. He flushed slightly. “Kacchan, I… I don’t want to waste any time. All Might’s already been missing for almost two weeks. Who *knows* if he’ll even—”

He couldn’t find the strength to finish that sentence.

Katsuki was silent for a moment, then groaned. “Alright, fine. We’ll leave now.” Izuku perked up.“But you’re going straight to sleep as soon as we get there.”

Izuku deflated again.

“But the—“

“—I’ll handle the journal, Deku.” Katsuki cut in. “I know who to take it to. You can come with me tomorrow morning to actually discuss it. He’s gonna need some time to read through the whole thing and analyze it, anyway.”

Izuku took a breath, preparing to fight back some more, but no response came to mind.

“You still wanna argue with me?” Katsuki raised an eyebrow. “‘Cuz at this point, you’d just be fighting the reality that time is linear and that actions occur over non-zero intervals of it.” He deadpanned. “I’m really not in the mood to debate you on the lower limit of fucking *duration.”*

Izuku blinked a few times.

Was that supposed to make sense?

Maybe I'm more tired than I thought…

"…Alright. But first thing in the morning tomorrow, okay?"

Katsuki nodded. "We'll leave when you're ready."

Izuku finally got up, grabbing Shinsou's cloak and pulling it over his head before he began looking for his shoes.

"What the *fuck* is that?"

His back straightened, eyes widening a bit as he looked at Katsuki. "Oh, this?" He pinched the fabric of the cloak. "Shinsou actually gave it to me. I didn't have any dark cloaks."

Katsuki stared at him for a long time, his jaw tight. Eventually, he tore his eyes away. "Well. You don't need it anymore, so you can just leave it behind."

Izuku frowned. "I can't do that, I'd feel bad."

"Then take it off and put it in your bag."

"But—"

"—Deku, it's fucking *June,* and we're going to *Hell."* He interjected. "If I end up havin' to carry you 'cuz your *dumb ass* passed out from heatstroke, I swear to *fuck* I'll kick your ass."

He was a bit startled by how emphatic Katsuki was being, but ultimately, he had to concede his point. He removed the cloak, carefully folding it and storing it in his bag.

"Ready!"

Katsuki nodded, and headed for the motel door, prompting him to follow.

"So, how exactly is this going to work?"

"Well, like I said, the process of getting an Angel to Hell is a bit more involved than it is for Humans." He shrugged. "Not too bad, but it's a bit of a hike. Hope you're wearin' comfortable shoes, nerd."

Apparently, Katsuki's definition of 'a bit of a hike' was a two hour long trek through the forests of northern Estonia.

"Are you *sure* we can't fly closer than this?" Izuku asked. There wasn't any sort of discernible trail this far out, and between watching where he was stepping, ducking under branches and keeping pace with Katsuki, Izuku quickly grew tired.

"Y'can't see it overhead. That's the point." He told him, not even bothering to look back.

Katsuki pushed past a small branch, causing it to smack Izuku right in the face as he treaded the same path right behind him. Izuku winced, a small, involuntary noise coming from his throat. Katsuki muttered a quick *'sorry,'* but something about the grin on his face made his remorse seem insincere.

Izuku mumbled something under his breath, taking a seat on a mossy boulder. It took a moment for Katsuki to realize he wasn't following him anymore. He paused, turning around and regarding him with one eyebrow raised.

"Am I gonna have to carry you after all?"

"No." He muttered, rolling his eyes. "I just need a minute." He pushed his bangs back with a sigh. The climate out here was fairly cool, but the humidity stuck to his skin in ways that made him wish he could somehow take it off. Katsuki didn't seem fazed by it. He leaned his shoulder against a tree, examining his nails performatively. After a few minutes, Izuku stood up, giving Katsuki a small nod and following him again. To his credit, Katsuki slowed down a bit—just enough for Izuku to walk alongside him, where the width of their path permitted.

"So, are you just used to this kind of thing, or…?"

Katsuki shrugged. "Compared to the forests in Hell, this is nothing."

Izuku did a double take. "Wait, there are *forests* in Hell?"

He side-eyed Izuku. "Well, duh. Hell's a big place, Deku. There's all kinds of biomes, even tundras." He smirked. "Places where Hell has literally frozen over."

"That's… unexpected."

Katsuki grunted.

"'Course, on the whole, the climate skews hot, and most of the environment wants to kill you. If you've ever been to Australia, it's a bit like that."

"Huh…."

Katsuki pushed a branch out of the way, and Izuku perked up at the familiar sight up ahead.

Black fence stretching into the distance on either side of a large, iron gate, enclosing an apple orchard that seemed to go on infinitely. Katsuki pulled the gate open, holding it for Izuku. The moment Izuku set foot in the orchard, it was as though he were in a completely different place. The air was dry, the temperature moderate, and the sound of birds and wildlife that once surrounded them abruptly ceased. All that could be heard was the faint sound of wind blowing gently through the trees, perfect, red apples swaying in the breeze.

It was bizarre. Unsettling. A strange, liminal energy seemed to pervade the orchard, and a chill ran down Izuku's spine as Katsuki closed the gate behind them.

"This isn't Hell, is it?"

“Nah.” Katsuki shook his head. “It’s more like purgatory, I guess.”

“Oh,” He said. “Then how do we get to Hell from here?”

“Well,” Katsuki arched an eyebrow. “If you were *human,* all you’d need to do is pick an apple and take a bite.”

“But I’m not.” Izuku frowned. “So what does that mean?”

“Means we gotta keep walking.”

And walk they did. And for a little while, nothing really happened. They just continued on through the aisle of trees, traveling in a straight line, and everywhere he looked appeared essentially identical.

But then, at some point, things started to change. Izuku couldn’t say for certain when it was; it was so gradual, he didn’t even notice at first. It wasn’t until around fifteen minutes in that he actually registered it consciously.

It started off normal enough. The trees were just a little bit taller, their branches a little more vertical.

Twenty minutes in, the trees had begun to grow at an odd angle, their trunks arcing inward along their path, as though they had all turned toward them, watching them specifically. It made Izuku nervous in a way he couldn’t fully describe.

“Kacchan…” He swallowed. “What’s going on?”

“We’re gettin’ closer.”

“And that’s related to why the trees are—”

“—Yep.”

Izuku nodded, though he knew he couldn’t see. He just continued to trail behind him, trying to will his goosebumps away. Several times, he had to apologize for stepping on Katsuki’s heels.

At the half-hour mark, all the trees were growing on distinct curves, forming arcs overhead that brought the tops of those across from each other together. It was at that point that Izuku realized what was actually happening.

It’s like…

They’re forming a tunnel around us…?

The arcs became more extreme, eventually pushing the tops of each tree into direct contact with the ground, and then it was as if they were growing straight through it.

The space between one tree and the next began to shrink, and after around forty-five minutes of walking, the trunks were locked so tightly together, all Izuku could see were tiny slivers of morning light overhead.

Their path was no longer straight, and it was beginning to get very dark. Izuku needed to run his fingers along the tree trunks to keep himself on track. After around five more minutes of this, the ambient light slowly returned.

And then it ended.

The tunnel opened into a small, circular enclosure of sorts, roughly six feet in diameter. The walls were organic, packed with winding brown tendrils that stretched high into the sky. It took him a moment to recognize what he was looking at, though it eventually hit him that the walls were, in fact, roots, and the floor was the simply the base of a massive tree. Izuku looked up, squinting at the tiny speck of blue many feet above him, the only confirmation he had that they were still on Earth.

When he glanced at Katsuki, he found him rummaging through his bag, pulling out a pair of gloves and a hoodie. He put the gloves on first, then pulled the hoodie over his head.

“C’mere.”

Izuku blinked. “Sorry?”

Katsuki grumbled, simply taking Izuku by the shoulders and pulling him against his chest. Izuku’s breath caught in his throat, his face going hot. Hesitantly, he wrapped his arms around Katsuki’s back.

“U-Um.” He squeaked. “Is this it…?”

“Mm.” Katsuki pulled him even tighter to his body. “Stay close to me, nerd.” He told him. After a second, he tacked on, “Oh—and try not to puke.”

And with that ominous statement, it began. Izuku became transfixed as the roots around them started to glow a strange, otherworldly red. His arms constricted further around Katsuki when they started to move toward them.

“S’okay. Don’t worry.” Katsuki said, as a few started to wrap around them, like serpents capturing their prey.

The process sped up as more and more roots joined in, encasing them in a tight cocoon of luminous red, so bright Izuku had to close his eyes and hide his face in Katsuki’s chest.

After a moment, it began to move, pulling them down into the Earth, or perhaps the trunk itself. At the same time, Izuku noticed an odd gravitational shift, and realized that they were slowly rotating. A minute or so passed, and it felt like he was lying on top of Katsuki. Pretty soon, he was fully upside-down.

The tendrils stopped for a moment, and then quickly unraveled, revealing a small room of sorts inside a massive, hollow tree trunk. There was a doorless opening in front of him, but it

seemed to be upside down.

Even more strangely, however, was that Katsuki was, too.

“One sec.” He called out. Stepping outside and disappearing for a moment, before coming back with a red apple in hand. He offered it to Izuku.

“You gotta eat this.”

Izuku took the apple, eying it warily. He was still unsettled by the fact that Katsuki appeared to be abiding by completely different laws of physics.

“This won’t hurt me, will it…?”

“Nah.” He said. “Deku, you ain’t the first Angel to come here. Just take a bite so we can keep going.”

Izuku shrugged, and then sunk his teeth into the flesh. He wiped the juice off his lips as he chewed, glancing at Katsuki, who had his arms held out in an odd way. He frowned, swallowing the bite before asking, “Why’re you—“

Suddenly, the pull of gravity reversed, and Izuku fell from the ceiling with an undignified yelp. Katsuki caught him with a low grunt, and set him down on his feet, but the shift was so abrupt, Izuku very nearly vomited up the bite he just swallowed.

“Y’good?”

Izuku was clutching Katsuki’s gloved hand, leaning heavily against him as he waited for the dizziness to pass.

Finally, he took a deep breath, and exhaled. “Yeah.”

“Well, then.” He grinned, gesturing toward the opening. Katsuki stepped through it, pulling Izuku along with him.

His breath caught in his throat. For a while, all he could do was stare.

The sky was a pale, reddish orange, and scattered across the expanse were a number of clouds, some grey in color, others a bit more yellow. They were standing right on the edge of a cliff which towered over a vast valley of bronze soil, the various plants dispersed throughout painting it in the colors of a sunset on Earth, as far as the eye could see—which wasn’t especially far. There seemed to be a fair amount of dust suspended in the air near the ground, and the further he looked, the more the low-lying areas seemed to fade.

Out on the horizon, Izuku could see tall, jagged mountains cutting into the sky, some of them stationary, while others had thick columns of smoke rising from their peaks.

Peering down the cliffside, he found a long, winding black stairway, leading down to a platform of sorts.

“This is Serpent’s Crossing,” Katsuki said, breaking him out of his trance. “And that,” he pointed to the right, “That’s where we’re headed.”

Izuku followed the path of his finger, and his breath caught. Out in the distance, a large mass of something carved through the dust, and Izuku realized it was a city of some kind. It was lit up in a few places, and tall, twisting structures stretched up into the sky.

“Oseryth.” Katsuki said. “That’s where I live.”

Suddenly, something zipped by below them, making Izuku jump. “What was *that?”*

“Oh, that’s just the train.” Katsuki shrugged. “Speaking of, we should probably head down there so we can catch the next one. But first…”

Katsuki reached into his rucksack and pulled out a small, satin bag. “Here.” He handed it to Izuku.

He pulled open the drawstring and looked inside. When he pulled it out, he realized it was a necklace of some kind.

“What is this?”

“An artifice.” He replied, hoisting his bag over his shoulder again. “Makes you look like one of us. Figured you wouldn’t wanna attract too much attention.”

“Oh.” *That’s thoughtful…* “I didn’t even know things like this existed.”

Katsuki raised an eyebrow. “Deku, I know you know about the double agent defector incident. Did’ya think Izaiya and Setsuko just strolled in here, white wings, halo and all, said, *‘Hello, fellow Demons,’* and that was that?”

Izuku scoffed. “I knew they had disguises, Kacchan.” He rolled his eyes. “I just didn’t know the details of how they worked.”

Katsuki grunted. “Well, put it on. We should get going.” He muttered. “Don’t wanna stay out here for too long.”

“Why not?” Izuku unhooked the necklace, bending slightly to hook it around his neck. He adjusted the artifice’ position on his chest, but he didn’t actually feel any different.

“Most of the animals and at least half of the plants out here are aggressive, so it’s just—“ He faltered. “Just… uhh…”

Izuku looked up and found Katsuki staring at him with an odd look on his face. “What? Did it not work?”

“Oh, *it worked.”*

“Really?” Izuku frowned, glancing back at his wings. “Why can’t I see it, then?”

“Doesn’t work on the person wearing it.”

“Oh…” He rubbed the back of his neck awkwardly. “Well, um. How do I look, I guess…?”

“Gorgeous.” His response was immediate.

Izuku’s cheeks flared up, but before he could respond, Katsuki was grabbing him by the wrist, pulling him toward to stairs. “C’mon.” He said. “Next train comes in a few minutes.”

He followed Katsuki as they descended the long, winding stairway. It took a minute, but when they finally made it to the platform, Izuku sighed, standing beside Katsuki, waiting.

“Um.”

“Hm?”

“Will there be a lot of people?” Izuku fidgeted with the necklace. “On the train.”

Katsuki hummed. “Probably not, this time of day.” He replied. “But just so you know, your wings are still there. They’re just invisible. So, y’know. Try not to let anyone bump into you.” He shrugged. “On the off chance it’s crowded, you can stand with your back to the door, maybe.”

Izuku bit his lip, nodding silently. A few minutes later, the train arrived, slowing to a stop in front of them so quickly, Izuku briefly wondered if the laws of physics were different here. The doors slid open, and he held his breath as they stepped inside.

There weren’t a lot of people in their car, and none of them distinctly looked at him, apart from a few brief, passing glances. Nonetheless, the fact that Izuku couldn’t see his own disguise made him nervous, and he shuffled in place, staring down at the ground to avoid making accidental eye contact with anyone.

The doors slid shut, and the train began to move. *Very quickly.*

Izuku released a small yelp, stumbling back against Katsuki, who was holding a handrail, smirking as he caught him.

“S-Sorry.”

“I gotcha.”

Izuku sheepishly turned away, looking out the window. The train was moving too fast for him to see much more than a formless blur of red and orange, punctuated by the occasional flash of glowing matter that Izuku could only assume to be hellfire. Then the train entered a tunnel, throwing the outside world into a darkness that persisted for a few minutes before they emerged.

Shortly afterward, the train began to slow, just enough for Izuku to make out their surroundings. The terrain was largely rocky and mountainous, so he couldn’t see too far out most of the time, but he saw a few things he’d never forget. A lake of fire, glowing bright in

the distance. At one point, he watched a large *'tree'* snatch a bird right out of the air with its branches before proceeding to swallow it through a cavity inside its trunk.

Overall, it was pretty on par with what he'd expected Hell to be like.

But after a few minutes, the brutal landscape became tamer, and the appearance of buildings became increasingly common. Eventually, the train passed through a membrane of some kind, and slowed to a stop. A voice sounded over the intercom.

"Savaek station, Savaek station."

Katsuki took his hand, and Izuku allowed himself to be pulled out onto the obsidian walkway, leading into a large structure embedded in the mountainside.

Izuku looked around as Katsuki led him inside. It almost felt like an actual cave; the orange walls curved up smoothly into the ceiling, and embedded within them were large patches of yellow, luminescent stone that spread warm light throughout the station. Around fifty feet ahead, he saw five large, glass columns that extended through the ceiling. He didn't actually realize they were elevator shafts until a platform descended down into the chamber, stopping to let a group of six people out.

Katsuki pulled him into an empty elevator, and it began to ascend. They passed through the ceiling, and for a moment, it was dark. Eventually, they emerged in a large, outdoor area, only partially embedded in the mountain. He followed Katsuki out onto the terrace, and as they approached the edge, Izuku had to stop and stare.

The platform was elevated a few stories above the ground, and Izuku gripped the railing, mouth gaping as he took in the city below.

The buildings in Oseryth were notably tall, and oddly organic-looking in form—which seemed to work well, considering most of them appeared to have plants growing off the sides. To his right, he saw a staircase leading toward the ground, and to his left, a staircase leading to an upper platform, from which train tracks emerged. He traced the path of the tracks, and was immediately struck by the way that many of the buildings seemed to be built around the railway, leaving gaps in the structure through which the trains could pass. A couple of the buildings were also connected by covered bridges high in the sky, on which pedestrians walked.

Overall, there seemed to be a strong emphasis on building *up* rather than *out.* Perhaps this was the result of Demons' ability to fly being actively incorporated into the architecture, but there didn't seem to be very many people around who were more than partially shifted. Maybe it was simply their way of making the most of the space.

Izuku finally turned his gaze downward. Interestingly, although there *were* paved roads, there were no actual vehicles in sight, and most of the Demons seemed to operate as though they didn't exist at all.

Perhaps most striking, however, was the place just across the street from the station. The park was covered in violet grass, and scattered with crimson trees that grew from the ground like

corkscrews.

Not too far from them, a man sat alone on a bench, reading. Off to the left, a woman stood before an easel, brush moving across a canvas as she painted what appeared to be a normal, water-filled pond, just in front of her. On the other side of the pond, five people sat together on a picnic blanket, eating. *Laughing.*

Izuku gulped, gripping the railing harder.

He wasn't really sure what he was feeling. Up until that point, he'd been so overwhelmed by the bizarre aesthetic that he hadn't been able to properly contextualize it in his mind. The sound of laughter was like an alarm bell, breaking him out of his stupor and reminding him that this was a place where people lived, where people *laughed.*

A place in Hell, where happiness still exists.

"Deku?" The sound of Katsuki's voice made him jump, squeezing his hand tightly as he finally tore his gaze away. "You good?"

Izuku wasn't sure how to answer that. His eyes kept drifting back toward the park.

"We still got one more train to go." He said, nodding toward the upper platform. "But we can come back here later, if you want."

Not knowing what else to do, Izuku swallowed and nodded mutely, adjusting his grip on Katsuki's hand and following him up the stairs. They entered a partially enclosed area, and waited near the tracks. It wasn't long before the train rolled to a stop before them. They paused to allow others to get off before boarding themselves.

Izuku sighed, turning to look out the window. It was only then that he noticed it—the large mural sprawling across the opposite wall.

It was an abstract design, filled with a rainbow of chaotic, swirling colors. But out of the madness, something else seemed to emerge. Izuku squinted, leaning toward the window as the doors slid shut, and realized that there were words.

No Gods, he read, straining to decipher the rest. But by then, the mural was just a smear of color retreating into the distance.

They arrived about twenty minutes later at a station near the center of the city, and once they got off, Izuku followed Katsuki down the stairs and across the street.

"It's just a few blocks from here." Katsuki told him, bumping shoulders as they walked down the sidewalk together.

They crossed the street again, turning the corner into what appeared to be a large market of sorts. Izuku was so distracted by the strange look of some of the food set out, he almost missed the fact that no one seemed to be distinctly tending to any of the tables. He frowned.

Maybe they have some sort of anti-theft technology?

On one of the tables, there sat a large box of those fruits Katsuki liked—*embrites,* Izuku recalled—and as they passed, Katsuki grabbed two off the top and continued walking.

Izuku felt a spike of panic. “Kacchan, did you just *steal* those?”

“Hm?” He looked at him, his expression bewildered, as though he didn’t even understand the words Izuku was saying. But he could see the cogs turning in his head the longer Katsuki stared at him. Something clicked, and he burst out laughing. “Oh, shit.” He wheezed. “I guess I never told you, did I?”

“What?”

Katsuki shook his head, stashing one of the fruits in his bag, and taking a bite out of the other. “Thing is,” he swallowed before continuing, “That’s not really how shit works here.”

Izuku raised an eyebrow. “What does that even *mean?”*

“Outside of shit like…” He squinted. “I dunno, breaking into someone’s home and taking their toothbrush, or maybe grabbing a park bench and running away, *‘stealing,’”* he used air quotes, “doesn’t really exist down here. Least not in the sense you’re probably used to.”

“...So everything’s just *free?”* He asked, incredulous.

He just shrugged. “We don’t really have any reason to have, like, a monetary system. Post-scarcity and all that.” He took another bite.

“But what stops people from hoarding resources?”

Katsuki rolled his eyes. “Why do you think that’d be an issue?”

“…Because people are selfish?”

“Nah, that's where you're wrong, nerd." He clicked his tongue. "People ain't selfish, they're just *self-interested.”*

Izuku frowned. “Is there a difference?”

“People wanna survive and be happy. That’s self-interest. That’s *natural.”* He explained. “Selfishness is, like… self-interest at the expense of other people, I guess. It’s not usually a widespread problem unless you live in a society that, like, *rewards* that type’a behavior, or makes it necessary for survival.” He took another bite of the embrite, licking his lips.

“Far as people are concerned,” He continued, “I think there’s really only two things you can say about our nature.” He held up a finger. “First is that we’re self-interested—I wanna survive, and I wanna be happy. No shit.” He raised another finger. “And second is that we’re social—y’know, there’s a *reason* puttin’ people in solitary tends to make ‘em go crazy; we rely on others to know what’s real and what ain’t.” He shrugged again. “Outside those two, I think people are pretty malleable.”

“I’m…” He squinted, “Not really sure what point you’re trying to make.”

“I’m just sayin’, before you make big generalizations about people’s nature, you should think about the broader context.” He said. “Like, yeah, maybe it *is* the case that people are inherently *X.* But it might also be the case that they’re not, and it just seems that way ‘cuz they live in a world that incentivizes *X* behavior. Maybe without that influence, people would tend to act different.”

Izuku just stared at him for a while, his arms crossed as he walked alongside him. Katsuki took another bite, the red juice staining the corners of his mouth. He glanced at him out of the corner of his eye, and groaned, slowing his pace a bit.

“Deku, lemme put it like this.” He said, exasperated. “If you’re at a party with your friends, and they’re all eating cake or whatever, what prevents you from eating the entire cake?”

He blinked. “I…” Izuku squinted. “Where are you going with this?”

“Humor me.”

“…Is this going to be another tomato plant analogy?”

“No, but it could become one, if you don’t answer the damn question.” Katsuki replied, smiling ominously.

Izuku shot him a mild glare.

“Well?”

He sighed. “I mean…” He scratched his head. “I don’t know, Kacchan. I feel like that’s probably physically impossible.”

“Yes,” Katsuki said. “Much like you have a limited reserve of piss with which you can water a tomato plant, you also have a limit to how much you can eat before you get sick.”

“Kacchan.”

Katsuki snorted, teeth sinking into the embrite. He chewed and gulped the bite down. “Anyway, what if you could, though? Like, what if you could eat the whole cake at once and still enjoy it? What stops you *then?”*

Izuku scratched his head. “I mean, that’d still be pretty inconsiderate. I wouldn’t want to be rude…”

“Well, there’s your fuckin’ answer, nerd.” He took another bite, and spoke with his mouth full. “The reality is, when ya think about it, there ain’t really a *point* in hoarding most shit unless you can sell it. If ya can’t, then its only value is personal. Like, the actual *use* you get outta it.”

They turned a corner, continuing down the sidewalk.

“You can’t eat an entire cake at once, so after a few slices, it stops being valuable to you.” He paused to finish off the embrite, licking the juice off his fingers. “And that goes for basically everything else, y’know. Like, there’s no reason to own fifty TVs, ‘cuz after the first few, they just become useless. That’s the only kinda value that matters down here.”

A moment later, they reached the entrance to a tall, twisting building. “This is me,” Katsuki said, leading Izuku up the stairs and inside. Katsuki punched a button on the wall. “And even if something’s still useful in excess, social pressure usually keeps you from taking more than your fair share.”

The doors opened up, revealing a glass elevator, not unlike the one at the station. They stepped inside, the doors closing behind them. Izuku was momentarily distracted by the view —the city shrinking down before his eyes.

“I mean…” he eventually said. “I guess I can sort of understand the first part, but… Not everyone *cares* about being rude, Kacchan.”

“That’s the thing, though, Deku. They don’t have to.” He grinned. “Shitty behavior has consequences that even the biggest assholes can understand.”

“Such as…?”

Katsuki hummed. “Y’know, one time a few years ago, before this whole shitshow started, I was on the surface—unshifted, obviously.” He said. “I remember going to this coffee shop and watching this woman just fucking scream at the barista. I think it was about an expired coupon, or something.” He shrugged. “Anyway, at one point, I heard her say something like, ‘you have to do this, I’m a paying customer.’ Manager comes out, screaming bitch ends up gettin’ what she wants.”

The elevator dinged, opening out into a small sitting area. They stepped off, and Katsuki paused, turning toward him.

“You know what happens if someone pulls that kinda shit down here?”

Izuku looked to the side, then back at Katsuki. “What?”

“The barista throws ‘em the fuck out. The end.” He smirked. “There’s no obligation to serve someone who’s bein’ an asshole.”

“Huh…” Izuku scratched his head. “I mean, I guess that sounds better, at least *in theory.”*

Katsuki began walking again, and gestured for Izuku to follow. “Point I’m tryna make is, down here, your needs are provided for, but your desires are a different beast. If y’want something, being an asshole *literally* jeopardizes your ability to get it.” He smiled. “Some societies make good people act shitty. Down here, we believe in makin’ shitty people act *good.”*

They turned the corner into a hallway, and Izuku trailed closely behind Katsuki, until they reached a door near the end. Katsuki stopped, reaching into his pocket and pulling out a key.

“It just seems so…” Izuku frowned. “I don’t know. It seems too… *utopian.”*

He was about to unlock the door, but paused, turning to look at him.

“Listen, Deku.” He said, sighing. “I’m not sayin’ it’s fuckin’ perfect; it’s not. Sometimes shit doesn’t work out how we want, and yeah, assholes still exist. Sometimes they even get what they want, despite everything. It’s rare, but life’s too complicated for that to just *never fuckin’ happen,* but…” He shrugged. “There’s nothing *productive* about dismissing shit ‘cuz it sounds *‘utopian.’* You gotta believe better things are possible, or nothing ever changes.”

“I mean… I suppose.” Izuku rubbed the back of his neck, staring down at his feet. “It’s just hard for me to buy into the idea that all of this actually *works.* It seems like there are a lot of ways it could go wrong.”

“There’re a lot of ways *anything* could go wrong.” Katsuki snorted. “Y’know, Hell isn’t the only society that’s like this. Plenty of human societies have made some variation of this idea work, and the shit a human needs for survival is *way* more particular than it is for Demons.” He said. “Just ‘cuz it’s not what you’re used to doesn’t mean it doesn’t *work,* and anyone who says otherwise has a fucking agenda.”

Izuku sighed. “I guess I’m just waiting to find out what the catch is…”

Katsuki was silent for a moment. Then, “C’mere.” He gestured for Izuku to follow him, and led him to a window at the end of the hall. “You see that building across the street there? The one with the black walls and no windows?”

It wasn’t hard to find. The nondescript building sat sandwiched between what looked to be a cafe of some kind and another apartment building.

“Um. Yeah?”

“That’s the sex dungeon I told you about.” He said, then pointed off into the distance. “If you squint, you can see the Amphilux from here. It’s that big, circular building, on the left over there. You see it?”

“…I…yes?” He replied, his voice two octaves higher than normal, his cheeks burning. *“Why?”*

“See, for me, I see these places as a *feature,* not a bug. But for you, I imagine this causes you some level of distress.” He turned around and headed back toward his door. Izuku remained rooted in place for a moment.

“So, there ya go. That’s the *catch,* Deku: people in Hell are broadly known for having some unusual sexual proclivities. Which is to say, no one arrests you for not fucking in missionary.”

Izuku heard the click of the door unlocking, followed by the sound of it swinging open. After a moment, Katsuki called out, “You coming, or what?”

He shook himself, taking a deep breath before turning around. Katsuki was holding the door open, staring at him with a raised eyebrow, and the slightest of smiles. Izuku kept his head down and skittered inside. Katsuki shut the door behind them, and then flicked on the light. They were in a short hallway, and at the end sat a single potted plant. Still carrying his bag, Izuku toed off his shoes, walked to the end, turned the corner, and froze.

It was… *nice.*

The hallway lead out into a surprisingly spacious open area. The living space sat in front of him—a couch, a couple chairs, a TV—and to his right was the kitchen. Nearly the entirety of the back wall was composed of one long, curved glass window, the curtains only half-closed.

He heard Katsuki set his bag down, and so he did as well.

"Kacchan, this is *nice."*

Katsuki snorted. "Why do you sound surprised?"

Izuku blushed slightly, looking away.

"C'mon. I'll show you around."

There wasn't much else to see, really. Katsuki pointed out the bathroom, showed him to a closet where he could store his things for the time being. He took him out onto the balcony, where many large, purplish pants seemed to be growing off the side, and a few more sat in the corners in pots.

The last spot he showed him was Katsuki's room, which was surprisingly neat and organized, apart from the unmade king-sized bed.

Without thinking, Izuku asked, "So, am I sleeping in here, or…?"

Katsuki's answering grin made Izuku realize this was a mistake.

"Well, I was *planning* on pulling out the couch bed," He said, voice deep. "But if you'd rather sleep with me, I'm sure that could be arranged too, *De-ku."*

Izuku all but burst into flames. He jumped back, just beyond the threshold of the door frame that Katsuki was now gripping the top of, laughing lowly as he watched him squirm.

"I-I'm okay… thank you."

Katsuki shrugged, still smirking. "Offer's on the table." He hopped up a bit, swinging from the top of the door frame and landing just in front of him with a soft *thud.* "In all seriousness, though, you're welcome to sleep there right now. I'll get the couch bed made up and shit later, but for now, this is easier."

"…And what are *you* going to do?"

"I need to eat first, but after that, I'll head out."

Izuku nodded. “Head out where, exactly?”

“The academy.” He replied. “Someone there I think should see that journal of yours.” He threw a look over his shoulder. “You got clothes to sleep in?”

“Oh, yeah. I uhh, I brought everything. But, umm…”

Katsuki raised a brow. “Yeah?”

“Is there anyway I could, uh, take a shower, maybe?” He asked. “I’m… kind of sweaty and gross.”

Katsuki gestured toward the bathroom. “Towels under the sink.”

“Thank you.” He smiled.

With that, Izuku headed for the closet, grabbing a change of clothes before moving on to the bathroom.

“Y’can put your clothes in the hamper!” Katsuki shouted from the kitchen.

“Okay, thanks!” Izuku called back.

“Oh, and one more thing—if you use the toilet, stand back when you flush it!”

Izuku’s brows pinched together. “Why?”

“You’ll see!”

He frowned, an ominous feeling settling in his gut as he shut himself inside the bathroom, putting his clothes on the countertop before turning toward the toilet.

The first thing he noticed was that there was no hole at the bottom. Instead, there were two smaller holes, one on either side, near the top of the bowl. It was weird, but Izuku wasn’t really in a position to question it. He needed to go, so he did his best to shrug it off.

Once he was done, he reached for the handle on the side, only to find that there was nothing there. Izuku blinked, puzzled as he looked around, until finally he spotted a button on the floor in front of him.

He gulped, taking a few steps back before slowly inching his foot toward it. After a moment of hesitation, Izuku clenched his jaw and pushed it before he could lose his nerve.

Instantly, two jets of fire shot from the holes on the sides, right down into the bowl. Izuku screamed, scrambling back against the door, his heart pounding. The fire didn’t last long, but for several seconds afterward, he couldn’t move.

And through the door, Izuku could hear Katsuki cracking up, all the way from the kitchen.

Thankfully, Katsuki's shower was normal, in the sense that it dispensed water, and did not cleanse things with fire.

Katsuki was in the living room eating when he came out. He sat in the chair across from him with a sigh. Katsuki paused mid-bite.

"Did you use my shampoo?"

"Um. Yeah," Izuku said. "Sorry, I forgot to bring my own. I should've asked."

"Eh, do whatever."

Silence.

Izuku found his mind drifting back to their conversation earlier.

"What happens if there *is* a food shortage?" He impulsively asked.

Katsuki froze, slowly looking up at Izuku. "Do you really want me to answer that?"

"I mean, I wouldn't have asked if I didn't."

"Okay, smartass." He scoffed, taking another bite, chewing, and swallowing. "That's the thing about being a Demon, Deku. Just 'cuz we've figured out how to grow food enriched with sin doesn't mean we can't still feed the old fashioned way."

Izuku blinked. "You mean…?"

Katsuki smirked. "In a pinch, I can always just fuck someone and feed off the lust that generates."

He nearly choked. "A-Ah."

"Yeah. *Ah."*

Katsuki held eye contact as he raised his fork to his lips and slowly took a bite.

Izuku tore his eyes away, clearing his throat. "Does it, um…" He fidgeted with the hem of his shirt. "Does it have to be aimed at you?"

He hummed. "Nah." He licked his lips. "It just tastes way better if it is."

Izuku gulped. "…I see."

"That's the whole reason the Amphilux still exists, Deku. I mean, that and the fact that people are just fucking horny, but y'know." He waved his hand meaninglessly. "If you're hungry, you can simply stop by the fucking endless orgy goin' on down there. S'like an all-you-can-eat buffet of degeneracy. It's fucking fantastic."

Izuku grimaced. "I guess that's… *technically* a solution." He mumbled.

Katsuki just laughed, and they both went quiet again.

He sighed, slumping down in his seat. Izuku supposed that, when he really thought about it, it wasn't the lack of a monetary system that bothered him so much as it was the lack of obvious supervision.

One could argue about the nature of people until they were blue in the face, but there would always be outliers. Not every person *is* a rational actor. Surely there had to be someone around to enforce limitations. There had to be some form of hierarchy involved to keep others in check. That's what society *is.*

...Isn't it?

Izuku frowned. He sat there, staring out the window at the vast, alien cityscape. The view was strangely beautiful, in a terrifying sort of way. Whether the fear arose from Izuku half-expecting it to crumble before his eyes, or was merely a reaction to its radical unfamiliarity, had yet to be determined.

He just couldn't help it. Although the… *sexual stuff*… was certainly weird and uncomfortable for Izuku to think about, it wasn't exactly *news* to him. He'd expected *that,* but *this?* This was *absurd.* Things like this just didn't exist in the real world. It was one of those *looks good on paper, doesn't work in practice* sort of societies.

He could hear Katsuki's words from earlier echoing between his ears.

'You gotta believe better things are possible, or nothing ever changes,' he'd told him.

It wasn't that Izuku didn't believe better things were possible; he did. But for him, *'better things'* meant things like clearer expectations, and fewer restrictions on training among lower level Angels, not… whatever *this* was.

Izuku never intended to tear things down and rebuild from the ground up. He wasn't aiming for a revolution. He just wanted to patch things up. He wanted *reform.*

But as that thought passed through his mind, some voice inside of him released a mirthless laugh.

Reform? It cackled. *After everything you've learned, you still think this system can be* ***reformed?***

Heaven in its current state is not as God meant it to be, he argued with himself.

Izuku gritted his teeth, clenching his fists as he tried to put a stop to his dark ruminations. But before he could cut them off completely, one final thought clawed its way up through the rift, vile and heavy in the lowest register of his consciousness.

But what if this isn't an accident? It asked him.

What if this is the system functioning exactly as intended?

“Deku, are you good?”

Izuku looked up suddenly, and found Katsuki staring at him, one eyebrow raised, his fork hovering in front of his mouth.

“Y-Yes, of course! Why?” Katsuki looked down pointedly, then back up again. Izuku followed his gaze, and realized that he’d torn a hole in his shirt. *“Oh!”* He released it, as if it had burned him.

Katsuki took a deep breath, and exhaled. “Look, nerd.” He began. “It’s fuckin’ complicated, okay? *Obviously* there’s a lot more to it. More than I could explain in one sitting.” He gestured toward him with his fork. “All the questions you’ve got buzzin’ around in that head of yours *do have answers,* but for now, you’re just gonna have to fuckin’ trust me.”

Izuku nodded mutely, and Katsuki went back to eating. He turned and looked out at the sky, and though he tried to put it out of his mind, he couldn’t quite quell that sense of foreboding within him.

The other shoe was going to drop soon.

The only question was *when.*

Izuku heard a rumble of thunder up above just before rain began to fall. Almost immediately, a large, black, umbrella-like apparatus unfolded on Katsuki’s balcony, shielding the plants. Izuku watched, hypnotized, as similar structures started to pop up all across the city.

His brow furrowed. “Uhh. Why are they… doing that?” He squinted. “Isn’t rain *good* for plants?”

Katsuki took another bite, took his sweet time chewing it before he swallowed and stood up. Wordlessly, he beckoned Izuku closer to the window, and then pointed down at the street.

Izuku’s eyes went wide as he took in the smoke rising from the ground, wherever the rain hit it.

“Concentrated sulfuric acid.”

Izuku did a double take. “It *rains* sulfuric acid?!”

Katsuki shrugged, his expression distressingly casual. “It’s always a fifty-fifty chance. Half the time, it’s just normal rain. The other half—well.” He gestured broadly at the outside world. “Y’know, *this.”*

With that, he sat down and continued eating as though nothing was happening. Izuku, on the other hand, pressed closer, all but plastering himself to the window as he gawked at the street below. His eyes settled on what appeared to be a piece of fruit, left behind in the road, and he watched, transfixed, as the rain gradually reduced it to steaming, black sludge.

“It’s more common this time of year.” Katsuki said—with his mouth full, from the sound of it. “Most of the native plants can survive. The engineered ones, not so much—hence the auto-

hoods."

"Kacchan, this is *insane."*

Katsuki snorted. "Told ya the weather was trash." He stood up, taking his empty plate to the kitchen. When he returned, he came to stand by Izuku's side again. "Luckily, it doesn't last too long, usually. 'Course, you still gotta be careful a little while afterward. The fumes can make you sick."

Izuku finally tore his eyes away from the window. "So—what?" He frowned. "You're just… trapped indoors for the next few hours?"

"Of course not." Katsuki scoffed. "This is Hell, Deku. Y'think we don't know how to handle a little *acid rain?"*

He turned and walked over to the closet, opening the door with all the drama of a game show host unveiling a prize.

There, hanging inside, were a couple of rain coats, boots and umbrellas, all apparently made from the same type of heavy-duty rubber material. Hanging off the coat hook on the back of the door were two black, full-face respirators. Grinning, Katsuki grabbed one of them, fitting the mask over his head. He slid on the boots next, followed by the coat, before finally brandishing an umbrella that he pointed at Izuku like a sword.

"I am *un-fucking-stoppable."* Katsuki proclaimed, his voice muffled. Izuku couldn't help but glance out the window again, at the pile of black sludge. He gulped.

"Welcome to Hell, Deku."

Katsuki left shortly afterward, dressed head to toe in thick protective gear. He made Izuku promise he'd go to sleep as soon as his hair was dry, and left with one last parting threat:

"If I come back here and find you still awake, I will *personally* put your ass to sleep."

And so, Izuku headed to Katsuki's room and shut the door softly behind him. He stood still for a moment, eying the bed as if he could expect it to attack him. Then he shook his head, and went to sit gingerly on the edge. It seemed comfortable enough, but—

"Eep!" He felt something touch his foot, and reflexively pulled them up onto the mattress. "What the—?!"

Staring down at the floor, he watched the shadows shift, and then the creature emerged. It was a black cat, and after it was out, the cat turned to look at him curiously. It very quickly became clear that this was not a normal cat, with the most obvious differences being that this cat had two tails, and a third eye situated between the other two.

A Hell cat?

"Um." Izuku blinked a few times. "Hello…"

The cat meowed, then turned and ran toward a cat tree in the corner of the room. Izuku wasn't sure how he'd failed to notice its presence until that moment. The cat leapt and climbed, curling up on the highest platform.

"Well, okay then…" Izuku muttered.

He wasn't entirely sure if this was safe. As far as he knew, creatures in Hell didn't have the ability to corrupt Angels through touch, but it was more of a gap in his knowledge than a sure thing.

But Kacchan would've told me if this was dangerous, right?

He might not know, though. There probably aren't many opportunities to find out something like that…

Izuku chewed his lip, sliding under the covers. *Still, if there was any chance, I'm sure he would've warned me.*

With that final thought, he laid down and shifted around until he got comfortable, burying his face in the pillow, breathing in the sweet, smoky scent.

Smells like Kacchan, he thought to himself, blushing a bit when he realized he kind of liked it. Izuku pulled the sheets over his head and curled up into a ball, wrapping his arms around the pillow as he snuggled in closer to it.

He had been fully prepared to spend the next few hours struggling to fall asleep again, but as he lay there, engulfed in Katsuki's scent, he found himself drifting off in a matter of minutes.

Izuku woke to the sensation something of rumbling in his chest, and when he opened his eyes, he saw Katsuki above him, leaning over the edge of the bed. "Rise and shine, nerd."

He blinked a few times, clearing his vision.

"Kacchan…" he murmured. He furrowed his brow. Katsuki wasn't talking, but he still felt the same rumbling sensation inside him. "What's... Going on?" He asked. He wasn't quite sure how to explain the sensation; he just hoped Katsuki would know what he meant. Based on the way he smiled, it seemed he did.

"Well, Triplet likes you, I guess."

He felt movement on his chest, and it was only then that he noticed the cat curled up there. Katsuki picked the cat up, causing them to nip his thumb.

"Ow!" He winced slightly, then clicked his tongue. "I'm gonna *feed* you, jackass." He released the cat, allowing her to exit the room.

"Wait," Izuku blinked. "Your cat's name is Triplet?"

"Yep."

Izuku swallowed. “As in…”

“Yep,” He repeated, popping the *‘p’* sound. “But if ya haven’t unlocked my *‘tragic backstory’* yet, I’ll usually just say it’s ‘cuz she has three eyes.” Katsuki snorted.

Izuku smiled softly, and sat up in bed. He yawned. “What time is it?”

“Little after six.” He replied. “Figured you’d be asleep for a while, so I ran a couple errands while I was out, so I—”

There was a rustling sound coming from the living room that immediately made Katsuki’s eyes widen.

“Oi! Hey!” He shouted, making quick strides out the door. “Get the fuck outta there, asshole!” Triplet meowed, and Katsuki returned a second later, right as Izuku was standing up.

“What was that about?”

He rolled his eyes. “She just always wants to fuck with the habanero plant. S’why I keep the doors closed when I’m out. Dunno why she’s so goddamn interested in it.” He sighed. “Anyway, I gotta feed her.”

Izuku nodded, quietly following Katsuki out of the room. As they passed through the living area, Katsuki said, “Oh, I made up the pull out couch for ya, by the way.” He waved lazily toward the bed.

“Oh, thank you!”

“Mm.”

He trailed behind him into the kitchen. He leaned back against the counter, watching quietly as Katsuki pulled a container from the fridge, Triplet right on his heel. Izuku would’ve been worried about stepping on her, but it seemed Katsuki was used to it.

“Sleep well?” He asked, setting a small food bowl on the counter.

“Oh! Um, yeah,” Izuku said. “I did. Your bed’s really soft.”

Katsuki threw a glance over his shoulder, smirking. “Good to know,” he told him. The suggestive cadence instantly dropped when Triplet tried to bite the spoon he was holding. *“Hey!”* He snapped, pulling it away. He mumbled something inaudible under his breath and scooped the food into the bowl, then set it down on the ground.

“Anyway,” Katsuki said. “I talked to the Nexus, told ‘im we’d be there around nine tomorrow morning.”

“Nexus?”

“It’s the person whose job it is to coordinate between different sections of the military.” He said.

Izuku frowned. “I thought you didn’t *have* ranks.”

“Nexus isn’t a rank.” He said. “They don’t have power over their sections. They just make communication more efficient.”

“Huh…” Izuku mumbled. “Then what’s the use in giving it to them?”

“Well, they’re usually the first to know when something happens with other segments. It’s just a faster way to disseminate information.”

“Ah…” he trailed off. “Well, how long do you think it will take for them to make a move?”

Katsuki leaned back against the counter. “Hard to say. It varies.” He said. “We’ll have a better idea by tomorrow, though.”

Izuku frowned, his heart rate speeding up.

“But… But we need to act fast.” His brow wrinkled. “All Might, he’s…”

“Deku,” He sighed. “I get it. But y’gotta try to keep some fuckin’ perspective, here. You’re basically talking about invading heaven. Just getting in is already a massive hurdle. Storming in there without a plan would be a waste of intelligence at best, and suicide at worst.”

Izuku gulped. Somewhere, in the back of his mind, he understood that Katsuki was correct. But it didn’t make him any less anxious.

After a moment of silence, Katsuki took another step toward him. “There’s somewhere I wanna take you.”

Izuku blinked, looking up at him. “Tonight?”

“Mm. If you’re up for it.” He replied. “I think it’ll make you feel a little better.”

“What is it?”

Katsuki grinned. “It’s a surprise.”

Izuku raised an eyebrow, thinking it over. Eventually, he nodded. “Sure.”

“Great.” A rustling noise came from the living room, and Katsuki immediately spun around. *“Triplet, you* ***fuck!”***

Some twenty minutes later, Izuku heard a small meow from inside Katsuki’s room. He peaked through the crack just in time to see Triplet sitting on the edge of Katsuki’s bed, as he leaned down and kissed her on the top of the head. Izuku quickly backed away from the door, and seconds later Katsuki emerged.

“Fuck are *you* smilin’ about?”

“Nothing.” Izuku replied—still smiling.

The train ride took around ten minutes, and by the time they arrived at their final destination, it was about a quarter to seven.

From the outside, it was a building not unlike the one Katsuki lived in, though the actual interior design was far more traditional in style. A short elevator ride and a few paces later, and they were standing before a red, wooden door.

Katsuki knocked, and they waited. A moment later, the door opened to reveal a familiar face.

“Inasa?” Izuku perked up.

Does this mean…?

His pulse picked up, and he started shifting his weight back and forth between his feet in anticipation.

“Ah, Deku!” Inasa gave a wide grin. “It’s so nice to see you again!” He turned toward Katsuki. “And Bakugou! So you managed to tempt him, eh? Nice job!”

Katsuki raised an eyebrow. “Not quite.” Izuku tensed as he felt Katsuki’s gloved fingers against the back of his neck, deftly unhooking the artifice.

Inasa’s eyes widened. “Oh, wow! I’m confused, but somehow this is even more impressive to me?”

Katsuki snorted, dropping the artifice in Izuku’s open palm. “I’ll explain later.”

“Later, right!” He held the door open “Well, come in, then! I think there’s someone in the living room who’d really like to see you.”

Izuku nodded quickly and ducked under his arm. He all but ran down the hall, rounding the corner into a larger room. From behind, he spotted a familiar head of red and white hair, and he couldn’t help but tear up.

Todoroki was sitting on the couch, a cup of tea in one hand, an open book in the other. He was only partially shifted, and it was strange to see him without his wings. He looked up as Izuku entered, and did a double take.

“Midoriya?” He dropped the book and set his drink down, nearly spilling it in the process.

“Todoroki!” Izuku ran over to him, holding his barrier as he threw his arms around him. After a second of shock, Todoroki returned the hug. “It’s so nice to see you!” He started sniffling, sitting on the couch beside him when he eventually pulled away. “Are you doing okay?”

Todoroki smiled, warm and content and *genuine* in a way Izuku had never seen before.

“I am.” He replied softly. “I miss everyone, but… on the whole, I’ve been doing better.”

Izuku gave a wobbly smile, nodding as he wiped his eyes. “I’m so glad.”

“What are you doing here, though?”

Izuku opened his mouth, but no sound came out. He rubbed the back of his neck. “It’s… complicated.” He muttered. “I guess the short answer is… I’m in hiding?”

Todoroki tilted his head. “From the Council?”

He bit his lip and nodded. “It’s… a long story.”

Todoroki simply stared at him expectantly. Izuku sighed. *I guess there’s no way around it, really.*

He chewed his lip, mulling over his words for a moment before taking a deep breath and beginning. He did his best to streamline it, and Todoroki sat there, nodding along slowly. He didn’t seem particularly surprised by anything Izuku had to say until he got to the part about All Might’s theory, at which point he raised a single eyebrow and told him, “Well, that’s pretty out there, but I can’t think of a better explanation for how you’ve managed to make it this far without Falling.”

Izuku felt vaguely slighted by the comment, but he shook it off.

“Yeah,” He laughed awkwardly.

Todoroki slurped his tea.

A few minutes later, Katsuki walked in, followed by Inasa, and set his sights on Todoroki. “So, this is the guy I’ve heard so much about, huh?”

Todoroki waved, taking another sip. “I take it you’re *‘Kacchan’?”*

“Bakugou Katsuki.” He glanced at Izuku. “You told him about me, huh.”

Izuku blushed slightly. “Well, there’s not really anyway around it, Kacchan.” He muttered, rubbing the back of his neck. “But, um. I’m sorry I never told you about him before now.”

Todoroki blinked. “Why would I expect you to have told me about him?” He cocked his head. “Given how much trouble you could get in if this got back to the Council, that would’ve been reckless and idiotic, Midoriya.”

Katsuki barked a laugh.

“Point taken.” Izuku murmured, smiling softly.

Todoroki raised his teacup to his lips again, noisily slurping it.

“So, um.” Izuku cleared his throat. “Ah, what have you been up to?”

“Shouto’s learning magic!” Inasa interjected.

“Oh, really?” Izuku sat up straighter. “What kind?”

“I haven’t decided yet.” He replied. “I’m thinking either Wrath or Sloth… or possibly both.”

“Double-classing?” Katsuki snorted. “Seriously?”

“Shouto’s a fast learner. You should see him!” Inasa said. “He’s super talented and passionate!”

“Ah, yes.” Katsuki deadpanned. “This guy, right here. Fuckin’ passion extraordinaire.”

“Kacchan!”

Todoroki seemed completely unfazed. “It’s mostly the teaching. It makes things very… intuitive, I suppose.”

“Wrath and Sloth is a weird combination, though.” Katsuki said. “The point of double-classing is usually to be able to use different types at the same time.” He raised an eyebrow. “You can’t do that with Wrath and Sloth.”

“Ah, sorry,” Izuku interjected. “Um, I know how Wrath works, but...” He scratched his head. “What is Sloth, exactly…?”

“Cooling.” Todoroki answered. “Sloth Demons aim to lower the temperature of their souls below freezing levels.”

“Which is inherently incompatible with heating.” Katsuki deadpanned. “So where’s the benefit?”

“Well, it’s like how you can use Wrath to burn things!” Inasa jumped in. “There’s no real reason why Sloth Demons shouldn’t be able to use their powers to freeze things in the same way!”

Katsuki blinked. “Baldy, the *reason* I can burn shit is ‘cuz of special movement techniques that’ve been developed specifically for Wrath magic. Sloth magic doesn’t involve anything like that.”

“There’s no apparent reason why it couldn’t, though.” Todoroki said. “Compression-related movement techniques aren’t incompatible with Sloth.”

“Exactly!” Inasa said. “And if he can move *and* freeze simultaneously, then he should be able to freeze with his touch!”

A look of recognition dawned on Katsuki’s face. *“Ahh, I getcha now.”*

“Clever, isn’t it?”

“Dunno about that.” Katsuki grinned. “But it’s probably not the *dumbest* thing I’ve ever heard.”

“That’s high praise, coming from you!”

“Whatever.” Katsuki snorted. “Anyway, we should probably head out.”

“Ah, where are you going?” Izuku asked.

“We’re picking up dinner!” Inasa said.

“Mm. Shouldn’t take more than twenty minutes.” Katsuki shrugged. He looked up at Izuku, throwing him a smirk. “See ya later, *De-ku.”*

The way he drew out his name made Izuku’s face feel hot.

“R-Right.” Izuku waved. “Later, Kacchan!”

Inasa and Katsuki left the room. The front door clicked shut behind them, leaving the two of them alone in the quiet living room. When Izuku looked up, he found Todoroki staring at him with a subtle glint of amusement in his eyes.

Izuku blinked rapidly. “Wh-What?”

“Nothing.”

“Todoroki.”

“I was just wondering about your relationship with Bakugou.” He took a sip of his tea. “Are you two together, or something?”

A high pitched noise came from Izuku’s throat. “N-No! Of course not!”

“Oh, really?” He frowned. “I guess I read it wrong, then. Sorry.”

Izuku hesitated, felt a twinge of guilt in his chest.

“No, it’s okay, it’s just…” He winced. “I mean, you’re not wrong… I guess? I just…” He sighed. “It’s just that I don’t really know… *what* we are.”

“What do you mean?”

Izuku whined, covering his face with his hands.

He blinked. “We don’t have to talk about it if it makes you uncomfortable.”

“No, no!” Izuku waved his hands around. “I just—I don’t know.” He exhaled heavily.

For a moment, it was silent. Todoroki raised his cup to his lips again and loudly slurped his tea, and set it down on a coaster with a soft *clink.*

“He… teases me a lot.” Izuku finally said, staring down at the ground.

“…He makes fun of you?”

“No!” He immediately said. “I mean, yes! I mean—“ he cringed. “Kind of…?”

“Midoriya, I’m having a hard time following any of this.”

Izuku bit his lip. “Hang on, let me just…”

He took a deep breath and exhaled slowly, taking a moment to gather his thoughts.

“Kacchan is… very flirtatious,” He eventually said. “At first, I thought he was just doing it to embarrass me. You know. He makes a lot of inappropriate jokes. But then…” He rubbed the back of his neck. “He kind of just… never really stopped doing it?”

“…Does that make you uncomfortable?”

“Yes.”

“Do you want him to stop?”

“Ye—“ He bit his tongue. “…No.”

“Interesting.” Todoroki tilted his head slightly. “Are you attracted to him?”

Izuku’s face grew impossibly hotter. “I… think so?” He scratched his head. “I mean, I know he’s attrac*tive.”*

“But do you get *aroused* when you’re around him? Or when you think about him?”

Izuku wrapped his arms around his head, squirming. “I don’t know! H-How am I supposed to know something like that?”

Todoroki closed his eyes, finishing off the last of his tea and lightly setting in down on the coffee table in front of them. “Just a second.”

He stood, disappearing into the kitchen, and a moment later, returned with a kettle and a second tea cup. Without asking, he set the cup down in front of Izuku and poured him a cup before refilling his own.

“Oh, um. Thank you!” Izuku smiled. Todoroki nodded, taking the kettle back and then returning once more. He sat beside Izuku, and took a sip of his fresh cup of tea.

“When Inasa kisses me, my body temperature rises. I feel his touch a lot more intensely, and I want him to touch me more.” He said, his tone nonchalant. “A similar thing happens when he whispers in my ear, but it’s a lot more sudden. Like a wave of heat rushing down all at once.” He shrugged. “Do you ever feel like that around Bakugou?”

For a minute, Izuku couldn't speak. He knew Todoroki well enough not to be shocked by his candidness, but the subject matter seemed to override that. He blushed bright red, curling in on himself a little.

"I-I mean…"

Memories flooded into his mind, every dicy interaction he'd ever had with Katsuki coming into stark focus. Images of Katsuki pinning him, either physically, or just with his eyes. Katsuki's elegant fingers wrapped around an apple, pressed against his lips. Katsuki's tongue dragging across the palm of a latex glove. Those hooded, glowing eyes, that damn smirk of his. The way he carried himself, playful, cocky, always standing at the threshold of 'too far' at any given time. Always just a little bit closer than he needed to be, his voice deep and raspy, resonating inside Izuku.

Every move Katsuki made was an implicit offer, teasing at the possibility of something more. And when he looked at him that way, spoke to him that way, got close to him in that way, everything else disappeared.

Izuku swallowed, contemplating the best way to phrase it. "S-So, when you feel that way…" He began, "does it ever feel like, uhh… L-Like you can't really feel anything else? Like everything else is sort of just… you know, background noise?"

Todoroki blinked. "Yes." He replied. "I tend to get caught up in the moment."

Izuku chewed his lip, nodding slowly. He finally picked up his tea cup and took a sip.

"Is that how Bakugou makes you feel?"

"Sometimes."

"I see. Does that scare you, or does it feel like it's not enough?"

"…Yes?"

Todoroki's lips quirked up at the corners. "Well, there you have it, I guess." He shrugged. "What are you going to do about it?"

Izuku's mind went blank, apart from the sound of those words echoing inside his skull.

Do about it?

Do about it?!

"Uhhh… do I…" He squinted. *"Have to* do something about it…?"

Todoroki looked up in thought, humming. "I guess not. But if you have feelings for him and it seems mutual, why not?"

He brow furrowed. "Because I'm an Angel, Todoroki."

“So was I, and yet.” He gestured to his horns and tail.

Izuku shifted on the couch nervously.

In an effort to deflect, he asked, “What’s it like, being with Inasa?”

Todoroki blinked a few times. “Well, it hasn't been that long, but it’s been good so far.” He said, reaching for his tea again. “He’s nice, and entertaining to be around. He’s very enthusiastic about basically everything, which I like, since it shows he cares.”

Izuku nodded. “I’d, um, imagine it’s pretty important to feel like your significant other cares about your interests.”

Todoroki took a long sip of his tea.

“He also has a pretty big dick. So there’s that, I guess.”

Izuku nearly choked on his own spit. “H-How do you even *know* that?!”

Todoroki gave him an odd look. “Because I’ve seen it, Midoriya.” He told him. “You haven’t seen Bakugou’s dick?”

Izuku sputtered. “Under *what* circumstance would I even *have* that opportunity?!”

He shrugged. “Peeing, I guess.”

“Well, I’ve never watched Kacchan *pee,* so I’m afraid I have no way of knowing how… *big*... it is.”

“I didn’t ask you how big it was.” Todoroki said. “I just asked if you’d seen it.”

Izuku’s face burned with all the heat of a thousand suns.

“Also, that’s not quite true.” Todoroki continued. “There are other ways to gauge that sort of thing. Certain types of pants.” He shrugged. “Obviously I didn’t meet him for very long, but for what it’s worth, he does seem to carry himself with a fairly wide stance. Have you ever seen him sit cross-legged?”

“I… don’t… know…?”

He shrugged. “Well, in any case, take it with a grain of salt. Most of this only works if he’s a *shower,* as they say.”

“A *what?”*

“*Showers* are guys whose dicks don’t get significantly bigger when they’re hard. *Growers* are the opposite.”

Izuku took a sharp breath, and closed his eyes. He raised his fingers to his temples, slowly massaging them in small circles. “Why are you putting these things in my head?”

Todoroki frowned. “I assumed you’d already thought about this before, since you’re attracted to him.” He replied. “You’ve never thought about having sex with him?”

That’s it. Izuku was going to die.

Again.

Right there, in Hell.

For a while, he just sat there, quietly burning up. His mind was somehow both vacant *and* racing.

Around a minute into his silent turmoil, Todoroki spoke again. “Sorry, I don’t mean to…” He trailed off for a moment, wincing. “I guess it’s just because I’m able to speak freely, now. I never really realized how much energy it took to filter everything I said until I didn’t need to do it anymore.” He traced his finger over the edge of his teacup, frowning. “And I figured that it was alright, given what you said about All Might’s theory, but…” He hesitated. “I should be careful not to go overboard. I don’t want to offend you.”

“Offend?” Izuku frowned. “No, don’t worry about that! it’s nothing like that, Todoroki. You’re fine, I just…”

Don’t know how to answer that question.

He gulped.

There was a part of Izuku, somewhere in the back of his mind, that recognized that Katsuki’s teasing had never been neutral. *Obviously* it wasn’t. How could he *not* know that?

But during his time as an Angel, he’d learned to compartmentalize things like that. He’d learned to file things separately from their context, to build walls between the different things he believed, so that he wouldn’t have to deal with the consequences of them overlapping. Although he never thought of it in such clear terms, the fact of the matter was, it was just easier to survive as an Angel if one kept clear barriers in place to stop certain trains of thought before one could arrive at some sort of contradiction, or worse—a dangerous synthesis.

In one cell of Izuku’s mind, he held the way Katsuki talked to him, the way he *looked* at him.

In another, he kept the implications of being spoken to like that, of being looked at like that.

In one cell of his mind, he held his attraction to Katsuki, the way he made him feel.

In another, he kept the desires such feelings would lead to. In yet another, he stored the actions that could be built from those desires.

It wasn’t something he did consciously; it was an instinct. A reflex he’d developed long ago —one he’d gotten very comfortable not thinking about.

...Maybe it was time he thought about it.

Izuku took a deep breath and opened his mouth, but before he could get a word out, the front door opened, and the thoughts sunk back into the deep recesses of his mind.

It was half-past ten o'clock when they returned. Immediately after they arrived, Katsuki grumbled something about needing a shower and promptly disappeared into the bathroom, leaving Izuku to his own devices.

Having slept all day, he wasn't tired yet. He dug through his bag until he found his fire tea, and headed for the kitchen, the only background noise being the sound of the shower running.

Kacchan is naked in there, his mind supplied—violently unhelpful.

He shook himself and focused on finding a tea kettle. A task that continued to elude him even after the shower had turned off. *I guess I'll just have to ask him.*

"Kacchan?" He called out. "Do you have a tea kettle anywhere?"

"Under the stove." Katsuki called back.

Izuku frowned. "I don't see it there?"

After a pause, Katsuki yelled, "Alright, uh. Hang on a sec."

Izuku heard the bedroom door open, and a minute later, it closed again. Katsuki strolled in a moment later.

Izuku started to turn toward him. "Hey, sorry, I just can't—"

The moment he laid eyes on him, the words died in his throat.

Katsuki stood there, his hair damp, a small, red towel slung around his neck. He wore a pair of grey sweatpants.

And nothing else.

His skin was dry, apart from a few stray droplets, and the low light of Katsuki's kitchen cast shadows along the contours of his muscles. The sweats tapered in at his ankles, hung low on his hips. Izuku's eyes drifted just a little further down, and for several seconds, his brain simply stopped working.

Katsuki was not wearing underwear; that much was certain. Of course, it made sense—he was in a hurry, but knowing that did nothing to quell the existential agony raging in Izuku's head.

Todoroki's comment about *showers* and *growers* came to mind.

…Izuku hoped Katsuki was the former.

He snapped out of his trance at the sound of Katsuki's voice.

"Oi, Deku."

Izuku looked up. Katsuki was smirking, his glowing eyes half-lidded. "Lookin' for something?"

Izuku's cheeks lit up so quickly, he broke a sweat. He immediately averted his gaze, eyes darting around, looking at anything but Katsuki. "K-Kettle," He said, his voice two octaves too high. "I-I couldn't…"

Katsuki advanced toward him, stopping to stand right in front of him. Izuku held his breath, glancing up at his face, taking in the amused glint in his eye.

"The stove, Deku."

"…What?"

He raised an eyebrow. "You're standing in front of it."

"Oh…" he breathed. And then, finally, his brain rebooted itself. *"Oh!* Right, sorry!" He hastily stepped to the side, allowing Katsuki access. The Demon opened the cabinet doors and dropped to a squat. He reached far into the cabinet, moving pots and pans out of the way, and when he found the kettle, he stood and handed it to him. Izuku muttered an awkward *'thanks'* and shuffled over to the sink to fill it with water.

He set it down on the stove, and grabbed his tea infuser. But his hands were shaky, and he ended up dropping it, causing it to roll behind the fridge.

Izuku groaned, gritting his teeth as he fell to his hands and knees, wincing as he strained to grab it. He eventually managed, but it took a moment. And during the whole ordeal, Katsuki hadn't said a word. With a sigh, he stood up again and spun around, only to find Katsuki leaning back against the sink right behind him, staring at him with dark eyes and wetted lips, and something else Izuku couldn't quite place.

"Wh-What?"

"Nothing…" Katsuki drawled, in this deep, teasing cadence that seemed to suggest that it was *absolutely* something.

Still, Izuku figured it'd be best not to push it, especially after his slip up just a few minutes prior. He moved toward the sink, intending to wash the infuser off, but when he came to a stop in front of Katsuki, he didn't move. He just stayed there, his arms outstretched on either side, fingers gripping the edges of the counter top, blocking off the sink completely.

Izuku looked up, meeting his glowing gaze.

"Yes?" Katsuki smirked.

"You're, um." He swallowed. "You're blocking the sink."

Katsuki hummed, and after a moment, he shrugged and stepped aside, allowing him to rinse the infuser. He remained there, right next to the sink, for the next few minutes. But the moment Izuku turned his back on him, and started to pack the tea infuser—

"What's that?" Katsuki's voice was way closer that he'd expected.

Izuku yelped, physically jolting before he looked over his shoulder with a mild scowl.

"Don't *do* that!"

"Sorry," Katsuki said, but he was grinning. Izuku rolled his eyes.

He sighed, turning back to his work. "It's fire tea." He mumbled, putting the infuser in the kettle. "It helps stave off corruption damage." He turned on the stove and set the kettle down.

"Huh." Katsuki eyed the box. "Can I see?"

"Uhh," Izuku blinked. "Sure, I guess." He handed it to him, and Katsuki started examining it. Izuku turned around and watched as he peered into the box of dried, orange petals and leaves. Then something seemed to dawn on him.

"Deku, is this made from *fire lilies?"*

"Uhh," Izuku cocked his head. "I don't know, actually."

Katsuki sniffed the box. "It *is."*

Izuku raised an eyebrow. "How do you know that?"

"Fire lilies are one of the only Earth plants that can survive out in the Wilds." He explained, turning the box over in his hand. "They're called *fire* lilies because they only bloom after a fire." He set the tea box down on the counter, beside Izuku. "If you're ever brave enough to go hiking out there, you might see some of 'em. They usually bloom around a week after a forest fire."

"Huh… I didn't realize there were plants that had *fire* involved in their life cycles."

"Mm, it's actually not that unusual." He said. "Lotsa plants have adapted to withstand or benefit from fire, but fire lilies actually *depend* on it. If you want 'em to bloom, somethin's gotta burn." He smiled, eyes flashing. "It's sorta poetic, I guess. Something new growin' in the ashes of something old."

Izuku averted his eyes, fidgeting with the hem of his shirt. "Um… how do you know so much about this, anyway?"

"Eh, past a certain level, some magic just ain't safe to practice within the city." He shrugged. "There's a place out in the Wilds I like to go to work on some of my more destructive moves.

"A while back, I started noticing these little orange flowers popping up, and every time I come back, there's more. Eventually I decided to just pick a few and bring 'em to my

neighbor; she's a botanist." He planted a hand on the counter next to Izuku, idly tapping it with the tips of his claws. "And that's the story of how I found out pyrophytes existed."

"…Wow."

"S'really somethin,'" He agreed.

Izuku nodded.

And then it was quiet.

He wasn't sure when Katsuki had gotten so close to him, but in the silence, it was getting difficult to ignore.

Especially with the way he was looking at him.

"Um… what is it?"

"Hm?" He blinked. "Oh, nothing. Was thinking about something… unrelated."

He swallowed. "What's that?"

"I was just wondering about your barrier." He cocked his head. "How hard is it to focus on keeping it up?"

"Oh." Izuku hummed. "Not *extremely* hard, but it does take focus. It's a bit like flexing a muscle, I guess. It gets tiring after a while."

"Huh." Katsuki drummed his fingers on the countertop. "Are there any limits to it?"

"What do you mean?"

"Mm, I dunno, really." He squinted. "Like, are there places where it doesn't work, or is less effective?"

Izuku was still confused, and it must've shown on his face.

"I guess what m'askin' is, like…" He gestured vaguely. "Like, if I touch your hand, for example, would that be different from touching your cheek, or is it equally effective everywhere?"

"Oh!" He said. "I see what you mean, now. That's… hmm." He rubbed his chin. "I don't think so? I think it's, ahh… fairly consistent everywhere."

After a moment, Izuku added, "I mean, I'm sure there're ways someone could touch me that would make it harder for me to focus." Katsuki raised his eyebrows. "For example, if someone were to… I don't know, *tickle* me or something, it'd probably be a lot harder to hold it."

“Ah.” Katsuki nodded. “I imagined that sentence goin’ somewhere *very* different, but that makes sense, too.”

Izuku blinked. “What’re you—“ Then it hit him. *Ah. Right.* His cheeks instantly heated up. *“K-Kacchan, that’s—!”*

“—So it’s all the same, then?” He interjected, smirking. “What about the point of contact on the Demon? Is there any difference between, say…” Katsuki reached out, giving him time to raise his barrier before he grabbed his hand. “This,” He lifted it up, holding it tight. Then, his hand slid down, fingers encircling Izuku’s wrist as he pulled his hand up toward his face. He placed Izuku’s palm against his cheek. “Or this?”

Izuku gulped. “I…” He hesitated. “N-No, I don’t think so.”

Katsuki hummed. Izuku felt the vibrations beneath his hand. They traveled up his arm, resonated throughout his entire body. Katsuki’s tongue flicked out, wetting his lips, and Izuku’s eyes traced the movement.

“Interesting.” He said, releasing his wrist. Katsuki planted both hands on the counter, boxing him in. “So, in theory, there’s really nothing you *can’t* do, is there?”

Izuku’s eyelids fluttered as he stared up into Katsuki’s glowing red eyes, and the weight of it all came crashing over his senses.

It was quiet, apart from the gentle sound of their breathing. He was backed up against the countertop, the ledge pressing into his back as Katsuki loomed over him, half-naked, and bathed in soft, warm light that gently highlighted every bump and ridge of his body. Izuku could feel the heat of his presence surrounding him, of his breath as he leaned closer, his sweet, smoky scent filling up his lungs, so potent he could almost taste it.

Katsuki was the moon, eclipsing his reality. A Pandora’s box filled with fire.

He licked his lips again, red and shining slightly as he leaned in closer, pinning him in place with his gaze. His finger curled beneath his chin. His hands were shifted, and Izuku felt the tip of his claw touch the underside, but he was gentle. Careful pressure with the sharpest knife.

Katsuki tilted his head upward and leaned in close, deep into his space, hot breaths intermingling.

It felt like he was floating. Izuku closed his eyes.

And then he felt it. Katsuki’s lips pressed softly against his own, the point of contact sending ripples throughout his body.

The kiss was gentle, at first. The soft sound of Katsuki’s lips moving slowly against his own filled his body up with warmth. Despite his inexperience, Katsuki’s easy pace allowed him to keep up, following his movements as the Demon took control.

Katsuki pulled back after a moment, and Izuku opened his eyes as he leaned in, resting his forehead against Izuku's own. The hand that had been holding his chin returned to the countertop, caging him in again, as if to say, *this isn't over.*

"Breathe." He rasped, the sound resonating deep in his throat, sending shivers down Izuku's spine. He didn't register it as a word, at first. It was just a sensation.

"…Wh-What?"

Katsuki laughed, low and breathy. He looked at Izuku with heavy-lidded eyes, catlike pupils blown so wide, they were almost circular. "You gotta *breathe,* baby."

Izuku took a deep, shuddering breath, and then Katsuki was on him again, kissing him slowly, sensually. He whimpered softly, knees going weak, and Izuku blindly reached backwards, searching for something to hold onto. He felt Katsuki smile into the kiss as he grabbed his wrists, pulling them up toward his shoulders. Izuku got the message, and wrapped his arms around his neck. Katsuki's hands slid down his sides, coming to rest on his lower back, just beneath his shirt.

Just as Izuku was beginning to settle into it, Katsuki deepened the kiss. He felt his tongue swipe across his lip, coaxing him to open up for him. And as the Demon's tongue slid into his mouth, the temperature seemed to skyrocket, every point of contact searing into him like a brand. Katsuki's tongue was hot against his own, deep and indulgent.

And then Katsuki's knee slid between his thighs, and Izuku released a small, startled cry that had Katsuki digging his claws into his lower back. He bit his lower lip, pulling it lightly between his teeth.

It was getting very difficult for him to focus.

Izuku broke away, disengaging his hands and panting as he met Katsuki's gaze.

"Sorry," Izuku said, breathless. "It was just getting a bit…"

"Hmm?" He cocked his head.

"…Hard to focus."

Katsuki smirked, licking his lips. "Yeah?"

"Y-Yeah."

Katsuki hummed, a low rumble in his chest, like a cat's purr. He leaned in a bit closer, stopping just short of touching him. His lips ghosted over Izuku's before he bypassed them completely, hot breath wafting against his ear.

"Lookin' forward to the day you don't need to focus anymore." He whispered.

Izuku's breath caught in his throat.

And then Katsuki took a step back, hands sliding into the pockets of his sweats. Izuku forced himself to keep his eyes above the belt as Katsuki backed away, a rhythmic energy in his step, and a sharp grin on his face. He stopped beneath the archway.

“Good night, *De-ku.”* He said, lips red and slightly swollen. Then he turned on his heel, and disappeared from view. He heard the sound of his bedroom door closing shortly after.

For a while, Izuku just stood there, his brain struggling to process the feelings inside of him. In lieu of Katsuki’s touch, Izuku ran his thumb across his lower lip, and let his back slip down the cabinet behind him. He sat down on the cool, tile floor. He was tempted to lay down and press his cheek against it.

It was a difficult thing to come to grips with—so unfamiliar, yet oddly natural at the same time. He found himself wanting Katsuki’s touch. In some weird, abstract sense, he wanted to feel the heat of his presence enveloping him, taking up residence inside of him. The feeling burned in the pit of his stomach, and Izuku realized that even his own touch felt different, somehow. He sat there in a daze, his palms smoothing up and down his thighs, unconsciously creeping inward, heat spreading over his skin like a forest fire.

Izuku wondered what would happen if he let those flames take him.

He wondered if anything would grow from his ashes.

Then the kettle screeched, jarring Izuku out of his trance. He scrambled off the floor, nearly tripping over his own feet as he went to turn off the stove.

Chapter End Notes

Alrightalrightalright lmao
guess who just took her last final EVER yesterday? yes it was I. that class got brutal toward the end, so this wound up taking a bit. but it’s here now, and it’s twice as long as it should’ve been lmao

A couple of you have guessed…certain things…about hell in the comments (i’m always tempted to reply but spoilers lmao) and well. there u have it. if ya know, ya know. That’s actually the other reason why this took longer lol. there’s some shit in here that i seriously considered just taking out entirely, bc as much as i like to joke about the comments section here just devolving into bloodthirsty political debate, i do not actually desire that. but honestly if this story isn't contentious, I'm doin something wrong lmao

oh yeah this chapter’s also horny. haha deku, u thought todoroki “yeah i don’t think demons are intrinsically evil” shouto had no filter? you are like a little baby, meet todoroki “my boyfriend’s cock is huge it’s pretty sick” shouto

Also kacchan hot. Also, namedropping the title moment. Also kacchan hot. UHh. anyway.

as usual, pls leave a comment if u enjoyed this. i have been on the internet with no restrictions for as long as i can remember and now i dont know if ive done something unless other people acknowledge it. lmao but more than that, this chapter is super fucking long and scary as FUCK to post so like. jesus fuck i hope it's okay lol.

anyway uh. tune in next time for more sexual tension ~~and thinly veiled propaganda.~~ it'll be cool. we'll meet some more demons, uncover some dark secrets, delve deeper into How Shit Works, and of course, watch deku attempt to cope with this whole "hmm I think I want kacchan to touch me everywhere all the time?" development lmao

Chapter 13: Inferno II: No Masters

Chapter Summary

> “Give me a reason to give up on God.”

Chapter Notes

> this one's 11.5k and it's all over the place

See the end of the chapter for more notes

As Izuku laid in bed that night, all wrapped up in cozy sheets and staring at the ceiling, he found himself struggling with the same problem he did the night before. Namely, he couldn’t sleep—though this time it wasn’t due to racing thoughts so much as it was the fact that he’d only woken up around five hours earlier.

Although he knew Katsuki meant well, he couldn’t help but feel a bit aggravated with him. After all, if he hadn’t been so insistent, Izuku wouldn’t have this problem now.

With a sigh, he leaned over and switched the bedside lamp on. For a few minutes, he just sat there propped up against the back of the couch, twiddling his thumbs and gazing at nothing. Eventually, he stood and wandered over to the window, gently pushing the curtains open.

Outside, the city was alive and vibrant, downtown lights twinking like glitter. Izuku raked his hands through his hair and turned away, eyes roaming aimlessly around the quiet apartment. He paced around a bit, and then wandered over to Katsuki’s door. He pressed his ear against it, but could hear no sound coming from within. Shaking his head, he padded over to the large bookshelf in the corner on the living room and began to scan the shelves.

It hit him, as he was standing there, that for the first time in his memory, he could read anything he wanted.

Every book before him was his to experience, if he so desired. It was so bizarre, Izuku almost didn’t know how to process it. He kept having to remind himself of that fact every time he reflexively skipped over a title that felt like it’d be off-limits. It was strange how that worked—even with total freedom, his mind still operated as though he were in chains.

The top shelf was mostly cookbooks, it seemed, along with some faded copies of books with Russian-sounding authors. Curious, he picked one up, opened it to a random page and began to read.

In the United States, in the Democracy that authoritarians hold up to us as an ideal, the most scandalous fraudulency has crept into everything that concerns railroads. Thus, if a company ruins its competitors by cheap fares, it is often enabled to do so because it is reimbursed by land given to it by the State for a gratuity. Documents recently published concerning the American wheat trade…

Izuku closed the book, and put it back on the shelf.

Taking a deep breath, he moved on to the lower shelves, where most of the books appeared to be fiction. He wasn't really sure where to begin with those, and so he decided to just close his eyes and grab the first one he touched.

That ended up being a novel titled *Hiro Worship*. It wasn't particularly long, and so Izuku shrugged to himself, climbed back in to bed, and began to read.

He was surprised to discover that it was a romance novel. It became apparent rather quickly, just based on the way the two male leads were introduced and how they interacted. Still, it was surprising—Izuku hadn't pegged Katsuki as the sort of person who'd want to read something like this. But then, there was probably a lot he didn't know about him.

The book told the story of a young police officer, Shun Yamazaki, and the elusive thief, Hiro Nakamura, who he'd spent the past few years trying to catch. The two crossed paths at the scene of many of Hiro's heists, each time growing a little bit more familiar with one another.

After some amount of time, Hiro began regularly breaking into Shun's apartment. At first, he would simply sneak in to leave the officer notes or gifts, but eventually, the two began to spend deliberate time together. There was a bit of a ritualistic aspect to it; every time Hiro broke in, Shun would up his security measures, but when the time came, Hiro always found a way.

The tension between them was palpable.

Izuku found himself growing invested in the story rather quickly. The mystery surrounding Hiro, the constant will-they-won't-they. He was shocked by how quickly he'd managed to burn through the bulk of it.

It was during the final stretch of the novel that the perpetual game of cat and mouse finally came to an end, and in an immensely satisfying scene, the characters shared a passionate kiss.

Somehow, Izuku thought that would be the end of it.

And then he turned the page.

Hiro grabbed the front of Shun's shirt, fingers wrinkling the fabric as he urged him down onto his knees. Shun stared up at him hungrily, his cheek resting against his thigh.

Hiro reached into his pants and pulled himself out, smacking his dick against his lips. Shun closed his eyes, licking up the side before stretching his lips around the fat head

and sucking. Hiro groaned, fingers knotted in his hair as he spread his legs wider, beginning to thrust into his mouth.

"Fuck." He hissed. "Bet you'd look real good handcuffed to my bed, officer." He emphasized the word with a particularly deep thrust that had Shun moaning around his cock. Hiro grinned. "You like that, huh? Bet you'd scream and cry real pretty while I fucked you right in your tight little—"

Izuku slammed the book shut and threw it across the room. Luckily, it landed on a soft chair, making virtually no noise. He sat there paralyzed for what must have been several minutes, at least, his eyes bulging out of his skull, his face burning hot as he struggled to process what he'd just subjected himself to.

When he finally regained the ability to move, the first thing he did was stand up and grab the book again, sliding it back onto the shelf, though not before spending a few minutes obsessing over making sure he'd put it back *exactly* where he'd found it. He eventually crawled back into bed, switching off the lamp and wrapping himself up in blankets, as though they could protect him from the flow of his own thoughts.

As he laid there, staring at the ceiling again, he briefly contemplated picking up the political theory book again—just as a pallet cleanser—but he couldn't gather the willpower to emerge from the cocoon he'd built around himself.

And so it was just him, the blankets, the soft glow of the city outside, and his *own mind.*

Izuku squirmed, pulling the covers over his head. He wasn't sure why he felt guilty. He had no real way of knowing what sort of book he was getting into. Even the most wholesome of saints could've made the same mistake.

He just wasn't sure how to process the effect it had on him.

The issue was, it wasn't… unappealing, exactly. Sure, there was a part of him—the rational part—that recoiled at the thought of being spoken to like that. But on a deeper level…

Well. Izuku wasn't really sure how to sort through those feelings, and frankly, he wasn't sure he even wanted to. Wasn't sure if that would make things better or worse for him.

Izuku whimpered, curling up into a ball around his pillow. He closed his eyes and forced himself to remain still, ignoring any and all itches or urges to move.

Around half an hour later, he finally managed to fall asleep.

Izuku stood in the aisle between the pews, bathed in the warm light of sunset. Katsuki stood before him, his body backlit, his glowing eyes burning into Izuku's own. As he held eye contact, Izuku felt the familiar sensation of something clicking into place, and the subsequent weight in his mind that left Izuku hazy and pliant before him.

On some level, Izuku was aware that he had lived through this moment before.

Katsuki smirked, slow and dangerous.

"Get on your knees."

Immediately, Izuku dropped down, knees pressing against the dusty red carpet as he gazed straight ahead vacantly.

A moment passed by in silence as he waited for it to end. Waited for that weight to dissipate just as it had that day.

The Demon's hips came into focus.

And then Katsuki reached for his belt.

Izuku watched as he unbuckled it, heard the sound of leather sliding over leather. It all seemed to happen in slow motion, as though the extra weight in his mind had somehow encumbered his perception of time. The fabric rustled as he popped open the button fly and lowered his zipper.

Katsuki reached into his pants, and with a rough voice, he said: "Open your mouth, Deku."

Izuku did as he was told, his eyes slipping shut.

When he opened them next, however, he was no longer on his knees. In fact, he was in a completely different church.

He stood, backed up against a stained glass window. His mouth was still open, but where he'd expected to feel the press of hot, hard flesh, he instead felt the smooth skin of an apple against his lips. Katsuki stared down at him with heavy-lidded eyes, waiting. Izuku sunk his teeth into the fruit, tasting the sweet juice on his tongue. He felt Katsuki's fingers ghost over his nape gently just before he wrapped his hand around his neck.

Izuku shuddered, shivers running down his spine as he pressed into his touch.

And then Katsuki shoved his knee between his legs, and Izuku cried out, eyes tearing up as Katsuki rubbed between his thighs, pressed so hard his heels lifted off the ground.

Apple juice leaked from the corners of his mouth. Katsuki reached up to wipe it away. Except his hands weren't bare anymore.

Izuku wasn't standing up anymore, either.

As his eyes focused, he found himself lying on the training room floor, Katsuki on top of him, their bodies pressed together as the Demon looked down at him with heated eyes. He watched his gloved hand descend toward his mouth, tips of the claw caps ghosting over his lips.

But instead of covering his mouth, Katsuki pressed his fingers against it. Izuku released a startled noise as Katsuki's middle and index fingers dipped past his lips, running along the inside edge of the opening.

Then, he made eye contact with Izuku and slowly sunk his fingers inside.

Steady, steady—past his teeth, over tongue, and just barely into his throat.

Izuku's eyes began to water as his lips wrapped around Katsuki's knuckles. And then he started to move, thrusting them in and out in smooth strokes of his tongue, his teeth, the roof of his mouth, the insides of his cheeks—like he was trying to map out the features of Izuku's mouth, trying to commit them to memory.

Izuku felt something hot and tight coiling up inside of him. It was so bizarre, and yet his response came to him so naturally, it was sort of alarming in itself. Izuku squeezed his eyes shut, hollowed out his cheeks, and ***sucked.***

But before he knew it, he was standing up again, and Katsuki's fingers had been replaced by his tongue. Izuku was in the Demon's kitchen, pressed up against the countertop as Katsuki kissed him breathless.

Izuku dug his nails into the back of his neck as he gasped and whimpered. Katsuki's leg slotted between his thighs, and as the Demon bit his lip, he felt those hands slip lower, grabbing his ass and squeezing, pulling him harder into Katsuki's thigh.

Izuku moaned against his lips as he felt heat rushing south. Katsuki broke away from his mouth, kissed his jaw, down the column of his neck before sinking his teeth into his nape, just enough to hurt. His body burned. He felt the sting of Katsuki's teeth, of Katsuki's claws digging into the flesh of his ass. He felt the press of something big and hard against his stomach and nearly choked on his own spit when he realized it was Katsuki's cock.

"Shit." He groaned, low and reverberating through ever inch of his body. "Just can't help myself with you, baby." Izuku shuddered, squirming against his thigh, overwhelmed with sensation. "Wanna wreck you. But don't worry… I'll put you back together when I'm done."

Izuku cried out, something snapping inside him.

"Deku…"

His knees went weak, thighs clamping down around Katsuki's leg.

"Deku."

He felt like he was floating. Like he was in heaven— ***real*** *heaven. It couldn't get better than—*

"Oi, Deku!"

Izuku awoke with a start, his body tangled in the blankets. He was covered in sweat, and Katsuki was standing over him, holding a coffee mug in one hand.

It was a jarring change of pace, to say the least.

For several seconds, Izuku was frozen. He just lay there, staring up at Katsuki with wide eyes. He looked down at him, one elegant eyebrow arched as he sipped his coffee.

“The fuck’s up with you?”

At that, it all came rushing back. He felt the heat accumulating in his cheeks and instinctively pulled the sheets over his head.

“Deku?” Katsuki said, sounding mildly annoyed.

“B-Bright.” He squeaked, then cleared his throat. “It, um… hurts my eyes.”

Katsuki grumbled something inaudible, but seemed to accept the excuse. “Whatever.” He sighed. “It’s like, half past seven. You don’t gotta get up *immediately,* but if you wanna shower before we head out—and judging by how sweaty you are, I sure *hope* you fuckin’ do—then you’d better get on it.”

“R-Right.” Izuku gulped. “I’ll, um. I’ll do that.”

He grunted in acknowledgement, then added, “There’s coffee in the kitchen, if you want any.”

Izuku managed to squeeze out a *‘thank you.’* Then listened as Katsuki turned and retreated to his bedroom, presumably to get dressed.

Izuku moved to get out of bed, and then froze again. His eyes went wide, and he clutched the sheets tight in his fists.

His underwear felt… *wet.*

And *sticky.*

He could hear blood rushing in his ears. After the initial moment of shock, he sprung out of bed with renewed urgency and bolted toward the bathroom, forcefully shutting and locking the door behind him. He stood for a moment with his back pressed to it, panting, and then he heard a muffled voice yell from down the hall. “Oi, don’t slam the fuckin’ door!”

Izuku tensed. “Sorry!” He called back, his voice cracking. Izuku bit his lip, tasting blood, and forced himself to move again.

He took off everything else first. Obsidian rings. Shirt. Pants. Everything until he was standing there in front of Katsuki’s bathroom mirror in nothing but his soiled underwear. He slid his thumbs beneath the waistband and forced himself to look. As if he didn’t already know.

Yep. Izuku thought, with the sort of comedic absurdity that can only arise when your life is falling apart.

That sure is semen.

Izuku gulped, his throat tight, wincing as he carefully peeled his underwear off and turned on the sink, doing his best to rinse the stain out. He quietly weighed the pros and cons of just dropping it into the toilet and letting the hellfire destroy it, but fortunately, the stain was fresh enough for it to come out fairly easily.

Which means that it happened recently, he thought to himself, heart rate picking up. He turned off the water and glanced in the general direction of Katsuki's room, as though he could see through the walls.

How long has Kacchan been up? What if he… Izuku shook his head. *No. No, if he knew, he would've said something. He wouldn't be able to help himself.*

Suddenly, a foggy memory of dream-Katsuki violently forced its way into his consciousness.

"Just can't help myself with you, baby."

Izuku barely resisted the urge to slam his head against the bathroom mirror.

Instead, he redirected that impulse into his hands as he attempted to ring as much water out of the wet underwear as possible. With any luck, they'd be dry by the time Katsuki used the bathroom again. The less irregularities there were, the less questions Katsuki could ask.

He buried his underwear at the center of a ball consisting of his other clothes, and shoved it into the hamper.

Izuku turned on the shower and stepped under the warm spray, and with several more pumps of body wash than necessary, he destroyed the evidence. As the water swirled down the drain, he felt some of the tension release from his body. He took a deep breath and sighed, closing his eyes.

Izuku wasn't an idiot. He knew what happened.

He understood his anatomy, to the extent that he needed to be aware of it. Izuku woke up with erections on occasion. It was annoying and uncomfortable, but they always went down within a minute or two. And sure, on some level, he understood that this was a sexual phenomenon. But he never really thought about it that way. The morning erections weren't *pleasant*—if anything, they were a bit painful.

Even the current situation wasn't wholly unfamiliar to him. In fact, he'd woken up in a similar state a couple of times over the years. It was rare, and it was awkward, but it happened. He understood these sorts of things on a clinical level. It was easy not to think about them as they were when he experienced them outside of any sort of surrounding context. The key difference was that, those times, he never remembered the dreams he had leading up to the… *event.*

This time, the dream seemed determined to burn itself into his memory.

Izuku felt a tremor run down his spine. He could almost feel the phantom sensation of Katsuki's lips on his neck, and his cheeks heated up.

How am I supposed to look him in the eye after this?

Izuku sighed, turning off the water and stepping out onto the shower mat. He grabbed his towel and began drying himself off. It was at that moment that he realized he'd made a fatal error, and froze.

Clothes.

I forgot to bring a change of clothes!

Izuku's heart sped up again as he hastily wrapped the towel around his waist and silently argued with himself over what to do.

Should I ask Kacchan for help? To bring me a change of clothes? Izuku clenched his fists. *That'd be so awkward!*

After a moment of quiet panicking, he softly opened the door, nervously looking back and forth. From the bathroom, he could see straight into the living room, and Katsuki's bedroom was to his left. The closet where he kept his bag was in sight.

Maybe if I'm quick…

Izuku ran through the living room, clutching the towel around his waist. He grabbed the door knob, turning it sharply, and then shut himself inside.

He sighed. It was dark, and there was no light, so he had to search his bag more or less blindly.

He managed to get his underwear on just fine. It was only his pants that gave him trouble. He ended up tripping and falling against the wall with a heavy *thud.*

"Deku?"

Oh no.

Izuku squirmed, trying to get his pants on correctly, but it was no use. Katsuki was already turning the doorknob. Izuku scrambled, grabbing a handful of clothes from his bag and haphazardly throwing them over his hips and legs.

As light spilled into the closet, Izuku was left motionless on the floor, curled awkwardly on his side, half-hidden beneath a pile of assorted garments. He looked up at Katsuki, and found the Demon staring down at him, with the sort of blank expression that could only arise when one was presented with information they did not know how to classify.

After a moment, he raised his coffee cup to his lips and took a long sip.

"What the fuck are you doing?" He asked, conversationally.

For several seconds, Izuku just stared back at him, not really sure how to answer. Because really, what *was* he doing?

What was *anyone* doing?

“I…” He eventually said, squinting. “Uhhh, well… I… forgot to bring clothes… um. To the bathroom, so I was just…” Izuku trailed off. He wasn’t really sure how to explain the link between that and the present situation, so he just… didn’t. Instead, he squirmed on the floor, and tried to surreptitiously reach under the pile of clothes and tug at his pants.

“What’s goin’ on under there.” Katsuki asked, with almost no intonation. Izuku paused, then went limp, staring blankly at Katsuki’s shoes.

“…The consequences of my actions.”

Katsuki laughed, and the sound broke the weird spell he’d been under. Izuku sighed.

“I, uh, went in here to get dressed, and… Well. I was putting on my pants, but for some reason I can’t get them to go up all the way. I still can’t. I don’t know why.”

Katsuki took a loud slurp of his coffee. “It’s ‘cuz they’re half inside out.”

Izuku blinked, turning to look up at him again. “What?”

Katsuki gestured down with his coffee mug, at the place where Izuku’s lower legs emerged from beneath the pile of clothing. “Your left pant leg’s inside out. The right one isn’t.”

“…Oh.”

“Dunno why you’d pack your clothes like that, but—“

“—I was in a rush!”

“All that tells me is you have a habit of takin’ your pants off like that and then just fuckin’ leaving ‘em that way.” He said. “Maybe try *folding* your shit next time.”

Izuku pursed his lips, glaring up at him. For a few seconds, Katsuki just stared back down at him.

“Anyway, you should come outta the closet.” He deadpanned, taking another sip of his coffee.

He blinked a few more times. “Wait, what?”

“Come outta the closet, Deku.” He repeated. “I promise, this problem will cease to exist if you simply *exit this fuckin’ closet.”*

“Kacchan, I’m not wearing *pants!”*

“I don’t mind.”

“That’s not the issue, here!”

“Would it make you feel better if I took off my pants, too?”

Izuku flushed. “Why would that make me feel *better?!”*

“I dunno.” He shrugged. “I want you to come out, Deku. I’m just tryna create some incentive, here: come outta the closet, and I will take my pants off.”

Izuku narrowed his eyes. “That sounds more like a *threat* than an incentive.”

He smirked against the lip of his coffee mug. “Oh, I won’t do anything you won’t *enjoy…”*

Izuku squirmed in place, cheeks burning hotter. “C-Close the door, Kacchan!”

Katsuki snickered, disappearing as the door clicked shut in front of him, casting Izuku into darkness once more.

When Izuku finally managed to make himself decent enough to open the door, he found Katsuki slouching in a chair in the living room, holding some sort of touch pad in his hands. Izuku quietly ducked into the kitchen to get himself a cup of coffee. He was more of a tea person than a coffee person, but given how little sleep he’d gotten the night before, he figured he could use the caffeine.

He poured himself a cup and looked around, searching for the sugar. There was a small container set out beside the coffee maker, filled with assorted substances. The proximity of it suggested that these were meant to be added to coffee, but none of them looked like sugar. Izuku headed out into the living room again, where Katsuki was still sitting in the same place. He looked up as he walked in.

“Uh, where’s the sugar?”

Katsuki hesitated, like he had to think about it for a moment. “Second shelf in the pantry.” He then said.

Izuku muttered a *thanks* and went back to the kitchen. He returned a minute later, with a mug of steaming coffee in hand, and went to sit beside Katsuki. He peered over at the screen, but saw only a wall of text. Katsuki tapped something on the touchpad, and the screen lit up green, and then proceeded to another screen not unlike the one before it.

“Um. What are you doing…?”

“Voting.”

“Oh?” He perked up, leaning closer. “On what?”

He just shrugged. “Nothing special.”

Izuku frowned, sipping his coffee. “Voting on anything at all seems pretty special to me.”

Katsuki sighed, another screen lighting up green. “Here.” He handed the pad to Izuku. “Hit the arrows to flip through it.”

Izuku accepted it, and began to do just that. He scanned the first proposal.

Oseryth Dist. 7, Proposal E 508 — Theater on Sadith and Mocna.

The workers of the Korraiyasant Construction Collective request consent to build a community theater on the corner of Sadith and Mocna. This space, formerly utilized by the Saurex Redicent, is deprecated and in need of…

Izuku's eyes glazed over after that. He scrolled down, noting the Katsuki had voted *yes* on that one, and flipped to the next.

Special Proposal Sigma 3369: Trial Run of Emerging Weather Neutralization technology

New research at the Northern Weather and Safety Center has led to the development of promising rain neutralization technology. Analysis of existing weather control systems have led to the conclusion that the safest cities to test this technology in each region are:

Central Region: Erykos

Southern Region: Kolarthm

Northern Region: Svaakyr

Western Region: Aerolijk

Eastern Region: Oseryth

NWSC researchers request the consent of the population of these cities to deploy experimental technology in these locations. Please consult the following documents for in-depth information regarding potential risks.

He scrolled down. Katsuki voted *yes* on that, too.

After that, Izuku stopped really reading the proposals. He just glanced at the titles and Katsuki's responses.

Grand Proposal X 1092 — Harvesting Crystals from Sjerre Park

Vote: ***No.***

Oseryth Collective Proposal G 288 — Expansion of Underground Bunkers

Vote: ***Yes.***

Subregional Proposal K 221 — Expansion of Central Pyrofutia Farmland

Vote: ***No.***

"Do you just… vote on everything?"

“Not everything. Only the shit that could impact me personally.” Katsuki said, taking the touchpad when Izuku handed it back to him. “Routine shit, or things that have no real chance of affecting larger communities, are handled internally within firms.”

“Huh…” Izuku said. “Who supervises that?”

“What d’you mean?”

“Just… I mean, how do you make sure things actually get done?”

Katsuki blinked, staring at him blankly. Izuku shifted uncomfortably.

“Are you asking me how you make sure that a construction firm…” He narrowed his eyes. “Constructs shit?”

“I mean… if everyone’s provided for, anyway.”

Katsuki sighed. “Deku, if no one did anything, providing for people wouldn’t be possible.”

“Okay, but if *one* person did nothing, they could still be provided for.”

“Here’s the thing, Deku. Contrary to what you might think, most people actually *enjoy* being, like, productive and shit. They just don’t like working for the sake of it. They want to feel like they’re contributing to society somehow.”

“But what about the people who don’t care about that? How do you make them contribute?”

“We don’t.”

“You… what?”

Katsuki shrugged. “First of all, it’s not a big enough problem to be a widespread drain on resources. We can provide for a few non-contributors, it’s really not a big deal. Second of all, if you can’t trust people to do their part, why should we trust them to supervise others?”

“I’m… not sure what you’re saying.”

“Lemme put it like this.” Katsuki said. “There are two options here as far as people’s nature goes. Either people are *good,* or people are *imperfect.”* He turned off the touch pad, setting it aside. “If people are *good,* then no one has to *tell* them to be good.” He stood up, stretching his arms over his head. “If people are imperfect, then we obviously can’t trust them to rule over other people.”

Izuku stared at him for a moment. “That seems… overly simplistic, somehow.”

He raised an eyebrow. “You got a counterargument?”

Izuku blinked. “I’ll…” He squinted. “Get back to you on that?”

Katsuki snorted, pulling his gloves out of his pockets. Izuku sat there and watched as he slid them on. “You ready?”

He donned the artifice, and they were on their way.

The train ride took about fifteen minutes. Izuku was still nervous being out and about around other Demons, but Katsuki remained a comforting, if slightly sadistic, presence. He stuck close to him on the train, and on the walk afterward. He stuck close when they reached the massive entrance to the place Katsuki had referred to as, *‘The Academy.’*

Once they were inside, Katsuki took off his jacket and grabbed his arm, causing the mark to glow.

“Hey, we’re here.” A pause. “Mmkay. See ya soon, then.” He turned toward Izuku. “He’s says he’ll meet us in a minute.

But Izuku didn’t really hear him. He was too busy staring at what stood at the center of the room.

There, hovering above a small table, was an odd, silvery sphere. As he got closer, he noticed that the table had what appeared to be two large hand prints embedded into it. He waved his hand under the sphere, confirming that it was, in fact, floating.

“Kacchan, what is this?”

“Oh, that?” Katsuki stepped up next to him. “S’called a touch stone.” He said. “Most magic lessons are taught in this building, so they gotta ton of these around here.”

Izuku cocked his head. “What does it do?”

Katsuki bumped shoulders with him, prompting him to step out of the way. He pulled his gloves off, shoving them into his pockets before planting his hands right in the impressions in the table.

Instantly, the sphere, which had been around the size of a small watermelon, shrunk down to the size of a tiny pebble, hellfire emanating from the surface, brighter than the sun. Katsuki turned and looked at him.

“It allows us to see the state of our souls.” He explained. “It’s real handy, ‘specially for beginners.”

“That’s… incredible,” Izuku breathed, hands covering his mouth. “Your *soul* is doing that right now?”

“Sure is.” He replied, grinning. Izuku couldn’t even find the will to scoff at his obvious arrogance. It was too amazing for him to do much more than stare at it in awe.

“It does somethin’ different for each type, of course.”

Suddenly, the fire went out, and it returned to its original size for a second before it changed again. This time, it transformed into a gas. It wasn't quite as dramatic, but the way the vapor rotated and coiled was a spectacle in its own rite.

"This is Envy."

The touch stone returned to its solid state again, and then abruptly melted down into a liquid, swirling around in the air.

"And this is Lust."

Izuku circled around the display, trying to look at it from all angles. "That's so *cool."* He couldn't help but enthuse. "Are they all like that? State changes?"

"Not all of 'em." He said. "Some of 'em just change certain properties. Gluttony's the weirdest, in my opinion."

"What's Gluttony?" Izuku asked. "Can you do that one, too?"

"A bit," Katsuki shrugged. "It's been a while, though." His brows pinched together as he leaned against the table, pressing his hands harder into the imprints. After a second, the once-perfect sphere began to deform, taking on an almost clay-like appearance.

"What is it doing, now?"

Katsuki quirked an eyebrow, side-eying him. "Why don't you try touchin' it and see for yourself?"

"…Is that safe?"

"Wouldn't suggest it if it wasn't."

Tentatively, Izuku reached out, and at first, lightly touched the wobbly mass. It was soft, and oddly… *sticky?* Izuku pinched one piece of it and pulled, amazed at the way it stretched. "It's like gum." He commented, going to grab a bigger piece, only for his fingers to hit a solid mass.

"Can't do it with the whole thing," Katsuki told him, as though he had read his mind. "Never studied Gluttony beyond the basics." He took his hands out of the imprints, and the stone returned to its normal, solid state. "If you wanna get the full picture, you'll need to talk to an actual Gluttony Demon."

"Still," Izuku said, smiling brightly. "That's amazing, Kacchan! What about the others?" He asked, practically bouncing up and down. "Can you do them all?"

"To an extent, yeah." He shrugged. "Most Demons learn the basics of all of 'em before we pick one to specialize in."

"Then there's three more, right?" Izuku asked. "Can I see them?"

Katsuki smirked. “What do you wanna see first?”

Izuku hummed, thinking about it. “Pride?”

Katsuki planted his hands into the impressions again, and the soul stone blew up to about four times its normal size. He raised an eyebrow. “Next?”

“Sloth!”

The stone shrunk back down to its original size, and Katsuki closed his eyes, concentrating. Izuku watched, transfixed, as ice crystals started to form on the surface. “Can I touch it?”

“Go for it.”

Izuku smiled, lightly brushing his fingers across the frozen surface. “Amazing…” Katsuki opened his eyes, and he felt the stone slowly return to room temperature. “That just leaves Greed, right?”

Katsuki grunted, brows pinching together. To Izuku’s confusion, however, the stone didn’t seem to change. “Is… something happening?”

Katsuki hummed, looking around the room. “See that little box in the corner, there?” He nodded toward it. “Grab it and open it up.”

Izuku all but ran over to it, picking it up and pulling off the wooden lid. All he managed to see was a flash of something metallic and a blur of movement before the box was empty, all the magnets sticking to the surface of the soul stone.

“You might wanna get behind me for this part.”

Izuku hurried over, standing behind Katsuki, but leaning to the side to watch. Just as quickly, the magnets were repelled, shooting out in an arc and colliding with the walls, only to reverse a moment later and return to the stone. He released them a second later, cupping his hands under the stone to catch the magnets, and depositing them into the box in Izuku’s hands. “As you’ve probably guessed, Greed manipulates charge.”

“Wow,” Izuku breathed. “That was incredible, Kacchan!”

“And I’m not even a damn specialist in most of those.” He said. “There’s Greed Demons who can fire magnets like bullets, even generate electricity. Envy Demons who can surround ‘emselves with soul vapor and bend light around their bodies. Lust Demons who can send droplets into open wounds to enter someone’s bloodstream, and use that to control their movements manually…” He shrugged. “People come up with new techniques all the time. ‘Course, mine’s still the best one.”

Izuku nodded. “Wrath *definitely* looks the coolest!”

Katsuki smirked. “Y’think so, nerd?”

“Yeah!” Izuku barely resisted the urge to jump up and down. “It’s so… *flashy,* and intimidating. Like turning your soul into a star. I bet there’s a lot of cool things you can do with that. You’ll have to show me sometime!”

Katsuki leaned in, looking down at him with heavy-lidded eyes. “Oh, I could show you some moves.”

Izuku blushed at the proximity, nodding awkwardly.

“Oh, Bakugou. Are you flirting, or just showing off?” Izuku jumped at the sound of another man’s voice, spinning around.

There stood a man with long, dark hair, wearing a grey scarf around his neck. He reminded him of Shinsou, a bit, in the sense that he, too, looked as though he hadn’t slept in years.

“I’ll have you know I’m flirting *and* showing off.”

The man snorted, taking a few steps toward them.

“Deku, this is Aizawa. He’s the current Oseryth nexus.”

“Ah!” Izuku tensed a bit, extending his hand toward him. “Um, n-nice to meet you!”

The man shook his hand, looking him in the eyes. “Don’t be so nervous.” He said, before turning on his heel and beckoning for them to follow. “C’mon. We’ll take this upstairs.”

Aizawa led them to an office at the end of a third-story corridor. Two chairs were already set out for them in front of the desk, and after Aizawa sat down, he swiveled around in his chair, grabbing a pot of coffee set out behind him. He poured himself a cup, and then turned around again, looking at Izuku and raising an eyebrow. “You can take the artifice off now. There’s no one else around.”

“Ah, right.” Izuku muttered, reaching around the back of his neck to unhook it. He tucked it away into his pocket, glancing at Katsuki. “Don’t let me forget to put it back on again.”

“Yeah, yeah. I won’t.” Katsuki turned his attention to Aizawa. “So, you’ve read the whole thing?”

The man set down his coffee mug.

“Cover to cover.” He said, before opening his desk drawer and pulling the journal out. He set it down and slid it across the desk toward Izuku. “I’ve already made a record of it all. However…” He looked up at Izuku. “I need to verify that this is a trustworthy source before we move any further.”

Izuku perked up. “Oh.” He said. “Well… to the best of my knowledge, it’s accurate.” He shrugged. “My mentor is a third-sphere Angel. I don’t see any reason for him to lie…” He faltered, wincing slightly. “At this point, anyway… He’s a good man.”

“Sure.” Aizawa took another sip of his coffee. “But how do we know *you’re* trustworthy?”

“Aizawa.” Katsuki said.

“It’s a perfectly rational question to ask, Bakugou.”

“Well, the answer is because *I* know he is.” Katsuki shot back, clearly irritated. “I can vouch for him.”

“And you’re absolutely sure about that?”

“Fucking obviously, *idiot.* You think I’d just bring someone all the way down here without fuckin’ *vetting* them first? You—“

“Kacchan…” Izuku put a hand on his arm, putting on his best reassuring smile. Katsuki side-eyed him as he continued softly, “It’s okay. Really.”

Katsuki looked back and forth between Aizawa and Izuku for a moment, and then sighed, slouching down in his chair.

“‘Kacchan,’ huh?” He smirked. “Well, I guess that’s all I really need to hear.”

Izuku blushed.

“Anyway,”Aizawa went on. “What I’ve read corroborates much of what we already know, so I feel fairly confident in saying that the information presented here is accurate.”

Katsuki glared. “Then why’d you act so damn suspicious at first?”

Aizawa gave Katsuki a look that seemed to deepen the bags beneath his eyes.

“Bakugou, I know that as a principal Wrath Demon you’re not exactly accustomed to these sorts of procedures, but it really is nothing personal.” He said, tone a bit softer. “It would be irresponsible to simply take an Angel’s trustworthiness for granted, even if the information appears to be legitimate.”

Katsuki stared at him for a moment, then tore his eyes away with a long exhale. “Whatever,” He grumbled.

After a brief pause, Aizawa added, “Frankly, I ought to be interrogating him much, *much* more. The only reason I’m not is because I *know* you. The fact that an Angel has managed to gain the confidence of *you,* of *all* people, is a testament to his trustworthiness in itself.”

His gaze snapped back onto him. “Oh yeah?” Katsuki narrowed his eyes. “Does that mean you’ll stop fucking with his emotions now?”

Izuku froze for a moment, and then slowly turned to look at the other Demon, who simply sat there with a deceptively bored expression, fingers drumming along the surface of the desk.

Aizawa hummed, closing his eyes and sitting back in his chair. Izuku felt something release, like a soft phantom of a sensation in his mind. He would've probably never even noticed it if he hadn't been paying attention.

Izuku gulped, suddenly growing nervous again. It was nothing like the feeling he'd gotten when Katsuki had hypnotized him.

"Y-You…" Izuku gulped. "You're a Lust Demon."

He shrugged. "Sorry. You seemed nervous, is all."

"And now he's even *more* nervous than he otherwise would've been." Katsuki said, monotone.

"Wh-What did you do, exactly…?"

"Nothing much. I just eased your anxiety a bit." He replied. "If it makes you feel any better, I'm doing the same with Bakugou."

"The difference is that I'm a Demon, so I see you doing it. Deku doesn't."

"It's easy to forget when you mostly interact with other Demons." He shrugged.

"But you're not doing it anymore, right…?"

"I'm not."

Izuku glanced at Katsuki, searching for confirmation.

"He's telling the truth." Katsuki told him. And that, at least, put Izuku's mind at ease.

He took another sip of his coffee. "Anyway, back to the matter at hand." He set his mug down, the cup hitting the desk like a gavel. "It feels strange to say this, but it's my opinion that the information provided is sufficient to infiltrate Heaven. Many of the questions we've been asking are answered here." He paused. "That said, it also presents us with a number of challenges that we weren't aware of."

"And knowing how slippery these fuckers are, it's safe to assume that's just the tip of the iceberg." Katsuki added.

He nodded, grunting in agreement.

"So then…" Izuku said. "What's the plan?"

Aizawa looked at him, raising an eyebrow. "There is no plan. Not yet, at least."

Izuku blinked. "Well, how soon will we be able to act?" He asked. "Can you at least give a rough estimate?"

“That’ll depend on the scale of the plan and how quickly we’ll be able allocate the necessary resources.”

“Isn’t there any way to speed things up?” He pressed. “I mean, can’t you override that process?”

Aizawa and Katsuki exchanged looks.

“Deku, we talked about this. Aizawa doesn’t have that kind of power.”

Izuku frowned. “Well, can’t you take me to someone who does?”

“No.” Katsuki said. “Deku, *no one* has that much power, at least not for shit like this.”

“But this is an emergency!”

“I don’t see that being the case.” Aizawa said.

“What do you mean?” Izuku asked, his heart rate picking up. “Sir, the Council took him. If we don’t act fast, who knows what could happen?” His voice broke. “What if they k-kill him? Or, or turn him into a husk, or—“

“Alright, first of all.” Aizawa interjected, holding up one finger. “Don’t call me ‘sir.’ It’s weird.” He raised a second finger. “Second, both of those cases seem highly unlikely.”

“What?” Izuku froze. “Why…?”

“Because they need information from him.”

Izuku’s brow furrowed. “But… you saw the letter.” He said. “Whatever he used to wipe his memories will have worn off by now.”

“It’s not about that.” He paused, raising his coffee mug to his lips, taking a long sip and finishing it off. “Here’s the thing.” He then said. “Few Angels manage to fall after being captured, and much less in the past few hundred years since the addition of this so-called *‘Acolyte’* rank. However, in every case we’ve seen, the process has taken at least a month to complete, at an absolute minimum.”

Izuku started at him for a while. “Process…?”

“Whatever interrogation tactics they use.” He shrugged. “Not much is really known about the specifics. In most cases, people don’t remember anything at all, and in the ones where they do, it seems all they can really recall are vague memories of having weird dreams.” He said. “But the duration is easy enough to ascertain. If your last clear memory was in early March and your next is in the middle of April… well, there you go.”

Izuku nodded slowly. “So then… What you’re saying is…”

“At an absolute minimum, we have two weeks before your mentor’s life or soul come under legitimate threat.” He supplied. “Almost certainly more than that, since he had the foresight

to pre-wipe his memories. Given the depth of knowledge displayed in that journal of yours, I doubt you'll be the only person he ends up implicating. The Council would logically want to get everything they can out of him."

Izuku remained silent, staring down at the journal that still sat before him, chewing his lip.

Eventually, he swallowed, and asked, "Can we act within two weeks?"

"Sure." Aizawa replied. "Again, it'll depend on the plan we settle on."

"Have you put in the request?" Katsuki asked.

He grunted. "Grand allseer network tonight at six."

Izuku blinked. "Grand *what?"*

"That's the main job of the Nexus." Katsuki told him. "It's how they're able to communicate so efficiently. Kind of like a tiered, selective hivemind."

That raises more questions than it answers.

"A grand allseer network is one that involves every other defense nexus in Hell." Aizawa said. "I'm sure Bakugou could explain it to you in more detail later, but at this point, I really need to point out that we've yet to actually get to the true purpose of this meeting."

Izuku's brow furrowed, forcing his curiosity down as he waited quietly for the man to go on.

Aizawa leaned forward, resting his forearms on the desk. "So, I'm assuming, since you're here right now, that you're willing to help us further. Is that correct?"

Izuku quickly nodded. "Of course."

"Good." He said. "I can't speak for everyone, obviously, but I think the majority of us are willing to help you out, as well."

He paused for a moment that seemed to last an eternity.

"However, you need to understand what that actually entails. I need you to understand that we're talking about invading Heaven, here. Do you know when the last successful invasion of Heaven was?"

Izuku shook his head.

"Never." Aizawa said. "It's never been done." The words hung in the air for a moment. Izuku's eyes widened, a cold feeling dropping into his gut.

"Heaven is exceptionally secure," He continued. "Everything about it, from its very conception, has been designed to keep Demons out, categorically. What we have right now, along with hundreds of years of research and technological development, may be enough to override that, but it could just as easily be snuffed out. Then we're back to square one.

“Given that, if we’re going to do this, it will need to be big enough to justify the risk of wasting all that effort.”

Izuku gulped, a nauseous feeling creeping up his esophagus. “I’m…” He swallowed. “Not sure I follow.”

But he knew, just like everyone else knew, that it was a lie.

Aizawa lowered his chin. “Midoriya, if you’re going to help us, you should understand that you won’t just be helping us win another battle.” He paused. “You’ll be helping us win the *war.”*

Izuku laced his hands together, to try and keep them from trembling. He couldn’t find it in himself to respond verbally. Katsuki placed one gloved hand over Izuku’s, stabilizing them. The warmth of his hand radiated through the gloves.

Izuku took a deep breath, and asked, “What happens… if you manage to succeed?”

“The dogma that pervades Heaven is one which sees Demons as subhuman. The goal of the Council is to either force us back into eternal torment, or wipe us out entirely.” He said. “It’s an inherently violent ideology. As long as it continues to exist, we will never be safe.”

Izuku felt his throat closing, his vision darkening at the edges.

“So what do you do?” He asked. “When does it end?”

Aizawa paused. Izuku closed his eyes.

“I think you already know the answer to that question.”

As they left the Academy, Katsuki held his hand, but he couldn’t feel it, could hardly perceive his own thoughts. Katsuki actually *did* have to stop him and remind him to put the artifice back on before they left.

They walked hand in hand down the street in downtown Oseryth. He didn’t take note of their surroundings in any sort of persistent, lasting way. It was all just colors and shapes to him, a strange backdrop to a dream he couldn’t wake up from. It wasn’t until Katsuki set something down in front of him and said, *‘eat’* that he began to register reality again.

Izuku blinked a few times, his brain struggling to get things going again. He looked around, and realized they were in a bakery or cafe of some kind. He was sitting in a chair across from Katsuki, at a table next to the front window. He met Katsuki’s eyes and found him staring back at him. Only then did he look down at what was in front of him.

It seemed to be some sort of frosted pastry. Izuku’s brow furrowed, and he looked back up at Katsuki.

“It’s safe.” He said, sipping an iced coffee. “It’s just an apple fritter.”

Izuku nodded quietly, and tentatively picked it up. He took a small bite…

…And then immediately took a larger one, scarfing down half of it in a matter of seconds.

“Woah, hey.” Katsuki said. “Slow down, nerd. You’re gonna choke.”

His self-awareness slammed back into him like a freight train, and Izuku immediately dropped the pastry back on to the plate, blushing bright red.

“Sorry.” Izuku gulped, his shoulders pulling up and inward as his eyes darted around the bakery. Luckily, no one seemed to be looking at them.

Katsuki scoffed. “You don’t gotta apologize.” He stood up. “One sec.” He walked away, and a minute later returned with a glass of water. Izuku accepted it, holding it in both hands as he sipped.

Katsuki sat down again and set his forearms flat on the table, leaning toward him.

“Seriously, though, are you okay?” He asked softly.

He hesitated a moment. “Y-Yeah, I just…” He sighed. “I don’t know.”

A pause.

“Are you scared?”

Izuku’s eyes widened. He gulped. “I don’t… know if that’s the right was to put it.” His brow furrowed. Katsuki took a sip of what looked to be an iced coffee, and waited.

In a sense, Izuku supposed that he was scared. But it was complicated.

He knew that what he’d come here to do would have some sort of impact on the state of affairs between Heaven and Hell. He just hadn’t thought about where exactly it would ultimately lead them, at least not *consciously.* The war had always felt so much bigger than him. It was hard enough to imagine that he, a first-sphere Angel, could affect the outcome in any meaningful way.

The end of Heaven felt like the end of the world.

He needed to save All Might. There were no other options in his mind. He simply *had to do it.*

But… if doing that means…

Izuku swallowed.

He kept thinking that there had to be another way. There had to be some way to save All Might without betraying everything he was. This just wasn’t something Izuku could come to grips with.

Maybe there was a part of him that never expected to make it this far. But he was here, now, and the questions he didn't want to confront were on the table in clear terms. He couldn't avoid them any longer. As Aizawa spoke those words, it all came crashing down on him, and he didn't know what to do. He was like a deer in the headlights of reality.

He couldn't keep playing both sides. Izuku needed to decide, once and for all, who was in the right. He needed to decide where his loyalties lied.

Izuku took another bite of the apple fritter, chewing slowly as he scanned his surroundings. People sitting together in the bakery, eating and chatting happily. People passing by the window, smiling, holding hands. And Katsuki sitting across from him, his elbow on the table, cheek resting against his palm as he slurped down the last of his drink.

And Izuku knew he didn't want to be anywhere but here. He didn't want this moment to end.

Izuku had always been taught to regard joy and pleasure with suspicion. Nothing was ever as nice as it seemed, and if it was, then it was probably wrong. But as he sat there, watching Katsuki—handsome, brash, crude, *caring* Katsuki—he thought back to how he felt before he'd met him. How tiring it was to live as he did, work as he did. How physically and mentally draining.

Living like that was difficult.

In retrospect, the most exhausting part was convincing himself that that was as good as it could get.

Izuku's body curled inward. He could contemplate it as much as he wanted, but at the end of the day, he knew he was going to do it. Could see the event coming toward him steadily, ready to happen to him. Ultimately, these quiet ruminations were of no consequence for anything other than Izuku's feelings about the event that would inevitably unfold.

It was going to happen.

It was going to *hurt.*

And Izuku needed to feel okay with that, somehow.

And so, he looked up at Katsuki and muttered something quietly, half-hoping he wouldn't hear it.

"Hm?" Katsuki set his drink down, leaning toward him. "What was that?"

Izuku gulped. "I asked you to give me a reason."

Katsuki's brow furrowed.

Izuku took a deep, shuddering breath.

"Give me a reason to give up on God." He whispered. "To want to kill him."

Izuku could tell right away that Katsuki knew what he needed to show him. He could see it in his eyes.

Despite that, he initially pushed back.

"I don't want you to have to see that." He'd told him.

The irony was not lost on Izuku. Despite having spent the last several months painstakingly whittling away at Izuku's faith, when the opportunity to deal the final blow was presented to him on a silver platter, Katsuki resisted.

But in the end, he acquiesced. And that's how Izuku found himself back aboard a train beyond the city limits. Katsuki didn't say much about where they were going, only that the length of the trip meant they wouldn't be able to stay for long.

Izuku sat in the corner beside Katsuki, fidgeting with his sleeves. He occasionally glanced over at him, but Katsuki rarely glanced back. His expression always seemed distant, as if he'd forgotten his mind back in the city. Izuku wondered, from time to time, if asking this of him might have been insensitive, somehow. But it wasn't like he had any way of knowing where the request would take them.

They finally got off at a stop about two hours north of Oseryth. The platform was not unlike the one near Serpent's Crossing, in that it was cast in the same black, obsidian stone. There were a few trails sprouting from it in various directions. Katsuki took none of them. He simply walked straight through the tall grass, leading Izuku into the sparse forest beyond.

Izuku looked around nervously, remembering what Katsuki had told him about the Wilds. "Um, Kacchan?" He jogged to catch up with him. "Isn't this a bit dangerous?"

"No." Katsuki replied. "Not here, at least. You gotta venture a few more miles away before you start runnin' into any sort of aggressive wildlife." He paused for a moment, his mouth still open, like he wasn't sure if he should say any more. Then, he gestured broadly at the forest around them, and in a quiet voice, he said, "Most of these trees are dead."

Izuku's brows shot up, his eyes widening as he looked around them. It was only then that he really noticed the state of the trees. Though most were still standing, he noted that many looked somehow… faded. But oddly, none of them appeared to be rotting.

The further they ventured, the less trees there were, until eventually there was nothing but rocky terrain and gravel. Izuku felt an ominous feeling rising in his gut as he trailed behind Katsuki, staring at the back of his head. His posture seemed to indicate relaxation, but Izuku knew better. He knew that this was hurting him, in some way. He just didn't know how.

Eventually, they reached the crest of a large hill. Katsuki came to a stop a little ways ahead, where the ground plateaued for a few feet before dropping off completely. Izuku hurried to catch up, coming to stand beside him at the edge of the cliff.

He had meant to ask what was wrong.

But when the time came, there was nothing Izuku knew how to say.

Down below the cliff, the color of the landscape gradually desaturated. The soil, the rocks, the trees and the shrubs—all of it faded to an ashy, grey tone that spanned a radius of around twenty feet. Beyond that point, the grey slowly became lighter until everything that touched the ground was as white as fresh snow.

And then there was the town at the center of it all.

It wasn't a large town. Probably less than a thousand people, judging by the number of houses in sight. But if there were any people still living there, Izuku didn't see them.

Every building within the settlement was bleached as white as the surrounding land, and for a minute, all Izuku could do was stand there, gaping at it. The town gave off a surreal, sterile feeling that sent shivers down Izuku's spine. It was as though something had leeched all the color from the area. Cut open the land and bled it dry.

Perhaps the strangest part of it all was that, apart from the absence of color, all the buildings, structures, and plant life seemed completely unharmed. They just stood there, frozen, vacant and hostile. And the longer Izuku looked at it, the more he began to feel like he wasn't supposed to.

"Toxic blessation." Katsuki said. Breaking the silence. Making Izuku jump.

He did a double take. "Wh-What?"

Katsuki clenched his jaw slightly. "That's what it's called." He muttered. "Toxic blessation. It's the result of overexposure to divine light." He kicked the gravel beneath his foot. "When a Demon gets hit by divine light, they die. This…" he gestured vaguely down toward the town, *"bleaching* effect is what happens when it's prolonged, or concentrated."

Izuku's breath caught in his throat. "You mean…" He looked out at the town, a metallic taste on his tongue. *"We* did this…?"

Katsuki turned toward him, finally. "Not you." He said softly. *"Them,* Deku. *They* did this."

For a moment, Izuku was silent, his heart in his throat. "Is… Is it *all* like this?"

Katsuki hesitated for a second. "Probably… but we don't know for sure. None of us can go down there."

Izuku looked at him again, his brow furrowing.

"We call it *'toxic'* for a reason." He offered a bitter smile. "Most of the people down here didn't die from direct exposure. They died because of the hostile environment it creates.

"If I were to set foot on the bleached part, I'd make it maybe thirty seconds or so. After that, I'd go into something a bit like anaphylactic shock and collapse." He closed his eyes. "It eats away at your soul. I'd be gone within a few minutes." He took a deep breath. "It's… a very painful way to die."

Katsuki paused, sighing. When he spoke next, his voice sounded rougher.

“The grey zone’s… survivable. But you’ll still get real fuckin’ sick. You’d be lucky not to develop some kinda chronic illness.”He opened his eyes, wincing a bit. “Frankly, even standin’ this close is makin’ me kinda nervous. It’s supposed to be harmless at this distance, but it’s still makin’ me feel all psychosomatically itchy.” He peeled the gloves back a bit, scratching his forearms.

For a few seconds, neither of them spoke.

“How many?” Izuku whispered.

A pause.

“Around six-hundred or so.”

Izuku clenched his fists, eyes darting around, searching for a path down the cliffside.

“Deku, I know what you’re thinking.” He muttered. “But trust me, you really, *really* don’t wanna go down there.”

Izuku frowned. “…Is it dangerous for me, too?”

“Who knows.” He shrugged. “But even if it’s not, it’s still a terrible fuckin’ idea. It takes ages to get all the bodies out, ‘cuz we have to do it all remotely. We haven’t found any more at this *specific* site, but—“

“There are *others?”*

Katsuki blinked. “Well, yeah. Dozens.” He replied, as though it were obvious. Izuku slowly raised his hands to his mouth, covering it. “The worst attack was two years ago, up in the Northern Region. Kataghaerek. Estimates up there run at around twenty-thousand.” He shoved his hands into his pockets. “We still find bodies there, every goddamn day.”

For a few seconds, Izuku just stood there. Everything Katsuki said sounded muffled to his eyes as the static white noise of his rushing blood seemed to take precedence.

“That’s why you shouldn’t go down there, Deku. We think we got all of ‘em, but,” He grimaced. “I can’t promise you won’t… uncover something… if you go lookin’ around.”

Izuku wasn’t sure how long it was before he managed to gather his thoughts enough to speak once more.

“How…” He gulped. “How long has it been?”

“For this one? About fifty years.”

“Fifty?!”

He nodded. “Even after decades, it still looks like a fucked up colorless version of what it used to be. Like everything’s just frozen in time. It’s all just… dead.” His voice broke. Katsuki clenched his jaw, muscles tensing up as he apparently fought to reign himself in. Then, after what felt like an eternity, he said, “Nothing will ever live or grow down there again.”

Izuku shook his head, his eyes starting to water. “But… why…?” He whispered. “Is this just… b-because of the war?”

Katsuki turned to look at him again.

“No, Deku.” He said. “The war is because of *this.”*

Izuku’s brow wrinkled as he stared back at him, and something seemed to break through. “Wait, but—*n-no,* the—“ He gulped. “The war started because of Demonic presence on Earth.”

“Demons have *always* had a limited presence on Earth.” Katsuki told him. “But for tactical purposes, our presence increased a couple hundred years ago, after the first attack.

“They used to happen once every few decades. Mostly at rehabilitation centers, and smaller settlements like these. Lately… it’s been happening a hell of a lot more.” Katsuki sighed. “Things only escalated to end-times levels two years ago, though.” He took a step closer, his volume lowering. “The so-called *rapture* began three days after the Kataghaerek attacks.”

Izuku gaped up at him, a few tears finally spilling over.

“So, there you have it, Deku… There’s your reason.”

He swallowed, his throat growing tight. “I… I can’t. God wouldn’t…” He shook his head. “This had to be the Council, Kacchan.”

“Angels can’t normally get to Hell without the help of a Demon, remember?” Katsuki said, “That said…” He sighed. “Let’s say you’re right. Let’s say the Council really is acting independently. Y’know, it’s not that crazy to imagine they found another way.” He shrugged. “But you better fucking hope that’s not the case, Deku. ‘Cuz if it is…” He gave a mirthless laugh. “This shit gets a whole lot darker, if that’s even possible.”

“Wh-What do you mean?”

“Deku,” He murmured, the glow in his eyes seeming to dim slightly. “Do you know where divine light *comes from?”*

Izuku’s brow furrowed.

“The look on your face tells me you don’t.” He gave a tight smile, pausing for a moment, looking off to the side, a contemplative look in his eyes.

“I wanna give you the option to remain ignorant of that for now.” He eventually said, speaking slowly, as if he were choosing his words very carefully. “If that’s what you want, we

can turn around and go back now. If not...”

He trailed off for a moment, hesitating.

“I mean, I'll *tell* you. But if you want my opinion, I dunno if there’s any point in puttin’ yourself through that shit right now.”

Izuku gulped, taking a second to collect his thoughts, to ground himself in the moment. He stood there under Katsuki’s gaze. Tear tracks staining his cheeks, hands trembling as he lowered them from his face. It was oddly cold out there, and the only sound came from the soft ebb and flow of their breathing. Izuku closed his eyes, and asked himself what was stronger: his desire for the truth, or his fear of finding out.

Eventually, he opened his eyes, and met Katsuki’s gaze.

“I want to know.”

Katsuki took a deep, shuddering breath.

“In that case, open up your bag and give me the journal.”

Izuku did as he asked, shaky hands fumbling with the closure of his messenger bag. He handed Katsuki the leather-bound book, and as he began to flip through it, he spoke. “Have you ever heard of *endotoxins?”*

He blinked a few times. “N-No?”

Seeming to have found what he was looking for, Katsuki paused. “There’re some types of bacteria that release certain toxins when they disintegrate. Sorta like a last-ditch effort to eliminate a threat, even as they die.”

Izuku frowned, not sure what to make of the information.

But then Katsuki began to read aloud.

“Due to their volatility,” he read, “the pain inflicted on the husks during these tests is necessarily very minor.”

Katsuki closed the journal and looked up at him. *“Volatility.”* He repeated. “What do you suppose that *means,* Deku?”

It took no more than a second. Izuku felt all the blood drain from his face.

“There's two kinds of divine light.” He raised a finger. “There’s the kind that comes directly from God himself…” He raised a second finger. “And then there’s the kind that comes from *you.”*

That last word hit him like a bullet.

“You, after you bleed out the essence of who you just to keep your body functioning, and you’ve got nothin’ left to lose.” He slowly lowered his hand. “If you’re mortally injured past that point, there’ll be nothin’ left of you in the end.”

Izuku stumbled back, hands covering his mouth again, tears welling up. *“No.* No, I c-can’t —“

“Deku!” Katsuki shouted. Izuku’s heart lurched against his chest in some mess of confusion, shock and fear, and before he realized what had happened, Katsuki was already grabbing his wrist, yanking him against his chest. He wrapped his arms around him. “Shit, nerd. *Be careful.”*

It was only then that Izuku realized that they were standing right on the edge. That he’d been just a second away from falling to the ground, hundreds of feet below. The realization set something off inside of him, and he began to sob against Katsuki’s chest.

A few seconds went by, and he felt Katsuki’s gloved fingers lacing through his hair, stroking it gently. He wasn’t sure how long they stayed that way. Standing on the edge. Holding each other.

When they eventually parted, Katsuki was careful to guide Izuku away from the edge before he spoke once again.

“They don’t care about you, Deku.” He said, a bit scratchy. “And they sure as fuck don’t care about me. As far as God’s concerned, there’s really only two options, here—either he’s behind these fuckin’ atrocities, or he’s negligent enough to allow even worse atrocities to occur.” After a pause, he continued, “And based on that *Operation Lacuna* shit in the journal, I can only assume it’ll get worse.”

“What do you mean…?”

“They’re building their own Hell, Deku.” He said. “What do you think happens when they’re done? When they don’t *need* us anymore?”

He opened his mouth, but the words died on his tongue.

After a minute of silence, Katsuki spoke once more. “C’mon. We should head back.”

And then he took Izuku by the hand and led him down the hill again, back into the dead forest beyond.

“Maybe…” Izuku swallowed. “Maybe we can reach a truce,” he said. But it sounded hollow, even to himself.

Katsuki just shook his head.

“There’s not gonna be a truce. There’s no compromise, here; we either accept eternal suffering, or we fucking die.” He scoffed. “This isn’t just gonna go away for us, Deku.

“They won’t be satisfied with anything less than absolute obedience. God will keep tryin’ to coerce us into accepting him as our eternal master, and it’ll never happen. We’re not gonna bow down. We’ve fought way too fucking hard for the right to be our own masters, Deku. And we’ll *keep* fighting, ’til there’s nothing left of us.”

He was quiet for a moment, simply staring straight ahead as they walked. Then, “This was never gonna end cleanly.” He murmured. “But if you’re still havin’ trouble choosin’, think of it like this: on the one hand, you got the death of God and some percentage of Angels, and the Fall of all the others.” He paused. “And on the other hand, you got the death or eternal torture of every single Demon, and whatever the *fuck* this place becomes once they’re through with it.”

The train ride back passed in silence. Izuku dozed on Katsuki’s shoulder, staring blankly at the windows across from them. All he could see were blurs of color.

But at least he could see *color*.

They arrived back at Savaek station two hours later, and subsequently boarded the same train they had when they first arrived.

Izuku looked out the window, at the vast mural stretching across the wall, and finally managed to make it out in full.

Ah. He thought. *That makes sense.*

No Gods, No Masters.

Chapter End Notes

yoooo so uhhh. damn lol I'm not even sure what to say here. I kinda rushed to finish this today; i really hope it turned out alright and i didn't make too many errors. im kinda sitting here low key panicking like, i feel like i fucked something up but idk what. when the chapters get this long it gets hard to keep track of all the things i made a mental note to "fix later" lol. i mean i kinda felt like aizawa was maybe OOC, but. idk, of course that's not the last we'll see of him. so hopefully i can make up for it later? skdfjdksfj.

also i know the tone is very much all over the place. like, we start off horny, and then we've got kacchan being a show off, and then izuku has another existential crisis (because surprise surprise ur actions do in fact have consequences and implications, wow what a concept) and then we just dive straight into some L O R E right in the fucking. deepest pits of fucking darkness. which is ironic, considering the town is bright white. christ dude

ANYWAY, i had originally planned for Hell Arc to be only two chapters, but when i realized this was over 11k, I kinda had to be like.... u can write 1 more hell arc

chapter.....as a treat. so yeah, 1 more chapter in hell—it'll be way more chill. like there'll be some drama but the drama will be more of the "fantasy action wooo" type and less of the "hey bro check out these atrocities" type lol

as always, pls consider commenting if u enjoyed this. fucked up zoomer brain, etc etc lmao. also wanna say thank you to everyone who's reading this. i honestly never expected this story to reach as many people as it apparently has. when i started it, i kinda already accepted that this was probably just gonna be my weird, self-indulgent fic where i could just be political REALLY LOUDLY and write about angel deku gettin dicked by demon kacchan. there are so many things about this fic that i would expect to drive ppl away, and the fact that they apparently haven't amazes me. so yeah, thank you guys

Chapter 14: Inferno III: No Limits

Chapter Summary

> “Wake up, asshole. We’re goin’ on an *adventure.”*

Chapter Notes

> this is 24.3k words i'm gonna die. warnings for smut and creepy eldritch forests (not at the same time)
> Oh also i made a playlist for this fic. Some songs are more literal, some are kinda just Vibes but yeah. may add some shit to it from time to time

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izuku did not want to kill God.

Not at that point, anyway. There were still so many conflicting thoughts inside of his head, and he hadn’t really gotten the opportunity to process them. Though Katsuki had done his best to comfort him in his own way, the colorless town came to exist in the back of his mind, and with it, a whole mess of emotions, the most prominent of which being guilt.

Although he was not personally to blame for the attacks, he couldn’t help but feel ashamed over his connection to them, however tenuous it may be. He felt a sense of responsibility, but he was careful to keep it tucked away in his mind, even as it quietly ate away at him.

They arrived back at the Academy an hour before the allseer network was due to begin.

“There are a number of ways you could help us further.” Aizawa said, holding a stack of papers and tapping the edges against the desk to straighten them. “It just depends on how much you’re willing to do.”

“Anything.” Izuku immediately said.

Both Aizawa and Katsuki froze.

“Anything?” Aizawa repeated, brows furrowed.

“Deku…” Katsuki said. He exchanged looks with Aizawa.

For a moment, it was silent. Then, Aizawa cleared his throat.

“Including return to Heaven?”

Izuku tensed for a moment, then forced himself to relax. He nodded his head, swallowing the fear churning inside of him.

“Well, a solo infiltration mission would certainly speed things up. It’d also be a fairly easy pitch to the others.”

Katsuki grabbed his shoulder, forcing him to turn and look at him head on. “Deku, are you *sure* about that?” He asked, his expression sober. “‘Cuz that ain’t a trivial task, y’know. It’d be *really* fucking dangerous.”

Izuku swallowed the nausea rising in his throat. “I’m sure.”

“You know there are other ways to—“

“I’m sure.” Izuku repeated louder, trying to be firm about it.

Trying to put an end to the conversation, so he wouldn’t have to think about it any longer.

Katsuki stared at him for a moment, his eyes searching, but eventually, his expression morphed from concern to an uneasy acceptance. He sat back in his chair, and didn’t say anything more.

The chamber was vast and circular, roughly two-hundred feet in diameter.

All along the edges were a number of smaller rooms, and within each, Izuku counted five round tables, all with around nine or ten chairs. At the front of each room was one smaller table, surrounded by five more chairs.

Izuku paused to count the rooms and found that there were twenty of them, though they seemed to be divided into five distinct groups of four. There was another table set out in front of each group, all of which had four chairs, and then a final table near the center, with five seats.

Izuku’s brows pinched together as he paused to do the math in his head, and found that, if his calculations were correct, it looked like the room was designed to accommodate around a thousand people at full capacity.

And that was just the first floor.

As he peered up at the subsequent stories, he noted that each of them had a similar layout, with the only noticeable difference being the five floating walkways that seemed to sprout from the center, connecting each cluster of rooms to the spiral staircase in the middle.

As he looked around, he got the distinct impression that this layout was the result of rigorous planning for a specific purpose, but he couldn’t quite figure out what that purpose would be. Then, as if reading his mind, Katsuki began to speak.

“This is what I meant about it being a tiered hive mind.”

Izuku’s gaze snapped onto him, and he blinked rapidly. “I don’t follow…?”

Katsuki shrugged. “Y’know about like, levels of organization? Like, squads, platoons, companies, all that shit?”

Izuku nodded.

“Well, we have that, except instead of each level having like, a sergeant or a lieutenant, or whatever, we just take turns being the nexus. So there’s a squad nexus, or a platoon nexus—you get the idea.”

“Sure, but…” Izuku squinted. “I mean, what does the nexus actually *do?”*

“I’m gettin’ to that.” Katsuki grumbled, taking a deep breath. “So, here’s the deal.” He sighed. “The military is a big organization, and we need a way to efficiently make decisions, right?”

“Right…?”

“So, that’s what the allseer network does. It’s a special type of magic that Demons can use that connects us to other Demons. Y’know, kinda like when I use my sigil to communicate with others.” he gestured toward the mark on his arm.

“So… it’s like that, but with a group?”

“Not quite.” He shook his head. “It’s more complex than that. It’s kinda like…” He hesitated. His eyes darted toward an empty room to their right. “C’mere.” He said, waving Izuku over.

He led him into the room, pulled out a chair for him, and gestured for him to sit down. Katsuki planted his palms on the table beside him. “Let’s say we’re in the same squad, and I’m the squad nexus.” He paused. “During a discussion, you’d be sitting here at this table, talking shit over with the rest of the squad—everyone except me.”

“You wouldn’t be here?”

“Nope.” He stood up straight, and began to walk toward the smaller table at the front of the room. “I’d be sitting here, discussing shit with all the other squad nexuses in the platoon. But the key difference is that, as the squad nexus, I’d be mentally linked with the rest of my squad.” He gestured toward Izuku’s table. “And my job would be to carry their thoughts and concerns over to the other squad nexuses.”

“So… you’d have nine other people’s thoughts in your head simultaneously?” Izuku frowned. “That sounds kind of overwhelming.”

“Well, not *all* their thoughts.” He shrugged. “That’s why it’s a *selective* hive mind. M’not up here havin’ to try and filter out fuckin’ Steve’s dinner plans, or whatever. The magic works so that I only have to hear about shit that’s actually relevant.

“It also prioritizes information. Like, if there’s someone who feels really strongly about something, or if there’s a lot of people worrying about the same thing, that shit gets pushed to the top of my awareness.

“Basically, the system’s optimized to keep the nexuses from getting overwhelmed, while still dealing with the most pressing concerns.”

“Ohh!” Izuku smiled. “I see! So it’s like that for every tier up, too?”

“Yep.” Katsuki nodded. “The platoon nexuses tap into the minds of all the squad nexuses from their platoon.” He gestured toward the table set out in front of the four rooms. “The company nexuses do the same for the platoon nexuses.“ He pointed at the table next to the staircase. “Then there’s the battalion nexuses, the city nexuses—ours is Aizawa, right now—and shit just goes on and on ’til we’re all the way up at the regional level.”

“Wow.” Izuku said. “So that’s how you make decisions?”

“No, that’s just how we regulate *discussions.”* He replied. “Actual decisions are made by a vote at the end. But we have to have the discussion first so we can figure out what we actually need to vote *on.”*

“Still, it seems… complicated.”

“Well, sure.” Katsuki shoved his hands into his pockets. “It’s complicated in the sense that coordinating a large group of people is fuckin’ complicated, but it’s not complicated in *particular.”*

Izuku chewed his lip. “I guess so…”

“Anyway, let’s—“

“Bakugou!”

They both turned their heads simultaneously, and Izuku’s eyes locked on a room across from theirs. There, he spotted a group of four people sitting at one of the tables.

Well, three of them were sitting; there was one person—a blond man—standing up on a chair, waving at them enthusiastically, trying to beckon them over. Izuku glanced over at Katsuki, and found him staring at the man with narrowed eyes.

The blond did not seem deterred. Rather, he began miming as though he were holding a rope, theatrically acting up the effort of trying to pull Katsuki in. This continued until finally Katsuki just rolled his eyes, glanced over at Izuku, and told him, “This was gonna happen eventually, anyway.”

And with that, Katsuki started walking toward them, his feet dragging across the floor. Everyone at the table began to cheer and clap, as though getting Katsuki to come to them was some sort of grand achievement.

When they eventually reached the room the group was in, the blond man was still standing in his chair. Katsuki raised an eyebrow at him. “We really gotta switch to chairs without metal legs.” He said. “It ain’t fair for you to be able to be this fuckin’ obnoxious without any consequences, Kaminari.”

The blond—*Kaminari*—scoffed dramatically. “You wound me, Bakugou. To think you’d prioritize insulting me over introducing us to your…” He glanced at Izuku, and waggled his eyebrows. *“Friend.”*

“Bro, is this who I think it is?” A man with spiked, red hair asked.

“Kirishima.” Katsuki said, tone laced with warning. Kirishima put his hands up, shaking his head.

“I know an artifice disguise when I see one.” A woman with short, dark hair said.

Izuku shuffled awkwardly, not quite sure what to do.

“Fine.” Katsuki groaned, stepping aside to gesture at Izuku. “Yeah. This is fucking *Deku.”*

The table instantly erupted into whoops and hollers.

“Oi, stop that!” Katsuki shouted, notably red in the face. “You’re makin’ him nervous!”

“Nay, I think it is you who is nervous, my good bitch.” Kaminari said.

“Kaminari, I will set your ass on *fucking fire.”*

“You promise, daddy?”

Katsuki smacked his own forehead, slowly dragging his hand down his face, skin pulling along with it before his arm fell limp at his side.

“Yeah, y’know what? Fuck this.” Katsuki grabbed Izuku’s hand, and he stumbled as he began dragging him away. The others immediately stood up, chair legs squealing across the floor as they shouted their dissent.

They were around twenty feet away when Katsuki released an exasperated growl and spun around again, fixing the group with a stern glare. “If you can’t fuckin’ behave yourselves, why should I—!”

“It was Kaminari!” The woman shouted. “He doesn’t represent us!”

“Kyouka—!” Kaminari cried, clearly offended.

“No, Jirou’s right.” A tall, dark-haired man said. He leaned over and slammed his hands down on the table. “We disavow Kaminari!”

“Sero, how *could* you?!”

“Raise your hand if you disavow Kaminari.”

The other three raised their hands.

“Kirishima, seriously? You too?!”

Kirishima offered only an apologetic smile. “There’s a time and a place for daddy jokes, man.”

“So,” Sero said. “Since we’re all in agreement that Kaminari sucks, will you come back?”

Katsuki clenched his jaw, remaining rooted in place for a moment before he finally sighed, and started back toward them, pulling Deku along with him. As they came to stand before the table, Katsuki pointed at the others from left to right. “Deku, meet Kirishima, Kaminari, Jirou and Sero.”

“Um. Hello.” Izuku waved awkwardly.

Katsuki pulled out two chairs, and gestured for Izuku to sit.

“Ooh, pulling out chairs, Bakugou? That’s so ro—“ Jirou smacked her hand over Kaminari’s mouth, shutting him up. Katsuki gave her an appreciative nod.

“Anyway,” she said, still grinning as though she were trying very hard to control herself. “It’s nice to meet you, Deku.”

Izuku offered a small smile. “Are you all in the same squad?”

“Yep!” Kirishima said. “There’s five more of us, but they haven’t gotten here yet.”

“So, uh. Deku,” Sero said, leaning toward him from across the table. “Bakugou’s, uhh, told us a lot about you.”

Izuku blinked a few times. “Oh, really?” He glanced at Katsuki, and found him staring at Sero with narrowed eyes. “What sort of things?”

Kaminari snorted. “Um, well—“ Jirou elbowed him in the ribs, and he lurched away. “Ow!”

“Oh, you know. Just that he thinks you’re, uhh…” Her eyes darted around. “Um. Cool…?”

“Yeah!” Kirishima nodded. “Honestly, we’ve wanted to meet you for a while now. So if we seem a bit over-excited, that’s the reason.” He smiled. “It’s just that we know Bakugou, and we know he’s not an easy person to impress. We’re all just excited to meet the guy who finally won his…” He trailed off for a moment, eyes widening as he looked off to the side. “Uhhh…”

Sero snapped his fingers. “Appreciation!”

Jirou snorted. “Nice save.”

Izuku fidgeted with the hem of his cloak. “Um, well… it’s nice to meet all of you, too. I, uhh…” He cleared his throat. “Appreciate Kacchan as well?”

“Kacchan.” Jirou repeated, trying to cover the wide smile on her face.

“Oh god, that’s so *cute.”* Kaminari said, banging his head against the wall behind him.

“Well,” Kirishima said. “We’re glad Bakugou’s got mutual… *appreciation*... with someone.”

“Yeah.” Kaminari snorted. He then looked at Katsuki and made an odd gesture, his fist moving back and forth in front of his mouth, his tongue pressed into his cheek, making it bulge out. *“Appreciation.”*

Katsuki looked him in the eye and made a clear throat-slitting gesture. Kaminari responded with a wide grin and a thumbs-up.

For a moment, it was silent.

Sero cleared his throat. “So, Deku…” He said. “You enjoyin’ Hell so far?”

“Oh,” Izuku sat up a bit straighter. “Yes, it’s been…” Memories of the town, leeched of all color, flooded his mind. He winced and looked down for a moment. Izuku closed his eyes, and then looked up again with a soft smile. “It’s been nice, mostly. It’s very different from Heaven, though.”

“Yeah, I’ll bet.” Kaminari snorted. “So, has Bakugou taken you to the nightmare forest yet?”

Izuku’s brow furrowed. “The… what?”

Kaminari’s grin widened, and he leaned toward him. “See, Bakugou has a bad habit of wanting to take people he cares about to the most Hellish part of Hell.”

Katsuki scoffed. “Maybe you’re just a fucking coward, Kaminari.”

“That may well be the case,” Kaminari replied. “But that does not negate the fact that most of your past relationships fell apart soon after you decided to take them on a fun little date into the death trap forest of doom.”

Izuku frowned. Somehow, the thought of Katsuki having past relationships at all made him feel like curling in on himself. But now wasn’t the time to examine that feeling.

“Um, is that what you meant about hiking, Kacchan?”

Katsuki looked at him, the glare he’d been directing at Kaminari softening. “Yeah. It really ain’t that bad, though.”

“Yeah, honestly, I’m with Bakugou on this one.” Kirishima said. “Like, you gotta be careful, but if you know what you’re doing, you should be okay.”

“Maybe for Wrath Demons like you two, but for the rest of us—“

“—Nah, I’m kinda with Bakugou on this, too.” Jirou cut in. “I mean, I don’t *like* it, but it’s not *that* bad.”

“Well, *okay.”* Kaminari rolled his eyes. “But you’re an Envy Demon. You can make yourself basically invisible.”

“Not to *everything.”*

“Well, whatever!” Kaminari said. “Sero knows what I mean, don’t you?”

“I mean.” He squinted. “I fucking *hate* that place, but I can escape most things by just climbing the trees.”

“There are no branches for over six-hundred feet, and the trees are too cramped to fly.” Kaminari deadpanned.

“I said *I* could escape by climbing. Not you.” Sero grinned, and pointed finger guns at him. “That’s just Gluttony, baby.”

“I hate all of you.” Kaminari groaned. “What am I supposed to do, huh? There’s no metal in the forest!”

“The hell kinda Greed demon would you be if you didn’t carry that shit with you already?” Katsuki rolled his eyes. “Why don’t you just admit you’re still freaked out ‘cuz of that time you opened your mouth too close to a fuckin’ Vassalite colony?”

“It was *in my mouth.”*

“We got it out.” Katsuki shrugged.

“But it was *inside* of my *fucking mouth,* Bakugou!”

“Well, at least it wasn’t up your ass!” Katsuki shot back. “Kaminari, I’ve almost died in there multiple times. That shit was *nothing.”*

Kaminari laughed uncomfortably. “Y’know, reminding me that it could’ve been a lot worse really isn’t the argument you seem to think it is!” He said, with what was perhaps the most painful smile Izuku had ever seen. “The fact that you’ve almost died on multiple occasions *strengthens* my point, actually!”

“Multiple times, spread out over more than a hundred years.” Katsuki said, monotone. “Kaminari, I’ve gone hiking at least once a week for over a dozen decades.”

“Yep!” He chirped. “And we’re all hoping you get better soon!”

“Whatever.” Katsuki rolled his eyes and stood up. “Where’s Aizawa?”

“Oh, yeah.” Sero said. “He’s upstairs, I think.”

Katsuki nodded, gesturing for Izuku to get up.

“Um, nice meeting you all.” Izuku called out. They all smiled and responded in kind—well, all except Kaminari.

“Don’t take him to the forest, Bakugou!”

“You know what?” Katsuki shouted back. “I think I fucking will, just to spite you!” Then, softer, so that only Izuku could hear, he added, “Probably safer than fuckin’ Heaven, anyway.”

Kaminari began to yell many variations of *no* and *don’t,* but the further they got, the more indistinct they became. Once they’d made it up the stairs, they fizzled out entirely.

Because the discussion would necessarily delve into information from the second half of the journal, Izuku was advised to sit out for the actual meeting, though even without sound, viewing it through the window in the hall was a fascinating experience. He watched as Aizawa stepped onto a platform on the top floor, causing several hologram-like projections to appear down on the lower levels, standing in front of every cluster of rooms. Had he seen it from above, he imagined it would’ve looked a bit like a kaleidoscope.

Izuku settled in on the bench near the window. He squinted, trying to read Aizawa’s lips, but he was too far away. It was pointless, anyway. Aside from the information in the latter half of the journal, Izuku already knew what they were planning to pitch.

The end of the discussion was marked by Aizawa stepping onto the platform again, and from there, the voting began, and ended around twenty minutes later.

When the meeting came to a close, Katsuki was the first person out, at least on the fifth floor. Izuku quickly stood up. They met each other in the middle.

“The day after tomorrow.” Katsuki told him, his expression somber. “That’s when you’re set to go back.”

They returned home at around nine o’clock that night, and as seemed to be the trend with him, the first thing Katsuki wanted to do was shower.

Izuku sighed as he dug through his bag, searching for his feather glue. He figured it was time to re-apply it, if only as a security blanket to comfort him about the events of that day. He quickly changed into his pajamas, selecting a shirt with a scoop-back to avoid getting the paste on his clothing. Then he switched on the lamp beside the couch bed, and got to work.

It was difficult, though; normally, he had a mirror he could use, but as things were, he could manage most of the feathers, but the ones near the back gave him trouble.

A couple minutes later, Katsuki emerged from the bathroom—wearing clothes, thankfully. He was in the process of toweling off his hair when he noticed Izuku’s predicament.

“Uhh…” He grunted. “What’re you doing?”

Izuku held up the paintbrush. “Gluing my feathers.” He shrugged. “It helps keep them from falling out—for a while, at least.”

Katsuki stared at him blankly for a moment, blinking slowly. Then, a grin slowly spread across his face. “Wait, for real?” He snorted. “Damn. What’re you, some kinda arts and crafts project?”

Izuku laughed.

“I thought the same thing when All Might… first…” He trailed off, the smile falling from his face as dark, fearful emotions began to creep back into his consciousness. For several seconds, he was silent, and the subtle shift in Katsuki’s expression gave him a sense that he knew why.

After a moment, Katsuki put the towel around his neck, letting it hang loosely. He looked Izuku up and down. “You want some help?”

Izuku blinked a few times, taken off guard by the offer. “Oh, uhh—“

“—I can see you strugglin’ to reach the back.” Katsuki said. “So if you want, I can give you a hand there.”

Izuku chewed his lip, glancing down at Katsuki’s bare hands.

“I’ll be careful not to touch skin. Just touchin’ your feathers is safe, right?”

Izuku nodded, and offered a small smile. “Thanks, Kacchan.”

With that, Katsuki pulled up a chair near the edge of the bed, and gestured for Izuku to sit. Once he was situated on the edge of the mattress behind him, Katsuki grabbed the brush from the pot of glue, and got to work.

The next few minutes passed peacefully as Katsuki meticulously applied glue to his feathers. Izuku closed his eyes and let his head fall forward as he felt the careful movements of the brush, slowly sliding around the roots of each feather, soaking into the follicles.

Sometimes, Katsuki would pause to blow on the spot he’d just glued. It surprised Izuku at first, enough to make him jolt.

“What’re you doing?” He’d asked.

“Just makin’ sure it’s dry.” Katsuki had said. “Don’t wanna gunk up your other feathers.”

The tension eased from his body then, and he came to expect it soon enough. Came to appreciate it.

Once in a while, he’d hear Katsuki shift around on the mattress, and occasionally he’d stop and ask Izuku to extend his wing for him. But for the most part, it was silent.

It was only at the end when Katsuki started up what might be considered a conversation.

“I like your wings,” He told him.

Izuku’s back straightened, his cheeks dusting pink. He bowed his head, hoping Katsuki wouldn’t see. “R-Really…?”

Katsuki hummed, leaning over to dip the brush in the glue again. “They’re pretty,” He murmured.

Izuku blushed harder, his shoulders drawing up. He wasn’t sure why it made him feel so embarrassed, at first. But once he started thinking about it, it didn’t take long to zero in on the reason.

In all his time spent working with him, this was the only occasion he could recall when Katsuki had actually told him, in no uncertain terms, that there was something about Izuku’s appearance he found *attractive.*

There’d been times he’d gotten close. Katsuki was rather fond of teasing him, after all, and through his teasing he would sometimes say things that implied a sort of attraction. He’d called him cute before, but it was always tongue-in-cheek, and generally felt more patronizing than complimentary.

And of course, there was that time just one day ago, when he’d told him the artifice made him look *‘gorgeous.’*

Izuku chewed his lips, wringing his wrists as he thought back to it. It wasn’t *nothing,* that was for certain, but because Izuku had no way of knowing what he looked like while wearing the artifice, it was hard to say how much of it was him, and how much of it was just the magic itself.

No, as far as Izuku could remember, this was the first time Katsuki had expressed appreciation for Izuku’s natural looks.

Izuku’s hands balled up in the fabric of his pants as a warm feeling nestled up in his heart.

“Oi.” Katsuki said. “Don’t get your feathers all ruffled over it. *Literally.”*

“Ah! Right, sorry!” Izuku squeaked, willing himself to relax, so his feathers would lie flat.

A minute later, Katsuki was finished.

“Alright, I think you’re good.” He said, standing up and stretching his arms over his head.

Izuku stood as well. He rubbed the back of his neck, face still feeling a little too warm. “I, um… thank you, Kacchan.”

Katsuki gave him an odd look. “Why’re you actin’ all weird? Like you’re…” He trailed off for a moment, eyes narrowing. “Wait,” he said. “Are your wings, like, a fuckin’ erogenous zone, or some shit?”

“A *what?”* Izuku’s brow furrowed.

Katsuki shrugged. “I’m just tryna figure out if what I just did was some kinda weird Angel sex act or whatever.”

“Kacchan!” Izuku reflexively covered his face, his blush intensifying.

“Be honest, Deku. Did I give you a fuckin’ wing-job just now?”

“Kacchan!”

“Hey!” Katsuki put his hands up. “It’s okay if the answer’s yes! I won’t be mad. If anything, I’ll be a little turned—“

Izuku suddenly threw his arms around Katsuki’s body, burying his face in his chest. For a moment, Katsuki seemed too shocked to even move or say anything.

“I just…” Izuku said, slightly muffled. “Didn’t realize there was anything about me that you actually… um, liked.”

Katsuki remained frozen for just a second longer, before he sighed, and gently wrapped his arms around him, his chin resting on the top of his head.

“Seriously?” Katsuki said, laughing softly. “That’s it? *Really?”*

“Don’t make fun of me.”

“M’not fuckin’—“ Katsuki huffed, pulling back a bit, so he could look him in the eye. “Deku, c’mon. You should know that by now.”

Izuku frowned, looking off to the side. And then Katsuki tipped his head up, and pressed his lips against his own. It was slow, gentle, sweet—nothing like the raw, charged kiss of the previous night. Like warm tea in the wintertime, or the sound of rain outside your bedroom window. The kind of kiss you’d come home for.

Katsuki pulled away after a moment, met Izuku’s eyes and licked his lips.

“Tomorrow.”

Izuku blinked a few times. “What?”

“M’gonna take you out. Alright?”

“I, umm…” Izuku gulped. “Sure… okay.”

Katsuki grinned, and planted one last peck on his lips. “Get some rest, nerd.” He murmured. “You and your *pretty wings* are gonna need it.”

Izuku woke the next morning to the sensation of Triplet landing on his chest, and based on the way Katsuki was standing and the position of his arms, it wasn’t hard to deduce that he was in some way responsible.

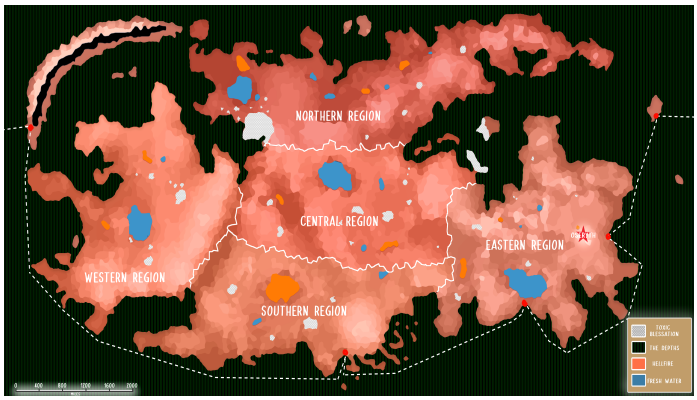
“Wake up, asshole. We’re goin’ on an *adventure.”*

When Izuku’s eyes finally adjusted to the morning light, he realized that Katsuki was dressed head to toe in hiking gear. Dark green cargo pants, a black shirt, and a utility belt with all sorts of strange items attached to it.

Izuku sat up slowly, careful not to disturb Triplet, who was curled up in his lap, purring. As he gently petted her, he looked up at Katsuki with narrowed eyes. “What *sort* of adventure?”

“Nothin’ you can’t handle.” He shrugged. “Wanted you to get to do some sight-seeing, is all.” Katsuki turned and reached into his bag, which was set aside on one of the living room chairs, and handed a touch pad to Izuku.

There, on the screen, was what looked to be a map.



“Wait.” Izuku’s eyes widened. “Is… Is this *Hell,* Kacchan?”

Katsuki smirked. “Sure is.”

Izuku just stared at it for a while, zooming in on different features. Triplet, having grown bored now that he wasn’t petting her, hopped off his lap and made a beeline for the habanero plant.

“Oi!” Katsuki barked, scooping her up in his arms. “Y’little fucker, don’t think I don’t know what you’re up to.”

She meowed at him.

“Yeah, yeah. I’ll feed ya.” He glanced at Izuku. “Be right back.”

Izuku just grunted, still staring at the map as Katsuki walked away.

When he finally zoomed out again, he noticed two things he hadn’t before. First was the highlighted route on the map. Second was the scale bar down in the bottom left corner. Katsuki returned just as the realization hit him full-force.

“Kacchan… it says every inch here is *a thousand miles.”*

“Yeah,” Katsuki took a sip from the coffee cup he was now holding. “What about it?”

Izuku stared at the path Katsuki had drawn. It basically had them circling around the entire continent. “How long is this route, exactly?”

“Roughly eighteen-thousand miles.”

Izuku just looked up at him for a while, attempting to come to grips with that concept. “And you’re expecting this to take us *how* long, exactly?”

“Well, it’s about seven right now. If we head out soon, we can be back before ten tonight.”

He blinked a few times pointedly. “And how exactly is that supposed to work?”

Katsuki merely grinned, a mischievous glint in his eye as he stared at him over the lip of his coffee mug. “Oh, you’ll see, nerd.”

Their journey began with a train ride just over an hour east of Oseryth, and after ten minutes of walking, they reached the edge of a dense forest, surrounded by a short but highly visible red fence. As they got closer, Izuku squinted to read one of the signs posted up ahead.

WARNING: now entering THE DEPTHS.

Extreme caution is advised.

Izuku felt a chill run down his spine.

“Um, Kacchan? Are you sure we should be here? It seems kind of…” He side-eyed the signpost. “Dangerous?”

“I said I was takin’ you on an adventure, didn’t I?”

Izuku hesitated, staring back at him for a moment. Then, his eyes narrowed. “Wait.” He said. “Is this the forest Kaminari mentioned?”

Katsuki simply stared back at him, and Izuku took that as a confirmation, his eyes widening.

“Um, I don’t know if—“

“—It’ll be fine.” Katsuki waved his hand. “You’re with me, and I know what I’m doing. That said,” he gave Izuku a stern look. “We gotta set some ground rules, Deku. And I really mean it. This shit is fuckin’ *non-negotiable.”*

Izuku gulped. “Okay…?”

“Rule number one,” He raised a finger. “Is that you stay close to me at all times. I’ll walk just slightly ahead of you, but I want you fuckin’ glued to my side, you got that?”

He nodded. *That’s easy enough.*

“Good.” He lifted another finger. “Rule number two is, once we’re in there, there’s no stopping. We can slow down if you need to, and if it comes to it, I can carry you, but we have to keep walking the entire time, no matter what.”

Izuku frowned. *That one’s a little… disconcerting.*

Still, he nodded again.

“Alright.” He raised a third finger. “Finally, rule number three is… if it starts *talking* to you, don’t react to it.” He stopped for a second, giving him a grim look before continuing.

“It’ll use your own voice, and it’s weird as *fuck,* so, y’know—be prepared for *that* shit, but do not *fucking* respond, Deku.” Katsuki grabbed him by the shoulders, shaking him slightly. “Don’t respond, and do *not*, under *any* fucking circumstances, turn to look in the direction you heard it from, because *that is how it finds you.*” He paused, taking a deep breath. “Just keep your eyes locked *straight ahead* and ignore it ’til it stops.”

Izuku shivered, a cold, ominous feeling dropping into his gut that seemed to freeze him from the inside out. He wasn’t sure he wanted to know, but couldn’t resist the urge to ask. “What…” He gulped. “What do you mean by *it,* exactly…?”

“The Depths, Deku.” Katsuki replied. “The forest itself.”

The words hung in the air for a moment.

“A-And what happens when it… finds… you?”

“I dunno, nerd. But considering no one’s ever lived to tell the tale, I think it’s safe to assume it’s nothing good.”

Katsuki stood and held something out to him that looked like a belt. “Here, put this around your waist.”

He took the belt, and noticed that, among other things, it had a pair of ear muffs and a full-face respirator attached to it.

“What are these for?”

Katsuki shrugged, hooking a matching belt around his waist. “Creatures in the Depths can sense the strength of other creatures. I’m actually gonna shift before we go in, just for good measure. Since you’re with me, most of the shit we come across out here won’t attack us, but there’re exceptions. If I tell you to put those on, do it *immediately.”* Katsuki paused for a moment. “Actually, if I tell you to do *anything,* do it immediately.” He amended. “That’s rule zero. Any questions?”

“Yes, actually.” Izuku replied. “Is it perhaps an option for us to simply…” He squinted, gesturing vaguely. “You know, *not* enter the murderous nightmare forest?”

Katsuki scoffed. “It’s not *that* scary.”

“Kaminari seemed to think it was, and everything you’ve told me appears to confirm that.”

He rolled his eyes. “So if you don’t got any more questions, I’m assuming you’re ready to go?”

Izuku just pursed his lips and stared back at him. Katsuki seemed to take that as a tacit agreement.

“Great. In that case…”

In less than a second, Katsuki shifted, his horns twisting and extending as his wings all but shot out of his back. It happened so quickly, Izuku actually jumped. Given how long it had taken that day with Shinsou, he’d expected it to be more gradual.

Guess that was just for dramatic effect…

He clapped his large, clawed, black hands, and an orb of light appeared a few feet in front of him. Then, he stepped over the red fence, and gestured for Izuku to follow.

Katsuki entered the woods with Izuku by his side. The morning light crested the mountains in the distance, spilling abstract patterns through the trees. The orb floated in front of them, mostly useless, at first.

But as the minutes ticked by, Izuku noticed the trees becoming taller, and oddly regular in their spacing. The pattern emerged as a sort of grid, with every tree around the same distance from its neighbors, which was just enough space for them to walk side by side comfortably.

Their branches became fuller, too—gradually covering more and more surface area, until they seemed to obscure the sky completely. From there, it felt somewhat reminiscent of twilight.

After ten minutes, Izuku could no longer see the tops of the trees. The trunks simply faded into the darkness, hundreds, perhaps even *thousands* of feet above their heads. The orb illuminated a radius of roughly five feet around them; just enough to see their immediate surroundings, and perhaps catch small glimpses of what lay beyond.

As they walked, Katsuki held what looked to be a compass in his hand, and from Izuku’s position—quite literally under Katsuki’s wing—he noticed that, even as they walked in a straight line, the compass seemed to display otherwise. At times, they’d be walking straight north, and the compass would start to drift east or west, at which point Katsuki would veer off the path in order to get back on track. Other times, it would abruptly jerk one way or another, and Katsuki would have to make sharp turns to compensate.

On one occasion, the compass even made a complete one-eighty, forcing them to turn around and backtrack, or so it seemed, at least.

It was somewhere around the half hour mark when Izuku finally heard it.

“Are you ready to go, yet?” A voice—his *own* voice—asked.

Izuku tensed. It seemed to come from the left, roughly ten feet away. But Izuku didn't look. He clenched his jaw and kept his gaze locked on the path in front of them.

Up above, he could hear the distant sound of wind blowing, swaying the trees ever so slightly. Apart from that, the forest was dead silent.

It came from behind him next.

"Don't forget to turn your heart off." It told him.

Then, from his right this time: "Do the shadows still bleed for you?"

Izuku's brow furrowed. It was… strange, to say the least. It was as though the Depths knew how to construct a sentence that technically expressed an idea, just not one that corresponded to any sort of reality. Like it was piecing together puzzle pieces from many separate sets, all cut in the same way, yet displaying different images; the result was structurally coherent, but meaningless.

The next one came from his left again. Closer, this time. Perhaps only a foot away from his ear. "I thank my transparent skin in this night of vile fairytales."

Izuku's hands had been shaking since he first heard the voice, but for some reason, that one just got to him. He wasn't sure why; it didn't make sense, but his eyes teared up nonetheless. He wished he had thought to ask Katsuki beforehand how long he could expect this to go on. He wasn't sure how much more of it he could handle.

Fortunately, however, it seemed that it was over. A few minutes went by, and then Katsuki spoke.

"Good job."

Izuku's breath caught, his heart still racing. "…Did you hear it, too?"

"No," he shook his head. "But you looked like you were about the shit yourself, so I assumed."

Izuku nodded quietly. "Have you heard it yet?"

The compass suddenly twisted east, and Katsuki made a sharp left turn to continue on north. "I haven't. And it's probably targeting you, 'cuz it can sense you're the weakest link. No offense." He shrugged. "Be careful, though. It can start up again at any time."

Izuku gulped. "What… *is* it, exactly…?" He asked. "The Depths."

Katsuki hummed. "Y'know, no one really knows. 'Course, there're theories. One is that it's all one big organism. That's probably the one most people buy into. But even within that, there's a lot of debate about its specific nature. Y'know, how intelligent it is, where it comes from. That sorta shit."

The compass spun west, and Katsuki made a sharp right turn in response.

“There’re some people who think that calling it an organism is kinda dangerous, though.”

Izuku blinked. “Dangerous?”

“Yeah. Not like, *literally* dangerous, but… well, it’s kinda hard to explain.” Katsuki paused, his brow furrowing. “I guess the issue is that categorizing it that way presupposes that it’s something we’re *able* to categorize.”

“…What do you mean?”

“Well, just think about it. It’s like—the Depths is this big, massive thing that nobody really understands, y’know? There’s something kinda weird and arrogant about looking at this fucking horrible eldritch location and saying, *‘oh yeah, that’s totally something we can describe based on our current understanding of how shit works.’”*

“Ohh, I think I get it.” Izuku smiled. “So, what you’re basically saying is it’s sort of like trying to fit it into a box, when the right box might not even exist yet.”

“Yeah, pretty much.” He nodded. “And the issue is, when you categorize something, it’s sorta like choosin’ a lens to look at it through. And like, sure, maybe lookin’ at it through that lens could lead to some new discoveries, but y’gotta be careful, ‘cuz if you overcommit to it, you risk losing the bigger picture. That’s the argument, anyway.”

“Huh… I guess I’d be inclined to agree.”

“Same, but I dunno. I don’t think it has to be, like, an *absolute* thing.” Katsuki shrugged. “You can call it an organism when it’s useful without fully committing to that definition. Y’know, ‘cuz it *is* useful. It’s actually real fuckin’ hard to further your understanding of shit if y’never pick a framework to analyze it with.

“Plus, there’s a point where this ‘no categorization’ argument just kinda devolves into blanket anti-science bullshit. Like, there’re people out there who think that trying to study the Depths *at all* is pointless.”

Izuku frowned. “Well, I wouldn’t go *that* far.”

Katsuki grunted in agreement. “Yeah, but it’s all kinda part of this bigger philosophical argument about the conflict between our desire to understand shit and the actual limits of our understanding. No one can really say where the line is, or if it even exists.”

“I mean, I think there’s a line.” Izuku said. “It’s like when God flooded the Earth. Everyone always asks why he did it, as though that’s something they could understand.”

“Oh, that one actually has a very simple explanation, Deku.” He grinned. “It’s ‘cuz God is a fucking asshole.”

For a moment, Izuku wasn’t really sure how to respond. A few months ago, he would’ve immediately gotten defensive, but *now*...

The image of the snow-white town interjected itself into his thoughts, and Izuku gripped the fabric of his cloak as he tried to force it out of his head, tried to sever the wave of guilt that tugged at his heart.

Izuku gulped. “I mean… I guess that’s… *one* explanation for it…” He cleared his throat. “Anyway, uh. How much further is it, by the way?”

“Shouldn’t be long, now.”

And sure enough, just a few minutes later, light slowly but surely began to leak into the forest from above, and soon they reached the threshold. They emerged in a frigid, rocky landscape, and as Katsuki stepped over the fence, he returned to his partially-shifted form.

Izuku looked around at the cold, mountainous area. “Where are we?”

“Hades Island. About two-thousand miles northeast of Oseryth.”

“What? Kacchan, we’ve been walking for, like, forty-five minutes!”

“I know.” He grinned. “That’s the thing about the Depths, Deku. You don’t feel like you’re movin’ that fast, ‘cuz the Depths move with you. S’part of what makes it so dangerous. Even when you’re standin’ still, you’re still moving.”

They came upon a small opening in the side of the mountain, and as Katsuki ducked inside, Izuku followed. It was a cavern of some kind, and it expanded the further they went. Izuku strained his eyes to see as the space grew darker, and then Katsuki reached into his bag and pulled something out. Izuku heard a cracking sound, and the cave was immediately lit up an otherworldly green. Katsuki tossed on glow stick off to the side, and threw the other down a shaft up ahead.

Izuku raised an eyebrow. “No orb of light this time?”

He grinned. “I just think it packs more of a punch this way.”

The shaft was around ten feet long, and fortunately, there was already a rope secured in place. Once Katsuki reached the bottom, he looked up at Izuku.

“You comin’?”

Izuku nodded, getting down on his hands and knees, carefully easing himself into it. He had to pull his wings tight against his body in order to fit, but luckily the actual process of getting down wasn’t too hard.

One of the first things he noticed as he reached the ground was that the temperature had risen a few degrees. The cavern was humid, and there was an oddly sweet smell permeating the air.

Katsuki led him down a few makeshift corridors until finally they reached a chamber large enough for them both to stand comfortably. It was pitch black, and Izuku waited quietly as

Katsuki fumbled with his bag.

“You ready?”

“Um.” Izuku said. “For what, exactly…?”

Katsuki laughed low and under his breath as he proceeded to pull out several more glow sticks, cracking them all at once, then tossing them quickly around the enclosure.

As the glow sticks flew, Izuku watched the world glitter. He held his breath, his eyes wide. And it hit him right as the second glow stick landed, just what it was he was seeing.

The room was filled with gems.

Sprouting from the ground and protruding from the walls were enormous, glittering crystals unlike anything he’d ever seen before. The soft, green light of the glow sticks gave the room an otherworldly atmosphere.

“Welcome to Hades’ Treasure Chest, Deku.”

“Kacchan, this is *beautiful.”*

“You ain’t seen nothin’ yet, nerd.” Katsuki said, approaching one of the larger crystals. He then clapped his hands, just as he did prior to entering the Depths, an orb of light appeared before him. It shone brightly through the crystal, and as it filtered through, beams of light shot out from its sides, bouncing off the other crystals in colors all across the rainbow.

As Izuku stood at the center of the iridescent chamber, for a minute, he was just speechless. Hands held over his mouth, goosebumps raising on his skin, ruffling the feathers of his wings. Izuku was in awe. It felt like he was standing at the center of some beautiful dream, and the feelings it brought from his heart were genuinely difficult to describe.

Overloaded with emotion, Izuku began to tear up. He turned around and looked at Katsuki, who, upon meeting his gaze, seemed momentarily alarmed. “Woah, what—“ He didn’t get a chance to finish before Izuku threw his arms around him, pressing his face against his chest, tears soaking through the fabric of his shirt.

Katsuki tensed for only a second before he relaxed. Then he wrapped his arms around him, chin resting on the top of his head.

“Cry baby.”

Izuku whined. “Hey, you brought me here! Don’t act like you didn’t know this would happen!”

Katsuki’s chest rumbled as he laughed softly. “Hey, m’just statin’ facts.” He said. “And it is a fact that you’re a massive fuckin’ cry baby.”

“Rude.”

“Never said it was an insult.”

Izuku just grumbled incoherently against his chest.

“…Y’know, the crazy thing is, the first time I came here, it wasn’t even on purpose.”

“What, really?”

“Yep.” He said. “It was my second time travelin’ the Depths alone. One of the straps on my bag broke, and I spilled all my shit on the forest floor.”

“Oh wow. So you had to stop?”

“I mean… uhhh, what’s that shit Aizawa always says?” He squinted. “Somethin’ like, *‘reasonable people can disagree on whether I should’ve stopped.’”* He used air quotes. “If something like that happened today, I’d probably stop. But I was still an amateur, y’know? I’d heard way too many fuckin’ horror stories about people stoppin’ in the Depths, and endin’ up in way over their heads, so I was just like, fuck it.” He shrugged. “Found the first exit point I could and contacted my teacher.”

“Your teacher?”

“Mm.” He said. “More of a friend than a mentor at this point, but yeah. I’d introduce you, but she’s been real fuckin’ busy.”

“Ahh.”

“Anyway, yeah. I contacted my teacher, and once she was done chewin’ me out for keeping my respirator in my bag like a fucking *moron,* she agreed to come meet with me.”

Izuku giggled. “So you had to get picked up?”

“Like a fucking loser.” He rolled his eyes. “But yeah, I had a few hours to kill, so I did some exploring. And that’s how I wound up finding this place.”

“Wait, so you *discovered* it?”

“No.” He snorted. “I fuckin’ thought I had. I was real excited about it, too. Then my teacher showed up, and I’m like, *‘you gotta come see what I found.’* And she’s like, *‘yeah, yeah, Hades’ treasure chest. We know.’”*

“Aww!” Izuku laughed.

“I was so disappointed.” He sighed. “I thought I was Neil Armstrong…” He paused, running his fingertips across the surface of one of the crystals. “But it turned out I was Christopher fucking Columbus all along.”

When they eventually left the cavern, Katsuki pulled out a map and scanned it for a moment. Izuku glanced up at the sky, noting that it was perhaps nine in the morning.

“Well, we’re in luck, nerd.” Katsuki said. “‘Cuz the next spot shouldn’t take us more than half an hour in the Depths.” He paused to fold the map up again. “Course, that’s no excuse for you to get careless. Bad shit can still happen, even if you’re only in there for a bit.”

Izuku nodded, and watched as Katsuki shifted once again.

“You ready?” He asked.

And with that, they were off.

By the ten minute mark, they were back in the dark portion of the Depths, and Katsuki broke the silence first.

“You haven’t heard it again?”

Izuku shook his head. “No, not so far.”

“Good.”

After a minute, Izuku commented, “I’m surprised we haven’t run into any animals yet.”

“Oh, they’re around.” Katsuki told him. He jerked his head toward the right. “There’s a lot of Hyleks out this time of year. Little furry creatures that burrow inside the trees. They’re harmless, though. Some people even keep ‘em as pets.”

The compass veered south, and Katsuki made a rapid course correction.

“I spotted a couple Saevyrs during the first trip. Those things can be pretty nasty. Real aggressive, opportunistic predators.” He said. “But again, the creatures out here can sense when they’re up against something they can’t beat. They’d never challenge me, and they know you’re mine.”

Izuku’s eyes bugged out a bit, a blush spreading across his cheeks. He knew that Katsuki didn’t mean it like *that,* but that didn’t stop his mind from going there.

In an effort to distract himself, Izuku asked, “I-Is there anything out here that *would* try to attack you?”

“Well, yeah.” Katsuki replied. “Just not in the parts we’re traveling through.”

At that, he frowned. “But how can you tell? It all looks the same to me…”

Katsuki hummed, then pointed up. “You hear that?”

“Hear what?”

“The wind.” He said. “Blowin’ through the trees.”

“Oh.” He blinked. “Well, yeah.”

“That’s the easiest way to tell.”

The compass veered north, and Katsuki responded with a sharp right turn.

“That’s why we can’t just wear ear plugs in here all the time. Once the light’s gone, it’s that sound more than anything else that keeps you oriented. If it starts to fade, that means you gotta tread carefully. ‘Cuz if it disappears…” He chuckled softly. “That’s when you know you’re in deep shit.”

When they emerged from the forest half an hour later, it was to a landscape caught between two extremes. On Izuku’s left was a line of mountains and volcanoes that cut the skyline like jagged teeth. On his right, an enormous rift that stretched far into the distance, so deep Izuku couldn’t even see the bottom of it.

But the most striking part of it all was the way that two opposing forces converged within the crevasse. On the side closed to Izuku, streams of lava and hellfire poured endlessly from the smoking volcanoes, spilling into the rift, disappearing into its depths. On the opposite side, a large river met its end in the chasm, in the form of a massive waterfall.

Izuku stared at it for a long time. There was something about the scene before him than just didn’t look right to him. It seemed like the falloff of light was too abrupt. Darkness wasn’t the result of a presence so much as it was the result of an absence—namely, the absence of light. But as he gazed into the abyss, at the bizarre, inky blackness within, he got the sense that there was something there, something physical.

“It’s got a couple different names, but I like to call it *Schrödinger’s Lake.”* Katsuki told him, snapping him out of his trance. Izuku furrowed his brow.

“Lake...?”

Katsuki grinned, beckoning him closer to the edge, where he crouched down and grabbed the nearest rock. Izuku came to squat beside him.

“Check this out.” He said, and proceeded to throw the rock into the chasm. As expected, it fell, disappearing into the darkness. Izuku wasn’t really sure what point he was trying to make.

But then Katsuki reached out and touched it.

To Izuku’s astonishment, the space that had once appeared empty suddenly gained form, behaving like a sea of black liquid, rather than a dark pit. Katsuki cupped his hands, scooping some of the mysterious substance up. It spilled between his fingers like water, and rippled just the same.

“You shouldn’t try to touch it yourself.” Katsuki warned him. “It’s really hot, and even if it wasn’t, I have no idea how it’d affect you.”

Izuku nodded, staring at it in awe for a moment before grabbing a rock himself. He glanced at Katsuki briefly, waiting for him to give a small nod before he chucked it into the mysterious

body, watching it fall into the expanse, much as it had before. Katsuki then handed him a stick, and he leaned forward slightly, poking at the surface, watching the liquid engulf it.

It was unlike anything he'd ever seen before.

"I'm… so confused." Izuku muttered. "Kacchan, what on earth *is* this?"

"S'called hellwater," Katsuki replied. "It's what happens when hellfire interacts with a much larger body of freshwater. Basically, it'll act like either a liquid or a gas depending on the speed of the object hitting it. Like this," Katsuki thrust his hand down under the 'surface' and then stopped abruptly. At that moment, the hellwater engulfing his hand suddenly became opaque, like black tar. He remained still for a moment before he slowly pulled his hand back. Once it was out, Katsuki quickly shook his hand, and Izuku watched, mouth gaping, as the hellwater coating it seemed to evaporate instantly.

"Theoretically, if you were to jump in there, it'd feel like you were falling right up until you got to the bottom." Katsuki explained. "At that point, the feeling of being underwater would hit you like a fuckin' freight train."

Izuku blinked a few times pointedly. "Okay, that… I feel like this is illegal—I mean, in like a scientific sense."

Katsuki snorted. "Hell doesn't follow the same rules as Earth, Deku. That's just something you're gonna have to come to terms with."

"Yeah, but, like…" He squinted. "What rules *does* it follow? I can get on board with the rules being different, I'm just… trying to work out the logic, here."

"Well, lucky for you, there are entire fields in academia dedicated to studying how shit works down here." Katsuki grinned. "They're called the chthonic sciences. If that's somethin' you're interested in, well…" he shrugged. "There're plenty of books out there, schools and research groups focused on that sort of thing."

"Huh…" Izuku said, still entranced as he stirred the surface with the stick. "What happens if you try to swim in it?"

Katsuki winced. "Well, you *can…"* He said. "But it's a slippery fuckin' slope, y'know? You can do it if you're real careful, but if y'move too fast, you're pretty much fucked. Sudden movements lead to falling, which leads to *more* falling, and before you know it, you're hundreds of feet underwater."

Izuku frowned. "Couldn't you just fly out?"

"I mean…" Katsuki squinted. "Technically? But by the time you're able to start, you're already pretty fuckin' deep, is the thing, and as soon as you start gliding, you feel the water again. In theory, you can swim to the surface at that point. Problem is, when you're that deep, it's real fuckin' hard to stay calm. Most people start panicking, which makes you move too fast, which pulls you deeper." Katsuki stood up, stretching his arms over his head. "So it's basically just a fuckin' death trap."

“Jeez.” Izuku mumbled. “Has anyone ever survived? Swimming in it, I mean.”

“Oh, yeah. Tons of people.” Katsuki replied. “Including me.”

“Wait, *seriously?!”* Izuku gasped. *“You* did it?”

“Yep.” He pursed his lips. “Almost fucked it up, too. But luckily I was close enough to the edge when I slipped, so someone was able to grab me and pull me out before it was too late.”

Izuku stood up slowly. “Kacchan, with all due respect… what is *wrong* with you?”

He snorted. “I did it for a dare when I was young and stupid as fuck. I was kinda drunk at the time, too.” He shrugged. “The fucked up part is, the friend who dared me to do it was both older than me *and* sober at the time.”

Izuku’s face twisted up in disgust. “Seriously?”

“Yeah.” He scoffed. “So, needless to say, we ain’t fuckin’ friends anymore.”

Izuku just shook his head as he gazed down into the abyss. “Good riddance.”

Katsuki had warned him prior to entering that this trip would be the longest one by far.

Izuku felt the tension in his body increasing with every step they took, and the longer they went without incident, the more he began to expect something would happen. The sound of leaves rustling, twigs snapping in the distance made him jump, and Katsuki even went so far as to offer to take a detour at the next exit point, though Izuku insisted it wasn’t necessary.

It was almost a relief, when the forest started speaking to him again. It was still terrifying, of course, but at least he knew how to handle it.

“Lately the ordinary has deepened our grave.” It said, as Izuku stared straight ahead, wiping his clammy hands on his robe. It fell silent not long after, and Izuku felt much of the tension in his body ease away. The worst was behind them, now. The terror had already struck, and that meant he no longer needed to worry.

Right?

At some point, Katsuki began to slow a bit as they were walking, looking around at something Izuku couldn’t discern. Something rustled nearby.

“Shit.” He hissed. “Deku, mask and earmuffs. *Now.”*

Izuku’s breath caught in his throat, and he froze up for a second before scrambling to pull the mask off his belt. It was designed to come off when pulled, so at least he didn’t have to waste time fumbling with it.

With shaky hands, he quickly pulled the mask over his head, and grabbed the earmuffs next, pulling them apart as he went to put them on.

Then his fingers slipped.

Ice dropped into the pit of his stomach as he watched the earmuffs hit the forest floor. They were still walking, and once they left his sight, he craned his neck to look behind him, only to find that they were nowhere to be seen. Izuku began breathing heavily in the respirator.

“K-Kacchan…”

Katsuki looked at him, and paled.

“Shit. *Shit!”* he hissed. “Barrier up. *Now.”* That was the only warning he got before Katsuki shoved Izuku in front of him and sealed his large, shifted hands over his ears. It was as though he’d been plunged under water.

And then he saw it.

The creature emerged from the shadows around ten feet ahead of them. It looked like some sort of strange, mutant deer, with two extra legs and a few more eyes placed around its head. It wasn’t a particularly intimidating creature in itself.

What *was* frightening, however, was the way that it moved.

It staggered through the dirt and leaves, threatening to topple over with every step it took. It was as though the deer wasn’t moving so much as it was *being* moved, the way you might expect it to look if someone were to hold an unconscious person upright, while another person moved their legs manually. Each step was careful and heavy, and the creature’s head hung forward limply.

As it got closer, Izuku noticed the strange rippling of its skin, as though many small things had been trapped inside of it, writhing beneath the creature’s flesh. Izuku gagged at the sight, fighting back the urge to vomit inside the respirator.

Katsuki kept his hands over his ears for a minute afterward, and in his heightened state of awareness, he began noticing odd, red patterns on the trees. They came in clusters of blotches, and looked a little like messy finger prints. Only after the patterns disappeared did Katsuki finally take his hands off Izuku’s ears, returning to his place slightly ahead of him as he removed his own ear muffs and mask. Izuku did the same, hooking his mask on his belt again.

“I’m sorry.” He said, voice barely a whisper.

Katsuki shook his head. “Don’t be.” He replied. “I should’ve noticed the signs sooner.”

Izuku tried to swallow the nausea within him. A minute passed before he finally asked, “Um... What *was* that thing?”

Katsuki glanced at him out of the corner of his eye. “Do you really wanna know?”

Izuku shrugged. “It’s going to keep bothering me if I don’t.”

Katsuki sighed. *"Those,"* He emphasized the word. "Are called Vassalites. They're a type of parasitic insect that reproduce by entering a host's body and laying eggs inside them. Would you like to learn *more?"*

Izuku swallowed the nausea welling up in his throat. "Uh, no." He said. "No, I think I'm good, thank you."

Katsuki nodded. "If you ever meet God, ask him why he felt the need to give us so many creatures that reproduce by layin' eggs inside other creatures. 'Cuz I mean, I *get* that it's fuckin' gross and like, viscerally upsetting, but that can only justify *so much.* At a certain point, it just gets *suspicious."*

Izuku frowned. "I'm not really sure what you're trying to say."

Katsuki opened his mouth, then seemed to think better of it. "You know what? Never mind. That's probably for the best."

When they emerged next, it was at the foot of what appeared to be a mountain that stretched high up into the clouds. Its sides were steep, almost unnaturally so. Izuku felt tired just looking at it.

"It's just at the top, here." Katsuki muttered nonchalantly.

Izuku's eyes bugged out. "Wait, this one?" He pointed at the mountain. "This one, right here? *Seriously?"*

"Uhh, yeah?" Katsuki replied. "Why?"

Izuku hesitated a moment.

"Look, it's just…" He sighed. "I'm not sure about this one. I mean, don't get me wrong, I want to see whatever you're trying to show me, but... Well, I'm not much of a hiker normally, and this just seems…" He grimaced. "A bit out of my league, to say the least."

"Well, guess it's a good thing there's no hiking involved here."

Izuku did a double take, brows pinched together as he looked at him. It was only then that he realized that Katsuki was still fully shifted.

"Sorry, what?"

Katsuki gave him a blank look. "I just said we don't have to climb it, Deku."

Izuku simply stared back at him for a while, blinking pointedly. After a moment, Katsuki lowered his chin and raised an eyebrow. Then, gesturing back at his wings, Katsuki slowly explained, "Because we can fly to the top, Deku."

A second went by.

"…Oh." Izuku muttered. Another two seconds, and his eyes went wide. *"Oh!"*

Katsuki burst out laughing, buckling over and clutching his stomach.

"Holy fuck," he wheezed. "Did you seriously fuckin' forget you could fly, dumbass?"

"W-Well—!" He flushed. "I mean, it's not like I've had a chance to recently, w-with the artifice and all!"

It took way too long for Katsuki to calm down, but eventually, he stood up straight and exhaled fondly. "C'mon. Follow me," he said, moving a few feet away, so that he could extend his wings fully. "It'll take like five minutes, tops."

Izuku stood there for a moment, watching as Katsuki extended his large, black wings and took flight. For a moment, he just stood there, gazing up at him. Though he'd seen Katsuki's wings stretched out before, he'd never actually seen him fly, and the sight of him moving so gracefully made his heart flutter inside his chest and his face heat up.

Kacchan really is incredible…

"Well?" He shouted, hovering high in the sky. "You comin,' or what?"

Izuku swallowed, shoving the thoughts out of his mind as he, too, took flight, meeting Katsuki in the air many feet above.

When they landed a few minutes later, Katsuki returned to his normal, half-shifted form with a sigh. He paused to roll his shoulders, stretching his arms above his head, before gesturing for Izuku to follow him. He led him up a short pathway, and one of the first things Izuku noticed was that the closer they got, the warmer it became.

It did not take long to figure out why.

When they reached the peak of the mountain a minute later, Izuku realized it wasn't a mountain at all, but rather a volcano. And as he peered over the crevasse at the center, he saw something that took his breath away. Down there, around twenty feet below, was a vast lake of lava, bubbling and popping, and moving around sluggishly, though it didn't seem to be actively erupting.

The really amazing part, however, was the color. The lava glowed an otherworldly violet and sparkled like amethyst, and when Izuku stood there looking down at it, his heart raced with a mixture of wonder and anxiety that he wasn't quite sure how to process. It was oddly familiar, however. Almost like…

…When I first met Kacchan.

Izuku's breath caught in his throat as it came back to him, an odd sort of nostalgia. He could remember that period, when that conflict raged within him, the knowledge that Katsuki could kill him in an instant, paired with the inability to look away from him. It'd been a while since he'd last felt afraid of Katsuki, though.

He tore his eyes away for a moment, peering over the opposite edge. It truly was a bizarre formation. The steep drop-off on the exterior felt more akin to a skyscraper than a volcano, and the distant sight of jagged rocks thousands of feet below made it almost as intimidating.

The ground around the opening was perhaps a little more than the width of a standard doorway. It was more than enough for the two of them to move around with relative freedom —just not enough for what came next.

“Hey, Deku.”

Izuku turned his head toward Katsuki, and found him standing there with one gloved hand outstretched. He was a bit confused, but he tentatively took his hand.

He regretted it almost immediately.

Because as soon as the Demon’s grip closed around his hand, Katsuki yanked him closer, pulling him into his chest. He grabbed Izuku’s other hand and placed it on his shoulder, and with a wide grin, began to move rhythmically, humming some random tune. Izuku was too busy being terrified to care what it was.

“What the hell are you doing?!”

Katsuki gave a shit-eating grin.

“Dancin’ with you, obviously,” he replied, somehow managing to puppeteer Izuku into a waltz, even as his feet dragged along the ground.

“Seriously? *Here?!”*

“Sure, why not?”

“Kacchan!” Izuku looked back and forth between their two potential fates: one a bed of jagged rocks thousands of feet below, the other just a short drop into a pit of molten lava. Though the first was more than long enough for him to fly out of it, the other was not so certain.

“It’s just a little lava, Deku.”

“I’m going to *kill* you.”

At that, Katsuki just laughed, and Izuku stumbled, jaw clenching as Katsuki twirled him around. His palms were sweaty against the fabric of Katsuki’s shirt and glove, and his heart would not stop hammering in his chest, but ultimately, he decided to just grit his teeth and go along with it. The lip of the volcano didn’t seen particularly stable, after all. Putting up a struggle was just too risky in a place where one wrong move could send you hurdling to your doom.

And so, Izuku gritted his teeth and matched his movements, dancing with him even as he stared up at him with a withering glare.

“Oh, c’mon.” Katsuki rolled his eyes. “Quit bein’ so nervous.”

“Not all of us are heat-resistant, Kacchan.”

Katsuki pulled him a bit closer. “Deku, you *know* I’m not gonna let anything happen to you.”

Izuku looked away, grumbling under his breath before falling silent. For a moment, it was just the ambient sound of steaming lava, the soft shuffle of their footsteps, and the occasional sound of a bubble popping, or a rock falling into the volcano, that made Izuku tense up all over again.

“You know, I actually got thrown in there once.”

Izuku blinked. “Sorry, *what?”*

Katsuki grinned. “It’s kinda like a Wrath Demon rite of passage, I guess.” He shrugged. “This is the hottest volcano in Hell. The idea is that once you’ve taken a swim in there, you can handle pretty much anything.”

Izuku just stared at him for a few seconds, momentarily distracted from the objectively perilous situation they were in.

“You swam… in a volcano.” He deadpanned.

“Well, *‘swam’* might not be the right word.” He said. “You can’t really swim in it. It’s basically just hot goo.”

“…And this is like, a tradition?”

“Guess so. I dunno who started it, though.” He snorted. “I’d like to meet the first guy who did it. Imagine that—just thinkin’ *‘fuck it,’* goin’ balls to the wall and jumping straight into a goddamn volcano. What a fucking legend.”

“Wait, but…” Izuku narrowed his eyes. “Didn’t that hurt?”

“Oh, it hurt like a motherfucker.” Katsuki grinned. “Didn’t speak to my teacher for two weeks afterward.”

“So did she just… not tell you what she was planning?”

“She told me, like, ten seconds in advance.” He rolled his eyes. “I remember her takin’ me up here, me askin’ what the Hell we were doin’ here. And when she finally told me, *‘you’re going to jump into this volcano,’* I was like, *‘Uh, no, actually. I’m not. Fuck you very much.’”* He sighed. “Famous last words.”

“Jeez.”

“Yeah.” He scoffed. “I couldn’t hold the grudge for long, though. ‘Cuz after that, I actually did see a lot of rapid improvement. But damn if I wasn’t pissed for a while.”

“Guess I can’t blame you.” He mumbled. A moment passed by in silence, and Izuku noted that his heart rate had slowed down a bit, thanks to the distraction the story had provided.

That did not last long.

Suddenly, Katsuki dipped him over the edge, causing him to hover right over the lava, one foot in the air, the other precariously placed on the edge. Izuku’s heart lurched in his chest, his eyes nearly bulging out of his skull. Katsuki pulled him back a second later, but his heart was still pounding.

“I hate you.”

“Aw, baby. Don’t be like that.”

Izuku gave him a bright smile. “Sleep with your eyes open, Kacchan!” He chirped.

Katsuki snorted, but gradually, his movements began to slow, until they were holding onto one another, swaying back and forth beneath the glow of violet light. The fear gradually dulled as their movements stabilized further, and eventually, Katsuki gently pulled away.

“We should probably head out.” He muttered. “You ready?”

Izuku nodded *very* enthusiastically.

With that, Katsuki shifted once again, and the two of them set off, flying down the mountain and landing at the edge of the Depths again.

“Hey.” Katsuki said, getting his attention. He looked up just before Katsuki pulled him into a hug, his cheek pressing into his chest. “Sorry for scarin’ ya.”

Izuku released a long sigh, shaking his head. “I feel like you’re the sort of person who’d go to a public pool and dunk kids’ heads underwater as a joke.”

That made Katsuki laugh. “Well, a baptism’s a baptism.”

Despite himself, Izuku cracked a smile.

Izuku shivered as he walked behind Katsuki. It was quiet, apart from the distant sound of the wind.

Izuku gasped when he caught sight of something moving out of the corner of his eye.

“It’s okay.” Katsuki was quick to say.

“There’s—“

“It’s just another Hylek. Don’t worry.”

Izuku craned his neck, searching for the creature, but he couldn't find it in the darkness. Eventually, he gave up, sighing as he turned his gaze back toward the path before them.

Suddenly, Katsuki froze.

Actually *froze.*

It was only for a second, but given how adamant Katsuki had been about never stopping, it set off alarm bells in Izuku's mind before Katsuki even spoke.

"Deku, I'm gonna need to carry you for this."

"What? Why—?" Before he could finish that thought, Katsuki swooped his arm under his knees and pulled him into a princess carry. "Kacchan, wha—"

The words died on his tongue when he looked up ahead and saw it. Not too far from them, there were what appeared to be a number of orange eyes, glowing like candlelights in the darkness.

There were roughly a dozen of them, all arranged in a circle that wobbled, rotated, and receded from time to time. The movements were so perfectly synchronized, Izuku could only conclude that they all belonged to the same creature. He felt Katsuki's chest grow warmer as they drew closer, and curled into it.

More than anything else, it was the sounds that put Izuku on edge. A constant, mechanical grinding noise, every few seconds punctuated by something else, almost like the sound of steam being released from a massive engine. It evoked images of something overwhelming, industrial; like standing in the middle of a city at night, where the brutalist architecture made your soul feel as heavy as the exposed concrete the buildings were made from. It was that feeling of being small, yet unable to escape—a kind of claustrophobia that follows you out into the open.

If such a feeling could be encapsulated, wrapped up in the flesh of something living, this creature would be the result.

As they passed, Izuku could pick up the sound of something wet and squishy that he could only assume to be some sort of meat, gnashing between the creature's teeth, and at this distance the steam-like industrial sounds were loud enough to rattle Izuku's entire body.

He was tense in Katsuki's arms, paralyzed in fear beneath the creature's gaze. It watched them as they passed, but it did not attack them. And once they were a safe distance away, Katsuki set him down again with a sigh.

"What the hell was that thing?" Izuku barely whispered.

"A cyclogeist," Katsuki replied. "Like most shit out here, they won't attack somethin' stronger than them, but they're real fast. Sometimes they'll try to steal prey, if they think they can get away with it. Luckily, that one was already eating."

"You think it would've gone after me if it wasn't?"

“Mm, probably not.” Katsuki shrugged. “Not while I was carrying you, at least. I mean, maybe it if was *desperate,* but…” He trailed off for a moment. “Well, y’know.”

Izuku shivered.

“Means we’ve gotta be careful, though; if we’re running into cyclogeists, that usually means we’re gettin’ close to the midnight depths.”

“The… midnight depths?”

“Yeah.” He said. “There’re different regions in the Depths. Like, there’s the daylight depths, where it just looks like a normal forest. Then there’s the twilight depths, where most of the light is gone. After that is the nighttime depths, where basically all the light’s gone. That’s what most of it is.

“But then there’s the midnight depths. It’s where the sound of wind starts to get faint. Technically, I can safely travel there, but I avoid it whenever possible, ‘cuz it’s real easy to get swept into the void depths from there, which is infinitely more dangerous.”

“Why?” Izuku’s eyes widened. “What’s down there?”

“Eh, lots of shit.” Katsuki shrugged. “The thing about this place is, the deeper you go, the more you start to run into creatures that are very specifically adapted to live in the Depths. Which often means they have a kind of creepy, symbiotic relationship with it.” He explained. “There’s a bit of that in the higher regions, but most of the creatures in those parts live at odds with the forest just as much as we do.”

The thought of creatures having a symbiotic relationship with something as vast and unfathomable as the Depths sent shivers down Izuku’s spine.

“S-So have you ever been down there?” He asked. “In the void depths.”

“Yep.” He said, popping the ‘p’ sound. “It’s happened a few times—not on purpose, obviously. Most of those times, I was able to find my way out before anything *too* dangerous happened, but…”

“But...?”

“Well, there’ve been close calls, obviously.” He shrugged. “The worst one was actually pretty recent. Happened like, a month before I met you. Got swept into the void and ran into a fuckin’ deepseeker, barely made it out alive.” He shook his head. “They’re like these massive creatures that secrete this weird toxin that fucks with your muscle control and makes you really suggestible.”

“Suggestible?”

“Yeah.” The compass veered south, and Katsuki corrected it with a sharp left turn. “That’s part of the symbiotic relationship I mentioned. Basically, when you get dosed with that stuff, you’re almost guaranteed to react when the Depths calls out to you.

“And that’s the other thing about the void depths. Like, if you thought that shit was scary before, it’s fuckin’ nothing compared to how it is when you’re down there. The deeper you go, the more likely it is to talk to you, and when it does, it’s so much fucking worse.”

“It’s… kind of hard to imagine it getting scarier than it already is.”

Katsuki hummed. “What’d it say to you when you heard it earlier? Just gimme an example.”

“Uhhh…” Izuku squinted. “Well, at one point it asked me something like, ‘do the shadows still bleed for you?’”

“Yeah, that’s some classic Depths nonsense.” He said, snickering. “Thing is, though, the level of sense it makes is actually dependent on the region. It’s really rare to hear it in the daylight depths, but if you do, it’ll spout literal gibberish. Like, just some fuckin’ *sounds.*

“In the twilight depths, it can form words, but not proper sentences. It just strings together random words and throws ‘em at you.

“The nighttime depths is where you’ll hear weird phrases like that. Sentences that’re technically correct, but make no fucking sense conceptually—or if they do, it’s a coincidence.”

The compass made a sudden turn, going from pointing north to pointing south in a matter of seconds. Katsuki responded with a quick one-eighty, and they continued on.

“In the midnight depths, things start to get…” He trailed off for a moment, wincing.

“Kacchan?”

He shook his head. “Well, for one thing, that’s when it starts callin’ your name. So, that’s *fun.”* He scoffed. “And the shit it says is short, but coherent. Like, it’ll literally just say *‘look at me,’* or *‘follow me,’* or even *‘help me.’”* He paused for a second. “It starts affecting your other senses, too. You’ll see movement in the direction the voice comes from. It’s indistinct, but it’s there.”

Izuku got goosebumps just thinking about it.

“It gets worse, if you can believe it.” Katsuki offered a tight smile. “‘Cuz once you’re in the void depths, the Depths is basically in your head. It *knows* you. And it’ll weaponize that knowledge to try to provoke a reaction.” He explained. “It’s happened to me four times out of the seven or so I’ve ended up there on accident, and it’s legitimately the worst shit ever, ‘cuz at that point you can actually *see* it.”

Izuku shivered. “What do you mean *‘see it’?”*

“Deku, imagine this.” He said, gesturing vaguely. “You’re stumbling through the dark, trying to find your way out of this goddamn eldritch location, and suddenly, you see your fucking doppelgänger right there in your periphery, just fucking staring at you, while it gleefully taunts you about every insecurity, every traumatic memory you’ve got. And you just gotta keep walkin’ as though it ain’t there. What would you *do?”*

For a second, Izuku just stared up at him, mouth slightly open. “I mean… realistically?”

“Sure.”

“Probably pee my pants.”

“Yeah, that’s fair.” Katsuki nodded. “Now, imagine you have to deal with that shit when you’re injured, gettin’ chased by a deepseeker, and dosed on a drug that makes you wanna do everything you’re told to.”

“Wait, seriously? You heard it *then?”* Izuku gaped. “How are you still alive?”

“I got lucky.” He said. “Thing about deepseekers is they’re real territorial. When I was runnin’ from the one that dosed me, I ran through another one’s territory, which led to them attacking each other. It was enough of a distraction to keep me from looking long enough to find my earplugs.”

“That’s *insane.”*

“Yeah, well—this is pretty much the domain of insane shit.” Katsuki said. “Only a handful of people have escaped after gettin’ dosed with deepseeker venom. I remember hearing a story once, ‘bout a woman who managed to escape by bashing her head against a tree to knock herself out ’til the venom wore off.”

Izuku’s eyes widened. “I can’t see how that’d be anything other than another death sentence.”

Katsuki snorted. “It’s a big fucking gamble, that’s for sure. You risk somethin’ else finding ya, and y’have no idea where you’ll be when you wake up. You might still be in the void depths. If you’re real unlucky, you could end up deeper.”

“There’s a *deeper region?!”*

“Oh yeah. See, that’s the thing about this place, Deku—every time you think it can’t get worse, it fuckin’ does.”

“No kidding…” Izuku muttered. “So, what is it, then? The nightmare depths? The *murder depths?”*

Katsuki laughed. “It’s actually just called the Quiet.”

“Somehow, that’s even worse.” Izuku grimaced. “What’s down there?

“Who the fuck knows?” Katsuki replied, grinning. “It’s sorta like the event horizon of this place, in the sense that, as far as we know, no one’s ever made it out alive.”

“Couldn’t they send, like, a robot or something?”

“The Depths is hostile to technology.” He shrugged. “If it wasn’t, we’d use it to develop some sort of large rapid transit system. But anything you put out here gets swept away, and most electronics just don’t work.” He explained. “A lot of real smart people have been

studying this shit for a very long time, but the situation hasn't changed much. At this point, in order to travel out here safely, you either gotta be strong yourself, or be accompanied by someone who is."

Izuku went quiet for a while, taking a moment to process the information. While they walked, he noticed their surroundings getting a bit lighter as they entered what he supposed would be referred to as the twilight depths.

"Well, what do they *think* is down there?" He eventually asked.

"In the Quiet?"

Izuku nodded.

Katsuki sighed heavily, looking up in thought. "I mean, it's all just conjecture at this point. Some people think there's somethin' hidden there, like maybe some kinda treasure, or some sorta Lovecraftian horror.

"Others think there's nothing there, and the reason people don't come back is just 'cuz the Depths is too powerful at that point. Like, it's just the logical conclusion of the pattern we've already seen. The Depths knows more and can affect you more the deeper you go." He shrugged. "Maybe at that level, it becomes impossible to ignore for some reason. There're as many theories as there are people theorizing about it."

"But what about you, specifically?" Izuku asked "What do *you* think is down there?"

"Me?" Katsuki smirked. "Personally, I think it's God's porn stash."

They entered through a hollowed out cavern in the hillside, where the walls were lined with faintly pearlescent stone and the distant sound of the tide resonated throughout its body. Even at night, the ambient light still managed to leak in, casting the cavern in a wash of blue and pink that made the whole area feel like a dream.

The light gradually became brighter as they approached the opening.

Katsuki stepped out first, and then offered Izuku his hand. "Careful. It's slippery."

Izuku nodded, taking Katsuki's hand as he stepped down. His feet still skidded, but Katsuki was quick to react, wrapping his other arm around his lower back and lifting him off the slick part. The experience of nearly falling made Izuku's heart pound in his chest. He took a few deep breaths once Katsuki set him down on the ground.

"Y'good?"

Izuku sighed, nodding his head.

"Great." Katsuki smiled. "In that case…" He inclined his head toward something behind him, and as Izuku turned around, all the breath he'd just recovered seemed to flee his lungs once again.

They were inside a small cove, where the smooth stone formed walls around them and made it feel as though they were enclosed in their own private world. But most striking was the sea itself.

It was early nighttime, and as the tide washed in and out gently, it seemed to sparkle. Izuku inched closer, hands over his mouth as he saw that the waves were carrying what looked like small, bead-sized balls of light that swirled and glittered beneath the night sky, almost like…

“They call it the sea of stars.” Katsuki said, suddenly standing right beside him. He pointed somewhere in the distance. “You see all those trees surrounding the water?”

Izuku nodded.

“Those are kaizen trees.” He said. “Mature seeds glow when they’re immersed in water. During the summertime, they release ‘em, and the waves disperse them all around the coasts, where they’ll either take root, or attract certain animals that’ll carry them away.” He approached a tree at the far end of the cove. “Here, watch this.”

Katsuki grabbed a low branch and began to shake it lightly. Izuku watched in awe as the seeds rained down from the branch, lighting up in a bright, bluish tone as soon as they hit the water.

“The fresher ones are brighter.” Katsuki said, hopping off the rock and approaching Izuku again. As seemed to be the theme for the day, for a moment, Izuku was just speechless. He stood there, his mouth covered by his hands, staring out at the sea with wide eyes. “Here, take off your shoes.” Katsuki told him, as he did the same.

Once they were both barefoot, Katsuki beckoned him over to a large boulder near the edge, where he sat down, rolling up his pants and putting his feet in the water. Izuku followed suit, sitting beside Katsuki. He wasn’t as tall as him, and so while Katsuki’s feet were immersed up to the ankle, the water only touched the bottoms of Izuku’s feet, and only his toes ever breeched the surface.

They sat there for a few minutes in comfortable silence. Izuku stared down at the water, entranced. As it swirled around, the seeds seemed to congregate around their feet like a bed of starlight.

He sighed, resting his cheek on Katsuki’s shoulder, felt the heat of his skin through the fabric of his shirt, and started giggling.

Katsuki tensed slightly. “What?”

Izuku lifted his head to look at him properly. “I just think it’s funny, is all. You act all tough, but deep down, you’re a romantic.”

Katsuki just glared at him, though his cheeks were tinted red. *“Fuck you.”*

“I don’t hear you denying it.”

For another minute, it was quiet.

“I just… wanted to give you a reason to come back.” Katsuki eventually said. Then, a bit quieter, “…Or a reason to stay.”

Izuku looked at him, at the strangely vulnerable expression on his face. Katsuki didn’t look back, simply kept his eyes fixated on the water. The red glow merged with the ambient blue, leaving a sort of lavender halo around his head.

“Kacchan…” He whispered, lacing his fingers through Katsuki’s. “I’ll come back. I would, even if it was just you down here. Even if this whole place was a wasteland, and you were the last thing alive here… I’d still come back for you.”

Katsuki looked at him again, a small grin on his face. He shook his head, laughing softly. “Deku… you really gotta be more careful with your words. If I didn’t know better, a line like that would make me think you were in love with me.”

Izuku froze, the word echoing in his head.

Love.

Love.

*Do I… **love** Kacchan…?*

He gulped, and opened his mouth to speak. For a second, it just hung there. Izuku cleared his throat.

“Um. So, how would—“

“Ow!” Katsuki suddenly shouted, startling him. “Fuck!” He yanked his feet out of the water, revealing a fish that had latched onto his big toe. “Mother*fucker!”* Katsuki grabbed the thing, yanking it off, and hurling it back into the water.

“Are you okay?!”

“Yeah, just—hang on.” Katsuki grumbled. Izuku leaned forward, and saw that his toe was bleeding. It wasn’t severe, but it was enough to warrant Katsuki standing up and angrily limping to his bag, pulling out a first aid kit. He cleaned and bandaged the bite, cursing under his breath as he did.

Once he was done, Izuku asked once more, “Are you okay?”

Katsuki sighed. “Yeah,” he rolled his eyes. “Fuckin’ forgot about those little bastards.” He muttered. “They eat the seeds, but they’re dumb as shit, so sometimes…” He shrugged, gesturing down at his foot. “Well, y’know.”

Izuku nodded, awkwardly shuffling in place.

“Whatever. It’s getting late, anyway.”

When they returned, they had circled back to almost the exact same point they'd departed from. They rode the train back quietly, and it was only then, when the danger was behind them, that Izuku really felt the high of their adventure. As they entered Katsuki's apartment, Izuku could barely hold back the smile on his face.

Katsuki showered first, and Izuku second. After he dried his hair and put on his pajamas, he came out of the bathroom to find Katsuki lying on the couch bed. He wasn't sure what to say, so he just approached him with an awkward, questioning smile. Katsuki provided no explanation. He just patted the space next to him. Izuku only hesitated a second before he climbed in beside him.

They lay on their sides, facing each other. Katsuki spoke first.

"Have fun today?"

Izuku nodded, smiling. "Feels like I just saw the whole world in one day."

"Oh, there's plenty more I could show ya." He said. "I chose those places mostly 'cuz they're all really close to the Depths. If there was more time, I could show ya shit that'd blow that the fuck outta the water."

Izuku laughed. "Well, I hope I'll get to see them soon."

Katsuki hummed. "There's one place in particular that I skipped today. Somewhere nearby."

Izuku raised his eyebrows. "Oh, really?"

"Mm. It's not the *most* visually spectacular, but it's special." He paused, grabbing a stray lock of hair and brushing it out of Izuku's eyes. "When you get back, I'll take ya there."

When I get back.

He shoved the lingering anxiety into the back of his mind.

"Well, I'll look forward to it." He smiled. "Today was… honestly, probably the most fun I think I've ever had. Thank you, Kacchan."

Katsuki hummed, and for a while, just gazed at him quietly, a wide grin on his face. It made Izuku a little self-conscious.

"Wh-What?"

"Nothin.'" Katsuki replied. "Was just thinkin' 'bout how a few months ago I had to convince you I wasn't gonna torture children."

Izuku blinked a few times, and then started giggling again. "Yeah… frankly, just from the way you kiss Triplet, it's kinda hard to imagine you doing anything like that now."

Katsuki blushed slightly. "Oi, you *saw* that?!"

He could barely contain his laughter. “I did.”

“Didn’t anyone ever tell you not to spy on people, you *fuck?”* Katsuki glared. “Quit fuckin’ laughing!”

“I’m sorry,” He wheezed. “M’sorry. I just think it’s funny, is all… and sweet.”

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“You know, for a Demon, you’re not very demonic.”

Katsuki looked him up and down, and then his eyes seemed to darken. “Oh, I can be *demonic*.”

Izuku shrugged—as best he could while lying on his side, at least. “I just don’t see it.”

He raised an eyebrow, holding Izuku’s gaze for a few seconds. And then, in one sudden flash of movement, Katsuki lurched toward him, rolling Izuku onto his back and straddling him. It was like all the breath had been sucked right out of Izuku’s lungs. He lay there, his cheeks dusted pink as he stared up at the Demon above him, his soft skin and sharp features painted in the cool wash of the city lights.

It was moments like these that reminded him just how handsome Katsuki actually was, all hard lines and sharp edges, wrapped up in an aura of something smooth, ethereal. As he sat there above him, dark horns poking through spiky, blond hair, tail swaying gently behind him, Izuku couldn’t help but feel mesmerized. As he leaned in toward him, the soft glow of his eyes shone beneath his lashes, creating subtle patterns on his eyelids in the dimly lit room.

And to see him like this, watch the way his muscles shifted beneath his skin, catch the brief glint of his sharp canines whenever he licked his lips… well, it was nothing short of entrancing.

Katsuki always looked at him as though he were winning a game Izuku never knew they were playing. Always two steps ahead of him, like the apex predator the creatures of the Depths instinctively knew him to be.

Katsuki’s eyes left a stain on his soul that Izuku could never scrub away.

Though even if he could, he wouldn’t want to.

After a moment, Katsuki began to laugh, low and deep in his throat.

“Y’know,” he purred, fingers ghosting beneath Izuku’s chin. “You talk a lotta shit for a guy who keeps throwin’ me looks I could feed off of.”

Izuku’s breath caught in his throat, his face burning hotter as he realized just how much of an open book he was being. He quickly turned his head away. “I-I don’t know what you’re talking about.”

Katsuki chuckled, grabbing him firmly by the chin, turning his head back toward him. “Oh you don’t, huh?” His free hand traveled down Izuku’s body, lingering at his hips, drawing lazy circles there.

Izuku squirmed a bit, “No.”

Katsuki cocked his head. “You sure about that?”

He chewed his lip, averting his eyes as he nodded. He held his breath as Katsuki hummed, leaning in closer.

“Well…” he murmured.

There was a moment of silence that seemed to last an eternity, as Izuku waited with bated breath to see what the Demon would do next.

And then suddenly, Katsuki stood up.

By the time Izuku’s mind registered the shift, he was already standing several feet away, his hands stuffed into his pockets casually. Izuku blinked several times, propping himself up on his elbows, his brow furrowed.

Katsuki just shrugged. “I guess that’s that, then.”

He turned on his heel and began to walk away.

For a few seconds, Izuku was so shocked, he couldn’t even form words. He found his voice just as Katsuki was about to disappear into the hallway.

“W-Wait!”

Katsuki stopped, looking over his shoulder at him, one eyebrow arched.

“Why…” Izuku gulped, sitting up fully. “Why’d you stop…?”

“Why?” Katsuki parroted, turning to face him. “Well, ‘cuz you said I was *wrong,* of course.” He spoke with this overly dramatic, feigned innocence.

Izuku simply stared at him for a moment. “But… that’s—“

“—Just a little *miscalculation* on my part.” Katsuki interjected, leaning back against the wall casually. “You see, Deku—I was under the impression that you *wanted* me.” He placed a hand over his heart. “But since that apparently ain’t the case, I guess the right thing to do here is to just back off. *Wouldn’t you agree?”*

Izuku blinked a few times. “Back… off…?”

“Yeah,” He took a few steps toward him. “Y’know, you might not be aware of this, but all that touching and kissing shit I do? That’s actually not, like, *platonic.”* He ran a hand through his hair. “It actually means I wanna do stuff with you involving *this.”* Katsuki suddenly

grabbed his dick through his sweats. Izuku's eyes widened as he followed the movement, watched as he lingered there for a fleeting moment before he released it, sliding his hand back into his pocket.

Izuku was paralyzed, his eyes wide, face hot enough to break a sweat. He swallowed the excess saliva that had suddenly begun to well up beneath his tongue.

Katsuki licked his lips. "It's really my bad, y'know?" He then said. "I should've expected this. You *are* an Angel, after all. I'm sure the sex ed up in Heaven leaves a lot to be desired."

Izuku squirmed, gripping the sheets on either side of him. "Kacchan…"

"But that's alright." He continued. "It's a shame, but it's whatever, y'know? I'll just…" he shrugged, taking a few steps closer, until he was standing right at the foot of the bed. "Go back to my room, jerk off like I usually do. No big deal."

An involuntary whimper escaped Izuku's throat.

"Oh, sorry—does hearing about me jerking off *bother* you? *My bad."* Katsuki grinned, sinking one knee into the mattress as he leaned toward him. "Well, don't worry, nerd. I'll be sure not to tell you about how I like to…" He hummed. "Wrap my hand around my cock and stroke it, while I fantasize about you, down on your knees, sucking me off."

Izuku swore he could hear threads popping from where his hands gripped the bedsheets.

"Won't tell you about how I sometimes like to imagine you down on all fours, takin' it like a good boy." He purred. "My hands wrapped around the roots of your wings, using 'em like a fuckin' harness to pull you back onto my cock." Katsuki's tongue darted out, licking his lips as his eyes raked over his body. "Wouldn't wanna make you *uncomfortable,* right, *De-ku?"*

Izuku made a small, broken, wheezing noise that sounded vaguely like Katsuki's name as he squirmed even more, thighs rubbing together as his body heated up beneath the Demon's gaze.

"Hmm, yeah?" Katsuki rasped. "Y'know, you really gotta be more careful about the kinda signals you send, Deku." He smirked. "'Cuz if I didn't know better, I'd think you were gettin' turned on right now."

He whined, eyes starting to tear up. Katsuki grinned even wider, clearly enjoying his struggle.

"What's wrong, *De-ku?* Somethin' I said?"

"I… *fine,* I take back what I said earlier, okay?" He glared weakly. "Will you stop this now?"

"Stop what?"

Izuku clenched his jaw. "You're *definitely* a sadist."

"Oh?" Katsuki cocked his head. "Are you *suffering,* Deku?"

“I *hate* you.”

“Aw, don’t be like that.”

“Wh-What do you *want* from me, Kacchan?!”

“Oh, Deku… *baby.”* He purred. “I don’t want anything *from* you. I just want *you.”*

“But you *have* me,” Izuku almost sobbed. “Kacchan, I’m *right here!”*

“That so?” He raised his eyebrows. “Then I was right after all, huh? You *do* want me.”

“Obviously!”

He paused for a moment then, staring down at him with a self-satisfied smirk on his face. Then he slowly removed his knee from the mattress, taking a wide stance at the foot of the bed. “Well, in that case…“

In a flash, Katsuki grabbed his ankles, dragging him down the mattress. Izuku yelped as Katsuki continued to pull until his hips were situated right on the edge, and he only barely managed to raise his barrier before he dove down and kissed him, lips smacking as Katsuki immediately went for the kill, kissed him like he was trying to consume him. Katsuki swallowed every little sound that escaped him, sucked in every breath he released until he felt lightheaded.

When they eventually parted, Izuku gasped, trying to hold back the urge to moan as Katsuki kissed down his jaw and neck, his hands rubbing up and down his thighs. Even through his clothes, Katsuki’s touch was overwhelming. “Ah, Kacchan—“ He choked back a whine when Katsuki sealed his lips over his neck, sucking the skin there until his toes curled. “I… I don’t know if I’ll be able to…”

Katsuki pulled back a moment later, humming. “Well…” He murmured. “Luckily, there’s plenty of shit we can do *without* direct contact.”

Izuku gulped, still panting a bit. “L-Like what?”

He slid one hand up into his hair, grabbing by the roots and pulling slightly. Then, Katsuki rolled his hips down into his, and Izuku nearly choked, because he could *feel* him. Katsuki’s cock pressed against his own through the fabric of their thin pants, hard and swelling up further with each passing second. Izuku’s thighs began to shake as Katsuki grinded against him, pulling his head to the side and leaning down, until his lips just ghosted over the shell of his ear.

“You okay with gettin’ a little messy, *Deku baby?”*

Izuku bit his lip. He didn’t trust his voice, so he just nodded, and felt Katsuki grin against his ear.

And then, in one quick movement, Katsuki flipped their positions, lying on his back with Izuku straddling him. He grabbed his ass, claws biting into the flesh through his pajama

pants. And when he used that hold to pull Izuku flush against his hips, he nearly choked, struggling to keep his balance as this body flooded with heat. In this position, he could both feel and see the outline of Katsuki's cock, hot and swollen, straining against the fabric of his sweatpants.

"Fuck," He groaned, reaching under his waistband, adjusting himself. He had to pull his sweatpants up toward his waist just to keep everything contained as he grabbed his cock, laid it flat against his body. Izuku's eyes widened, and he seemed to notice. "What?" He asked, with a grin on his face that said he knew *exactly* what.

He flushed as Katsuki returned both hands to his ass and rolled his hips up into him. "Got somethin' to say?"

Izuku shook his head.

"Really?" Katsuki rasped. "'Cuz it seems like you've got somethin' on your mind."

He shook his head again. "I-I'm not going to—*ahh*—feed your ego, Kacchan…"

He snorted. "Aw, well. That's okay." He said. "I think watchin' you cum in your pants for me will have basically the same effect."

Izuku glared weakly, fighting to stifle the sounds that threatened to spill past his lips as he pulled him down harder. Even through the layers of clothing, it was intense. The feeling of his dick, all hard and grinding against Katsuki's, was so far removed from anything he'd experienced before, it was genuinely difficult for him to describe. Like warm tea on a cold morning, or a hot bath after a long day, only infinitely more concentrated. It made him want to collapse forward, bury his face in Katsuki's shoulder, and just let the Demon take care of him.

He would've been perfectly content to just stay there, panting and shaking while Katsuki worked him like that, groped his ass and dragged him back and forth on his cock. But it felt like almost as soon as he'd started, Katsuki stopped. Releasing his hold on him, he folded his arms up behind his head and stared up at Izuku, pupils blown wide, as if he were expecting something.

Without his hands on him, Izuku wavered, and planted his palms on Katsuki's chest over his shirt to keep steady. He blinked a few times, and when he met Katsuki's eyes, it took a moment for his brain to catch up. "Wh-Why'd you stop…?"

"'Cuz I wanna see *you* do it." Katsuki said, looking him over. "You ever touch yourself, Deku?"

Izuku tensed, some of that initial embarrassment rushing back to him. He averted his eyes and shook his head quickly. He could've sworn he felt Katsuki's cock swell up bit more after that, but he couldn't be sure.

"Well… guess that just means we'll *both* be learning what you like." He rasped. "C'mon baby, start off slow. Roll those hips against me. Whatever feels right."

Izuku shivered as Katsuki's words washed over him, nodding and squeezing his eyes shut. He leaned forward on his hands, doing as he said and rolling his hips down against him. A whimper managed to slip out, and he felt Katsuki's cock twitch in his sweats.

When he finally worked up the nerve to open his eyes, he glanced up at Katsuki and found him staring back intently, his lips wet and parted, his eyes dark, roaming up and down his frame as he watched Izuku stumble through the process of learning his own body in real time.

He eventually settled into a rhythm of sorts, leaning forward on his hands as he moved his hips languidly against Katsuki's. His eyes locked on the point where they met, where Izuku's pants were beginning to feel a bit damp as he rubbed his cock against Katsuki's. Where Katsuki's cock was hot and hard and pulsating in his sweats, long, thick, heavy against his body. When he finally met his eyes again, Katsuki smirked, arching his hips up into him.

"Mm, that's right." He purred. "That feel good, Deku?"

Izuku couldn't find it in himself to form words, so instead, he just nodded, ducking his head and blushing.

"Good," he licked his lips, spreading his legs a bit more. "Just keep rubbin' yourself up on my cock. That's it. Doin' so good, *angel."*

"Hahh—"

"—Oh? You like when I call you *angel,* huh?" He grinned, putting one hand on his hip—not directing him, just following Izuku's movements wherever they led. Katsuki's other hand slid down his body, grabbing the tip of his own cock through his pants, rubbing a bit before he released it. Izuku felt him throbbing against him.

"Ahh, Kacchan," he choked out. "F-Feels…"

"You close?"

Izuku wasn't really sure what he meant, so he just wrinkled his brow, and doubled his efforts.

"Fuck." He hissed, finally grabbing his ass with both hands again, pulling him harshly down into him, so fast Izuku fell forward, forearms flat against Katsuki's torso as he whimpered and moaned helplessly. "Look so fuckin' hot like this, *angel."* He said it like it was a dirty word. Izuku felt Katsuki's voice vibrating deep in his chest, felt his body shaking with it.

"Better be fuckin' ready, nerd, 'cuz when you get back, *I ain't holdin' back on you."*

The heat in Izuku's stomach began to build, and every word out of Katsuki's mouth added fuel to the fire. He gripped his shirt tight, holding on for dear life when Katsuki suddenly lurched forward, sitting up until Izuku could feel his hot breath wafting against his ear.

"Bet I could fuck you 'til you forgot what you are. How's that sound?"

Izuku couldn't take it anymore. He felt the tension rising, like wind-up toy reaching its limit. Something was coming, and he wasn't really sure what to call it, but at that moment, he

wanted it more than anything else.

“Shit,” Katsuki rasped. “Can’t fucking wait to watch you Fall on my cock, *angel.”* He emphasized the word with a hard buck upward, and that was all Izuku could take.

His body tensed, thighs trembling and straining to spread further as the warm feeling inside him burst, spreading throughout his entire body. His wings stretched outward involuntarily. “Kacchan—!“ he borderline sobbed, his dick twitching in his pants, spilling into the fabric, leaving behind a wet stain as evidence. Izuku was floating, every inch of his body tingling.

The sight of it seemed to set Katsuki off. Izuku felt his claws digging into his ass harder as he snarled, and he watched hazily as Katsuki’s horns seemed to extend, his hands growing just a little bit larger as he thrusted up against him. Then he groaned, thick cock pulsating in his sweats. He continued to pull him back and forth against him as he came, soaking through the material a little more with every harsh grind. Izuku was so entranced, he didn’t even care that the oversensitivity was starting to hurt.

In the aftermath, they were both left panting. It took Izuku a while to even become aware of his surroundings again.

“Hey.”

Izuku jumped, opening his eyes. Katsuki was back to his normal, half-shifted form, and when he met his eyes, he felt a residual tremble run through his frame.

“You okay?”

“I, uhh…” Izuku blinked a few times. “Y-Yeah, just, umm…” He winced. “Sticky?”

“Yeah, no shit.” Katsuki snorted. “I meant more like, y’know. In your head.”

“Oh! Uhh…” Izuku thought about it, scanning his emotions. There was definitely some guilt mixed in there, some fear and embarrassment. He wasn’t really sure how to feel or act now that it was over. *But on the whole*... “I…” He bit his lip. “I don’t think I’m… *that* much more conflicted than I’m used to being with you…?”

“Well, I guess that’s good.” Katsuki smiled. “Wasn’t really sure what to expect there. Like, would you be fine? Would you have a breakdown before the cum in your pants even finished cooling? Felt like it could go either way.”

“Yeah, I uhhh… might get back to you on that once it starts feeling… real?”

Katsuki snorted. “So after it cools, then?” He raised an eyebrow. “‘Cuz at that point, shit’s kinda *too* real.”

Izuku laughed awkwardly. “Yeah, I… *would* like to get cleaned up sooner rather than later.”

Katsuki hummed. “We could take a shower together.” He suggested, pitch dropping lower.

Izuku blushed, dropping his forehead against Katsuki's shoulder. "One thing at a time, Kacchan."

It came up around an hour later, as he was lying in bed with Triplet snuggled up against him, purring softly as he stroked her silky, black fur. Katsuki was sitting beside him, holding a touchpad, presumably voting on something. After a few minutes, he set it aside with a sigh.

"It's midnight." He said. "Should probably go to sleep soon, so you'll be rested."

Izuku nodded slowly. He wasn't sure why exactly, but at that moment, he suddenly remembered Katsuki's words from earlier, at the sea of stars.

'If I didn't know better, a line like that would make me think you're in love with me.'

He never did get a chance to ask.

Izuku bit his lip, and cleared his throat. "Um… c-can I ask you a question…?"

He blinked. "Sure."

"How, umm… How would I know…?" Izuku hesitated, falling silent for perhaps a moment too long. He was staring at Triplet, mostly to avoid looking at Katsuki. But then he heard that telltale intake of breath that always preceded speech, and it spurred him to continue. "I-I mean, if I was, you know… in love."

His shoulders drew up as he curled into himself reflexively. When he finally gathered the nerve to look up at Katsuki, he found him staring back. From the look on his face, it seemed he'd genuinely caught him off guard.

After a minute, Katsuki sighed, shifting onto his side to rub and scratch Triplet's head. He made a sound, somewhere between a huff and a laugh.

"You're askin' the wrong guy, nerd." He eventually said. "I'm not that good at, like… describin' feelings and shit."

Izuku hummed, and fell silent. The unease persisted inside of him, unresolved. Eventually, Katsuki spoke again.

"But honestly… who cares?"

Izuku looked up at him. "Sorry?"

"No, just…" He shrugged. "Who cares what you call it, y'know? Personally, if it feels right, I think that's enough."

For a moment, neither of them said anything. Then, Izuku exhaled.

"I… guess so." He mumbled.

“I mean,” Katsuki said. “For me, personally, I just try to act in ways that line up with how I feel. Y’know, actions speak louder, and all that crap.” He muttered. “It’s easier for me to just *show* people how I feel. That’s kinda what today was about.”

He nodded, chewing his lip. Then he froze.

“Wait, so then…” Izuku’s eyes widened. “You mean to tell me that whole trip was like… a confession?”

Katsuki flushed, averting his eyes, rubbing the back of his neck sheepishly. “I-I mean, when you put it like that, I fuckin’ *guess… so…?”*

“So you…” Izuku gulped. “… *Love*… me?”

Katsuki didn’t say anything. He just gave him a look, subtle but meaningful, before he went back to petting Triplet.

Izuku cleared his throat awkwardly. “And how long have you felt this way…?”

He scoffed.

“I dunno, Deku. I can’t like, identify a specific point a where one second I didn’t and the next second I did.” He shrugged again. “Falling for someone is a *process,* not an *event.”*

“I-I see.” Izuku said, his voice small, and his cheeks hot. “Sorry, I’m just trying to, um… B-Because I’ve never… really had to…” he stammered. “You know, I just don’t know how to, uhhh, classify these sorts of things, or—“

“Then don’t.” Katsuki said, soft but firm. When Izuku worked up the nerve to look at him again, he found Katsuki staring right back at him. “Like I said, in the end… it doesn’t really matter what you call it. Don’t get yourself all fucked up over it, alright?”

Izuku relaxed a bit, nodding his head.

“Good.” Katsuki said. Then he glanced down at Triplet again. “Oh, and just so you know, you’re about one and a half belly rubs away from getting bit.”

“What are you—*ow!”*

The next morning found Izuku sitting at a round table in a room with Katsuki, Aizawa, and a pink-haired woman he’d never met before.

“Midoriya, this is Hatsume.” Aizawa said, gesturing toward her. “She’s an engineer from the MagiTech workers syndicate.”

“Ah! Nice to meet you.” Holding his barrier, he extended his hand toward her, and winced at the bone-crushing handshake he received.

“Wow, a real live Angel!” She shook his hand up and down so vigorously, his whole body moved with it. “I’ve always been so fascinated by you guys! Hey, maybe if you’re free after this, we could meet up and I could run some experiments on—“

Katsuki severed the handshake with a firm hand chop. *“No experiments on Deku.”*

Hatsume winced as she retracted her hand. “Possessive, huh?”

Katsuki simply narrowed his eyes.

“Anyway,” Aizawa began, already sounding exhausted, “I’ve brought her in because she was one of the main engineers behind this.” He slid something across the table, and when he lifted his hand, Izuku saw a small, metal object. It looked a bit like a pill capsule, but had a button on the side and what looked like a tiny LED on top.

“What is this?”

“It’s called a gravity seed.” Hatsume said.

“Okay…?” Izuku frowned. “What does it do?”

“The main reason Demons can’t enter Heaven is because of its gravitational lock.” Aizawa explained. “The whole place is essentially built to reject Demon souls, to the point where just setting foot in Heaven causes the ground to immediately collapse.”

“And this… counteracts that, somehow?”

Hatsume nodded. “It’s a major breakthrough! You see, up until recently we couldn’t figure out what—“

“—Hatsume, we talked about this.” Aizawa interjected, throwing her a look. She rubbed the back of her neck sheepishly, and averted her eyes.

After a second, Aizawa set his sights back on Izuku. “Sorry,” he told him. “We’d like to tell you how it works, but we want to avoid revealing too much information, just in case.”

Just in case things go wrong, Izuku’s mind supplied. *Just in case I get caught.*

“But you won’t withhold any info that could put him in danger.” Katsuki said, as a statement of fact rather than a question.

“Obviously not.” Aizawa rolled his eyes.

“Um, so… what do I do with these, exactly?” Izuku asked.

Hatsume pulled one out of her pocket and leaned over to show him. “See this button here?” Izuku nodded. “Just push it, twist the capsule, and that’s it.” She demonstrated, and the LED at the top began to glow red.

Izuku nodded. “Okay. So… should I hide them in the ground, or close to it, or…?”

“Hiding them in or near the ground is preferable, but not required.” She said. “It’ll latch onto just about anything, as long as it hasn’t been blessed. They’re also waterproof.”

“And how many do I need to plant?”

“Ideally, three, but it’s possible to make do with one.” With a grimace, she continued, “There’s… one other thing, though.”

“Um, what’s that?”

“The efficacy is dependent on how far away the seeds are.” She explained. “You can think of it like a tripod. The further the legs are from each other, the more stable it is.”

Izuku’s palms started to feel sweaty, and he wiped them on the bottom of his cloak as he asked, “H-How far are we talking, exactly?”

“Well… if you think of the first circle of Heaven as being like a clock, then ideally, you’d place the three gravity locks at twelve, four and eight o’clock, respectively.”

Izuku gulped, gripping the fabric of his cloak. And suddenly, Katsuki’s gloved hand was covering his.

“Deku,” He said. “You don’t need to go that far.”

Izuku took a deep breath and nodded slowly, his grip relaxing a bit.

“Maybe now’s a good time to talk about safety measures.” Aizawa said, standing up. He went and grabbed a box off the shelf, and then slid it across the table to Izuku. “Here.”

Izuku opened the box to find a thick, silver chain, with a translucent pendant.

Is this…?

“It’s an artifice.” Aizawa said. “A more powerful kind.”

“Ohh. So that’s what I was sensing over there.” Katsuki snorted. “Christ, Aizawa. Feels like there’s an entire fuckin’ soul crammed into this thing.”

“…What does it do?”

“Why don’t you put it on and find out?” Aizawa suggested.

Izuku hesitated for a moment, and then shrugged, leaning forward to hook it around his neck. He looked around and saw Katsuki staring at him with wide eyes. “Uhh, how do I look…?”

“You don’t.” Katsuki said, cracking a grin.

“Excuse me?”

“You’re fucking invisible.” Katsuki said, his grin growing even more. “Holy shit, Aizawa.”

Katsuki waved his hand in the air until it smacked right up against the side of Izuku's head. "Ah—Hey!"

"Still solid, though." Katsuki noted.

Izuku glared at him, before remembering that he was literally invisible. He sighed and took the artifice off, placing it back in the box as he looked up at Aizawa. "Um. Thank you."

"You still need to be careful, though." Aizawa told him. "I think it's safe to assume this won't work on an Acolyte. Stay aware of your surroundings. If you see one, get away before they can get too close." He lowered his voice slightly. "We still don't know much about them, but I think it's safe to assume that if you're close enough to feel their presence, they're close enough to feel yours. If that happens, drop everything and focus on getting out as fast as possible. Even if we're wrong, it just isn't worth the risk."

Izuku nodded solemnly, a chill running down his spine at the mere thought of it.

"Any questions?"

Izuku chewed his lip, thinking for a moment. When he couldn't come up with anything, he shook his head.

"Well, I have one for you." Katsuki chimed in. Izuku looked up, and was met with a grave expression. "Are you *really* sure about this?"

Izuku hesitated. "What? I-I mean, of course."

"No, I'm serious, Deku." Katsuki said, leaning a bit closer. "I would hope you don't need me to tell you this, but this ain't a trivial fuckin' task. This is a dangerous mission."

Izuku smiled nervously. "It's just a walk through heaven, Kacchan." He said, though the words left a bitter taste on his tongue. "It's… not that different from what I normally do."

"It *is* different, Deku. You know that." He sighed. "You're a fucking fugitive now. If this goes wrong, you could get killed, or worse."

Izuku didn't respond. He just stared down at his lap, wringing his wrists.

"Honestly," Katsuki continued, "I don't think you should even *try* to plant all of them. Put one down at soon as you set foot in there, and then get the fuck out."

"That'd make invading much more physically demanding." Hatsume noted.

"Speaking as one of the Demons *doing* the actual invading, I don't care." Katsuki told her. "We'll make it work. We can plant more during the actual invasion."

"It's not that easy, unfortunately." She shook her head. "The gravity seeds require at least thirty-six hours to become effective."

"What the fuck? *Why?"*

“Any faster than that, and we run the risk of them being rejected entirely, according to our models.” She shrugged. “Believe me, I know it’s not ideal, but this is the only method we’ve come up with that doesn’t require shutting down the entire gravitational lock system.”

Katsuki glared at her for a while, and then sighed heavily. *“Fuck.”*

After a moment, Aizawa spoke up.

“If Midoriya were to get caught, would the seeds be easy for them to disable?” He then asked.

“No. That would be difficult, unless they were able to find them within a relatively short period of time.” She explained. “So, at least if he were to get caught, you’d still be able to rescue him.”

“Yeah, in *thirty-six hours.”* Katsuki scoffed.

Aizawa sighed, rubbing his temples. “Well, regardless, I’m leaning toward Bakugou’s perspective, here. We shouldn’t take unnecessary risks.”

“Fucking *thank* you—“

“—That said,” he interjected. “If the opportunity to plant more arises, I won’t say you shouldn’t take it.”

Izuku nodded, chewing his lip.

After a second, Katsuki exhaled sharply. “Well, my recommendation stays the same. Get in and get out.”

Aizawa shrugged. “I suppose that’s just a judgement call you’ll have to make yourself, then.”

The trip to Earth was a quiet affair, for the most part. Izuku couldn’t really find it in himself to hold a conversation, given how anxious he was. Part of him wanted to run away, and another part just wanted to get it over with.

But before he could even think about entering Heaven, he first needed to wash off the *‘aura of Hell,’* as Aizawa had called it.

The hot spring was tucked away in a mountainside resort, where the trees were thick and the water bluer than the sky. A small waterfall fed into a gently-steaming pool, and the altitude counteracted the summertime enough to leave the air cool.

Izuku toed off his shoes, setting them aside before coming to stand before the hot spring, fidgeting with the hem of his cloak.

“Well, go on then.” Katsuki said, standing just a few feet behind him. “Undress.”

Izuku flushed. “Um…” He turned to look at him. “C-Could you maybe turn around, please?”

He released a long, dramatic sigh, as though the thought of doing so physically pained him. Still, he did as he asked, and turned around.

Izuku made quick work of his clothes, haphazardly folding them up on a nearby boulder before stepping into the water. It was hot, and he probably would've liked to ease into it a bit slower, but the fact that Katsuki was waiting on him spurred him to move faster. Izuku winced slightly as he quickly got in to hip-height, and then slowly waded deeper into the water.

"Okay!" He called. Katsuki turned around, and went to sit on a large rock near the edge.

As seconds ticked by and the initial shock of the heat wore off, Izuku sighed as he felt some of the tension ease from his muscles. He sunk down until his chin touched the water, stretched his arms and wings out. After a moment, he dunked his head under, letting the warm, spring water flow through his hair. He came up for air, and brushed his wet hair back.

But all the while, he felt Katsuki's eyes on him. Izuku glanced at him nervously a few times, at the way he sat there on the boulder, his legs spread, one elbow propped up on his knee and his chin resting in his palm. Katsuki's eyes followed his movements with a subtle heat that had Izuku flushing, crouching down until the water reached his nose.

"H-How long did he say I should stay in?"

"At least fifteen minutes." Katsuki drawled. *"Minimum."*

Izuku sighed. It'd been less than five minutes, and he was already starting to squirm under Katsuki's attention. He turned his back on him, and tried to focus on the pleasant warmth of the spring.

A few minutes went by, and then suddenly, Izuku felt the water behind him shift.

"Hey."

"Ah!" Izuku tensed, spinning around to find Katsuki standing right there with him, grinning. Undressed. *Naked.* "K-Kacchan!"

Katsuki laughed lowly, crowding him against the side of the hot spring.

"I-I don't think we should do anything in here! It might not work if we do!"

"What do you mean by *'do anything'?"* Katsuki teased. "What are you thinkin' of doing, huh?"

Izuku gave him a tired look. "Kacchan, you're naked." He said. "You know exactly what I was thinking. In fact, I'm willing to bet that making me think that was part of your motivation for getting in here in the first place."

Katsuki stared at him for a moment, and then grinned, rolling his eyes. "Yeah, okay. You got me."

“Unbelievable.”

Katsuki laughed. “Sorry, nerd.” He shrugged. “You’re just too fun to tease.”

Izuku sighed, shaking his head.

For a minute, it was quiet.

“Really, though.” Katsuki said, his expression suddenly much more serious. “It’s not too late to back out of this, Deku.”

Izuku stared at him for a moment, and then started to laugh a bit, under his breath. Katsuki’s brow furrowed.

“Kacchan…” He mumbled. “You know I can’t just back out of this.”

Katsuki frowned. “The hell? Of *course* you can.”

“And what?” He interjected, his brow wrinkling. “Just leave him there? Just let All Might *die?”*

“Deku,” Katsuki took a few steps toward him. “You *know* this ain’t the only option.”

“It’s the fastest one, though.” Izuku said. “And I’m partly responsible for him being there.”

“What the *fuck* are you talking about?”

Izuku shrugged, gazing down at the water. “If I hadn’t pressured him to teach me things he wasn’t supposed to, he might not be there right now.”

“Yeah. Key word being *might,* Deku, ‘cuz *you don’t know that.”* He scoffed. “And he’s a fucking adult. If he didn’t want to teach you something, he could’ve just said no.”

“Well, what other choice did he have? He had to teach me those things once I started working with you!”

“And who’s fucking *idea* was it to work with me, *huh?”* Katsuki shot back. “Deku, don’t be fucking stupid. We both know your mentor’s been in some shit for a *while.”*

Izuku opened his mouth to retort, but the words never came. He sunk down until his chin touched the surface, and stared vacantly at the water.

Katsuki sighed.

“Look, I get it, okay?” He muttered. “I know what it’s like to have survivor’s guilt, or whatever. But you gotta find a way to shut that voice up, ‘cuz it ain’t gonna do you any good.”

Izuku sunk down to his nose, and for a minute, Katsuki was silent.

“Is that really all this is about?” He eventually asked. Izuku didn’t move. “Deku…?”

The image of the town came to mind, bleached white and devoid of life. Izuku closed his eyes, then stood up again.

He whispered, "…What would it say about me if I backed out now?"

Katsuki's brow furrowed. "The hell d'you mean?"

"I mean," He took a deep breath. "If I refused to help, even after seeing that… *place."*

Katsuki's eyes widened as he stood there, staring at him. Then, he cursed under his breath, turning his back on him as he slid his hands into his hair, gripping it harshly by the roots.

"K-Kacchan?"

"I fucking *knew* I shouldn't have shown you that shit. *Fuck."*

"No, I'm grateful you did!" Izuku said. "Kacchan, I need to make this right, I'm partially re—"

"Stop!" He shouted, turning around sharply. "Just fucking *stop!* Deku, don't you *dare* try to put that shit on your shoulders. You're not fucking responsible for the crimes of the regime you live under. You're a fucking *victim* of it, just like we are."

For a minute, Izuku couldn't even look at him, much less formulate a response.

"Okay, y'know what? Fuck this. We're callin' it off."

"What?!" Izuku paled. "No, please!"

"M'not gonna let you risk your fucking *life* over some fucking misplaced guilt!"

"Kacchan, wait!" He cried. "I'm sorry!"

Katsuki threw him an incredulous look. "I don't *want* you to be fucking sorry!"

"Well, how am I supposed to feel when I see something like that?!"

"Angry, Deku! You're supposed to be fucking angry, because anger is *productive!"*

He faltered, his brows pinching together.

"W-Well, I'm still *doing* it, aren't I?" He then said. "If it gets the same result, I don't see why—!"

Katsuki took a step closer, planting his hands on either side of the ledge behind him, boxing him in.

"It is *not* the fucking same, Deku." He snapped, his volume lower, but his tone even more resolute. "When you're pissed off about injustice, you become a rebel. When you feel guilty about it, you become a fucking *martyr."*

Izuku froze for a moment, speechless. For a very long time, neither of them spoke. Katsuki just stood there, staring him down. Eventually, he backed away, moving over to the far end of the hot spring, his back turned. After a moment, Izuku followed him there. Holding his barrier, he placed his hand on his back.

"…I'm sorry, Kacchan."

"I *just* told you—"

"—No, listen. *Please."*

When Katsuki didn't say anything else, he took that to mean he was listening.

"I think…" Izuku began, his voice so very small. "I think sometimes I have a hard time with stuff like this. I'm just… so used to shame and guilt that I sometimes just sort of… default to it."

Katsuki sighed, and turned around, grabbing the hand that had been on his back. "You can't do that for shit like this, Deku. It's too fuckin' dangerous."

"I know. I *know* it is." He swallowed. "But… please. I *have* to do this. I don't want to waste any time. This is too important."

For a very long time, Katsuki just gazed down at him, his eyes searching. Then, seemingly out of nowhere, he asked: "If you had to choose between saving yourself and saving All Might, who would you choose?"

Izuku's breath caught in his throat, eyes widening. He stared at Katsuki for a moment, and then looked away.

"That's what I thought." Katsuki said, with a bitter smile.

"Kacchan, you can't just ask me to choose between my life and the life of someone I care about."

He snorted. "Okay, what about someone you *don't* care about?" Katsuki shot back. "Remember the second time we met, when you were ready to fucking *die* just to stop me from taking those two girls to Hell?"

"They were *kids!"* Izuku said. "Kacchan, this isn't fair, you can't just—"

"—I *can,* actually." He interrupted. "Deku, I need you to have a basic sense of fucking self-preservation."

"Why are you so—!"

"—Because I fucking *love* you, you piece of shit!"

Izuku froze, his mouth still open. After what felt like an eternity, Izuku said, "Kacchan, I lo—*ow!"*

Katsuki flicked his forehead.

“Don’t say it back, asshole.” He grumbled. “Not *now.”*

His mouth moved, but no sound came out. He sunk down in the water again, up to his chin.

“Here, how about this.” Katsuki sighed. “You take *exactly one* gravity seed with you, plant it the first place you can, and come right the fuck back. And then, if you really mean what you were about to say just now, then you can say it.”

Izuku stared up at him for several seconds. “Kacchan, that’s—“

”—Those are the terms.” He said. “Take it or leave it.”

Izuku hesitated, but eventually he gave in, shoulders slumping. “…Fine.”

“Okay?”

“Okay.”

They got out a few minutes later, and dressed themselves in silence.

Izuku stared at the single gravity seed in his hand, and curled his fingers tightly around it.

“I guess I’ll be off, then.”

“Wait.” Katsuki said, stepping toward him. He gave Izuku a look as he closed in, one that Izuku had learned to recognize without words. It said, *‘I’m about to touch you, so get ready.’*

He felt a finger beneath his chin first, tilting his head up slightly before Katsuki leaned down and kissed him. It was a slow kiss, a sweet one. It brought Izuku’s senses to life without making him feel like he was about to implode. The kind of kiss you could build a life around.

When Katsuki pulled away, the look in his eye was soft in a way Izuku couldn’t recall seeing before. His palms cupped his cheeks as he leaned in close, resting his forehead against Izuku’s.

“You’ll come back to me, Izuku.” He murmured, as though he could speak it into reality. “You *will.* You hear me?”

Izuku was so startled by the naked vulnerability in his voice, it took him a moment to respond.

He gulped.

“Of course, Kacchan.” He whispered, fingers wrapping around Katsuki’s wrists.

They stayed that way for a moment, looking into each other’s eyes. When they eventually parted and said their goodbyes, Izuku breathed a sigh of relief upon taking flight.

He thought for sure Katsuki would find out, but apparently not. He was in the clear, now—with one gravity seed stowed away in his pocket…

…and the other three hidden safely in his mouth.

Izuku arrived at the station with the invisibility artifice around his neck, and the gravity seeds pressing into his cheeks.

He looked around the corner nervously, making sure that no Acolytes were around before he quietly ran to the platform, boarding the shuttle along with a couple other people.

Whether or not invisibility would be enough to get him through to the inner circles was unknown, but it didn't seem likely. Even if it was, testing it wasn't worth the risk. Izuku needed to keep his head down, stay silent.

The shuttle arrived at an entry point at the first circle, and Izuku quickly ducked into a nearby alley. There, he scanned his surroundings once again before he took out the first gravity seed—the one he'd kept in his pocket—and dropped to a squat beside a trashcan. He pressed the button on the side and twisted it. A brief flash of light confirmed that the device was active, and he quickly set it down behind the trashcan, out of sight.

Izuku stood up again, brushing off his clothes. He paused for moment to look around again, and as he stood there, Katsuki's words echoed in his mind.

Get in and get out.

He bit his lip, felt the other three gravity seeds inside his mouth as he flattened himself against the wall, his heart pounding.

Izuku knew he should quit while he was ahead. He peered around the corner, watched as a couple of Angels stood waiting for the outbound shuttle. It arrived a minute later, the doors opening, letting a few people out before the others began to board. He shifted back and forth between his feet, looking around nervously.

Just go. Just get on the damn shuttle! He could almost hear Katsuki shouting.

But he was already here. He had three more seeds.

And he knew he could do *so much more.*

With a shuddering breath, Izuku backed into the alley again, checking his surroundings once more as he considered his options. They'd warned him not to go anywhere they might expect him to go, which naturally ruled out the campus and dorms. The library seemed like a safe bet, and it usually wasn't too busy this time of day. Taking a deep breath, he poked his head out and looked both ways before he set off toward it.

Despite the artifice, he was still careful to stick to low-traffic areas, keeping quiet and moving through the shadows whenever possible. He passed a couple of people, but no one ever

looked at him. With a bit more confidence, he entered the building behind another Angel, and immediately ducked to the right.

He headed toward the end of the library, into the parts which technically penetrated into the inner circles, and backed himself into the corner there. He stopped to look around yet again before he took out another gravity seed. He wiped it off on his clothes, then activated it and slid it behind the bookshelf there. Already, he felt more accomplished.

Just one more, he thought. *I know I can do just one more.*

A fair distance from the library, there was a park located near an exit point. It wasn't technically on the campus grounds, but it was close.

It's an open area, though, he reasoned. *I'd be able to spot any Acolytes way before they were close enough to sense me.*

Nodding to himself, Izuku quickly exited the library, and set off for the park next. He once again kept to back alleys and side streets, and his trek went undisturbed.

Once he reached the park, Izuku found a soft spot in the ground beside a tree, activated the third gravity seed and quite literally planted it in the ground.

He stood up slowly, his back pressed against the tree as he looked around. There were a few people out walking, but no one Izuku knew. He briefly wondered if he should try to plant the extra gravity seed somewhere. The hospital was a fair distance away.

That'd be a good place…

Izuku shook his head. The hospital was definitely out of the question. If there was one place outside of the innermost circle that he could expect to encounter an Acolyte, it would be there.

He sighed, and ultimately decided to just leave.

The closest platform was nearby, but he'd get there even quicker if he cut a bit close to campus. He knew, at least rationally, that it was risky, but it was also a path he knew well, and he could easily see his surroundings. Izuku shut out his lingering anxiety and set off in that direction, making his way up the grassy hill at the other end of the park, which separated it from the residential neighborhood beyond.

It was quiet. It had been ever since he'd arrived. It was a little unnerving, but when he actually thought about it, it wasn't that weird, given the time. It was around eleven in the morning; most people were either in class or working, which naturally meant that most of the streets would be empty.

He wasn't planning on passing All Might's house. He'd been planning on altering his route slightly to avoid it, but when he reached the corner, he stopped, looking around cautiously. His eyes fixated on the turn. Just a few more steps and he'd be able to see it.

He wondered if the light in the study would still be on, and swallowed. Just a peak, he decided, quietly inching toward it. One last look, and then I'm gone.

He carefully poked his head around the corner, and then froze.

There was a second that went by which seemed to stretch on for an eternity, during which all he could do was stand there, paralyzed as he stared at it.

All Might's house was on fire. He could smell the smoke from where he stood, watching the angry, red flames swallow the structure.

"What…?" He said, barely a whisper. *"Why?"*

It's a trap, his instincts told him. *They're trying to lure you in. Don't fall for it!*

Izuku nodded to himself, swallowing roughly.

I need to get away. They're probably waiting just behind the fence, ready to ambush me, as soon as I'm close enough for them to sense. He started backing away, stumbling slightly. *I just need to—*

He took one more step back, and froze once again.

The house was no longer burning.

It stopped, the moment he'd gotten a certain distance away. Like he was out of range for the illusion.

Which means…

All the blood drained from his face as the cold realization washed over him.

Which means I've already gotten too close.

Izuku bolted. He went straight for the nearby forest he'd been planning to cut through anyway, and did not look back. He couldn't even hear his own footsteps. Only the blood rushing in his ears as the trees blurred past him.

He emerged at the nearby creek, just a minute away from the closest platform. He was making a beeline for the bridge, when a flash of what looked like white and gold in his periphery spurred him to duck underneath it and hide, instead. He sat there in the shadows, heart pounding in his ears as he carefully peeked in that direction, but all he saw was brown and green.

Maybe it was just my imagination, but what if it wasn't? What will I do if they get closer, and —

"Midoriya." A voice said.

A *familiar* voice.

It was like he'd been doused with a bucket of ice water. He remained still for a second before the shaking started. Slowly, he turned around.

And there he was.

All Might.

There was a large bandage wrapped around one of his eyes. His feet were bare, his body thin —even thinner than he had been before, if that were even possible—and he was kneeling on the jagged, rocky ground beneath the bridge. The subtle sound of a chain clinking alerted him to the fact that his wrists were shackled, and Izuku's heart lurched when he noted that the handcuffs were stained with blood, his wrists bruised and discolored.

His wings looked different, too, and Izuku realized, with shock and horror, that they'd been clipped.

"Help me!" He called out weakly. "Please!"

Izuku felt a bead of cold sweat roll down his neck. There was a metallic taste on his tongue, and somehow he knew that the gravity seed was not to blame. His vision wavered as nausea churned his stomach so hard, he almost fell over.

Because this is a trap, he realized. *It has to be a trap. It's too convenient not to be.*

And if there was any doubt left in his mind that the Council was capable of unrepentant cruelty, it died at that moment, when he looked at All Might and felt something inside of him break.

The look of pain on his face was far too visceral to ignore, especially when he turned around, and showed Izuku the massive wound in his shoulder.

"All… Might…?" He choked on the words.

"Please, Midoriya. I don't have much time before the soul bleed starts again, and I can't—" His wrists pulled against the handcuffs in vain.

Izuku knew what he was asking.

He knew it was a trap.

But he also knew it didn't matter, anymore. It was too late for him to escape.

Izuku wiped his tears away, and stumbled closer. He reached for the hem of his cloak, intending to tear off a piece of the fabric.

"No, it's alright, just use—" he gestured up toward the white gauze wrapped around his head and eye. "My eye's healed already." Izuku gulped, and nodded. He got down on his knees, rocks scraping up his skin. And as he got closer, he actually felt a glimmer of hope. It really did look just like All Might. Maybe it really *was* him, and they could escape together.

He carefully undid the bandage, unravelling it from around his head. All Might didn't say anything else. All he heard was the sound of water flowing through the creek.

When he finally managed to unravel the bandage completely, All Might leaned forward, giving him access to the wound.

But there *was* no wound, only white fabric.

Izuku wasn't holding white gauze, but rather a length of crimson silk.

And finally, the sob he'd been holding back this whole time broke free.

I'm so stupid.

*I'm so, so **fucking** stupid.*

Izuku wiped his eyes on the red fabric as he sat back.

In that moment, he felt the full weight of the Acolyte's presence come rushing back, as though it had been contained within the illusion. He stared at the water as it flowed through the small stream.

"I think you dropped these." He said, holding his hand out.

Izuku's eyes went wide, and for a moment, the world went silent again. Because there, resting in the Acolytes palms, were the gravity seeds. All three of them, misshapen and destroyed. And suddenly, it hit him.

Oh, I see.

One by one, snow-white finger tips dropped the gravity seeds into the stream.

They knew all along, he realized. *From the moment I landed at the station, they knew.*

Escape was never an option.

And despite the situation, the epiphany wrapped around him like a warm blanket. They'd been following him the entire time, slowly closing in. Making sure he couldn't escape.

Making sure he couldn't be *saved.*

And in a dark way, the realization comforted him. Because at least he knew it wasn't his fault.

They'd played right into their hands. It was always going to end this way.

The creek swept away the last gravity seed, and Izuku's tears dried. As he slowly raised his gaze, Izuku made a decision. A last-ditch move to try and preserve what little he had left.

He swallowed the fourth gravity seed.

It wasn’t active. It couldn’t save him. But at least *he* could save *it.*

And as he looked up at where the Acolytes eyes would have been, Izuku saw only a flash of blinding red light. His muscles tensed up as the paralysis set in, and he collapsed, head smacking painfully against a nearby rock, just above the water in the creek.

His ears were ringing, the world wavering.

Katsuki’s voice echoed in his head.

“You’ll come back to me, Izuku.”

He watched his own blood as it swirled before his eyes, deep red mixing with the murky water of the creek.

“You will. You got that?”

Then, darkness.

Chapter End Notes

just goes to show that no matter what AU u put him in, Deku's still... Deku, I guess

so. lots of shit happened here, huh. ngl, probably my favorite part of writing this was the scenes in the Depths,,, like it was really self-indulgent Lore for the Sake of Lore type shit, but i really enjoyed developing that idea. i was shooting for like a combination of the house from House of Leaves, the abyss in Made in Abyss, and the ocean, because all three of them both fascinate and scare the absolute shit out of me. so yeah

anyway,, um, yes. a few of you may know i've been in a pretty dark place these past few weeks. it's been hard. i hope that didn't affect my writing. and i hope this story sticks with you, or maybe makes you feel something worth thinking or talking about. sometimes i worry that all the world building might take away from the emotional impact of the story, or something. idk, i'm trying my best not to get too down on myself lol

Next chapter's gonna be a bit different, but it'll be cool, and hopefully satisfying to read. I call it "the chekov's gun chapter" in my head because it's the one where like four different things that have been brought up at various times over the course of the story for no obvious reason all suddenly come back and become really fucking important. so yeah. as always, thank you for reading

Chapter 15: Vertigo

Chapter Summary

Katsuki turned around, walked down the aisle between the pews. He ran his fingers over the polished wood, then stopped in front of the altar, just stared at it for a while. It almost seemed to stare back, that heavy feeling sinking deeper into his gut.
Because here he was, alone in a church, waiting for someone who might never come back. By all accounts, one would probably expect him down on his knees, praying for Izuku's safe return. The sickening part was that, for a moment, he almost considered it.

Chapter Notes

Spotify playlist
Content warnings for this chapter:
GRAPHIC violence, minor character death, more eldritch forest fuckery, and there's a scene where someone vomits. pls enjoy this 14.2k rollercoaster

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was silent in the church.

It'd been ten hours since Izuku left.

Ten.

For a mission that had been expected to take two hours at most—even less, if Izuku only planted one gravity seed.

...But of course that *didn't fucking happen.*

Katsuki dug his claws into his arms as he stood there, back turned toward the others. It hadn't taken long for him to realize the other three seeds were missing, but by then, it was already too late.

And he knew he should've seen it coming from a mile away. He *knew.* But damn it, he just… *hoped.*

He hoped that Izuku wouldn't go that far. That he'd keep his promise.

I should've never taken him there.

I should've never—

Someone cleared their throat. Kirishima.

Katsuki tensed. *"What."*

"Oh, it's… um."

"Spit it out."

"Right." Kirishima said. "We just heard from Hatsume."

Katsuki immediately turned around. "Should've opened with that." He muttered. "What'd she say?"

Kirishima coughed, and seemed to be avoiding eye contact.

"What the *fuck* did she say?" He repeated, gritting his teeth.

"There's no signal." He blurted out. "It… none of the seeds are active, Bakugou. She can't detect any of them."

For a very long time, Katsuki didn't respond. He just stared at Kirishima, his jaw clenched. Fighting the urge to lash out, to allow his mind to take that knowledge and follow it where it naturally led.

He took a few deep breaths. Kirishima remained rooted in place, and did not move a muscle.

After a moment, Katsuki closed his eyes. "Is there *any way* to activate them remotely?" He waited. When Kirishima didn't respond immediately, he opened his eyes. "Just fucking tell me. I don't need you to *coddle* me, asshole."

Kirishima swallowed audibly. "No." He replied. "We… asked about that already. It's not possible."

Katsuki took a sharp breath, and turned around again. For a very long time, no one spoke. It was dark outside. Inside, too.

Through the window, Katsuki watched as thick columns of smoke grew from the horizon, obscuring the stars.

"Uh," Kaminari eventually said. "It's… getting pretty late, man. Maybe we should… call it a night…?"

Katsuki shrugged. "Do whatever you want."

"Wait, you mean you're staying?"

He scoffed. "Obviously."

"Man, you need to sleep." Sero said. "And what about Triplet?"

He shrugged again. “I’ll ask my neighbor to feed her.”

Another moment of silence.

Kirishima put his hand on his shoulder, and he tensed.

“Look, man. I get it, but… at this point? It’s… *really* not looking—“

Katsuki turned around sharply, swatting his hand off his shoulder. “I *know.*” He said, through gritted teeth. “I don’t need you to fucking tell me that. I fucking *know.”*

Kirishima’s eyes widened, darting around nervously. He put his hands up. “L-Look, man. I know how you feel, but—“

“No, you *don’t.”* He snapped. “You have no *fucking* idea what this is like. Don’t fucking pretend you do!”

After a long, tense moment, Kaminari opened his mouth, inhaling as though he were about to speak. Sero gave him a look, shaking his head. Kaminari shut his mouth.

After a while, Sero broke the silence.

“Don’t do anything stupid.” He told him. “And if you get a chance to sleep for a bit, take it.”

Katsuki gave no response. He just turned his back on them again and waited silently, until the presence of their souls dissipated behind him. And then he was alone.

Katsuki turned around, walked down the aisle between the pews. He ran his fingers over the polished wood, then stopped in front of the altar, just stared at it for a while. It almost seemed to stare back, that heavy feeling sinking deeper into his gut.

Because here he was, alone in a church, waiting for someone who might never come back. By all accounts, one would probably expect him down on his knees, praying for Izuku’s safe return. The sickening part was that, for a moment, he almost considered it.

But instead, he sneered, his soul flaring in his chest. Throwing its weight into his fist, he slammed it down on the altar, splitting the wood down the center. The flames caught onto the white fabric, and he watched for a moment as it burned, steadily spreading over the cheap material, leaving behind only soot and ash.

It made him feel a little bit better. Right now, that was enough.

Just for tonight, Katsuki didn’t care about anything else.

Katsuki left the church right as the steeple was beginning to collapse, the whole structure engulfed in flames.

"Rise and shine, nerd.”

Izuku opened his eyes to the sight of Katsuki standing at his bedside, and a warm, rumbling sensation on his chest.

It felt as though he'd just woken up from a coma.

"Kacchan..." He said, shifting in bed. "What's going on…?"

"Well, Triplet likes you, I guess." He then proceeded to pick the cat up, causing her to nip his finger.

"Ow!" Katsuki winced, then clicked his tongue. "I'm gonna *feed* you, jackass." He released the cat, allowing her to leave the room.

"...Your cat's name is Triplet?"

"Yep."

Izuku gulped. "As in…"

"Yep," He repeated. "But if ya haven't unlocked my 'tragic backstory,' I'll usually just say it's 'cuz—"

"—Because she has three eyes?" He finished.

Katsuki froze, seeming surprised at first. Then, he grinned. "You got it, nerd."

Izuku held his breath as his vision went out of focus, Katsuki's eyes flashing brighter as the room seemed to flicker around them. It only lasted a second. Then he was yawning, sitting up in Katsuki's bed.

"What time is it?" He asked.

Ever since he'd woken up, Izuku had been feeling strange. It was that sort of odd anxiety, where you feel as though you've forgotten something important, but you can't even begin to guess what it would be.

It sat at the back of his mind like an itch he couldn't scratch, and though he was able to forget about it from time to time, the quiet moments always brought his mind back.

When they returned from Inasa and Todoroki's apartment that night, Izuku's mind felt hazy. He wasn't sure why he was so tired. He'd only woken up a few hours ago.

Fire tea. I should make fire tea. He thought. *That'll clear my head.*

He set out in search of a kettle, the only sounds coming from the shower in Katsuki's bathroom. When Izuku checked under the stove, he didn't see it at first. But after pushing aside some pots and pans, he eventually was able to find the tea kettle, shoved all the way at the back. He pulled it out and held it in both hands, and his mind went blank as he stood there, just staring down at it for a moment.

He heard the shower turn off, and a minute later, the bathroom door opened.

“Kacchan?” He called out.

“What?” Katsuki called back.

Izuku blinked a few times, slowly realizing he didn’t *know* what.

He didn’t know why he’d called out to him.

“Deku?”

“Sorry! I just, uhh…”

“Hang on a sec.”

Izuku chewed his lip, not quite sure how to tell him it was fine. He was fine. He didn’t need anything, he was just—

“What is it?” Katsuki asked, a few feet behind him. Izuku turned around sharply, and for a second, his mind went blank for an entirely different reason. His face heated up as he took in the sight of him, standing there, red towel slung around his neck, wearing grey sweatpants, and nothing else.

His eyes drifted down his body, from his damp hair and sharp features, to the chiseled muscles of his upper body. His hips. His crotch. Because evidently, Katsuki wasn’t wearing underwear. His eyes remained fixated there for a while, and his blush grew more intense. But it was odd. Somehow, it just… wasn’t really shocking to him.

His gaze slipped down to the floor eventually, and then returned to the tea kettle again.

This is wrong, his gut told him.

But… why?

Izuku swallowed, and then suddenly, Katsuki was directly in front of him, his arms caging him in on either side. When he looked up, his expression was one of concern.

He reached up slowly, giving Izuku time to prepare before he caressed his face gently.

“You doin’ okay, nerd?”

Izuku blinked a few times. “Y-Yeah! Yeah, I am, I was just…” He looked down at the kettle again.

“What?” Katsuki prompted. “Is it not clean, or somethin’?”

“No, no! Nothing like that, I’m not…” He trailed off again, looking off to the side, toward the window. Outside, the city was alive and well. Bright. Vibrant.

Unchanging.

“Do you…” Izuku gulped. “Do you ever get that feeling, like something’s not right, but you just… can’t figure out what?”

When he glanced up, Katsuki’s expression was thoughtful. “Yeah, I guess so.” He replied. “Kinda like when you feel like you left the stove on?”

“Yeah!” Izuku said. “Like that, just…”

“What?”

Izuku bit his lip. “I just can’t think of anything I could’ve possibly forgotten, and it’s… bugging me, I guess.”

“Well, you’re making tea, right?”

Izuku blinked. “Yes…?”

He smirked. “Then obviously, you forgot the kettle.”

Izuku tensed. “Sorry?”

“The kettle.” Katsuki snorted. “Y’know, that thing you use to make tea…?”

Izuku looked down, and his eyesight seemed to flicker.

His hands were empty.

Of course they are. He thought. *I haven’t found it yet.*

Izuku shook his head. “Right! You’re right.” He cleared his throat. “I was, uhh, looking for it. I just couldn’t…”

“The stove, Deku.” Katsuki said, an amused glint in his eye.

“…What?”

He raised an eyebrow. “You’re standing in front of it.”

“Oh…” He muttered. And then it hit him. *“Oh!* Right, sorry!”

He hastily stepped aside.

Izuku fell asleep quickly, that night.

He awoke sometime around three in the morning, startled by the sound of something hitting the wall. When he opened his eyes, he winced as light filled his vision. He squinted as he turned toward the source—the bedside lamp.

He frowned.

I could've sworn I turned that off… He thought, a chill running down his spine.

Cautiously propping himself up on his elbows, Izuku looked around the apartment, searching for any signs of life. It certainly *seemed* like he was alone. "K-Kacchan…?"

No response.

The apartment was dead silent.

Izuku gulped, pulling the blankets closer as he moved to sit up fully. It was only then that he noticed the book sitting on the edge of the bed. He glanced at the title. *Hiro Worship.*

He blinked.

…I was reading that, wasn't I?

Hesitantly, Izuku reached out toward it, brushing his fingers against the smooth cover. In that moment, it felt as though all the fear and paranoia just melted away, and though that odd itch in his mind still remained, it no longer screamed to be scratched.

Izuku opened the book to the last page he could vaguely remember.

Must've fallen asleep, He thought.

The book was a welcome distraction. He forced the unsettled feeling down into the depths of his consciousness, and allowed himself to become immersed in the fantasy once again.

"Was that you last night?" Kirishima asked.

They were standing on the roof of an old schoolhouse, Katsuki's eyes sky bound, as usual. Kirishima didn't say anything else, but he didn't have to. Katsuki already knew what he meant.

"Yeah."

Kirishima sighed.

"Man, you can't just *do* shit like that. Someone could've gotten hurt."

"I didn't let it spread." He scoffed. Then, a bit quieter, "Place was an eyesore, anyway."

A moment of silence.

"…Have you slept?" Kirishima eventually asked. "Like, at all?"

"I dunno, shitty hair." He groused. "Would *you* be sleeping if this happened to Ashido?"

He hesitated, and then took a deep breath. "I… okay, no. Probably not." He said. "But… we're just trying to look out for you. I mean… what if you get attacked? Are you really

gonna risk your life fighting while *sleep-deprived?"*

"M'not so sleep-deprived that I can't take care of a couple shitty, over-confident extras."

Just then, they heard the boom of a distant explosion along with a brief flash of light, characteristic of a level nine Angel's energy attack.

"Could you handle one of *those?"* Kirishima asked. "Because that's what you're likely to encounter, if you stay this high up all the time."

Katsuki didn't respond. Just clenched his jaw, narrowed his eyes as he continued to search the clouds.

Kirishima sighed. "Listen, man. I'm not here to tell you what to do. I just came to give you this." He offered a brown paper bag to Katsuki.

He frowned, eyes darting down at it, then back at Kirishima's face. He raised an eyebrow. "What's that."

"Food."

Katsuki blinked, taking the bag and peering into it, eyes widening a bit. There were enough full meals in there to last him a few days, with some embrites thrown in, too.

"…Thanks," He murmured.

"We're here for you, man." He said, smiling. "If you want me or anyone else to take over so you can sleep for a while, we can—"

"No," Katsuki shook his head. "I… don't think I'd be able to sleep, anyway."

"…Right." Kirishima nodded. "Well, we'll let you know if we see anything."

The next morning, though that bizarre feeling remained, it had shrunk itself down to something small enough for him to comfortably ignore, at first. But as the day progressed, that itch seemed to rear its ugly head more and more frequently.

It was difficult to describe—almost seemed like his senses were taking in information at different rates. Sometimes Katsuki would start speaking, and Izuku would feel as though he were hearing the words faster than his lips could form them. Sometimes he'd ask a question, and then realize he already knew the answer immediately after it left his tongue.

But it wasn't until that night that it truly became unbearable.

Izuku lay on his back, watching as the ceiling fan spun round and round, forming odd shadows in the cool glow of the city lights.

He had tried everything. Drinking fire tea, stretching, even counting *sheep.* But no matter what he did, he just couldn't make himself fall asleep. His mind was racing, and every

moment he felt as though he were just one minor surprise away from full-on fight-or-flight.

It was around three hours after Katsuki had gone to bed when he finally decided to give up, at least for a little while. The springs of the mattress squeaked as he hauled himself out of bed.

He wandered over to the window first, hand pressing against the glass as he gazed out at the city. It really was a gorgeous view, in its own weird way.

But there was just something… *off* about it. It felt static, canned—more like a convincing backdrop than an actual place. Izuku was too mentally drained to try and make sense of the feeling, however, and eventually, he tore his eyes away.

He found himself in the kitchen next, running his fingertips along the countertop, eyes drifting around the room vacantly.

Out of idle curiosity, he reached out toward the fridge, grabbing the handle and pulling it open.

His brow furrowed upon realizing that it was empty.

Wait… that doesn't…

Izuku blinked.

The insides of his eyelids flickered like TV static.

He was standing at the center of the room, his head faintly throbbing.

Out of idle curiosity, he approached the fridge and grabbed the handle, pulling it open.

There were a number of things inside of it, none of which looked particularly strange or unexpected. Without looking too closely, the contents of Katsuki's fridge seemed remarkably normal.

For some reason, the thought of actually looking closer sparked some primal fear response inside of him, his heart lurching in his chest. He hastily closed the fridge door and headed over to the sink, turning it on and splashing his face with cold water.

What is wrong with me?

Izuku took a few deep breaths, and left the kitchen.

He wound up in front of Katsuki's bedroom door, somehow, and for a while he just kind of stood there, staring at the doorknob, his clammy hand hovering just above it. He wasn't sure where the urge to go in there was coming from, and what exactly was preventing him from doing so was somehow even more confusing. After a minute, his hand fell limp at his side.

He looked at the clock. It was around one in the morning.

If I don't get to sleep soon, I won't be rested enough for whatever Kacchan has planned…

He closed his eyes and racked his brain for a solution.

Back in Heaven, Izuku used to go on walks on nights when he couldn't sleep. Something about the act just calmed his nerves, the fresh air allowing him space to breathe, to think. He bit his lip, glancing over at the window. He couldn't really think of any reason why he couldn't do the same here. And so, with a sigh, he slid his shoes on and hooked the artifice around his neck. He didn't really expect to encounter anyone this late, but figured he was better safe than sorry.

Once he was ready, Izuku left the apartment, shutting the door softly behind him. He didn't have much choice but to leave it unlocked, but it was easy enough to rationalize; he wouldn't be out for long, anyway.

He stepped into the elevator, pressing the button for the ground floor, and leaned against the glass as it descended.

The streets were quiet this time of night, at least in the area where Katsuki lived. Once he left the building, Izuku crossed the street, arbitrarily decided to turn left, and walked down the sidewalk at a leisurely pace.

It felt a bit disconcerting, going for a walk out there on his own. He found himself looking over his shoulder a lot, as though he could expect someone to jump out and attack him. But there was never anyone there. The streets were remarkably empty.

Izuku stopped to peer into the windows of a nearby cafe, but it was far too dark inside for him to make out any distinct objects. Only shapes in the darkness.

He shook his head and continued on, his hands stuffed into his pockets as he gazed up at the night sky. The gentle wind felt nice blowing through his hair. So nice, in fact, that he could almost forget about the persistent sense of unease that continued to plague his mind as he meandered through that quiet night.

Almost, but not quite.

Because the further he wandered, the less distinct his surroundings appeared. Distant buildings seemed to almost blur together, and those that were nearby just looked like bizarre amalgamations of other buildings he'd seen before. Izuku frowned, pinching himself to no avail. As he continued to walk, his thoughts gradually began to feel almost as hazy as the world around him.

He was around four blocks from Katsuki's apartment when the nausea abruptly hit him, stomach churning as he struggled to focus on his surroundings. His head spinning, Izuku backed up a few paces and closed his eyes. It made him feel a little bit better.

He took a few slow, deep breaths before he finally managed to open his eyes again. The queasy sensation returned. It wasn't quite as overbearing as it had been before, but it was still more than he was willing to put up with.

I guess I should just head back, he thought. And then, slowly, so as not to upset his stomach, Izuku turned around.

He stopped halfway through the turn, the sight of his own reflection in the building's window giving him pause. There was something off about one of his feathers. It wasn't white, like the rest, but rather a warm, metallic color, as though it were cast in gold.

Izuku looked down at his own wing, but saw nothing out of the ordinary. Still, the golden anomaly remained in his reflection's left wing, shining in the pale moonlight.

"What the—" Izuku tensed.

Wait.

Suddenly, a memory came rushing back to the surface.

Himself, standing in an apple orchard. The weight of the golden apple in his palm. Izuku's eyes widened.

Is this…? He gulped, heart rate accelerating. *No… it can't be, can it? This entire place?*

He stopped for a moment, looking around anxiously before settling back on his reflection. With shaky hands, Izuku gripped the feather, took a deep breath, and pulled.

He winced as it came free, and waited.

But nothing happened.

His reflection still showed the golden feather in the exact same place, undisturbed.

Izuku's shoulders slumped as he glanced down at the feather in his hand, slightly bloodied at the quill.

Well… at least it wasn't an important one.

With a sigh, he turned and started back toward Katsuki's apartment building. Over time, as he periodically glanced at his reflection in the windows of passing buildings, something strange began to happen.

The closer he got to the apartment, the less obvious the golden feather became. Its luster dampened, yellow tones fading out until eventually, it looked no different from any of the others.

Once he'd made it back to Katsuki's, he made a beeline for the bathroom, flicking on the lights and looking in the mirror. This time, his reflection was accurate, the feather he'd pulled out missing from the image.

He stared at it for what must have been several minutes before he finally turned off the lights and headed back to the living room. Taking a deep breath, he set the feather down next to the lamp before switching it off and crawling into bed.

He lay there, staring at the ceiling again.

The fan wasn't spinning anymore.

"Wake up, Asshole. We're goin' on an *adventure."*

Izuku opened his eyes right as Katsuki was throwing Triplet at him. He sat up before she could land on his chest, and ended up in his lap instead.

"Woah, that was fast." He quirked an eyebrow. "You good?"

"Yeah, I just…" He frowned. "Was having a weird dream, I guess." He cleared his throat. "Um. What sort of adventure…?"

Katsuki told him something evasive, and then handed him a touchpad with a map of Hell pulled up.

He hadn't asked if that was what it was, and Katsuki hadn't told him.

He just figured it made sense in context.

As he looked closer, he noticed that the scale indicated that every inch was roughly a thousand miles. Somehow, this neither shocked nor concerned him.

He asked Katsuki how long it would take them.

"Well, it's about seven right now. If we head out soon, we can be back before ten tonight."

He pressed him no further—just nodded silently in understanding and handed the touchpad back.

As he climbed out of bed, he glanced at the spot next to the bedside lamp.

There was nothing there.

"There you are." Jirou said. "Dude, we've been looking *everywhere* for you."

Katsuki shrugged, biting into an embrite as he stared out the window of the church. A different church. One that *hadn't* burned down.

Jirou lingered somewhere in his periphery, along with Sero, who was currently busy notifying the others that he'd been found. Katsuki didn't care.

Eventually, Sero sighed. "So… have you slept?"

Katsuki snorted.

"…Gonna take that as a no."

“So, is there a *reason* you’re here, or are you just gonna lecture me?”

“We’re just worried about you, man.” Sero said. “It’s been three days.”

“I’m aware.”

Jirou sighed. “Dude, I know this shit is hard, but if you don’t take care of yourself, you’re just gonna get—” She abruptly stopped talking, her body tensing. She glanced over at the window, her eyes widening just before she shouted, *“Get down!”*

All three of them ducked right as the windows shattered beneath a barrage of projectiles. The arrows hit the pews they hid behind, sticking in the wood.

“Fucking *seriously?”* Sero groaned. “Now, of all—*hey!”* He yelled, as Katsuki stood up, and strode over to the door. “Bakugou, what the *hell* are you doing?!”

Katsuki gave no answer. He simply kicked the door open and took off, already shifted. Angels in combat knew how to dull the resonance of their souls so as not to be detected, but in a case like this, it was only a matter of retracing the trajectory of the arrows. He found the sniper faster than one could blink, grabbed his neck and twisted it. He heard a sharp crack, dropped the Angel’s limp body to the ground, and cracked his skull with one quick, efficient stomp.

The next one came at him from behind, swinging a sword at his neck. Katsuki ducked beneath the attack, flared his soul alight as he grabbed the Angel’s wrist, burning his skin until he dropped his weapon. Less than a second later, the man’s body was yanked away, thrown into the side of a nearby building as if shot by a powerful slingshot. He gave Sero a nod as he grabbed the man’s sword, hurling it at a woman just as she emerged from the bushes. As it speared through her abdomen, she fell the ground, choking on her own blood.

Another man emerged from the shadows with a crossbow in hand. Katsuki only had to dodge one shot before the man suddenly started to cough violently. As he keeled over, Jirou materialized behind him, kicking him off his feet and swiping his crossbow, firing it back at him, straight through his head. The wound began to heal around the arrow as the soul bleed almost instantly set in.

Katsuki thought that was all of them. But then, he spotted movement out of the corner of his eye, and as he turned, he saw only the Angel’s back as they fled, running down the street and taking off into the sky.

Katsuki didn’t think. His body simply operated on autopilot as he shot off after him, his speed enhanced by the flaring of hellfire in his soul.

It took all of a second for him to catch up, wind whipping against his face as he closed in, grabbing his wing and snapping the bone in two. He cried out, losing control of his trajectory and falling into a downward spiral.

The man crashed into the asphalt of the alley below, coughing and groaning, muscles straining as he tried to force his body to cooperate. Katsuki landed some ten feet away,

shoving his hands into his pockets as he approached him at a leisurely pace. The Angel had managed to pry himself up onto his hands and knees, and as he got closer, he could make out speckles of blood on the pavement as he heaved.

Katsuki kicked him off balance, rolling him over onto his back and glaring down at him. He was about to deal the final blow, when he saw the look on the Angel's face and froze. Because despite everything, he still had the nerve to look almost smug about it. Here he was, lying on his back, his skin covered in blood and filth, his blond hair matted with sweat, and still, he had the gall to look up at Katsuki as though he were looking *down* at him.

Katsuki clenched his jaw.

He knew he should just put an end to it. This guy wasn't some big, third-sphere Angel; it was just some nobody, on the low end of the second sphere. If he were to hazard a guess, he'd say the guy was just some shit-head level four, probably even weaker than Izuku, despite being one level above him.

It wasn't even worth his time to kill him. He could let the Angel live, and nothing would change.

But Katsuki was not feeling merciful today.

He narrowed his eyes as he stared down at the man, and in that moment, all he wanted was to wipe that stupid, arrogant look off the asshole's face.

And so, with a menacing smile, Katsuki slammed his foot down on the Angel's hand, choking a scream out of him as the bones shattered beneath his boot. He repeated the action again with more force, then again, and *again*—crushing his bones a bit more each time. He kept doing it until there was nothing left to break, and all he could hear were those sickening, wet sounds, as though he were stomping on a hunk of raw meat, rather than a person's hand.

When he finally stopped, the Angel's hand was just a disfigured mass attached to his wrist, swollen and bruised, and seeping blood slowly. The smug look was long gone, the man's face just a pale void of shock, blue eyes wide and unseeing as he lay there, wheezing on the ground.

The wrecked hand wasn't lethal, of course. If it were, then it would've triggered soul bleed, and Katsuki would've seen it beginning to heal by now. Seriously injuring an Angel after soul bleed already had begun was a one-way ticket to death by divine light exposure, but prior to that point, there was nothing he couldn't do.

Katsuki looked at him for a while, his expression blank, his mind distant. He proceeded to kick him firmly in the side a few times, cracking ribs, bruising his kidneys. It looked like the Angel was on the verge of passing out, his eyes hazy and vacant; his brain likely trying to dissociate from the reality of the pain he was in.

Seeing that he was likely to fall unconscious soon, Katsuki grabbed his uninjured wing, intent on breaking it as well, but before he could do so, an arrow shot through the Angel's temple, and instantly the flesh began to heal around it.

Katsuki just stared down at the body for a few seconds, blinking slowly before he looked over his shoulder and found Jirou standing a few feet away, Sero landing beside her soon after. She was glaring at him, her jaw clenched as she tossed the crossbow off to the side.

Sero's eyes widened as he took in the state of the Angel at Katsuki's feet. "Bakugou, what the *fuck?"*

Katsuki pursed his lips, turning on his heal and briskly walking away from the scene, his hands stuffed into his pockets, still. He gritted his teeth when he heard them trailing behind him, but only stopped when Jirou suddenly grabbed his wrist in a tight grip. He stood there, frozen for a moment.

"What." He hissed.

He didn't even look back at her.

"You *know* what." She snapped.

He scoffed. "Fuck off."

Her hand tightened, but he yanked it away easily enough, and began walking away again.

"Bakugou!" She yelled.

Something in him snapped, and he spun around sharply. "Just leave me the fuck alone!" He shouted. "You fucking *know* I'm upset, so just fuck *off!"*

"There's being upset and then there's *that* shit!" She yelled, pointing at the body. "You can't just—!"

Sero put his hand on her shoulder, and the words died on her tongue. He looked her in the eye and shook his head. Katsuki didn't stick around to see if either of them had anything else to say. He simply broke into a run, and took off, suddenly desperate to get as far from the area as possible.

Traveling through the Depths was a terrifying experience, and stacked up with his existing anxiety, it had Izuku feeling like he was about to break down, even before anything actually happened.

It was around the half hour mark when he finally heard it—his own voice, speaking to him. And it was like a splash of cold water. Not because it was frightening, though it certainly was, but because it felt…

...Different.

Actually *different,* in a way he wasn't sure how to describe. It stuck out to him, reached through the haze of his mind. Everything up to that exact moment had been giving him this odd sense of deja vu, like something he'd dreamed of once, or seen in a movie somewhere. In some form or another, all of it felt familiar.

This did not.

“Sometimes there is safety in the spirals of reality.” It said, from his left.

Izuku kept his head facing forward, trying not to let the shock show on his face.

It was a bit like hearing the first few notes of a song you thought you knew, only for it to diverge in a completely different direction.

“I swam through the sunrise, and it brought me home.” It told him, from behind.

He shivered, clenching his fists at his sides.

From his right, then: “The real prison is inside your mind.”

He almost tripped when he heard those words, and only barely resisted the urge to look.

That one made just a little too much sense for Izuku’s comfort.

Throughout the day, that feeling of unease further metastasized. Because with each trip through the Depths, Izuku grew more and more certain, until he finally felt confident enough to speak the words inside his own mind.

None of this is real.

It’s all an illusion. Every last part of it.

And if it’s an illusion… then there must be a way out.

Izuku’s mind flashed with images of his own reflection, the golden feather featured prominently. It seemed like the obvious answer, but…

Izuku sighed.

The issue was obvious, of course. While the golden apple was something Izuku could directly interact with, his reflection was not so straightforward. If pulling out the corresponding feather wasn’t enough to break the illusion, then what *was?*

Maybe I just need to… break the mirror? He wondered. *But… no, that doesn’t seem right.*

He continued to contemplate it until their second to last trip through the Depths, when Katsuki eventually said something that made him want to stop thinking about it altogether.

“…It’s legitimately the worst shit ever, ‘cuz at that point you can actually *see* it.”

Izuku tensed. “What do you mean *‘see it’?”*

“Deku, imagine this.” Katsuki said. “You’re stumbling through the dark, trying to find your way out of this goddamn eldritch location, and suddenly, you see your fucking doppelgänger

right there in your periphery…”

In that moment, all thoughts fled Izuku’s mind as the blood drained from his face. In an instant, everything clicked together in the worst possible way, triggering a primal, nausea-inducing panic.

That… No, it can’t be.

It can’t be.

Please.

Anything but that.

He spent the next few hours trying in vain to convince himself that he was wrong. But it was a losing game, and he knew it. He just couldn’t come up with a good reason to doubt his conclusions. This had to be the way out. Things lined up too well for it not to be.

To break this down, assume for a moment that all of this was, in fact, an illusion, and consider the mirror effect. It seemed fairly obvious to Izuku that it was somehow connected to distance, either from Katsuki, or more broadly, from that which was familiar.

Given how quickly one could travel through the Depths, the task of getting someplace far away from both would be trivial. It’d likely take less than a second for the currents to carry him far enough, at which point, if he were to somehow find a mirror, he could expect to see the gold feather in his own reflection.

But, of course, that wasn’t the point. Looking into a mirror would serve no purpose.

Izuku could not interact with his own reflection.

…He *might,* however, be able to interact with his doppelgänger.

And wasn’t *that* just the most quaintly horrifying little thought?

Izuku had to wonder: if he peed himself inside the illusion, would he also pee himself in real life?

That’s assuming this actually is *an illusion,* he reminded himself. Hypotheticals were fine and all, but he needed to be careful not to take that fact for granted. The reality was, there were plenty of other explanations for what he’d been experiencing these past few days, and some of them were objectively more plausible. Maybe there was just something in the air in Hell that caused bizarre cognitive effects in Angels. Maybe his experience last night really *was* just a dream.

As he thought it over, he noticed their surroundings slowly lightening up as they entered the twilight depths. Their trip was nearly over. Izuku’s heart rate accelerated as he felt some unholy mixture of relief and panic.

He didn't have much time. He needed to decide, within the next few minutes, whether he was confident enough in this wild theory of his to *bet his life on it.*

Hands shaking, Izuku reached out toward his wing, touching the feather he thought he'd pulled out last night. He tugged on it gently, and could've sworn he felt some residual ache in the follicle, as though it had been damaged somehow. It could've easily been psychosomatic. It almost certainly was.

Do I really trust my own instincts enough to risk my life like this?

…With a wave of ice-cold terror, Izuku realized that he *did.*

He swallowed roughly, letting his eyes slip shut for a moment.

Here.

It just had to be here.

The one place any sane person would avoid like the plague.

But perhaps Izuku just wasn't a sane person. Even considering everything else, it was still the only explanation he could offer for what he voluntarily chose to do next.

With his heart pounding inside his chest, Izuku did exactly what Katsuki told him not to, before he could lose his nerve.

He simply.

Stopped.

Walking.

And there was a part of him that expected nothing to happen. Thought that maybe it wouldn't be fast enough, that maybe Katsuki would notice before anything bad could occur, and he'd simply toss him over his shoulder and continue on, lecturing him all the way back.

But it was nearly instantaneous.

"De—"

He was gone before he could even hear the second syllable. The sound of Katsuki's footsteps disappeared as the otherworldly currents of the Depths swept him away. He kept his eyes closed tight as he stood there, listening to the sound of wind blowing through the trees up above.

It took maybe fifteen seconds before it disappeared completely.

He only opened his eyes then, and slowly started walking again. He wasn't sure what exactly distinguished the void depths from the Quiet, but he wasn't too keen on finding out if he didn't need to.

Without Katsuki to guide the way, there wasn't much he could see. His halo provided some minimal amount of light, but nowhere near enough to see his surroundings properly. Still, he wiped his hands on his cloak as he moved slowly through the forest, trying to stay quiet, ears straining for any sounds, near or far.

As he walked, Katsuki's absence left him feeling naked. Made him acutely aware of the fact that something could attack him any second. It was surreal, a level of danger his brain struggled to properly grasp. Even the silence felt hostile.

The more time passed without incident, the more certain Izuku felt of his imminent demise. His heart raced in his chest. His feathers stood on end. And then, for whatever reason, it seemed to hit him all at once—the realization that he was either going to die down here, or experience something so awful, he'd probably carry it with him for the rest of his days.

And suddenly, it wasn't even a question of whether he was wrong. It was a question of whether this would even be worth it if he was *right.*

Because that feeling, waiting helplessly in the dark for something horrifying to occur, was absolutely paralyzing. He was suffocating in the darkness, and nothing could save him from what was about to occur.

Without realizing it, he began to cry, tears silently slipping down his cheeks.

What the hell is wrong with me? Why am I such an idiot?

His hands trembled as he reached up to wipe away his tears.

I need to get back to Kacchan, but how? How would I even begin *to—*

Izuku stopped breathing.

Something was *moving.*

It was in his periphery, just out of sight.

He sped up, closing his eyes as he walked. He didn't want to see it. Didn't want the added fear of having to look at whatever horrible creature had come to kill him. And he nearly tripped and fell multiple times, throat tightening as his body was overpowered by a sense of impending doom.

He was imagining something with writhing flesh, bizarre, asymmetrical forms housing dozens of eyes, and teeth sharp enough to tear through his body in an instant.

That characterization turned out to be a bit too optimistic.

As the ambient temperature dropped another degree, Izuku heard the sound of laughter.

His *own* laughter.

"Aw, come on, Izuku. Look at me." It said, on his left.

Izuku felt cold tears wetting his skin as he stumbled through the darkness, eyes still squeezed shut. He could feel its presence beside him. The sensation of its breath wafting against his face, cold and alien.

And something happened to his brain, at that moment. It was like his fear hit a ceiling he never knew existed, only to then plow straight through it. He couldn't think, couldn't reason. Couldn't feel anything but that all-encompassing terror as his ears began to ring, and his mind plunged into an endless cycle, alternating between the same three thoughts at increasing speed.

This isn't an illusion.

It's too real to be an illusion.

I'm going to die.

It was already too much, and he hadn't even opened his eyes yet.

But it was bound to happen eventually. A few seconds later, he walked straight into a tree, head smacking against the trunk painfully. The shock of it caused him to open his eyes. He still had enough sense to keep his head facing forward, but the image in his periphery would stick with him for the rest of his life—if he even lived long enough to remember it in retrospect.

Because there, standing right beside him, was *him*. Or rather, the Depths' mirror image of him. It grinned at him just a little too wide, and even with his eyes facing forward, Izuku could still feel those dead eyes boring into him as the entity's halo shown down on its face, bangs cutting dark shadows into its features.

It followed him, matching his pace perfectly, though its movements were unnatural, joints not quite moving correctly as it contorted itself to face him. It was as though Izuku's body was simply a costume It put on.

Bashing his head against a tree wasn't looking so bad anymore.

He yelped when it suddenly appeared on his right, its eyes wide, penetrating deep into his mind. He could feel its presence there, flooding him like seawater. His brain became a vessel for the Depths itself, an ocean trapped inside his skull.

Izuku was drowning.

I'm going to die.

"That's why you stopped, isn't it? Why you left his side?" It asked, tone sickly sweet. "You *wanted* this, Izuku."

He clenched his jaw, but kept his head forward. He had to suppress the impulse to lurch away when It abruptly leaned in, its face now just inches from his own.

“He’s panicking, you know.” It whispered. “He’s screaming your name, searching desperately. We’re hundreds of miles away, but he’ll keep going, Izuku. Kacchan will kill himself looking for you.”

More tears slipped from his eyes, and he squeezed them shut.

“Aw, why are you crying?” It asked, performing concern. “Was it not your *intention* for you both to die alone in the dark?”

Izuku choked on a sob, clenching his fists at his sides. The slight pain of his nails digging into his palms woke him up, if only a little bit.

Get it together. Get it together! He screamed at himself. *Don’t let it manipulate you!*

“It’s not manipulation, Izuku.” It said, reminding him of its presence in his mind. “It’s honesty. Don’t you think it’s about time someone was *honest* with you?”

Izuku doubled his pace, but the creature easily matched it. He blinked, and it was on his left again.

“It’s a really pathetic combination, you know. You’re desperate to be useful because you’re desperate to be *loved,* but you’re too insecure to believe that anyone could ever *actually* love you.”

Don’t listen to it.

“So you just keep raising the stakes. Just keep trying to do *more.* But since you won’t protect yourself, those who care for you are forced to do it, instead.”

Don’t listen to it!

It leaned in further, eyes widening. “Hey. You know what you get when you land yourself in a situation that’s over *everyone’s* head, Izuku?”

Don’t—!

“—You get Kacchan’s corpse rotting in the Quiet.”

Izuku gritted his teeth, clasping his hands together, trying to keep them from shaking. He gave up after a moment.

What does it matter, anyway?

Misery bled in with the terror, mixing up into a dark haze.

It’s right.

“You promised him you’d come back to him.” It whispered. “You lied to him. He told you he loved you, and you lied.”

Izuku faltered.

Wait.

“Can you really call that *love,* Izuku?”

What is it talking about, exactly? I don’t…

And then a barrage of memories bombarded his mind.

Him and Katsuki in the hot spring.

The gravity seeds pressing against the inside of his cheek.

All Might under the bridge.

Red.

Black.

But… none of that happened. He thought, brow furrowing.

And then his eyes went wide.

No, he realized.

None of it has happened **yet.**

And that means…

Just then, a flash of something reflective caught his eye. He kept his gaze forward, but it was visible enough for him to see that it was golden. A single golden feather, situated in his mirror-self’s wing.

The ocean of fear flooding his mind drained just enough for him to get his head above the water.

Everything clicked into place.

I was right.

There was a chance that this could still be dangerous, but—

“—How does it feel, knowing you’ve killed him?”

He found he didn’t care anymore. No matter what this creature claimed, it was lying. All day long, there was only one thing it had said to him that Izuku could really say was true.

“The real prison is inside your mind.”

Izuku clenched his fists. It was about time for him to break free.

In a flash of crackling electricity, Izuku turned and grabbed the creature by the face, slamming its head into the nearest tree.

Izuku smiled, but his tone was cold. “I’m not afraid of you.” He hissed, just as the ground began to shake. “You can’t hurt me.”

But the entity just grinned, wider, *wider,* its mouth just a hollow pit, dark as the forest itself. And when it suddenly engulfed Izuku’s hand, even the adrenaline pumping through his veins couldn’t keep him from screaming.

It was cold—colder than his body was capable of comprehending. He experienced only a brief shock of ice before the sensation deteriorated into an all-encompassing, searing pain. Within seconds, Izuku couldn’t even *sense* his hand, and as he ripped his arm away, he very quickly discovered why.

It was as though it had been melted off. The wrist to which his hand had been attached was scorched black, reduced to an almost gum-like consistency. Izuku’s ears were ringing, bile rising in his throat. The ground was starting to sink, and it made it look as though the trees were bowing down to them.

The creature was speaking again. He couldn’t understand the words, yet they seemed to pile up in his head, testing the strength of his skull. He felt something crack.

Gritting his teeth, Izuku’s body surged with power. In one final, desperate move, he lunged for the creature’s wing, grabbed the golden feather and ripped it straight out, and then—

Izuku gasped awake, eyes snapping open, only for him to quickly close them again as the bright, fluorescent lights made him cringe.

The first thing he did was look at his hand, relieved to find that it was still there. The next thing he did was take stock of his surroundings.

He was lying on a steel table in a cold, mostly barren room, with a single, heavy-duty door. At first glance, it looked like he was alone.

Izuku sat up quickly, wincing as the dizziness made him nauseous, and it was then that he saw him. The lone Acolyte was lying on the floor, motionless on his stomach. Not too far from him was a chair, knocked over on its side.

Izuku’s heartbeat quickened as he stared at the seemingly-unconscious man, and he had to pause to take a few deep breaths before slowly sliding off the table, half expecting the Acolyte to spring up and attack him.

With a shaky hand, Izuku checked the man’s pulse, confirming that he was alive, though as he rolled him over onto his back, he got the impression that he wouldn’t be waking up anytime soon.

Did **I** *do this…?*

Izuku thought back to the illusion, when he'd ripped the feather out of the doppelgänger. He'd been using power. And since this Acolyte was presumably *responsible* for the illusion…

Izuku gulped.

Which reminded him of the gravity seed that presumably still remained dormant in his stomach. He wasn't sure how long it had been, but there was hope in the fact that Angels' digestive systems *did* tend to move more slowly.

The room, though mostly empty, did have a small sink in the corner, next to some steel drawers. But as Izuku stood up and headed over to it, he couldn't help but notice something… *off* about his sense of balance. It gave him pause, and he stopped to look himself over. Nothing jumped out at him as being particularly unusual.

Then he extended his wings.

Izuku felt a shock of cold run through his system when the realization hit him, dropping heavily into his stomach.

His wings had been clipped, the flight feathers now short and useless. Izuku grabbed his right wing, brow wrinkling as he examined it. They hadn't even done a clean job with it. The cuts were jagged, and in some places, didn't even penetrate the entire shaft, instead just sort of leaving it hanging there.

"I like your wings." Katsuki had told him.

"They're pretty."

It was difficult to describe the strange shame he felt, when he realized that he'd thought of Katsuki's words first, and his inability to escape through flight second.

Shaking his head, Izuku headed over to the sink, drinking from the faucet. He swallowed down a decent amount in preparation for what would come next—namely, a remarkably unpleasant few minutes, during which he sat, kneeling on the floor, his eyes watering, nose running, as he tried to force himself to vomit.

With the matter of his wings still fresh on him mind, Izuku was more aggressive about it than he perhaps would've otherwise been. He rationalized it with the mantra, *'desperate times call for desperate measures.'* But even then, in that moment of panic, he knew that wasn't the full story.

Izuku was upset, and with nowhere else to direct his pain, he directed it inward.

And sure, he knew that given several months, the feathers would eventually grow back. But then, given several months, Izuku would most likely be either dead, or a Demon. Perhaps it was irrational, but there was something so depressing and frustrating about the knowledge that he would never again touch the sky as an Angel.

And so, forcing his fingers further down his throat, he eventually managed to make himself throw up. The first two times, it was just water and bile, but the third time, he finally managed to bring the gravity seed up with it.

Izuku took a moment to wash his hands and face off before he picked it up and looked around.

He only had one seed, and he needed to put it somewhere he could be sure it wouldn't be discovered. He knew he couldn't count on finding a place to hide it once he left the room, but there weren't very many hiding places to choose from. He could put it in the drawers, but they'd probably find it.

Eventually, his eyes fell upon the unconscious Acolyte, and that's when the thought first entered his head, with a sort of dark, disconcerting sadism. He didn't grant it much viability at first, but when he actually thought about it… well, there was no reason why it *wouldn't* work.

It'd be a perfect hiding place, too, in some ways.

And so, before he could change his mind, Izuku crawled over to the man and propped him up on his knee. Then he activated the gravity seed and placed it on his tongue. It was a bit of a struggle, but he eventually managed to get him to swallow it as he stroked his throat.

With a satisfied sigh, he stood up.

Good luck finding it there.

But now came the much more difficult question.

How the hell am I going to get out of here?

Izuku looked around the room, and shuffled over to the door. He pressed his ear up against the cold steel, and held his breath. He couldn't hear anything on the other side, though that could've been due to the thickness of the door.

Chewing his lip, he glanced back at the Acolyte. He was going to wake up eventually. If he was going to get out of this place alive, he really didn't have much time to spend ruminating on it. And so, with a sigh, he decisively approached the unconscious Acolyte, and with shaky hands, he began to remove his clothes.

The white and gold cloak came off easily enough, but he couldn't help but stare at the form he found underneath.

As he'd expected, the man had a few different pairs of wings. In addition to the standard pair sprouting from his shoulder blades, he had a smaller pair of wings stemming around halfway down his spine.

As he removed the undercoat, he found two additional wing-like structures, each running along his forearms, somewhat similar to the fins of a fish. The existence of such wings was not a strange thing on its own; Izuku had seen them on other Angels. They were known as

precision wings—wings which were designed to help Angels make rapid directional adjustments during flight.

What *was* odd, however, was the fact that they were rather small and mostly bare, which raised questions in Izuku's mind that were hard to push out, even under dire circumstances. As they were, he couldn't imagine the wings being particularly useful. Was it corruption damage? Disillusionment? Or were they just *always* like that, for some reason?

Shaking his head, Izuku moved onto his pants, carefully sliding them off. He'd expected to find an additional pair of precision wings sprouting from the man's ankles, but the boots he wore did not seem to allow for it. As he removed the shoes, he found only faint bumps where the wings would have gone.

With a sigh, Izuku stood up, staring down at the half-naked man—it was hard not to describe him as a *creature.* There was something so bizarre about his appearance, his sickly, yellowed skin stretched around a gangling form. His gaunt facial features remained relaxed, and though he did have eyes, they remained closed.

Izuku felt something strange at that moment, almost like pity. He swallowed, and tore his gaze away.

He quickly removed his own clothing and donned the Acolyte's. The boots were a bit big on him, so he stuffed his own socks into the toe of each boot. If he needed to run, he didn't want anything to slow him down.

The red blindfold was going to be a challenge, but Izuku was satisfied with positioning it just slightly above his eyes. If he needed to, he could pull it down.

He knew he couldn't count on the disguise working, but at the very least, he hoped that it would buy him some time.

The last thing he did was check the drawers of the steel cabinet. Most were empty, but the bottom drawer contained a number of medical tools—among which he found a surgical knife. Izuku gulped, grabbing the tool and tucking it into his pocket.

Just in case.

Then, with his heart hammering inside his chest, Izuku approached the door, and slowly turned the doorknob. He'd half-expected the act to instantly trigger some alarm, and when he was met with only silence, he almost felt *more* nervous.

Izuku carefully peered through the crack, ensuring the coast was clear before he stepped out, and quietly closed the door behind him.

He found himself in a small hallway branching off from a larger one. All the doors looked essentially the same. He had no intention of finding out what was behind them.

Instead, he tiptoed over to the corner and looked both ways down the larger hallway, confirming the coast was clear with a sigh of relief.

The last thing he did was head back to the room he'd emerged from, open the door and lock it from the inside, hoping it would delay their discovery of his escape, if only by a minute.

And then, with his heart in his throat, Izuku forced himself to walk with intention. There was no way for him to know which way was the right one, so he just picked a direction and followed it.

The building was like a labyrinth. Izuku wasn't sure how they were able to navigate it; every turn looked essentially the same. He ultimately had to just pick a single path and see where it took him.

Fortunately, things eventually became a bit more distinct, the layout less convoluted. After that point, Izuku soon found himself standing before a set of double doors. Looking around one more time, Izuku leaned forward, peering through the small crack in between. The room seemed to be empty, and so he quietly opened the door and ducked inside.

The first thing he noticed was the second set of double doors at the opposite end of the room.

The second thing was the bizarre setup at the room's center.

He wasn't quite sure what he was looking at. There was a sort of large, cylindrical structure, made entirely from metal. One one end was what looked to be a door, large enough to enter through. On the other end, some additional smaller structure was connected, with two circular gaps in the steel, each around five inches in diameter. Sitting directly in front of that was a chair, and beneath it were two holes in the floor, close to where a person's feet would sit.

And all along the walls of the room were large lockers, with door-sized openings.

Izuku didn't know what to make of the whole place, couldn't even begin to guess what its purpose was.

He didn't need to wait long.

Because as he approached one of the lockers, he heard the soft sound of echoing footsteps outside, and it made his heart rate spike. Panicking, he opened the closest locker, only to immediately freeze.

Because somebody was inside of it.

Multiple people, in fact—the cavity extended much deeper into the walls than Izuku had anticipated. They were all lined up, a complicated system of racks and bars supporting their bodies. It was the look in their eyes that really made his heart rate skyrocket. That dead, vacant stare.

Husks.

The doorknob turned. With a shot of adrenaline, Izuku swiftly forced himself inside the locker and shut the door in front of him. And as he peered through the tiny slits in the metal, he saw them.

Two Acolytes walked in, talking casually as they shut the door behind them.

“I’m still not sure about this one. After what happened, it just seems like an unnecessarily risky pick.” The shorter one said.

“Have the aptitude tests ever been wrong before?”

“…Good point, I guess.”

“I can understand the concern, I assure you.” The taller said, shrugging. “But pragmatically, it just doesn’t seem like a big deal to me. It’s not like we couldn’t handle it if something went wrong.”

“I guess you’re right.” He sighed. “And really, it’s my own fault for not raising my concerns sooner.”

He chuckled. “If it’s any consolation, I don’t think it would’ve changed much if you did.”

The other shook his head, and Izuku had to cover his mouth when suddenly, the shorter Acolyte yanked open the locker right next to him.

He held his breath, paralyzed as the man counted the husks within, mumbling under his breath.

“How many do you think?” He asked. “Twelve?”

“Twelve?”

“Well, he’s a big guy.” He shrugged.

“I don’t see why that matters. Ten is standard—have you not done this before?”

He scoffed. “Of course I have. But I’ve seen it go wrong before.”

“Twelve still seems a bit excessive, though.” The taller Acolyte said. “These things don’t grow on trees, you know.”

“I just want to make sure nothing goes wrong, is all.” He replied. “Can we compromise on eleven?”

The other man sighed. “Don’t let this get back to Three.”

“I won’t, I won’t.” He grunted as he yanked a husk off the rack. “Open the chamber, would you?”

The man nodded, spinning the wheel on the outside until he was able to yank it open with a *pop.*

Immediately, both of them recoiled.

“God! When’s the last time this was *cleaned?!”*

“It’s never clean enough.” The shorter man said, unceremoniously shoving the husk into the chamber. He sighed, heading back to the locker. “There’s always a spot they missed.”

The smell slowly began to seep into the locker, and Izuku pulled his blindfold down over his nose, resisting the urge to gag.

“This is even worse than usual, though.” He said, pinching his nose. “There’s *got* to be another way to handle this.”

“What would you have them do?”

The man shrugged. “Fill the whole thing with bleach, maybe? I don’t know.”

The other snorted as he shoved the second husk into the chamber. At the same time, the other man opened up another locker and pulled a husk out, dragging the Angel across the floor and throwing him inside. They continued to do this for a few minutes, until finally they had loaded in eleven husks. At that point, they closed the door, spinning the wheel to tighten it, until it was fully sealed.

To say Izuku did not have a good feeling about all of this would be the understatement of the century.

The taller Acolyte sighed, and just then, there was a knock on the door. He went and opened it, and Izuku tensed at who he saw on the other side.

Endeavor.

The man who was allegedly Todoroki’s father.

“You can sit in that chair right there.” The shorter man said, pointing. With a quiet nod, Endeavor entered the room, taking a seat in front of the chamber. One of the Acolytes swiftly dropped to a squat, closing and tightening the leather restraints around his legs.

“How does this work, exactly?” Endeavor asked.

“We find it’s usually better not to explain the specific mechanisms, at least not beforehand.”

“Oh. Is it less effective if you do?”

“Something like that.” The other Acolyte said, shutting the door and walking toward the chamber. “Put your hands through the gaps, there, and press your palms flat against the surface.”

Endeavor did as asked, and raised his eyebrow when a second set of restraints were then wrapped around his arms. “Is it painful, or something?”

“Not exactly.” The shorter Acolyte said. “But some Angels have a bit of a knee-jerk reaction to it. It’s… an odd sensation.” He sighed. “We won’t blindfold you just yet, but do try to keep your eyes closed.”

“Is that everything?”

“Yes. We’re all set.” The taller Acolyte said, approaching a large lever on the side. At the same time, the shorter Acolyte stomped the floor three times, highlighting its obvious hollowness.

Izuku felt a pulling sensation in his heart as he watched the process unfold. He wished he could put a stop to it, somehow, but he knew that to try would be suicide. He gripped the fabric of the Acolyte cloak, resisting the urge to intervene. There was nothing he could do for those Angels, now. Their fates were already sealed.

Izuku thought that the helplessness of the situation would be the worst part.

And then it actually *started.*

In one sharp movement, the Acolyte pulled the lever down, and the sound that followed was one Izuku knew would follow him for the rest of his life.

That sickening *crunching* noise that even the thick, steel walls could not contain.

Izuku felt all the blood drain from his face as he covered his mouth with his hands. Almost immediately, a flash of light seemed to leak out around Endeavor’s wrists. It hurt his eyes, but he couldn’t look away.

The noise repeated a couple of times, though it gradually became less distinct. Izuku didn’t know when his eyes had begun to water, only that the tears were now streaking down his cheeks as he clutched the red blindfold closer to his face, struggling to cry quietly.

And as he stared, he noticed something he hadn’t before: two hands wrapped firmly around Endeavor’s ankles.

More specifically, two *Demon* hands.

The corruption was progressing much faster than usual, as the black, static markings bloomed from his ankles and started to spread up his legs. Pretty soon, feathers began to fall out, starting with the precision wings on his ankles. The ones on his arms were next, followed by the lower set on his back. When the ankle wings were bare, they began to shrink, until they were no more than small bumps. At that point, the Acolyte the lever up again and stomped the floor two times, prompting the Demon’s hands to release Endeavor’s ankles, retreating down into the darkness.

Izuku could see their lips moving, but he heard no sound. His ears were ringing, his entire body shaking. At some point during the procedure, a part of Izuku’s mind had left him, traveling off someplace very far away. He wasn’t sure if he’d ever find it again.

Eleven people.

Eleven.

When his eyes eventually began to refocus, Endeavor was standing up, a red blindfold already wrapped around his head. Izuku could sort of hear their voices, but it was muffled, as though he were underwater.

He closed his eyes and tried to focus on listening, tears still rolling down his cheeks, soaking into the red fabric.

Endeavor asked something about the blindfolds, and one of the Acolytes—he wasn't sure which one, and didn't care—responded. He caught the phases *'get in trouble'* and *'accidental hypnosis.'* A couple of moments later, he managed to gather something about their *'field of perception'* becoming *'more distinct'* over time, but that was all he could make out.

The three of them left a few minutes later, but Izuku remained paralyzed long after they were gone.

He wasn't really sure how long it was. It could've been ten minutes. It could've been an hour. And a distant part of him understood that he needed to get a move on, but it was hard to make himself care.

But eventually, he managed to force himself to get out of the locker.

He glanced at both of the room's exits, and then his gaze gravitated toward the holes in the floor. He couldn't hear anything, but he knew the Demon had to be down there, still. Izuku swallowed, and inched closer to the gaps in front of the chair, and dropped to a squat.

"Hello?" He whispered, and waited.

No response.

"Is there someone down there?"

No response.

Izuku swallowed. *I should just go. Someone could walk in here at any time.*

But.

"I won't… hurt you," he tried, fingers drawing closer to the hole, slowly dipping inside. "I'm not—Ah!" He stifled a yelp as something sharp swiped over his finger, nicking it on the side. Izuku instinctively brought it to his mouth, licking the blood away. It wasn't deep, but it stung, and would most likely lead to some corruption damage.

Eyes watering, he said, "I'm sorry. I'm…" He took a shuddering breath. "I'm going to get help for you. I promise we'll get you out of here. I *swear."*

He wasn't sure who he was trying to convince.

But nonetheless, there was still no response.

Izuku shook his head, slowly standing up and heading toward the door. He couldn't afford to waste any more time than he already had. But just as he started in that direction, he heard a thud down below, and nearly jumped in surprise. He turned to look back, staring at the gaps. With no sign of the Demon, he started toward the door again, only to hear two more thuds.

When he looked back that time, the Demon's hands were curled over the edge.

Izuku gulped, glancing at the doors again before he shuffled back over, returned to his original squat, and whispered, "What is it?"

The Demon fought to squeeze both hands through a single hole, and with their index fingers, they formed an *'X.'* Izuku stared for a moment. Then it hit him.

"Wrong way?" His brow furrowed. "You're trying to tell me I'm going the wrong way… right?"

The Demon gave a thumbs-up. *Well, that's easy enough to understand.*

Izuku scooted closer. "Can you tell me how to get out of here? I don't know where the exit is."

The Demon tapped the floor, and after a pause, pointed in the direction of the other door. They then pointed left.

"Left turn?" He asked. "Go to that door and then take a left?"

Thumbs-up.

After that, they pointed right, tapped the floor, and pointed right again. This continued until eventually, the Demon's hands retreated back into the darkness.

"Left, right, right, left, right?" He whispered. "Is that correct?"

Thumbs-up.

Izuku stood up slowly, repeating the sequence under his breath, trying to commit it to memory. A second later, the Demon hit the floor again.

"…What?"

Another hit. Then two more, more insistent. The Demon pointed at the door, and it was only then that Izuku heard the approaching footsteps. He ran for the opposite door, swiftly but quietly leaving the room just as the other door started to open.

I guess I'll have to thank them later.

Izuku continued down the hall, silently mouthing the directions as he went. He'd made it through the first two turns without incident. It was at the third when he finally ran into one.

The Acolyte stood at the far end of a long hallway. Too far to sense him. Izuku chewed his lip. He might be able to get around him, if he was careful, but…

Izuku shifted back and forth between his feet for a moment. It was only when the Acolyte began to move in his direction that he finally made a choice, shaking his head and changing course. It just wasn't worth the risk, if it wasn't necessary.

He ducked into a nearby alcove, where he found another door. He pressed his ear against the surface, listening for any signs of life. Hearing nothing, he quietly entered the room, and closed the door behind him.

He found himself standing at the start of a long but narrow hallway, with a second door at the end. Izuku contemplated just staying in the hall for a minute, but if anyone were to come in, he'd have nowhere to hide.

And so, although the place gave him a bit of a bad feeling, Izuku swiftly made his way to the end of the hall, pausing to listen at the door again before entering himself.

On the other side of the door was a large chamber. It was dimly lit and windowless, and the ceiling stood many feet over his head.

At the center of the room was a large, circular hatch.

Izuku swallowed, his throat suddenly very dry.

Although he of course couldn't say for certain, it did not take much thought for him to come up with a hypothesis about what was down there.

Swallowing, Izuku approached it slowly, warily, as though he could expect it to open up at any moment, pull him in, snap shut like an alligator's jaw. Swallow him whole. Regardless of what was under that hatch, there was still something quite eerie about the room. A sense of danger hanging in the air. Izuku found himself continually glancing over his shoulders, back and forth between his surroundings as he squatted in front of the trapdoor, ran his fingers over the latch that held it in place.

He probably shouldn't.

No, he definitely *shouldn't.*

But…

Izuku wiped his sweaty hands off on the robe, and then lifted the latch. His heart pounding, Izuku held his blindfold over his nose and pulled.

And *pulled.*

But the hatch would not budge. Izuku frowned, not quite sure what was wrong. Then he saw the lock on the opposite side.

Oh. Of course, Izuku thought. *That makes sense.*

He was perhaps a bit disappointed, but it was probably better this way. Though there were undoubtably many mysteries within the walls of this place, now wasn't the time to push his luck with uncovering them.

With a sigh, he stood up again, and made a swift escape from the room. He peered outside the alcove as surreptitiously as he could, and when he could confirm the coast was clear, he continued on.

He made it the rest of the way undisturbed, and went he made that final turn, it was hard to describe the joy he felt just at the sight of windows. Izuku held his breath as he walked outside, and found himself standing in a grassy field, scattered with trees and picnic tables. He scanned the area until he finally saw it. A shuttle platform, just up ahead.

Freedom.

…The only problem was the space he'd need to cross to get there. The area was partially enclosed, surrounded by the tall walls of the innermost circle. At the moment, there were around a dozen Acolytes sitting out at the tables, some talking, some even *eating.* Izuku counted four tables which were currently occupied, but they were all spread out across the field.

Any way you sliced it, he was going to have to enter at least a few Acolytes' fields of perception.

He briefly considered waiting it out, but that didn't seem viable, either. There weren't really any good places to hide, if one of them came back inside. He doubted he had much time left before they found out he was gone, anyway.

Izuku took a long, deep breath, and exhaled slowly.

It was warm out there, not a cloud in the sky. A beautiful day. Izuku hoped he'd get to enjoy a day like this again, sometime. He hoped this wouldn't be the last time he saw the sky.

Pushing those thoughts out of his head, he began to move, his heart in his throat. He wiped the sweat off his palms one last time for good measure.

Act natural. Be confident, as though you're supposed to be here.

He stuck as close to the innermost wall as he could, and didn't look under the blindfold once he got to a certain point. He made sure the platform was straight ahead before proceeding, ears straining to listen for any signs of movement, any indication of suspicion.

He felt it when he reached the edge of the first Acolyte's field of perception. It didn't feel as strongly as it did up close, but it was unmistakably there. He could only hope that the lower strength correlated with the Acolyte's ability to sense him clearly, too.

The next two he felt in rapid succession, and the added pressure weighed down on his limbs. Still, he powered through it, taking firm strides toward the platform. It seemed the table had quieted down a bit, which made Izuku nervous, but he didn't hear anyone geting up.

He felt himself leave one of the three's field, and allowed himself a small smile. He was almost there. He could feel it. Just a little more, and he'd—

"Stop him!"

Izuku's body practically turned to ice. He quickly turned his head, peering over the blindfold. There, standing on a balcony a couple stories up, was a man.

It was hard to make out too much about his features at this distance, but Izuku could see enough. No blind-fold in sight, red and gold cape flowing behind him as his halo glittered like a crown. This was no Acolyte.

This was a *Councilman.*

He couldn't tell which one, but in that moment, it didn't particularly matter. All that mattered was that he was there, and he was *pointing at Izuku.*

He looked at the Acolytes, watched as they all stood up simultaneously, as though possessed, and that was it. Izuku ripped the blindfold away, dropping all pretense of disguise, and he *bolted.*

He was halfway to the platform. He could make it. He was *going to* make it, he was going to get out.

A second later, his feet touched the platform. Izuku dove for the shuttle doors, only to smack up against them hard with a yelp. Izuku's brow furrowed in confusion. And then he noticed the red light glowing up above, denying him entrance, and paled. Because *of course.* He could dress like an Acolyte, but that didn't make it so.

Izuku looked over his shoulder just as one of them was closing in, and with a surge of adrenaline, he dodged his hands, leaping and climbing up the side of the shuttle car. He reached the top, and rolled over onto his back right as the car began to move, leaving the flock of Acolytes in the dust. Izuku lay there, watching as the ceiling of the tunnel passed just inched above his face.

For a moment, he thought he might have made it.

Then he heard the sound of glass shattering, and moments later, an Acolyte's head popped up over the edge, his blindfold removed. Izuku quickly rolled onto his stomach, covering his eyes. There wasn't room for him to climb onto the roof, however, and so with a curse, he retreated back into the car.

The shuttle arrived at the primary dispatch station just seconds later. Izuku sat up the moment they emerged from the tunnel, and scooted toward the spot just above the door.

He slipped his hand into his pocket, and wrapped his fingers tight around the surgical knife.

It all seemed to happen in slow motion.

The shuttle screeched to a stop.

The door started to open, the Acolyte bumping his shoulder against it in his rush to get out.

Just as he was beginning to turn his head, Izuku closed his eyes and slid off the roof.

He landed on his shoulders, and tightened his legs around the man's neck.

And in one decisive strike, Izuku drove the knife deep into the Acolyte's left eye.

Time sped up again as the Acolyte released a blood-curdling scream, reflexively reaching for the knife. He could hear people shouting all around them as they watched the horrific spectacle in shock. But what he hadn't anticipated was the subsequent sound of bodies hitting the concrete. Izuku was alarmed at first, but when the Acolyte spun around in an attempt to throw him off and several more dropped like flies, it hit him.

Their hypnosis, he remembered. *They really* can't *control it!*

The Acolyte projected red light from his right eye as he grabbed Izuku's legs, clawing at the fabric of his pants until it started to tear. Izuku ripped the surgical knife out of his eye, and the rate of blood loss rapidly increased. The Acolyte managed to throw him off eventually, but the bleeding continued, and didn't seem to be stopping anytime soon.

Izuku landed shoulder-first on the concrete, keeping his eyes closed as he hissed in pain. The Acolyte stumbled toward him, but in his weakened state, Izuku easily managed to pull away from his grasp. Izuku scrambled off the floor, looking around at the dozens of unconscious bodies around him. Some were still standing, having averted their eyes in time, but they remained frozen in place, too shocked to act.

He made a break for it, his right sleeve stained with the Acolyte's blood as he continued to grip the surgical knife, just in case. But none of the bystanders tried to stop him, and he got through the gates unchallenged. The sight of the open air as he stepped out onto the flight runway reminded him of the state of his wings, and for the first time in recent memory, he hesitated.

Swallowing roughly, he looked over his shoulder, and dropped the knife back into his pocket as he inched closer to the edge. And as he looked down at the vast expanse of clouds below, he was hit with a sudden, overwhelming vertigo that churned his stomach and had him stumbling back in fear.

Because this was *insane.*

Izuku looked at his clipped wings, at the cut of his feathers. Experimentally, he tried flapping them, but found that he couldn't even lift off the ground. They might help him slow his descent a bit, but considering how high up he was, Izuku couldn't imagine it being enough. Any way you sliced it, this was still a fatal fall.

Unfortunately, however, he didn't have time to think about it. He could hear the next round of shuttles arriving, and with them, the distinct sound of boots hitting the ground. Izuku could see them coming in his periphery, and now, he only had two options.

He could let them catch him. Shove him in a cell, put him under hypnosis. Toss him in the darkness until the light of his soul flickered out.

Or he could choose to die.

That was what it boiled down to.

Live in chains, or die free.

Izuku closed his eyes, tears slipping down his cheeks.

He'd already made his decision.

Dizzy and terrified, he extended his wings, and backed up a few paces, to a get a running start. Their footsteps were getting closer, louder, like a funeral march.

Izuku took one last breath, and that was it.

He ran.

He jumped.

And he *fell.*

He felt the wind rushing by as he desperately flapped his wings, hoping to achieve a glide.

It wasn't working. He passed through the clouds, and he wasn't slowing down fast enough. As he looked at the ground, he saw that he was on a collision course with an overgrown cornfield. Nothing to break his fall. Nothing to save him.

He kept trying, as the ground grew closer, but at a certain point, he was forced to accept that it was hopeless. He squeezed his eyes shut, curling into a ball, clutching his head and neck as he prepared for impact. He hoped it'd be over quickly, so he wouldn't have to feel it.

He was nearly there.

But just before he could hit the ground, there was a shift in the air around him. It was so fast, he didn't even have a chance to open his eyes before it happened.

Two strong arms found him, one swooping beneath his knees while the other firmly cradled his shoulders, pulling him into a warm chest.

It didn't feel real, when Izuku opened his eyes and saw him. It was as though he were violating some grand, cosmic law. And yet there were no illusions. No asterisks or footnotes.

It was just Katsuki.

He was *there.*

Flying through the sky, black wings eclipsing the sun.

“You’re late.” Katsuki told him.

It took a second for his brain to catch up, and when it did, he began to cry, smiling as tears welled up and were swept away by the wind. *“K-Kacchan!”* He sobbed, wrapping his arms around his neck, burying his face in his chest.

“Oi. You’re gettin’ snot on me.” He said, flight slowing down as he descended.

“R-Right… Sorry.” He said, laughing awkwardly.

Katsuki grumbled something under his breath as he landed on an empty street. “You don’t have to carry me, I can walk.” Izuku said, but instead of putting him down, Katsuki tightened his grip. Flushing slightly, Izuku cleared his throat. “H-How did you find me?”

Katsuki glanced down at him, one eyebrow raised. “Same way I always have. Don’t ya remember what I told you, all those months ago?” He clicked his tongue. “You make yourself *very* easy to find.”

Chapter End Notes

see if u can find all the chekov’s gun moments lmao. I think there are four? guess it depends how u count tho.

i had the pleasure of getting to read a bunch of ppl’s theories about how Deku would get out of this mess, and i think the main flaw in most theories was just the assumption that Katsuki was gonna be the one to rescue him lol. I mean, he DID, at the end, but this was always gonna be mostly Deku lol. Idk, i just feel like it's better from a character perspective. He lied to katsuki, and even though he was doomed to get caught regardless, it wouldn't have felt right to me for katsuki to swoop in and save his ass after that. but for those of you who were hopin to get to see Katsuki raising hell to save deku, don’t worry. There’ll be time for that soon enough lol. This isn’t the climax of the story (we’re gettin real close tho)

A lot of people have asked how many chapters this fic will have. At this point, my outline accounts for 20 in total, but don’t hold me to that lol. Certain things could get combined, or expanded upon. it’s hard to really predict, but yeah.

Oh yeah, also I made a song about this fic it’s nothing special but i like how it turned out and
u can listen to it here. (check the chapter time stamps if u wanna get a feel for what i was thinkin as i made it)

Anyway, as always, thanks for reading! and if you enjoyed this, pls consider leaving a comment. fucked up zoomer brain, etc etc.
Next chapter is… well… let’s just say i think y’all are gonna like it a LOT

Chapter 16: Bloom

Chapter Summary

Because in some form or another, creation always came at the cost of destruction.

Chapter Notes

this is 18.3k words and about 50% of it is NSFW lmao

See the end of the chapter for more notes

They were around ten minutes into their journey when Izuku realized that something was off.

“Kacchan, are we… not going back to Hell?”

Katsuki shook his head, keeping his gaze fixated on the path ahead. “It’d take too long.” He mumbled. “Need to get you to a doctor.”

“Oh.” His brows pinched together. “I mean, I think I’m okay…”

“Yeah?” Katsuki scoffed. “Then what the hell’s that?” He nodded toward Izuku’s right sleeve, where the blood stains were still moist.

“It’s not mine.”

Katsuki snorted, looking down at him. “Then who’s is it?”

“I…” Izuku cleared his throat. “Might have stabbed an Acolyte in the eye.”

At this, both of Katsuki’s eyebrows shot up, and for the first time since they’d reunited, Katsuki smiled. *“Damn.”*

Izuku just laughed awkwardly. “Yeah, it’s… a long story, I guess.”

“Well, maybe you can tell me about it later.” He gave him a pointed look. *“After* you get examined.”

Izuku frowned, but decided not to argue any further.

The trip was not particularly long, but Katsuki still insisted on carrying him the entire way there. He held him close to his chest, his grip firm, claws biting into Izuku through the fabric

of his clothes. It was a bit uncomfortable at times, but something about the hard-set look on his face deterred Izuku from pressing the issue. It was as though he were scared that Izuku might slip through his fingers again, the moment he let him go.

After around thirty minutes of travel time, they arrived before a pair of heavy, steel doors leading into what looked to be a bunker of some kind.

He banged on the door a few times, “Oi, let me in!”

A voice shouted back from inside, muffled by the door. “What’s the password?”

Katsuki clicked his tongue. “Let me in or I’ll break this door down and kick your ass!”

A moment later, Izuku heard a series of clicks, and then the door opened. A familiar face peaked out. *Kaminari.*

His eyes went wide. “No fucking way.” He said, looking Izuku up and down.

“H-Hey, Kaminari.” Izuku stammered, blushing as he became hyper-aware of the fact that Katsuki still had him in a princess-carry.

Katsuki didn’t even say anything. He simply bumped him out of his way with his shoulder, and Kaminari stumbled back with an indignant grunt. Katsuki just kept walking.

After a moment of stupefied silence, Kaminari shut the door, hastily re-locked it, and then came running after him.

“Dude, how the hell did you—“

“Not now.” Katsuki snapped.

“But—“

Katsuki whirled around sharply.

If looks could kill…

Kaminari’s eyes widened slightly, and he stopped in his tracks, putting his hands up in surrender. With that, Katsuki turned around again and continued down the hall. Izuku curled inward in his arms. Beneath the cold, fluorescent lights, the dark circles under Katsuki’s eyes were even more obvious. He swallowed the lump in his throat.

They turned the corner, and Katsuki knocked sharply on the first door on the right. It was his only warning before he barged inside.

“What on Earth—“ The person cut themself off with a gasp. It was a short, older woman, one who almost could’ve passed for human, if not for the subtle, otherworldly glow of her eyes. “Oh my goodness.” She immediately hopped off her chair and pulled open a curtain, revealing a small hospital bed. Katsuki gently laid him down on it. The woman then

beckoned him toward the door, and the two of them stepped out into the hall, the door closing heavily behind them.

Izuku could hear them talking, but couldn't make out anything said. When the door opened next, Katsuki was nowhere to be seen.

Izuku opened his mouth to ask about it, but before he could even get a word out, she was already bombarding him with questions, most of which he did not know the answer to. With a frustrated sigh, she shook her head and proceeded to shove a thermometer into his mouth. By then, Izuku had more or less given up.

The initial tests showed no signs of serious injury, though he did have a rather nasty bruise forming on his right shoulder, from when he'd hit the concrete after stabbing the Acolyte. Still, the woman—*Dr. Shuzenji*—insisted on putting him through just about every test available to them. When Izuku finally worked up the nerve to ask if all of it was really necessary, she just waved her hand dismissively, and said something vague about *'covering all bases.'*

After the third time she told him that something would be *'the last test,'* Izuku gave up any hope of getting out of there soon.

The fifth *'last test'* had him carrying a plastic cup to the bathroom, where he was tasked with getting a urine sample. He took a few minutes to decompress before doing as she requested, and when he was done, he put the lid on the cup and set it off to the side before washing his hands.

The bathroom was cold, and the fluorescent light above the sink flickered every so often. Izuku sighed, glancing up at the mirror. It was bizarre, seeing himself in the Acolyte's uniform. The garment was undoubtedly well-made, and at least in isolation, he supposed that it was aesthetically pleasing. But of course, Izuku couldn't see it without the context surrounding it, and in the end, it just left a bad taste in his mouth.

He kept his gaze mostly on his hands as he washed them, and when he was done, he splashed his face with cold water a couple times before he turned the water off. Wiping the water out of his eyes, he scanned the room around him, but found no towels in sight. He frowned, and considered using toilet paper, but ultimately just decided to wipe his hands off on the uniform—the parts that weren't stained with blood, anyway.

That's when he felt it.

Something tucked away in one of the pockets at the front of the coat, small and cylindrical. His brow furrowing, Izuku unbuttoned the pocket and reached inside, pulling out what looked to be a vial of… well, Izuku wasn't exactly sure. It was a black liquid, and when he swirled it around, it seemed to be roughly the consistency of syrup. It was closed off with a small cork at the mouth.

Izuku carefully removed the cork, sniffing the liquid. It didn't have an obvious scent. He touched the surface with the tip of his finger. Nothing seemed to happen, but he noted that it

had a slightly sticky feel to it. All in all, however, he was no closer to understanding what the liquid was than he had been before. He wasn't dumb enough to taste it, and so he replaced the cork and washed his hands again, just in case.

He left the bathroom a moment later, and as he walked down the hall, someone called out to him.

"Midoriya!"

Izuku turned and saw Kirishima jogging toward him with a wide grin on his face, followed by Kaminari and Sero.

"Oh, hello." Izuku awkwardly said. It felt a bit strange to talk to Katsuki's friends without him around.

"Hey, man!" Sero said, with a friendly slap on the shoulder. "Glad to see you're still in one piece!"

"Impressed, more like." Kaminari said. "We thought for *sure* you were dead." Kirishima gave him a look, and Kaminari's eyes widened a bit. He rubbed his neck sheepishly. "Uhh, sorry, I just mean—"

Izuku laughed softly. "Don't worry about it. I thought I was a goner, too, multiple times. I… still kinda can't believe I actually managed to escape."

"You'll have to tell us about it at the meeting!" Kirishima said. "If that's alright with you, of course."

"Meeting…?"

"Oh, Aizawa's gonna be here soon, along with Hatsume. It's just a small meeting among some people who are around, and who are aware of the situation."

Izuku nodded. "Will Kacchan be there?"

"He better not be." Kaminari snorted. When Izuku frowned, he added, "For his own health, I mean."

"…What do you mean?" He asked, brows pinched together. "He's sick?"

"Oh, no—don't worry! There's nothing wrong with him." Kirishima assured him.

"Well…" Kaminari narrowed his eyes, doing a *'so-so'* sort of gesture.

"He's just getting some much-needed sleep." Sero said. "We're pretty sure he hasn't slept since you left."

The image of Katsuki's tired eyes came back to him, and his heart lurched in his chest. "Ahh, and… how long is that, exactly?

Kirishima gave him an odd look. “About three days.” He said. “You… don’t *know?”*

“It’s… a long story.” He winced. “I’ll explain later.”

“Well, Aizawa and Hatsume should be getting here pretty soon, so it won’t be long.” Sero said.

Izuku nodded slowly. “And, um… Where *is* Kacchan, exactly?”

“You wanna see him?” Sero asked. “He’s not gonna be awake, you know.”

“I know.” Izuku said. “I just…” He trailed off.

Kirishima pointed out a staircase near the end of the hall. “If you go down the stairs, I think it’ll be the second door on the right.”

“Thanks,” Izuku said, smiling. And after a moment of hesitation, he cleared his throat. “Well, I should probably, uhh… you know.” He gestured at the cup of urine that was still in his hand. The other three’s eyes widened, and Kaminari almost immediately started laughing.

“Oh, shit!” Kirishima said. “Uhh, sorry for keeping you, man.”

Izuku laughed softly. “No, no. Don’t worry about it!”

“Whelp,” Sero clapped his hands, grinning. “Good luck, Midoriya. May your piss be free of abnormalities.”

“And your boyfriend well-rested!” Kaminari added.

Izuku snorted softly, averting his eyes as his cheeks heated up.

Boyfriend.

That was the first time anyone had referred to Katsuki as his boyfriend.

Or Katsuki as his anything, really.

They all said their goodbyes, and Izuku headed back to the doctor’s office, the urine sample now almost room temperature.

When he was finally permitted to leave, Izuku headed strait for the stairs. He descended, and followed Kirishima’s directions until he found himself standing before a door. He pressed his ear against the wood, listening for any signs of life, before very slowly turning the doorknob.

Sure enough, Katsuki was lying in a small bed in the corner, dead asleep. Izuku gently closed the door behind him.

There was a moment during which he just stood there, not quite sure what to do. If he were being honest, he wasn’t really certain what his goal had been, in coming to see Katsuki like

this. Maybe there was a part of him that still didn't trust that all of this was actually real. That maybe his whole escape had been just another part of the illusion, and he was still up there, lying unconscious on that steel table.

As he inched closer, he saw the dark circles beneath Katsuki's eyes, visible even with his eyes closed. It made his heart feel tight, imagining Katsuki staying up, day in and day out, waiting for him. His return was far from a sure thing. Izuku wondered how long he would've kept it all up before…

"Kacchan will kill himself looking for you." The doppelgänger had told him. Tears began to well up in his eyes, but he wiped them away, taking a few deep breaths to compose himself before he moved closer.

There was a small, wooden chair near Katsuki's bed, and as Izuku sat down, he winced at the way the wood creaked. Fortunately, Katsuki didn't stir. His breathing was slow, even. And despite the obvious marks of exhaustion, Izuku couldn't help but feel enthralled by just how… *peaceful* he looked. No hard lines carved between his brows, no cocky smirk tugging at the corners of his lips. He was just… *calm.*

Izuku didn't intend to stay for long. There was a point—though he wasn't sure when, exactly—at which watching a person sleep became creepy. And with a small creak of his chair, he stood up again. Izuku was about to turn and head out, but hesitated.

He gulped, taking a few steps closer, and bending over his bedside. And then, his barrier in place, Izuku pressed his lips to Katsuki's cheek. The kiss was gentle, chaste, and as he pulled back slightly, he brushed Katsuki's bangs out of his face. Barely, a whisper, he said, "Thank you for saving me." And then he stood up straight.

Katsuki's breathing seemed to have changed, but he didn't respond. Didn't open his eyes, and after a few seconds, it returned to normal. With a sigh, Izuku turned around, careful not to make too much noise as he left the room.

"I managed to plant one."

That was the very first thing Izuku said, before he even sat down at the large, round table. Aizawa sat across from him, and Hatsume to his right. Clustered together to her right were Kirishima, Sero and Kaminari.

All of them seemed surprised to hear this statement.

"You *did?!"* Hatsume shouted. The others were already cheering in celebration.

He nodded, biting his lip. "It was the last one I had. The other three got destroyed, but I managed to hold onto one and plant it during my escape."

"Where'd you plant it?"

Izuku opened his mouth to respond, but hesitated as he realized how weird it was probably going to sound. Ultimately, he just bit the bullet. “I actually, um… planted it in an Acolyte’s stomach.”

Everyone was silent for a moment, and then Kaminari raised his hand. “I have *several* questions.” He said. “Like, first of all, *how…?”*

Izuku blushed, smiling sheepishly. “I was stuck in an illusion for most of my time up there. I’m still not a hundred percent sure, but I think the fact I was using magic when I broke out caused some sort of… power surge… that knocked the Acolyte unconscious.” He bit his lip. “So I basically just forced it down his throat.”

“Dude!” Sero laughed. “That’s so fucking sick.”

“Yeah!” Kaminari said. “That’s really—“

“—It won’t work.” Hatsume interjected.

Izuku tensed. “Sorry?”

“It’s not going to work, Midoriya.”

Izuku paled.

“Why not?!”

“Remember what we told you? It can only attach to matter that hasn’t been blessed.” She sighed. “Angels are pretty much blessed *by default.”*

For a very long time, he just sat there with his mouth hanging open. Someone sighed—Sero.

“Back to square one, I guess.”

“Don’t feel bad, man.” Kirishima told him, smiling. “We’ll—“

Then it hit him.

“—Wait.” Izuku said. “I… is there any way to check if it’s active?”

Hatsume frowned. “Well, sure, but it’s not going to be. Again, Angels are—”

“—No, but that’s the thing! I…” He gulped. “The thing is, I don’t think Acolytes are… actually Angels.” He said. “At least… not technically.”

Aizawa raised his eyebrows. “How do you figure that?”

“While I was up there, I actually, um… saw one being created.”

Everyone went silent, leaning forward as they waited for him to continue. Izuku sighed, closing his eyes. The event was still fresh on his mind, and the memory of the sounds from within that… *machine*... echoed inside his skull.

Kirishima broke the silence. “Hey, man. You alright?”

“Y-Yeah.” He stammered, staring down at his lap. “Just…”

He closed his eyes. Took a long, deep breath, and exhaled slowly.

“So, without going into *too* much detail about the actual…” He winced, “Uh, process…” He swallowed. “Acolytes, at least from what I could tell, are created by exposing an Angel to both divine light and corruption damage simultaneously.” He kept his eyes closed, so he couldn’t see their expressions. No one dared to speak. “Given what I saw, I don’t think it’s correct to call them Angels, but they’re not Demons, either. It’s, like… something in between, maybe.“

When he eventually looked up, he found Aizawa staring at him with his brows pinched together, as if contemplating this very intensely. Hatsume, on the other hand, had pulled out a touchpad of some kind. She spent a few minutes tapping at it before her eyes widened.

“Holy shit, he’s right.” She whispered, and then looked up at the others. “There’s a signal! It’s not finished taking root, but it’s clearly active.”

Izuku felt a rush of relief as the others cheered once more. When eventually everyone settled down, Aizawa began speaking again.

“Well, that’s certainly a revelation.” He said dryly. “Anything else you can tell us? Within your own comfort, of course.”

“Hmm, well…” Izuku chewed his lip, looking up in thought. Finally, he shrugged. “I guess maybe I should just start at the beginning.”

And so, Izuku spent the next half hour recounting his time in Heaven, from his capture to his escape, though he glossed over some of the details for the sake of keeping his composure. Still, it was a mentally draining experience. He was happy to help, of course, but that didn’t make it any less exhausting.

When the meeting eventually came to a close, Aizawa asked if there was anything he’d neglected to mention. It was then that he pulled out the vial, and slid it across the table.

“I found this in my pocket earlier.” He said. Aizawa held it between his fingers, squinting as he examined it

“What is it?” He asked, handing it off to Hatsume. She held it up against the overhead light as she looked at it.

“I don’t know.” Izuku replied. “It doesn’t smell like anything, and it’s kind of sticky, but I still have no idea.”

Aizawa blinked. “You just… touched it?”

“I… yes.”

“In general, you should avoid smelling or touching unknown substances.” Hatsume told him.

“I hope you didn’t try to taste it.” Aizawa said, sounding very tired.

“N-No, of course not.” Izuku shook his head.

“So you have some common sense, at least.” He sighed. “Well, we’ll send this to a lab and see if they can figure it out. In the meantime, if you come across any other strange chemicals… for fuck’s sake, don’t touch them with your *bare hands,* okay, kid?”

Izuku looked down, blushing. “Yes, sir.”

“I told you not to call me that.”

“Yes, si—okay.” Izuku cleared himself. “Yes. Got it.”

It was quiet, apart from the sound of distant wind and gentle waves. Izuku opened his eyes to find himself standing atop a large boulder, protruding from a vast sea of red. As he looked at his feet, at the liquid surrounding the boulder, he noted that the space was well-lit, reminiscent of dawn. But when he looked toward the sky, he saw only an infinite expanse of darkness.

And standing in front of him was a large, wooden door. There were intricate patterns carved into its frame, and the longer he looked at it, the more strange he felt. He got the sense that this door had existed for a very, very long time.

But the most bizarre part was that it did not seem to go anywhere. It simply stood there, disembodied.

He considered trying to open it, but figured he should look around first. As he scanned the horizon, he saw nothing of note. Just a firm dividing line between the red ocean and the abyssal sky.

But then he turned around, and that’s when he saw it.

Out there, in the distance, there sat a small island, the majority of which was clutched beneath the roots of an enormous tree. Izuku’s eyes ran up its trunk, to where it split off into a wide span of branches that stretched out into the sky in sprawling patterns.

But the longer he stared at it, the more Izuku nervous he started to feel. He just couldn’t shake the feeling that he was not supposed to be here.

And so, he turned around and reached for the door handle, attempting to open it.

But it would not budge.

Just then, he heard the sound of fluid moving, and turned just as the first stepping stone emerged. It was a small, flat platform, just in front of the boulder on which he stood, and as

soon as it broke the surface, another one appeared after it. Then another. It didn't take long for him to recognize this event for what it was:

An invitation.

One Izuku wasn't sure he wanted to accept, but then… Well, what other choice did he have?

Swallowing his anxiety, Izuku took that first step, and then the next, careful not to slip in the red fluid that still dampened the surface of the stone.

And as he watched the island growing closer and closer, he struggled to make sense of his own emotions. The nervousness began to dissipate, replaced instead with a sort of calm sense of inevitability. He was afraid, but the fear did not drive him to seek a way out. He was curious, but it was muted, because somehow, he knew that there was no resolution. No explanation that could sate him in any meaningful way.

He could feel the power of the place, but could sense neither benevolence nor malice behind it. The power did not seem to exist for any particular end, it just… *existed.* And as he drew ever closer, he got the feeling that it had always existed.

Izuku eventually reached the island, and carefully stepped off the platform. He walked around the tree, stepping over its thick roots as he examined it. Its roots spanned the island, extending just near the shore. As he got closer, he noticed that the tree seemed to be moving slightly, its trunk expanding and contracting, as though it were breathing. And when he got around to the back, he found a small tap protruding from it, not unlike the ones he'd seen used to collect sap.

The tide washed in, touching the tips of the tree's roots, and he watched as they seemed to swell for a moment, before they relaxed again. Curious, he got down on his knees, careful not to touch the roots as he kneeled by the shore. And with a shaky hand, he reached out and touched the red water.

But as soon as his fingers made contact, he gasped, thousands of images immediately inundating his mind. Izuku yanked his hand away, as though he'd been burned. He clutched his wrist with his other hand, and groaned as his head ached.

What the hell was that?

The images had flashed through his mind faster than he could perceive them, overloading his brain with stimuli. But as he sat there, gasping for air, he gradually started to feel it, the shift in his mental state.

He was *miserable.*

It came like a black cloud over his mind, a sort of hopeless darkness that threatened to swallow him whole.

It was terrifying. The tide came in, and the roots swelled up yet again. Izuku looked over his shoulder, at the massive tree behind him, and felt as though he were kneeling at the feet of

something incomprehensibly vast. Some primordial existence that he was never really meant to know about, much less understand.

His eyes watering, he slowly looked up, tracing the tree's long trunk as it stretched into the black sky and split off into dozens of branches, long, sharp and jagged. And he realized that he couldn't actually see the ends of most of them. They simply faded away, disappearing into the furthest reaches of the expanse.

Izuku looked out toward the sea, at the horizon, and then the shoreline. The red liquid ebbed and flowed in soft waves. He looked back at the tree again, at the ashen bark that covered its body. And with a shaky hand, he reached out.

But before he could actually touch it, he heard a sudden clicking noise. Heart pounding, he turned to look in the direction he'd heard it from. The direction he'd come from. And he tensed.

The door was open.

Izuku woke with a start, snapping upright in bed. He clutched the front of his sleep shirt as he gasped. He frantically looked around, eyes scanning the dark room. He wasn't sure what he was looking for. It took him a moment to fully grasp reality.

Oh, that's right. He remembered. *I'm at the base. I'm… safe.*

Still, the images remained in his mind, fresh and vivid, as though he'd actually been there. He wanted to brush it off as merely a dream, but something about it just… bothered him. Without thinking about it, Izuku found himself staring down at his hand. The one he'd touched the black substance with.

He shook himself, turning to look at the clock. It was just past four in the morning. Still too early to get up.

With an uneasy breath, he forced himself to lie down again. He lay there, on his back, staring up at the ceiling, the sound of his own heartbeat in his ears. He honestly wasn't sure he'd be able to fall asleep again, but miraculously, he managed to drift off not two minutes later.

This time, his dreams were as they ought to be: forgettable.

When Izuku awoke next, it was to the sound of someone shouting just outside the room. He blinked blearily, eyes drawn to the door, where he could see movement in the way the light that leaked in flickered.

And just then, the doorknob started to turn. Izuku froze, but when he saw who was on the other side, all tension melted away from his body.

"See? You woke him up." Todoroki said, his tone lightly chastising. Inasa looked down sheepishly.

“Ah, right. Sorry, Midoriya!”

Izuku just shook his head, not really thinking to respond verbally. He was too busy detangling himself from the sheets and scrambling out of bed, a wide grin on his face. He made a beeline for Todoroki, holding his barrier as he wrapped his arms around him. After a second, Todoroki returned the hug, patting him on the back. Izuku pulled away a moment later, turning to hug Inasa, as well. He laughed, arms constricting around his back so hard, his back actually cracked.

“Inasa.” Todoroki said.

“Right, sorry.” His hold loosened enough for him to breathe, and then fell away entirely as Izuku stepped back.

“What’re you guys doing here?”

“We couldn’t make it yesterday, but we wanted to see you.” Todoroki said.

“We’ve been really worried about you,” Inasa added. “Everyone has. It’s been a rough few days!”

Todoroki nodded, his eyes drifting away. “I… honestly thought I’d never see you again, so…” He trailed off.

Izuku swallowed, his throat feeling tight as he looked at the ground. “For a while up there, I thought the same.”

For a moment, it was quiet—words just hanging in the air between the three of them. The sound of a new voice broke the silence.

“Oh hey, he’s up!”

Izuku turned and saw Kaminari approaching, along with Kirishima, Sero, Jirou and Mina, who—upon closer inspection—appeared to be crying. She pushed past the others and started running toward him, and the sight activated his fight-or-flight response. He started backing away.

“Oh h-hey, Mina. It’s nice to—“

She all but launched herself at him, arms coiling around his body with all the strength of a boa constrictor, easily knocking the wind out of him. Izuku barely managed to put his barrier up in time.

“Midoriya!” She sobbed. “I’m so happy you’re safe! We thought you were a goner!”

“Me… too…?” He wheezed, reflexively struggling against her grip. She did not appear to register it. It was only after Kirishima put his hand on her shoulder than she seemed to realize that she was, in fact, suffocating him. She released him abruptly, hopping back.

“Ah, whoopsies!” She waved her hands around. “Sorry!”

“I-It’s okay,” Izuku replied, still a bit winded.

“She’s got a point, though.” Jirou chimed in. “I mean, of course we did all we could to help Bakugou, but… honestly, we thought you were done for.”

“Has this even happened before?” Kaminari asked. “I mean like, an Angel escaping after being captured.”

“Not intact.” Sero shook his head. “There’ve been a few cases where an Angel managed to escape by Falling, but this is pretty much unheard of. Once they clip your wings, you’re fucked, unless…”

“You’ve got someone waiting to catch you!” Inasa said.

“So manly.” Kirishima wiped a fake tear from beneath his eye.

“Oh, speaking of—is sleeping beauty up yet?” Kaminari asked.

“Nah,” Sero replied. “I checked an hour ago. He’s as good as dead.”

“So that means…” A grin slowly spread across Kaminari’s face. “We have Midoriya all to ourselves.”

Izuku swallowed, looking around nervously. “Uhh…”

Jirou elbowed Kaminari. “Don’t say it like that. It’s *weird.”*

“He’s right, though!” Mina said. “We should do something! Go somewhere fun!”

“That’d be cool!” Kirishima grinned, turning to face Izuku fully. “No pressure, of course. If you’re too tired, we get it.”

“No, I’m fine.” Izuku shook his head. “It’s just, uhh…” He rubbed the back of his neck sheepishly. “Well, it’d need to be somewhere sort of nearby, considering…” He weakly gestured back at his wings, and the others nodded in understanding.

“There’s that old theme park nearby.” Kaminari said. “Maybe some of the rides still work.”

Everyone nodded, seeming generally amenable. “What do you think, Midoriya?”

Izuku hummed. “Sure, it sounds fun.” He glanced at Todoroki. “Will you come, too?”

Todoroki nodded, with a slight smile.

The others cheered and high-fived. “Alright!” Kaminari shouted. “Let’s do this!”

The park was about a half hour away on foot, just on the outskirts of a nearby town. Izuku stayed near the back of the group, walking alongside Todoroki and Inasa, the latter of whom was loudly chatting about something Izuku was too zoned out to really take note of.

As soon as they passed beneath the archway, the group spread out, everyone eager to look around the abandoned attractions. One of the first rides they encountered was the merry-go-round. It stood there, rusty and discolored, the paint stripped in some places. It made the horses look less whimsical and more like something out of a horror movie.

Kaminari, Mina and Kirishima immediately set out to try and get it running, but when the switch didn't work, Kaminari directed the others to stand back.

Izuku frowned. "What's he doing?"

Sero threw him a look, over his shoulder. "Taking part in the ancient tradition of hitting shit to make it work."

And just then, lightning shot out from his hands, striking the control panel. It glowed slightly on impact, and a second later, the music came on, and the ride slowly started to move. Kaminari, Mina, Inasa and Kirishima all cheered, high-fiving each other as they all ran to get on the merry-go-round like excited children. Izuku stayed behind with Todoroki, Jirou and Sero.

"You're not gonna get on?" Todoroki asked him, with a subtly ironic sort of glint in his eye.

Izuku eyed one of the horses, on which someone had spray-painted a large dick. He raised an eyebrow. "Yeah, I think I'm okay."

For a moment, they all just stood and watched, but it didn't take long for Izuku to realize that something was wrong with it.

He glanced at Jirou, whose expression was somewhere between concern and amusement.

"Is it…?"

"Yup." She said. "It… sure is."

The speed of the merry-go-round was steadily increasing.

"Uh, guys?" Sero called out. "Maybe you should…?"

Todoroki shook his head. "It's too fast, now."

The sound of joyous shouting quickly became… less joyous.

"Hey!" Mina screamed. "Someone turn this thing off!"

Izuku ran for the controls, pulling lever to turn it off.

…Nothing happened.

"Oh dear." He gulped.

“Shit.” Sero muttered, striding over to the edge of the merry-go-round. He glanced back at the others. “Everyone cover your ears!”

After a second of hesitation, Izuku did as he said and watched as Sero adjusted his stance, and extended his arms, almost as if he were throwing something. He could tell the moment it stuck from the way he stumbled and struggled not to get dragged along with the pull. And with it came the sound of metal screeching, gears grinding together. He pressed his palms harder against his ears, but it still made him cringe.

It took a good minute for him to slow the merry-go-round enough for the others to get off, and by then, he was visibly sweating. Kirishima stumbled toward the center and with a firm punch, he destroyed some part of the machinery, which allowed Sero to release his hold.

They all stumbled off in various states of disorientation. Kirishima and Inasa managed to stay on their feet, but Kaminari and Mina both immediately collapsed onto the ground. The sound of retching caught Izuku’s attention, and he jogged over to where Kaminari was crouching, vomiting.

“Are you okay?” He asked, putting a hand on his shoulder.

Kaminari said something he couldn’t make out.

“Sorry?” Izuku said. “What was that?”

Kaminari sat up, wiping the bile from his lip as he looked at Izuku, eyes water. He smiled. “That was *awesome.”*

Izuku was taken aback, but in retrospect, he knew he probably shouldn’t have been.

After testing out a few more rides, the group shifted their focus to the food and game stalls, and that was how Izuku found himself standing before a snow cone stand, watching as the others loaded a block of freshly-frozen ice into the machine, courtesy of Todoroki. When they realized it was broken, Kirishima put the ice in a bowl and resorted to just punching it to a fine slush.

They found the syrup in a box in a cabinet below the counter, and offered the first snow cone to Inasa. With a smile, he took a bite, and his expression remained the same as he swallowed it.

“How is it?” Todoroki asked.

Cheerfully, Inasa replied, “It’s the worst snow cone I’ve ever had! Thank you!”

Izuku couldn’t help but laugh.

Half an hour later, they attempted something similar at the cotton candy booth, but miraculously, the machine actually worked that time. Sero held a thin, paper cone as Kaminari poured something pink and granular into the center, and Izuku watched, entranced, as webs of pink slowly started to collect around the cone.

When a substantial amount had accumulated, Sero offered it to Izuku, and he hesitantly took it. “Um… you’re sure this is *edible?”*

Mina laughed. “Yeah, sweetie. We’re sure.”

Izuku hesitated only a moment longer before he just shrugged, bringing it closer to his mouth. He wasn’t really sure how he was supposed to eat it, but he managed to get a small clump of it between his teeth. As the fluff touched his tongue, he froze.

It was sweet. Sweeter than anything Izuku could remember tasting before, and it melted on his tongue.

Izuku immediately went for a bigger bite, and then another one.

“Woah, slow down!” Kirishima said. “You’re gonna give yourself a stomach ache, dude!”

Izuku blushed, nearly dropping the cotton candy. “R-Right.” He stammered. “Um.” He glanced at Todoroki, offering it to him instead. He pulled off a small piece of it, tasting it, looking up thoughtfully. After a moment, he started to walk away, beckoning for Izuku to follow him.

They wound up around the corner, just out of sight of the others. There, Todoroki immediately pulled off a much larger piece. “Wait, but he said—“

“If I want to make myself sick, that is my right.” He deadpanned, before stuffing the cotton candy into his mouth. After a second of hesitation, Izuku smiled, pulling off an even larger piece.

Can’t argue with that.

They did, in fact, make themselves sick.

No more than a few minutes went by before Izuku felt the stir of nausea in his stomach, and Jirou suggested they find a place to sit down for a while.

And so, they found themselves sitting in the grass beneath the shade of a large oak tree.

“See, that’s the problem with cotton candy.” Kaminari said. “It’s good for like, the first fifteen seconds or so, and then it reaches you’re brain and you’re left wondering why you ever wanted to eat it in the first place.”

“That’s… not how digestion works, Denki.” Jirou said, patting him on the shoulder.

“Makes a good point though, even if his reasoning doesn’t make sense.” Sero shrugged. “You gotta be careful, ‘specially if you’re not accustomed to sweets.”

Izuku nodded slowly, so as not to exacerbate his nausea. Todoroki was simply laying on his back, staring at the sky with a vaguely uncomfortable expression. Inasa sat beside him, smoothing his bangs out of his face.

“Man,” Kaminari sighed. “This is one of the things I really miss about Earth. Theme parks like this.”

“Uh.” Kirishima raised an eyebrow. “You go to Tenth Circle like once a month, man.”

Izuku blinked. “Tenth Circle?”

“It’s a theme park in Hell.” Mina supplied.

“The theme park.” Kaminari said. “It’s the only one. It’s fun, but… I dunno, the feeling’s different. It just doesn’t have that same carnival atmosphere, y’know?”

Sero scoffed. “Atmosphere? You mean like, carnival games where little kids get scammed while trying to win prizes made by *other* little kids? That atmosphere?”

“Yeah!” Kaminari said, snapping his fingers. “It’s that ‘casino, but make it for kids’ type of feeling, you know? I miss it.”

Mina patted Kaminari on the head. “Sometimes nostalgia is flawed.”

“I like Tenth Circle.”

Kirishima smiled. “Remember that time Bakugou broke the high-striker?”

“How could I forget?” Kaminari snorted. “It was the only time he agreed to go with us.”

“‘High-striker’?” Izuku cocked his head.

“It’s that carnival game where you hit a button thingy with a giant hammer and it makes this little weight go flying up.” Mina explained. “You’re trying to hit it hard enough to ring the bell at the top!”

“Ohh.” Izuku’s eyes widened slightly as he remembered. “Wait, so Kacchan broke that? *How?”*

Kirishima hummed. “Basically, he hit it so hard the bell got knocked off.”

Izuku’s brows pinched together. “Wait, but… he’s a Wrath Demon. Doesn’t that give him an unfair advantage?”

“See, that’s the thing.” Sero shook his head. “He wasn’t actually using magic at the time. He kind of just… *did* it.”

Izuku blinked. “You mean, just… with his own strength?” The others nodded. “I… don’t understand.”

“Welcome to the club.” Kaminari deadpanned. “Freakin’ cartoon logic ass shit.”

Kirishima laughed. “But it was kinda my fault, honestly.” He sighed. “I shouldn’t have challenged him in the first place. He’s *way* too competitive.”

Izuku imagined it. Katsuki holding a heavy mallet, slamming it down on the base of the contraption. The weight hitting the bell so hard enough to send it flying. Izuku pulled his knees up toward his chest, his face heating up slightly. "…Wow." He muttered.

"It was awkward having to explain that to the attendants there." Jirou said. "So awkward, Bakugou's vowed never to go back."

Izuku frowned. "Oh…"

He couldn't mask the disappointment in his tone.

"Oh, he'd go with you." Sero said, sounding very sure of himself.

"What, really?"

"Oh yeah." Kaminari agreed. "He'd move fucking mountains for you, Midoriya. You've got his heart by the balls."

"'Heart by the balls.' What a strange and unsettling mental image that is." Jirou said, wincing.

Izuku just shook his head. "I-I don't know about that."

"Oh, no. He's totally right." Mina said. "Bakugou's *whipped."*

"He literally never shuts up about you." Kaminari deadpanned. Kirishima simply nodded solemnly.

"It was shocking for all of us." Kaminari said. "'Cuz like, early on, whenever he mentioned you, he kinda just acted how he does about a lot of people. Like, vaguely annoyed by your existence." He paused for a moment, staring blankly at the sky. "Everything changed when one fateful party came around."

The others collectively groaned.

"Wh-What happened there?"

"He got plastered." Jirou said. "Started ranting about how cute you were."

Mina tugged at her own hair. "Ahh, I'm still so mad I wasn't there to see it."

"If you saw him like that, he'd probably kill you just to keep you quiet." Jirou snorted.

"But still!" She sighed.

"So yeah." Sero said. "That's how we all found out he was into you."

"I-I see…" Izuku gulped. "Well, that's… nice, I suppose." He laughed awkwardly.

"Oh, it was a lot more than just *nice."* Kaminari said.

“Dude…” Kirishima gave him a warning look.

“Oh, c’mon.” He groaned. “What’re we here for if not to embarrass Bakugou in front of his boyfriend?”

“It’s your funeral, I guess.” Sero shrugged.

Seeming to take that as a cue to continue, Kaminari leaned in closer, and began to speak in a tone Izuku could only describe as *conspiratorial.* “See, the thing about Bakugou is… he’s a horny drunk.” He said. And almost immediately, Izuku’s cheeks flushed so hot, he wondered if he was glowing. “You get him fucked up enough, and he’ll try to fuck his own shadow.”

“Well, you need to give him, like… a pillow, or a stress ball, or something.” Sero added.

Mina nodded. “He calms down if he has something to squeeze.”

“Oh, right. Why is that, d’you think?” Kaminari looked up in thought. “I’ve always wondered about it…”

Sero blinked, giving Kaminari a blank stare. “He’s a sadist, my guy.” He told him, in a distressingly offhand sort of way. “Really doesn’t take a genius to figure that one out.”

“Look, whatever. It doesn’t matter.” Kaminari waved his hands dismissively. “Anyway, a little while back, he got wasted at our friend’s birthday party and wound up going off on this big rant about you. It got…” He squinted, pursing his lips. “Uhh… *explicit.”*

“A-Ah.” Izuku squeaked. “I… see.”

“I was also pretty drunk at the time, though, so I don’t really remember a lot of what he actually said.”

“I remember!” Inasa shouted, so suddenly Izuku jumped. “He said he wanted to ‘fuck some sense into him’!”

Izuku was burning up. “Uhh, that’s… um.”

“Guys. C’mon.” Kirishima groaned. “Don’t make him uncomfortable.”

“I-It’s okay! Really!” Izuku said, waving his hands. “I’m not, uhhh…” He trailed off for a moment. “Sorry, *when* was this exactly…?”

“Around the middle of January.” Kaminari said.

Izuku’s eyes widened, but he said nothing else.

The middle of January. The words echoed in his head.

That’s less than a month into our partnership.

After their stomaches settled, they set off into the park again. Izuku trailed behind the group, walking alongside Todoroki. They came to a stop near a rollercoaster, and Izuku watched nervously as a couple of the others attempted to get it up and running. It was then that Todoroki spoke.

“Is it true?” He asked. “You stabbed an Acolyte in the eye?”

Izuku blinked, going stiff. “Oh, y-yeah.” He laughed awkwardly. “They told you about that?”

“Mm.” He said. “That’s impressive. Their strength is… well, it’s no joke.”

Izuku offered a wobbly smile. “It was all just adrenaline. At that moment, I just… did what I needed to survive.”

Todoroki nodded quietly.

Just then, the roller coaster came to life and the others high-fived each other in celebration. “Midoriya, Todoroki! Are you getting on?” Mina called out.

“Ah, no thanks!” Izuku called back. Todoroki just shook his head. Izuku glanced at Todoroki and remarked, “I don’t have that much of a death wish.”

Todoroki smiled.

A minute went by as they nervously watched Mina, Kaminari and Kirishima piling onto the cart as it began to move. So far, so good.

“I heard you found out how they were created.”

Izuku froze, memories of hiding inside the locker resurfacing. Staring through the slits in the door, as Endeavor was strapped down in the chair.

Endeavor.

Todoroki’s father.

Should I tell him…?

Izuku glanced at Todoroki nervously, but got no clues from his expression. He frowned, looking down at the ground.

He must already know, right? His father was next in line to become an Acolyte. Todoroki told me that himself.

“…Midoriya?”

“Ah!” Izuku jumped, turning toward him again.

Todoroki blinked. “Sorry. I didn’t mean to scare you.”

“It’s okay,” He waved his hands. “You’re, uhh, you’re right. Though, I wouldn’t say I found out so much as I was… subjected to it.” He said, with a nervous laugh. Izuku reached up, rubbing the back of his neck. “Listen, Todoroki, about—“

“I know.” Todoroki interjected. Izuku looked up, and found him staring straight ahead, watching the roller coaster as it ran through a loop. “It’s fine,” He muttered. “I… kind of figured.”

Silence, then, apart from the sound of the others screaming and laughing as the roller coaster went through its last drop, and then rolled back to where it started. Sero and Inasa got on with them, and the five of them went again.

Izuku just stood there for a minute, not really sure how to continue the conversation.

“You’re not planning on going back, right?” Todoroki then asked.

Izuku hesitated for a moment before he replied. “No. I mean, even if I *wanted* to I wouldn’t be able to…” He trailed off. “Why do you ask?”

“I just noticed you’re still holding your barrier around us, is all.”

“…Oh.”

A pause.

“So,” Todoroki said. “What’s your plan, then?”

Izuku’s brows pinched together. “I don’t really have a plan, exactly. I’m kind of just…” He shook his head. “I don’t know. ”

He hummed. “Do you *want* to be a Demon?”

“I… suppose so?”

“You don’t sound that sure.”

“I guess it’s…” Izuku sighed. “I don’t know. I guess I don’t really see any particular reason to stay an Angel, but at the same time, I’m kind of hesitant to make a choice I can’t go back on.” He paused, chewing his lip. “But then again, I’m kind of useless if I can’t fly. Becoming a Demon seems like the fastest solution.”

“I… don’t think you should be thinking about an irreversible change to your body in terms of how useful to others it would theoretically make you.”

“That’s not what I meant,” He was quick to say. Todoroki side-eyed him knowingly, and Izuku averted his eyes. “Okay, that’s not *all* I meant.”

Todoroki laughed softly.

“In all seriousness,” He then said. “If all you want is to be able to fly again, you don’t have to become a Demon to do it. There are other options—other than just letting your feathers grow out, I mean.”

“Really?” Izuku raised an eyebrow. “Err, like what?”

“You can have your flight feathers replaced.” He replied. “It’s apparently a pretty simple procedure. They just remove whatever’s left of the old feathers and implant synthetic ones.”

“Wait, seriously?”

He nodded. “In some ways, it’s actually better. Most of the newer synthetic feathers are designed to be very difficult to cut.” He shrugged. “Of course, someone could still try to pull them out. But I think the adhesive they use is supposed to be pretty strong—enough for most situations, anyway.”

“Wow. They do this in *Hell?”* Izuku tilted his head.

“Mm.” He nodded. “I mean, obviously it’s not a very common procedure. The only Demons who actually *have* feathered wings are Fallen Angels, after all. The only reason I know about it is because I’m planning to fight. A lot of Fallen Angels do it as a precaution, I guess.”

“Huh…” Izuku scratched his head. “You know, now that I think about it, I wonder why Heaven never tried to do something like that…”

He shrugged. “Part of it might be because higher-level Angels usually have multiple sets of wings, anyway, so the risk isn’t quite as high.” He muttered. “But other than that, I’m not really sure. I feel like the more time I spend in Hell, the less I’m able to understand about Heaven.”

Izuku nodded slowly. After a moment, he cleared his throat. “Well, that’s, uhhh… certainly something to think about, I guess…” He bit his lip. “That’s… not the only reason I have to Fall, though.”

“Oh?” Izuku didn’t say anything, but his cheeks heated up. Todoroki tilted his head. “Midoriya?”

“It’s…” His eyes darted around. “Well… You know.”

“I don’t.” He said, monotone. But Izuku could tell from the subtle glimmer of amusement in his eyes that it was all an act. He shot him a weak glare, and turned away.

“I just… want Kacchan to be able to touch me.” He sighed. “Happy?”

“Yes.” He replied. Izuku scoffed. “Well, if that’s the case, then yeah. Falling does kind of seem like your only real option.”

Izuku ran his fingers through his hair, and after a moment, he asked, “Does it… hurt?” He swallowed. “Falling, I mean.”

Todoroki hummed thoughtfully. “No. Not physically, at least. It was…” He hesitated. “Traumatic, I guess. I think that’s how it is for a lot of Angels… but I can’t think of any reason why it would *have* to be that way. If you willingly Fall through corruption damage, I’d imagine you wouldn’t feel any sort of distress at all. Much less pain.”

Izuku felt some of the tension easing from his frame. “Well, that’s good to know.”

After a pause, Todoroki said, “If you want, I could help you.”

“Sorry?”

“I could help you Fall.” He shrugged. “I’m not sure how long it’d take from where you are, but if I maintain contact, it’ll happen eventually.”

“Oh.” Izuku said, blinking. “Ah, no, that’s alright. Thank you, though.”

He cocked his head. “Are you still unsure?”

“No,” Izuku bit his lip, looking down “At this point, I think I’m pretty sure. It’s just…”

Todoroki stared at him for a moment longer, and then smiled.

“You’re waiting for him, aren’t you.” He said, as a statement of fact, rather than a question. “You want him to be the one who…” He trailed off. He didn’t need to say anything more.

Izuku flushed, offering the smallest of nods.

“Well, I don’t blame you. I think if I had the option, that’s what I would’ve done with Inasa…” He paused, humming. “Though, in that case, I should probably amend what I said before. If you go that route, it’ll probably hurt a bit.”

Izuku’s brow furrowed. “What do you mean?”

Todoroki looked over at him, a playful glint in his eye.

Izuku’s eyes went wide. He felt like his face was on *fire.*

“T-Todoroki!”

And as if on cue, that was when Inasa came running over. “Midoriya!” He shouted. Or spoke normally. It was hard for Izuku to really distinguish between the two, with him. “He’s awake!”

Izuku gasped. *“Really?!”*

“Yep! Well, unless he somehow called me in his sleep. But!” He grinned. “He said he wants to talk to you.”

Izuku gulped, suddenly hit with a cocktail of conflicting emotions. “O-Oh…?”

He nodded. “He wants you to meet him in a church nearby.”

Izuku blinked. “A church?”

“I believe he said something about wanting to, *‘yell at you in a sufficiently echoey location.’”*

Sero snorted as he approached, followed by the rest of the group. Apart from him, they all appeared visibly disoriented. “So dramatic.” He shook his head.

“We’ll take you there!” Mina said.

Kaminari scoffed. “We’re just going to escort Midoriya to his own murder like that?”

“Ooh, yeah. You might be right.” She said sheepishly. “If you want us to smuggle you somewhere else, we can do that, too!”

“Yeah, man. We’ll put you in Bakugou Katsuki Witness Protection, *copyright-tradement-all-rights-reserved.”*

Jirou snorted.

“Oh, c’mon, guys.” Kirishima rolled his eyes. “It’s not gonna be *that* bad.”

“No.” Todoroki suddenly said, a slight smile on his face. “It’s definitely going to be that bad.”

Izuku pointedly looked away. Something told him that the scenario in Todoroki’s head was very different from the one in Kaminari’s.

They did end up escorting Izuku to the church, in the end, and as they climbed the hill, Kaminari pointed out a church at the end of the road. “This is it?”

“Mm.” Jirou said. “It must be.”

Izuku cleared his throat. “Well, I think I’ll be okay from here, guys, but…” he wrung his wrists. “Thanks.” He offered a wobbly smile. “I had a lot of fun today.”

Mina grabbed him by the shoulders and started shaking him back and forth. “Midoriya! You can’t keep being this cute, it’s not *fair!”*

Kirishima put a hand on her shoulder, and she threw a pouty look back at him, but backed off nonetheless.

“Thanks for humoring us. Bakugou picked a good one!” Kirishima said, with a smile and a thumbs-up.

Izuku’s cheeks dusted pink. “Ah, um… thanks.”

Kaminari suddenly stepped up, his arms outstretched. “Can I give you a hug before Bakugou murders you?”

“Denki.” Jirou muttered.

“What? We all know that’s why he’s called him here. He’s gonna tear him a new one.”

Sero closed his eyes, pinching the bridge of his nose. “You’re not helping the situation by freaking him out like that.”

“I-It’s okay,” Izuku waved his hands. “I’m sure it’ll be fine, though.”

“Well, in any case—“ Kaminari held out his arms again, and with a gentle smile, Izuku acquiesced, allowing him to pull him into a hug.

“I want a hug, too!” Mina shouted.

And so began Izuku’s hugging tour. They all said their goodbyes, with everyone telling him something to the effect of, ‘good luck.’ Everyone except Todoroki.

As Izuku pulled away from the hug, Todoroki looked him in the eye and said: “Have fun.”

Izuku flushed, opting not to respond as he started down the road, waving at the others one last time before setting his sights on the church. It was a smaller one—appropriate for a small town like this one. But even without any sort of special magical intuition, Izuku swore he could feel Katsuki’s presence even from all the way down the road, heavy and bright.

It was around sunset, and the sky was painted in shades of orange, pink and violet. The others had already taken off, and the only thing he could hear was the sound of cicadas buzzing, of gravel shifting beneath his footfalls. He reached the church a minute later, slowly climbing the steps. Then he reached out, put his hand on the door handle, and paused.

Izuku closed his eyes, taking a few deep breaths. “It’s okay.” He told himself. “It’s just Kacchan. It’s *just* Kacchan.”

And with a sharp intake of breath, he hauled the door open, spilling golden light across the pews that fanned out until it reached the altar. And it was there that he found him, sitting half-shifted, one muddy boot propped up on the edge of the altar, dirtying the once-pristine, white fabric. And for a moment, he couldn’t help but feel nostalgic. It was this way, too, that Izuku found him the first time, all those months ago.

Different place, same Katsuki.

His tail flicked behind him as he looked up, eyes glowing in the dim light.

“Deku.” He said.

Just that. Nothing else.

And try as he did, Izuku couldn’t read his mood from that one word, his tone was far too ambiguous, and that only made him more nervous.

He gulped, and smiled nervously. “H-Hey, Kacchan.” He said, stepping inside. The door shut behind him heavily, like the lid of a coffin. For a minute, he just stood there, staring at Katsuki warily from across the room.

“Baldy said you were hangin’ out with him and the rest of the dipshit brigade.”

“Oh.” Izuku cleared his throat, looking away. “Yes, actually. We, uh, went to this old, abandoned theme park. It was fun.” He offered a small smile. “They’re all really nice.”

“So was Ted Bundy.”

Izuku almost choked on his own spit.

“Uhh, sorry—*what?”*

“M’just saying.” He shrugged. “If you find yourself in a situation where a flock of weirdos you’ve barely fuckin’ spoken to are tryna take you to a *second location*… I dunno, maybe think twice about goin’ along with it.” Katsuki pulled out an apple, wiped it off on his shirt and then brought it to his lips. He sunk his teeth into it, with a sharp crunch. “Just a little *self-preservation* advice.”

Izuku winced at the subtle bite to his words. “Well, sure, but… they’re your friends, Kacchan.” He muttered. “I trust them because I trust you.”

Katsuki stared at him for a moment, and then sighed.

“…Aizawa filled me in on everything.”

Izuku felt some of the tension ease from his shoulders. “So you knew that—“

“—It was a trap?” Katsuki interjected. “Yeah. I know.” He took another bite. And then for several seconds, it was silent, apart from the sound of his chewing.

But eventually, Izuku worked up the nerve to speak again.

“I’m sorry.” He told him. “F-For lying to you.” He swallowed the lump in his throat. “Even though it wouldn’t have changed the outcome… I’m still sorry. I promise I… won’t do anything that reckless again.” Katsuki snorted, and the sound was so sharp, Izuku almost jumped. Even from this distance, he could still see the look of incredulity on his face. Izuku met it with a sheepish smile. “Okay, I promise I will seriously *try* not to do anything that reckless again…?”

Katsuki scoffed. “God,” He groaned. “You’re such an asshole, you know that, nerd?” He set the half-eaten apple down on the altar, and leaned back on his hands. And then, in a much softer tone, he said, “It just had to be you, didn’t it?”

The words hung in the air for a while. Katsuki never specified what he meant, but Izuku knew. Could feel the meaning burning deep into his body like a brand.

It just had to be you that I fell for.

Izuku wasn't sure how long they stayed there, stuck in limbo. But eventually, Katsuki sighed again.

"Apology accepted."

Izuku blinked, just staring at him for a few seconds. "Wait… seriously?" He squeaked. "Just like that? Y-You're not going to…"

"What? Punish you?" Katsuki snorted. "You should know by now, nerd. That's not what we're about." He paused, and then a smirk slowly spread across his face. "I won't punish you… unless you *want* me to."

Oh.

Izuku gulped, wiping his sweaty palms on the back of his robe as discreetly as he could manage.

"Besides," Katsuki grunted. "Based on what Aizawa said, I'm guessing you've been through more than enough bullshit without me arbitrarily adding to it." With a sigh, he stood up, stretching his arms over his head. He picked up the apple again and took another bite. "Frankly, we're just as much at fault, if not more. We should've known it wouldn't be that easy, but we let you go through with it anyway."

Izuku frowned. "I'm an adult, Kacchan. I made the choice to—"

"—Take part in an official military operation?" He cut in, tone sickly sweet. He rolled his eyes. "Deku, *baby.* You're not separate from the world around you. Y'can take responsibility for your role in this shit while still acknowledging the broader context. Which is that a whole bunch of people with more information about the situation than you led you to believe that this shit was anything other than a fuckin' suicide mission."

"But I'm the one who rushed you all, it's—"

"—I'm not gonna stand here and argue with you about the exact amount of bullshit that you are at fault for. It doesn't fucking matter." He said, strutting a bit closer, until they were around ten feet apart. "I said I forgive you, so just let it go."

Izuku wrung his wrists, staring down at his feet. "It just feels too easy."

Katsuki raised an eyebrow. "Yeah? Well, what d'you want, Deku? Want me to make you grovel at my feet and beg for forgiveness?" He snorted. "If you *really* want me to punish you, I could throw you over my knee and spank 'ya."

Izuku's face burned, all the way to his ears. He shuffled around in place, looking at everything but Katsuki.

"I-Is it true?" He eventually asked. "You really stayed up three days straight looking for me?"

Katsuki shrugged, taking another bite and finishing off the apple. "I've been awake longer before." He chucked the core over his shoulder.

Izuku winced. “That’s… not really the point.”

Katsuki stared at him for a while, and then sighed. He shoved his hands into his pockets and took a few steps closer. They were now around five feet apart.

“Look, nerd. It’s not like you’re gettin’ off completely scott free with me.” He said. “M’gonna expect you to be a lot less dumbfuck-reckless. And you’re not goin’ back to Heaven again. At least not alone.”

Izuku smiled bitterly, gesturing back at his wings. “I couldn’t go back even if I wanted to.”

Katsuki hummed, glancing at his wings. “Yeah, they really did a number on ‘ya, didn’t they.”

Izuku tensed, eyes downcast as he instinctively pulled his wings as tight against his back as he could. Just hearing Katsuki point it out like that made him feel as though his heart was sinking into his gut. For a moment he just stood there, letting the silence speak for him. Letting it consume him.

And then eventually, Katsuki closed the distance, moving behind Izuku. He tried to turn away, but Katsuki just followed him, and so Izuku gave up, tears prickling the corners of his eyes as he just let him do as he pleased. Katsuki touched his right wing, gently unfolding it so he could look at it fully. His fingers brushed along each haphazardly clipped feather, and then he moved on to his left wing, and did the same thing there. When he seemed satisfied, he released him, letting Izuku pull his wings back in against his back.

“Yep.” He said, moving to stand in front of Izuku again. “Still pretty.”

Izuku’s breath caught in his throat. He looked up, but Katsuki had already turned around, and was now lazily wandering down the aisle again, in the opposite direction.

It was a complete one-eighty from what he’d been feeling before. Where he used to feel a heavy weight in his stomach, instead, he felt only butterflies.

“So.” Katsuki stopped walking halfway down the aisle. He stood there, his back turned to him. “We’re in agreement, then? You’re not going back there.”

Izuku swallowed. “I already told you. I couldn’t, even if I wanted to.”

Katsuki snorted. “Yeah, right.” He threw a look over his shoulder. The briefest flash of glowing red. “Deku, you and me both know that if you *really* wanted to go back, you’d find a fuckin’ way. Turn my back for five minutes and I’d catch your ass tryna hijack a fuckin’ hot air balloon, or some shit.”

Izuku laughed softly. “I mean it, Kacchan. I’m done.”

And in that instant, as the words left his lips, Izuku swore he felt a shift in the air, in Katsuki’s posture, even before he turned around. Even before he saw the dark, devilish look on his face. Slowly, Katsuki advanced toward him again.

“So…” He murmured, voice deep. And at a leisurely pace, he began to circle around him. “I guess that means… you’ve got no real reason to block my touch anymore. Doesn’t it?”

For a moment, time seemed to stand still. Izuku looked up at him, felt his eyes burning into him as he continued to walk around him. The reality of the situation seemed to hit him in waves.

Because here he was, alone with Katsuki, in a place where no one would bother them, and Katsuki was looking at Izuku like he wanted to devour him.

And suddenly, the fact that Izuku no longer had any reason to remain an Angel was not just some abstract property of his existence. Katsuki had acknowledged it, and in doing so, he made it *real,* in some sense. Presented it to Izuku with an implicit question that threatened to take away everything Izuku was. Promised to remake him into something new.

‘What are you going to do about it?’

Izuku shivered, despite the warmth rising in his cheeks. He clenched his fists, took a deep breath and unclenched them. “That’s true.” He swallowed the lump in his throat. “I guess I just… won’t.”

“Oh, really?” Katsuki raised an eyebrow as he came to a stop, turning to face him, just a few feet away.

His heart pounding in his ears, Izuku nodded. “You’re free to do, um… as you please?”

Katsuki chuckled softly, taking a step closer. “Oh yeah?”

“Y-Yeah.”

Katsuki hummed, cocking his head. “Well, in that case…”

He reached out to him then, as if to touch his face. Izuku watched his hand draw near in slow motion, but before he could make contact, he stopped. Katsuki’s hand hovered over his cheek, radiating heat, but never quite touching.

His eyelids drooping, Izuku tried to lean into it, but Katsuki pulled his hand away just in time, with a sadistic smirk. The action triggered something inside of him, and an embarrassing whine slipped out before he could stifle it. Katsuki just laughed, his catlike pupils blown wide as he looked him up and down.

Being so close only to have it taken away made him want it even more, and as he looked up at Katsuki, his brows pinched together, it was like every thought, every need or desire Izuku had that was not directly tied to him immediately faded away.

Because here Katsuki was, staring down at him. With his full lips and glowing gaze, sharp jaw and imposing frame.

He was the incarnation of everything Izuku was not supposed to want. Everything he was built to oppose.

And yet.

That smirk of his hinted at a danger previously unknowable to him. But that was then, and this was now.

Cards on the table. Izuku was calling his bluff.

Another almost-touch, this time just over the nape of his neck. And again, he pulled his hand back before he could feel him.

Katsuki licked his lips. Izuku's eyes tracked the movement of his tongue. "Y'want me to touch you that fuckin' bad, baby?" His voice was deep, gravelly. He could feel it in his bones. Katsuki leaned in just slightly, his volume dropping a bit. "Want me to make all those pretty feathers fall to the floor?"

He couldn't ignore it any longer. He needed Katsuki's skin against his own. Nothing else mattered to him.

His jaw clenched, Izuku took a step forward, and Katsuki took a step back. Izuku could feel tears prickling the corners of his eyes.

"Please, Kacchan." He said. *"Please.* I'm already… so far gone. I-I wanna feel you when…" He swallowed. "When it happens."

Katsuki's grin expanded. He looked absolutely *feral.* And after a second, he leaned in further, hot breath wafting against his ear. "When *what* happens?"

Izuku's wrung his wrists, not responding at first. Katsuki pulled back a bit, so he could look at him straight-on. Izuku's eyes fluttered shut as Katsuki brushed his thumb over his lower lip. The touch was light, barely there—but even *that* felt potent in a way Izuku struggled to meaningfully describe.

"Say it, Deku."

Izuku opened his eyes, meeting Katsuki's glowing gaze. "When I… Fall."

At this, Katsuki sucked in a sharp breath, his composure seeming to slip for a moment before that teasing smirk of his returned. "Yeah?" He whispered. "You gonna Fall for me, Deku baby?"

Izuku couldn't hold back the sob that escaped his throat then.

He just couldn't take it any more.

"I've *always* been falling for you."

Katsuki swore under his breath, and just like that, he dropped the act.

His lips crashed into Izuku's, strong hands pulling him in by the sides of his face as he stole the air from his lungs. Izuku moaned into the kiss as his senses came alive. He reached up,

lacing his fingers through Katsuki hair, his thumbs brushing along the base of his horns.

It was strange, to simply let Katsuki touch him without his barrier. There were moments when he caught himself reflexively raising it, and it took a bit for him to fully relax into the idea that he didn't have to. That this was okay. He could just let himself feel all of Katsuki, let Katsuki feel all of him.

He wasn't prepared for how much more intense it would feel. Without his barrier, Katsuki's hands and lips felt so much hotter against his skin, his touch so much more distinct. It lingered on his skin long after he'd shifted his hands, like a brand burned into his soul.

Katsuki's hands slid back, cradling his neck, pulling his hair, making Izuku gasp at the sudden pain. He took the opportunity to press his tongue past his lips, running his hands down his shoulders, his arms, and then under Izuku's shirt to touch his chest and back.

It was greedy; like he refused to leave a single inch of him untouched. Izuku wondered if he could lose his mind like this. It certainly felt like it, when his hands dipped beneath Katsuki's shirt and he felt the hard muscles of his abdomen, flexing under his touch.

And then, Katsuki grabbed him by the hips and started to walk, forcing him to back up, until he was pressed up against the edge of the altar. And when Katsuki broke the kiss, Izuku didn't have the presence of mind to feel embarrassed about the way he whined over it.

He opened his eyes, and found Katsuki staring down at him with a wide grin.

"Hey, nerd." He jerked his head toward something behind him. "Check it out."

Brow furrowed, Izuku leaned to the side to look, eyes widening at what he saw.

There was a trail of white feathers, leading down the aisle to where they now stood. It was nothing crazy, barely a dent in the total volume of his wings, but it was *something.* It was proof that it was working, that Katsuki's touch was changing him.

Katsuki leaned in, resting his forehead against Izuku's. "If you're havin' second thoughts about Falling, now's the time to tell me. You're really sure?"

Izuku swallowed, nodding his head. "I'm sure."

Katsuki leaned in, planting another kiss on his lips, though this one was slower, more sweet. He broke away after a moment.

"In that case…" Katsuki shoved his knee between his legs, drawing out a gasp from Izuku's lips that he immediately swallowed. Izuku opened his mouth and let Katsuki in, let him consume him. He felt his hands sliding down the back of his pants, grabbing his ass and pulling him down against his thigh. Katsuki bit his lip, pulling it between his teeth. It was intoxicating. Izuku breathed him in, felt him coating the inside of his lungs. It monopolized his senses—*Katsuki, Katsuki, Katsuki.*

And for the first time, there didn't need to be anything else.

His claws bit into the flesh of his ass, and his dick throbbed in his pants. Katsuki pulled back again, started yanking at his cloak until he seemed to lose patience, and with a swipe of his claws, he tore through the fabric, shoving the tatters away.

"H-Hey!"

It was hard to stay indignant for long, because soon, Katsuki's hands were back on his body again. He licked his lips before he lunged, kissing down his jaw, his neck, and then there were sharp teeth pressing against his flesh, and Katsuki was sucking marks into his skin.

"Aah, *Kacchan…"* Izuku moaned, high and breathy.

"M'gonna fuck you up so *fucking* good, Deku." He murmured, words muffled against his skin. "God." He grabbed his wrist, yanking his hand down to his crotch. Izuku gasped, blood rushing south as Katsuki held his hand right there against his cock, grinding into his palm with a deep groan. "Y'see what you fuckin' do to me, nerd?" He punctuated it with a sharp nip to his neck.

Izuku's breath caught in his throat, his own cock twitching inside his pants. He felt like he was about to cum already, just feeling Katsuki's cock all hard and swollen up like that.

He blamed the lack of blood flow to his brain for what he said next. It was muffled, slightly slurred, as though he were drunk. "All of this is for me…?"

He didn't think about it; it sort of just came out. He could feel Katsuki's grin against his skin, preening at the implication.

"All for you, baby." He rasped, hissing when Izuku squeezed him through his pants, bucking harder into his hand. And then he was whispering right into Izuku's ear. "You know how fucking long I've been thinking about this shit?" He growled. "How long I've fucking struggled to even look at you without thinkin' about how much I wanted to *wreck you?"*

Izuku whimpered, thrusting harder against Katsuki's leg. He didn't even have the presence of mind to feel embarrassed about it; he was just too desperate. It was crazy how much more potent it felt, without the barrier in place. Izuku felt as though he were drowning in the heat of the Demon's body, intoxicated by his touch. And it was so intense, his eyes started watering. He ran his hands over Katsuki's chest, up and down his back, but he couldn't get enough of him fast enough. It was like Katsuki's touch was oxygen, and he was struggling to catch his breath.

"K-Kacchan, *please."* He sobbed, pressing his face into the crook of his neck. *"Please,* you feel so good, I can't—"

"—Shhh," Katsuki soothed him, running one hand up and down Izuku's spine, and then lacing his fingers through his hair. "You're alright. You're fine. Here," Katsuki pulled back for just a second, yanking his tank top up over his head, and then leaned in again, pressing their chests together as he ran his fingers through his hair. Izuku shuddered at the feeling of Katsuki's bare chest against his own, and tried to press himself closer. He wouldn't be satisfied until he was close enough to feel Katsuki's soul right up against his own.

Grabbing his ass with both hands again, Katsuki pulled him down harder against his thigh.

“Aah—Kacchan, I can’t. At this rate…”

“Don’t fight it.” Katsuki said. “C’mon, nerd. Wanna see you cum on my thigh, just like this.” Izuku whimpered, eyes fluttering. He could feel his cock leaking through the thin material. “So pretty, baby.” He rasped. “Cum like the sweet little Angel you are.”

Izuku cried out as the dam inside him burst, cock pulsating and twitching as he soaked through the fabric of his briefs. It felt so good, he didn’t even know how to handle it, really. For a moment, his vision whited out, and all he could do was sob and buck his hips clumsily.

“Oh, *fuck* yeah.” Katsuki hissed, leaning down to kiss him again, swallowing his cries as he rode it out. “That’s it, that’s right…”

When he eventually came down, Katsuki started on the button of Izuku’s pants, shoving them down so he could step out of them, leaving him in just his underwear. In that brief moment of clarity, Izuku chanced a glance at the floor, and his eyes widened when he saw how many feathers had accumulated. It was a sizable pile, at this point, and when he looked back at his wings, he estimated that he had about half as many feathers as he did twenty minutes earlier.

Katsuki grabbed his attention again when he picked him up and set him down on the altar. Izuku immediately wrapped his legs around him, pulling him closer, until Katsuki’s hips were flush between his thighs. Katsuki groaned, kissing down his jaw and neck, sucking a bruise into his skin.

“So fucking sexy,” He rasped, lips moving against his throat. “Pretty. Gorgeous. My perfect little Angel.”

Izuku shivered. “N-Not for long.”

At that, Katsuki laughed. “Nah, you’ll *always* be my Angel, Fallen or not.” He grinned. “You’re my sweet little Angel, ‘cuz I’m never gonna get over this shit.”

Izuku laughed softly, ducking his head into Katsuki’s neck.

For a moment, they just stayed that way, embracing each other. Katsuki hummed. “So, what do you want?”

Izuku wasn’t really sure how to answer that, but he went with his gut.

“Anything.” Izuku said. “Everything.”

Katsuki pulled back a little, raising a brow with an amused glint in his eye. *“Everything,* huh?” He scoffed. “You fuckin’ sure about that, nerd?”

“Why wouldn’t I be?”

“I dunno. Just wanna make sure you know what the fuck you’re askin’ for.” Then, holding eye contact, he slid his hands down underneath him, grabbing his ass in both hands and

squeezing. Izuku's breath hitched, and he leaned into his chest as Katsuki pulled his cheeks apart.

"Y'know, Deku," he continued, "Obviously I wanna fuck you. But I also get that you're new to a lot of this shit. I ain't gonna push you on somethin' you're not ready for." He shrugged. "There's plenty of other shit we could do. Doesn't have to be *everything."*

Izuku bit his lip, doing his best to think critically—though the rough movements of Katsuki's hands on his ass were not all that helpful in that regard.

But when he glanced down at the steadily growing pile of feathers on the ground, he knew what his answer had to be. Maybe it was rash, but… well, Izuku just couldn't imagine Falling for anything less.

He met his eyes again. "I… I want it, Kacchan." He said. "Wanna feel all of you. Need you closer."

"Yeah, well." He snorted. "Can't get much closer than my cock up your ass." Izuku's legs tightened around him, and he bit his lip as he felt his bulge press up against his ass.

"…Will it hurt?"

Katsuki hummed. "Maybe a bit, at first. I'm kinda…" He trailed off, and then shrugged. "So, you know."

Izuku blinked. "What?"

He could feel Katsuki's chest rumbling against his own just before he pulled back, grabbing Izuku's hand and guiding it to his belt. "Why don't you just see for yourself?"

Izuku gulped, hesitating for a moment before slowly starting to undo his belt, his ears zeroed in on the sound of leather sliding against leather as he pulled it through the buckle. He reached for the button next, popping it free before slowly unzipping his pants.

The whole time, Katsuki just stood over him, staring down at him with heated, glowing eyes. Once his zipper was down, Izuku paused, his eyes glued to the patch of orange boxer briefs peeking through. Hands hovering. Fingers twitching.

"Well, go on." Katsuki rasped. *"Take it out."*

With shaky hands, Izuku reached into his underwear, heard Katsuki's breath hitch when he wrapped his fingers gently around the base. And slowly, he dragged Katsuki's cock out.

And it wasn't like he had no idea. Izuku had felt it before, seen it bulging in his pants. But actually seeing it in full was something else entirely.

Katsuki's cock was thick and heavy in his palm, dusky pink and red at the tip. He pressed his thumb against one of the thick veins running up the side, and bit his lip at the way it twitched.

...Big, he thought to himself.

It wasn't until he saw the way Katsuki was smiling that he realized he'd said it out loud, and he flushed. But the embarrassment didn't stop his hand from moving, slowly stroking up the shaft, all the way to the tip before he slid it down again. He was tempted to try and compare it to the length of his forearm, but didn't really want to give Katsuki the satisfaction.

"Is this just a Demon thing, or…?"

Katsuki scoffed.

"You askin' me if *corruption* makes your *dick bigger?"* He cackled. "Sure, Deku. I think I remember that porn ad. 'Grow your cock five inches overnight with this one weird trick God doesn't want you to know about!'" Izuku squeezed his cock just a little too hard, and Katsuki hissed. "Ow!" He clicked his tongue. "Little shit."

"Don't make fun of me." Izuku glared up at him.

Katsuki rolled his eyes. "M'not makin' fun of you, dumb ass." He leaned in, running his fingers through his hair. "I just think you're cute. I mean—god, you shoulda seen the look on your face."

Izuku frowned. "Don't patronize me, either."

"I'm not." Katsuki sighed. "Deku, nothing makes me feel more violent than seeing you sitting there, with your little halo and wings and your hands wrapped around my cock."

"Violent?"

Katsuki blinked, his expression unchanging. "I meant to say horny."

Izuku stared at him for a very, very long time. "So…" He gulped. "I, uh… feel like I'm in danger."

"You say that as if you've ever *not* been in danger around me." Katsuki scoffed. "C'mon, Deku. You know I've always been like this."

"Like *what?"*

"Doesn't matter." He rolled his eyes again. "Look, the bottom line is it's *hot,* okay? When you go all doe-eyed over my cock, it makes me wanna, like… hold you down and squeeze you, or something."

Izuku laughed nervously. "Kacchan, respectfully—" His pitch jumped an octave. "What the *hell* is that supposed to mean?"

Katsuki hummed. "You ever heard of 'cute aggression'?" He asked. "It's like, when you see somethin' cute and your impulse is to squeeze it." He shrugged. "It's kinda like that, except I also wanna obliterate your ass with my cock."

"Ah." He blushed. "How romantic."

“Damn right.” He smirked, bucking into Izuku’s hand. “Take you out to dinner and bring you flowers, then take you home and handcuff you to my bed and fuck you ’til you can’t walk, yeah?”

“K-Kacchan!” Izuku squirmed, hiding his face in his chest.

Katsuki just laughed.

After a moment, he reached down, running his fingers through Izuku’s hair. He pulled lightly, slowly coaxing him to look up at him again, to look into his eyes.

“So, what d’you think, nerd?” He asked. “Still want me to fuck you?” Izuku gulped, and after a moment, he slowly nodded his head. Katsuki’s cock twitched in his hand, and his eyelids lowered, chest rumbling. “In that case…”

Katsuki suddenly pulled him off the altar, spinning him around and bending him over it. He kicked Izuku’s legs apart, and snapped the waistband of his underwear a few times before he all but ripped them off of him. Izuku gasped when he felt Katsuki’s cock slotting between his ass cheeks, sliding gently. A bit nervous, he looked over his shoulder.

“K-Kacchan…”

“S’okay, nerd. M’not puttin’ it in yet.” He grunted, grabbing his cheeks in both hands and pushing them together, sliding back and forth between them. Katsuki looked up at him under his lashes, a devious smirk on his face. “I’m just appreciating this gorgeous fuckin’ ass of yours.” He licked his lips.

Izuku buried his face in his arms, cheeks burning hotter than the sun. Eventually, Katsuki pulled away, spreading his cheeks instead. Izuku whimpered as he felt cool air against his hole, and held his breath as he waited for something to happen.

And he wasn’t sure what he was expecting, but it *definitely* wasn’t a hot, wet tongue swiping across his hole.

Izuku tensed, crying out.

“K-Kacchan?!” He turned and looked over his shoulder, only to find Katsuki’s face buried in his ass. Shakily, he reached back and laced his fingers through Katsuki’s hair, trying to push him away. “Y-You shouldn’t, that’s—“ Katsuki suddenly smacked his ass, and he yelped. *“Ah!* What—!”

Katsuki looked up at him, meeting his eyes with a grin. “Don’t tell me what *I* shouldn’t do.” He said. “Unless you’re tellin’ me *you* don’t want it, I don’t wanna hear it.”

Izuku covered his face with his hands, his cheeks red hot as he peered between his fingers. “But it’s so *embarrassing.”*

“Oh, I know.” He said, fingers shifting into claws again, sinking into the flesh of his ass cheeks. “Can feel the heat radiating off your face all the way over here, nerd. You’re fuckin’

cute when you're embarrassed." With that, he dove back in, planting a kiss on his hole before circling his tongue around the rim. Izuku squirmed.

It took a minute for him to get used to the sensation, but once the shock wore off, he found himself struggling to keep himself quiet. He choked on a moan as Katsuki flicked his tongue back and forth rapidly.

Izuku couldn't understand why it felt so good, only that it *did.* His thighs were shaking, back arching as he held onto the edge of the altar.

It was probably the sounds that got to him most of all.

Katsuki alternated between licking and sucking on his hole, filling the church up with filthy, wet noises. Something about hearing those sounds and knowing where they came from filled his stomach up with heat.

And when his tongue finally breached his entrance, Izuku gasped. The sensation was unlike anything he'd ever felt before. That hot tongue slowly fucking in and out of him left him hungry and needy in a way he wasn't sure how to address.

Izuku whimpered, trying to rub his dick against the edge of the altar. He yelped when he felt something wrap around it, and it took a moment for him to realize it was Katsuki's tail. He moaned as it began to stroke him languidly.

"Oh, god, Kacchan..." He gasped, not quite sure whether he wanted to thrust back onto Katsuki's tongue or fuck into the tail coiled around his cock. It was all so intense, and before he knew it, he was already nearing the edge again. But before he could get there, Katsuki stopped.

Izuku whined, frustrated tears filling his eyes. But then Katsuki was leaning over, pressing his chest flush against his back. He stroked up and down Izuku's side, pressed his lips against his shoulder.

"S'okay, baby." He murmured, muffled against his skin. "I gotcha."

After a minute, Katsuki stood up again. He could hear the sound of fabric rustling, of Katsuki's pants hitting the floor. It was the sound of a cap popping open that really caught his attention, though, and as he looked over his shoulder, he saw Katsuki holding a bottle, pouring some clear substance out on his fingers.

"What's that?"

"Lube." He said, without looking up.

Izuku stared at him for a moment. "You just… have that on hand?"

Katsuki shrugged, spreading the slick liquid over his fingers. "I always have it—when I'm around you, at least."

"You *what?"* Izuku nearly choked "Since when?!"

He closed the cap, setting the bottle on the altar. “Mm, wanna say it was around when we started sparring.” He looked up in thought, and then nodded. “Yeah… Yeah, I’m pretty sure it was after the first time.”

Izuku sputtered, indignant. “Th-That’s awfully presumptuous of you.”

Katsuki finally looked at him again, raising and eyebrow. “Came in handy, though, didn’t it?” He smirked. “If it weren’t for my impeccable foresight, I wouldn’t be able to fuck you right now. So really, you oughta be thankin’ me.”

Izuku pursed his lips. He thought about talking back, but ultimately, he just shook his head and quietly averted his eyes.

“You ever put anything in here? Or play with it at all?”

Izuku shook his head again, before realizing Katsuki probably wasn’t looking. “Ah, n-no,” he stammered. “It’s… It’s a—“

“—A sin, yeah.” Katsuki finished, nodding. “So I’ve heard.”

Izuku peeked over his shoulder just in time to watch as Katsuki pressed one of his fingers—unshifted, of course—against his hole, rubbing in slow, teasing circles. Izuku’s body tensed up before he forced it to relax.

“‘Flee from sexual immorality. Every other sin a person commits is outside the body, but the sexually immoral person sins against his own body.’” Katsuki recited, then slyly looked up at Izuku. “1 Corinthians 6:18.”

Izuku flushed, eyes going wide. Just then, Katsuki pressed a finger past the resistance, gradually sinking it deeper, deeper, all the way to the knuckle. It was strange, at first. But then, Katsuki began to move, languidly fucking his finger in and out, and Izuku nearly choked on his own spit as he moaned.

“And of course, who could forget the classic—Leviticus 20:13.” Katsuki kept his finger shallow, rubbing just inside the rim of his hole. *“’You shall not lie with a male as with a woman; it is an abomination.’”*

Izuku whined, burying his head in his arms. “Kacchan, cut it ou—Ah!” Katsuki curled his finger, rubbing against something that sent shockwaves up his spine.

Katsuki just kept talking.

“Even after two-hundred years, I still remember this garbage. It makes sense, I guess. I used to read scripture every damn day. But still, that’s space in my brain that I could be using to store literally anything else.”

He started fucking into him faster, his finger crooked inside him, pinpoint-stimulating that one spot that made him see stars. He could hardly even hear what Katsuki was saying anymore.

“I could be usin’ those braincells for something important, but instead I gotta use them to recall direct quotes from the story of Sodom and Gomorrah.” He muttered, twisting his finger as he drove it back in. “Which, by the way, is a fucking weird-ass story. Even as human, I remember reading it and thinking, ‘wait, what the fuck?’”

He eased in a second finger alongside the first, and Izuku’s thighs started to shake.

“Lot’s framed as being the righteous one—at least relatively speaking—but when the men of Sodom show up and are like, ‘hey bring out those men who are staying with you so we can rape them,’ the first thing he does is offer up his two daughters for them to rape instead. Because hospitality. Or something.” Izuku could almost hear the eye-roll in Katsuki’s tone. “And that’s not even getting *into* all the fuckin’ incest shit after they escape.” He clicked his tongue. “It’s a garbage story in a garbage book. Zero out of ten.”

Izuku wasn’t really sure what Katsuki was expecting him to say to any of this, if anything at all. Fortunately—or not, depending on how you looked at it—he never needed to come up with a response, because as soon as he finished his rant, Katsuki pushed a third finger inside, and Izuku almost choked on his own saliva.

“You good, nerd?”

Izuku took a few deep breaths, and then shakily replied, “Y-Yeah.”

Katsuki hummed, smoothing his free hand up and down his spine as he leaned down and pressed his lips to the shell of his ear.

“You look so fucking good like this, y’know that?” All Izuku could respond with was a small, strangled cry as Katsuki slowly bent his fingers inside him, rubbing, twisting. Had it not been for the altar underneath, him, he’s certain his legs would’ve given out. “Takin’ it so fucking good. Can’t wait to see you stretched out around my cock.” He emphasized with a buck of his hips, rutting his cock against Izuku’s thigh as he ran his tongue up his neck.

When Katsuki eventually started fucking him with all three fingers, he coiled his tail around Izuku’s cock again, stroking slowly, in time with his thrusts. By then, Izuku’s eyes were watering, tears threatening to spill over. Without really thinking, he’d begun to press his hips back onto Katsuki’s fingers, trying to get them deeper, even as he shoved them in to the last knuckle.

He couldn’t take it anymore.

“Kacchan, *please.”* He said, breathless. “Please, I’m *ready.”*

Katsuki hummed against his ear, and he could feel the vibrations against his back. “Ready for what, exactly?”

Izuku clenched his jaw. “For you.”

“Me?”

“Yes, you!” Izuku pushed his hips back in frustration. “Stop teasing me, please.”

He could feel him grinning against his neck. “Aw, c’mon. I just wanna hear you say it.”

Izuku released a strangled whine.

“Shh,” he soothed. “Just tell me what you want, and I’ll be happy. Alright?”

Izuku sniffled, his face burning up as he squeezed his eyes shut.

“I-I want you… inside of me.”

“But I *am* inside of you.” He emphasized with a twist of his fingers that made Izuku gasp for air. “Y’gotta be specific.”

He whimpered, shivering as Katsuki stroked up and down his spine with his free hand.

“I want your pe—“

“—If you say ‘penis,’ I’m actually gonna fucking leave, Deku.” Katsuki interjected, completely deadpan.

Izuku groaned in exasperation, hitting his forehead against the surface of the altar a few times. And Katsuki—the bastard—actually had the nerve to laugh.

Izuku gritted his teeth.

If he wants me to be as vulgar as him, then fine.

And with that, Izuku opened his mouth, and began speaking with the kind of confidence that could only arise through *pure spite.*

“I want your *cock,* Kacchan.” He said, through gritted teeth. “I want you to shove your stupid, big cock up my ass and *fuck* me, and if you don’t do it right now, so help me god, I’ll fucking do it myself, and—“

Suddenly, there was a hand in his hair, gripping it by the roots and yanking him into a standing position. Izuku yelped at the sudden pain. Katsuki’s cock was slotted between his ass cheeks, twitching as he rutted against him. His fingers had shifted back into claws, and as one hand stayed buried in his hair, the other one wrapped around Izuku’s neck. He wasn’t choking him, but the threat was there, and somehow, that only made Izuku’s dick harder.

Katsuki leaned down, hot breath against his ear as he whispered in a low, deceptively sweet tone, “Deku, baby… do you have a fucking death wish?”

Izuku’s breathing stuttered. He had to strain his eyes to look at Katsuki. “Would I even *be* here if I didn’t?”

Katsuki snorted, the hand around his neck sliding up to his cheek, turning his head to the side, so that Katsuki could lean in and kiss him roughly. He broke away after a second and grabbed Izuku’s hips, spinning him around. Before he knew it, Katsuki was sitting atop the

altar, with Izuku straddling his lap. With one hand, he squeezed his ass, and with the other, he smacked his cock against his thigh, before rubbing it between his cheeks.

Izuku glanced at his wings, eyes going wide.

They were almost completely bare.

The sensation of Katsuki's cock head pressing against his hole brought his attention back to where it belonged, and then Katsuki's hand was on the back of his neck, pulling him in close. Izuku stared into his hazy, glowing eyes and shivered.

"Well, if you want my cock so fuckin' bad, why don't you *take it?"* Izuku's breath hitched. He'd been so brazen before, but as he sat there in Katsuki's lap, lost in his eyes, with a thick cock poised to enter him, Izuku blushed as some of the anxiety creeped back into his mind.

Katsuki leaned in, planting a kiss on his lips.

"You're fine." He murmured. "All you gotta do is lower your hips. Think you can handle that?"

Izuku closed his eyes, nodding.

And then, with a deep breath, he started pressing down. Even with all the lube and preparation, the first push was met with some resistance. But soon enough, he gasped as he felt the tip of Katsuki's cock pop into his hole, the entire head quickly getting sucked inside.

"Fuck, Deku." Katsuki groaned. "Try to relax."

Izuku nodded again, doing his best to release the tension inside him. It didn't hurt as much as he was afraid it would, but it wasn't completely painless, either. After a few deep breaths, he started to lower his hips again, gradually taking more and more of Katsuki's cock. It was intense. So intense, in fact, that Izuku felt tears slipping down his cheeks, long overdue.

"You alright?" Katsuki murmured.

"Yeah, I just…" Izuku took a shuddering breath. "There's just… so much."

Katsuki's chest rumbled. "You're doin' so good, angel." He rasped. "Takin' my cock so fucking well. That's it. Half-way there, baby."

"Half?" Izuku's eyes shot open, ass clamping down around Katsuki's cock, drawing a hiss out of him.

"Yes." He said, teeth gritted. "It's okay. You can handle it. Just relax."

Izuku nodded planting his hands firmly on Katsuki's shoulders as he willed himself to loosen up. Katsuki grabbed his hips, helping to pull him down a bit further.

"That's it." He whispered. "That's right. Almost there."

Izuku whimpered, his head bowed against Katsuki's shoulder as he let him take over, guiding his hips the rest of the way, until finally, he reached the base, Katsuki's balls pressing against him. Katsuki ran his hands up and down his back, then, soothing him as he adjusted. He was just so *deep.* It almost felt like he was in his stomach.

"Hey. Deku." Katsuki softly said. "Look."

Blearily, he raised his head, following Katsuki's line of sight to his wings.

They were completely bare.

Izuku looked down, eyes widening at the sight. All his feathers were strewn across the floor, like piles of fresh snow.

And it hit him then, that this was it. The point of no return.

Izuku held his breath as he watched it happen, watched as seconds later, all the feathers on the floor abruptly turned black, and then went up in flames. He craned his neck, wanting to take in the spectacular sight in full. The feathers turned to ash rather quickly, but Izuku tensed upon realizing that the fire had not gone out with them. There were a couple of places where the flames had managed to catch onto the wooden floor, and when he turned around, he saw one spot where it was already climbing up the side of the pews.

"Uh, Kacchan, should we—ah!"

Katsuki suddenly pulled out a little, and thrust back inside hard. His head whipped back toward him, eyes wide.

Katsuki gave him a knowing grin, licking his lips. "What?"

"The fire, it's—" Izuku choked on another cry as Katsuki did it again, pulling out a bit more before slamming back in. Izuku wrapped his hands around his neck, leaning into his chest for stability as Katsuki set a rhythm of short, deep thrusts.

"I know, I've got *eyes,* nerd." Katsuki snorted, hands sliding from his hips to his ass, spreading his cheeks apart so he could grind even deeper. "I've also got your tight ass wrapped around my cock. I ain't stoppin' over some wimpy ass fire."

"You're so—*eep!"* Izuku tensed as he felt his hair apparently shifting on its own, and reflexively reached up.

There, he found two sharp bumps, steadily growing in length. Katsuki's grip on his ass loosened a bit as he watched, eyes wide as the horns emerged, slowly taking form. Even without seeing them, Izuku could tell that his horns were different from Katsuki's. They seemed to split off at some points, almost like branches on a tree, or—

"—Antlers," Katsuki said, with this sort of breathless awe.

Izuku's eyes widened.

“I have *antlers?!”*

“Mm,” Katsuki smiled, reaching up to touch them gently, just as their growth began to slow. “There’s a few different types of horns, but antlers are by *far* the rarest. Come to think of it, I’m not sure if I’ve ever actually seen anyone with ‘em in person…”

Izuku frowned, his face burning. It seemed so weird, and he wasn’t really sure how he felt about it. But he didn’t really get much chance to think about it, because as soon as they finished growing, he felt a similar sensation stemming from his tailbone. It didn’t take long to figure out what it was.

The growth of his tail was a slow thing, and as it gradually gained length, Katsuki started fucking up into him again. He worked him in longer strokes, pulling out most of the way before pushing back inside, until Izuku couldn’t even think about the changes his body was undergoing.

And all the while, Katsuki looked up at him with this mesmerized stare, his cheeks flushed with arousal, lips swollen from kissing. Izuku watched his tongue dart out to lick them, and then Katsuki smiled. “Gorgeous.” He said. “That artifice really didn’t do you justice…”

Izuku teared up, cheeks burning as he ducked his head into Katsuki’s shoulder, nails digging into his back as Katsuki’s thrusts sped up. He breathed him in, the smell of smoke and caramel flooding his lungs as Katsuki fucked him, abusing that spot inside him that made Izuku desperate for more.

Just as his tail finished growing, Katsuki grabbed it at the base, and Izuku choked on a moan as he lightly tugged on it, his cock leaking between his legs. He clenched around Katsuki’s cock, and felt the vibrations of his chest as he groaned.

“Interesting.” He murmured, grinning mischievously. “Not everyone likes that. Good to know you’re one of the ones who does.” He laughed darkly. He pulled it a bit harder, and Izuku squirmed, walls fluttering as Katsuki fucked him harder. He held on to Katsuki’s back, nails biting into his skin.

…Except they weren’t quite nails, anymore. He watched as the skin there began to darken as his nails morphed into black claws. Another pull on his tail, and he was scratching at Katsuki’s back, leaving angry, red marks as he clamped down on Katsuki’s cock.

“Fuck.” Katsuki groaned, teeth sinking into his shoulder.

There was a shift in his center of gravity, and Izuku could feel his barren wings starting to shrink. He was almost there, in more ways than one.

He rode Katsuki’s cock, back arching as he pushed down to meet his thrusts. It was all so intense. Katsuki was so fucking deep. And when he felt an odd shift in the muscles on Katsuki’s back, he realized that—unintentionally or not—Katsuki was shifting.

His dick throbbed between his legs, leaking against Katsuki’s stomach. “Ah—I can’t,” He cried. “Kacchan, *please.”*

And as if reading his mind, Katsuki's tail found his cock again, coiling around it and stroking up and down in time with his thrusts. Katsuki grabbed him by the hair and pulled him into a downright filthy kiss, and Izuku's thighs shook. Katsuki bit his lower lip, pulling it back between his teeth.

"Shit… wanna fill you up, Deku." He said, right against his lips. "Stuff you real fuckin' good. You want it?"

Izuku nodded, with a breathless, *"Please."*

It was around then that he felt his wings finally recede fully into his back. He glanced over Katsuki's shoulder, watching as the fire climbed up the walls until it finally met with a large, wooden cross. It went up in flames almost immediately. That was all he had a chance to see before Katsuki's wings extended out, blocking his view. Izuku gasped as Katsuki's cock seemed to grow a little bit larger inside of him.

"Did it just—?!"

Katsuki's only response was a knowing laugh. A second later, both of his hands smacked down on his ass, gripping his cheeks roughly as he stood up. Izuku locked his ankles around Katsuki's hips as his thrusts became downright frantic, cock pumping in and out of his hole, slamming in a bit deeper every time. Izuku cried out, holding on for dear life as that heat began to gather in the pit of his stomach.

The spot where his wings used to be started to tingle. It happened so quickly, he barely even had time to notice it before suddenly, there was another shift in his center of gravity, as two black, feathered wings all but shot out from his back, stretching to their full span on either side.

And that was pretty much it for him.

"Kacchan—!" He cried out, clamping down hard on Katsuki's cock as he came, his own cock pulsating, shooting against Katsuki's stomach. Katsuki groaned, fucking up into him faster, pulling his cheeks further apart, trying to get deeper.

"Fuck, fuck, fuck, shit—!" With one last thrust he slammed Izuku down on his cock and came, groaning as he grinded up into him, shooting hot and thick, deep inside him.

Katsuki sat down on the altar again, and the stayed there for a minute, panting, and a bit sweaty. When he finally had the presence of mind to process stimuli other than Katsuki's touch, he looked around, and his eyes widened.

The church was thoroughly on fire at that point. It was only a matter of time before the structure started to break down.

Katsuki grabbed him by the hair—much gentler, this time—and pulled him into another kiss, this one relaxed, languid. Izuku gasped as Katsuki slowly pulled of him, half-hard cock smacking against his thigh. Seconds later, Izuku squirmed as he felt his cum starting to leak out of him. Katsuki smirked against his lips.

Izuku's eyes fluttered as he looked up him, then, and Katsuki's smile only grew. With one hand, he reached up to cup Izuku's cheek. With the other, he reached back the lightly touch the soft, black feathers of his new wings.

"I like your wings." He said. "They're pretty."

Izuku smiled, leaned in to place a soft kiss on his lips. And for whatever reason, it was then that he remembered what Katsuki had said to him, before he'd left.

'Come right the fuck back. And then, if you really mean what you were about to say just now, then you can say it.'

Izuku sighed, pressing his forehead against Katsuki's, lacing his fingers through his hair.

"I love you, Kacchan." He whispered.

Katsuki's eyes widened a bit. Had he not been so close, he might not have noticed it at all. But then he hummed, and with the way his chest rumbled, it almost felt as though he were purring.

"Yeah," He replied. "Right back atcha, angel."

They sat there like that for a few seconds longer before a creaking sound from the left caught Izuku's attention, and he looked over just in time to watch as one of the structural pillars break, causing the church to cave in partway.

"We should probably, uhhh…"

"What?" Katsuki said, an eyebrow raised. "Doncha know, Deku? You're a Demon, now. That means you're fire-resistant."

Izuku rolled his eyes. "Being *able* to withstand fire and *wanting* to withstand fire are two very different things." He said, hopping off Katsuki's lap.

"Okay, yeah." Katsuki snorted. "Guess you got me there."

Fortunately, their clothes had managed to survive the fire, though Izuku's robe hadn't survived Katsuki. To his credit, Katsuki was decent enough to offer Izuku his tank top, which he accepted. He'd expected he'd need to ask Katsuki how to unshift, but when the desire came to him, it was as easy as breathing, really. With his wings out of the way, Izuku pulled the black tank top over his head, and they left.

As they walked together, Izuku realized how nice it was, not having to worry about his wings. It made his body feel less cumbersome. He was so light on his feet, he felt the urge to skip—so he did. Katsuki raised an eyebrow at him, but didn't otherwise comment.

He still wasn't really sure what to do with his tail. It sort of just swayed behind him, if he wasn't trying to use it. There were many things he'd have to ask Katsuki about, once he got the chance.

They were about a block away when a loud, creaking noise prompted them both to turn around, and Izuku's eyes widened as he watched the steeple collapse, the fire flaring up on impact. As he stood there staring at it, Izuku fidgeted with the hem of Katsuki's shirt. It was a lot looser on him, and it smelled like Katsuki. It brought a smile to Izuku's face, warmth curling up in his chest.

"Now that you're a Demon, we won't have to go through so much trouble to get you in and out of Hell."

Izuku tore his eyes away from the fire to look at him. "So, what's the process, then?"

"It's hardly a process, really." Katsuki shrugged. "I can just kinda hold your hand and walk into a shadow. Eventually, you'll be able to travel back and forth by yourself."

Izuku hummed, setting his gaze back on the flames. Silently, Katsuki laced his fingers through his. Izuku leaned against him.

"You ready?" He asked.

"Just a little longer."

Katsuki nodded, resting his cheek on top of his head.

And as they stood there, watching in comfortable silence, Izuku thought about how he'd felt before, about how nervous he'd been, how hesitant. As an Angel, the idea of Falling had the emotional weight of death. It felt like the end. And in some sense, Izuku supposed that was still technically true. But it didn't feel that way. Not anymore.

As he watched those flames rage on, he thought about what it'd look like, once they'd run their course. About the empty space they'd leave behind, and what that empty space could one day become. The possibilities were endless and varied, but the one common feature they all shared was that, in order for them to come to be, the church needed to be destroyed.

Because in some form or another, creation always came at the cost of destruction.

Izuku squeezed Katsuki's hand in his own. He breathed in the smoke, and it made him bloom.

This was only the beginning.

Chapter End Notes

so uhhhhhhhhhhh yeah that happened, huh. I kinda rushed to finish this today lol, I hope it turned out alright. past a certain length, it gets really hard for me to like, check and make sure all bases have been covered in terms of editing. like, I start losing track of the mental notes i make while writing, so it's easy for shit to fuck up and leave in stuff i

didn't mean to, or forget to replace something. especially when i write smut, I'll be like "this line is cringe, delete later" and then i just,,,, don't. idk, i guess all i can say is: i hope that these things, if present, do not destroy ur experience lol
but yeah, I hope the smut was worth the wait??? there'll be more later of course. we're right on the cusp of like the big climax (hahah climax) of the story. There's like,,,, 3 or 4 chapters left, I'm thinking. Small chance it could end up being 5, but probably not. I decided to change the chapter count thingy to 16/20, just so ppl will have a general idea

anyway, yeah. pretty chill chapter, not a lot of new plot-related shit (except for like, deku's weird ass dream) but after chapter 15 i guess it makes sense. So yeah, hope you enjoyed this, and if u did pls consider commenting to appease my dopamine receptors or whateverthefuck lmao. until next time!

Chapter 17: From the Ashes

Chapter Summary

> “Hey, Kacchan…?”
> “Yeah?”
> “I…” He hesitated for a moment. Then, “Why haven’t I remembered anything yet?”

Chapter Notes

> lol sorry this took so long im currently in tech job interview hell. anyway, this is 18.6k words yeeeeeee

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izuku stood before the foggy mirror in the bathroom of Katsuki’s apartment. Never before had he been so fascinated by his own reflection.

The cat-like slits of his pupils changed the character of his eyes in a way he couldn’t quite describe, and when he experimentally switched off the light, he found that he could see in the darkness much better than he could as an Angel. The green light of his eyes radiated outward, giving off an otherworldly glow.

He turned on the light again, leaning forward to examine his teeth. His canines were a lot sharper than they used to be, and carried a dull ache from the rapid growth.

His hands gravitated toward his damp hair. In his half-shifted state, his horns looked similar to Katsuki’s, at least at a glance. But as he slowly shifted, Izuku watched, entranced, as they grew outward, the little bumps lining the sides extending in all different directions as they gradually morphed into antlers. Izuku ran his fingertips over them. The surface was smooth and black, but had a slightly metallic, green sheen whenever the light hit them just right.

His hands fell limp at his sides, and Izuku sighed. He still wasn’t sure how he felt about having antlers. Katsuki had noted that they were rare, but in a way, that only made him more uncomfortable. Standing out wasn’t something he was accustomed to. What could possibly stand out more than a pair of big, shiny antlers?

Izuku wrung his wrists, his tail swaying gently behind him.

At least that part isn’t too unusual.

Izuku shook his head, returning to his half-shifted form before grabbing a towel to wrap around his waist. He emerged from the bathroom, and for a moment, he just stood there in the hall, eyes darting between the unmade pull-out bed in the living room and the open door to Katsuki's bedroom. He wasn't really sure where he was meant to go.

The sound of Katsuki's voice calling out to him was enough for him to make up his mind, though.

He crossed the short distance into Katsuki's room, where he found him sitting in bed, pillow propped up against the headboard as he lounged atop the covers in nothing but his boxers. Katsuki's brow was pinched as he tapped away at his touch pad, and when he looked to his right, he found Triplet curled up on what was probably meant to be Izuku's pillow.

He shut the door softly behind him, glanced down at his towel, and then around the room. It occurred to him then that he didn't have anything on hand to wear. His bag was still in the living room closet from his earlier stay, but save for a few stray items, most of his clothes weren't clean.

Izuku cleared his throat. "Um…"

Katsuki raised his head, one eyebrow arched. He took one look at the towel around Izuku's waist, and then pointed at the dresser on the other side of the room. "You can wear my clothes for now." He told him. "We'll get you more soon."

Izuku nodded, and headed over to Katsuki's dresser.

He opened the first drawer, and his brow wrinkled as he found himself staring at one of the most bizarre assortments of items he'd ever seen.

A large coil of bright red rope sat in the corner, and laying across the length of the drawer was a black riding crop. Alongside the crop was something that looked kind of like handcuffs, only with a long, metal bar stretching between one cuff and the other. At the back, there sat an abnormally large flashlight, and beyond that, a vast array of other objects he couldn't even try to identify.

Izuku stood there for a moment, just staring into the drawer, attempting to come up with a situation in which any of these items would go together. He squinted, imagining Katsuki riding on horseback at night, his tail wrapped around the flashlight, one hand holding the riding crop while the other gripped the rope. In his mind, he was using the rope as a lasso, attempting to capture something. Or perhaps some*one.* Who he would then proceed to shackle in those strange handcuffs, for some reason.

Off to the side was a pile of neatly folded underwear. Shrugging, Izuku grabbed a pair of basic, black boxer briefs, and slowly slid the drawer shut.

"Shirts in the second drawer." Katsuki muttered.

Izuku swallowed as he pulled the drawer open. This one, at least, was normal. He ran his fingers over the folded shirts until he found a soft, black t-shirt, which, upon closer

inspection, seemed to have a skull graphic on the front of it.

He slid the boxers on first, followed by the shirt. They were both pretty loose on him, but not so much that he'd have to worry about whether they'd stay on. With a sigh, he shut the drawer and turned, only to find Katsuki staring at him with this sort of smug appreciation.

Izuku squirmed. *"What?"*

"Nothin.'" He smirked.

Izuku shook his head, crawling into bed beside Katsuki. Triplet was still curled up on his pillow, and he didn't have the heart to disturb her, so he just cuddled up next to Katsuki instead, his head resting on his shoulder.

It was nice, being able to just… touch him like this. Katsuki wrapped his arm around him easily, pulling him closer to his side, like it was just natural. Izuku sighed in contentment, and peaked at the screen. Katsuki was voting again.

"Will I get to do that soon?"

"Mm." He nodded slightly. "There's a bit of a process, though. Every city's a little different, but ours is pretty straightforward. Basically, we just gotta go down to city hall and draw up a contract."

"Contract?"

"Yep." He turned off the touchpad and set it down on the nightstand. "Everybody's got one. Essentially, you just agree to contribute to the community to whatever extent you can, and the community agrees to support you. S'different depending on people's needs and desires, though. That's why it's gotta be discussed."

"Huh. So, when can we do that?"

"Eh, soon as you want, I guess. Just not tomorrow morning."

Izuku blinked. "What's tomorrow morning…?"

"Meeting." He grunted. "There's some people who wanna meet you, ask a couple more questions about your escape."

"Oh." Izuku bit his lip.

At the uncertain tone of his voice, Katsuki turned and looked at him. "Somethin' wrong?"

"Not really," he said. "I'm just… not sure if there's anything else I could say that would really help anything."

He shrugged. "Well, don't stress about it. Y'never know, but if it doesn't go anywhere, it's whatever."

Izuku gave a small smile. “Alright, Kacchan.”

Katsuki hummed, turning fully onto his side to face him. He began idly running his fingers down Izuku’s arm, then sliding over his hips and sides.

He squirmed. “That tickles.”

He grinned, but didn’t stop. “Oh yeah?”

“Yeah.” He winced, trying to scoot away, but Katsuki’s other arm snaked under him, holding him in place as he continued his aimless exploration. *“Kacchan.”* He whined.

“I’ve held off on touchin’ ya for over six months, nerd. Just let me have this.”

Izuku rolled his eyes, but gave in. Scooting closer, he buried his face in Katsuki’s chest and wrapped his arms around him. Eventually, Katsuki’s ministrations slowed, until he was just stroking up and down his back idly, and for several minutes, it was silent.

“Hey, Kacchan…?”

“Yeah?”

“I…” He hesitated for a moment. Then, “Why haven’t I remembered anything yet?”

Katsuki hummed, chest rumbling as he considered the question.

“It’s not always immediate.” He said, after a while. “Obviously, I can’t say from personal experience, but that’s what I’ve heard. I mean, some Fallen Angels take *months* to recover all their memories.” He paused for a second, sliding a hand into his hair, stroking gently. Izuku’s eyes fluttered. “Far as I’m aware, the only thing that’s been known to speed things up is if you actually meet someone you knew while you were human.”

Izuku frowned. “Oh…”

He didn’t even try to mask the disappointment in his voice.

After a moment, Katsuki sighed. “Listen,” He said. “It’ll happen eventually. It always does. Just gotta be patient, okay nerd?”

After a second, he nodded, and snuggled deeper into his arms. And in his warm embrace, Izuku drifted off easily.

The room was circular, with high ceilings and walls lined with bookshelves. He was standing at the center, near the top of a black spiral staircase, leaning against the rails. Staring down into the darkness below. And eventually, two figures emerged from the abyss, steadily climbing up.

As they drew near, he realized they were Acolytes. Izuku took a few steps back as they reached the top of the staircase, and came to stand before him.

“I’m afraid the yield was a bit lower than usual today.” The first one said, opening up a leather messenger bag. He pulled out a smooth, mahogany case and handed it to Izuku. After a second, he accepted it, and hesitantly reached for the golden latch on the front. Popping it open, Izuku slowly lifted the lid. Inside, he found two vials encased in soft foam. Swallowing, he pulled one out and held it up to the light. It was filled with a thick, dark liquid, and when he looked close enough, it almost seemed like he could see patterns swirling within it…

He glanced up at the Acolyte, who cocked his head.

“...Sir?”

Izuku gasped awake, sitting up in bed. His eyes darted around the dark room, as though he could expect an Acolyte to emerge from the shadows, but of course, that didn’t happen. It was just him, and Triplet, who slept curled up at the foot of the bed.

“Deku?”

Izuku’s breath hitched, and he looked to his right to find Katsuki lying on his side, one eye opened a crack. He glanced at the clock. It was around three in the morning.

“Whass wrong?” Katsuki slurred.

He gulped. “Nothing, I just…” He winced. “Had a weird dream, I guess.”

Katsuki hummed, and after a moment, reached up and grabbed the fabric of Izuku’s shirt, tugging gently. Izuku got the message, and laid down on his side again. Katsuki scooted closer, and threw a heavy arm around him, lacing his fingers through his hair to pull him closer. Izuku wrapped an arm around him as well, and tucked his head under Katsuki’s chin.

It was funny, how quickly he managed to forget about it. Wrapped up in the comfort of Katsuki’s warmth, he felt his anxiety melt away. And perhaps at a later time he might recall the dream and return to that place of fear, but here, in this moment, as he was moving toward sleep, all he could do was wonder how he’d ever gone without Katsuki’s touch.

Izuku woke the following morning to the sensation of something being placed on top of him —and for once, it wasn’t Triplet. He groaned, blinking groggily as his eyes gradually adjusted, and he realized it was a tray of food.

“Morning, jackass.” Katsuki said affectionately, standing at the foot of the bed. “Be careful not to spill that shit when you sit up.”

He grunted as he slowly propped himself up and scooted up the mattress. On the tray was a cup of coffee and a large plate with an assortment of what looked like exotic fruits. “What’s all this?”

“Call it the *Eating for Dummies Starter Pack.”* Izuku shot him a glare that Katsuki met with a teasing grin. “Nah, but seriously. Now that you’re a Demon, you’re gonna need to get used to eatin’ like the rest of us plebs. It helps to know what you like. Figured I’d just throw together an assortment of random shit, just so you can get an idea of what’s out there.”

“Oh,” Izuku blinked a few times, and smiled. “Thanks, Kacchan. That’s really thoughtful of you.”

“All I did was put things on a plate.” He said, shrugging.

But Izuku knew better; he could tell from the neat way the fruits were sliced, the careful arrangement on the plate. More effort went into it than he was letting on. “Still,” he said, picking up the coffee cup. “I appreciate it.” He took a sip.

Katsuki looked away. “Well, show your appreciation with your mouth, nerd.”

Izuku nearly choked on his coffee. “E-Excuse me?”

“The fruit, Deku.” Katsuki drawled. “I’m telling you to eat the fucking fruit.”

“Oh.” Izuku swallowed. “R-Right, right! Of course.” He laughed awkwardly, and then looked down at the plate. His eyes were drawn to something with white flesh and bright blue skin. It looked a bit like an apple, but when he poked at it with his fork, it was notably softer. “What’s this?”

“Aveldt. It’s mostly greed.”

Izuku hummed, sinking his fork into it and slowly pushing the bite into his mouth. The first thing he noticed was that it was sour. Not unbearably so, but definitely not what he’d been expecting. The texture was somewhat creamy, and as he chewed it, he noticed hints of sweetness.

“What do you think?”

Izuku swallowed. “I think I like it?” He said. “Maybe not all the time, though.”

“Mm. Well, try somethin’ else.”

Izuku scanned the plate, and his eyes landed on something purple. The slices were heart-shaped. “What’s that?”

“Gourkest. It’s like a hybrid of pride and lust, mainly.”

Izuku licked his lips as he picked up one of the slices. He took a small bite, and as his teeth sunk into it, he was hit with a tangy, savory sort of flavor. The fruit was dense, too; Izuku suspected he wouldn’t need to eat much of it to feel full. “This one’s fine, but it doesn’t really… seem like a *fruit,* if that makes sense? It’s almost like—”

“—Meat?” Katsuki finished, snorting softly. “Yeah. I’ll admit, it’s not exactly a light snack. Try another.”

He nodded, and pointed at another fruit. It was segmented like an orange, but pale pink in color. “This one?”

“Senvil.” Katsuki said. “Basically just pure gluttony.”

Izuku picked up a slice between his fingers, took a bite, and as his teeth sunk into the slice, it oozed a white, sticky substance. Immediately, an intense sweetness spread across his tongue. The consistency was thick, almost like syrup, and as soon as he’d gotten the slice into his mouth, he went for another.

“You have the palate of a child.”

“Rude.” Izuku said, scarfing it down and reaching for more again. This time, Katsuki grabbed his wrist.

“You’re gonna give yourself cavities.”

Izuku arched a brow. “Is dental care included in that contract you told me about?”

Katsuki blinked, his expression blank. “Well, yeah. Course it is.”

“Then I don’t care.” He yanked his wrist out of his grip, grabbing a few more slices and cramming them into his mouth all at once. “I like sweet things. Let me live!” He said, mouth still full of that thick, sweet juice.

Katsuki stared at him intently as he chewed. After a second, he sunk his knee into the mattress beside him. “Y’know what? You’re right.” He said, picking up a slice. “I shouldn’t be so critical. By all means, eat all the senvils you want, Deku.”

With that, he shoved the slice into Izuku’s mouth. A bit of thick, white juice leaked from the corners of his lips, and Katsuki’s eyes seemed to track the flow of it. After a moment, he scooped it up with his finger and pressed it back into his mouth. Izuku awkwardly closed his lips around his finger. “There you go. *Good boy.”*

Izuku flushed, narrowing his eyes. “Kacchan, are you…?”

“Yes.” He deadpanned, shoving his finger deeper into his mouth. “Yes, I am getting off on this. Thanks for asking.”

With his finger that deep, Izuku couldn’t really respond. His blush intensified, and he grabbed his wrist and pushed it gently away, swallowing the juice. “Too early for this.”

“Yeah?” He snorted. “It’s nine in the morning. What time am I allowed to make sexual advances on you?”

Izuku thought about it a moment. “I’d say around five o’clock onward.”

“Seriously?” He mumbled. “Damn. I want a refund.”

Izuku snorted. “Sorry, Kacchan. I don’t think Heaven is accepting returns.”

“What a fucking scam.” He muttered, just before he tilted Izuku’s chin up and pressed his lips to his. “I wanna speak to the manager.”

He laughed. “Who, *God?”*

“Nah, God’s, like… the CEO.”

“The Council?”

“Executives. Board of directors.” Katsuki said. “I’m thinkin’ probably the Acolytes.”

Acolytes.

Izuku tensed as he suddenly remembered the strange dream he’d had, his brain flooding with images. The circular room; the spiral staircase. The Acolytes. The wooden case. The *vials.*

It was all so vivid, so real. The worst part, however, was how… *normal* it felt, even now, as he was recalling it. Not in terms of content, but rather logic. Izuku’s dreams didn’t typically follow any sort of rational sequence of events; they made sense as they were happening, but the moment he woke up, the logic would quickly start to unravel. And it would be little things—an object that hadn’t been there before suddenly appearing before him, a normal action leading to bizarre consequences.

But this wasn’t like that. This was *stable,* grounded in reality. And this was the second night in a row he’d had a dream like that.

He didn’t like it.

Katsuki’s brow furrowed. “You okay?”

Izuku didn’t respond at first, lost in thought.

“Deku?”

“Ah! Sorry,” Izuku muttered. “Y-Yeah, I’m… fine. Um.” Unsure what to say, he hastily grabbed an odd, reddish pink berry off the plate and popped it into his mouth. Almost immediately, his eyes went wide and started to water. It was perhaps the spiciest thing he’d ever tasted. Wordlessly, Katsuki pushed his cup of coffee closer. Izuku drunk a good few sips of it, washing the taste out of his mouth. “What *was* that?”

“Ekkoberries. Basically just wrath.” He shrugged. “Not as intense as embrites, though.”

Izuku shook his head, taking another sip of his coffee, only to freeze. “Wait. Do I have to eat foods associated with a particular sin in order to do that kind of magic?”

“Nah. I mean, some people *claim* it helps them, but I call bullshit. There’s zero evidence to suggest they’re linked.” He said. “Magical classes are named based on the cardinal sin of the Original Demon who developed it. It has nothing to do with sin in, like, the *nutritional* sense.”

“Oh, thank god.” Katsuki raised an eyebrow. “I mean, uh. Thank… Lucifer?”

Katsuki snorted, rolling his eyes. A moment later, he said, “So, you’re thinkin’ of learning magic, huh?”

“I mean, yeah.” Izuku said. “As soon as possible, really.”

“Hmm, well I’m sure that can be arranged.” He smirked.

Izuku flushed, looking away. “What time did you say the meeting was?”

“I didn’t.” He replied. “But it’s in like an hour. Y’should probably get ready.”

Without another word, Izuku pulled back the covers and began getting dressed.

They left the apartment around thirty minutes later, and as they boarded the train, something occurred to Izuku.

“Kacchan?”

Katsuki grunted.

“You… why do you bother taking the train?”

He blinked. “What d’you mean?”

“Well, you can basically teleport, can’t you?”

“Oh.” A look of recognition crossed his face. “Yeah, thing about that is… it’s not really allowed. At least in most situations, anyway.” He shrugged. “Most cities have some sorta provision against using transport magic within city limits, ‘cuz it can actually really fuck up electronics.”

“Wait, seriously?”

“Yep.” He said. “So like, shadow jumping, and most other types of teleportation, are usually only used to travel around Earth, or to and from it.” They reached their stop, and the two of them stood up. “You can do it outside the cities, but y’gotta be careful. There’re a lot of smaller settlements.” The doors opened, and Katsuki took his hand as they stepped off the train. “Most of those techniques are either practiced out in the middle of nowhere, or in controlled environments with special insulation. The basement at the Academy is like that, actually.”

“Huh…” Izuku looked around, his eyes drawn to the park as they walked. When he eventually looked back at Katsuki, he asked, “Well, what about your sigil?” He glanced at the marking on his bicep. “That doesn’t cause similar problems?”

“It actually can, but only if you’re tryin’ to communicate with someone whose sigil you don’t know. Long as you’ve got it in your head, you’re fine.” He paused as they turned the corner.

Izuku could see the main building of the Academy up ahead. “The magic *is* similar, though. That’s kinda what’s interesting about it. Theoretically, it should be possible to use sigils for transportation as well, but so far no one’s been able to come up with a practical way to do it.”

“Huh…” Izuku’s brows pinched together. They reached the front steps, and began to ascend. “How does it work, exactly?”

“I dunno. M’not a fuckin’ chthonic physicist, nerd.” Katsuki snorted. “I think the answer has somethin’ to do with vectors, but I’m not sure. You could read about it, if you want. Or take a class.”

As they entered the building, Katsuki placed his hand over his sigil, and it began to glow. “We’re here.” He waited a moment. “Gotcha.” He turned to Izuku. “Third floor.” He said, and set off toward the stairs.

Izuku followed, and as they entered the stairwell, he asked, “Will I get my own sigil?”

“I mean, sure, if you want one.” Katsuki replied. “Not every Demon has one, though. They’re actually pretty rare if you’re not a magic user.” He paused, glancing back at him. “Course, most of us on defense have ‘em, for practical purposes.“

They were starting up the second flight of stairs.

“Huh.” Izuku said. “I mean, couldn’t you just use some sort of technological device?”

“Like a phone?” Katsuki raised an eyebrow.

Izuku nodded, and as they reached the top, Katsuki pushed the door open, and held it for him.

“Yeah, two main problems with that.” Katsuki raised a finger. “One, you could lose it.” He lifted a second finger. “And two, they don’t work everywhere. Calls between Hell and Earth are basically impossible without *some* sorta magic, and like most electronics, that shit won’t work in the Depths.” He paused. “Hell, even sigils have limited range once you’re deep enough.”

“I guess that makes sense…” He trailed off, following him as they continued down the hallway.

“So?” Katsuki said. “D’you want one?”

“I mean, sure.” He shrugged. “They seem pretty useful.”

They came to stop before a redwood door. “Well, I’m sure that can be arranged.” Katsuki grinned as he echoed his statement from earlier. With that, he pushed the door open, and they entered a small conference room. At the center was a round table, where two men he’d never met before sat.

The first one on the left was a man with shaggy, red hair. He appeared to be fiddling with something, though Izuku wasn’t close enough to see what it was. Regardless, he seemed to be

intensely focused on it, and did not look up as they entered.

The second man was a different story.

“Ah, you must be Midoriya.” He said, standing up from his seat. As the man circled around the table to greet him, Izuku couldn’t help but notice the jarringly formal nature of his attire; while the first man wore only a wrinkled t-shirt and sweats, the second was clad in a tailored black suit and tie. When he came to stand before Izuku, he noted that he was roughly the same height as Katsuki.

There was another thing he noticed. Namely, the guy was almost absurdly handsome. Part of that was surely due to the well-kept nature of his appearance; his dark, brown locks slightly wavy, but neatly combed such that not a hair was left out of place. When he smiled at Izuku, the skin around his violet eyes crinkled, and his sharp teeth were almost too white for reality.

He shook Izuku’s hand firmly, and then folded his hands behind his back.

“I wanted to thank you.” He said. “What you did was incredibly brave. Without your help, this would’ve never been possible.”

Izuku blushed, averting his eyes. “It’s no problem, really.” He cleared his throat. “Um. And you are…?”

He heard Katsuki’s mouth open, but the man beat him to the punch.

“Luke.” He said, his eyes locked on Katsuki rather than Izuku. “Just call me Luke.”

With that, Luke looked over his shoulder at the red-headed man. “Bee? Are you going to introduce yourself?”

The man—*Bee, allegedly*—blinked a few times, as though his mind had just returned after a long trip away. Slowly, he looked up at them and froze. Then, he stood up so quickly, the chair squealed across the floor.

“Oh, fuck.” He muttered. “Uh… Uh, sorry. Midoriya, right?” He extended his hand across the table, but before Izuku could accept the handshake, his eyes widened, and he yanked his hand away. “Shit, sorry!” He hissed, blushing. “I just realized my hand’s, like, *really* sticky. You, uh… probably don’t want to…” He trailed off, eyes drawn to the table. It was only then that Izuku was actually able to tell what he’d been up to. There, on the table, was what seemed to be a long strip of bubble gum, peeled into multiple thinner strips. It looked like he’d been working on braiding them. “Uh, anyway. I’m, uhh… Yeah. I’m just gonna…” He awkwardly sat down again.

Izuku couldn’t help but smile. “It’s nice to meet you, Bee.”

“Where’s Levi?” Katsuki asked. “Wasn’t he supposed to be here too?”

“Ah.” Luke grinned. “Behold.”

With that, he walked right up to a chair that seemed to be empty, and collapsed onto it. Only he never actually touched the chair, and upon hitting the invisible barrier, someone grunted. Seconds later, the air shimmered, revealing a man with dark, olive skin and long, black hair tied back in a ponytail. He firmly pushed Luke off of his lap, and after a minor stumble, he put his hands up in the air, as though he had just nailed the landing following some insane feat of gymnastics.

When Levi stood, Izuku's eyes went wide. The man was insanely tall, and as he leaned across the table to shake Izuku's hand, he was further amazed at how small his own hand felt compared to his.

"Midoriya, right? I'm Levi." He said. "Sorry, I actually fell asleep."

"Oh, no worries." Izuku smiled. "Uh, how tall are you…?" He blurted out.

"Seven-foot-five." He replied, without missing a beat.

"Seven-foot-five." Izuku repeated to himself. "Ah, sorry, you probably get asked that a lot."

He shrugged. "I'm used to it. For the record, though—no, I don't play basketball. And the weather up here is fine."

Izuku giggled softly, pulling out a chair and sitting down, as Katsuki did the same beside him. It was around then that Aizawa entered, carrying a pot of coffee and a stack of paper cups. Following behind him was a tall woman with black hair and silver eyes that Izuku didn't recognize. Aizawa looked at him, and faltered. "Midoriya?"

"Ah." Izuku looked away nervously. "Um, yep."

"I was meaning to ask about that," Luke said. "I was under the impression that you were still an Angel."

Katsuki smirked. "It's a recent development."

Izuku flushed, directing his attention to the woman Aizawa had entered with. "Um, I don't think we've met."

She smiled, holding her hand out to him. "Pleased to meet you, Midoriya." She said. "My name's Setsuko Kaneshiro—but please, call me Setsuko."

Izuku froze, his eyes going wide. He was so shocked, he nearly forgot to shake her hand, and went he remembered, he hastily did so vigorously.

"S-Setsuko? As in…?"

"Yep." Katsuki grunted. *"That* Setsuko."

Izuku gulped, recalling memories of early conversations with Katsuki, of journal entries he'd read, classes he'd taken—all of it, rushing back to the surface.

Izaiya and Setsuko.

The spies who rejected God.

“I, uhh, learned about you in school.” Izuku said, and then immediately wondered why he’d done it.

“Oh?” Setsuko raised an eyebrow. “Do I even want to know what they taught you about me?”

Izuku laughed awkwardly. “Probably not…” He paused. “For the record, I don’t believe any of it, though.”

She giggled, and pulled out a chair to sit.

Looking bored, Aizawa gave Luke a pointed look. “You were going to ask him some questions?”

“Oh, yes.” He said, lacing his fingers together on the table. “There were a couple of things I wanted to ask about, but let’s start with the illusion. Could you elaborate on that?”

Izuku blinked. “Sure, but… why?”

“Acolytes use illusions as interrogation tactics primarily. Knowing what the illusion involved will give us insight into what they were hoping to gain.”

“Ah.” Izuku nodded. “Well… they essentially just had me re-living my time down here, before I left.”

Luke hummed. “Yes, we figured it’d be something like that. How much information were they able to get?”

“Well, I mean… we made it through to the last day. I broke the illusion while I was, uh, on a hiking trip with Kacchan.” He explained, shifting nervously in his seat. “So I guess they know that we’re planning something… though I guess, to be fair, they probably already knew that when they caught me.”

“I see. And you were not in on the discussions, correct?”

“No, thankfully.” Izuku sighed.

“Well, that’s one thing down, then.” He said. “The other thing was this. You mentioned seeing a Councilman on your way out. Can you tell us a bit more about him?”

“Um…” Izuku rubbed the back of his neck. “I mean, there’s not much I can really say. He was too far away for me to see his face.” He squinted. “We didn’t really interact, he just kind of… shouted at me from a balcony a few stories up.” He gave a wobbly smile. “If it weren’t for him, I might have made it out without anyone noticing.”

“What did he shout?” Setsuko asked.

“He just told the Acolytes to stop me.”

She hummed, narrowing her eyes. “And when he did this, did you notice anything odd? Like, for example, multiple Acolytes moving simultaneously?”

Izuku’s eyes widened. “That’s… yes. How did you know?”

“Setsuko here is our top authority on all things concerning the Council.” Luke said, smiling fondly. “She knows everything there is to know about them.”

“Well, no.” She said. “There’s actually quite a lot I *don’t* know about them. It just so happens that Midoriya, here, has apparently interacted with one of the more familiar ones. Namely, my old boss.” She sighed. “Councilman Three. *The Commander.”*

Izuku’s mind flashed with memories of notebook paper and carefully copied correspondences. “The journal entries. The ones from you and Izaiya. They were always addressed to a commander.”

“Ah, very astute observation.” She smiled. “You’re correct. However, Commander isn’t a rank—it’s a title. One that specifically refers to his particular ability.” She paused, reaching for the coffee pot and pouring herself a cup. “Essentially, he can use vocal commands to force others to do his bidding. There are limits, though. To my knowledge, it doesn’t work on Demons, and he can’t issue differing commands simultaneously.” She took a sip of her coffee. “So, for instance, he couldn’t command one person to dance and another person to sing. The number of people he can control at once is virtually infinite, but any commands issued must apply to all of them equally.”

Izuku leaned in, nodding along with rapt attention. But there was a problem he couldn’t get past. “That… doesn’t sound like a very natural extension of Angel magic.”

“You’re right. It isn’t.” Setsuko replied. “That’s because in addition to the standard soul-magic Angels use, members of the Council also have their own unique powers. Powers which are said to be gifts from God himself.”

She stood up then, approaching the white board at the other end of the room. She pulled the cap off a marker and began writing a vertical list, numbered from one to six.

“There are six Councilmen. Each one is granted a special ability which correlates to a particular virtue, and a title—such as *The Commander*—that references that ability.”

Next to the number one, she wrote *‘The Healer.’*

“One is the Healer; the Councilman of Forgiveness. His power includes the ability to heal his own injuries at an accelerated rate.”

After two, she wrote *‘The Rejector.’*

“As the Councilman of Temperance, the Rejector can both manifest and eliminate the consequences of various forms of deprivation in others. Things like thirst, hunger, sleep—all of these are things Two can either increase or decrease, much like turning a dial.”

She wrote *'The Commander'* next, but skipped over the explanation, and simply moved on to the fourth: *'The Cleanser.'*

"This is the Councilman of Purity. His powers involve memory manipulation, up to and including elimination."

After that, she quickly wrote out two more titles. Beside five, she wrote, *'The Martyr,'* and next to six, *'The Violator.'*

She turned toward the table, tapping the whiteboard with the marker. "These are our two primary unknowns. The Martyr is the Councilman of Sacrifice, and the Violator is the Councilman of Humility. But apart from those basic facts, little is known about their powers."

"Well, they're all kind of unknowns, aren't they?" Bee chimed in. "Since we don't necessarily know the full scope of the others' powers."

"That's true." Levi agreed. "We need to be prepared for anything."

"Hit 'em hard when they're not expectin' it." Katsuki said.

"No one asked about your sex life, Bakugou." Luke commented.

The others stifled snorts.

"Very funny, *'Luke.'"* Katsuki said, using air quotes. "Y'know what else would be funny? Turning the ceiling fan up to the highest setting after I string you up there by your shitty tie." Katsuki grabbed a paper cup and reached for the coffee pot, pouring himself a cup. "And for the record, people *expect* it when I hit them. That's kinda the whole point."

"Enough." Aizawa said, the bags under his eyes somehow deeper. "Setsuko, please continue."

Setsuko coughed, a poor attempt at covering up her laughter. "Right. Anyway." She cleared her throat. "To my knowledge, no one outside of Heaven knows about Five or Six's powers."

"Is there anything else you can tell us about them?" Levi asked. "Anything, really. Even if it doesn't seem important."

She sighed. "All I know of the Martyr is that, for whatever reason, the Commander always seemed to despise him. And as for the Violator… well. Unfortunately, I Fell before he was even inducted."

"Well, maybe we'll be able to find out more tonight." Luke said, elbowing Levi.

Levi sighed. "Luke, the mission is to plant more seeds. Nothing else."

"Well, sure." He shrugged. "I'm not saying you should try anything risky. Just, you know—if you happen to see something while you're up there."

"I doubt I'll be there long enough to see much of anything."

“Uhh, sorry.” Izuku interjected. “What are you talking about, exactly?”

“Oh, right.” Luke said. “Levi, here, is going to Heaven tonight.”

“It’s a strategic mission.” Levi said. “I’ll just be planting a few more gravity seeds.”

Izuku blinked. “Wait… you mean *alone?”*

Levi nodded. “For stealth missions, the fewer people involved, the better.”

“I mean, I guess?” He chewed his lip. “But… I don’t know. That seems *really* dangerous.”

“Maybe for some people, but him? You’ve got nothing to worry about, I assure you.” Luke smiled, smacking him on the shoulder. “Levi once looked the Depths Siren dead in the eye and came out of it unscathed.”

“That’s a baseless rumor and you know it.” Levi deadpanned.

“Oh, whatever.”

Levi closed his eyes and took a deep breath. “Do you know how many researchers have contacted me since you started spreading that around?” He opened his eyes, and the blank stare he threw Luke’s way told Izuku this was a conversation they’d had many times before. “Actions have consequences. At this point, you’re actively polluting scientific discourse.”

“Sure, but people should know not to trust me by now, don’t you think?”

“Unbelievable.”

“I’m just saying. I’ve been doing this for centuries. At a some point, surely the people who continue to take everything I say at face-value must bear *some* of the blame, yes?”

“They take you seriously because you have a Ph.D in chthonic ecology.”

He froze. “…Wait, I *do?”*

“You do.”

Luke stared at him for a moment, and then looked down at the table. He mouthed, *“What the fuck.”*

Levi groaned. “Whatever.” He looked up at Izuku and Katsuki. “Sorry to keep you two. We appreciate you answering our questions, Midoriya.“

“Ah, it’s no problem.” Izuku gave a wobbly smile.

“Is there anything you’d like to ask us?” Bee asked, his mouth full of chewing gum.

“I mean….” Izuku hesitated, thinking it over. There was one thing he kept coming back to, ever since he’d woken up—namely, the dream. But he wasn’t sure what to ask, wasn’t sure how to phrase a question about it in a productive manner.

Eventually, he settled on asking, “Are there any updates on the vial I found in the Acolyte’s pocket?”

“Ah. Thanks for reminding me.” Aizawa said. “Apparently, it’s mostly just a mixture of water, sucrose, and something called, uhh…” He squinted. “Polyphenics…?”

“Polyphenols.” Katsuki corrected him.

“That’s it.” Aizawa snapped his fingers. “Basically, it’s chemically similar to maple syrup, or at least it appears to be. They’ve sent it to the chemoturgic lab in Eyrket for further testing.”

Izuku’s brow furrowed. “Chemo…. What?”

“Chemoturgy.” Katsuki said. “The study of intersections between magical and chemical phenomena.”

“Huh. That’s interesting.” Izuku said. “Well, do you know how long it’ll be before we hear back?”

“Probably something like a week, but it’s hard to say.” Aizawa replied.

Izuku bit his lip, nodding slowly.

“Any other questions?” Levi asked.

“Yes, actually.” Izuku cleared his throat. “Uh, when exactly is the invasion?”

“Counting today?” Luke said. “Thirteen days out.”

Izuku did not expect to be invited when the actual invasion took place, and even less so after they left the Academy that day.

At the end of the meeting, Aizawa mentioned something about wanting to involve as few people as possible, so as to avoid attracting too much attention. It made sense, of course; given that the innermost circle shared its wall with the third circle, where most third-sphere Angels resided, it was only logical to want to keep things contained for as long as possible. Because as soon as God fell, it would all be over. Anything else was merely an obstacle standing between them and that ultimate goal.

So naturally, they would need to be selective. Only the strongest among them would be eligible, and though he hated to admit it, there simply was no reality where Izuku fit the bill.

He sighed, sliding his hands into his pockets as they walked down the sidewalk.

“Somethin’ wrong?”

“Huh?” Izuku tensed. “Oh. No, it’s nothing.”

Katsuki side-eyed him, openly skeptical.

Izuku sighed again, shoulders sagging. “I just… wish I could do more.”

He stared at him for a moment, blinking slowly. Then, “Deku. You’re literally the *reason* any of this shit is possible.” He rolled his eyes. “Leave some glory for the rest of us, ya fuck.”

Izuku huffed a small, exhausted laugh. For a minute, it was silent, apart from the ever-present soundtrack of the surrounding city.

“Kacchan?”

“Mm?”

Izuku hesitated, eyes fixated on a group of teenagers rollerskating down the street. One of them fell, and the others attempted to stop and help, with varying degrees of success. Izuku shook his head, tearing his eyes away and instead focusing on his feet as he traversed the concrete.

“What happens… you know… *after?”*

Katsuki didn’t respond immediately, but after a few seconds, he sighed. “Hard to say. I mean, if the mission fails? Who the fuck knows what’ll happen. Figure it’s safe to assume shit’ll get real bad real fast, though.”

Izuku didn’t say anything. He just nodded, his eyes still fixated on the ground.

“But… if we win?” He continued. “Things’ll improve, eventually—at least in terms of morale. We may be dealing with the fallout for quite a while, though. Who knows.” They turned the corner, and passed a couple walking a small, furry creature that Izuku couldn’t identify. “When everything’s settled, the Defense department will gradually phase out. Not entirely, but mostly.”

That caught Izuku’s attention. “Oh, really?” He raised an eyebrow. “Why?”

Katsuki shrugged. “Militaries are only necessary when other people have them. If no one had an army, no one would *need* an army.”

Izuku frowned. “But then… what would *you* do?”

“Me?” Katsuki stretched his arms over his head, yawning. “I dunno. Might try somethin’ new. Or maybe I’ll just go back to what I did before shit hit the fan.”

“…You had a job *before* this?”

“Sure. I’ve had a few, actually.” He replied. “Used to design clothes. Did that for a while. After that, I worked in a chem lab for a couple decades. Mostly focused on developing weather-resistant building materials.”

“Seriously?”

“Yep.” Katsuki grinned. “There were a couple others in between, but those were the main ones. I still visit the lab sometimes, just to see what they’re up to these days.”

“Wow,” Izuku muttered. “That’s… unexpected.”

“Oh yeah?” He raised an eyebrow. “How so?”

“I dunno.” He rubbed the back of his neck. “I guess I just always imagined you fighting.”

“Well, I’ve always *fought.* It just wasn’t always my *job.”*

“Still…” Izuku bit his lip, and tried to imagine him in those roles. Katsuki, sitting at a desk, sketching out designs next to an old sewing machine. Katsuki wearing a white lab coat and goggles, swirling some colorful liquid inside an erlenmeyer flask. The longer he thought about it, the more he longed to see it for himself, to experience all sides of Katsuki first hand.

Someday, he told himself. *When the dust settles.*

***If** it settles.*

“Oh, by the way.” Katsuki spoke again, breaking him out of his fantasies. “Just so you know, I heard about what happened with the substance you found in the Acolyte’s uniform. Aizawa told me.” He said. “I just want you to know, if you ever tried to touch any sorta mystery chemical in *my* lab with your bare hands, I’d throw you the fuck out, bouncer style. Just like I used to toss out creeps at the strip club I worked at on Earth.”

“The what?”

Katsuki snickered. “It’s a long story.”

Around ten minutes later, Katsuki led him through the front entrance of what looked like an odd hybrid between a fabric store and a workshop of sorts. The walls were lined with dozens of rolls of white fabric of all different types, but the floors and ceilings were occupied by numerous large, steel contraptions, and machines Izuku couldn’t identify.

As they entered, Katsuki waved at the lone attendant sitting behind the counter, and then headed straight to the back. Around the corner were what looked like dressing rooms. As they stepped inside one, the first thing he noticed was that it was a lot bigger than most he’d seen on Earth, and on the back of the door, there was a large touch screen.

“Um, what’s all this?”

“A catalogue.” Katsuki said. “Ya go through it and select the clothes you think you’d like.”

“Huh.” He leaned in, scanning over the interface. “And the attendant will bring them to me…?”

“Nope.”

Izuku faltered, turning to look at him over his shoulder. “I’m…” He narrowed his eyes. “Not sure I understand?”

Katsuki snorted. “Just pick something. You’ll see.”

Izuku shrugged, and began flipping through the options. He found a simple red button-up shirt and black pants, and selected it.

“Now what?”

“Now…” He grinned. “Take off your clothes.”

He flushed. *“Wh-What?”*

“We’re in a changing room, Deku.” Katsuki rolled his eyes. “What did you *think* was gonna happen?”

Izuku stared at him a moment longer, but eventually, he shook his head and gave in. Averting his eyes and muttering under his breath, he began to remove his clothing, stripping down to his underwear.

“Those too.”

Izuku squawked. “What? *Why?!”*

“If you want it to measure you correctly, you gotta get naked.” He smirked, then leaned back on the bench, legs splayed as he stared at Izuku, eyes roaming up and down his body shamelessly. “Well, go on.”

“D-Do you have to be in here?”

Katsuki scoffed. “Fuck’s sake, Deku. I had you bouncing on my dick *last night.”*

Izuku whined, but with a deep blush, he shed his underwear. “Now what?”

Katsuki didn’t respond, at first, too busy openly eye-fucking him.

“Kacchan.”

He rolled his eyes. “Just push the green button.”

Izuku did, and then suddenly, the lenses on all sides of the changing room began to glow, shooting thin lines of light that scanned down his frame. And then, suddenly the image in the mirrors changed. In his reflection, he was wearing the outfit he’d selected, though as he looked down his body, he found that he was still naked.

Katsuki stood up, standing beside him as Izuku looked in the mirror, turning around, checking himself out. Katsuki whistled lowly. “Pretty sharp.” He said. And then he proceeded to smack Izuku’s bare ass, the sound of his hand hitting flesh echoing in the changing area.

He yelped. “Kacchan!”

Katsuki snickered, leaning back against the wall. “Try somethin’ else.”

Izuku grumbled under his breath, but turned back to the screen nonetheless. He flipped through the pages, chewing his lip. There were just so many options. He wasn’t sure how to even begin searching for things he’d actually want.

And so he told Katsuki as much.

He hummed. “Well, you could try just hitting the ‘randomize’ button, see what comes up.” He offered. “It’s down there in the bottom left corner.”

Izuku nodded, locating the button and tapping it without hesitation. The mirror instantly changed to display a simulation of Izuku wearing a three-piece, floral print suit—a concept which would have been dubious enough on its own, but was made infinitely worse by the fact that each individual piece was actually a *different type of floral print.*

“Well, damn.” Katsuki snorted. “That might actually be the most hideous shit I’ve ever seen.”

Izuku winced, quickly tapping the button again. This time, it was a lavender sweater over a white, collared shirt, paired with white pants and brown oxford shoes. Izuku turned and looked himself over. “This isn’t too bad.”

“You look like you’re about to knock on my door and ask if I’ve accepted Jesus Christ as my personal lord and savior.” Katsuki deadpanned.

Izuku frowned, looking away. “Oh. Um, okay.” He turned toward the screen, and was about to hit the button again, but stopped when Katsuki spoke.

“I never said that was a *bad* thing.” He said, clicking his tongue. “If you like it, you should get it.”

Izuku blinked a few times, looking over at him. “Ah… Well, okay then. How do I do that, exactly?”

Katsuki leaned in, pointing out the ‘add’ button, and Izuku selected it with a small smile. Finally, he was getting somewhere.

He hit the ‘randomize’ button again, and froze upon seeing his reflection, momentarily speechless. Katsuki immediately burst out laughing.

Because Izuku was now wearing an Angel costume, of all things.

The fake, white wings clung to the straps around his shoulders, and hovering above his head was a golden halo, attached to a thin wire extending from the headband that sat just behind Izuku’s horns. Both the wings and halo wobbled in the simulation every time he moved. On his feet, he wore a pair of gold sandals that laced up to his knees in criss-crossing patterns,

and the little white skirt was so short, Izuku found himself trying to smooth it down before remembering he wasn't actually wearing anything.

He pursed his lips, shuffling in place. "This… looks nothing like an actual Angel."

Katsuki snorted. "It's a Halloween costume, Deku." He said, shaking his head. "And honestly, it looks pretty good on ya. You should consider it."

Izuku side-eyed him, and then hit 'randomize' again. Katsuki sighed, and rolled his eyes.

The next few outfits were more or less normal, and though most weren't really his style, there were a couple he did like alright. It wasn't until he was around twenty outfits in that he found one he really *loved.*

The pants were black, high-waisted, topped with two columns of three buttons on the closure, similar to a double-breasted suit. Beneath the pants was a burgundy halter-style top. But what really struck Izuku was the garment overlaying it.

He wouldn't quite describe it as a shirt, but it was black, with a grey 'X' shape over the chest. The bottom of the 'X' gave way to a hem that dropped lower in the back, not unlike a tailcoat, while the top split into multiple tree-like branches, to which several round, red crystals were attached.

The branches wrapped around his shoulders, converging together at the back, forming a window through which his wings could emerge.

The tail of the garment was adorned with grey embroidery that gradually faded to gold, and took on the shape of roots.

"Huh." Katsuki said. "Didn't know that was still in the system."

Izuku managed to tear his eyes away from his reflection in order to look at him. "What do you mean?"

"That's my design." Katsuki said, shrugging—as though it was *no big deal.*

Izuku's eyes went wide. "Wait, *really?!"*

"Mhm," Katsuki nodded. "I wanna say it was around a hundred years ago."

"Kacchan, this is *gorgeous."*

"Yeah?" Katsuki smirked. He sauntered up behind him, placing his hands on his shoulders. "Well, it looks pretty damn good on you, I'll tell ya that."

Izuku flushed, chewing his lip. Katsuki released him so he could check himself out, turning his body this way and that. "…C-Can I get it?"

Katsuki hummed, a sort of pleased rumbling deep in his chest as he closed in behind him again, wrapped his arms around Izuku's waist and rested his chin on the top of his head.

“‘Course, baby.” He all but purred. Izuku shivered, felt a rush of heat run through his body as Katsuki’s thumbs drew small circles on his ribs. Shakily, he reached for the screen and hit ‘add.’

“N-Not sure how anything else is supposed to top that,” he said, with a small, awkward laugh.

Katsuki smirked, slowly pulling away. “Well, that’s alright.” He sighed. “We should probably move on to some of the more basic things, anyway.”

Biting his lip, Izuku nodded slowly. And from there, he stepped aside and let Katsuki take the reigns. He ran down a list of basic wardrobe elements, sorting and selecting options with practiced ease. Casual, formal, sleepwear, athletic wear—one by one, they crossed them off the list. Once all of it was out of the way, Katsuki scrolled through the items and tapped a few of them, so that the options were highlighted green.

“What are you doing?”

“Just marking which ones to prioritize.” He said. “They should all be done within a few days, but it’s good to have a couple of things for right now.”

“Oh.” Izuku said. “You mean they’re all made to order?”

“Most of them, save for a couple of the most basic ones.” He tapped a few more. “Alright, we’re set.” Katsuki hit a button that said ‘confirm,’ and immediately, there was a beeping sound, along with a series of mechanical clicks. Katsuki opened the door and led him out to the floor of the shop, just in time for him to watch one of the many rolls of white fabric start to unravel as a large, robotic arm dragged it out onto the counter.

A second arm, with a rotary tool attached, then lowered onto it, and in a series of rapid, efficient movements, it cut out the pieces of the pattern, and trimmed away the excess.

A large, opaque dome lowered from the ceiling, hiding the fabric from view for a minute, and when it lifted off, it was dyed a light blue. Izuku watched, entranced, as the first arm came down and lifted the pieces away, whisking them over to a massive machine near the back, which swallowed the fabric like a paper scanner. He heard the fast, repetitive clicking of a sewing machine from within. Meanwhile, the cutting machine had already begun working on the next garment.

A shirt emerged from the sewing machine just as the pattern pieces for the next item were going into it. Katsuki grabbed it off the conveyer belt and handed it to Izuku. It was just a simple, blue shirt, made from light, breathable material—one he recognized from when they were looking at exercise clothing. A minute later, a pair of sweatpants emerged, and Katsuki handed them off to him, as well.

“You should go put those on.” Katsuki said. “We’re goin’ to train after this.”

“…We are?”

Katsuki grinned. “You said you wanted to learn magic, didn’t you?”

“Ah, right. Of course.”

He lingered a moment longer, watching the machine work. There were a couple of tools laid out nearby—wrenches, screwdrivers— but at the moment, the shop attendant wasn’t even really looking at the machine. He had his feet up on the counter, and was picking at the strings of something that looked almost like a ukulele, but not quite.

Eventually, Izuku tore his attention away from the whole spectacle, and headed back to the changing area to slip into the freshly-made clothes. The fabric was soft against his skin, and the fit was nearly identical to the simulation.

By the time he emerged, the machine was already finished.

Half an hour later, they were once again ascending the front steps of the Academy, only this time, instead of heading upstairs upon entering, Katsuki led him down a wide hallway on the first floor.

“The training rooms are just through here.” He told him, backing up into the crash bar on the door to a larger gymnasium. But as they entered, they soon realized it wasn’t empty.

Izuku recognized Kaminari’s voice before he actually saw him. “Oh, hey Baku—*holy shit.”*

He looked up, and found Kaminari, Sero, Kirishima, Mina and Jirou all standing around in gym clothes not unlike Izuku’s, and it was at this precise moment when Izuku realized that this was his first time seeing any of them since he Fell.

Mina attacked first.

Squealing, she came running over, and as soon she was with within range, she reached out and started pinching his cheeks. “Holy shit, it’s true! Oh my god, you look so *cute,* and are those—?” She gasped, brushing his hair out of the way, examining his horns. In their half-shifted state, they didn’t look *too* unusual, but at close range, it was easy to tell the difference. *“Oh-my-god-you-have-antlers!”* She gushed.

“Oh shit, for real?” Sero said, approaching at a much more leisurely pace, along with Kaminari, Jirou and Kirishima.

Kaminari came to stand near Mina, leaning in. “Damn.” He whistled. “Haven’t seen those in…” He squinted. “Actually, never?”

“Wow. It’d be really cool to see you fully shifted, when you get the chance, man.” Kirishima grinned. “Only if you want to, of course.”

“Maybe later.” Izuku smiled, though his cheeks were red. “I’m not really dressed appropriately right now.”

“You could take your clothes off.” Kaminari suggested, to which Katsuki responded with a sharp smack upside his head. “Ow! Jeez, I was kidding! Possessive, much?” Katsuki raised his hand again, a silent threat. Kaminari put his hands up and backed away.

Izuku cleared his throat awkwardly.

“So, when did this happen?” Sero asked. “Yesterday?”

“Ah, yes.” Izuku nodded.

“You mean… at the church…?” Jirou raised her eyebrows.

Izuku averted his eyes as Mina started to giggle uncontrollably.

“Ohh, so *that's* why the church burned down…” Kaminari said.

“Yep.” Katsuki said, popping the ‘p’ sound. “And for once, I wasn’t responsible for it. Not directly, at least.” He smirked. “Anyway, we’re gonna leave before you start askin’ weird questions.”

“Hey, Midoriya.” Kaminari called out. “How was it?”

Izuku flushed. “How was what?”

“We may never know.” Katsuki said curtly, as he hooked his elbow under Izuku’s arm and started to drag him away. The others shouted after them, but there were too many people speaking for Izuku to pick anything out. So instead, he just smiled awkwardly over his shoulder and waved, as Katsuki dragged him out into the hallway. The heavy double doors shut behind them, and Katsuki released his arm.

Izuku followed him down another hallway, until they reached the second to last door on the left. Katsuki opened it up and held the door for him, then stepped inside and flicked the light on.

The training room was far nicer than the one they’d been using on the surface, presumably because this one was actually maintained.

Katsuki shut the door and locked it, then strode over to a closet on the other end. He slid the door open, and hauled out something large and rectangular. He carried it to the center of the room and set it down. It was only when he removed the opaque cover that Izuku realized what it was: a touch stone.

“Take off your shoes ’n come over here.”

Izuku was quick to obey, stumbling to toe off his sneakers before running over. He came to stand in front of the touch stone, with Katsuki on his left.

He crossed his arms, and looked at Izuku expectantly. “Well, go on. Try it.”

“What do you mean?”

He shrugged. “Just stick your hands in there,” He pointed at the impressions, “and see if you can make somethin’ happen.”

Izuku pursed his lips and took a moment to roll his shoulders. Then he took another step toward it, and proceeded to do just that.

When he pressed his hands into the impressions, at first, the stone didn’t appear to change at all. The shiny orb just floated up and down gently, and all he could see was his own warped reflection staring back at him.

His brow furrowed. He wasn’t really sure what Katsuki meant by making something happen, but after a moment, an idea came to him. Jaw clenched, Izuku did his best to recreate the sensation of raising his barrier. He narrowed his eyes, watching carefully, but if it had changed at all, he couldn’t tell.

He glanced over at Katsuki. “Is anything happening…?”

Katsuki hummed and reached out, and as he touched the surface, he raised his eyebrows. He made a fist and proceeded to knock his knuckles against the stone. The sound it produced was reminiscent of solid glass. “Huh. That’s interesting. What’re you doing?”

“Just what I always did whenever I raised my barrier.”

Katsuki smirked. “Damn. That’s pretty cool. It’s normally kinda soft, like clay.”

“Is it useful?”

“Ehh…” He narrowed his eyes. “Okay, probably not.” Izuku deflated a bit. “But it’s *something.* Means you’ve at least got some intuition for how to manipulate your soul’s form. I can say from experience—that goes a long way.”

Izuku bit his lip and sighed, taking his hands out of the impressions. “Well, what now, then?”

He crossed his arms, and leaned against the side of the touch stone mount. “I dunno, nerd. Depends what sorta magic you’re lookin’ to do. I can give you basic instruction for any of them, but… I mean, have you thought at all about what class you’d wanna go into?”

“I… don’t really know.” He admitted sheepishly. “Any suggestions would be welcome?”

“It depends what you wanna do, nerd.” He shrugged. “Every type’s the best for *some* subset of applications. Trick is to figure out what sorta use you’re lookin’ to get out of it.” He paused.

“Well, I wanna use it to fight, so….” Izuku pursed his lips. “I guess that’d be Wrath, right?”

“I mean, sure. But it’s not that simple.” He said. “If it was, the whole military would be nothin’ but Wrath.”

His brow furrowed. “What do you mean?”

“Wrath is real hard on your body.” He explained. “It’s got a steep learning curve for that reason. Basically, condensing your soul is one thing, but actually using that to fight is another. It requires a lot of physical strength that takes a while to build up.”

“Oh…” Izuku frowned.

“Not sayin’ that to dissuade you. I’d fuckin’ love it if you chose Wrath, obviously.” He said. “But this ain’t a one-size-fits-all type of deal, Deku. Shit that works for me might or might not work for you.”

Izuku bit his lip, nodding slowly.

“Here. Lemme give you a basic run-down.” He continued. Folding his hands behind his back, Katsuki began to circle around him lazily as he spoke. “Greed and Envy are both decent fighting styles in the early stages. They’re really technical, but if you’re good with that sorta thing, you can gain access to some pretty good fighting abilities fairly quickly.

“Pride’s good, but it’s kinda like a diluted version of every class. Not ideal if you’re lookin’ for raw power, but it’s great if your goal is to be versatile right off the bat.

“Gluttony’s great if speed is important to you, or if you want a style that includes a lot of long-range attacks.

“Sloth…” He squinted. “Well, Sloth is a tough sell. You can use it to immobilize and put people to sleep, but it takes a long time to actually get to that level.

“Lust is better, but it’s still not super combative early on. The only reason to choose it would be to straddle Wrath and Gluttony, which are both solid choices for fighting.”

“I see…” Izuku trailed off, staring into space.

Katsuki grunted. “Here. Maybe we should just go over the basics of each so you can see how they feel.”

Izuku looked up, blinking a few times. “Alright. That sounds like a good idea.”

“Mm. Put your hands in the impressions again. We’ll start with Wrath.”

Izuku nodded, placing his palms flat in the hand prints. He looked up at Katsuki expectantly.

“Again, since ya already know how to consciously affect your soul in some way, you’re already miles ahead of most Demons, but the real challenge is affecting it the *right* way. For that, you’ll need the right visual.”

“Visual?”

“Mm. Magic is all about connecting a mental image to a physical action.” He paused, sliding his hands into his pockets. “Wish I could just tell you what to visualize, but again, what works for me might not work for you. It’s best to just experiment ’til you figure out what

your body responds to." He shrugged. "So, go ahead. See if you can imagine something that'll make your soul smaller."

Izuku took a deep breath, leaning forward into the table, his eyes locked on the floating touch stone. Engaging his stomach muscles, he tried to imagine a pair of invisible hands exerting pressure from the outside. And at first, nothing happened.

"Just keep at it. Feel around. You'll figure it out eventually."

Izuku tried the same thing for a little while longer before he decided to switch tactics, instead imagining a force buried within his chest, pulling inward, like gravity. And amazingly, that actually seemed to work. Shakily, the stone started to shrink down in front of him, hovering at around eighty-percent of its initial size. Nowhere near as impressive as when Katsuki had done it, but frankly, Izuku was just happy to have managed to do anything at all.

"Nice job." Katsuki said, and he took it as a cue to release the pressure, panting slightly at the effort of it.

"You *fight* like that?"

Katsuki laughed softly. "You're just not used to it." He shrugged. "Y'gotta build up the right muscles to sustain it, but once you're there, it's easy."

Izuku pursed his lips, still a bit embarrassed at how draining the act was for him.

"You did good though, nerd. Seriously. It usually takes a lot longer for people to figure that out."

Izuku blushed slightly, looking away.

He clapped his hands together. "Alright, so that's Wrath. Let's give Envy a shot, yeah?"

Izuku took a deep breath before placing his hands in the impressions again.

Things went on this way for a while, with Izuku stumbling his way through each individual class until he discovered a mental image that his body could understand.

Envy was a challenge, at first. He tried to visualize his soul as boiling water, but since his soul was solid, it didn't really work. He imagined dry ice next, but the concept was just too foreign for his body to really respond to it. It wasn't until Izuku visualized himself floating on his back in a pool of hot spring water that the stone finally started to sublimate, a small percentage of its total mass converted to a warm vapor that swirled around the surface. The only issue was that Izuku wasn't sure he could move that way.

Greed was next, and for that, Katsuki brought out a couple of magnets. It was the most difficult one so far for him to figure out, and the only one where he actually needed a hint from Katsuki in order to get it right.

"Don't think about charge. That's too complicated in the beginning stages." He'd said. "Just focus on your soul's relationship with the magnets."

Izuku tried a few more things before he finally found something that worked. It wasn't a clear image so much as it was an abstract concept; he focused on the magnets, and imagined his body as some vague inversion of them. At that point, they flew from Katsuki's hands and stuck, but he could never quite figure out how to reverse the force. Every time he tried, the magnets just fell to the floor.

In contrast, Pride was a lot more intuitive. Izuku imagined his soul as a balloon inside his body, and when he inhaled, he visualized it inflating just like his lungs. It was quite effective, and he was able to hold it so long as he held his breath. But as soon as he exhaled, it would deflate again.

Sloth was similar to Envy in the sense that, when he finally managed it, he felt like he was unable to move, albeit for a completely different reason. Where Envy felt like a delicate balancing act, Sloth felt a lot more like muscle fatigue. He could move a little bit while he did it, but it took every ounce of strength and willpower just to lift a finger.

Gluttony was probably the strangest one, in terms of how it felt while doing it. He imagined himself sinking into a pit of sticky goo, and it took a minute for it to work, since he'd never actually experienced anything like that before. Still, compared to some of the others, it was easy enough to maintain, and he could sort of move, albeit sluggishly.

And then there was Lust.

"This is liquification. Give it a try."

Izuku chewed his lip as he focused on the shiny soul stone in front of him. He envisioned a stick of butter, melting in a pan.

Almost instantly, the stone matched the mental image, more than half of its mass melting down around a solid core. Izuku was alarmed by how natural it was, but when he looked up at Katsuki, he didn't seen surprised at all.

"Fallen Angels usually take well to Lust." He told him. "After all, before you Fall, most of your soul is liquid, anyway." He grinned. "See if you can do anything with it."

"What do you mean?"

"Like, try to move it, or something."

Izuku swallowed and leaned in, brows pinching together as he focused on the swirling mass of liquid before him. With some effort, he was able to pull a couple of droplets away from the rest, but at a certain point, he started to feel very off-balance. Had it not been for the surface he was leaning on, he probably would've fallen over.

"Not bad."

Izuku sighed, releasing the stone and taking a moment to get his bearings before taking his hands out of the impressions.

"I could barely do anything, though…"

Katsuki shrugged. “Honestly, most of that comes from *actual* movement. Once you figure out how to maintain the form, it tends to flow with your movements.”

“Oh? Huh.” Izuku looked up in thought. “I guess that makes sense.”

“Mm.” Katsuki nodded. “Anyway, since Lust seems to be easiest for you right now, I suggest focusing on that today.”

Izuku frowned. “Really? But… you said Lust wasn’t a good choice for combat.”

“There’s more to all of this than just whether or not a specific style is good for fighting. Learning to manipulate the form of your soul will make it easier when you try different styles.” He explained. “Just ‘cuz it’s Lust today doesn’t mean it’ll be Lust tomorrow.”

Izuku smiled softly. “Well, alright… So,” He cleared his throat. “Uhh, what first?”

“We’ll start with the most basic thing.” Katsuki replied, approaching the touch stone. “Eye contact-based hypnosis. Stand across from me. I’ll show you how it works.”

Izuku scooted to the other side of the soul stone as Katsuki was placing his hands into the impressions, and immediately, the stone melted down to a swirling liquid. As he looked up, Izuku met Katsuki’s eyes.

“Now, watch what I do.”

And then, Izuku observed as two small droplets split off from the rest of the mass, moving closer and closer to his face, until they were right in front of his eyes. But for some reason, Izuku didn’t feel any urge to flinch. He just stood there, holding eye contact as they gradually eclipsed his vision, and just before they made contact, they faded, phasing through his skull. He felt that familiar click within his brain, followed by the weight of Katsuki’s control.

“Raise your left arm.” Katsuki barked.

Izuku obeyed him instantly.

And then, just as quickly as it had started, it was over. Katsuki removed his hands from the impressions and cocked his head. “Seem easy enough?”

“I… sure? I mean, I guess so.” He muttered.

He gave a short nod, and switched places with him again. Izuku sighed as he stuck his hands in the impressions, brows pinched together.

Butter melting in a pan.

Quickly, the better part of his soul’s mass melted down. Izuku slowly looked up and met Katsuki’s gaze.

His brows pinched together as he concentrated, willing two droplets to break off from the rest. He could feel his palms sweating in the impressions as he leaned into them hard, and

slowly pushed them toward Katsuki, never once breaking eye contact. It took some time, but once he managed to get them through his head, they seemed to stick, as though naturally drawn toward something within. Izuku felt a strange sensation at that moment, as though he wasn't fully in his own body. There was a part of him, however minuscule, that lived inside Katsuki's head. *Waiting.*

And it was at that moment when he realized he had no idea what he was supposed to tell Katsuki to do. A part of him panicked, and his control nearly slipped. Izuku found himself saying the first thing that came to mind.

"Umm, uhh… take off your shirt…?"

Immediately, Katsuki's arms criss-crossed, grabbing the hem of his tank top and calmly pulling up. But the moment the fabric blocked his vision, it was like an elastic band snapping back into place. The part of him that resided in Katsuki's mind abruptly returned to his own, and Katsuki froze for a second before completing the movement, pulling his shirt fully over his head. And the look on his face when he emerged had Izuku's cheeks burning up.

"Deku." His voice sounded deeper than usual.

"I-I just, uhh," he floundered. "Sorry! I realized after, uhh, after I hypnotized you th-that I didn't actually know what to ask you, so I just…"

Katsuki raised an eyebrow.

Izuku averted his eyes. "You can, uh, put your shirt back on now."

"Oh, can I?" He said. "I dunno. I think I'm pretty comfortable like this, actually."

Izuku chose not to respond to that. "C-Can we just move on?"

Katsuki smirked, and *oh,* Izuku thought.

Oh, this is hell, alright.

The rest of the session progressed in more or less the same fashion, with Katsuki instructing Izuku to hypnotize him in various ways, under various circumstances. After a few hours, he got a pretty decent handle on it, even managing to pull it off while moving, and without the visual aid of the touch stone.

Katsuki never put his shirt back on, which was sort of a blessing and a curse—while he was undeniably very nice to look at, it didn't do his ability to focus any favors.

Izuku took a sip of his water and sighed as he turned and looked at Katsuki, at the way his fitted sweatpants clung to his body, the bob of his Adam's apple as he drunk from his own water bottle, and he swallowed roughly, shuffling around in place.

There was one thing that had been bothering him from the very beginning of that session, though if Izuku were being honest, this was far from the first time it had crossed his mind.

Still, despite that, he could never quite work up the courage to bring it up. But in that relaxed moment, it took center-stage in his mind. He wasn't sure if he'd get a better opportunity than the one presented to him now.

And so, Izuku cleared his throat. Katsuki glanced over at him, expectant.

"H-Have you ever, uhhh…"

"What's that?" He barked. "You're mumbling."

Izuku faltered, nearly losing his nerve. He paused to take a deep breath, and tried to ignore the weight of Katsuki's curious gaze on him. "I was just, um, wondering if you've ever, uhh," He averted his eyes. "You know. Used hypnosis for anything… *other* than fighting…?"

When he finally looked up at Katsuki, he found him staring back at him, blinking slowly, his expression blank.

"Well, sure, I guess." He said, screwing the cap back on his water bottle, and setting it aside. "I mean, more advanced Lust techniques have more broad applications, like that instant-Xanax shit Aizawa pulls sometimes." He rolled his eyes. "But as far as straight hypnosis goes… well, it's not *that* common, but yeah, I've used it in other situations."

"O-Oh, really?" He clenched his fists behind his back. "Like what?"

"Uhh," He scratched his head. "One time Kaminari stole my hat off my head, and I used it to force him to give it back." He said, pausing as he continued to think. "I've also used it on humans to get 'em to let me into places I had no fuckin' business being." He snorted.

"Oh." He tried not to let his slight disappointment bleed into his voice. "So, that's it? You've never used it for anything *else…?"*

Katsuki just stared at him for a while longer, his eyes narrowing a bit, sweeping up and down his frame. Izuku could see the moment he realized what he was getting at; the way his eyes widened the slightest amount just before a grin stretched across his lips.

And as though a switch had been flipped, Katsuki slid his hands into his pockets and sauntered over. "Oh, I get it." He drawled. Izuku backed up against the mount of the touch stone, and as Katsuki closed in, he planted his hands on either side, boxing him in. "You're a little pervert, ain't ya, Deku?"

Izuku sputtered, leaning back as far as he could. "I-I'm not, I just—"

"—What?" He cut him off, eyes heavy-lidded.

He gulped. "I just… think it's a natural question to want to ask, is all…"

Katsuki hummed, a rumbling sound deep in his chest. He gave Izuku another once-over before he leaned back just the slightest bit and shrugged.

“Usin’ it for sex is kinda dubious, just like any other situation where a person can’t revoke consent.” He told him. “Which isn’t to say that people don’t ever *do* it, just that it’s, y’know, not really somethin’ people tend to do during *casual* sex.”

“I-I see.” Izuku said, nodding quickly. “Right. Of course. That makes sense.”

Katsuki chuckled, grabbing him by the chin and tilting his head up. “You’re so fuckin’ cute when you’re flustered.” He said, leaning down to kiss him. It was slow, sensual, and relatively brief. Katsuki pulled away after eight seconds.

Not that Izuku was counting, of course.

Izuku reached up, wrapping his fingers around the hand Katsuki had pressed against his cheek. “W-Would you ever do something like that with me?”

“Sure, if you want.” He licked his lips. “Do ya?”

He swallowed. “M-Maybe?”

Katsuki smiled, leaning in to plant another kiss on his lips, his hand sliding down to rest on Izuku’s hip, thumb dipping just beneath the waistband, tracing circles over the bone. “Where’s all this comin’ from?”

“I don’t know.” He lied.

“Bullshit.”

Izuku shook his head, pausing a moment. “I guess, just… ever since that first time you hypnotized me…”

The grin on Katsuki’s face was positively feral. “Yeah?” He leaned in, hot breath against Izuku’s ear. “You mean the time I told you to get on your knees?”

Izuku squirmed, thighs pressing together. He nodded slightly.

“Fucked you up with that one, huh?” He murmured, his voice low, raspy. “Mm, you’re not alone. Looked so fucking good on your knees for me. You have no idea.”

Izuku whimpered, wrapping his arms around his neck and lacing his fingers through his hair. Katsuki’s hands dipped beneath his shirt, sliding over his stomach, and Izuku felt as though he could drown in his body heat.

“But,” he said, pulling back a bit too much for Izuku’s liking. “You’re still new to all this, y’know.” He brushed his bangs out of his face. “Probably best not to jump into that shit before you’ve even had a chance to do everything normally.”

Izuku dug his fingers into his hair, not expecting the needy sound that escaped his throat then. He leaned in, pressing his face into Katsuki’s chest.

Sensing something was off, Katsuki wrapped his arms around him. “Deku?”

“It’s just…” He hesitated. “I don’t know what to *do.* You know, normally.” He bit his lip. “I just think it’d be kinda nice, if you just…”

A brief pause, and then Katsuki hummed, pulling him in tighter. “Told ya what to do?”

He swallowed, nodding against his chest.

Katsuki clicked his tongue. “Y’know, it’s fine to just not know what to do, nerd. First time for everything.” When Izuku didn’t respond, he went on. “Hypnosis ain’t somethin’ you should take lightly.”

“I don’t take it lightly.” He said. “But I just figured… well, it’s just *you,* Kacchan.”

Katsuki snorted, pulling back enough to look him in the eye. “‘Just me’?” He smirked. “Aww, baby. You trust me *so* much, huh?” He cooed. Then his eyes darkened. “You shouldn’t.”

Izuku felt a shiver run down his spine, heat blooming in the pit of his stomach.

Oh.

“…Wh-Why not?”

Katsuki’s thumb rubbed against his bottom lip. “Total control, Deku.” He said. “I could make you do all *kinds* of fucked up shit.”

Izuku gulped.

“Well…” He said. “Maybe that’s what I want.”

“Oh yeah?”

“Yeah.”

“Like this?”

Suddenly, something clicked inside his head, and Izuku felt his body become relaxed and pliant. Katsuki’s eyes glowed bright as he stared into Izuku’s and whispered, “Get on your *fucking* knees.”

Immediately, he fell to the floor, knees hitting the soft training mat below. After a moment, the weight in his mind dissipated, and Katsuki laced his fingers through his hair and pulled, forcing him to look up at him.

“What do you think, nerd?” He asked, a feral look in his eye as he stroked Izuku’s curls. And then, biting his lip, Katsuki tightened his grip and tugged again, pulling him face-first into his crotch. Izuku whimpered as he felt his cock against his cheek through the thin material of his sweats, slowly swelling as Katsuki rolled his hips against his face. “Just how much power are you willin’ to give me?”

Izuku's eyes glazed over as he stared up at him dreamily, a hot blush on his face.

"Anything." He whispered. "All of it."

Katsuki's breath hitched, and he could've sworn he felt his cock twitch inside his pants.

He licked his lips. "You're really playin' with fire, y'know that?"

"Kacchan." He breathed. "Please?"

"Fuck."

Just like that, the glow of his eyes flared up, and Izuku could feel him in his head again. "Now, Deku," He cooed, "You're gonna take my pants off—*only* my pants."

Wordlessly, Izuku hooked his fingers under the waistband of his sweats and slid them down to his ankles, where Katsuki proceeded to step out of them and kick them off to the side. He was left in only his plain grey boxer briefs, and Izuku whimpered at the sight of his half-hard cock, barely confined in his underwear. Katsuki pulled his face into his crotch again.

"Stay right there." He murmured, as though the grip on his hair gave him any other choice. Katsuki rolled his hips against his face, and Izuku whimpered involuntarily at the feeling of him growing larger against his cheek. "Ya wanna suck me off, huh?"

Yes, he wanted to say. *God, yes, please.*

But he couldn't, not unless Katsuki told him to speak. The only sounds he could make were the little, incoherent whines and moans that occasionally slipped out unconsciously as Katsuki ordered him around.

"Open your mouth."

He did.

"Stick out your tongue."

He did.

"Stay there."

He did, and his mind felt dreamy as Katsuki curled his fingers under his chin, pressed his thumb against the flat of his tongue and hummed in satisfaction. And then, sliding his hand into his hair again, he gently pulled Izuku forward, so that his tongue was pressed against the bulge of his cock through the fabric. He was confused, at first. And then Katsuki spoke. "Lick it. Just like that."

And just like every other time before that, Izuku followed orders. Dragging his tongue over the outline of his cock, Izuku felt his face burn as the fabric started to get wet.

"That's right." He rasped. "Get it nice and wet."

Izuku whimpered, tearing up slightly as he let his saliva soak through the grey fabric and cling to Katsuki's cock. He could've never imagined his request would lead to *this;* it was embarrassing, but he couldn't stop himself.

And honestly, he wouldn't want it any other way.

Because there was just something about it, about putting his mind and body in Katsuki's hands and letting him do as he pleased. He didn't have to think about anything else, or how he'd feel about it later. Katsuki's sadistic streak always did seem to veer more toward the humiliation side of things, but it didn't sting the way he would've expected it to. Even when he was on his knees, debasing himself at his feet, there was no real shame in it, because Katsuki had commanded him to do it, and that meant he didn't have to worry. He could just enjoy it. He could just *feel.*

Izuku's dick was already straining in his sweatpants, and he hadn't even touched Katsuki's skin yet.

Hissing, Katsuki grabbed him by the hair and pulled him away, smirking at the way Izuku kept his tongue out. "That's what I like to see." He purred, reaching for his waistband. Katsuki stared into his eyes as he grabbed his boxers and shoved them down a bit, pulling his cock and balls over the waistband, slightly shiny with Izuku's saliva."Stay still, just like that." Biting his lip, he grabbed the base of his cock and slowly rubbed the tip against the flat of Izuku's tongue.

Izuku's eyes crossed a bit as he tried to watch. Sometimes Katsuki would push it just inside his mouth, pressing against the insides of his cheeks to make them bulge just before it popped out again. All the while, Izuku just stared up at Katsuki with that dreamy gaze, eyes flitting between Katsuki's heavy-lidded eyes and the hard cock dipping into his mouth.

"Perfect," Katsuki said, his voice just a low rumble deep in his chest. It traveled down Izuku's spine and made him tremble. "Gorgeous. Such a pretty Angel. *Fuck."*

He pulled out of his mouth. It took Izuku a moment to realize that the weight in his mind was gone, and then Katsuki was dropping down to a squat in front of him, his fingers combing through his hair. "You good?"

Izuku blinked a few times, and then nodded slowly. Katsuki raised an eyebrow. "Y'sure? Nothin' too overwhelming for ya?"

"No." He shook his head, cheeks heating up as he said, "I-I like it."

Katsuki licked his lips, tilted Izuku's chin up and kissed him briefly, then pulled back and spoke against Izuku's lips. "Y'wanna keep going?"

"Please."

He grinned, standing up straight again. As soon as he met his eyes, Izuku felt his presence return, vision darkening at the edges. Katsuki stroked his hair softly for a moment, humming as he seemed to consider something. Then, with one hand wrapped around the base of his

cock, Katsuki proceeded to smack his cheek with it. And it was so sudden, it almost broke the spell. A soft sound escaped Izuku's throat, heat curling in the pit of his stomach.

He hadn't expected to enjoy something like that—and *yet.*

Katsuki repeated the move a few more times, a wicked grin on his face as he dropped it against his cheek and rolled his hips, rubbing against his skin. "Can't believe you actually *like* this shit." He said, his tone a bit mean. It softened when he added, "You really *are* fuckin' perfect."

Izuku moaned, already painfully hard in his sweatpants.

"You wanna suck my cock, doncha?" He said. "Say it."

Izuku's brow wrinkled.

"Say you wanna suck my cock. *Tell me."*

Izuku's mouth opened before his brain could even catch up. "I wanna suck your cock." He said, his cheeks impossibly hot.

"Good boy," he purred, stroking and running his fingers through his hair. Izuku unconsciously leaned into the gesture, eyes hazing over.

It was the contrast, he figured—the sweetness of Katsuki's touch, juxtaposed with the sadistic glint in his eye as he stared down at him, devouring him with his gaze, like he was getting high off Izuku's vulnerable state.

Honestly, Izuku was, too.

"Wrap your hand around the base of my cock." Izuku leaned in and obeyed him, fingers curling around hot flesh. Katsuki's hand slid down, thumb dipping into his mouth. Izuku whined as he felt him press against his sharp canine, provoking a dull, aching sensation. "Gotta be careful with those teeth, Deku baby."

Izuku's eyes fluttered.

"Go on, then." Katsuki told him. "Put it in your mouth. Swirl your tongue around the tip for me." Izuku immediately complied, sticking his tongue out and licking around the head of his cock. Katsuki bit back a groan. "Yeah, there you go. Wrap your lips around the head, and suck. Remember to watch your teeth."

If he had the capacity to think about it, Izuku would be surprised at how easily his body managed to follow his instructions. He opened his mouth wide as he sucked him in, lips forming a tight seal around the tip of his dick. Katsuki moaned, twitching in his mouth.

"That's it. That's my sweet Angel." Izuku couldn't help but moan around him. "Fuck," Katsuki hissed. "Yeah, I know, baby. You're my sweet little cocksucking Angel, aren'tcha?" He cooed, tone sickly-sweet. He licked his lips. "Take another inch. Bob your head and suck."

Izuku did, sliding his lips down past the head to take it deeper. He was only a small fraction of the way down, and it was already borderline overwhelming as he kneeled there, throbbing in his pants.

“Fuck yeah.” Katsuki pressed on the back of Izuku’s head. “More. Take more. You can do it.”

Izuku forced himself forward, trying to relax his jaw so he could take him in properly. Tears spilled down his freckled cheeks as Katsuki urged him forward, hiting the back of his throat. He wasn’t even halfway down yet.

“Use your hand on the rest. Stroke it.” Izuku mindlessly obeyed, jerking Katsuki’s dick as he desperately tried to take him deeper. “Fuck. Shit. Look so fucking hot like this, Deku. With your pretty lips stretched out around my cock.” He purred. “Can’t decide if I wanna cum down your throat or all over your face.”

Izuku moaned around his length, bobbing his head faster. *“Shit.* Take your hand off.” He was a bit confused, but did as he was told. Then Katsuki grabbed his hair with both hands, and as Izuku looked up, his eyes met with Katsuki’s—deep red, and glowing with sadistic glee. “Wanna try something. Let’s see if it works, yeah?” He smirked. “Deku… *don’t choke.”*

And a second later, he slid all the way down his throat. He couldn’t understand it, but somehow, when Katsuki told him not to choke… his body actually *obeyed* him.

It was uncomfortable, sure, and he felt like he was always just seconds away from choking, but it never quite happened.

“Holy fuck.” Katsuki hissed, teeth gritted. He pulled out a bit and then thrusted in all the way again, so Izuku’s nose pressed against his skin, and laughed in amazement. “I can’t believe that actually *worked.”*

He grinded his hips against his face for a moment before he pulled out completely, the weight inside his head once again easing.

“You still alright, nerd?”

Izuku coughed slightly, but nodded still.

“You sure?” He asked, grabbing himself at the base and dragging his cock head over Izuku’s cheeks, almost idly. “Might get kinda rough. If you don’t want that, tell me now.”

Izuku swallowed, the heat in his cheeks concentrating. He opted not to respond verbally, and instead, simply looked up at him with teary eyes and opened his mouth again. The grin on Katsuki’s face was positively feral, and immediately, he felt his mind falling under the spell again.

“Don’t choke. Don’t gag.” Katsuki repeated, just before he shoved back into his mouth and pressed in to the base. From there, he slowly fucked in and out of his throat, making it bulge each time he bottomed out. His jaw ached with the effort of keeping his mouth wide open

around him, but he never gagged. He just sat there, drool spilling from the corners of his lips as he took him down his throat.

He groaned, grinding against his face for a moment. “Touch yourself.” Katsuki said. “Pull your waistband down. Wanna watch you fuck your fist.”

He was quick to obey, fumbling to pull his sweats down enough to get his dick out, wincing at the feeling of cool air against his skin. As Katsuki resumed fucking his face, he wrapped his hand around his dick and stroked up and down, moaning around Katsuki’s cock as pleasure coursed through his body, so intense he nearly toppled over. Katsuki groaned, cock twitching inside his throat as he stared down at him, ravenous.

Izuku stroked himself greedily, bucking and rotating his hips into his hand. He sucked harder, gradually starting to enjoy the sensation of him fucking his face, discomfort and all. There was something intoxicating in the movement of Katsuki’s hips, a single-mindedly indulgent pursuit. He looked up at him through teary eyes, and saw a man who had lost control of something deep inside, something he would normally restrict. But here he was, groaning as he fucked into Izuku’s mouth at a rapid, uneven pace.

I did this, Izuku thought. *I made Kacchan feel like this.*

And that realization was about all he could take. Stomach muscles tensing, Izuku moaned around Katsuki’s cock as he stroked himself faster, the pulsating sensation mounting until he came all over his hand and the floor.

And seeing this, Katsuki’s eyes turned wild. “Fuck!” His pace sped up for a few more seconds before he, too, came—slamming all the way down Izuku’s throat and groaning as his cock twitched and pulsated. Izuku could feel his cum, hot and thick as he shot down his throat. “Swallow.” He hissed. “Fucking *swallow.”*

Izuku did as he said, eyes closing as he swallowed as best he could around Katsuki’s cock. His throat constricted, and Katsuki moaned, his cock twitching a little more before he finished.

Panting, he pulled out of Izuku’s mouth and kneeled in front of him, releasing the hypnosis.

“Are you okay?”

Izuku coughed, but nodded still.

Katsuki grabbed his own discarded shirt, and wiped the saliva from Izuku’s chin. “I might’ve gone a bit overboard.”

“What do you mean?” Izuku asked, but his voice was so hoarse he could barely recognize it. Katsuki gave him a look. Izuku looked away. “Well, I *liked* it, so… I don’t really see the issue.” He muttered, shrugging. “Didn’t *you* like it?”

Katsuki snorted. “Well. You’re currently digesting my cum, so…”

“Kacchan!”

He laughed, but at the sight of Izuku pouting, he released a sigh and leaned forward, planting a kiss on Izuku's lips. "I fucking loved it."

Izuku flushed, a wobbly smile on his face. Katsuki reached up and ruffled his hair. "Well, I think that's enough *'training'* for today." He grinned. "C'mon, nerd. Let's get you home."

Izuku was curled up on the couch, sipping a cup of hot tea with honey. Katsuki came in a minute later and sat beside him. For a moment, it was quiet. Then Izuku cleared his throat, and Katsuki glanced at him from the corner of his eye.

"What time is Levi supposed to leave?"

"Hmm? Oh." He squinted. "Uhh, I think four in the morning was the cut-off. They wanna get there when most of the Acolytes are asleep, y'know."

"Right." Izuku chewed his lip. And after a pause, he asked, "Do you really think he'll be okay?"

Katsuki hummed, looking up in thought. "I mean, there's always a *risk*... But, y'know. Levi basically invented Envy magic. If anyone could pull it off, it'd be him."

Izuku faltered. "I—sorry, *what?"*

"I just said if anyone could pull it off, it'd be—"

"—No, *before* that."

Katsuki blinked. "Uhh. That he invented Envy magic?"

Izuku didn't speak, at first—just continued to stare at him. "You… what's that supposed to —"

"—Holy shit." Katsuki said, his posture suddenly straightening. He turned to face Izuku fully, a wide grin splitting his lips. *"Deku."*

"What?" He flushed.

"You really haven't figured it out?"

"Figured *what* out?"

He rolled his eyes. "Deku… Levi is short for Leviathan. Y'know, the original Envy Demon?"

"*What?!"*

Katsuki burst out laughing. "Seriously? C'mon, nerd. How did you *not* catch on?"

"I don't know!" Izuku cried. "Why didn't you *tell me* I was meeting one of the original Demons?!"

“Well, if we’re bein’ accurate, it wasn’t just *one.”*

Izuku’s eyes went even wider, practically bulging out of his skull. *“Excuse* me?!”

Wheezing with laughter, Katsuki barely managed to respond. *“Deku…* Deku, Bee stands for Beelzebub. Luke is short for Lucifer. *C’mon.”*

Izuku was glad he was sitting down, because if he hadn’t been, he would have surely collapsed by now. He took a deep, shuddering breath. “You’re telling me,” He said, “That I met *three* of the seven original Demons and no one *told* me?!”

“It’s not like the clues weren’t there!” He cackled. “C’mon, nerd. I thought you of all people would figure it out.”

Izuku pulled on the roots of his hair. “Do they *all* go by nicknames?!”

“Well,” his laughter died out a bit. “Technically, yeah. Thing is though, those three are the last ones. All the others are dead.” Katsuki hesitated. “Y’know, like legit dead. Perma-dead, if you will.”

Izuku didn’t respond at first, still in shock. “I… why didn’t they *say* anything?”

“Eh, I think they just get tired of it, y’know? Even if they’re not in any real position of power, most people still lose their shit when they find out who they’re talkin’ to. Can’t blame ‘em for wantin’ to go incognito sometimes, I guess.” He shrugged. “Levi and Bee have been goin’ by those names for centuries. I guess ‘Luke’ was a recent development, though.”

Izuku released a strangled noise, pulling his feet into his chest.

Katsuki clicked his tongue. “Oh, c’mon. It’s not *that* big a deal.”

“Kacchan, how am I supposed to *act* next time I see them?!”

“Same way you did before.” He told him. “The Originals ain’t anything special, Deku. They’re literally just fuckin’ old.”

“How can you just *say* that?”

“‘Cuz it’s *true!”* Katsuki threw his hands up. “Deku, Leviathan *regularly* hits his head on door frames. At a certain point, it gets kinda hard to justify worshipping him—mostly ‘cuz puttin’ him on a pedestal just leads to him bangin’ his head on *even more* shit.

“Beelzebub has no idea what the fuck is going on most of the time.” He continued. “And half the shit in his apartment is edible for no reason. It’s like Willie Wonka’s chocolate factory, but without all the slavery. One time I sat down in a recliner only to find out it was made from cotton candy, somehow. I was sticky for *weeks,* Deku.

“Oh, and Lucifer?” He scoffed. “Don’t even get me started on that fucker.”

“What?” Izuku’s brow furrowed. “What’s wrong with him?”

“Oh, don’t worry, nerd. You’ll figure it out.”

“What does that *mean?”*

“He’ll make it abundantly clear.” He shrugged. “That make you feel better?”

“No.”

“Good.” He shot back. “It shouldn’t.”

“Kacchan!”

Katsuki just laughed, buckling over, clutching his stomach. When he eventually calmed down, he sighed, leaning back against the couch cushions. “Look, nerd. In all seriousness… just don’t worry about it, okay? Those fuckers are weird, but like… weird in the way you’d expect people to be, when they’re that fuckin’ old. At a certain point, they just got bored of being normal, I guess.”

Izuku frowned, not quite sure what to say to that.

“They’re all, like, *nice* and shit, if that’s what you’re worried about.”

“No, that’s not…” He sighed and shook his head. “I guess I’ll just… have to get used to it.” He took a sip of his tea.

Katsuki hummed, then fell silent. For a minute, neither of them spoke. Eventually, Katsuki cleared his throat.

“So…” He began. “The illusion.”

Izuku nearly choked on his tea.

“Woah, hey. You good?”

Izuku coughed a bit, but nodded, still. He was already dreading this conversation.

“Wh-What about it?”

“I dunno, was just curious.” He shrugged. “Talkin’ about the Originals reminded me you never actually explained how you got out.”

Izuku chewed his lip. “Well, I’d tell you, but…”

He blinked. “What?”

Izuku shifted on the couch, looking away. “You might get mad at me.”

He snorted. “Why the hell would I get *mad?* It was a fuckin’ illusion, nerd. What, did ya have to fuck someone to get out?”

“Wh-What?! No, of course not!” Izuku blushed, holding his teacup in front of his face. “Just…”

A moment of silence.

“Deku. It’s okay.” Katsuki said, his tone even. “I’m not gonna get mad. You wouldn’t be here right now if you hadn’t done whatever you did.”

“W-Well, you see…” He began. “It was actually, um, when we were in the Depths.”

“Oh?” Katsuki raised an eyebrow. “So what, you had to break a rule?”

“I had to break… *every* rule.”

Katsuki’s eyes widened a bit. “You mean—“

“I stopped walking… and I waited until I couldn’t hear the wind anymore.” As he spoke, his eyes grew even wider. “And when it came, I…”

For a long time, Katsuki just stared at him, speechless. Izuku was expecting him to yell. But he didn’t.

Instead, he said, “That’s… why did you think I’d be *mad* at you for that?”

“W-Well, because I wasn’t… certain.” He winced. “I didn’t *know* if it was an illusion. I just kind of… suspected it.”

He exhaled. “Deku… look. I shouldn’t need to say this, but I trust your judgement enough to know you probably knew what you were doing.”

Izuku’s mind suddenly flooded with images and words of months long past. Of Katsuki in the forest, during the wintertime.

“Let’s get one thing straight.” He’d said. *“You don’t know what the fuck you’re doing. You* don’t. *So if I fucking tell you to do something, even if you don’t exactly understand it, even if it makes absolutely no fucking sense to you, if I say it’s important, you do it, and ask questions later. You got that?”*

He frowned. “I mean… you’ve told me otherwise in the past.”

“There’s a thing called personal growth, nerd.” Katsuki scoffed, rolling his eyes. “Like, are you still a naive dweeb with a martyr complex? Yeah. Obviously. But you’re not the same twerp I met in the church last December.”

Izuku stared at him for a moment, his cheeks dusted pink. He averted his eyes.

“Seriously, though. You...” He said. “Are you, like, *good?”*

“What do you mean?”

“Deku… you confronted the fucking Depths Siren.”

Izuku laughed awkwardly. “Y-Yeah, I sure did.”

But Katsuki didn’t smile. His expression stayed the same—calm and serious.

Izuku sighed. “I try not to think about it. It was just an illusion, anyway.”

Katsuki remained silent for a moment. “Illusions can still be traumatizing.” He muttered. “And…” He bit his lip. “Never mind.”

Izuku tensed. “What?”

“Nothing.”

“Kacchan!”

“Fine.” He exhaled, exasperated. “There’s just this… legend. Y’know. About the Depths.” He hesitated. “They say that every time you go in, a piece of your spirit gets trapped in there…” He trailed off, then cleared his throat. “It’s not actually *true,* of course. I mean, I’ve been in there hundreds of times, and I’m still me. But sometimes…” He fell silent.

Izuku gulped. “What?”

He shrugged. “Sometimes I have dreams about being in the Depths. Compared to other dreams, they’re a lot more… vivid.” He winced. “But I dunno. I feel like it’s the other way around, if anything. You don’t stay in the Depths. It’s more like the Depths stays in you.”

He shivered, his body suddenly feeling too cold. He took a sip of his hot tea to compensate. “You mean… Are you trying to say that part of the illusion was *real* somehow?”

Katsuki was quick to shake his head. “Nah. Not *real* real. ‘Specially since you’ve never actually been to the void depths. But… there’s a lot we don’t understand, y’know?”

“I know.”

Katsuki sighed. “Look, s’nothin’ to worry about. Just… forget I said anything.”

Izuku swallowed, and for a minute, it was silent. He finished off his tea and set it on the coffee table, before reaching for a blanket laid across the back of the couch. He wrapped it around his shoulders as Katsuki was grabbing the remote, turning the TV on. It was clear that neither of them wanted the conversation to continue.

That night, Izuku spent his first two hours in bed tossing and turning. He wasn’t sure why he couldn’t fall asleep.

Well, maybe that wasn’t completely true.

Izuku peeled the sheet off his sweat-damp body and turned onto his back. He watched the ceiling fan as it spun up above, the metallic embellishments on the blades occasionally catching flashes of light from outside.

He closed his eyes, and the Acolytes stood before him, against the backdrop of a circular library centered around a spiral staircase.

"Sir?"

Izuku tensed, and pulled the sheet over his feet.

He had gotten up a couple a times throughout the past two hours, and had it not been for the risk of waking Katsuki up, he probably would've done so a few more. Not that it had been particularly helpful so far.

Izuku turned onto his side with a sigh, looking at Katsuki's sleeping face. He was on his back, limbs sprawled out in all different directions. His mouth was slightly open, and Izuku could see the way his eyes moved around beneath his eyelids. He was dreaming.

Izuku scooted a bit closer, trying not to rock the mattress too much. He curled up in a ball at Katsuki's side, and closed his eyes again.

He knew he was just being paranoid. Two weird dreams wasn't a pattern; it was a coincidence. Come morning, Izuku would probably wake up wondering why he was ever worried in the first place.

That is, if I manage to fall asleep by then, he thought.

Frowning, Izuku turned over onto his back again. The sweat had mostly dried, so he pulled the sheet fully over him again, and closed his eyes.

It was then that he remembered something—some little piece of trivia he'd picked up somewhere along the line. He couldn't recall the context he'd heard it in, but someone once told him that if he closed his eyes and stayed still for long enough, he'd fall asleep within fifteen minutes or so. Izuku wasn't sure if that was true or not, but figured it was worth a try.

And so, he took a deep breath and exhaled, trying to release the tension in his muscles, to feel his body sinking into the mattress. Now, he just had to wait.

Less than a minute had passed, and Izuku already felt an intense urge to scratch various itches all over his body. He stayed still, and ignored them.

After around five minutes, he could see colorful lights flickering beneath his eyelids, and his body began to feel heavy. Izuku watched the colors dance as his limbs gradually grew numb. And that's when the noises started—little things. Something creaking in the walls, unintelligible whispers, the sound of faint music playing in the distance. And then he was floating, levitating above the bed.

He continued to watch the colors writhing in the darkness as his grip on consciousness began to slip. The line between the real world and the dream world became increasingly blurry.

Izuku exhaled, and let the dancing lights carry him away.

Izuku made no attempt at maintaining awareness as he dreamed. He let himself float from place to place, experiencing event after event. He could never remember where he came from, much less where he was headed, but that was alright, because it was *normal.* Dreams were supposed to be strange and indistinct. They defied logic, both external and internal. Continuity could not exist without consequences.

He was everywhere and nowhere at once, until suddenly, he was somewhere.

Izuku opened his eyes to find himself standing at the end of a long, dreary hallway. Light leaked in from a room at the end, where a spiral staircase extended upward, beyond view. Izuku took a step toward it, only to freeze at the sound of someone speaking behind him.

“You owe me for this.”

Izuku quickly turned around. There, at the end of the dimly lit hall, stood a man. His face was marred by faint wrinkles—the sort Izuku would expect to see on a human in their mid-thirties. His generally youthful features stood at odds with the snow white hair the covered his head, combed back and neatly styled.

Even in the low light, he could see the sheen of his luxurious silk robes, wrapping around him in hues of red and gold. Embroidered on the right side of his uniform was the number four, written in Roman numerals.

Izuku’s eyes drifted to the side, for a moment focusing on the door just behind him, large and worn, but ornate nonetheless.

The man reached for his hand, taking it between his own. “Not that I expect you to remember any of this tomorrow, of course.” He muttered. “Update the quotas as soon as we’re through —before it sets in again. If we keep at it at this rate, I’ll end up just like you.”

Izuku felt himself nodding.

The man stared at him for a moment, and then sighed. “Alright. Once again… this may sting a bit.”

And then it happened. The man’s palms lit up in a burst of pale light, surrounding his hand like a glowing orb.

The pain was immediate.

Izuku released a strangled cry as he clamored upright in bed. His eyes were open, but he couldn’t see anything. Couldn’t really feel anything at all, apart from the searing pain radiating from his right hand. Heat traveled up from his palm and made his whole body sweat, and as it passed his neck, he could feel it clawing its way down his throat. Izuku

buckled over, tears in his eyes as he violently coughed, trying to rid himself of the fire in his lungs, but it only got worse. Tears leaked from his eyes. He could feel his throat swelling up.

He wasn't sure when he'd moved. Wasn't really able to register the sensation of being carried until he felt his hand being pulled beneath a stream of cool water. It helped cut the burning just enough for him to register parts of his surroundings. He was in the bathroom, leaning against the bathtub. The lights were bright. They hurt his eyes.

And at the center of it all was the blurred image of Katsuki's panicked face. He kept touching him, like he was trying to examine him, but was impeded by his relentless coughing. Izuku closed his eyes as his movements began to make him dizzy.

He started to cry for another reason, then, as fear and helplessness set in. He felt the irreconcilable urge to reach down his throat and scratch the inside of his lungs, and the longer he sat there unable to act on it, the more miserable he became.

He didn't want to go out like this. Didn't want this to be the last thing he ever felt.

Izuku registered himself being picked up again, and opened his eyes a crack just in time to catch Katsuki turning the bathroom lights off. He felt a rush of wind, and then they were outside. Streetlights passed them by, flickering on and off overhead as Katsuki sprinted down the sidewalk.

He crossed the street, ran through an automatic door. He could hear Katsuki speaking, but the words were buried beneath the ever-present fuzz inside his head.

Then he was on his back. Multiple pairs of hands on all sides of a stretcher, wheeling him toward a pair of double doors.

They entered a hallway. Someone was talking. He couldn't hear them. Cool, rectangular lights embedded in a white, tiled ceiling, flashing above him. He winced, turning his head to his right to watch the brick walls pass instead—also white.

It was only then that he actually caught a glimpse of his hand.

White walls.

White noise.

White marks, like sprawling tree roots, embedded deep in his skin.

Everything was white just before it all went black.

Chapter End Notes

welcome to the endnotes essay

so yeah uh. like i said im in tech interview hell rn so my attention has been really divided. on top of that, i had to spend a lot of time planning the precise details of the ending before i could even start this chapter lmao, so that took a while, but i think i have a much better handle on it now.

there are a lot of things in this story i'd probably change if i could, but the serialized nature of fic kinda makes that difficult. so i'll just say right now, if anything feels weird of rushed or like it came out of nowhere,,,, sorry lol. im doin my best. im actually planning to revise the shit out of this once im done and maybe print it? idk. dw tho, the original version will stay the same lol.

also, we got some OCs here. I mean, kinda. other than setsuko the others are just like. biblical demons whose names attached to some hot immortal guys with fancy powers. We'll see a lot more of them in coming chapters, and the councilmen (who are, in fact, OCs rather than the LoV im sorry i just couldn't do that it felt too on the nose lol). Idk, I know that OCs in fics are kinda one of those things that a lot of people aren't too crazy about but,,, idk, i hope they'll be kind of an exception??? im tryin real hard to make them an exception

oh also, someone made a wiki for this and i'm???? AAAAAA????? Here's the link, if u feel like looking at it or contributing lmao. and if ur the person who made this, first of all wtf thank you?? and second of all it'd be super cool if u could give me admin privileges just so i can fix a few tiny errors i don't have the authority to change lol jshdfjdhf

anyway, we're getting real close to the end. i actually had to cut this chapter earlier than i intended bc it was getting to a point where it was just too long and i had no idea where it was gonna end lol, so the first 6k words of chapter 18 are finished. hopefully that means it'll be done sooner! anyway, as always, pls comment if u enjoyed this to appease the dopamine overlords thank u

Chapter 18: Bodysnatchers

Chapter Summary

> “What if I told you that by Sunday morning, Midoriya would be able to beat you in a fight?” Luke asked.
> Katsuki’s brows practically shot up to his hairline. “I’d say you were full of shit.”

Chapter Notes

> merry chrysler y’all
> we can have a little sacrilege for christmas,,, as a treat
> well, not a little bc this is literally 24.6k words sorry about that oh gOD but uhhh
> enjoy??
>
> oh yeah, content warning for smut lmao

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izuku awoke to the sound of steady beeping and a throbbing pain inside his head. He opened his eyes blearily, only to close them again, wincing at the bright light.

“Deku?”

Izuku squinted as his eyes adjusted, and when he turned, he found Katsuki sitting at his bedside, looking pale and tired. “Kacchan,” He said, voice hoarse. He propped himself up on his elbows, and eased into an upright position. “What happened…?”

Katsuki barked a mirthless laugh. “Fuck, nerd. I mean…” He raked a hand through his hair. “You tell *me.* The nurses assumed there was another attack… Should’ve seen their faces when I told ‘em you just fuckin’ woke up like that. Which reminds me—” He reached over and pressed a button on the wall, presumably to alert them that he was awake.

Izuku’s brows pinched together. “Woke up like what…?”

“You don’t remember?” He raised an eyebrow, and then his eyes drifted downward. Izuku tracked the trajectory of his gaze until he settled on his right hand, which was currently fitted with a thin black fingerless glove. Izuku reached out to remove it. Katsuki grabbed his wrist before he could.

Just then, the doctor came in. “Ah, Mr. Midoriya.” She said. “Glad to see you awake.”

“Yeah, umm.” He glanced down at his hand. “What happened, exactly…?”

“Ah.” She nodded, grabbing a pair of vinyl gloves from a wall-mounted box and slipping them on before turning toward him again. “Now, I must warn you to refrain from touching it, alright?”

He nodded in agreement, and she proceeded to carefully remove the glove.

His jaw dropped.

Because there, on his hand, was what appeared to be a scar of some kind—but it was no normal scar. Snaking around from front to back were multiple vein-like impressions in his skin, more similar to a chemical burn than any sort of actual cut.

But the most alarming part was the color.

White, like fresh snow.

The memory of his dream came rushing back then, just as the doctor slid the glove back on. “We aren’t sure if touching it could be dangerous, but we figured it was a reasonable concern, given the nature of the injury.” She peeled her own gloves off and discarded them. “How are you feeling otherwise?”

“I’m… okay.” He replied. “Just a bit of a headache, but…” He trailed off, eyes still fixated on his hand.

“Well, we can give you something for that headache, if you’d like. Though I will say, considering what you’ve been through, that being your only symptom is pretty incredible.”

“…I see.”

After a moment, the doctor sighed, pulling out a rolling chair and sitting down. “Mr. Midoriya… I’m not sure how, but it seems you’ve been exposed to a heavy dose of—“

“—Divine light?” Izuku finished, looking up to meet the doctor’s eyes.

“…Correct.” She said. “The technical term is *angelic radiation,* but yes—divine light.”

Izuku returned his gaze to his hand, blinking slowly, trying to process it.

The doctor cleared her throat. “Do you have any idea how this could’ve happened?”

“I… Yes.” Izuku hesitated for a moment before he began speaking again, doing his best to recall the details of his dream. Both Katsuki and the doctor’s incredulity at the situation only seemed to increase in light of it.

“Wow.” She said. “That’s… new.”

“You’ve been having weird dreams for a few days now, haven’t ya?” Katsuki asked.

Izuku nodded.

He lowered his chin. “Do you think there could be some connection between them?”

Izuku huffed a small laugh. “At this point, I can’t think of any other explanation.” He glanced up at the doctor. “Umm… Will it heal?”

“I wish I could tell you.” She replied. “The thing is… normally, when Demons get exposed to angelic radiation, they go into anaphylactic shock and die shortly after. It’s hard to say what will happen to you, because frankly, you’re *already* in uncharted territory.”

Izuku swallowed roughly. “You mean…?”

She nodded grimly. “By all accounts, you should already be dead.”

Izuku couldn’t sleep—he wouldn’t allow himself to. The harrowing experience had left him afraid to dream, and so for the most part, he just lay there, staring up at the white ceiling tiles as the steady beeping of the heart monitor punctuated the passage of time.

He wondered when he could go home. When he asked the doctor, she couldn’t give him a straight answer.

Katsuki had excused himself around an hour ago. He’d promised to return as soon as possible, and though Izuku trusted that to be true, it’d be a lie to say the boredom wasn’t beginning to grate on him. But just as he was entertaining the idea of pulling out the IV and attempting to climb out the window, the door opened. In walked Katsuki, and trailing behind him was Aizawa, and… the Originals.

All three of them.

Lucifer and Beelzebub came through first. Leviathan sort of limboed under the doorframe.

It felt different, now that he knew who they were. Izuku tensed, shooting upright in bed with wide eyes.

Luke gave him one look and groaned. “Damn it. You told him, didn’t you?”

Katsuki just rolled his eyes. “He was gonna find out eventually.”

Luke sighed. “It’s nice to see you again, Midoriya.”

“Um, n-nice to see you, t-too, uhh… L-Luci—“

“Nope.” Luke gave him a strained smile. “No thanks; we’re not doing that. Stop it *immediately.”*

“Just give him time.” Levi said, patting his shoulder. “He’ll get over it eventually.”

Luke groaned again.

“I mean… we might be able to speed things up a bit.” Bee said. “Ah, Midoriya—do you know how to play chess, by any chance?”

The question caught him off guard. “U-Um… sure?”

“I dunno about that, Bee.” Katsuki snorted. “We wouldn’t want the nerd to lose *all* respect for him.”

Brushing off the insult, Luke took a step forward. “So.” He clapped his hands together. “We heard you’ve been astral projecting into Heaven. Is that true?”

“Um.” Izuku squeaked. “Th-That’s uhh, w-well… um…”

After a moment, Katsuki sighed. Then, without any preamble, he proceeded to march right up to Luke and forcibly remove his blazer, leaving him in only his crisp red dress shirt and tie.

“Bakugou, what—?“

“Roll your sleeve up.” Katsuki muttered.

“Why?” He frowned, narrowly managing to catch his coat before it hit the floor.

“Just fucking do it.”

“Alright, alright.” Luke sighed, proceeding to roll up his left sleeve. At that point, Katsuki grabbed him by the wrist and yanked him over to Izuku’s bedside.

“Look.” Katsuki said, all but shoving Luke’s wrist in his face. “Read it.”

Izuku squinted. There, on his wrist was a small tattoo, written in elegant black lettering.

It read: *No regerts.*

His brow furrowed, and he blinked a few times to make sure he wasn’t misreading it, but no. It was right there, clear as day.

No regerts.

Regerts.

“There. See?” Katsuki deadpanned. “He dresses and acts like this to try ’n trick people into thinking he’s smart, but in reality, he’s just an idiot—an absolute fucking moron. Get it?”

Luke yanked his wrist back and shuffled away. Looking up, Izuku could see Levi smiling, and Bee very obviously struggling to contain the urge to laugh.

Katsuki leaned over his bedside, raising an eyebrow. “Feel better?” He asked. “If you need me to humiliate the other two, I can easily do that, too.”

Levi and Bee immediately stopped smiling.

“Uhh, no.” Izuku said, waving his hands. “No, that won’t be necessary!”

“Alright.” Katsuki smirked, standing up straight again and sliding his hands into his pockets. “In that case, we can get on with it.”

“Um. Get on with what, exactly?” Izuku asked.

“You getting some fucking sleep.” He said. But that only made things more confusing. Seeming to sense his bewilderment, Aizawa stepped forward.

“You’re worried something could happen to you in a dream, right?” He asked. “I can help you there, at least in the short term.”

Katsuki nodded. “My Lust magic isn’t advanced enough to observe dreams, but Aizawa’s is.”

“So… if anything happens…” Izuku said.

“I’ll wake you up.” Aizawa finished.

“I see.” Izuku looked back at the Originals. “But then… why are they…?”

“We thought we’d conduct a small allseer network, so all of us can observe, too—if that’s alright with you, at least.” Levi said.

“Plus, we’re assuming you’ll need to be monitored overnight.” Bee added. “We figured it’d make sense to take it in shifts.”

His brow furrowed. “But aren’t you a Gluttony Demon?”

“Past a certain point, it’s not really useful to distinguish by type.” Katsuki shrugged. “As you’d probably expect, all of ‘em passed that point a long fuckin’ time ago.”

“Ah. Well, I guess that makes sense…” Izuku bit his lip. “But…”

“What?” Katsuki grunted.

He flushed. “Just, uhhh… what if I, um.”

“Spit it out, kid.” Aizawa muttered.

“I mean, what if I dream about something, you know… *embarrassing?”*

“If I see Bakugou in your dreams, I’m dropping out immediately.” Aizawa told him, monotone. “No one wants to see that.”

Katsuki opened his mouth, as if to argue. Aizawa shot him a sharp glare. Katsuki rolled his eyes, but didn’t try to speak again.

And that was that.

A few minutes later, Izuku found himself laying on his back in the hospital bed, an eye mask blocking out the daylight, covers pulled up to his chin. It was more than a little weird, going to sleep knowing that others would be observing his dreams. He could feel their presence as they all sat gathered around his bed. To their credit, they did seem to be doing their best to keep quiet, so he could at least *try* to forget they were there.

Izuku sighed, shifting around on the mattress, attempting to tune out the sound of the heart monitor on his left. In spite of his exhaustion, for a moment, he worried he wouldn't be able to fall asleep at all.

But as time passed by, his body gradually released the tension wound up inside, and soon, he could feel himself beginning to drift.

Within twenty minutes, he was out.

Izuku was standing in front of a dark, wooden door. He turned and looked around, observing that he was near the end of a wide corridor, lined with similar doors. On the wall behind him sat a large, ticking clock.

It was around half-past noon.

At the sound of someone shouting, Izuku returned his attention to the door in front of him. He inched closer, hesitantly turning the handle and pushing inward.

The door opened silently as two figures came into view.

Councilmen.

Neither of them seemed to have noticed his presence—far too absorbed in their own argument.

"Will you just *listen* for once?" One of them said. He was the shorter of the two; a man with red hair, and a face comparable to a human man in his early twenties.

"Why should I care what *you* think of my work?" The other man sneered. He was large, broad-shouldered, with the wrinkles of a man in his late forties. His greying black hair was slicked back, and he regarded the other Councilman with all the respect one would show a worm writhing on the pavement.

The younger man clenched his jaw. "When your work affects the rest of us, I think it matters what we think of it, Commander. I think it matters quite a lot, actually."

He rolled his eyes. "That child is *hardly*—"

"—He's been here for over *fifty years."*

"Oh?" He snorted. "And tell me, how much of that do you suppose he was conscious for?"

“No shit!” The younger man slammed his fist down on the table. “That’s the problem I’m trying to address!”

“Keep your voice down.”

“Fuck you.” He said, though his volume was notably lower. He clenched his jaw. *“Don’t do that.”*

“Oh? You don’t like that?” He scoffed. “And what are you going to do about it, Martyr? How much do you think you can hurt yourself before I manage to stop you?”

“Wonder if you’ll still feel that confident once I sew your mouth shut.”

The Commander narrowed his eyes. “I’d like to see you try, brat.”

They glared at each other for a moment, and then the younger man sighed, standing up straight. “Wake him up or I’ll do it myself.”

“You’re full of shit.”

“Am I?” He asked, laughing mirthlessly. “Maybe I am, Commander. But is that really a chance you want to take?”

The older man gritted his teeth, and with a forceful shove, he stood up. As he turned toward the door, Izuku hastily backed up, but couldn’t quite get out in time. His fingers got caught in the door as he tried to shut it, and the spark of pain made him yelp.

Izuku sat up in bed with a gasp, reflexively reaching for his hand. For a moment, he could actually feel the pain of having slammed the door on his fingers, but as seconds passed and his mind adjusted to his surroundings, the feeling soon faded.

When he looked up, he found Aizawa, Katsuki, and the three Originals still gathered around his bedside, looking deep in thought. Izuku tensed at first, but relaxed a moment later as he remembered why they were there.

Izuku laid back with a sigh, wiping cold sweat off his forehead.

Bee broke the silence with an awkward laugh. “Well, uhh, I guess that confirms what Setsuko told us. You know, about the Martyr and Commander hating each other.”

“Mm, I’m not sure if I’d call that *hatred.”* Luke said. “I don’t feel like I walked in on a fight just now. The atmosphere was off.”

Levi gave him a look, as though he knew exactly where he was headed with this line of reasoning. “Luke.”

Aizawa raised an eyebrow. “What are you talking about?”

“I’m not sure how to describe it.” Luke said, then threw Katsuki a look. “Bakugou, you know what I mean, right? What did you make of it?”

“I dunno.” Katsuki shrugged. “Felt kinda like watching the intro to some kinda hatefucking porno.”

He snapped his fingers. “That’s the analogy I was looking for.”

Aizawa sighed. “Does anyone have any *useful* observations?”

“Well, It’s interesting that slamming the door on your fingers woke you up.” Levi offered. “It seems like that might be a viable way for you to protect yourself going forward.”

“Inflicting pain?” Katsuki said.

“So it would seem.” Levi shrugged.

“Ehh… I dunno,” Bee said. “I mean, unless I’m wrong, every instance of pain was unexpected, wasn’t it? It might not work if he’s not surprised by it.”

“Well, we can have him test it later.” Aizawa said, before turning to address him directly.“Midoriya? What about you?”

“Sorry?”

“I’m just asking if you have any observations you want to share.”

“Oh,” Izuku bit his lip. “Uhh, I guess the thing that’s bothering me is what Three said… you know, when he was taunting him.” He squinted. “Something about Five hurting himself?”

“‘How much do you think you can hurt yourself before I manage to stop you?’” Levi recalled.

“So, what? The Martyr’s power’s got somethin’ to do with self-harm?” Katsuki raised an eyebrow. “Guess that’d check out.”

“I’d caution against getting too caught up in the ‘self’ part. For practical purposes, we should assume it doesn’t matter who is inflicting injury on him.”

“But that’s what we’re going with?” Bee asked. “Like, he gains special powers when he gets hurt?”

“Powers that get stronger based on the severity of his injuries, I’m guessing.” Levi added.

“Makes sense.” Katsuki said.

“That’s hardly the only thing the dream tells us, though.” Aizawa said.

Luke raised his eyebrows. “Oh?” He tilted his head. “Care to elaborate?”

“Midoriya isn’t just astral projecting into Heaven. He’s *possessing* someone. And based on the look of his uniform—the parts we could see, at least—it’s not just anyone. It’s a Councilman.” He stood up, clasping his hands behind his back, slowly pacing back and forth. “Last night ruled out Four. This one rules out Three and Five. Which means…” He trailed off, raising an eyebrow.

For a second, it was silent, as the realization settled into their minds.

“There are only three remaining options.” Luke said. “One, Two and Six.”

“The Healer, the Rejector, or the Violator.” Izuku whispered.

Aizawa gave a short nod. “And with any luck, we’ll be able to pin down which of those three it is before the invasion.”

Izuku never liked the hospital. It had a way of filling him up with contradictory feelings, everything simultaneously contaminated and sterile all at once. When he asked if he could leave, the doctor was silent for a while, which was, on its own, more than enough to put him on edge. Then she actually responded, and it got worse.

“Well, I can’t stop you from leaving, if that’s what you want.” She told him. “But if you *do* choose to leave, I can’t stop you from dying, either.”

Needless to say, Izuku agreed to let them observe him overnight.

Without much else to do, he fell asleep pretty early that night, and woke up several times throughout. It wasn’t until the third time, at around three in the morning, when it finally happened again, though compared to his last dream, this one was a bit anti-climactic.

In the dream, he was lying in a soft bed, staring up at an ornate chandelier. He stayed there for a moment, remaining perfectly still, half expecting to awaken any moment. But when a minute passed and nothing happened, he opted to climb out of bed and look around.

The room was the pinnacle of ostentatiousness. A vulgar display of wealth and decadance that Izuku couldn’t help but feel put off by. White furniture, hand-carved with curvy embellishments. Gemstone buttons and golden flourishes; smooth, marble floors, so cold he flinched when his bare feet touched them. Izuku spotted a pair of velvet slippers by the bedside, and went to slip them on.

He scanned the room one more time, eying the large door that would presumably lead him somewhere more interesting. But just as he was about to go for it, a flash of something caught his eye, pulling his attention to a smaller door off to the side.

Izuku’s breath caught when he realized it was a bathroom.

Which meant there was probably a *mirror*.

Slowly, Izuku began to move toward it, his steps cautious, as though he could expect something to jump out and shock him awake. He reached the threshold, and peered around

the door frame. But as he looked into the mirror, he saw only an empty room.

Next thing he knew, he was back in his own body, once again staring at the white ceiling tiles above his bed at the South Oseryth Medical Center. Swallowing roughly, he shifted on the mattress, pulled the sheets over his head, and drifted off once again.

Izuku spent most of the night searching for more ways to wake himself up, and so the next time he slammed his fingers in a door, he did so deliberately. He was pleased to find that the action did, in fact, wake him up.

More often than not, however, the dreams would end far more abruptly, and oftentimes for no apparent reason. Things generally lasted longest if he stayed wherever he was when the dream started, and the more he acted independently, the less stable things would become.

Izuku had a theory that exercising his control increased the likelihood of his host becoming cognizant, on some level, of his presence, thus leading to his body rejecting him. But as things stood, it was all just conjecture.

The next time Izuku woke up, it happened naturally. He blinked his eyes open blearily, the morning light filtering in through the blinds. He stared at the ceiling for a minute, waiting for his eyes to adjust before looking around. He found Bee sitting in the chair beside him, halfway through a bag of gummy candies. Bee offered one to him. Izuku politely declined.

His eyes were drawn to his other side, where he found Luke and Levi sitting across from one another, apparently playing chess. It was obvious that the game had only just begun. Luke, playing white, had a pawn on the e4 square, while Levi's black pawn sat on c5. With one foot propped up on the edge of the chair and his hands clasped around his knee, Luke studied the board intensely.

"Luke." Levi said.

He did not respond, but made his move a few seconds later. With all the confidence of a grandmaster, Luke proceeded to move his king to e2.

"Fuck you." Levi said, sounding tired. "I hate you so goddamn much."

Luke merely smiled. "It's your turn."

He made no move to proceed. "Luke, I'm begging you. Seriously."

"I made my move." He shrugged. "What more could you want from me?"

"Just learn a few openings. Learn some basic checkmates. You know, *strategy?"* He shook his head. "You were willing to learn how the pieces moved. Why are you drawing the line there?"

"Well, I'm fine with doing it. I just don't want to be *good* at it."

“Learning the Sicilian will not make you ‘good’ at chess, Luke, I fucking *promise.”*

“Look, if it’s so important to you, we can just start over.”

Levi stared at him blankly for a moment. “Fine.”

They moved the pieces back to their original position. Still playing white, it was again Luke’s move. He stared at the chess board for a minute, brows pinched together, as though deep in thought. Then, with a smile, he reached out and slowly push his pawn onto the f3 square.

Levi stood up and, without so much as a word, turned on his heel and swiftly left the room.

Katsuki caught the door as he was walking out. He was holding two cups of coffee in his hands, and Luke looked up as he entered. “Ah, Bakugou. Would you like to play a game of chess?”

“Yeah, not with you.” Katsuki snorted, before turning his attention to Izuku. “Oh, look who’s awake.”

Izuku smiled, sitting up in bed as Katsuki handed him an espresso. “Thanks, Kacchan.” He said, taking a sip.

“Anything new happen while you were asleep?”

Izuku shook his head. “I don’t think it happened this last time.”

Katsuki hummed. “So, what’s the score? Mirrors, pain… anything else?”

“Nothing concrete, I guess.” He replied. “Sometimes it just kind of ends on its own.”

“Hm. Well, I’ve got good news.” Katsuki said. “Doctor said you’re good to go.”

Izuku perked up. “You mean… we can leave?”

“Mhm. Whenever you’re ready.”

Izuku was already climbing out of bed.

It was around ten in the morning when they left the hospital, and they were walking down the sidewalk, heading for the train station, when Katsuki stopped in his tracks.

Izuku furrowed his brow. “Kacchan?”

“…Think you’d be up for a small detour?”

“I mean, sure.” He shrugged. “What is it?”

Katsuki grinned. “It’s a surprise.”

With that, he led Izuku across the street, through the side door of a large, multi-storied building. There were no signs posted on the path they took, or if there were, they were moving too quickly for Izuku to actually read any of them, and so it really was a surprise, in the truest sense. They made their way down a short hallway that fed into the main area, and Izuku didn't realize where they were until he saw it for himself.

It was a library.

A big one, at that. Though perhaps not as sprawling as the one Izuku had known up in Heaven, the sheer volume of books was undeniably greater. The main area was a circular room, with several stories stretching up into the sky.

And as he was looking around, it didn't really register for him, at first. But after a moment, it hit him like a freight train.

I can read anything I want.

Izuku's heart rate doubled, his eyes growing wider. It wasn't the first time he'd felt something in this vein—he'd experienced something similar at Katsuki's apartment.

But that was just one bookshelf.

This?

This was a level of intellectual freedom Izuku genuinely didn't know how to handle. His mind raced with possibilities as he spun around peering in all directions. There was just so much. *Too* much. Where would he even begin?

"Oi, nerd." Katsuki bumped his shoulder against him. "You good?

"I just… don't know where to start."

He hummed. "Maybe see if you can think of somethin' you always wanted to learn about but never could?"

Izuku nodded, falling silent as he racked his brain. "I mean… most of it was just stuff about Demons. But I feel like I've gathered most of that through experience now, other than maybe some history."

"Well, let's start with history, then." Katsuki shrugged. "Seems like a good idea, since most of what you've been taught probably ain't reliable."

He beckoned Izuku to follow him, stepping onto a platform which carried them up to the third floor. "This floor's the history section—most of it, anyway."

Stepping off, Katsuki took him to a large section labeled 'Hell.' He leaned against one of the bookshelves and grinned. "Here y'go. Go nuts."

Izuku was practically vibrating with excitement, his hands trembling as he touched the spines of the books. It was still a bit overwhelming, even in just that aisle alone, but Izuku started by

looking at some of the more prominently displayed books—ones recommended by the librarians—and it gave him something to latch onto.

He found a book on the history of conflict between Heaven and Hell that looked promising, if a bit intimidating, judging by how thick it was. Izuku reached out for it and pulled it off the shelf with ease. No extra weight. No glowing numbers denying him entry. He just picked it up and opened it, heart pounding as he flipped through it. He still couldn't help feeling like he was doing something he wasn't supposed to, like any moment now someone would snatch the book from his hands and reprimand him.

Perhaps that's why he reacted the way he did, when Katsuki tapped him on the shoulder and innocently asked, "Find one ya like?"

Izuku yelped, jumping and snapping the book shut.

"Woah, hey." Katsuki said. "You good?"

"Ah." Izuku flushed. "Y-Yeah, um. Sorry." He rubbed the back of his neck sheepishly. "What did you say?

"I just asked if you found a good one. That's all."

"Oh. Uh, yes, I did!" Izuku raised it up, allowing Katsuki to see the cover.

"Ah, yeah. I know that one. Haven't read much of it myself, but it's supposed to be pretty comprehensive."

"Oh, really? Well, good." Izuku said, chewing his lip."Um, can I maybe get another one?"

Katsuki snorted. "You can get as many as you damn well want, nerd."

Izuku grinned so wide, it almost hurt, and with that, he took off down the aisle again, a spring in his step as he scanned the shelves.

He found a book about the history of propaganda in Heaven, and another on the discovery of the Depths. There was a book cataloging the notable occasions when Demons and Humans crossed paths, and one which covered the events which led Hell to be the way it was today, and when Katsuki saw it, he perked up a bit. "Oh, this is probably about the Darkfire Revolt, huh."

"What's that?" Izuku asked, excited. "What's the Darkfire Revolt?"

Katsuki just smirked. "Read the book and find out, nerd."

Before too long, Izuku had more books than he could reasonably carry alone, and Katsuki had to help him. He was thinking he might be ready to leave soon, but as he passed a smaller section, one book in particular caught his eye. He turned and looked, and his brow furrowed.

Selected Fairytales.

It took him a moment to remember, but when it hit him, it hit him hard.

This is the book, Izuku realized. *The one All Might had me get for him all those months ago!*

He could remember picking it up, remember its weight, the way the spine glowed bright with the number 'six.'

He remembered being confused.

"There you are." Katsuki clicked his tongue. "Damn nerd. I've been lookin' for ya."

"Oh, um. Sorry." Izuku said. Katsuki followed his gaze to the book, and arched an eyebrow.

"Somethin' wrong?"

"…Why is this in the history section?"

Katsuki pointed at something to his right. "Check the sign, nerd."

Izuku turned, and for a moment, he just stared at it.

Defunct Memorandors.

And suddenly, it was like he was underwater. He could hear his heart beating in his ears, and everything around him went out of focus apart from what was right in front of him. "This…" He pointed at the book. "That's a memo?"

"Guess so. Unless it was put here by accident… which I doubt. I'm pretty sure *Selected Fairytales* is one of the designed forms."

"'Designed forms'?"

"There's two kinds of memos: designed and improvised." He explained. "Improvised memos repurpose books that already exist. The good thing is since they have specific owners, they're usually more secure. The drawback is that if the books have different page counts, you can run into issues where pages from the longer one are *'inactive.'"* He used air quotes. "Designed memos don't have that issue, 'cuz they're created as memos from the get-go, so both copies are *fully* identical."

Izuku remained frozen in place, staring at the book as things started to click.

This is why, he realized. *This is why the level was so high.*

It's not a book of fairytales.

It never was.

"C-Can I check this out?"

"I mean, yeah." Katsuki said. "But you've gotta return it within three days. Since memos are unique, they wanna avoid anyone havin' one for too long without a good reason."

Izuku nodded, reaching out and grabbing the book. He added it to his stack.

“Ready to go?” Katsuki asked.

“Yeah.” Izuku replied. “Ready.”

When Izuku finally got the chance to flip through his books, he was almost too scared to open the memo. For a few minutes, he just stared at the cover, but eventually, he worked up the courage to open it.

At first, there wasn’t much to it, at least nothing of consequence for Izuku. It was mostly just illustrations, maps of various areas in Hell, some labeled, others not.

That is, until he got to the last six pages.

He’d know that handwriting anywhere.

Hello, is anyone there? I was hoping someone could help me. I’m looking for a woman named Nana Shimura. She Fell about fifty years ago. Any information would help.

The note was signed with the date it was written, around six and a half months back. No name was included, but Izuku didn’t need it. He knew.

He swallowed the metallic taste on his tongue

The rest of the page consisted of a list of consecutive dates following the first—around fifty days in total, with the last being February 7th.

Izuku turned the page, and this time, the handwriting was unfamiliar.

Who is this?

When All Might responded, his words were calm and diplomatic, but the shakiness of his writing betrayed his excitement, his nerves. Izuku wondered how many times he’d done this, and for how long—seeking out old memos, hoping that someone would respond. Hoping to get lucky.

Toshinori Yagi. I am a retired third-sphere Angel.

Please hear me out. I know this is strange.

Nana Shimura was my mentor before she Fell.

If you ask her, she can vouch for my character.

I only wish to speak with her. Please.

Hello?

The next entry was written in entirely different handwriting, and what followed was a short back-and-forth between All Might and whoever it was he was speaking to.

What's your game, Yagi?

There's no game. I am simply seeking information for personal reasons.

I've already violated several laws by reviving this memo and contacting you.

If that's true, prove it.

State your name and intentions in sanguiscript.

All Might's next response was written messily in dark, red ink.

My name is Toshinori Yagi.

I am seeking information on the whereabouts of Nana Shimura for personal reasons only.

I am not collaborating with God or the Council.

Huh.

I wasn't expecting you to actually do it, but your cooperation is appreciated.

Give me a few days.

Much like All Might's response, the next one came in deep red ink.

(Izuku knew it wasn't actually ink.)

There is no record of anyone by the name of 'Nana Shimura' ever having appeared in Hell.

All Might's reply, and all thereafter, were written in plain, black ink.

I see.

May I ask how you know?

Upon Falling, Angels are transported to Hell unless a Demon specifically prevents it.

When this happens, they're automatically routed to one of around a dozen different locations.

We keep careful records of who is sent where.

If this Nana Shimura person had been to any of them, we would have a record of it.

Of course, there's a small chance she could still be down here,

but only if she was deliberately kept from being transported initially.

Do you have any reason to believe this could've been the case?

No. I was there. The transport mechanism was definitely initiated, at least.

I've suspected the magic might have been intercepted for a while now.

Back then, I remember the ground collapsing, but not her collapsing with it…

For a while, I just assumed my memory was faulty.

Well, if this were the case, it'd be the first we'd heard of it.

But it's not too outlandish, at least in theory.

I see.

Thank you for your help.

We suggest you destroy your copy as soon as possible.

I will.

From that point forward, the pages were blank, and for a long while, Izuku just stared. His mind flashed with memories, all those times in the past few months when All Might had asked him to retrieve books for him. Was this what he'd been up to? Just searching for an old memorandor, hoping to revive it, hoping its twin was still intact?

He ran his fingers over the page, and his eyes began to water. He knew the memo was dead, its twin having obviously been destroyed. If he wrote in it, his words would go nowhere but the page in front of him. That didn't stop him from picking up the pen, though.

I'm going to save you, All Might. I promise.

With those words etched into the parchment, Izuku set the pen down. He closed the book, held it in his hands. Waited for that warm feeling that would indicate that the memo was alive. It never came.

Izuku sighed, and vaguely wondered if what he just did counted as vandalism.

In the days that followed, a pattern began to emerge.

Every morning, Izuku would wake up already reaching for the small notebook on his bedside, and proceed to dump all his memories of his dreams that night out on the page.

Katsuki made breakfast most mornings, and Izuku was quickly discovering just how absurdly good at cooking he was. He wondered if there was anything Katsuki *wasn't* good at.

"Singing." He said, alerting Izuku to the fact he'd been thinking out loud again. "I'd probably be better if I actually worked at it, but out of the different elements of music, rhythm's the

more intuitive one for me. Most of my musical experience is with playing drums."

"You play drums?"

And that was the other thing. Izuku felt like he learned something new about Katsuki every day, discovered parts of his past that never failed to surprise him. Katsuki would roll his eyes and downplay it.

"I've been here over two hundred years, nerd." He'd say. "Of course I've done a lot of shit. It'd be boring as fuck otherwise."

Still, Izuku remained infinitely, perpetually impressed by him. And though he wouldn't say so aloud, he could tell Katsuki reveled in it more than he would ever admit.

When noon rolled around, Izuku would generally be down at the Academy. Izuku, and everyone else, for that matter, figured it was safe to assume that, because the Council was likely to be most active during the daytime, the potential for obtaining useful information was likely to be higher. Thus, every day, for around an hour and a half, Izuku consented to being observed in his sleep.

After discussing their findings, Izuku would often get lunch with Katsuki before heading back to the Academy, where they would train together until sunset.

At night, he would fall asleep next to Katsuki, repeating the words, 'mirrors and pain' in his mind, just to make sure he remembered them, should he ever find himself needing to wake from a dangerous situation.

All in all, things were pretty good.

But there was something off. A sort of tense undercurrent pervading his mind, driven by uncertainty.

Because Izuku wanted to participate in the invasion. He knew it wasn't fully rational, but he couldn't help it. He wanted to be there. He wanted to be the one to reach down into the darkness and pull All Might out from whatever privatized Hell the Council had invented.

But he knew he wasn't ready.

While magic had thus far been fairly intuitive for him, he was still a far cry away from being able to fight with it reliably. He still struggled to move while utilizing certain techniques, and frequently stumbled. He hadn't even settled on a class yet.

Izuku didn't talk about it. Didn't suggest it or press the issue. He simply went through the motions, attending the observation sessions, allowing the others to analyze his dream journal, because as things stood, that was all he could do. Though he wanted more than anything to play an active role in the invasion, he knew that if he did, he'd be more of a liability than an asset.

But as days passed by and his dreams continued to be monitored, as he continued to be briefed on information regarding the mission that he had no clear reason to be privy to, a

strange feeling started to cultivate inside of him. He was no longer sure of his role in all of this. No longer knew what to expect.

They were eight days away from the official invasion when it happened. It was at the end of the observation session, when Izuku and Katsuki were about to leave. They were already heading toward the door when Luke cleared his throat.

“Oh, by the way—we were thinking it’d be a good idea to bring Midoriya along on the mission.”

Both of them froze, but Katsuki recovered quicker. He spun around and fixed Luke with a sharp glare. “What did you just say?”

“Just that we think Midoriya should join in the invasion.”

Izuku turned around, then. Of the three of them, Luke was the only one sitting down. Bee stood off near the corner, his eyes darting between Katsuki and Luke, fidgeting anxiously with the bottom of his hoodie. Levi stood closer to Luke, and though he did not appear as outwardly nervous as Bee did, Izuku could tell from the way he held himself—it was like he was expecting a fight to break out, and was preparing to intervene at a moment’s notice.

Luke, however, seemed completely unfazed, as though he weren’t even aware of the precariousness of the situation.

“No fucking way.” Katsuki spat.

The two locked eyes for a moment, Luke’s face still relaxed, while Katsuki looked like he was barely holding back the urge to dive across the table and throttle him.

“It’s not exactly your choice, Bakugou.” He eventually said. “If Midoriya wishes to come with, he’s free to make that decision for himself.”

“What the fuck is wrong with you? Got vassalites for brains?” He snarled. “Why the *fuck* would you think that was a good idea?”

Luke laughed softly. “I guess you could say I have a hunch.”

“You want Deku to put his life in danger over a fucking *hunch?”* Katsuki hissed, striding closer.“Are you insane? *He can’t fucking fight.”*

“Well, it’s a good thing *you* can.”

At this point, Izuku couldn’t remain silent any longer. “Luke, I don’t want Kacchan to have to protect me.”

Luke shot him a charming smile. “Oh, come now. Bakugou’s strong enough to keep both of you safe. Don’t you have faith in your boyfriend?”

Katsuki slammed his hands down on the table. He leaned forward, getting in his face. “Cram it with the fucking manipulation, asshole. *Speak. Plainly.”*

They stared at each other for a while, until eventually, the handsome smile on Luke's face abruptly disappeared. "Alright, fine." He said. "Here's the deal. We don't know what's going on with his dreams, or why they're happening. But it's something he can do that no one else can, which is valuable."

"Valuable *how?"*

"I'm afraid that is presently unknowable, Bakugou." He replied. "I can only say that his ability to possess one of the Councilmen suggests a deeper connection with said Councilmen. We won't know how or if this connection will be useful during the actual invasion, and we never will, unless we bring him."

"We'll never know if he fucking dies, either."

"Based on Levi's analysis of the situation, we've concluded that ensuring his safety during the event itself is not as big a hurdle as you might otherwise assume." Luke said, still expressionless. "There's still a chance he could get killed, but when you think about it, there's always that chance, regardless of the situation. For example, I could kill you right now, if I wanted, but—"

Levi dropped a hand on his shoulder. "Luke. That's not helping."

Luke stopped speaking, pursing his lips.

Katsuki didn't seem bothered, however. "Is that true, Levi?"

After a moment of hesitation, Levi answered. "Yes. We're already taking measures to ensure the captives will remain safe. It's fairly trivial to extend those measures to our own personnel —in this case, Midoriya."

"But we don't know what could happen." Katsuki said, shaking his head. "This is unknown territory."

"Yes. That is correct." He replied, speaking slowly, carefully. "I'm not saying there will be no risk. I'm only saying that, to the extent that we can, we don't see this as being as big of a gamble as you likely do."

"And what about you, Bee?" Katsuki shouted, head snapping toward him, making him jump. "What do *you* think of all this?"

"Um, I-I just… I agree? With Luke and Levi?"

"Yeah? *Why?"*

"I-I mean… I dunno."

"Oh, you don't fucking *know,* huh?!"

Bee flushed, fists clenching around the fabric of his hoodie. "I don't know what you want me to say!" He cried, voice shrill. "I just—I agree with them, okay? Leave me alone!" He

grabbed his hood and pulled it up over his head, tugging on the drawstrings, so that it closed around his face. His back pressed into the wall, Bee proceeded to slide down it, until he was sitting on the floor with his knees pulled into his chest.

And rationally, Izuku knew that Katsuki didn't pose a real threat to Bee. He was an Original Demon, about as strong as either Levi or Luke, but it still stirred some protective instinct inside of him, prompting him to grab Katsuki by the arm. "Kacchan, *please* calm down."

Katsuki clenched his jaw, remaining tense under his touch for a good thirty seconds or so before he started to relax. Taking a deep breath, he directed his attention back to Luke, who stared at him blankly.

"So." Katsuki said. "You wanna explain to me why you feel so comfortable putting Deku in a dangerous situation based on the vague possibility of it being useful?"

"You seem to be misunderstanding the situation." Luke intoned. "I'm not going to force Midoriya to do anything. I'm simply opening the door. I have neither the power nor the will to draft him, Bakugou. If he's going to participate, it will be of his own volition."

Katsuki scoffed. "Fuck you. I've heard enough." He grabbed Izuku by the wrist. "C'mon, Deku. Let's get the fuck out of here."

He started pulling him toward the door. But as Katsuki was reaching for the doorknob, Luke spoke again—three simple words that gave the two of them pause.

"I'll train him."

Katsuki stopped in his tracks. For a second, he remained rooted in place, his grip on Izuku's wrist tightening. Then, he slowly started to turn, and looked at Luke like he'd grown a second head. "You'll *what?"*

Luke shrugged, examining his cuticles. "I said I'll train him."

Katsuki just stared at him, wide-eyed. After a second, he released Izuku's wrist. "What the fuck?" He muttered. "You haven't taken on a student in… what, a thousand years?"

"One thousand and thirty-six, to be exact. And I wasn't planning on taking another anytime soon. But since this is a special occasion, I think I can make an exception." He said. "And don't worry, I won't go easy on him. It'll be Hell on Earth." He faltered, squinting. "Or rather, Hell in Hell, or…" he shrugged again. "You get the idea."

When Katsuki finally managed to pick his jaw up off the floor, he swallowed. "It's… there's not enough time, Lucifer. The invasion's *next week.* Even under your mentorship, there's no way he'll be ready that quickly."

"Hmm, what day is it? Tuesday?" Katsuki said nothing in response. "What if I told you that by Sunday morning, he'd be able to beat you in a fight?"

Katsuki's eyebrows practically shot up to his hairline. "I'd say you were full of shit." He scoffed. "I don't care what kind of trick you've got planned. He's not gonna be better than me

by then."

"I never said *better."* Luke said. "I just said he'd be able to beat you. Say, once out of ten matches. Sound fair?"

"And what's the catch?" Katsuki asked. "Am I not allowed to use magic? Do I gotta wear weights on all my limbs?"

"No, it's quite straightforward, really. Ten fights, full power, no restrictions."

"That makes no fucking sense." Katsuki said. "I don't know what you're planning, but it won't fucking work."

"If you sincerely believe that, then you have nothing to worry about." He said. "Because if I'm wrong, I'll drop it. That's the deal. Ten fights. If he fails to win any of them, he'll stay behind. If he manages to pin you a single time, he'll come with."

Katsuki stared at him for a while. "Holy shit. You crazy fuck, you're fucking *serious,* aren't you?"

For the first time in what felt like an eternity, Luke smiled. He turned his gaze toward Izuku. "What do you think, Midoriya? No pressure, no fine print. You can back out any time you wish. Would you like to become my student?"

Izuku swallowed, and for a minute, it was like time stood still. Katsuki stood beside him, his muscles tense as he stared down at the surface of the table. Luke cracked his knuckles one by one, patiently waiting.

With a sigh, Izuku slowly reached over, lacing his fingers through Katsuki's. He glanced at him from the corner of his eye. Izuku gave his best reassuring smile, and squeezed his hand.

Then, exhaling all his reservations, he turned his head toward Luke, and squeezed Katsuki's hand one more time.

"I accept."

Tomorrow morning, nine o'clock sharp.

That was when his training was set to begin.

With *Lucifer.*

Izuku felt nervous just thinking about it, his sweaty palms slipping as he gripped the pole on the train. He wasn't sure if he was looking forward to it or dreading it.

And then there was Katsuki. Izuku glanced at him out of the corner of his eye as the city rushed by, trying to get a read on his expression. He seemed calm, enigmatic. There was something unsettling about it, but he didn't get the sense that he was angry with him.

Maybe Katsuki, like him, was having trouble sorting out his feelings about the matter.

On the way back from the train station, they stopped at a nearby restaurant and ordered takeout before heading home. Neither one of them broached the issue until around an hour after the meeting had ended, while they were sitting at the table, eating.

“Kacchan… is everything okay?” Izuku asked, anxiety plain to hear in his tone. “Are *we* okay?”

The question seemed to catch Katsuki off guard. He froze, fork halfway between his plate and his mouth. After a few seconds, he replied, “Uh, yeah? Why wouldn’t we be?”

Izuku frowned. “You know why,” he mumbled. “You seemed really upset earlier.”

He sighed, dropping his fork and leaning back. His eyes locked on the ceiling, Katsuki asked, “Why do you want to participate in the invasion?”

Izuku tensed. He knew he should’ve anticipated that question, but somehow, he still wasn’t prepared for it. He shrugged, sliding down the seat of his chair. “I mean, I dunno, I just…” he trailed off, eyes drifting off to the side. Triplet was curled up on the couch, her tails flicking occasionally as she slept.

When his gaze returned to Katsuki, he found him staring right back.

“You know you don’t have to do fucking *everything,* right?” He asked, with little to no intonation. “There’s some shit you oughta just leave to people who know what the fuck they’re doing.”

Izuku swallowed around the lump in his throat. “I know that, but…”

A moment of silence.

“What?” Katsuki prompted, impatience leaking into his tone.

He sighed, closing his eyes. When he opened them again, he kept his gaze fixed on his plate, pushing food around with his fork. “It feels too… personal, I guess.”

Another pause.

“What do you mean?”

Izuku hesitated, taking a deep breath before continuing. “Well, part of it’s because All Might is there. I just… feel like I need to be there to make sure he gets out safe.” Katsuki opened his mouth to retort, but Izuku held a hand up—his injured one, still covered by the thin, black glove. “Don’t,” He winced. “I know. I know that’s not, you know… rational. I *know.* It’s just… how I feel. That’s all.”

Katsuki regarded him quietly for a moment, as though he were trying to read his very soul. “You said that was part of it.” He eventually said. “What’s the other part?”

Izuku set his fork down, burying his hand in his hair. For a long time, he didn't respond. When he finally spoke, it was slow, quiet. And as the words left his mouth, he felt he was sorting through his emotions in real time, explaining them to Katsuki as well as himself.

"I… know I made the right choice. You know, by Falling. At least rationally I understand that, but… I don't know. I know I'm on the right side. A-And I believe you, Kacchan. I *trust* you when you say that God needs to be…" he trailed off, biting his lip. "But I think… deep down, there's still a part of me that needs to see it for myself. Or else I'll just keep… wondering." He took a deep, shaky breath, and exhaled. "I guess what I'm trying to say is… I need to see him. God. I need to feel that he's irredeemable, or else I'll always wonder if there could've been a better way."

Katsuki was silent for far longer than Izuku felt comfortable with. When he looked up at him, he found him staring back, his expression unreadable.

"Deku, sweetie. You watched them throw Angels into a fucking meat grinder."

Izuku felt a spike of nausea, paired with a rush of heat to his head. His shoulders drew upward, and the tears came suddenly, welling up and threatening to spill over.

"I know that!" He cried, strangled and shrill, shocking even himself. He gripped the fabric of his pants hard enough to hear threads popping. "It's just—"Izuku's lip quivered as he searched for an adequate explanation, but his thoughts were muddled, and it only heightened his panic. He didn't know what to say, and the longer he went without speaking, the worse he felt.

He couldn't get a grip on his emotions. He felt embarrassed, and confused, and scared. He wondered if Katsuki thought he was a bad person. He wondered if he *was* a bad person.

Izuku's body collapsed inward, shoulders shaking as he cried. He wanted to make himself smaller. Wanted to disappear.

He didn't realize Katsuki had moved until he felt his hand on his shoulder. Through teary eyes, he looked up and found that he'd pull up a chair next to him. Katsuki wrapped his arm around him and pulled him close. Izuku buried his face in his chest, threw one of his legs over Katsuki's so he could better hide against him. He gripped the fabric of his shirt and cried.

"What's wrong with me?" He said. "Am… Am I a bad person?"

"No." Katsuki pulled him closer. "No, baby, you're not."

Izuku cried harder, tears soaking the fabric of Katsuki's shirt.

It was all so complicated. He felt this desperate need to explain himself, to justify why he felt the way he did. Because for as much as he'd learned these past several months, it was still only half a year against decades of conditioning. He hated to admit it, but there was still a part of him that wanted to separate the character of God from the regime he represented.

He wanted to believe that God could still be benevolent, because misguided benevolence could be salvaged.

But he could hear the sound of bones crunching, the smell of blood both fresh and not. He could see the colorless, bleach-white town just beneath the cliff, feel the burn in his hand, the itch in his throat that made him cough uncontrollably, even as his brain steadily lost oxygen. The misery and the fear at the possibility of dying that way, just as hundreds of thousands, perhaps even millions, had before him.

But even as these memories rang vivid in his mind, that selfish desire remained. It was so much more comfortable to view it all as a matter of human incompetence. The folly of man, the corrosive force of power upon one's mind and soul. But that excuse could only go so far, even if God truly wasn't involved. At some point, inaction could only imply endorsement.

Maybe this was what God really meant, when he said he made them in his image.

"You don't have to explain." Katsuki murmured, his chin rested atop Izuku's head. "I know. I get it."

Izuku continued to cry, and Katsuki stroked his hair. Over time, it grew less intense, until eventually all he was left with was dried tears, a stuffy nose, and a headache. Still, he remained there, wrapped up in the warmth of Katsuki's arms. It'd been a while since either of them had spoken, and it was Katsuki who finally broke the silence.

"Look. I'm not gonna try and stop you, nerd. Frankly, I doubt I even could." He told him, chest rumbling against Izuku's cheek. "But just so you know, I ain't holdin' back on Sunday. You better train your ass off."

Izuku smiled softly, though Katsuki couldn't see it. He tightened his arms around his back, scooting closer.

Their food had long since gone cold.

Izuku arrived to find Luke sitting in a chair at the center of the training room, his ankle resting on his knee, an open book held in one hand. As he entered, Luke looked up, flashing a charming smile. "Ah, Midoriya. You're early."

Izuku laughed awkwardly. "Yeah, um. Hope that's okay."

"It's quite alright." He said. "Do you have a warm-up routine you like to do?"

"I mean, sure." Izuku smiled.

"Good. Why don't you take a few minutes to run through that, and then we'll get started."

Izuku nodded, setting his bag down. Luke turned his attention back to his book, and as his eyes scanned the page, Izuku shuffled around nervously for a moment before he took a deep breath and exhaled. As he worked through his stretches, the silence was filled only by the subtle shifting of his clothing, and the occasional sound of a page turning.

When he was done, Izuku stood up and cleared his throat.

“One moment, please.”

“Ah.” Izuku coughed, remaining rooted in place as he awkwardly waited for him to finish. Around twenty seconds later, he turned the page, folded the corner, and snapped the book shut.

“Right, then.” Luke stood up, grabbing the chair and setting it in the corner, along with his book. “So, I understand Bakugou’s been teaching you.”

“Uh, yeah.” Izuku nodded. “He has, uh, for I think five days, now.”

“And what sort of teaching methodology does he use?”

Izuku blinked. “Sorry?”

“How do you learn from him?” He clarified.

“Oh.” Izuku said. “Uh, I mean. He kind of just… works with me until I figure things out for myself. Sometimes he’ll give me advice if I’m struggling, though.”

“So, a Discovery approach.”

“A… what?”

“There are a few different schools of thought, when it comes to magical instruction. The major ones are called *Discovery* and *Direction.”* He explained. “In Discovery-based instruction, the teacher is really more of a guide. There’s a strong emphasis on not imposing one’s own way of doing things, and so while the instructor might offer general tips, most of the work is just trial and error on the student’s end.”

“Ohh, I see.” Izuku nodded.

“The benefit of it is that it builds off of your existing intuition, allowing you to incorporate magic into your natural behavior. Students who learn via Discovery tend to develop a more fluid style.”

“What about the other one?”

“The Direction-based methodology is what you’ll see more often in large classes. There, students are actually *told* what to visualize, and most of the hard work is in training your body to accept those images.” He said. “The main benefit of this is that the learning trajectory is well-trodden; if you’re struggling with some aspect of it, it’s almost always something that others have worked out a solution for already. So there’s much less guess-work involved.”

Izuku nodded silently. “I see… and which one do you use?”

“For you?” He raised an eyebrow. “Neither.”

Izuku blinked. “Sorry?”

He smiled, wagging a finger. “Those are the *major* schools of thought, Midoriya. I never said those were the *only* ones.” He paused, turning his back on him. “There are a fair number of others, but the method I’ll be using for you is what’s known as the *Dominion* methodology.”

Izuku waited for him to elaborate, but he didn’t. And after a moment, Izuku cleared his throat. “And what’s that?”

“Great question.” Suddenly he turned around, and as Izuku met his glowing, violet eyes, something hit him. An overwhelming presence took up residence inside his head, like a tsunami crashing into his very being. A force so intense, he staggered back, nearly losing balance.

Someone was speaking—more specifically, *Izuku.*

“Dominion-based instruction involves a complete overhaul of the student’s mind and body.” His voice carried the same sort of formal cadence he’d come to expect from Luke. “The instructor operates the student’s mind and body as though they were their own. The student will think however the instructor wants them to think, move however they want them to move, over and over again, until the images and movements are committed to memory, and the student is able to replicate them on their own.”

As he spoke the last word, he felt the presence inside him wane, and he immediately fell to his hands and knees, gasping.

This was nothing like when Katsuki had hypnotized him.

This was a whole new level.

Izuku did not like it.

He looked up at Luke and found him staring down at him with a passive expression. Izuku avoided making eye-contact, though he doubted he would actually need it.

Luke waited for Izuku to stand up. “How are you feeling?”

“Not… “ Izuku shivered. “Not good. Feel sick.”

He hummed. “Well, I will remind you that you are free to opt out of this at any point, if you decide it’s too much for you.”

“But is this really necessary?” Izuku was still feeling kind of clammy all over. “Can’t you just train me normally?”

“I could. But that would kind of defeat the purpose, would it not?” He tilted his head. “The whole point of me training you is to get you to a point of proficiency where you won’t be a complete liability during the mission, Midoriya. To that end, the Dominion methodology is really the only viable approach.”

He paused for a moment, and then sighed.

“Look. I won’t sugarcoat this.” He told him. “There’s a very good reason why this approach is so uncommon. It’s extremely aggressive and highly uncomfortable, both physically and mentally. On top of that, it also has the potential to be quite dangerous. There are only a handful of people competent enough to use such methods safely. Under normal circumstances, I would not recommend it.

”However, Dominion has exactly one advantage over Discovery and Direction, Midoriya. Namely, speed. And I regret to inform you that you now have just under four days to digest enough training to defeat an expert Wrath Demon ten-percent of the time.”

Izuku was silent for a moment, clenching his jaw. Though he didn’t like it, it did make sense. Taking a deep breath, he slowly exhaled, and then stood up again.

“What should we work on first?” he asked.

“Well, Bakugou is primarily a Wrath Demon.” Luke said. “What do you suppose would be a good counter against that?”

“Umm, well,” Izuku squinted. “I… don’t think I know enough to give an informed answer.”

“No need for that. Just take a wild guess.”

“Um. Okay, I suppose.” Izuku shuffled around awkwardly. “I mean… maybe also Wrath?”

“Oh? What makes you say that?”

“Well, Wrath is a really offensive style, right?” Izuku said. “That means it’s probably weaker on defense. But also, I don’t expect to get many good hits in against Kacchan, so when I do, I’d have to make them count.”

Luke smiled. “Interesting idea. I can see where you’re coming from.” He paused. “That said, if we were to focus on Wrath, come Sunday, the three of us would be left scraping your corpse off the training room floor. Because Bakugou would crush you immediately. Like a roach.”

The bluntness of his statement caught Izuku off guard. It took a moment for him to formulate a response.

“…Oh. Um,” his eyes darted around. “I see. Uh, why is that?”

“Well, you’re correct in your observation; the highly offensive nature of Wrath does lead to a deficit in defense—for both of you. And as the more experienced fighter, Bakugou would use that deficit to absolutely clobber you.”

“I… right. Okay.” Izuku winced. “Well, what do *you* suggest, then?”

“Sloth.” He said. “Sloth is the best style for countering Wrath, by far.”

“Really?” Izuku frowned. “But… Kacchan told me it wasn’t very useful.”

Luke rolled his eyes. “He’s just saying that because it’s not flashy. Sloth abilities are actually extremely powerful, just in a different way.”

“What do you mean?”

He hummed. “How about I just show you?”

After a moment of hesitation, Izuku nodded. With that, Luke beckoned him over to the touch stone at the center of the room. Izuku put his hands down, without needing to be told, and looked up at Luke.

He braced himself for the incoming invasion, but honestly, Izuku didn’t think he could ever truly feel prepared for it, even after experiencing it already.

The power of his presence was all-encompassing, a sort of mental weight that extended through his veins, into his bones. But Izuku couldn’t even think about it, didn’t have the capacity to acknowledge the burden consciously. That honor was left to Luke. Izuku felt like he was an observer inside his own body.

Soon, Izuku found himself conjuring up images in his mind—things he would’ve never thought of himself.

He imagined his soul losing heat. He visualized it like a fiery haze leaving its form, until there was hardly anything left.

And just like that, the stone froze over, ice crystals forming on the surface.

He kept the image in his head, trying to think of the heat clinging to the walls of the room. Then, suddenly, it came racing back to him, diffusing into his skin and muscles. He took his hands out of the impressions and began to move around, and though the chilled sensation seemed to stay at his core, his range of motion was normal.

He felt some of Luke’s presence ease, but the image remained at the back of his mind as Izuku’s thoughts came into focus.

“That’s the trick to Sloth.” Luke said, shrugging. “People tend to think of coldness as a property on its own. It’s not. Things that are cold lack heat. Things that are hot do not ‘lack’ cold.” He snorted. “The key thing is that, when you imagine the release of heat, you don’t just release it randomly. You keep it in your muscles, and that’s what allows you to keep moving.”

“…That actually makes a lot of sense.” Izuku said. “So, how does this help me defeat someone like Kacchan, then?”

“Like this.”

Suddenly, Luke lunged toward him, his fist connecting with Izuku’s jaw, making his head snap to the side. The force knocked him off his feet, sending him flying into the mirror

behind him. Izuku's eyes widened as his spine hit the surface, and he heard it shatter. As shards rained down, Izuku fell to the ground, hitting his head and shoulder on the hardwood floor.

His heart was racing, and he was breathing quite quickly, but as he lay there, he slowly realized… it didn't hurt.

And then Luke relinquished his hold, and offered a hand to him. Izuku accepted it, standing up shakily. He reached for his spine, then touched his head and shoulder, but there was no sign of injury. No aches or pains. It was as though nothing had even happened.

"People underestimate the effectiveness of Sloth in combat, because the moves aren't flashy. But if you're going up against an opponent whose main strength is his ability to hit you really hard, you'll need a style that will enable you to absorb those hits with minimal injury. To that end, there's really nothing better."

Izuku swallowed, nodding slowly. He glanced back at the broken mirror, eying the shards on the ground. "Should we, uhh…?"

"Later." He said. "We'll focus on your training for now. Are you ready?"

He blinked. "Are you… going to punch me in the face again?"

"Well, not necessarily the face. And not necessarily a punch."

"But you *are* going to attack me, is what you're saying."

"That is correct."

"…How many times?"

Luke shrugged. "Until it sticks."

Izuku sighed, hesitating. Of all the things he could've expected from this training session, he never once imagined he'd be spending the day getting kicked and punched by the prince of darkness himself. But Hell was full of surprises, it seemed.

And so, after a deep breath, Izuku nodded.

Seven hours in, the training room almost looked like the one on the surface, where he used to spar with Katsuki. And though Izuku remained uninjured, the constant weight of Luke's control over him had given him a whole new kind of headache.

It was the last hour of their session when Luke finally stopped, putting his hands on his hips.

"Alright, I think you've got it."

Izuku's eyes lit up. "R-Really?" Luke nodded. "So… does that mean we're done?"

He laughed, and Izuku felt an ominous feeling creeping up on him, even before he actually replied. “Done?” Luke said. “Oh, Midoriya, we’re only just beginning.”

“What…?” He cleared his throat, swallowing the anxiety creeping up inside. “I’m not, um. I’m not really sure what you’re saying.”

“It’s quite simple, really.” He shrugged. “I’ve taught you the basics. Now, it’s time to put your knowledge to the test.”

Izuku’s eyes widened, and he instinctively took a step back. “You… You don’t mean…”

Luke raised his fist, winding up a punch. As he moved, a grin slowly spread over his lips. Izuku paled, scrambling to replicate the moves he’d spent the last several hours learning—releasing heat, absorbing it into his muscles. He felt like he was watching his fist fly forward in slow motion just before it connected with his chest, time speeding up again as he was thrown into the wall behind him.

Though he’d managed to block the brunt of Luke’s hit, his control wavered in its aftermath. His back slammed into the wall, and this time, he *felt it.*

Izuku groaned as he fell to a heap on the floor, and winced as he slowly stood up, rubbing his shoulder, where the impact was the worst.

“Good work.”

Izuku gave him an odd look. “What? But… I lost it. When I hit the wall.”

“Sure, but under normal circumstances, that hit should’ve put you in the hospital. If you can still stand, I would count it as a win.” He smiled. “Ready to go again?”

And so it went.

For the next hour, Izuku was kicked and punched in a variety of ways, thrown into a variety of different objects and surfaces, collecting more and more bruises each time. He’d managed to block most of Luke’s hits, though a few he still felt a bit, and after a couple of tries, he managed to maintain his soul’s form during the rebound. Still, by the time the hour was up, Izuku felt like one big, walking wound.

And then it got worse.

Izuku was buckled over, hands on his knees as he panted heavily when he heard something click. His brows pinched together, and he looked up, only to immediately freeze.

“Is that… a *gun?”*

“Sure is.” Luke said, twirling the pistol in one hand. “You know, a lot of people seem to think we have no use for guns, since we have magic and all. But when you think about it, you could say the exact same thing about martial arts, and it’d make about as much sense.”

Izuku wasn’t even listening. *“Why do you have a gun?”*

Luke smiled pleasantly. “Because I am going to shoot you.”

Izuku’s voice leaped an octave. “I… would prefer that you *didn’t?”*

Luke just laughed. “Last test, Midoriya. After this, you’re finished.” He told him. “The trouble is that I’ve been holding back, you see—a bit of damage to the training room was to be expected, but I wanted to avoid compromising the structure of the building. However, I wouldn’t feel right leaving today without some idea of the strength of your defense.”

“So you’re going to *shoot me?”*

“Yes.” He said. “Well—it’s either that, or I push you off the top of the complex off Saren street. But then, there might be pedestrians around, and really, who has the *time?”*

“You’re going to shoot me.” He repeated, more to himself than to Luke.

“Whenever you’re ready.”

“And what happens if I can’t block it?”

“I’ll try to aim for something non-vital, if that makes you feel better.”

Izuku just stared at him for a while, silence stretching between them.

“You’re really serious about this, aren’t you.” He muttered. It wasn’t really a question, just an observation, to which Luke only nodded in reply—that same pleasant, nonchalant look on his face. Izuku closed his eyes for a moment, taking a deep breath.

There were a number of things that stood out about Lucifer, in the time he’d spent training with him. Chief of which was that he was… well, a bit unhinged. He was insane, but at the same time, competent.

He wasn’t sure if he should feel relieved by that fact, or terrified. But there, in that moment, it was more of a relief. Because Izuku knew he wouldn’t have suggested this if he didn’t think he could pull it off.

…Or at least, if he didn’t think he could *survive* it.

Izuku took a deep breath, body shaking. It felt like an eternity had passed before he finally forced himself to respond.

“…Okay.”

With a kind smile, Luke cocked the gun and aimed. “Nod when you’re ready.”

Izuku swallowed, closing his eyes in hope that it would help him visualize things better. By that point, it was almost second nature. The idea of heat leaving his soul like steam was baked into his bones, the dispersal throughout his muscles like a breath of oxygen.

He took longer that time, wringing out as much heat as he could. And when finally felt as ready as he could reasonably be, given the situation, Izuku nodded.

He didn't open his eyes. He didn't want to.

Bang!

The gun went off. And strangely, all Izuku could really think in that moment was how much louder it was than what he'd expected. Nothing like what he'd seen in the movies.

It hit him in the shoulder, and Izuku staggered back, eyes flying open as he fell down. His heart was racing. Did it pierce him? He wasn't sure—maybe it had, and his brain had just blocked out the pain. Maybe this was shock.

But as Izuku looked ahead, he spotted something shiny on the ground, a few feet away, and he realized it was a bullet.

It didn't appear to be bloody.

It was only then that he garnered the courage to actually check his shoulder. There was a hole in his shirt where the bullet had hit him, but the actual skin seemed mostly unharmed—perhaps a bit red. Come morning, he was certain it'd have bloomed into a massive bruise. Still, Izuku was so relieved, he couldn't help but laugh.

"Congratulations, Midoriya." The sound of Luke's voice made him jump. He looked up, and found him standing there, the barrel of the gun pointed toward the ceiling. He smirked. "You're officially bulletproof."

"He fucking *what?"*

Izuku smiled awkwardly, avoiding eye contact. They were back at the apartment. Katsuki was reading when he walked in, but dropped his book upon seeing him.

"Yeah… It was, uhh… pretty intense, I guess."

Katsuki stood up. "I'm gonna kick his ass."

Izuku frowned. "Kacchan, he's *Lucifer."*

"He's a *bitch,* and I'm not fucking scared of him." He snorted. "Fancy magic ain't no match for an unexpected kick in the balls."

Izuku exhaled, shaking his head. "Just…" he said, leaning into Katsuki's chest, arms wrapping around his back.

"…Deku?"

"M'tired." He mumbled. "Can we just… talk about it later?"

Katsuki was silent for a second. Then, he sighed, wrapping his arms around him in turn.

“Fine.” He grumbled.

Izuku listened to the sound of the water running in the bathroom. He was lying on the couch, trying not to think about all the aches and pains he felt. Katsuki walked in a few minutes later.

“It’s ready.” He grunted, and extended a hand to him. After a moment, he accepted it, groaning as he was pulled upright. He shuffled along behind Katsuki until they reached the bathroom, where he stiffly got undressed, dropping his clothes on the floor by the bathtub before stepping in.

Izuku hissed, pulling his foot out. The water was hot.

“Not so fast. Ease into it.” Katsuki muttered.

Izuku sighed, and after a moment, he slowly sunk his foot under the water again, adjusting to the temperature. It took a minute, but once he managed to get in and sit down, he felt the tension slowly start to ease from his muscles. The water smelled nice, like roses.

Katsuki shut the door, and came to sit next to the bathtub. Izuku cracked an eye open when he heard the click of something opening.

“Dunk your hair under.” Katsuki said, pouring shampoo onto his palm.

“O-Oh, you don’t have to—“

Katsuki rolled his eyes. “Just do it.”

Izuku pursed his lips, but complied, awkwardly scooting down the length of the tub until he could comfortably get his head under. Once he came up, Katsuki moved closer. He felt his hands in his hair, just running through it at first, spreading the shampoo. Izuku sighed as he began working it into his scalp.

“That feels nice.”

“Mm.” Katsuki said. But as he continued to work, he frequently found points of resistance, and clicked his tongue. “Damn it, Deku. Do you just not brush your hair, or somethin’?”

“Oh, uh, sorry.” His shoulders drew upward.

“Fuckin’ bird’s nest.” He mumbled. Then, a bit more clearly, “S’fine. Just might take a bit longer is all.”

“Right.” Izuku swallowed. “Um, thank you.”

Katsuki just grunted. After a moment of silence, he spoke again. “If he tries to pull somethin’ like that again tomorrow, tell him to go fuck himself.” He said. Then, a bit quieter, “The only

person who should be givin' you this many bruises is *me."*

Izuku blushed, though not quite as much as he thought he would. Maybe it was because he was getting used to it, the rhythm of Katsuki's vulgarity. Things like that weren't as embarrassing as they used to be.

"…Possessive."

"Yep." Katsuki said, popping the 'p' sound. "Only reason I ain't actin' out over it is 'cuz I know he's not an actual threat. Bastard's too fuckin' obsessed with Levi to try anything."

"Wait, they're *together?"*

He scoffed. "No. But they've been dancin' around each other for as long as I've known 'em. Fuckin' losers." He muttered. "You'd think bein' alive for thousands of years would make 'em less prone to pussyfooting around that shit, but I guess not."

"Huh…" Izuku murmured. "It's… kinda hard to imagine Luke in any kind of relationship."

"What d'you mean?"

"I dunno. He's just… weird. It's like I can't tell when he's being genuine or not."

"Oh, that." Katsuki said. "Yeah, he's kinda fake. S'not like, *malicious,* though… more like overcompensation. Empathy doesn't come natural to him, I guess." He shrugged. "Apparently, he used to be a real asshole."

"Oh, wow." Izuku blinked.

"Yep," Katsuki yawned. "Probably why he latched onto Levi so hard. Fucker knows what you're feeling before even you do." He scoffed. "Scoot forward. Tilt your head back."

"Ah." Izuku obeyed, and allowed Katsuki to gently pull him back, until his hair was just underwater, careful not to get anything in his eyes as he massaged the suds away.

As Izuku sat up, Katsuki reached for a bottle of conditioner, popping it open.

"What about Bee?"

Katsuki squeezed some conditioner out onto his palm. "Him?" He gestured for Izuku to scoot toward him, and started working it into the ends of his hair. "Far as I know, he hasn't shown interest in anyone in over a century. Not since Mammon died." He said. "He's always been a bit of a shut-in, but it got a lot worse after that. He says he's fine, but…" He trailed off, sighing. "Well, you know."

"Right…"

For a while, it was quiet, apart from the sound of water shifting, and Katsuki's hands working on his hair. The next time he spoke, it was to tell Izuku to tilt his head back against, so he could rinse his hair. Izuku came up after a moment, brushing his wet hair back.

Katsuki stood up, stretching his arms over his head before exhaling. “C’mon. You should get out before it gets cold.”

Izuku was leaning over the railing of a balcony, staring down at the courtyard below. The door slid open behind him.

“There you are.”

Izuku looked up and found an Acolyte standing in the doorway, with a small box in his hands and a nervous look on his face.

“Uhh, the Healer wanted me to give this to you.” He said, offering the box to him. Izuku tentatively accepted it. The Acolyte excused himself immediately after.

Taped to the top of the box was a small note. He unfolded it and read it out.

The quest continues!

This one’s a mixture of amethyst and bone. See if you can get a read on it.

Izuku had no idea what to make of that. He stared at the box for a moment, and then shrugged, flicking the small latch up and opening it.

And the moment he did so, the box immediately erupted with the loudest, most grating siren’s screech he’d ever heard. He reflexively dropped the box, and just as it was about to hit the ground, Izuku opened his eyes.

It was around eight in the morning. He could hear Katsuki in the kitchen, making breakfast.

For a minute, he just lay there wondering what the hell just happened. But the more he thought about it, the weirder it became. With a sigh, Izuku sat up, grabbing his journal and opening to the first page. There were a lot of things about the dream that didn’t make sense, but one thing, at least, was certain.

Izuku’s eyes settled upon the short list on the first page.

The Healer

The Rejector

The Violator

Izuku crossed off *The Healer,* and then turned to a fresh page.

“You *told* him?”

“Umm… yeah?” Izuku said, eyes darting around nervously.

Luke released a long groan. *"Midoriya*... You're trying to beat Bakugou in a fight. How are you supposed to do that if he already knows all the tricks you have up your sleeve?"

He frowned. "I mean… I don't really want to rely on *tricks*... I want to beat him fair and square."

At this, Luke actually laughed. "Yeah, I'm afraid that's not happening."

"Sorry?"

"Oh, come now. You didn't really believe you could reach Bakugou's skill level in a measly four days, did you?"

He flushed. "W-Well, *no*, of course not, but…"

"Bakugou's a master of Wrath. Like it or not, you *will* need tricks to defeat him." He paused, smiling. "Lucky for you, we have the master of tricks right here."

Suddenly, Levi materialized beside him. Izuku jumped back with a yelp.

"Sorry. Didn't mean to scare you."

"N-No, it's okay." Izuku waved his hands. "I'm just… surprised? I, ah, thought it was going to be just Luke."

"Ah." Luke nodded. "Yes, the thing about that is… while I, myself, have taught *every* style, Levi and Bee have only ever taught Envy and Gluttony, respectively." He explained. "I opted to omit their involvement during the meeting, just to avoid revealing which styles you'd be learning."

Izuku blinked. "So you mean…?"

"Yep." Levi said, smiling. "Today you'll be studying Envy."

"Wow, cool!" Izuku grinned. "So Envy's effective against Wrath, then?"

"Well, not specifically." Levi shrugged. "But Envy techniques are widely applicable against a variety of opponents—at least the ones that rely on sound or sight. They enable you to obscure your movements, making you unpredictable."

Izuku cocked his head. "Obscure your movements?"

"How about we give him a demonstration?" Luke offered.

Levi hummed. "Sure."

With that, they moved toward the center of the room, leaving a wide breadth of space between the two of them. "Ready?" Levi asked.

Luke nodded.

And with that, Levi ran at him.

But there was something off about it—namely, he didn't appear to be preparing an attack.

As he drew close, however, Izuku heard the sound of a fist hitting flesh, and Luke slid back with the force, head turning as though he'd been punched in the jaw. When Izuku looked back at Levi, he noted that his right arm was extended outward, implying he'd done just that.

"…H-How did you do that?"

"It's called light-bending." Levi replied, turning toward him again. "It's one of Envy's major success milestones. Every style has at least one."

"Yep." Luke cracked his neck. "In fact, if you manage to master it, you are legally allowed to be insufferably arrogant about it for up to one week afterward."

"It's true," Levi said, his expression nonchalant. "It's not very strict, though. See, we're still waiting for Luke's week to end, despite him having figured it out well over two thousand years ago."

Luke snorted, showing him his middle finger.

Levi grinned. "Anyway, ready to get started?"

Izuku eagerly nodded.

"Great—oh, one last thing." He said, pointing at something in the corner closest to Luke.

"Ah, right." Luke went and grabbed it. "Here!" He said, just before throwing it at Izuku. *Hard.* His heart lurched as it flew toward him. He only barely managed to catch it before it hit his head.

"Luke." Levi said, with clear disapproval.

"What?"

The two started bickering, but Izuku wasn't really listening. He was too busy being bewildered by the object he had in his hands.

It was a respirator.

"Um… What is this for?"

"It's for you to wear." Luke said.

He blinked. "Well, of course, but—"

"—It's just a safety measure everyone uses when they first learn Envy." Levi explained. "It's so you won't accidentally inhale your own soul's vapor."

"Oh." Izuku frowned. "What happens if I do?"

“Well, you won’t *die.”* He said. “But it’ll irritate your lungs and make you cough like crazy.” He paused, then smiled softly. “That’s actually one of the first really useful attacks you can learn early on—essentially just blowing it into someone’s lungs. It won’t hurt them much, but it’ll give you a great opening to do some real damage. But,” He clapped his hands. “That’s enough talk. Let’s do some actual magic, shall we?”

Despite having originally being one of the more challenging styles for Izuku to grasp, by around an hour into their lesson, Izuku felt he could comfortably say he had a good handle on the basics of Envy.

Under Levi’s control, he was made to visualize his soul as a cloud that he was flying through. Though it was far from what he’d intuitively imagine, the fact that he was familiar with the experience made it relatively easy for him to grasp. And just like that, all the balance issues he’d been having before ceased to exist.

Over the course of the day, they covered three main things.

First was basic stealth techniques—in particular, moving around in total silence. Izuku learned to use the vapor of his soul as a buffer between his feet and the ground, enabling him to walk and run around without his feet ever actually touching the floor.

The first time he managed the pull it off without being controlled, Izuku felt downright giddy. He thought back to all those times when Katsuki had snuck up on him back when he was still an Angel, and it was like pulling back the curtain, discovering all the magician’s secrets. He delighted at the idea of getting Katsuki back for all the times he’d scared him, though he was sure it wouldn’t have quite the same impact.

Next was the Breath Attack, as Levi called it. It was relatively straightforward, and impeded only by the fact that in order to practice it, he had to actually have someone who would allow him to redirect his soul’s vapor into their lungs. That ended up being Luke most of the time. Thankfully, the technique was simple enough that few repetitions were required, but Luke’s voice was still quite hoarse by the time they were done.

Finally, there came the last move of the day, which was by far the most difficult—a little trick Levi referred to as *Light Scrambling.* It didn’t give the illusion of Izuku having his arms at his sides during an attack, but it did obscure his movements just enough to create ambiguity in the crucial moments leading up to the attack.

When the session came to an end, Izuku was tired, though unlike the previous day, the bulk of his exhaustion was mental rather than physical. Katsuki wasn’t kidding when he said Envy was highly technical; never before had Izuku expended so much brainpower on the whereabouts of photons as he had during those eight hours.

As he left, Luke reiterated once more what he’d been repeating more or less all day.

“Don’t tell him what we worked on.” He told him. “And if he asks, I want you to give him something. You can tell him it’s from me.”

That last part was new. Izuku furrowed his brow. “Uhh, what’s that?”

Luke showed him his middle finger.

Despite himself, Izuku laughed.

Sure enough, when Izuku returned that evening, one of the very first things Katsuki did was ask him what he’d learned that day.

“Uhh, yeah. Um, the thing about that is… Luke told me not to tell you.”

Katsuki raised an eyebrow. “Oh yeah?” He snorted. “Guess I’ll just have to try and guess, then.” He leaned forward, looking Izuku up and down carefully. “Hmm.” Slowly, a smirk spread across his face. “You’ve got red marks on your face, nerd.”

“I-I what?”

“Red marks, like impressions on your skin.” He said, grin growing as he cocked his head. “Y’know, the kind you’d have if you were wearin’ a mask for an extended period of time… or a respirator.”

Izuku choked on his own spit, power walking away from him. Katsuki simply followed him as Izuku covered his face with his arms, trying to hide.

“The hell are you doin’ that for? I’ve already seen ‘em, nerd!”

“I-I don’t know what you’re talking about?”

“Then what are you tryna cover up, *huh?”*

Izuku made a shrill sound, stopping in his tracks. He wasn’t planning on relaying Luke’s ‘message,’ but…

“Luke also said… that if you asked, I should give you this, and say it’s from him.”

“Hmm?”

Izuku slowly raised his middle finger, the gesture unfamiliar to him.

And Katsuki, for his part, proceeded to burst out laughing.

Izuku entered the training room the next morning to find that Luke was nowhere to be found. Instead, Bee sat in the corner by himself, with a bag of candy to his left, a pencil in hand and some sort of book in front of him.

“Oh!” Bee jolted, looking up at him sharply. “Hello!”

“H-Hi,” Izuku said. “Ahh, nice to see you again.”

“You too.” He smiled, patting the spot in front of him. “Here, come sit.”

Izuku shut the door and toed off his shoes before going to sit down, crossing his legs. It was only then that he realized what the book was; apparently, Bee was playing sudoku.

“Luke’s not coming today?”

“Mm, nah.” Bee shook his head. “He and Levi both went together yesterday ‘cuz he was half-expecting Bakugou to show up and try to start a fight. He said if the first day didn’t make him freak out, we’d be in the clear.”

“Ahh, gotcha.” He cleared his throat. “So, uhh… you’re teaching me Gluttony, I’m guessing?”

“That’s the plan.” He said. “Uhh, I mean, unless there’s something else you’d rather I try to teach you instead…?”

“No, no!” Izuku waved his hands around. “Gluttony is… w-well, you developed it, right? It seems like that’d probably be the best one to learn from you.” Izuku stammered. “Um, n-not that the others wouldn’t also be good. I know you’re an expert on them all! So really, it’s whatever you—“

Bee reached out and tugged on Izuku’s sleeve, pulling him out of his rambling spiral with a warm smile. “Midoriya… it’s okay.”

He blinked. “Sorry?”

Bee popped a gummy candy into his mouth and chewed. “You’re nervous because of who I am, right?” Izuku neither confirmed nor denied it—which was functionally the same as confirming it. “Don’t worry, I get it. I know what it’s like.”

“What do you mean?”

“I’ve been around a while. I’ve met a lot of famous people. It’s intimidating. I used to avoid it, ‘cuz… well, y’know.” He shrugged. “I don’t really fit the idea of what an Original is supposed to be like. I’m not charming like Luke, or smart like Levi. I’m just kinda… me.” He sighed. “But y’know, eventually you realize that deep down, everyone’s worried about the same stuff. Rejection. Being judged…” he smiled. “And most people are too busy worrying what *you* think of *them* to even *notice* half the things you’re insecure about, y’know?”

For a minute, Izuku was so stunned by the heartfelt words, he couldn’t even respond. He just kind of sat there, gaping at Bee, until the Demon grew red in the face and started to fidget.

“Uh, s-sorry, that was a bit much, wasn’t it?” He said, his voice jumping an octave. “I shouldn’t presume to know what’s going on in your head, I just… well, you know, you kind of remind me of me when I was younger, so I was…” His face became even redder. “Oh god, does that make it worse? It *does,* doesn’t it?”

“N-No, please, don’t worry!” Izuku said, waving his hands around. “I appreciate what you said, you just… caught me off guard is all.” He laughed nervously. “I mean, you’re right, in a

way. I-I mean, because, uhh, well. I guess ever since you and the others agreed to train me—and I know you don't really do that normally—I guess I've just… been waiting for the other shoe to drop. Or something? I don't know."

He visibly relaxed. "Ohh, okay." He said, then smiled. "See what I mean? Everyone's a mess. Some people are just really good at hiding it." He looked away. "I am… *not* one of those people."

Izuku giggled.

Bee got up then, and offered a hand to Izuku. He accepted it, and as he stood, he noted that Bee was only a few inches taller than him—perhaps around five-foot-eight or so. When he smiled, the bags beneath his green eyes weren't quite as noticeable. "Ready?"

Izuku grinned, rolling his shoulders back.

"Ready!"

The visual aid Bee provided for Gluttony was so obvious, Izuku felt dumb for having not thought of it before.

Bubble gum.

Of course.

Izuku looked into his bright green eyes and felt the weight of his control overtake him, his hands pressed into the impressions of the touch stone. He sucked the insides of his cheeks beneath his molars, and began to chew lightly. Just like that, the stone started to move, as though he were chewing it instead. It rotated and compressed itself, and when he reached out and touched it, he could feel how sticky it had become.

"…Is that why you're always eating gummy candies?" Izuku asked, once Bee had relinquished his control.

Bee looked away, mouth opening and closing a few times before he said, "Well, no… it's just… my excuse…" he muttered. "I mean, if you knew how many times I'd bitten the insides of my cheeks too hard, I'm sure you'd agree it's for the best." He laughed awkwardly, and then winced. "My dentist, on the other hand…" he trailed off. "Uhh, never mind. Let's just… keep going."

And so they did.

In contrast with something like Envy or Lust, Gluttony wasn't so much an amalgamation of many *different* techniques as was just one or two moves that were highly versatile. Izuku learned to stretch and shoot sticky tendrils of his soul, latching onto objects and surfaces to either pull them toward him, or fling *himself* toward *them.*

Once he'd gotten that down, they began working on firing two tendrils at once in different directions, such as at two opposite walls, to keep him suspended in the air.

Things only got really difficult when he wanted to throw objects heavier than he was.

Around four hours into their session, Bee had opened up the closet and proceeded to haul out what appeared to be an anvil, which he then placed at the center of the room.

“We’re gonna try something called Root Anchoring.” Bee said. “The basic idea is that you can throw things that weigh more than you do as long as you’re anchored by something that weighs more than what you’re throwing.”

Izuku was made to imagine several strands of gum shooting down around him, locking him against the floor while a larger tendril shot out toward the anvil. He felt the strain in his core somewhat, but the anchors managed to hold as he flung the anvil across the room. Thankfully, Bee caught it before it could hit the wall.

All in all, of the styles he’d studied so far, Gluttony was definitely the one he had the most fun with, though part of that might have been thanks to Bee himself. There was something oddly comforting about having an instructor like him; it reminded Izuku that even the strongest among them were still flawed in their own ways.

Izuku left that day with a smile on his face and a spring in his step, both figuratively and literally.

“So…?” Katsuki said, moving up behind him. They were in the kitchen, in front of the sink. The dishwasher was open, and they were in the process of loading it.

Izuku went still. “Kacchan, you know I can’t tell you what I learned.”

“Aww, c’mon.” Katsuki said, smirk visible from the corner of Izuku’s eye. He leaned in, planting a kiss on Izuku’s neck, then speaking against it so that his lips tickled his skin. “Just tell me.”

Izuku squirmed, blushing under his attention. “Y-You’ll find out Sunday.”

“That’s too long.”

“It’s only two days. Less, even…”

“Yeah, but I’m impatient… C’mon, baby. Just tell me.” He purred, planting his hands on Izuku’s hips. He gasped as Katsuki pulled him back, so that Izuku’s ass was pressed against him.“I’ll give ya somethin’ *real special* if you do.”

Izuku whimpered, eyes fluttering as Katsuki sucked at the nape of his neck, undoubtedly leaving a mark. “But… you’ve already given me something special.”

“Huh?”

“Your heart.”

Katsuki froze behind him, and for a few seconds, he was totally silent. Four, to be exact.

Four. Three. Two. One.

Katsuki released a groan Izuku could only describe as *anguished.* “Why’d ya gotta go and do that?!”

“What?!”

“Be so—“ he squeezed his hips tighter, forehead dropping down to rest on Izuku’s shoulder. “So… fucking *cute* and shit.”

Izuku frowned. “I-I don’t know, I thought it was a nice thing to say! I thought you’d like it…”

“I *do.”* Katsuki muttered, lifting his head. “But see, I was *plannin’* on fucking you here, right in front of this sink full of dirty dishes.” He scoffed. “Now I feel like I gotta get you roses, or like, put on a fucking tie or some shit just to *kiss* you. Fuckin’ asshole. *Goddamnit.”*

Izuku giggled, turning around and wrapping his arms around his neck. “Sorry, Kacchan.” He said.

“You don’t *look* sorry.” Katsuki pouted.

Izuku hummed, and then without warning, proceeded to hop up and wrap his legs around his hips. Katsuki instinctively reached down, holding him up by his thighs. “How about now?”

“Hmm.” Katsuki narrowed his eyes. “Still don’t look too sorry, but… I’ll allow it.”

Izuku grinned as Katsuki leaned down to kiss him.

Izuku was standing in the bedroom again, his bare feet pressing against the cold, marble floor.

He could hear voices outside, one unfamiliar, the other less so.

“I understand where you’re coming from, but now isn’t the time.” A man said.

“It’s *never* the time.” Said another man, who he recognized as Councilman Five—the Martyr. “I’m sick and tired of it. Have you *seen* his condition?”

“I know.” He replied, tone placating. “But in light of the recent incident…”

“Oh, come on.” The Martyr scoffed. “What are we supposed to do? Launch an invasion over some first sphere *nobody?”*

“…I don’t think you’re taking this matter seriously enough, Martyr.”

“Why should I?” He shot back. “So some random fucking first-sphere got lucky. Who gives a shit? He’s just another braindead bastard drooling over Demon cock. I’d say I hope he chokes

on it, but frankly, I don't even care enough to have an opinion on whether or not his existence should continue."

"This is a massive security risk, whether you want to acknowledge it or not." The other told him. "I shouldn't need to tell you this. Aren't you supposed to be the *reasonable* one?"

"Look, *whatever.* Can you just fucking do what I asked? *Please?"*

A pause.

"…You've been quite agitated lately." The other man said, his volume dropping. Izuku had to press his ear hard against the door just to hear him. "Are you low?"

"…So what if I am?"

"Martyr." He sighed. "Please. I'd hate to see you taking your title so literally."

"I'm *fine!"* He snapped.

For a moment, neither of them spoke.

"Look." Martyr said. "Please. You're the only one who will listen. The Commander won't act unless I threaten him, the Cleanser is apathetic *at best,* and the Healer's barely able to hold a conversation. He just… forces me to give up before anything can be done." He took a deep, audible breath. "I just… I don't know what to do anymore."

"…Why is this so important to you?"

The Martyr didn't respond. After a minute, the other man continued.

"You're afraid, aren't you?" He said. "You're worried that if you allow yourself to give up on him, you'll forget how to care about anything else… He's your anchor." He paused. "I used to have an anchor. All of us did, save for the Commander. It'll slip… eventually."

"I know." Martyr said, voice strained. "I don't need you to remind me."

For a long while, it was quiet. Izuku was beginning to suspect they'd walked away. But eventually, the other man spoke.

"Okay, how about this: I'll tend to his needs. I know it's not a substitute for real care, but… unfortunately, without the Commander's cooperation, that's all I can really offer." He told him. "In the meantime, I want you to take care of yourself, alright?"

"I *am* taking care of myself."

"Arc." The man said, his tone stern. "You know that's not what I mean."

There was another long pause.

"…Fine." The Martyr said.

And then it was silent.

Izuku strained his ears, listening for anything he might've otherwise missed.

Then, there was a sharp knock on his door, and he stumbled back with a yelp.

Next thing he knew, he was in bed with Katsuki again. He reflexively grabbed his notebook, hastily opening to the list first page.

And after he crossed off *The Rejector,* he circled *The Violator.*

When Izuku arrived the following morning, Luke was there alone.

"Ah, Midoriya. Good morning." He said. "Bee tells me you took quite well to Gluttony?"

"I think so," Izuku nodded, smiling as he toed off his shoes. "It was a lot of fun, honestly."

"Well, that's great to hear." He said, closing his book and standing up, stretching his arms above his head.

Though Luke was still an intimidating person to work with in some respects, Izuku had grown a lot more comfortable around him these past few days.

"So, ahhh, what's the plan today?"

"Pride."

"Oh?" Izuku perked up. "That's the one you developed, right?"

He nodded. "I actually went back and forth quite a bit on whether I should cover it, just because I know Bakugou will probably expect it more than anything else. But after some consideration, I've concluded the advantages outweigh the potential disadvantages."

"Huh. So, what can Pride do that others can't?"

"A better question would be what others can do that Pride can't." He replied. "See, the nice about Pride is the degree of versatility it affords. There's a lot more to it than simply expanding your soul. In fact, I'd go so far as to say that framing it as being chiefly about expansion, as most do, misses the point." He paused, sliding his hands into his pockets. "The true power of Pride is in its versatility and multitasking ability."

"…Multitasking?"

He gestured toward the touch stone, planting his hands in the impressions. Suddenly, the stone blew up in size. Izuku jumped back as it expanded toward him, but as the boundary touched him, it seemed to phase right through him, becoming translucent as it grew larger, until it filled the whole room.

“Have you ever wondered if it was possible to, say… liquify one part of your soul.” Suddenly, a portion about Izuku’s head shrunk down, turning into a free-flowing liquid. “While freezing another?”

Izuku felt the temperature drop as the outer shell of Luke’s soul froze over, the liquid still floating freely up above.

“…Or perhaps condense one piece,” A portion on Izuku’s right suddenly shrunk down, becoming opaque. “And simultaneously sublimate another?” To his left, he watched as a pocket formed, mist swirling around inside of it.

The stone shrunk down again as Luke removed his hands. “With Pride, you can do all of that and more.”

For a moment, Izuku was silent, stunned by the display. “I… wow.” He muttered. “That seems… *really* powerful. Um… what’s the catch?”

“Well, the cost of being good at everything is that you’re great at nothing, as they say.” Luke smiled. “Part of that is simply due to the fact that when you divide your soul to do different things, there’s less available for each part. Sometimes that’s not a big deal, but for something like, say, Wrath, for instance, it makes a big difference in terms of strength.” He explained. “The other part is that learning the basics of each style is quite time-consuming, and meaning that many Pride Demons don’t gain access to advanced techniques for a while, if ever.” He paused, and then smirked. “Of course, I don’t have that problem.”

“R-Right,” Izuku cleared his throat. “So, is that what we’ll be learning? Multitasking?”

“Oh, no.” He shook his head. “I should’ve been more clear. Multitasking’s really more of an advanced move—not *incredibly* so, but it’s certainly beyond the purview of this lesson.”

“I see.” Izuku tried not to look too disappointed. “So, what will we doing, then?”

Luke hummed. “There are actually only two things I want to teach you today.” He replied. “You wanted to know what Pride could do that others couldn’t, and though the sort of chameleon-like nature of it is a big part of it’s appeal, there are a number of things Pride Demons can do which *are* fully unique. The one I’m going to teach you today is what’s known as a *Simple Ejection.”* He approached the touch stone again. “It works like this…”

Luke placed his hands back in the impressions, and Izuku watched his soul expand again, though this time, it only encompassed around half the room’s total volume. And then suddenly, Izuku was being pushed out—quite literally *ejected* from the mass of his soul, leaving him sitting on his butt outside the boundary.

Luke took his hands off the table. “Worth noting is that this move is far from foolproof. In fact, Bakugou will be able to resist it quite easily.”

Izuku frowned. “I mean, with all due respect… if that’s the case, why bother teaching me it?”

“Because it’s extremely easy, and just like every other move you’ve learned these past few days, it will probably work on him the first time, just not the second.” He shrugged. “For the record, there are, of course, far more advanced ejections that Bakugou would not be able to resist, but again, that’s beyond the scope of this session.”

Izuku nodded. “What’s the second one?”

“The second one is more advanced, but it’s invaluable in a sparring match.” He said. “It’s a little move known as the Spiderweb. To demonstrate…”

Suddenly, Izuku could feel something surrounding his body, moist and sticky. He attempted to struggle out of it on reflex, but the harder he tried the tighter it seemed to encase him. After a moment, Luke released his hold, and he found himself trying to wipe off his arms, despite knowing there would be nothing there.

“I recommend using it only when you have him on the ground already.” He told him. “It’s harder to escape, but not so difficult that it couldn’t be thwarted by someone who knew what they were doing, as Bakugou certainly does. But anyway,” he clapped his hands together. “That’s enough explanation. Shall we?”

Izuku took a deep breath, exhaled, and then nodded.

Instantly, he felt the overwhelming yet familiar weight of Luke’s presence in his mind, and then his soul exploded.

Izuku returned home that evening feeling like he’d stretched his body to its limits—and in a sense, he had.

He’d sort of hoped that the fact Luke was only teaching him two moves would mean he’d get out earlier, but in the end, he actually stayed later than usual.

The Simple Ejection was fairly straightforward, enough that he was able to conquer it in under three hours.

The Spiderweb was a different beast. Izuku struggled with it for nearly six hours before he was able to do it on his own. He didn’t expect it to be so challenging; it was a technique rooted in Gluttony magic, after all. But as it turned out, maintaining an expanded soul while simultaneously manipulating only a specific region of it required quite an intense level of focus. Past a certain point, Izuku began to feel like he was only getting worse with each repetition.

Tired as he was, Izuku fell asleep early that night. And he supposed it was good thing, too.

After all, come morning, he’d need all the rest he could get.

The following morning, for the first time in four days, Izuku took the train with Katsuki, though for an expressly different purpose.

He felt as though his heart had been racing since the moment he'd woken up, and as they sat side by side in the train car, he found himself needing to wipe the sweat off his palms more and more as time went by. When they reached their station, he stood up stiffly and followed Katsuki outside, staring at the ground as he walked. When Katsuki took his uninjured hand and laced his fingers through Izuku's own, he almost yanked his hand away out of surprise. Katsuki gripped it harder, and frowned.

"You fuckin' good, nerd?"

Izuku flushed, looking down again. "Y-Yeah, sorry. Just…" He trailed off, swallowing his nerves. His throat suddenly felt dry.

Katsuki hummed, giving his hand a squeeze. "Let's grab lunch after this, okay?"

Izuku's breath caught, and then he nodded, some of the tension easing from his frame. It was a small thing, but it comforted him. It reminded Izuku that, no matter what happened, they'd be okay. He sighed, leaning into Katsuki's side as they approached the front steps of the Academy.

Katsuki let go of his hand to open the door, holding it for him. "Which one did he say? Two-Seventeen?"

"Um, I think so."

He nodded, gesturing for Izuku to follow him down the hall.

The room they wound up in was a fair bit larger than the one Izuku had been training in, and when they entered, Luke, Levi and Bee were all already there.

After a brief greeting, Izuku and Katsuki went off to opposite corners of the room to get warmed up. Izuku found himself looking over his shoulder often as he ran through his exercises, always half-expecting to find Katsuki staring back. He never was. Izuku took a deep breath and stood up, rolling his shoulders back.

"How are you feeling?"

Izuku yelped, jumping nearly a full foot in the air. Levi was standing on his left, his eyes slightly wider. "Well, I suppose that answers my question, but I'd still like to hear it from you."

Izuku rubbed the back of his neck sheepishly. "I'm… okay, I think. Just, you know. Nervous."

"Well, I won't tell you not to be *nervous,* because it's normal to be nervous before something like this. But I think now's probably a good time to remind you that this is really only a formality. Even if you don't win any of the matches, there's really nothing stopping us from just bringing you along anyway." He smiled.

Izuku laughed softly. "I appreciate that, but… I mean, I wouldn't want Luke to have to break his promise."

Levi hummed. “Well, in that case…” he patted him on the shoulder. “Take some deep breaths, drink some water, and try to clear your head. You’ll be fine.”

Izuku nodded, offering a small smile. As Levi walked away, he closed his eyes and did just that—breathing in, counting to ten, breathing out. Slowly opening his eyes, he grabbed his water bottle and took a good, long sip, and then shook out his limbs, trying to ease the tension. Taking one last deep breath, Izuku turned around, and found Katsuki already standing at the ready.

With a shaky sigh, he came to stand across from him, leaving a wide breadth of distance in between.

“Let me know when you’re both ready.” Bee called out, from across the room. He had a whistle in his hand, and was turning it idly between his fingers.

“Ready.” Katsuki immediately grunted.

Izuku gulped, getting into position. He closed his eyes and counted to three. “Ready.”

But nothing could’ve prepared him for what would come next.

Because almost as soon as Bee blew the whistle, Izuku was face down. It happened so quickly, he barely had a chance to realize what was going on before he was pinned, Katsuki’s hands locking his wrists together, his knee pressing into the small of his back.

As Levi began counting down from five, Izuku struggled, but Katsuki tightened his grip, and before he knew it, it was already over. Katsuki stood up, turning and returning to his starting place. Izuku got up as well, brushing himself off and trying his best not to dwell on it. But it’d be a lie to say that it didn’t shake his confidence.

Izuku got back in position, and Bee blew the whistle again.

Katsuki launched at him, and this time, Izuku managed to dodge, leaping to the side. Katsuki skidded to a stop, using the remaining momentum to propel himself into a roundhouse kick. Izuku just barely had time to freeze his soul before his foot connected with his ribcage and sent him flying back.

When he hit the wall, it hurt a little bit, but it should’ve hurt a hell of a lot more.

Izuku tried to stand up, but Katsuki got to him faster, straddling his chest and pinning his arms over his head. Izuku’s heart sunk at the realization that he’d lost once again, but as he looked up at Katsuki’s face, he saw something in his expression that he hadn’t expected.

He almost looked… *impressed.*

Katsuki’s free hand ghosted over the right side of his ribcage, right where the kick had landed. “Pretty quick reaction.” He murmured, and then stood up again.

It took a moment for Izuku to will himself to sit up, mostly due to his surprise. But soon enough, he was back on his feet, assuming the position again.

At the sound of the whistle, Izuku managed to dodge Katsuki's initial attack again, and for the first time, he launched one of his own. Visualizing clouds, he let his soul sublimate and directed the vapor toward Katsuki. He was lucky to catch him while he was inhaling, as Katsuki's eyes went wide in surprise, and he began to cough.

Heart in his throat, Izuku lunged toward him, scrambling light as he came in with a punch. But Katsuki was already hunched over, and despite still coughing, he managed to grab Izuku around the midsection and toss him over his shoulder. Izuku landed on his back with a gasp. In his shock, Katsuki was able to throw himself on top of him again, pinning his shoulders with his knees, even as he continued to cough.

"Fuckin' knew it," He muttered, wheezing slightly.

Izuku just released a frustrated groan.

"Didn't expect the Light Scramble though." He smirked. "Not bad, nerd."

He got up and walked away. Izuku propped himself up on his elbows and watched him down a bottle of water, exhaling in relief as the irritated feeling eased away.

With a sigh, he stood up, and got ready again.

This time, when Katsuki launched himself at him, Izuku launched, too—upward, that is. Chewing the insides of his cheeks, he visualized bubble gum as he flung his arm up, latching a sticky tendril of his soul onto the ceiling and pulling himself toward it. The ceiling wasn't quite high enough, though; Katsuki was able to grab his ankle as he ascended, pulling down. As a last resort, Izuku snaked his legs around his neck, clamping down and attempting to throw him off balance. But he knew he stood no chance in a battle of strength. Katsuki pried his legs off with little effort and sent him flying.

He managed to freeze his soul before he hit the wall, so it didn't hurt.

Physically, at least.

Seconds later, Katsuki had him pinned yet again. His smile cut through the bitterness in Izuku's mind.

"Gluttony, too?" He whistled. "Nice." He said, before standing up and moving back into position.

Izuku returned to his starting spot, and took a deep breath. Maybe he ought to be more aggressive, quit letting Katsuki make the first move. Resolving to act faster, he gave Bee a nod, and he blew the whistle.

This time, when Katsuki came running at him, he quickly anchored himself, and then hit him with a sticky tendril before he could close the distance. His idea was to fling him into the opposite wall, but in his singular focus, he failed to account for one vital thing.

As Izuku stared into Katsuki's eyes, they flashed bright, and he felt a click in his head that made his heart sink.

“Stop.” Katsuki commanded. “Get on the ground.”

Without protest, Izuku obeyed, lying down. Katsuki didn’t even have to pin him that time. He had no choice but to stay down.

Once he’d held him long enough, Katsuki released the hypnosis, and Izuku blinked a few times before sitting up.

That marked his fifth loss.

Only five chances left. The prospect of winning felt more and more distant every second.

“Time out.” Bee called, jogging over. Luke and Levi followed shortly behind. “Hey, are you alright?”

“Yeah, just… a bit discouraged, I guess.” He laughed awkwardly.

“Oh?” Luke said “Why is that?”

Izuku frowned. “Because I just lost five times in a row?”

Luke gave him an odd look. “Well, sure. That’s why the deal was one out of ten, not one out of five.”

“C’mon.” Katsuki groaned. “No one said anything about time outs. Let’s *go.”*

With a sigh, Izuku got up, dusting himself off and assuming the position again.

As he passed, Luke patted him on the shoulder. “Don’t worry too much about the individual techniques. Think about the flow of things—the overall synthesis.”

Izuku had no idea what that was supposed to mean, but there wasn’t time to ask for clarification. He took a deep breath and resumed his fighting stance.

Bee blew the whistle.

For the sixth fight, he tried the same thing he did for the fifth, though this time he was careful not to make eye contact. Unfortunately, Katsuki was anticipating it, and managed to dodge the sticky tendril before it could make contact.

Izuku tried again, and this time it stuck, but rather than try to get away, Katsuki seemed to embrace it. As Izuku threw him, Katsuki used the momentum to make a full circle, winding the tendril around his body, ensnaring him in his own soul.

Izuku released the attack, letting his soul return to its normal form in order to free himself, but by then Katsuki was already upon him. He tackled him, pinning his arms over his head and holding tight until the count ran down.

Izuku groaned, standing up again. He grabbed his own water bottle and downed a good half of it.

He hadn't utilized any Pride abilities yet. Perhaps now would be a good time to try.

At the start of the seventh match, Izuku shot a sticky tendril at the wall to his left, using it to dodge Katsuki's initial attack. He shot another at Katsuki's ankle and managed to knock him down, yanking him toward him. Katsuki's foot hit the wall, and he used the leverage to knock Izuku on his back, clamoring atop him.

As Levi began to count down, Izuku planted his feet against the floor and expanded his soul outward, promptly ejecting Katsuki from his space.

He flung himself upright as Katsuki was stumbling back, eyes widened in surprise. Izuku lunged, managing to catch him while he was still on the ground, pinning his neck with a sticky tendril of his soul. Katsuki reflexively reached for it, his hands getting stuck to it as well.

This is it, he thought. *I might actually win this time.*

But just when he thought he had him, there was a sudden spark of light, and that was the only warning he had before Katsuki's palms lit up, bursting with hellfire that melted the sticky trap right off of him. Izuku was a bit too close when it happened, and as he reflexively shielded his face and jumped back, he wound up tripping over his own feet and falling onto his butt.

A second later, Katsuki was there, one hand wrapped around his throat, the other one trapping his wrists.

His hands were still warm.

"Pride, too?" Katsuki grinned. "So that makes it… Sloth, Envy, Gluttony and Pride? Impressive."

Izuku didn't *feel* very impressive.

The eighth match ended with Katsuki's shin locked over his neck.

The ninth with his shoe on the back of his head.

And for a while after that one, Izuku just stayed there, lying face down on the floor, not moving.

"Midoriya?"

It was Bee's voice. Izuku glanced up and found him squatting beside him, looking concerned. Izuku met his eyes, and then looked away.

"Um… maybe we can convince him to make it one out of fifteen…?" He offered. But Izuku didn't respond. He knew it was no use. He was already starting to get tired, and it was only going to get worse. His odds of winning could only decrease from here.

He didn't want to accept it, but things just weren't looking good.

“Hey.” Levi said, extending a hand to him. “Come on. It’s not over yet.” Swallowing roughly, he took his hand and stood up. Luke was standing there too, but to his shock, he still didn’t look worried.

“Luke?”

“Hmm?”

“Uhh, aren’t you worried?” Izuku asked, barely a whisper.

Luke hummed, looking up in thought. “No, not particularly.” He shrugged. “First of all, it’s worth noting that your chances were always slim, and naturally, the fact that Bakugou has seen most of your tricks at this point certainly doesn’t help.” He paused for a moment before continuing. “That said… there’s one thing you have working in your favor now that you didn’t have at the beginning.”

He frowned. “And what’s that?”

Luke glanced over his shoulder, where Katsuki was currently standing, eyes closed, guzzling down a bottle of water. Luke leaned in, his volume lowering. “The longer a winning streak goes on, the more overconfident and careless Bakugou becomes.”

Izuku just stared at him for a moment, processing.

“That’s true.” Levi added. “He’s clearly impressed with you, but he’s not worried. Even less so, now that he thinks he’s seen everything.”

Izuku gulped, nodding slowly. The three of them moved away, and he took a few more sips of his water bottle before setting it aside. His heart racing, he returned to his starting position, and took a deep breath, glancing up at Katsuki.

His opponent.

Katsuki always seemed to come at him with the same first move, despite it never actually landing. It was almost as though he didn’t expect it to, like it was just something he did to get the ball rolling.

Izuku swallowed, standing firm and freezing his soul preemptively.

Bee blew the whistle, and Katsuki ran at him again, winding up a right-hand punch and rapidly drawing nearer. But Izuku didn’t try to dodge this time. He just stood his ground, not moving an inch until the last possible second.

And as Katsuki swung, Izuku’s hand shot out to grab his wrist. He tightened his grip and spun around, back touching Katsuki’s chest as he suddenly bent over and thrust his arm down. Katsuki’s body followed the movement, flipping over his shoulder, smacking right down on his side.

“Five!”

Heart racing, Izuku kept his grip, twisting Katsuki's arm behind his back as he climbed atop him.

"Four!"

Imagining clouds as he sunk his knee into his back, he launched another breath attack, sending a rush of vapor through Katsuki's open mouth. He began to cough violently, body reflexively trying to curl inward.

"Three!"

Katsuki was struggling, and it was getting difficult to control. Izuku took a deep breath, and deployed his last trick.

The Spiderweb.

Letting his soul expand outward, Izuku chewed the insides of his cheeks, allowing the bulk of it to turn to sticky goo. It meant Izuku was trapped, but it didn't matter so long as Katsuki was, too.

"Two!"

As he registered the trap, Katsuki's eyebrows shot up. He looked up at Izuku, and he could tell from the look in his eyes. He knew it was over.

But he didn't lash out. Didn't gnash his teeth or glare.

As the realization that he was out of time set in, Katsuki only smiled.

"One!"

He stopped struggling.

"Zero!"

Izuku released him, soul snapping back to normal as he rolled over onto his back, panting. He could hear shouting, and realized that they were cheering. All three of them were at his side in an instant, smiling, congratulating him. Luke offered a hand, and Izuku took it, sitting up.

He glanced over at Katsuki, finding him still on the ground, staring at the ceiling. He didn't look angry, or really any kind of upset at all.

Just… surprised.

And that's when it finally hit him.

I beat Kacchan, he realized.

I actually beat him, fair and square.

Full power.

No restrictions.

I just… ***won.***

It almost didn't feel real. He was half expecting to wake up any moment.

Luke offered a hand to Katsuki next. "Told you so." He said, grinning.

Katsuki scoffed, slapping his hand away and getting up on his own. He went to grab his water bottle, chugging the rest of it.

The Originals took their leave shortly thereafter, and it was only then that Katsuki actually spoke to him. "Surprised you still remembered that takedown."

Izuku smirked. "Well, I learned it from the best."

He snorted, setting his water bottle down. He stretched his arms over his head. "C'mon, let's go again. One more time."

Izuku's smile faltered. "Kacchan, I've already won."

"I know that." He rolled his eyes. "This is just for fun."

Izuku chewed his lip, not quite sure what to make of this new development, but after a moment, he nodded and stood up. He took a sip of his own water before returning to his starting position.

They were alone, now, the other three having left a few minutes ago. There was no one there to blow the whistle, and so Katsuki didn't wait. He just came at him.

Izuku shot a sticky strand into the wall, pulling toward it and dodging his attack, but Katsuki course-corrected easily, lunging at him once more.

Izuku decided to try the takedown again, but he should've known it wouldn't work a second time. He grabbed Katsuki's wrist and spun around, but Katsuki simply leaned into the movement, sending Izuku toppling to the ground, Katsuki's body plastered into his own, from his chest to his hips.

Izuku groaned at the heavy force of his body weight above him. He was about to struggle.

And then Katsuki rolled his hips against his ass, and he tensed up for an entirely new reason.

"K-Kacchan?"

"Hmm?"

Katsuki got hold of both his wrists, pinning them above his head in one hand while the other snagged into his hair. He shoved his knees between his thighs, making him spread them open, so he could press against him harder. "Somethin' wrong, baby?"

He rolled his hips against his ass again. Izuku's breath caught as he felt his cock, half-hard in his sweatpants.

"Y'know, there's somethin' I failed to take into account, when I agreed to this whole thing." He said, lips moving against the shell of his ear. Izuku shivered.

"Wh-What's that…?"

Katsuki slid his hand down the back of Izuku's pants, grabbing a handful of his ass. "How fuckin' hot you'd look, holdin' your own in a fight."

Izuku squirmed, unconsciously pressing his hips back into his hand. "We've sparred before, though…"

"Those weren't sparring sessions." He scoffed. "Those were executions with extra rules."

Izuku shot a glare over his shoulder. "Rude."

But truthfully, he knew he was right.

Katsuki smirked, closing the distance to kiss him. It was a bit difficult, with the way he was lying face down; Izuku just let him do as he pleased, holding him with his chin turned to the side, neck arcing back off the floor as he all but devoured him. His tongue invaded Izuku's mouth, filling it up with that smoky, sweet taste that he came to know as Katsuki's.

After a moment, he pulled away, leaning back a bit and roughly shoving Izuku's pants down. He yelped, glancing over at the door. "Kacchan, what if someone comes in…?"

He snorted. "Didn't seem too worried about that when I had you down on your knees sucking my cock." Izuku flushed hotter, and despite himself, he lifted his legs, allowing Katsuki to work his pants off easier. "Plus," he continued. "It's hotter this way, doncha think?" He nipped at the shell of his ear. "The risk of someone walkin' in… seein' you like this." He grabbed his bare ass, squeezing it hard. "Pretty Angel face down on the ground, moaning on my cock like some kinda *slut."*

Izuku really didn't expect to react to that word the way he did. The sudden spike of heat had him choking on saliva, eyes widening as his cheeks burned hotter. He would've tried to hide his face, but Katsuki was still holding his wrists, and his grip only tightened as he registered Izuku's reaction.

"Oh?" He grinned, looking downright feral. "Which part was it, huh? Was it the thought of someone seeing you like this, or the word *slut?"* Izuku squirmed, whimpering as his face only became hotter. "Or maybe it was both…?"

Izuku remained quiet, trying to hide his face against the floor, but it was awkward.

"C'mon, tell me. I ain't gonna be mean about it." He faltered. "Actually, no. Scratch that. I *will* be mean about it, but only 'cuz you like it."

"Kacchan."

“I’m just messin’ with ya, nerd.” Katsuki said, nuzzling against his neck. “Seriously, though. I mean, considering the kinda shit I’m into, s’not like I have any room to *judge* you or whatever. In fact, we could even do this like a quid pro quo. You tell me your kinks, I’ll tell you mine.”

Katsuki shifted, shoving down the waistband of his pants. Next thing Izuku knew, he could feel his cock against his bare ass, swollen and hot. Katsuki held himself at the base, smacking against his ass a few times as his claws dug into Izuku’s wrists above his head. Izuku whimpered, a rush of heat running south at the thick, heavy sound it created.

“I’ll go first.” He said. “I’m turned on by the fact that any minute now, someone could walk right in here and catch me about to fuck you into the ground. How ‘bout you?”

Izuku squirmed, hesitating before eventually conceding. “I… like that, too.”

He could’ve sworn he felt Katsuki’s dick twitch against his ass. He hummed, chest rumbling against his back. “I also like the idea of callin’ you mean names while we fuck. Things like *slut* or *whore.”* He went on. “Maybe *cockslut,* if I’m feelin’ *festive.* How’s that sound?”

Izuku blushed hotter. “I mean… good? But,” He bit his lip.

“Hmm?” Katsuki paused his movements.

“Only… Only with you, Kacchan.” Izuku muttered, voice coming out small and squeaky. “I don’t want this with anyone else.”

For the first time since he’d pinned him, he released Izuku’s wrists, both arms wrapping around Izuku’s body, hugging him back against his chest.

“Aww, baby.” He murmured. “I guess that’s good, because I wouldn’t want ya doin’ any of this shit with anyone else.” He snorted, and then after a moment, his tone softened. “And of course, I don’t wanna do this shit with anyone but you.” He pulled back a bit, one hand spreading his cheeks apart. “Just the thought of it weirds me out. Like, the idea of stickin’ my cock in something that *wasn’t* attached to you makes my fucking skin crawl.”

Izuku winced, and glanced over his shoulder. “…There are simpler, more normal ways to tell me you love me.”

“Oh, I know. And here’s one of ‘em.” Izuku heard the sound of a cap popping open. That was the only warning he got before he felt something slick dribbling between his cheeks.

“Ah!” he jolted. Then it hit him. “K-Kacchan, why did you bring *lube?”*

“It is extremely important that I am always ready to fuck you at a moment’s notice.” He deadpanned. “We’ve been over this shit, nerd.” He closed the cap, and dropped his cock between his ass cheeks, rutting slowly between them. Katsuki smacked his inner thigh. “Now, spread your legs.”

Wordlessly, he obeyed him, parting his thighs.

“More.” Izuku did, spreading them until his legs made a right angle with each other. “More. *More.”*

Izuku whimpered, shakily forcing them further open until he reached something like a hundred-twenty degree angle, and he just couldn’t go any further. It was a bit uncomfortable, but oddly, he wasn’t really *bothered* by it. He could feel Katsuki’s heavy cock pulsating against his ass, his hands rubbing against his inner thighs reverently.

“Flexible…” he murmured. *“Fuck,* that’s hot.”

And then his fingers were there, dipping between Izuku’s ass cheeks, rubbing hot and slick over his hole, teasing him. Izuku arched his back as best he could in the awkward position, and was rewarded when Katsuki slowly sunk his middle finger into him. He gasped, his eyes fluttering as he steadily fed it deeper, until he could feel his knuckle pressing against him.

Over his shoulder, he watched as Katsuki licked his lips and curled his finger inside, carefully starting to fuck him with it. Izuku whimpered, wiggling his hips as he felt the pad of his finger rub over that spot inside him, the one that made him wonder why he’d waited so long to do this.

The speed of Katsuki’s thrusts increased gradually over time, and when Izuku started rocking back into him hand, he sunk his pointer finger inside. Izuku choked at the slight stretch, thighs shaking with the effort of keeping his legs open so wide. Pretty soon, Katsuki was thrusting fast enough to make audible smacking sounds each time his knuckles hit the soft flesh of his ass, and by then, Izuku was hard and leaking against the floor beneath him.

He added a third finger, spreading them out inside him until he winced at the pain, adding more lube until he was wet and messy for him.

When Katsuki finally pulled his fingers out, Izuku whined, pushing his hips back in protest, only to be met with a sharp smack on his ass. Izuku choked on his own spit, eyes widening as the sensation made him throb.

“Oh-ho? You like that shit?” Katsuki said, with some odd mixture of mockery and giddiness. He ran his hand over Izuku’s ass gently, and then spanked him again. Izuku barely stifled a moan. “Damn. We’re learnin’ all kinds of fun things about you today, huh Deku?” He hit him a few more times in quick succession, then reached between Izuku’s legs, grabbing his cock and stroking him slowly. Izuku nearly choked on his own spit. “Decent fighter. Nice and flexible. Gets turned on by danger and likes it when I call him a slut.” Katsuki grabbed his cock, pressing the head against Izuku’s hole. “If I wasn’t damned from the moment I was born, I’d think God created you for me specifically.”

With that, he began pressing inside. The fat head of his cock popped in first, and from there it was a slow, relentless push. Katsuki held his ass open, claws biting into his cheeks as he steadily sunk his cock into him, and didn’t stop until his balls were pressed against his ass.

It was overwhelming, even a bit painful in this oddly addictive sort of way. Izuku’s thighs were shaking with the strain of being spread so wide. He wished he could spread them further.

Katsuki groaned as he grinded against his ass, thick cock hot and throbbing inside him. “Shit.” He hissed. “You good? Does it hurt?”

Izuku hesitated, not quite sure if he should be honest or not. But he ultimately decided to tell the truth. “Y-Yes, kind of…” He said. When Katsuki tensed behind him, Izuku was quick to continue. “B-But it’s okay! I… it’s good.” Katsuki’s breath audibly caught in his throat, dick twitching inside of him. “Just… move, Kacchan. *Please.”*

Swearing under his breath, Katsuki could do nothing but obey. He pulled out only a little bit at first before pushing back in, but he soon picked up the pace, fucking him in longer thrusts, his chest plastered against Izuku’s back, lips pressed against his ear.

“Fuck.” He moaned. “Shit. How’d I get so fucking lucky? Findin’ such a sweet, masochistic *slut* among God’s flock… Goddamn.” He babbled. “Love you so fucking much, Deku. You’re perfect. Look so good. *Feel* so fucking good, all spread out around my cock. Shit. Baby. *Baby.”*

Izuku choked on a moan when Katsuki suddenly grabbed the base of his tail, yanking on it as he fucked down into him harder, faster, *deeper.* It was like he could feel him in his stomach, and Izuku couldn’t help but start crying, choking on little sobs.

Katsuki abruptly stopped, body going tense. “Shit. Deku, you okay? Baby—“

“No, please.” Izuku said, fat tears rolling down his cheeks. “Don’t stop. Keep… f-fucking me. *Please.”*

He hesitated a second, and then his cock twitched inside him. He rolled his hips against his ass. “You’re crying ‘cuz you *like* it?”

Izuku squeezed his eyes shut, nodding quietly. Katsuki groaned, hands snaking under his hips, and before he could react, Katsuki was yanking him back into his lap, his chest pressed against his back. He scooped his hands under his knees, pulling them up to his shoulders, and Izuku yelped, grabbing hold of Katsuki’s arms for stability as he started fucking up into him again.

“Hey, Deku.”

“Huh?”

“Look.”

Izuku blinked his tears away, and followed Katsuki’s gaze. It was only then that he noticed the mirror, and his eyes went wide.

His face looked absolutely wrecked. Tear tracks all down his cheeks, his eyes puffy, lips red and swollen…

But what struck him the most was lower. Katsuki’s cock splitting him open. His hole was shiny with lube, stretched out wide around Katsuki’s length. His cock twitched at the sight, and suddenly he was teetering right on the edge. Even the feeling of his dick smacking

rhythmically against his stomach felt like too much for him. But when Katsuki's tail snaked between his legs and wrapped around his cock, he knew he was done for.

Izuku's horns started to grow, morphing into antlers as his claws dug deeper into Katsuki's arms. He couldn't stop it. It was all too intense. Had the glove on his right hand not been fingerless, he would've surely ripped it.

He sobbed. "K-Kacchan, I can't." He whimpered. "I can't, I can't, I'm gonna—"

"Then cum, baby." He whispered, fucking up into him faster. "Cum all over my fucking cock."

Crying louder, Izuku felt the moment he lost it, his thighs shaking, spasming in Katsuki's grip as his tail stroked his cock faster, pumping up and down in a corkscrewing sort of motion. He turned his head, burying his face against Katsuki's neck as he came, spurting all over his chest and Katsuki's tail, clamping down on his cock. Katsuki hissed, hips stuttering against his ass as he fucked up into him frantically. He was starting to shift involuntarily—his hands becoming darker, bigger, his claws sharper.

His cock was getting longer, thicker inside him, too. Izuku could both feel and see it.

And just before he tipped over the edge, he sunk his teeth into his shoulder and slammed in deep, balls drawing up as he flooded Izuku's insides with a load of thick cum, groaning into his shoulder as his cock throbbed deep inside him.

The two of them stayed like that for a moment, both panting as they gradually came down. And then slowly, Katsuki dragged his cock out. Izuku couldn't help but watch as inch after inch emerged until finally the head popped out, wet, softening length smacking against Katsuki's thigh.

His hole looked wrecked, stretched out and red. Suddenly embarrassed, Izuku reached between his legs and covered himself, only for Katsuki to pull his wrist away with his tail. "Wanna *see."* He growled, palms sliding beneath his ass cheeks, spreading him open wider. Izuku squirmed as his cum started to leak out of him, his cheeks bright red, eyes full of unshed tears.

"Oh, I'm *so* eating you out as soon as we get home." Katsuki muttered, dick twitching against his thigh.

"I thought you said we'd get lunch."

"I mean…" He snorted. "Technically, it counts."

"Kacchan!"

Over the course of the past week, he had interacted with more than a few councilmen in his dreams, some directly, others not, but all verifiable in their own ways. And in all his dreams,

there was only one who had failed to appear even once: number six, the Councilman of Humility.

The Violator.

He hadn't been able to confirm it directly, but he didn't need to. It was just basic process of elimination. There were no other options. Izuku was the Violator—or rather, that's who he had been possessing.

He'd gotten comfortable with the idea, accepted it as fact. And given that the Violator was the single greatest remaining unknown, it was good news, too. They were already brainstorming various ways Izuku could try to sleuth out the Violator's powers.

All in all, things were looking good, just before everything went off the rails.

It happened the very next day, during Izuku's first observation session post-training.

He was sitting at the head of a long, mahogany table, a large, bright, round light hanging down from the ceiling, casting dramatic shadows in the otherwise dark room.

There were a total of six unoccupied chairs, three on each side.

The door opened, and the sound of the latch clicking echoed in the vast chamber.

The first to enter was a man of modest height, his eyes dark, his head shaved clean. Embroidered on the front of his cloak was the number one—the designation of the Healer.

He was followed by a taller man with greying hair, his own cloak adorned with the number two, marking him as the Rejector. They both came to sit on the left side of the table, in the two chairs closest.

The Cleanser came next, stark white hair neatly combed back, just as it had been the first time Izuku saw him. He took the remaining chair on the left side.

The Martyr entered a moment later, sitting in the furthest chair on the right.

And then the door opened again.

The Commander walked in first, looking just as stern and imposing as he had the first time Izuku had seen him.

But there was someone else with him—another man.

He was far shorter, with curly blond hair and the look of a boy no older than sixteen or seventeen, at least by human standards. Despite his youth, his face was pale and gaunt, and he moved almost robotically, his dark eyes almost as vacant as a husk's.

He wore a councilman's uniform.

And there, emblazoned on the right side of his cloak, was the number six.

Even beneath the haze of the dream, Izuku was shocked. He could only stare, his eyes wide, as the two of them approached the table.

“Sit down, child.” The Commander barked. The boy obeyed his command without so much as a glance in his direction, sitting in the middle chair on the right, as the other sat in the chair closest to Izuku.

The Martyr raked a hand through his hair, glancing at the Violator with noticeable concern.

For a moment after everyone sat, it was silent. Then the Martyr cleared his throat, and gave the Commander a stringent look. “Did you give him a chance to shower?”

The Commander scoffed. “You think I have time to do that every time I wake him?”

While the Cleanser and the Healer appeared largely disinterested, the Martyr and the Rejector both gave him disapproving looks, though the Martyr’s was notably more intense.

“It’s been four days.” He said, his jaw tight.

The Commander offered only a cruel smile. “And what of it?”

The Martyr’s eyes narrowed, but his expression softened as he turned to look at the Violator, who sat between them. “Kindred, are you feeling alright?”

Izuku tensed.

Wait.

Kindred?

“Respond to him, and *only* him, child.” The Commander barked. And just like that, some of the life returned to the boy’s eyes. He seemed disoriented for a moment, and then he turned to look at the Martyr.

“I’m… alright, I think. For now.” He said, speaking softly, his voice hoarse from underuse.

The Martyr smiled slightly, placing a comforting hand on his shoulder. “After this, I’ll make sure you’re taken care of, okay?”

The boy, Kindred, stared at him for a while, and then slowly nodded. His eyes were starting to water, his lower lip quivering.

“Oh, for fuck’s sake,” The Cleanser muttered. “Can we just get on with it?”

“Child, stop thinking.” The Commander ordered, and just like that, what little light remained in the Violator’s eyes was leeched away once more.

Izuku woke to a room full of silent observers.

All around him, the others appeared to be in varying states of shock and confusion. Even Aizawa seemed alarmed.

“Kindred…” Bee muttered. “We’ve heard that name before.”

“He’s the one the Martyr’s been talking about.” Levi said. “It wasn’t a prisoner. It was *him.”*

“This whole time he’s been talking about councilman six…?” Luke said, more a statement of shock than an actual question. “But then… Midoriya?”

“Evidently, he’s not one of them.” Aizawa said.

“But… if he’s not a councilman…” Luke started, trailing off.

It was Katsuki who finally finished:

“…Then who the fuck *is* he?”

Chapter End Notes

so i just wanna begin by saying: i should’ve known people would think deku was the martyr lmao, after all, it’s DEKU, so like. that was a totally reasonable theory. but uhhh yeah that’s actually,,, not the case lol. he’s connected to the council in a Way, but that has yet to be revealed lmao

also like. the smut scene definitely wasn’t like necessary for the plot but…. look man, I blue balled myself for 150k words. let me enjoy making sexy demon man fuck his sweet angel. especially since shit’s going off the rails next chapter lmao

anyway uhh yeah. i hope there weren't any massive mistakes, like i've said before, i have a hard time keeping track of that shit once chapters reach a certain length. also, lots of OC stuff in this chapter, very self-indulgent, once again i hope they weren’t boring or annoying. i just love them okay lmao. particularly luke and kindred (the violator). hell, i even like the commander, despite... WELL.

anyway anyway, yeah. im excited for the next chapter bc that’s when the invasion will start. it’s gonna be fucking crazy y’all, hope u will enjoy it. and as always, pls consider leaving a comment bc i am a braindead zoomer and i just want to feel Something, Anything. lmao but yes, thanks for reading! See y’all next time yeeeeeee

Links, i guess:
Fire Lily Wiki
Spotify Playlist
Song I made for this fic

Twitter Hashtag
Deku's Costume Designs
Other miscellaneous shit

Chapter 19: To See Fire in the Clouds

Chapter Summary

> “All your minions are down.” He shouted. “What now, bastard?”
>
> “What now?” The Councilman parroted, stepping out of the shadows. “I suppose now the fun *really* begins.”

Chapter Notes

> warnings for uhhhhhhhh EXTREMELY GRAPHIC VIOLENCE
>
> oh also, Satan and Lucifer are different dudes FYI bc the originals are based on binsfeld’s classifications of demons lol

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Wednesday, four o’clock in the morning.

That was when the invasion was set to begin.

And at two in the afternoon on the Monday preceding it, Izuku was pacing around the apartment, tugging on the roots of his hair and muttering to himself as he racked his brain for any clues he may have missed in his dreams.

“Hey.”

He stopped at the sound of Katsuki’s voice, turning just in time to catch something he had thrown at him. He looked down. It was an empty duffle bag. “C’mon, you should start packing.”

Izuku chewed his lip. “Right. Of course.”

That was the state of things. Izuku was losing his mind, and in two hours, they’d need to board a train to some megacity seven hours away. The Demons participating in the mission would be coming from all over Hell, and due to its small scale, the plan was to transport everyone simultaneously. It therefore made sense to choose a particular city for them to meet up in, ideally one which equalized travel time for most people. That wound up being the city of Erykos, located in the central region of Hell.

Izuku kneeled on the bedroom floor, sifting through piles of clothes. They'd arrived just over a week ago, but Izuku hadn't had time to think about long-term storage. He'd just been keeping them in the box they'd come in.

Socks, shoes, shirts, pants, underwear, pajamas. They wouldn't be staying long, but he grabbed three of each item when possible, just in case.

Katsuki walked in, opening his drawer and looking through it.

"Did you already pack the shampoo and stuff?"

"Yeah." Katsuki said. "They'll have that stuff at the hotel too, though."

"Oh, right." Izuku stood up, heading to the living room. He glanced at the coffee table and spotted his stack of library books, grabbing them and carrying them back to the bedroom. They had a long trip ahead of them. Might as well bring something to do.

Izuku glanced at each cover as he carefully slid them into his bag, and only faltered when he came to the one detailing the history of the Depths. He almost didn't ask, not wanting to tempt fate. But he knew Katsuki well enough to know he would've thought it through.

"Kacchan?"

"Yeah?"

"Uhh… why aren't we just traveling through the Depths?"

Katsuki looked up at him. "'Cuz we're goin' to a city near the center of the landmass. Traveling through the Depths is only faster if you're goin' somewhere pretty close to the coast." He shrugged. "From Oseryth, the closest entry point to the Depths is about an hour away. From Erykos, it's four hours, and the actual path through the Depths takes around two. Even in the best case scenario, it'd still take us seven hours."

"Ah. I guess that makes sense." Izuku slid the book into his bag—and every other book he still had, for that matter.

In the end, Izuku's duffle bag wound up weighing enough to make him sigh in relief each time he got to set it down. Another reason to be glad they didn't need to travel through the Depths.

They boarded the train at four o'clock, and for a little while, Izuku didn't do much more than stare out the window, watching the world pass them by. But as the train ventured further from the city, it gradually sped up, and pretty soon, the scenery was little more than a passing blur.

Two hours into their trip, Katsuki's eyes began to droop, and by the third, he was nodding off beside him. Izuku tried to do the same, but it was still fairly early, and he'd already taken a nap during the observation session. Eventually, his eyes wandered down to the duffle bag tucked between his feet. He bent down and quietly unzipped it, feeling around until his

fingers clasped around the thickest book in the stack. He pulled it out and set it in his lap, staring at the cover.

Divine Intervention: Heaven, Hell, and the Perpetual War.

Izuku had been meaning to start it, but hadn't gotten the chance. He cracked it open, glancing briefly at the table of contents before ultimately deciding to just start at the beginning.

Izuku turned to the first page.

Chapter I:

The Great Betrayal

It was a warm, summer day in 2348 B.C. when God first presented the idea of flooding the Earth to a room full of horrified disciples. It was only the latest in a long line of alarming ideas God had put forth.

"I still remember that feeling, when we all heard it. The room was dead silent." Belphegor mentioned, in his written account of the event. "I think we all must've felt the same way, but of course, no one wanted to be the one to stand up and tell him how deranged it sounded…"

But this sort of thing was not new. They had been noticing the changes for quite a while.

"There was this weird duality, at the time." Satan observed, during one of our phone conversations. "Some days, he'd refuse to speak to anyone at all. Or if he had to, he'd be a real asshole about it. Visibly tired, too. But the very next day, he'd be lively and cheerful, but slightly less coherent. It was always a sudden shift."

The disciples had a multitude of theories as to what might be going on. If one asked Leviathan, Hidaeriel or Mammon, one might receive responses speculating about the growing population of the human race compounding God's stress. If one were to ask Beelzebub, Asmodeus or Belphegor, the answer might err on the side of self-blame.

"I remember being nervous around him all the time." Beelzebub told me, sitting on a couch next to Mammon at their home in the central region. "I thought that we were the ones who were behaving badly, and that God was just reacting to us accordingly. I held onto that belief for as long as I could. But the truth is, there wasn't really any connection between our behavior and his… it was just kind of something we were subjected to."

If one were to ask Satan or Lucifer, however, the answer might lean more toward the conspiratorial.

"Well, from the very beginning, we all knew he was hiding something from us." Lucifer said, sitting beside Leviathan at a cafe in downtown Sjarsvel. "There was this place in

the catacombs called the restoration chamber. Some nights, he'd go down there and only emerge after sunrise. We still don't know what he was up to. He was quite protective of it, you see. Kept it under lock and key. Never allowed any of us inside—not even once."

While this behavior was far from new, the flood was a tipping point for the disciples. "Yeah, by that point, he wasn't even answering prayers anymore." Satan mentioned. "It was *infuriating."*

According to Asmodeus' memoir, Satan and Lucifer were the first to float the idea of an intervention, and one by one, the others got on board.

"Of course, Hidaeriel was last." Asmodeus wrote. "Bastard that he was."

Indeed, this was the case—though Hidaeriel eventually appeared to come around on the plan, his tune changed at the last moment, as he wound up siding against his fellow Angels. Armed with a laundry list of accusations, Hidaeriel proceeded to lay into each and every one of them, bombarding them with a variety of transgressions, some real, others not.

"Asmodeus' was particularly ludicrous." Lucifer said. "He was in a monogamous relationship at the time. They had a lively sex life, to be sure… but it was well within the purview of permissible conduct. But Hidaeriel? Not to be crass, but quite frankly, he fucked so many humans he could've changed his name to *Zeus."*

At first, the remaining disciples were not too concerned about Hidaeriel's accusations. "We really didn't expect him to get anywhere with it." Leviathan explained. "It was seven against one. Our word against his. We thought for sure that God would take our side. But of course, we wouldn't be here right now if that were the case."

To this day, those seven disciples who would go on to become the Original Demons still are not certain why things ended as they did.

"I think it was a combination of things." Mammon stated. "Hidaeriel had the closest relationship with God, so he probably just had a predisposition toward trusting him. But honestly, I think it was mostly just the creeping insanity. You've got to remember we're talking about the guy who thought it'd be cool to just flood the Earth in order to purge the wicked. This sort of shit wasn't exactly unheard of."

However, this view is not unanimously held.

According to Leviathan, "Hidaeriel was acting rather strangely at least two days before the whole ordeal." He further speculated: "Something happened with him during that time. I suspect the reason for his change of heart may be intimately linked with the reason God chose to believe him over us." He sighed. "But of course, we'll probably never know what it was."

The buildings in Erykos looked like crystals sprouting up from the ground, and from their hotel room at midnight, the city lights made them glitter. Izuku continued staring out the

window for a moment before heading to the bathroom, flicking on the light. It was nice and clean, with a glass door enclosed shower and a granite countertop housing the sink. Izuku glanced at the soap dish, picking up one of the bars. It was light pink and round, and when he brought it to his nose, it smelled so sweet, Izuku felt tempted to taste it.

Izuku glanced at the doorway. He could hear Katsuki moving around the room, unzipping his own bag. Thinking he was in the clear, Izuku slowly raised the soap to his lips. He was about to lick it when Katsuki suddenly appeared in his periphery and promptly snatched it out of his hand.

"Do not *lick* the fucking *soap*, Deku. *Seriously?"*

Izuku frowned, his face growing hot at having been caught. "But it's pretty and it smells good…"

"What're you, *five?"* He scoffed. "If you're hungry, we can just get food here. *Real* food."

Still pouting, Izuku nonetheless nodded, and after surveying the nearby restaurants, they eventually found one that was still open and put in an order. Katsuki threw a jacket on and went to pick it up, leaving Izuku by himself.

For a few minutes, Izuku just sat on the edge of the king-size bed, zoning out at the view, vision city lights blurring in and out of focus. His stomach growled, and he frowned, shifting around. He still wasn't fully used to this—the sensation of hunger. It made him uncomfortable at a level Katsuki didn't seem to share. Maybe that's why he did what he did.

After ten minutes, Izuku stood up and defiantly returned to the bathroom, staring at the soap. He glanced to his left and to his right, as though he could expect to find Katsuki lurking around the corner. But of course, he was alone.

Izuku picked up the soap and brought it to his nose again, smelling its sweet, fruity scent. Then he closed his eyes and leaned in, swiping his tongue over the surface, tasting it. Instantly, his face twisted up in displeasure, and he quickly set the bar down, turning on the sink to try and wash his mouth out. But even after doing so, he could still sense that vaguely soapy taste polluting his tongue.

Around half an hour later, Katsuki finally returned with their food. As he entered, he leaned down, greeting Izuku with a quick kiss, but as he pulled away, he froze.

His eyes slowly narrowed.

"…You licked the fucking soap, didn't you?"

"Uh. Maybe?"

Katsuki clicked his tongue, shaking his head. "Fuckin' dumbass Angel." He all but shoved Izuku's to-go box into his hands. "Remind me to childproof the apartment when we get back."

Izuku awoke the following morning to the sound of someone beating on their door. He sat up, hair messy from sleep, and glanced at the clock. It wasn't even six yet.

He glared at the door as the beating continued, and he heard a muffled woman's voice shouting, "Bakugou!"

Katsuki groaned and all but threw himself out of bed before stomping over to the door.

Izuku was starting to feel bad for the other guests.

He yanked the door open forcefully.

"The fuck d'you want?" He spat.

"Is that any way to greet an old friend?"

Izuku finally pried himself out of bed and peered around the corner. There, standing in the doorway, was a short woman with long, white hair, dark skin, and muscles that rivaled Katsuki's. Her eyes lit up when she caught sight of him.

"Is this him?!" She pointed at Izuku.

"Who *else* would it be?" Katsuki grumbled.

The woman grinned, shoving past him none-too-gently and letting herself into their room. She extended a hand to Izuku. "The name's Rumi. Rumi Usagiyama. But most people call me Mirko."

Izuku blinked a few times, still a bit disoriented from sleep. He accepted the handshake. "Uh, nice to meet you, I'm—" Izuku winced as she squeezed his hand like it was a damn stress ball. "Um. Izuku Midoriya."

She released her grip, and he rubbed his hand with his other.

Katsuki sighed, shutting the door. "Deku, Mirko's my old instructor."

Izuku's brows shot up. "Really?"

"Yep." She grinned. "Without me, this kid would be nothing." She elbowed him in the side in a way that looked like it should've been painful, but Katsuki didn't even flinch

"No, I'd just have less trauma." He quipped.

Mirko snorted.

*Ah, so **this** is the person who threw Kacchan into a volcano then.*

"So you're coming along on the mission?" Izuku asked.

"Sure am!" She grinned. "Gonna kick some holy ass."

Katsuki rolled his eyes. “Mirko was one of Satan’s last students. One of the few who are still alive.“

His eyes went wide. “Your teacher was Satan?”

“Yep!”

“That’s… wow, okay.” He muttered. “Uhh. What was he like?”

“Mm, a lot like Bakugou here, to be honest. Y’know, loud, crass, thinks he’s hot shit. Very honest, though.” She said. “That’s actually part of why I decided to take him on as a student. He reminded me of Satan. Made me nostalgic.”

Izuku couldn’t help but laugh at that a little bit.

“You still haven’t explained what you’re doing here at the ass crack of dawn.” Katsuki grumbled. “The meeting’s not til nine.”

“I figured we’d get breakfast, do some catching up.”

“And why didn’t you ask yesterday?”

“‘Cuz it’s not a request.” She said, expression darkening. “If I’ve gotta drag you out kicking and screaming, I will.”

Katsuki stared at her for a moment, the threat hanging in the air.

Eventually, he sighed. “Give us one more hour and we’ll come quietly.” He then said. “We don’t need three full fuckin’ hours for breakfast.”

She held his gaze for a moment in silence. Finally, she shrugged. “Alright.” She began walking toward the door. “But if you’re not up at seven, I’m breakin’ the door down.”

And with that parting threat, she left.

“So, you guys fuck, right?”

Izuku nearly spewed coffee out of his nose. It was half-past seven, and they were sitting inside a mostly-vacant bakery down the street from the hotel—the only place nearby that was open at this hour.

“E-Excuse me?” Izuku glanced at Katsuki, but he didn’t seem alarmed. A bit irritated, perhaps, but not surprised.

“Just asking.” She shrugged. “I assume you do, but I wanted to make sure.”

“Th-That’s—“

“—Yeah.” Katsuki said, not even looking up from his food. “And what about it?”

Mirko took a bite of her croissant and continued speaking with her mouth full. “Well, I couldn’t help but notice that Midoriya can still walk.”

Izuku’s face burned impossibly hotter. “I… *what?”*

“When’s the last time you did it?”

“Like two days ago. Sunday morning.” Katsuki said, his tone flat.

“Kacchan!”

Mirko barked a laugh. “Sunday morning, huh? Scandalous.” She grinned. “So how’s the Church of Dick treatin’ ya, Midoriya?”

Izuku was very tempted to just get up and run. Maybe even fly away. He had slits in the back of his shirt. He could probably make it pretty far before either of them caught up with him, if he could just make it out the door first.

Katsuki looked at him, and clicked his tongue. *“Now* look what you’ve done.” He groused. “You’ve got him lookin’ for fuckin’ exits and shit.”

Izuku stiffened, looking down at the ground. Was he really that obvious?

Mirko sighed. “Sorry, kid.” She said. “Can’t help it. You just look so nice, and it makes me wanna bully you, y’know?”

Izuku decided not to question her on that, and instead asked, “Why do you even *know* something like that?”

“About Bakugou’s dick?” She raised an eyebrow. “Well, ‘cuz I was his mentor, of course. I’ve spent a lot of time with him. Probabilistically, if you hang around him enough, you’ll eventually wind up seein’ it somehow. I think they call it the law of large numbers.” She grinned. “Or in this case, the law of large—“

“—Okay thanks, got it!” Izuku interjected, pitch climbing.

Mirko cackled.

The meeting that morning took place in a large room which Izuku suspected also doubled as a cafeteria, and as they came in, he fidgeted with the hem of his shirt anxiously. Though he had at this point attended a number of meetings in which other participants had tuned in remotely, this was the first time he’d seen everyone in the same room together. There were around a hundred and fifty people in total, and it was a bit of an awkward number to accommodate; enough that some degree of structure would be required, but not enough to warrant a full allseer network.

Levi, given his recent excursion planting additional seeds in Heaven and his knack for strategy made him a good fit to direct the discussion, and with the approval of the others, he took to the podium.

“Does anyone have any questions or concerns before we get started?”

Someone raised their hand, and upon looking over, Izuku was surprised to find that it was Mina. He hadn’t realized she’d be attending as well.

Levi looked over at her and nodded. She stood up.

“Where are the bathrooms?”

The room rumbled with slight laughter, but Mina did not seem deterred. Levi smiled, and pointed at a pair of double doors on the right. “If you go out into the hall and turn left, you should see them a little ways down. They’ll be on the right, I think.”

Mina clapped her hands together and smiled brightly. “Thank you!” She skittered out the door and disappeared.

Levi looked around the room again and raised an eyebrow. “Anything else?”

He waited, and after a long moment of silence, he nodded. “Right, then. Well, I guess we should probably start by introducing some people for those who don’t know…” He glanced at a woman sitting nearby, with long, black hair. As she stood of, Izuku noticed she had a whip attached to her belt, for some reason.

Levi stepped aside, letting her approach the mic. “Hello! My name is Nemuri Kayama, though most of you probably know me by the nickname *Midnight.”* She grinned. “By day, I teach tactical Sloth magic at the Western Academy in Aerolijk, and by night, I—uhhh.” She seemed to stop herself, one hand resting on the handle of her whip. “Well, by night I do something else.”

Katsuki snorted softly beside him, though Izuku wasn’t sure why.

“Many members of the Sloth squad are actually former students of mine.” As she spoke, she seemed to be getting a bit emotional. “They grow up so fast…”

Levi leaned over the mic. “Midnight is also Belphegor’s oldest surviving student.”

“Well, I’m not *that* old.” She said, with a strained smile.

Levi rolled his eyes.

Mirko was the next to introduce herself. She kept her introduction short. “I’m Mirko, Satan’s best student, and I’m here to curb stomp some prissy Councilman ass.”

Aizawa came next, introducing himself as the current Nexus of Oseryth before casually mentioning the fact that he was apparently Asmodeus’ only surviving student, a fact which surprised Izuku more than it probably should have.

As Aizawa stepped away from the podium, Levi’s eyes settled on him and Katsuki, and Izuku tensed. He knew this was coming, but despite his best efforts to mentally prepare himself, he couldn’t help but feel nervous as they both stood up, heading over to the podium. All around

them, people were quiet, apart from a few indistinct, stray whispers that Izuku's brain only knew how to overthink.

Mercifully, Katsuki got in front of the microphone first.

"Katsuki Bakugou." He grunted. "Instructor was Mirko. As you can probably guess, my main style's Wrath." He paused, side-eying Izuku. "'Course, I'm not the one you're curious about."

Swallowing roughly, Izuku watched as Katsuki stepped aside. He moved before the podium, wiping his sweaty hands off on his pants.

"U-Umm, uhh. Hello." His voice cracked, and Izuku flushed. For a second, he just froze up. And then Katsuki laced his fingers through Izuku's own, and gave his hand a firm squeeze. Izuku took a deep breath. "I'm Izuku Midoriya. I'm—well, I *was*—an Angel. But now I'm not. Uh, obviously." He cleared his throat. "I haven't picked a style yet, but Luke, Levi and Bee have been training me, so I won't, uhh, get anyone else killed. Right. Um, yes."

Izuku started to pull away, when Katsuki sighed and stepped in, rotating the mic toward him. "De—" He stopped himself. "Midoriya," he began again, carefully enunciating it, as though it were a complex word from a language he did not speak. "Is the only reason any of this shit is possible to begin with." He then said. "He's the one who gave us the journal, and the one who planted the original gravity seed that made it possible for Levi to go in and plant the rest. Without him, none of us would be in this room right now."

The longer Katsuki spoke, the redder Izuku got. But despite his slight panic, his heart still sung to hear Katsuki speak so highly of him, even if it was a bit embarrassing. He squeezed his hand tighter, eyes locked on his shoes as they backed away from the podium and went to sit down.

As they did, Levi took his position in front of the mic again.

"You alright?" Katsuki whispered, squeezing his hand.

"Huh? Oh." Izuku nodded, after a second. "Um, yes. Y-You didn't have to say all of that, though."

Katsuki shrugged. "It's true."

Izuku couldn't find the will to argue.

"Well, now that all of that's out of the way…" Levi smiled. "Let's review."

Of the people involved in the invasion, most could be sorted into one of two main groups.

The first group, *Containment,* was primarily concerned with preventing fights that were either unnecessary or disproportionately dangerous. It was mostly comprised of Envy Demons, with a specialized Sloth team thrown in.

The second group, known as *Engagement,* was concerned with actual combat, mainly with Acolytes. Given that Acolytes seemed to rely quite heavily on their powerful hypnotic abilities, most of those placed in this group were Pride Demons, due to their unique ability to sense the whereabouts of their opponents without the need for eyesight—so long as they were within the bounds of their soul, at least. Once all active threats had been neutralized, most of the Engagement group would shift their focus toward evacuation, and help to facilitate the mass transportation of prisoners.

Between these two groups, Izuku and Katsuki were in neither.

Instead, they were part of what Levi had referred to as the *Excavation* group, which included them, Mirko, Aizawa, the Originals, and a handful of others. The Excavation group was not united by a common task, but rather the fact that they held specialized roles.

Luke, Levi, Bee, Mirko, and to an extent, Aizawa, were tasked with targeting specific Councilmen—the ones who weren't too risky to engage, which included all but the Cleanser and the Violator.

Luke would take on the first Councilman, the Healer. The Rejector was to be fought by Levi, and Bee was slated to take on the Commander. The Martyr was allocated to Mirko, with Aizawa as backup, though they didn't think she'd need it, and it wasn't really his true role. No, Aizawa's real duty was to interrogate the Councilmen on God's whereabouts after they'd been defeated—provided that they were still alive. And once they had the information they needed, all of them, along with a team of powerful Greed and Wrath Demons, would proceed to engage God directly.

In addition to the combative roles, there were a number of designated medics, as well, and a handful of Envy Demons tasked with monitoring the overall situation, and relaying messages to other groups if all other methods of communication failed. According to Levi, there was a good chance that their sigils wouldn't work once they were in Heaven, and thus they had resolved to use walkie-talkies.

And then there was them. Izuku and Katsuki.

Their main responsibility was one thing and one thing only: to locate and break into the place where the majority of Heaven's captives were held.

New Hell.

Unbeknownst to Izuku, Bee apparently lived in Erykos, and when the meeting finally came to a close at around eleven, Bee invited them over for lunch, along with Luke, Levi, Mirko and Nemuri.

The seven of them rode the train heading north, and after half an hour, it was but a brief, five-minute walk to the entrance of a tall, crystalline building. They rode the elevator all the way to the top, and soon found themselves standing in an apartment better fit for two people than for one.

“Feel free to sit down.” Bee said, waving toward the living area before disappearing into the kitchen.

Izuku spotted a light blue chair set off to the side, but he didn’t get more than one step closer to it before Katsuki grabbed his wrist, stopping him. He looked over his shoulder, frowning.

All Katsuki said was: “Not a chair.”

Izuku blinked a few times, before suddenly remembering what he’d told him two weeks prior.

“Half the shit in his apartment is edible for no reason. One time I sat down in a recliner only to find out it was made from cotton candy, somehow. I was sticky for weeks.”

Izuku glanced back at the chair and found that, on closer inspection, it did look a bit… odd. Katsuki led him toward a couch and sat down. As the others began to chat, he couldn’t help but look around a bit, wondering what else in the apartment was edible. He spotted a couple of plants which, on closer inspection, were definitely made from some kind of gummy candy, and Izuku was almost certain the coffee table sitting in front of him was at least partially made of chocolate—though if this were the case, it apparently didn’t make it any less functional, as there were a number of coasters set out, and a small stack of books sitting on the edge.

Izuku only tuned back into the conversation when Katsuki nudged him, placing a touch pad in front of his face and asking, “What do you think?”

Izuku looked at the screen, blinking a few times as his brain struggled to process the image. It was a picture of Levi, standing next to a horrifying creature so massive, it managed to make Levi look small.

“What… am I looking at…?”

“Ah, he wasn’t paying attention.” Nemuri said.

“Well, he’s the only one who hasn’t been here before.” Levi shrugged.

“That’s one of Levi’s pets.” Katsuki said.

“Her name’s Stella.” Levi said.

“Stella…” Izuku narrowed his eyes. “And, uhh… what… is she, exactly…?”

“The harbinger of my demise.” Luke replied, completely monotone.

Izuku blinked. “Um. Okay?”

Levi rolled his eyes. “She’s a deepseeker.”

“A deepseeker?” Izuku’s eyes went wide, and he turned and looked at Katsuki. “Isn’t that what almost killed you in the Depths?”

“Yep.” He replied, popping the ‘p’ sound.

He looked at Levi again. “You keep a deepseeker as a *pet?”*

“Well, she’s domesticated.”

“Debatable.” Luke said.

Levi sighed. *“Luke.”*

Luke gave him a blank stare. “She’s tried to kill me nearly every time she’s seen me, Levi.”

“I know, but she’s usually so sweet!” He insisted. “I don’t know why she’s so aggressive around you specifically.”

“Oh, I know why.” Mirko said. “It’s the vibe he puts off. Animals can sense that kinda stuff, ya know.”

“What *vibe?”* Luke asked.

“Oh, you know.” Mirko replied. “The way you just… uhh…”

“Radiate used car salesman energy?” Katsuki offered.

Mirko snapped her fingers. “That’s it!” she grinned. “She probably wouldn’t attack you if you quit actin’ like you’ve got somethin’ to hide all the time.”

“You believe she’s suspicious of me?” The others nodded, and Luke frowned.

“It makes sense, actually.” Levi noted. “I mean, looking back… there’s only one time I can remember when she was loose with you and didn’t bother you.”

Recognition flashed in Luke’s eyes, and then he leaned back against the couch cushion, sighing. “So essentially, she won’t attack me if I’m already distraught.” He deadpanned. “Wonderful.”

Izuku zoned out again, glancing over at the clock. It’d been nearly half an hour, and Bee still wasn’t back. Brow furrowing, Izuku nudged Katsuki lightly.

“Be right back.” He muttered. Katsuki nodded, and then Izuku stood up, quietly tracing the path he’d seen Bee take. Soon, he found himself outside a sizable kitchen.

Bee was standing before the fridge, bent over slightly as he seemed to be searching for something. “Oh, there it is.” He said, closing the fridge, only to jump nearly a full foot vertically upon seeing Izuku standing in the doorway.

“Ah, I’m so sorry!” Izuku squeaked, waving his hands. “I didn’t mean to scare you!”

“It’s alright.” Bee exhaled. “Did you need something?”

“W-Well, um…” He muttered. “Not really, I just… noticed you’d been gone a while so I wanted to just… check and make sure everything was okay.

Bee offered a small smile. “I see. That’s nice of you, Midoriya.” He hopped over to an oven, peaking inside.

“It’s almost ready. Shouldn’t take more than ten more minutes. Uhh, sorry for the long wait.”

“No, no!” Izuku said, blushing. “Please take as long as you need. I, uhh, kind of didn’t realize you were actually going to be *cooking.”*

“Well, I am… uhh…” He looked around. “Is that alright…?”

“Yes, of course it is!”

“Oh. Well, good.” Bee sighed, peaking into the oven again.

Izuku shuffled around in place for a moment. “Um. Is there anything I can do to help?”

Bee seemed caught off guard when he looked at him again. “Uhhh…” he hesitated. “I mean, you could set the table? You don’t have to, though. Really!”

“No, I want to.” Izuku insisted. “It’s the least I can do, since you’re cooking.”

Bee grinned. “Well, okay.”

Izuku blinked after a second. “Um, where are the plates?”

“Oh, right!” Bee tensed, then pointed at a cabinet just behind him. “They’re all up there. Silverware’s in the drawer on the far right.”

Izuku nodded, and headed over to the cabinet. As he opened it, he released a small sigh. It felt like he’d just participated in some sort of awkwardness olympics.

but he tried to shake it off as he grabbed the plates, heading out to the dining area just outside the kitchen.

As he set each plate down, he noticed a number of framed photos hanging on the wall, and couldn’t help but linger. There was a larger one at the center, which, upon closer inspection, Izuku realized was actually a painting.

It depicted seven men, all standing in the snow in front of a frozen lake.

Levi was immediately recognizable for his height, though his hair was shorter, and he had a faint smile on his face. By his side stood a man with white hair, styled in an undercut. Looking closer, Izuku saw his eyes were different colors: one red, the other blue, both betraying a mildly irritated look. His arms were crossed, and he was the second tallest of the bunch.

Beside him was a man with long, flowing red hair. In contrast with the white-haired man, this man's body language suggested openness, and he sported an almost flirtatious sort of grin. To that man's left stood Bee, who was smiling brightly, and looked shockingly similar to how he did currently.

On Bee's left was a tall man with chin-length, black hair and bright orange eyes. He had his hands in his pockets, and his body turned slightly toward Bee's, but the look on his face was stoic.

After that man, there was a shorter man with wavy blonde hair and a slight smile on his face. Of the bunch, he was the only one who seemed to be slouching, and his poor posture made him appear almost as short as Bee.

Finally, at the end of the row stood Luke, his hands shoved into his pockets, with a profoundly bored look on his face.

Based on their style of dress, Izuku could tell the painting must've been quite old, though exactly *how* old he couldn't even begin to guess.

Realizing he'd been there too long, Izuku shook his head and went back to the kitchen, filling his hands up with silverware.

As he laid forks and knives out on the table, Izuku saw a number of other pictures, all of which were actual photos, though many were in black and white. On the far left side was a colored photo of Bee and what looked to be the same dark-haired man who had been standing beside him in the painting.

As he was looking at it, Bee came in, holding a large dish of some kind, which he set down on the table with a sigh.

Without thinking, Izuku pointed up at the photo and asked, "Who's that?"

"Mammon."

"Oh." Izuku tensed, mentally hitting himself.

Of course it's Mammon, you idiot! Kacchan told you they were together!

After a second, he turned toward him again, eyes darting around, looking at everything but Bee. "I… I'm sorry."

"Huh? How come?"

Izuku finally looked up to find Bee staring at him with a genuinely bewildered expression. It didn't take long for him to catch on.

"Ohh…" Bee said, eyes wider. He looked down. "You know."

"Y-Yeah, um. Kacchan told me." Izuku said, shuffling in place nervously. "I'm sorry." He repeated.

“No, no—it’s okay.” Bee assured him. “It’s fine. I really don’t mind people asking about him.”

Izuku sighed in relief.

Bee glanced down at the table. “Did you get spoons?”

“Oh!” Izuku jumped. “Sorry, I didn’t realize we needed them. I’ll just—“ He ran off to the kitchen, grabbing several spoons and returning to the dining area, laying each one out on the big, round table.

Bee was standing in front of the photo, looking up at it, smiling.

Izuku’s instincts told him to drop it, but he couldn’t help but feel curious. And Bee *did* say he didn’t mind, after all.

“Um, what was—“ Izuku’s voice cracked. He cleared his throat. “What was he like?”

Bee turned and looked at him. “Mammon?”

He nodded.

Bee looked up in thought. “He was clever.” He eventually said. “Funny, too. Though his humor was a bit of an… acquired taste.”

Izuku blinked. “What do you mean?”

“Ehh, he had a tendency to speak with this very flat sort of affect.” He explained. “If you didn’t know him too well, it was easy to mistake him for being serious when he very much was not. It led to some… strange situations.” He laughed fondly. “But he was sweet. Reserved, but at the same time, rather good with people. He always knew the right things to say…” He trailed off, eyes indicating that his mind was somewhere very far away.

“…How long?”

Bee glanced over at him, lucidity returning. “Sixty-three years. It was… one of the earliest divine light attacks. Sjarsvel. Mid-size city up north.” He said softly. “Both him and Satan—the one with the white hair…” He gestured back at the painting. “Luke would’ve died, too. He actually lived there, but he was out of town at the time. And Mammon…” He paused, taking a deep, shuddering breath. “Well, he just happened to be visiting.”

For a second, Izuku could even speak. Then, “I’m… so sorry, Bee. That’s horrible.”

“It’s alright.” Bee gave a sad smile. “I don’t think he’s… *really* gone.”

Izuku gave a quizzical look. “What do you mean?”

“I dunno. I just… don’t think this is the end.” He shrugged, flushing slightly. “I feel like something has to happen afterward. Maybe we’re reborn as humans again, or maybe something else…”

“Huh…” Izuku said. “Is that a common belief?”

“No, not really. It’s… fairly eccentric.” He said, with a nervous laugh. “Maybe it’s just a coping mechanism, but I dunno. I just can’t help but feel like a spirit like his had to go somewhere, you know? I can’t imagine the universe just… letting a soul that incredible go to waste. It feels… wrong.”

Izuku nodded quietly, understanding. Though he wasn’t sure he’d agree per se, Bee’s words resonated with something deep inside him.

Because by necessity, they both had believed in Heaven long before they died, and to do so took a particular kind of defiant sentimentality. One way or another, their human selves had to come to the conclusion that there was more than meets the eye, that the afterlife existed.

When he actually thought about it, the idea wasn’t so far-fetched, given the reality they lived in.

“You probably think I’m crazy.”

“No…” Izuku smiled. “Actually, I think you might be onto something.”

It was around two o’clock when they got back to their hotel room, and as Katsuki shut the door behind him, he sighed.

“M’gonna take a shower.” He muttered, toeing off his shoes. Izuku just nodded silently, hanging up his coat and going to sit on the edge of the bed. As Katsuki closed the bathroom door, he looked around the room idly. There was a small mini fridge under the TV. He went and grabbed a bottle of water, twisted it open and sat down again. As he sipped at it, he could hear the muffled sound of the shower starting up. Water hitting tile. Water hitting something else.

Izuku set the bottle down on the nightstand, grabbing the book beside it. He laid back in bed and tried to read, but he just… couldn’t seem to focus. Every time he heard the sound of a bottle being set down inside the bathroom, his concentration faltered. Eventually, he closed the book and stood up again.

He felt… antsy.

He tried to shake the jitters out of his limbs, but nothing seemed to help. He was pacing around the room, and with each pass, he drew closer to the bathroom, lingering just outside the door.

It hadn’t fully hit him yet, the reality of what was to come, but as Izuku stared at the boundary, it gradually started to creep into his consciousness. The realization that they might not live to see the next sunrise. That this might be their last night together.

He tried to push it down. The plan was about as solid as it could reasonably be. He had faith in the other Demons, in the Originals. He had faith in *Katsuki.*

But the fear was there, and it was *rational,* and as it settled in, he felt this steadily mounting pulling sensation within his chest. Izuku shifted his weight back and forth between his feet as his eyes bore holes through the bathroom door. And then, something finally snapped.

Izuku yanked his shirt over his head, removed his pants and underwear in one fell swoop. He left his clothes in a heap on the floor and then reached for the door. He hesitated for a second, hand hovering over the handle. Then he took a deep breath, and slowly opened it.

Stepping inside, Izuku eyed Katsuki's silhouette behind the semi-opaque shower door, the hum of the exhaust fan masking the sound of the door closing behind him. Izuku inched toward the shower, chewing his lip. And again, he paused for a moment, hesitating, before he took a deep breath and quickly slid the door open, poking his head in.

"Fuck!" Katsuki shouted, eyes wide, grabbing the shower head for stability. After a second, his expression morphed from surprise to something more along the lines of confused irritation. "Deku, what the *fu—"*

Izuku pulled back the curtain and stepped inside, cheeks flushed as he got under the spray with him. Upon realizing he was naked, Katsuki was rendered speechless for a moment. Izuku took a second to look him up and down.

It seemed odd, now that he thought about it; despite their… *activities*… these past two weeks, he hadn't actually gotten many opportunities to see Katsuki completely naked like this, at least not straight on. He truly was a sight for sore eyes. Tall and handsome, body packed with hard, lean muscle that glistened under the water. And of course, his cock hung long and thick between his legs, even when completely soft.

As Izuku looked up, he found Katsuki looking at him with a curious, amused sort of gaze.

"…Can I help you?" He asked, raising an eyebrow.

Izuku blushed hotter. "I, uhh… missed you?"

"Yeah?" Katsuki said, grabbing his body wash and squirting a bit out on his palm. "I've been gone… what, five minutes?" He snorted, as he started washing his arms and chest.

For a minute, Izuku didn't say anything. He was a bit embarrassed, really. Wasn't sure why he felt the need to go this far, why he couldn't just wait for him to come out.

Katsuki stepped under the spray, suds washing down the drain. He turned toward Izuku again and shrugged. "Well, if you're gonna be in here, might as well—*woah."*

Without thinking, Izuku snaked his arms around Katsuki's back, cheek pressed against his chest. He smelled nice, like roses. After a moment, Katsuki wrapped his arms around him as well, sliding one up into his now-wet hair. "You alright?"

Izuku nodded against him. "I just… I don't know."

Katsuki didn't say anything else. He just kept holding him like that, until eventually Izuku figured out how to explain what he was feeling.

“I’m just… scared.” He said. “Not of the invasion. I-I mean, I kind of am, but…” He swallowed. “I don’t know. I just… don’t want to waste any time. When this might be…”

Katsuki hummed, chest rumbling against his cheek, and he hugged him tighter. “I gotcha.” He murmured, chin resting atop Izuku’s head as he continued to stroke his hair. “Y’know, you don’t have to come, Deku. It’s not too late to back out.”

Izuku shook his head. “No… No, I still definitely want to go, it’s just… well…” He trailed off.

For a little while, they just stood there like that, embracing one another in silence. The only sounds coming from that of water hitting tile and skin, of Katsuki’s steady heartbeat thrumming in Izuku’s ear. The water was hot, but Katsuki’s skin was somehow hotter.

After what might’ve been five minutes, Izuku spoke again. “You’re warm, Kacchan.”

He snorted. “I mean, I hope so. I’m alive and all.” He faltered. “Well, kind of alive.”

Izuku smiled, pulling back slightly and shaking his head “No, I mean you’re like… *really* warm. I don’t think I’ve ever met someone who ran as hot as you do.”

Katsuki hummed. “So what you’re basically saying is… I’ve got a *hot body.”*

Izuku groaned, stepping back, hands covering his cheeks. Katsuki just laughed and pulled his wrists away. He curled a finger under Izuku’s chin and tilted it up, leaning down to kiss him. It was a slow, sensual kiss, but one that did the job. Every time Katsuki kissed him, Izuku felt as though he were being infected with something he couldn’t quite place. Katsuki’s body ran hot, and that heat always seemed to transfer into him by way of his lips, curling up inside him, wrapping all around him.

And just when Izuku thought he couldn’t possibly fall any further, Katsuki pulled him deeper still.

Katsuki walked him backward until his body hit the wall, shoulders pressing into tile as he kissed him breathless. When he eventually pulled away, it was slow, reluctant. And Izuku’s eyes fluttered open to the image of Katsuki beneath the warm light, soaking wet. He couldn’t help but stare.

Katsuki smirked, offering a glimpse of sharp, white teeth. “See somethin’ ya like?”

He didn’t even try to deny it—just nodded, sliding his fingers up into Katsuki’s wet hair. “Kacchan’s very handsome.”

“Yeah?”

Izuku bit his lip. “Yeah.”

“Well, you’re not so bad yourself, *I guess.”* He said, then laughed at the twisted up look on Izuku’s face. “M’just messin’ with ya, nerd. You’re handsome too. *More* than handsome.”

Katsuki kissed his forehead, and as he continued speaking, his lips moved against his skin. “Fuckin’ stunning. Gorgeous. Sexy. *Perfect.”*

As he spoke, his hands slowly slid down Izuku’s back, lower, *lower,* until he reached his ass, grabbed it with both hands and *squeezed.* Izuku’s knees weakened, spine curving to press back into Katsuki’s hands as he groped and kneaded each cheek. He released the smallest of whimpers, barely audible over the sound of the shower, his eyes fluttering shut.

The next time he opened them, it was at the feeling of something hot and heavy pressing against his hip. “You have no idea what you do to me, Angel.”

Izuku moaned softly at the sight of his half-hard cock. After a second, he reached down and wrapped his fingers around it, and Katsuki hissed as he started stroking him up and down, his grip loose, more tentative than teasing, though it had the same effect.

“Shit.” Katsuki said, voice low, gravelly. “Don’t start somethin’ you don’t plan on finishing, Deku…”

Izuku tore his eyes away from the thick cock in his hand and looked up at him. “Who said I couldn’t finish it?”

He laughed, a sort of rumble in his chest. “Never said you *couldn’t.* M’just sayin’ is all. Much as I’d love to just fuck your brains out, I don’t wanna risk giving you a limp before…” he trailed off.

“Oh.” Izuku said, hand going still for a moment as he chewed his lip, thinking. Eventually, he cleared his throat and looked up at him, before promptly looking off to the side. “I mean… if you’re *gentle…”*

Katsuki hummed. “Fuck you gently, huh? Guess I could try that…” He gave his ass another squeeze. “You sure?”

Izuku nodded, and with that, Katsuki kissed him again, squeezing his cheeks harder, pulling them apart. He traced his tongue over his bottom lip and then pressed inside, consuming him slowly, sensually. After a minute, he started kissing down his jaw, his neck, pausing where his neck met his shoulder. And then suddenly, he sunk his teeth into his flesh. Heat bloomed from the site of the bite, and Izuku cried out.

“K-Kacchan, I thought you said you’d be *gentle.”*

“Said I’d be gentle with your *ass.”* He corrected, grinning against his neck. “Never made any promises about the rest of ya.”

With that, Katsuki spun him around, pushing him into the shower door, Izuku’s cheek and hands pressed against the glass as he attacked his neck again, sucking deep, purple marks into his skin as his claws bit into his hips. Gradually, Katsuki worked his way down his back, kissing along his spine, all the way to his tailbone, and then he was on his knees behind him.

Taking his ass in both hands again, Katsuki kneaded his cheeks slowly, just admiring him for a minute. It felt nice, sort of like a massage, and served to lower Izuku's guard as a minute later, he spread him open, leaned in and swiped his tongue over his hole. Izuku gasped. He'd been leaning hard on the slick glass, and had to reach out and grab onto the door handle just to keep from slipping. He could feel Katsuki's breath, hot against his skin.

Katsuki held his cheeks open as he slowly worked him over, tongue circling around his rim, alternating between precise strokes with the tip of his tongue and hard, wet presses with the flat of it. Soon, Izuku's thighs were shaking, cock hard and drooling. When Katsuki pulled him open further and started pressing his tongue inside, Izuku nearly choked on his own saliva.

"G-God…" he gasped, cock twitching between his thighs. "Feels so—*ahh!"* He cried out when Katsuki slid one hand up, grabbing the base of his tail and pulling sharply. The move forced his tongue deeper, and Izuku whimpered, clutching the door for dear life as Katsuki set a rhythm with it, fucking his tight hole with his tongue, yanking on his tail to pull him into each movement. Izuku's eyes were welling up with unshed tears, and when Katsuki's tail snaked between his legs, wrapped around his cock and started stroking in time with his tongue, they spilled down his cheeks with a sob.

"K-Kacchan," he cried. "Wait, I can't, I'm—you're gonna make me—"

With a popping sound, Katsuki pulled away from his hole, just enough to speak. "So cum, then." He tightened his tail around Izuku's length. "Won't be the last time."

With that, he dove back down, fucking Izuku with his tongue faster, deeper. And after another minute, it was all Izuku could take.

"Kacchan!" He cried, knees shaking, clenching around his tongue as he came, spilling all over the glass and Katsuki's tail as his body filled with white hot pleasure. Katsuki kept fucking him with his tongue as he rode out each wave, pulling on his tail in tight little pulses. For a moment, he almost forgot where he was.

Then Katsuki was getting up, standing behind him again and pressing him harder into the glass door, his cock now fully hard, heavy and slick against his ass. Slowly, he ran the tip up and down between his cheeks, groaning softly under his breath.

"Still want this?"

Izuku nodded against the glass, eyelids fluttering. "Please."

Katsuki kissed the back of his neck. "Lemme know if anything hurts."

"…Okay."

"I'm serious, you fuckin' masochist." He said, tone warning. "There's a time and a place for me splitting your ass open on my cock, and it's tomorrow morning, in front of the festering corpse of God."

“I… really did not need that visual, Kacchan.” He shuddered. “Why do you feel the need to say things like that?”

“It’s not that I need to. I just want to.” He shrugged, and at the sound of Izuku grumbling under his breath, he laughed.

“Seriously, I—*Oh.”*

Izuku’s breath caught, words dissolving on his tongue as Katsuki rubbed the head of his cock harder against his hole. He felt himself opening up for him, trying to pull him in. Katsuki hummed in satisfaction, circling around the rim just a few seconds longer before he slowly started to push inside. Izuku’s cock gave a small throb as the head popped in, and his nails scratched against the glass as he carefully fed the rest into him. It was slow, gentle. Katsuki paused after every inch or so, allowing him to adjust. And there was a part of Izuku whose heart fluttered at the loving consideration Katsuki was giving him.

There was another part who wanted him to drop it entirely, slam inside and fuck him hard enough to crack the glass door.

But of course, he suppressed it.

It didn’t take long for Izuku to get hard again, in part because Katsuki’s tail had never really stopped stroking him. He’d slowed down after he came, relaxing into a gentle, persistent tease. By the time Katsuki was balls deep inside of him, Izuku was already half hard again.

He paused for a moment then, hips pressed tight against his ass, leaned down and kissed his shoulder. “You alright, nerd?”

Izuku whimpered, nodding. “Feels deep. Full.” he sighed. “Kacchan’s cock feels so good inside me.”

Katsuki’s breath hitched, and he could feel his cock twitching inside him.

“…Keep talkin’ like that and I might not be so gentle.”

Izuku snorted. “Don’t threaten me with a good time.”

With a grin, Katsuki leaned down, grabbing Izuku’s hair and pulling him into a kiss, grinding deep inside him. As he pulled away, he stared into Izuku’s eyes for a moment, and then sighed. “Y’know, you’re the only person I’ve ever wanted to protect this bad just so I could be the one who breaks you.”

With that, Katsuki slowly started to withdraw. Izuku gasped, clamping down on him reflexively. Katsuki didn’t pull out as much as he normally did, instead only withdrawing around a third of his full length before sliding right back in. Easy, languid. Katsuki’s body was pressed against him from his shoulders to his hips, where he was fucking into him in nice, sensual rolls. He moved his hips in this subtle circular motion, where every angle was a little different, had his cock pressing up against his walls, not a single inch of him left untouched.

“Fuck,” Katsuki grunted, deep, breathy. “Good?”

Izuku trembled against the glass, mouth gaping, knees weak as Katsuki fucked him slow and deep. He didn’t register the question at first. It was only when Katsuki stopped moving, brows pinched together, that he remembered himself.

Katsuki opened his mouth to speak, but Izuku beat him to it. “N-No, no, please don’t stop. It feels good. *Please.* You feel *so* good, Kacchan, your cock is *so big, fuck me, plea—”*

Suddenly, Izuku found himself unable to speak as Katsuki sealed his hand over his mouth. “What’d I say, nerd?” He said. “Keep talkin’ like that and you might need crutches tomorrow morning.”

Izuku shivered at the thought, pressing back against Katsuki’s hips, urging him to move again. Katsuki did, slowly, and Izuku’s brain once again checked out as he was consumed by the pleasure of getting fucked so thoroughly. He didn’t realize he was reaching down until Katsuki was gently batting his hand away from his cock, wrapping his fingers around it instead and stroking.

Izuku cried out, tears running down his cheeks again. “K-Kacchan, wait, I’m—“

“Shhh,” Katsuki spoke right into his ear. “S’okay, I’ve got you.” His words seemed to reverberate throughout his entire being. “Don’t gotta do anything at all, baby. All you gotta do is take it. Okay?”

Izuku only whimpered, nodding against the glass, his eyes squeezed shut as Katsuki stroked his dick in time with his thrusts. “That’s it.” Katsuki whispered, before leaning in to claim his lips again.

For a little while, they continued at this pace, basking in the heat of each others’ bodies. But eventually, Izuku wanted more. As Katsuki broke the kiss, he said, “C-Can you go faster? Please?”

Katsuki hummed, considering it, and after a moment he obliged, speeding up to a more moderate pace. Izuku moaned, knees shaking, cock leaking into Katsuki’s hand as he leaned heavily into the glass.

There was something about it, being pressed up against the shower door like this. He really was at his mercy. Trapped between the cool glass and his hot body, Katsuki’s thrusts felt all the more inevitable, each a gentle yet insistent roll of his hips that drove his thick cock deep inside of him, hit him in all the right places.

But as Izuku neared the edge, he couldn’t help but want it faster, *rougher.*

“Faster, please?”

With a grunt, Katsuki picked up the pace a little bit, but it wasn’t enough.

Izuku whimpered. “Faster. *Harder.”*

"Deku." Katsuki yanked on his tail, his tone warning, but that only drew him closer to the edge, made him want it even more.

"I don't care, *I don't care,* I'll take pain killers or something, just *please!"*

Swearing under his breath, Katsuki started fucking into him in earnest, hips smacking against his ass as he hammered into him, stroking his cock in time with his thrusts.

Izuku could tell Katsuki was close by the way his hands had started to grow, claws biting into his hip as he thrusted his cock into him deep and hard. Izuku was no better off—his antlers slowly grew out of his head as he pressed his clawed hands hard into the glass.

It was the feeling of Katsuki's cock growing bigger inside of him that finally pushed him over the edge. Clamping down around him, Izuku's body exploded with heat, spreading out from the pit of his stomach. His cock twitched and pulsated in Katsuki's hand, adding to the mess on the glass.

Katsuki wasn't far behind. "Fuck, shit, Deku, *baby—"* He groaned, slamming into him one last time before going still, grinding against his ass as his cock throbbed deep inside him, spilling into him, stuffing him full of thick cum.

He stayed inside him for a minute afterward before pulling out with a grunt. Izuku could practically *feel* his eyes on him as the cum started to leak out, but he didn't have the energy to try to hide from him.

Around an hour later, Izuku was wrapped up in his arms on the bed. There was a movie playing on the TV, but Izuku had stopped paying attention a while ago. Eventually, he sighed, turning around in his arms to face him. Katsuki grabbed the remote and paused the movie.

"What's up?" He muttered. "Don't like the movie?"

Izuku shook his head. "No, it's fine… just."

"What?"

"Can we maybe just… talk?"

Katsuki blinked. "What do you wanna talk about?"

Izuku drew a blank, chewing his lip. Katsuki continued to stare at him expectantly. Izuku sighed, and eventually replied, "Tell me something you've never told anyone before."

Katsuki's eyebrows shot up. "Uhhh…." He said. "Okay, I guess? Um. What kind of thing?"

Izuku shrugged, but it was awkward with the way he was lying down. "Whatever you want."

"Yeah, but like… are you lookin' for something small and light-hearted or something like, deeper?"

“I dunno. Whatever you feel comfortable with, I suppose.”

Katsuki sighed, falling silent for a minute. He could almost see the gears turning in his head, could see the way his eyes lit up when he finally came up with something.

“Okay, I think I got one.” He eventually said, and sighed.

“So… I told you about how I spent the last few years of my life wandering from place to place, right?”

“Ah, yes. I think so.”

“Well, when I was nineteen, I spent some time in Paris. At the time, they were running this ballet called *La Sylphide*… I snuck in almost every night to watch it.”

“Seriously?” Izuku smiled. “You like ballet, Kacchan?”

“Well, I didn’t really know anything about it before then, so it was kinda like this new and shiny thing to me, I guess.” He shrugged. "Anyway, I did that for around four months. It was the longest I’d ever spent in one place…” He paused. “Then one night I almost got caught, and I was so spooked I just left town. Headed back the way I came. I’d been wandering for around two years at that point. Paris was the farthest I ever got from home.”

Katsuki fell silent for a moment, his expression contemplative.

“Y’know,” He continued, “for a while after I died, I thought I’d never come back to the surface. Then around forty years later, I heard the theatre had burned down. That was the first time I came back. I went and saw the rubble.” He said. “It wasn’t a really emotional thing for me. Like, I thought it was kinda sad, ‘cuz it was a really nice theatre, but there was already a new one being built.” He smiled. “In fact, fifteen years later, I snuck into the new one and saw *Swan Lake.* Nice venue. In fact, I’m pretty sure it’s still there, even now…”

Izuku couldn’t stop smiling, and when Katsuki looked at him, he glared. *“What?”*

“Sorry,” Izuku said. “I just can’t get over the fact that you like ballet. It’s so… unexpected.”

“Ballet dancers are fucking *jacked,* Deku.”

Izuku just giggled.

“I’m serious!” He said. “You seen how those guys jump? You know how fuckin’ strong you gotta be to pull off those moves *and* make it look easy? And don’t even get me started on those fuckin’ toe shoes. That’s like, circus shit.”

Izuku continued to giggle, and Katsuki rolled his eyes, flicking his forehead. “Ow!” Izuku rubbed the spot.

“Your turn.”

“Huh?”

“Tell me somethin’ you’ve never told anyone.”

“Ah.” Izuku faltered. “I mean, I haven’t had as many adventures as you, Kacchan. At least not any I can remember.”

“It doesn’t have to be somethin’ super exciting. Just think about it for a minute.”

Izuku hummed, brows pinching as he racked his brain. “I mean, maybe this is cheating because there is *one* person who knows about it, but only because they were actually there.”

“Go on.”

“I, uhh… got stuck in a window on Earth, one time.”

Katsuki blinked. “You *what?”*

“Yeah, uhh.” Izuku flushed. “It was my first time on the surface, about six months before we met. You have to spend half a year working in a group before they’ll allow you to work independently.” He scratched his head. “I’m still not sure how I got separated from the others, but while I was searching for them, I passed this pet shop and realized there were still some animals in there. There was this bird cage near the window with a couple of parakeets. It was toward the end of the city’s evacuation, so I figured it was safe to assume no one was coming for them and, well… what was I supposed to do, just *leave them there?*

“Anyway, the problem was that the door and most of the windows were all boarded up. There was only one window that wasn’t, but it wouldn’t open all the way. From there, the cage was really close, though. I figured if I could just get in far enough to open it…” He bit his lip. “Well, long story short, when I tried to get back out, I couldn’t squeeze my wings through the opposite direction. Two hours later, it was actually Todoroki who wound up finding me. He helped me get out. We never spoke of it again.”

“Holy shit.” Katsuki cackled. “Deku, that’s incredible. So did ya free the birds?”

“Oh, yeah. It was only after I’d managed to open the cage that I realized I was stuck.”

“Damn.” He snorted. “Were you at least comfortable?”

“I mean, reasonably?” Izuku squinted. “I was kind of just bent over the windowsill. My feet were off the ground, though. That’s probably why I couldn’t get out on my own. No leverage.”

“Huh. So what you’re sayin’ is you basically just had your ass hangin’ out the side of the building?” He grinned. “Y’know, there’s a whole porn subgenre dedicated to that specifically.”

“What?”

“Yep.” He said, grin expanding. “The person’s like, *‘oh no, I’m stuck! Please, help me out, step-bro!’* And then they fuck.”

"What?!" He repeated, his pitch raised. "That's… That's so *wrong,* though."

"I dunno." Katsuki snorted. "S'kinda hot."

"Excuse me?!"

"I dunno!" Katsuki said again, shrugging almost aggressively. "It just makes me *kinda horny!"*

"Kacchan."

"Look, it's not like I fuckin' *chose* to get turned on by that shit. If you've got a problem with it, take it up with my dick." He scoffed. "And for the record, *obviously* I wouldn't have tried anything if it was me who found you back then. I'd've probably just laughed at you and left."

"And what about now?" He asked, eyes narrowing.

"Now?" Katsuki raised an eyebrow. "Well, obviously I wouldn't do anything you weren't cool with. But I'd be thinkin' about it, like, *really fucking hard.* And I'm willing to bet you would be too."

"What?"

"C'mon, nerd. Think about it. Visualize yourself trapped in the window again, and then imagine me standin' behind you, hands on your hips, tryin' to pull you out. Now tell me the thought of me fucking you *wouldn't* cross your mind."

Izuku flushed.

Oh god, he's right.

"Kacchan, you *jerk."* He groaned. *"This is all your fault."*

"Huh?"

"I wouldn't have thought about that before you—you—!"

"What?" Katsuki smirked. "Before I fucked you? No way you weren't thinkin' about it before then."

Izuku grumbled, but didn't deny it.

"When was it, then?" Katsuki asked. "When did the sweet, innocent Angel start thinkin' about cock, *huh?"*

Izuku placed his hands over his cheeks, peaking through his fingers. "Can't do this, Kacchan." He snuggled into his chest, hiding his face.

"Fine." Katsuki sighed, wrapping his arms around him. He idly stroked his hair, and several minutes passed by. Izuku was about to fall asleep when Katsuki suddenly spoke up again.

“It was the sweatpants, wasn’t it.”

“Kacchan!”

Three o’clock, Wednesday morning.

Izuku awoke to the feeling of being gently shaken, and the sound of Katsuki whispering. “C’mon, nerd. Time to get up.”

Things were silent in the hotel room as they both got ready, eating a quick breakfast down in the lobby before heading out.

As they rode the train, Izuku stared down at the bland, textured floor, his body rife with anxiety. Katsuki took his hands, wrapping them up in the familiar warmth of his larger ones. It was only then that Izuku realized they’d been shaking.

When they eventually arrived at Erykos Hall, they entered the main room to discover that a line was starting to form. Looking further, Izuku saw stacks upon stacks of boxes. Katsuki nodded over to it, and he trailed behind as they got in line.

Izuku stood up on his tip-toes, peering at those ahead of them. He spotted Mina and Inasa up ahead, but where the two of them would’ve normally been loud and cheery, they were instead quiet, their faces uncharacteristically sober. It took a moment for Mina to even notice they were there. She looked up, and gave him a small smile. Inasa glanced over his shoulder, but only nodded at them, acknowledging their presence before turning toward the front again.

Izuku wrung his wrists, eyes falling to his feet.

“Deku.”

He jolted, head snapping up to find Katsuki standing a few feet ahead of him, looking over his shoulder. The line had progressed. Izuku quickly moved up closer, muttering apologies to the people behind him. As he took his place by his side again, Katsuki wrapped his arm around his shoulders, guiding him with the movement of the line.

When they reached the front of the line, Izuku was faced with a woman with long, blue hair, who smiled at him as though they weren’t about to take part in a mission from which they might not return.

“Name?”

“Um, Izuku Midoriya.”

She tapped something on the screen of a touch pad, and then nodded. She turned around and grabbed one of the boxes, and handed it to him. “There ya go!”

Izuku glanced down at the box in his arms and saw that it had his name on it. “Ahh, what is this, exactly?”

“Your gear, silly.” She replied.

“Oh!” He gave a nervous laugh. “Ah, right, of course. Um. Thank you.”

Izuku scurried off to join Katsuki at his side.

“What now?” Izuku asked.

“Now we get dressed.”

“Ah. Makes sense.”

He followed Katsuki down the hall until they reached a pair of double doors that opened into what looked to be a locker room. There were around a dozen others inside, and they moved to a spot in the corner.

Izuku set his box down and opened it. Inside, he found a number of articles of clothing, all neatly folded up for him, along with a pair of combat boots and some light body armor. When he looked up, he saw that Katsuki was already removing his shirt. After a moment of hesitation, Izuku shed his shirt, as well.

The top he’d been issued was dark grey, and crafted from a strange, thick material which had just enough stretch for him to get his head through. It was sleeveless, and had a tight fit. There were two long zippers running down the back, and before he could ask about them, Katsuki pulled both down.

Izuku blinked. “Uhh…”

“Most of the time we’re up there, we’ll be shifted.” He explained, shrugging. “Might as well pull ‘em down now.”

“Oh. I see.” He muttered, zoning out as Katsuki began removing his pants. He shook himself, and proceeded to do the same.

The pants were tight around his waist, loose around his hips, and tapered off around his calves. There were many pockets lining the sides, and judging by the weight distribution, some seemed to be full. Izuku grabbed the boots next and found an open spot at the bench, sitting down to put them on. Once he’d finished lacing them up, he stood up and found Katsuki looking at him, most of his uniform already in place.

“Everything fit okay?”

Izuku walked around a bit, and then nodded.

The next article was something like a sash, with some pockets and compartments built in, and then something that went around his waist and reminded Izuku of a cummerbund. With those secured, he moved on to the armor, which was light and consisted of shoulder guards and vambraces. Katsuki helped him get the shoulder guards on, and from there, the vambraces were simple enough.

Standing up straight, Izuku examined himself.

“Think you can move around okay?” Katsuki asked.

Izuku lifted his arms and each leg, testing his range of motion. “I think so.”

“Y’sure?” He raised an eyebrow. “‘Cuz if there’s somethin’ that doesn’t fit right, now’s your only chance to get a replacement.”

Izuku walked around a bit more, and then nodded. “No, I think it all fits properly.”

Katsuki looked him up and down one last time before offering a short nod of his own. “Alright, good. Grab your stuff. We’ll leave it at the front.”

With that, Izuku grabbed the box and followed Katsuki out of the locker room, handing their boxes off to be stored in the same stack from which they came.

It was around twenty minutes until four, and the launch point was on the roof of the building. As they headed out into the hall, moving toward the stairwell, Izuku spotted many people milling about, some in uniform, but many more not.

People saying goodbye to their loved ones, he realized. *Because they know they might not make it back alive.*

Izuku swallowed the nausea rising in his throat, speeding up toward the stairs.

It was a cloudy night, thunder rumbling on the horizon, vibrating the walls of the stairwell as they steadily ascended.

The door to the rooftop was built from heavy steel, the metal cold against his palms as he held it open. Out on the roof, a sizable crowd was starting to accumulate, and at the center of it all were Luke, Levi and Bee, dressed similarly to the two of them, but fully shifted. While Luke’s horns were similar to Katsuki’s, Levi’s were more akin to those of a longhorn, and Bee’s were an odd, vertical coil.

Izuku gulped. He’d held off on shifting up until then, but now that they were up there, he knew he couldn’t delay it much longer. And so, with a sigh, he relaxed, wings emerging from his shoulder blades as his antlers extended through his hair. He looked around and flushed when he caught a couple of people looking at him, his body curling inward.

Katsuki laced his fingers through Izuku’s, prompting him to look up at him. Katsuki smiled and leaned down, brushing his bangs aside to plant a small kiss on his forehead. “Pretty boy.” He murmured, sending shivers down his spine.

Squeezing tighter, Katsuki led him toward the center of the rooftop, catching the Originals’ eyes. Levi and Luke both nodded, while Bee smiled and waved.

A few minutes passed as the others all got situated, and then Levi raised a hand in the air, requesting silence. Luke’s head appeared above the crowd as he stepped up onto a crate, which placed him at about the same height as Levi.

“Has everyone found their marks? If not, do speak up so that we may assist you.” When no one said anything after a moment, Luke nodded and continued. “Good. Alright, it’s about ten minutes until four, so I’ll make this quick.

“The mission ahead of us is a dangerous one indeed. I want to commend all of you for your bravery in volunteering to participate. That said, if anyone has changed their mind and wishes to back out, you may do so now without fear of judgement.” He paused for a moment, looking around.

“Are you all certain?” He asked. “If you’re at all hesitant, please back out now. I cannot guarantee your safety if you opt to do so during the actual mission. Getting home will not be simple. If you choose to go with us, you must be committed to seeing the mission through until the end.”

He waited another moment, and after a few seconds, Izuku heard shuffling. Two people, a man and a woman Izuku didn’t recognize, made their way out of the crowd, their heads bowed. Their departure spurred three others to join them, and the five of them all gathered near the door. Luke nodded at them.

“Very good.” He said. “If that’s everyone, then we shall prepare for departure.”

Katsuki squeezed his hand. Izuku looked up, and found him staring down at him. He mouthed, *‘Are you sure?’*

Izuku took a deep breath, trying to calm his racing heart. He gave Katsuki’s hand a returning squeeze, and nodded.

They turned their attention back toward the center.

“Are we ready?” Luke called out, raising his fist in the air. Everyone else did the same, the crowd rumbling with excitement. Luke grinned. “Tonight we will shed our chains once and for all. As Heaven falls, we shall see fire in the clouds.”

Izuku gripped Katsuki’s hand tighter as Luke opened his fist, reaching for the sky. Clouds began to congregate above them, swirling around like a vortex. Violet lightning flashed through, like cracks in the sky.

And in one swift movement, Luke slammed his palm flat on the ground, and lightning struck, all along the perimeter of the crowd. Everything was violet, and then everything was white. Izuku closed his eyes against the bright light.

When he opened them again, they were standing inside a dimly lit room which appeared to be an empty cafeteria. All around them, groups began to move, splitting off in different directions. The Originals were gone before Izuku even got a chance to see them.

As their group began to move, Katsuki clutched his hand and pulled him along with them, breaking him out of his momentary stupor.

They entered into a long, empty corridor, but their destination was near.

Remember the plan, he told himself.

As they approached the two double doors, he recalled the way Levi had leaned over the map, moving pins from place to place.

"Right off the bat, two things need to happen at once." He'd said. "The first is we need to sedate the sleeping Acolytes and restrain them. The Sloth team will be our key to achieving that." He moved the blue pin over the Acolyte's dormitory. "The second is that we need to barricade the Cleanser's tower." He moved the orange pin over to a circular section on the opposite side. "He's too dangerous to engage. We should try to keep him ignorant for as long as possible, or at least contained. Thankfully, a similar procedure shouldn't be necessary for the Violator, as he's generally kept sedated anyway."

When they entered the dormitory, the Sloth team was already there. The first thing Izuku noticed was just how freezing cold it was. Nemuri and six others paced up and down the aisles, keeping the Acolytes sedated throughout the commotion.

As they entered the main area, someone handed them both three lengths of rope each, and Katsuki took the lead, approaching the nearest bunk bed and shoving the unconscious Acolyte onto his stomach. He handed Izuku a length of rope and moved to the adjacent bed, similarly pushing the man onto his stomach before throwing Izuku a look. "Follow what I do." He said.

As Katsuki climbed up onto the bed and straddled the man's knees, Izuku did the same. He pulled the seal off the rope with his teeth, revealing that it was actually two separate lengths of rope. Katsuki set one aside and unraveled the other before folding it in half.

Moving slowly enough for Izuku to replicate his movements, Katsuki proceeded to grab the Acolyte's hands and pull them together. Holding the folded rope behind his wrists, he pulled the loose ends through the loop, tightened it, and then started wrapping it around his wrists in the opposite direction, creating another loop that he once again pulled the loose ends through. From there, he wrapped the rope around the center and tied sort of a slipknot, securing the two separate cuffs, with a substantial length of rope leftover.

As Izuku finished the knot, Katsuki leaned over and checked his work. Confirming he'd done it correctly, Katsuki scooted down the mattress and folded the Acolyte's legs up at the knees, and proceeded to tie them in a similar manner, glancing over every so often to make sure Izuku was following along. With the man's ankles firmly locked together, Katsuki proceeded to pull the excess rope from the wrist cuffs around the center of the ankle bonds, securing them with a square knot. After checking the tightness of his own work, Katsuki stood up and, again, checked Izuku's work, tugging on it a bit before nodding in satisfaction.

He looked at Izuku and raised an eyebrow. "That all make sense?"

"I… yeah, I think so."

"Good." Katsuki handed him another coil of rope and climbed up onto the top bunk as Izuku did the same.

He had to go a bit slowly, but the idea was simple enough for Izuku to manage it on his own. Still, by the time he was finished with the man's wrists, he was surprised to find that Katsuki had already moved onto his third Acolyte, and by the time he'd completed the full hog tie, Katsuki was already halfway through his fourth.

Izuku hopped off the bunk bed and approached Katsuki's side, watching as he deftly secured the man's wrists to his ankles, like it was second nature to him, as easy as tying one's shoes. Katsuki bit one end of the rope as he pulled the other, tightening it.

"How'd you get so good at this…?" Izuku asked.

Katsuki smirked, rope still caught between his teeth. Satisfied with its tightness, he tucked in the loose ends before finally looking up at Izuku, a playful glint in his eye. "I'll explain later."

There were around two-hundred Acolytes in the room and about fifty Demons. With most people working continuously, it took about twenty minutes to get everyone restrained. By then Izuku had managed to tie up three people, while Katsuki had gotten through sixteen. Izuku was relieved to finally get out of the freezing room, but also nervous.

Their real mission was only just beginning.

"Once the Acolytes are restrained, Bakugou and Midoriya will break away from the Containment group," Levi moved the green pin over to the room where the trapdoor Izuku had found was located. "And start searching for a way to get the hatch open."

Katsuki forced open the door to a small office attached to the dormitory and proceeded to ransack the area, pulling open drawers and cabinets and tossing aside anything that didn't look useful. Izuku did the same, though he was a bit less haphazard about it. But in the end, they didn't find anything useful there.

"What should we do?" Izuku asked.

Sighing, Katsuki leaned back against the desk, looking up in thought. After a second, he straightened up, and ran back into the dormitory, grabbing the nearest Acolyte. He lifted the man by the rope connecting his wrists to his ankles in a way that made Izuku wince, and unceremoniously tossed him into the office room before shutting the door behind him. Without the direct influence of the Sloth Demons' power, the man soon began to stir, pulling against his bonds and then tensing up as he seemed to recognize his predicament. He started to struggle, muffled sounds of distress slipping out behind the duct tape.

Approaching slowly, Katsuki dropped to a squat beside him and placed a hand over his throat. "I'm gonna take the tape off, and you're gonna shut the fuck up and behave, or you're dead. Got it?"

After a moment of shocked hesitation, the man nodded.

"Are you sure?" Katsuki pressed. "'Cuz there's about two hundred other bastards tied up just like you. If you step outta line, I can easily just kill you and swap you out for someone more

cooperative. Are we fucking clear?"

The man nodded more emphatically.

Katsuki smiled. "Good." And with that, he proceeded to rip the duct tape off the man's mouth, sticking it to the edge of the desk. He gasped for air, and Katsuki kept a tight grip on his throat.

"Please don't hurt me." He blurted out.

"If you answer my question, I won't have to." Katsuki said. "Where's the key to the hatch?"

"The… the what?"

"The hatch." Katsuki tightened his grip just a little. "Y'know, *'New Hell,'* or whatever you're callin' it these days. The dark pit where you throw all the undesirables."

"Oh." He said. "I-It's behind the painting. The one near the door?"

Katsuki glanced over at Izuku. "Go see if he's right."

Izuku nodded, swiftly exiting the small room and jogging over to the exit. Sure enough, he found a painting beside the entrance, and when he took it off the hook, there was a small, embedded cavity beneath, with three similar looking keys. Izuku took all of them, and returned to the room.

"Find anything?" Katsuki asked.

Izuku nodded, showing him the keys. "There were three, though. Which one is it?"

Katsuki tightened his hand around his throat. "Well?"

"Th-They're all the same," he said. "We… We have copies, just in case one gets lost."

Grinning in satisfaction, Katsuki grabbed the piece of tape off the edge of the desk. "What's your name?" He asked.

"Um." The man hesitated. "Lars…?"

"Lars, huh." Katsuki patted his cheek condescendingly. "Thanks for your help, Lars."

With that, he sealed the tape back over his mouth and hoisted the man up by the rope again. He released a muffled yelp of pain as Katsuki hauled him out of the room, depositing him on his bed again. The man's struggles soon slowed down though, until he fell unconscious once again.

Katsuki glance at Izuku over his shoulder with a look that said, *'ready?'*

Izuku nodded, and the two of them headed out.

It was half-past four in the morning, and the halls were mercifully empty, save for the occasional stray Acolyte, who were generally too shocked to put up much of a fight before Katsuki had them in a choke hold, one hand over their mouth. They'd kick and struggle for a good two minutes or so before falling limp, but other than the time it took to subdue and hide them, it was a lot easier than Izuku expected it to be. Though he assumed that was just because it was Katsuki, and they had the advantage of surprising them.

They were halfway to their destination when they passed a familiar door, and Izuku came to a stop.

"Deku?"

"This is it," Izuku whispered. "This is where the Demon was."

"Oh, shit." Katsuki whispered back.

"Should we…?"

After thinking about it a moment, Katsuki nodded once, and twisted the knob, entering the dark room. They shut the door behind them, just in case, and flicked on the light.

It was just as Izuku remembered it.

He didn't think he'd feel this way.

As he stared at the enormous steel vat situated in front of the chair, as his eyes flickered over the large lockers lining the room, he was suddenly paralyzed, hit with an overwhelming wave of nausea.

"Yeah, looks like the padlocks are—" He faltered. "Deku?"

Izuku couldn't really hear him, his voice was muffled, as though they were underwater. He *could* hear his own heartbeat, however. He could hear the sound of his accelerated breaths as his lungs fought to suck air through a constricting throat.

A second later, Katsuki was in front of him, his palms flat against the sides of his face, lips moving as though he were telling him to look at him. With shaky hands, he reached up and gripped Katsuki's wrists for stability. Katsuki looked like he was asking him something, but Izuku's mind wasn't in the moment anymore.

It felt like he was back there again.

He could *hear* the *sounds.*

Gritting his teeth, Katsuki tore away and all but dove to the floor, grabbing a padlock and melting it off. He worked quickly, ripping away molten metal until the floor was fully unlocked, patted it twice, and then swiftly pulled Izuku outside. He guided him into a small nook just around the corner. Izuku didn't realize he was crying until he felt Katsuki wiping his tears away.

After a few minutes, Izuku's breathing slowed down, and his heart stopped hammering into his chest so hard.

"S-Sorry," he wheezed.

"It's fine." Katsuki said. "Are you alright? You look like you just saw a fucking ghost, Deku."

"I just… didn't expect it. When we went in, I just… remembered, and…"

Katsuki's features softened, and he pulled him into his chest.

"I'm sorry." Izuku repeated.

"Quit apologizing, I told you it's fine." Katsuki mumbled. After a moment, he pulled back, looking around. "But we should get going. Are you good?"

Izuku swallowed, and nodded. He was still anxious, but not a whole lot more than he had been at the start of the mission.

"Are you sure?"

Izuku took a deep breath and exhaled slowly. "Yeah, I'm sure."

And with that, they were off.

They arrived at their destination just barely on time, and Izuku panted lightly as they made their way into the chamber. It was just as he'd remembered it, though thankfully, this fact didn't trigger another panic attack.

Running up to the hatch, Izuku immediately spotted the keyhole at the center. He glanced over at Katsuki as he handed him the key.

Izuku dropped to a crouch in front of the hatch and nervously slid the key into the lock, closing his eyes as he turned it.

It clicked, and a rush of relief ran through him. Without opening it, he stood up, catching the respirator Katsuki had tossed his way and carefully securing it on his head. It was a bit of a challenge with his antlers, but he eventually managed.

Izuku sighed, and without any further delay, he bent down and grabbed the handle. It was a bit heavier than he expected, and he struggled a bit, but just when Katsuki was about to step in and take his place, the hatch popped open.

Izuku was half expecting to see hundreds of people inside, packed together like sardines. But when he looked down into the pit, he saw only darkness. Katsuki clapped his hands and manifested an orb of light, just as he'd done in the Depths, and lowered it into the hole.

The light revealed a short tunnel of sorts, made of a hard, net-like material, similar to that of a chainlink fence. The cylinder extended around ten feet down, and was itself enclosed within a larger cylinder. Together, the two cylinders formed a sort of annulus, which appeared to have a floor.

Katsuki continued to lower the orb, but beyond that initial shaft, they found nothing but darkness.

Izuku leaned in deeper, until almost half his body was inside. “Can you see anything?”

“Nope.” He muttered. “You?”

“No…” With a sigh, Izuku pulled himself out of the pit. “…What is this?” He asked, pointing at the walls surrounding the cylinder.

“Not sure.” Katsuki murmured. “Kinda looks like an elevator, or somethin’.” He pointed out a panel on the far outer wall, housing only a single lever, which was currently in the ‘up’ position. “Dunno how we’re supposed to access it, though…”

Izuku frowned, searching for clues, but the whole structure was so weird and unfamiliar, he wasn’t even sure what to look for.

“…How deep do you think it goes?”

“Dunno.” Katsuki said.

Izuku bit his lip, and suddenly, he got an idea. “Do you have a coin?”

Katsuki turned and looked at him, his expression blank. It hit Izuku a few seconds later.

“Oh!” He squeaked, laughing awkwardly. “Uhh, right.”

No monetary system. Of course.

“W-Well, do you have anything small? Like, maybe a rock…?” He asked. “Just something we’d hear hit the bottom.”

Katsuki’s eyes widened as he realized what he was getting at. He started patting at his pants pockets until finally he found something: it was a half-melted padlock, one Izuku suspected must’ve come from the Demon’s enclosure.

Izuku cocked his head. “You… held onto that? Why?”

Katsuki shrugged. “Was tryin’ to get out quickly. It got stuck to my hand, so I just shoved it in my pocket. Figured it was better than leavin’ it out in the hallway where someone might find it.”

“Ah, right.” Izuku nodded, taking the padlock from his hands. “Well… let’s see, then.” He held it over the hole, then dropped it.

They waited.

And *waited.*

Ten seconds became twenty, half a minute became a full minute, and by that point, Izuku was beginning to think it truly was a bottomless pit.

“Is… Is it still falling?”

“Maybe. But at this point, I doubt we’d even hear it hit the bottom.”

“God.” Izuku muttered. “How are we supposed to get anyone out of this?”

“Imagine the first step would be figuring out how the fuck we get into this part.” He grabbed the netting surrounding the tunnel, and then stood up. They shut the hatch and looked at the surrounding area, and it didn’t take long for them to realize what they’d been missing.

There were seven additional keyholes, all evenly spaced around the perimeter of the hatch.

Immediately, Izuku tried sticking the key into one of them, but it wouldn’t turn. He tried the other two keys, but just like the first, they also didn’t work.

For each keyhole, they tried all three keys, but in the end, they had nothing to show for it.

Izuku sighed, standing up and crossing his arms. “What should we do?”

Katsuki hummed, seeming to think it over for a moment. Then, he dropped to a squat again and placed his hands on the hatch. Izuku could see his palms starting to glow as he heated them up, muscles flexing as he pressed down, attempting to melt through the material. But whatever it was, it was not budging. When Katsuki finally pulled his hands away, the surface was as smooth and unblemished as it had been before.

Katsuki grabbed one of the keys, opening the central hatch again and lowering his upper body into it. He grabbed the metallic netting and shook it, then tried to melt through it as well, but just like before, the metal was not budging. With a groan, he pulled himself out and forcefully shut the hatch, yanking his respirator off and tossing it to the side. He kicked the edge of the hatch. “The fuck is this shit made of, anyway?”

Izuku frowned, removing his respirator as well. He tapped the concrete with his foot. “We could try breaking through the floor…?”

“That’d just put us outside of it. It’s probably all made from the same shit.”

Izuku wrung his wrists. “I guess we could just… fly to the bottom?”

Katsuki raked a hand through his hair. “I mean… I guess,” he said. “But we don’t know how deep it is. The bottom could be, like, fifty miles down, Deku.”

After a moment of silence, Katsuki sighed. “If it comes to it, we can try. But I think we should see if we can figure out what the fuck is going on with these other locks first.”

Izuku nodded. “Sounds—“ He froze, turning toward the door. He thought he heard something. “Did you…?”

The door burst open, and both of them jumped away, backing up into the far end of the room. Izuku’s heart leapt into his throat when the first Acolyte came in. But he wasn’t alone.

One by one, they all piled in, and it seemed there was no end to them. By the time the last one came through the door, there were around fifteen or so Acolytes in total, all forming a small crowd on the opposite side of the chamber

Izuku was gonna be sick.

“Shit. *Shit,* get behind me.” Katsuki hissed.

“K-Kacchan.”

“I know.” Katsuki said, coming to stand in front of him.

But just when it seemed things couldn’t possibly get any worse, someone else entered.

A flash of red and gold silk made his blood run cold. The man stepped forward, and his face came into view. Izuku looked on in terror and confusion.

Councilman three.

The Commander.

But… wasn’t Bee supposed to take care of him?

*Where **is** he?*

The Commander raised a hand and pointed at them. His command was short, simple, and terrifying.

“Attack.”

The Acolytes tore off their blindfolds, and the room flooded with red light.

Katsuki ran ahead, his head ducked down to avoid looking any of them in the eye as they lunged, unsheathing blades from beneath their cloaks.

With a burning hand, Katsuki caught the first one’s wrist. The Acolyte yelped in pain, dagger clattering to the ground. Maintaining his hold, Katsuki yanked him forward and all but threw him into another one, sending both of them stumbling to the ground in a heap. Katsuki snatched the dagger off the floor and threw it hard, sheathing it in the head of the Acolyte on top. The one underneath tried to get up, but Katsuki got there faster. With one efficient stomp, he crushed his skull against the concrete.

A third Acolyte managed to slip past him and was heading straight for Izuku. Katsuki spun around and caught the man by the back of his cloak, yanking him toward him. The man

flailed, and managed to cut Katsuki's arm with his knife just before he grabbed hold of his head and twisted sharply, breaking his neck in one clean movement.

And as the man crumpled to the floor in front of him, Izuku finally sprung into action.

He kept his eyes locked on the ground, focusing on the movement of the Acolytes' feet as he strode forward, visualizing chewing gum. Flinging out a sticky tendril, he managed to catch one by the ankle, using it to fling him away. He hit the wall head first, then fell to the floor with a groan. And he sat there, clutching his head—for now.

As another one came at him, Katsuki leapt behind him, feet skidding to a stop.

"Dodge!"

Izuku barely had time to react before Katsuki was punching the Acolyte in the back of the skull, hard enough to send him flying toward him. He jumped out of the way just in time, and the man hit the wall behind him, unconscious.

Izuku wasn't sure how many were left, but it felt like too many.

An Acolyte managed to sneak up on Katsuki, grabbing him by the hair and attempting to force his head up, to make him look him in the eye. Katsuki gritted his teeth, hands flying to the Acolyte's head. He only looked up once he had his thumbs over his eyes. The Acolyte released a blood-curdling scream as Katsuki dug his claws in, reflexively reaching for his face as his eyes bled profusely. He crumpled to the ground, palms pressed against the wounds.

Another man came up behind Izuku, and as he felt his arms closing in, Izuku released heat from his soul, making it freeze over just in time. He felt the cold press of a blade against his throat, but all that came of it was a small scrape. Izuku grabbed his arms and sharply bent down, closing his eyes as he flipped the Acolyte onto his back. He slammed his boot down on his neck a few times. It wasn't as powerful as when Katsuki did it, but it did the job.

He saw another man running toward him, and still partially bent over, he tried to head butt him. Except his head never actually touched him. He felt himself hitting something solid as the man cried out in pain. Straining his eyes to look up, he could see blood soaking through the white fabric of his cloak. It was only then that he realized what happened—that he'd actually *stabbed the man with one of his antlers.*

Izuku tried to lift his head, but couldn't. Realizing the Acolyte was still conscious, still *holding his dagger,* he panicked, and drove his antler deeper, though not before the man managed to get a few good gashes on his arm.

As the man went limp and fell down, Izuku fell along with him, wincing as he struggled to dislodge his antler. He finally managed it, specks of blood flying as he ripped his head back. He tried to get up, but wasn't quick enough.

Another Acolyte tackled him, pinning him to the ground. Izuku struggled beneath him, eyes squeezed shut. He clumsily launched a breath attack, and felt specks of saliva hit his skin as

the man buckled over, coughing violently

As Izuku scrambled out from under him, his tailbone hit the ledge of the hatch. He pushed himself over its smooth surface, heart lurching when he realized the man was still coming, even as he hacked and wheezed.

Izuku patted the ground for a knife, but the only one he saw was the one in the man's hand.

In a split second decision, Izuku yanked open the hatch and visualized chewing gum, catching the man with a sticky tendril and hauling him toward the opening, trying to force him inside. The Acolyte seemed to realize what he was doing at the last second, grasping at the edges before he could fall. Izuku launched a second breath attack, but the man held on, quite literally for dear life. Gritting his teeth, Izuku stomped on his fingers, forcing him to let go of the ledge. He fell partway down the shaft, but managed to catch the netting before he could fall into the abyss below.

Izuku tried to close the door, but something obstructed him. An unconscious Acolyte's leg had fallen over the edge, keeping it from closing. Izuku darted over, struggling to pull the dead weight away. When he finally managed to haul him out of the way, he glanced up just in time to watch Katsuki snap the last Acolyte's neck, his face splattered in blood that was not his own.

Katsuki ran toward him, looking down when he heard the Acolyte below, still coughing even as he climbed up the shaft. He closed the distance, jumping behind the hatch. And as the Acolyte's head emerged, Katsuki dealt the final blow, slamming the trap door down on his head with a sickening *crack.*

The man instantly went limp, letting go and sliding down, falling into the infinite darkness below.

Katsuki kicked the hatch shut once and for all.

For a moment, the two of them just stood there, panting. Izuku looked around nervously, searching for any signs of movement, but finding none.

"Are you okay?" Katsuki asked, under his breath.

Izuku surveyed his injuries. The cuts on his arm would require attention at some point, but that point didn't have to be right now. Izuku nodded. "Are you?"

Katsuki just shrugged. "Nothing a shower wouldn't fix."

He shifted his attention to the Commander, who stood in the shadows on the far side of the room. Katsuki grinned, wiping blood off his cheek as he took a step forward.

"All your minions are down." He shouted. "What now, bastard?"

"What now?" The Councilman parroted, stepping out of the shadows. "I suppose now the fun *really* begins."

Katsuki scoffed, “Fuck’s that supposed to… actually, no. I don’t care. You’re fucking dead.” He lunged, fist connecting hard with his jaw. The Councilman was sent flying back into the wall behind him. He grunted in pain as his spine collided with it, but managed to stay standing. That was alright, though.

He knew Katsuki would rectify that shortly.

But as he closed in, the man righted himself, cracking his neck and fixing him with a wide grin.

“Stop.” The Commander barked.

Katsuki immediately halted in his tracks, and Izuku’s blood ran cold.

He could see Katsuki struggling, body shaking as he tried to will himself to move. “See, that’s where you went wrong.” He said, striding over at a leisurely pace. “It’s true that my power didn’t *always* work on Demons. But it’s been a long time since those traitors Fell, you know. A lot can change in that kind of time.

“These days, I can control just about anyone, so long as I’ve touched them at least once.” He reached out and poked his cheek, and Katsuki snarled. “Of course, I wouldn’t expect you to know that. Beelzebub made the exact same mistake, after all.”

At the sound of Bee’s name, Izuku tensed. “What did you do to him?!”

“Do to him?” The Councilman looked over at him and scoffed. “I didn’t *do* anything to him. See, that’s the difference between you Demons and us. Up here, we actually *value* a little thing called personal responsibility. Beelzebub chose to attack me. If he ends up doing something *regrettable* because of it, that’s really no one’s fault but his own, and the same goes for you.” He smiled at Katsuki again.

“‘Something regrettable’?” Katsuki spat. “The fuck’s that supposed to mean?”

He hummed. “Oh, it could mean all sorts of things, honestly. Starting a fight you can’t win… or perhaps one you don’t *want* to win.”

In an instant, all the color drained from Katsuki’s face.

The Councilman grinned wider, eyes beginning to glow.

And as he locked eyes with Katsuki, the Commander pointed at Izuku. The gesture sent a spike of terror through Izuku’s veins, but it was nothing compared to what he said next.

“Kill him.”

It was like a gunshot, ringing in his ears. Izuku’s body went cold, and for a moment, time stood still. He felt like he was standing outside of himself, watching as Katsuki turned toward him.

Slowly, Izuku put his hands up, backing away cautiously. “K-Kacchan…?”

He studied Katsuki's form—his pale, anguished face, clenched jaw, trembling muscles. And he could see every fiber of his being fighting back against the Commander's order.

It wasn't enough.

"Deku…" He said, voice but a quiet wheeze. "*Run."*

Katsuki lunged.

He managed to leap out of the way just in time, nearly tripping over his own feet as he landed.

"Bastard!" Katsuki screamed—strangled, fearful *fury.* His entire body shook, muscles cramping and straining as he struggled. But it was no use. The Councilman's power didn't work like a Lust Demon's did; it wasn't something one could simply *resist.*

And so Katsuki came running at him again, winding up a punch. Izuku braced himself, soul freezing over in preparation for the blow. But as his fist collided with his jaw, Izuku instantly felt the difference in his intent—a wake up call he should not have needed.

Because this wasn't like their sparring matches. Katsuki wasn't fighting to win.

He was fighting to *kill.*

As the punch landed, Izuku felt something crack. The force of the hit sent him flying back into the wall, and his frozen soul shattered upon impact. Pain bloomed throughout his body, radiating from his jaw and back, but despite the break in his shield, it still managed to absorb most of the shock.

He had survived the first hit, but he might not survive the next.

Gritting his teeth, Izuku got up, shards of his soul coalescing together again. He visualized chewing gum, shot a strand up at the ceiling and pulled himself up just before Katsuki closed in. He dangled there, over twenty feet off the ground, his mind racing as he racked his brain for something, *anything* he could use to escape. Katsuki leapt high into the air, reaching for his ankle as Izuku swung from the ceiling, flinging himself to the other side of the chamber. He landed clumsily on the ground and glanced at the door—the only way out of the room. But the Commander was blocking it, a smug grin on his face.

As much as he wanted to just make a run for it, he knew he couldn't. If he got too close, he'd risk coming in contact with the Commander. If the man touched him, he was as good as dead.

Katsuki shot at him, and Izuku watched his fist fly past his face in slow motion as he narrowly dodged the hit. Katsuki's body was still shaking, still trying to fight it. It dampened his precision a little bit, but nowhere near enough.

Shooting a tendril at the opposite wall, Izuku threw himself across the room again, glancing at the hatch as he passed it.

…Should he?

Izuku looked around, scanning the mass of fallen Acolytes. He'd set his respirator down before they came in, and in the heat of battle, he'd failed to keep track of it. It was as good as lost. Izuku glanced at the hatch again, jaw clenching. If he went down there, got a good whiff of the gas, he wouldn't be able to protect himself. Within minutes, all his senses would go dark… but so would Katsuki's.

Was it worth the gamble?

He wasn't sure. But he didn't have any other options.

Izuku dodged another attack and dove toward the center of the room, landing near the hatch. He dashed toward it, lunging for the handle.

Someone grabbed his ankle.

Izuku yelped and fell forward, head snapping down. One of the Acolytes—the one who'd lost his eyes—was still conscious, it seemed. Running on pure adrenaline, Izuku yanked his foot free and scrambled over the hatch. He got ahold of the handle, and was about to pull it open.

But Katsuki got there first.

He landed in a pool of someone else's blood, and could feel it soaking into his clothing as his back hit the ground. Izuku quickly released heat from his soul, allowing it to freeze over, but he knew he was only delaying the inevitable. He was on top of him a second later, and as his face came into focus, Izuku felt his heart breaking.

Katsuki was crying, bloodstained cheeks streaked with tears.

Izuku struggled beneath him, tears welling up in his eyes as well, but it was no use. Katsuki had him pinned.

"Deku…" He choked. His voice had never sounded so small as it did then, when he slid his fingers into his hair, grabbing onto the roots, holding tight. *"I'm sorry."*

Then he slammed Izuku's head against the concrete floor. Izuku felt his soul crack. He tried to push more heat out, hoping to mend the fracture. It wasn't working, and Katsuki was pulling him up by his hair once more.

"I'm sorry." Katsuki repeated. He rammed his head into the hard floor again. Another crack, and this time the pain managed to seep through. The pattern continued, new fractures appearing with every hit, each one more painful than the last, weakening his defense that much more. "I'm sorry. *I'm sorry."*

"I-It's okay, Kacchan. It's not your fault."

Katsuki sobbed harder. Wet droplets hit Izuku's cheeks. By the fifth hit, Izuku was starting to get dizzy. "I'm sorry, I'm sorry, *I'm so fucking sorry, Izuku."*

Those words hurt more than the blows to his head ever could.

“It’s okay, it’s okay.” Izuku repeated, tears sliding down his cheeks. “I love you, Kacchan. I love you.”

He said it even as Katsuki slammed his skull into the concrete, and at last, Izuku felt his defense shatter, leaving him completely vulnerable. And he could see it in Katsuki’s eyes; he knew.

With trembling hands, Katsuki pulled him up by his hair again.

Izuku knew this was it.

Katsuki tightened his hold on his hair. This would be the last blow.

But in those final moments, his life didn’t flash before his eyes. It didn’t need to, because it was already right there in front of him, sobbing as he fruitlessly fought against the power possessing him. Izuku did not think of himself. As he gazed up into Katsuki’s anguished eyes, all he could do was hope that he could heal from this. That if he somehow managed to get out of here alive, he wouldn’t spend the rest of his days blaming himself for what he’d been forced to do.

Izuku reached up weakly, covering Katsuki’s hands with his own. Not trying to stop him—just holding on.

“Izuku, *baby,* I’m *sorry.* I love you. *I love you.”*

“I know. I love you too.”

Izuku resisted the impulse to close his eyes.

He wanted to stay with Katsuki until the end.

But just as he was about to slam his head into the concrete, Katsuki suddenly went still, his grip loosening as he turned and looked to his left. His jaw dropped.

Disoriented, Izuku winced as he followed his gaze.

And when he saw what Katsuki saw, his eyes nearly bulged out of his skull.

Because there, standing in the doorway, was the sixth Councilman—the Councilman of Humility.

The Violator.

Kindred.

Izuku didn’t recognize him at first; he wasn’t dressed in the typical silk robes, but rather a set of wrinkled, blue pajamas. But as his vision focused, as he saw that gaunt face, that light hair, those dark eyes—there was no doubt that this was the same boy he’d seen in his dreams.

Izuku felt a surge of adrenaline, his muddled brain staggering to accommodate his sudden, racing thoughts.

Why is he here? Who woke him up? What does he want?

But he didn't have time to really think those questions through, because almost as soon as they came, Izuku noticed something else.

There was something… *different* about him.

His body lacked the tension he'd seen before, and he was looking around the room, head tilted with a sort of childish curiosity. When his gaze eventually settled on the Commander, his eyes were startlingly lucid.

And the Commander was pale as a ghost.

Izuku's brain finally caught up, then.

Oh, he realized. *That's the difference.*

He's free.

"Who…" the Commander whispered. Then Kindred's hands twitched at his sides. Eyes wide with panic, the Commander opened his mouth. *"Sto—"*

He never got a chance to finish.

Because in that split second, Kindred had extended an arm toward him, hand open at first, but promptly curling into a fist. In place of words, only a flat, choking sound came from the Commander's throat. He covered his mouth and buckled over with a muffled scream.

Deep red seeped between Kindred's fingers, and he slowly opened his hand, revealing something small and bloody. He plucked it up between the fingers of his other hand and brought it closer to his face, turning it this way and that, examining it with childlike curiosity.

It was only after the blood began pouring out of the Commander's mouth, with a cacophony of inarticulate cries, that Izuku realized what it was.

His tongue.

"Wow." Kindred said, his voice soft. "I didn't know I could do that…"

As the Commander kneeled on the ground choking on his own blood, Kindred turned his attention toward the two of them, and Izuku's heart lurched into his throat. Looking straight at Katsuki, he reached out and repeated the action, hand curling into a fist.

Izuku felt Katsuki tense up above him, but when Kindred opened his hand, there was nothing there.

“Aww. Wonder why it didn’t work that time…” He stared down at his hand, brows pinching together. After a second, he shrugged. “Oh well.” He turned toward the Commander again, approaching him. “You can have it back,” he said, before bending down and gently placing the Commander’s tongue on the ground in front of him.

The Commander opened his mouth, more blood spilling out as he tried to speak, but all that came out were garbled cries as Kindred stood before him, studying him as though he were a particularly interesting science experiment.

“Hmm…” He tilted his head. “This probably won’t work, but…”

With both hands, he reached out, palms hovering around the Commander’s head. And Izuku watched, petrified, as his skin began to bubble and swell.

“Shit. *Shit!”* Katsuki hissed. And suddenly, he was sweeping him up into his arms. “Hold your breath!”

That was the only warning he got before Katsuki yanked the hatch open and leapt inside. The Commander started screaming, and Izuku could hear the sound of flesh popping. He held his breath, grabbing onto the netting as the hatch slammed shut above them. They heard the explosion mere seconds later. The sound was muffled, and immediately followed by a burst of divine light that glowed around the edges of the hatch.

Izuku heard a couple more popping noises as the light died down.

And then, silence.

The two of them dangled from the shaft in limbo, cheeks puffed out as they held their breath. Izuku’s lungs were burning, but just when he thought he couldn’t take it any longer, he heard the faint sound of the door opening, and then closing again.

Katsuki opened the hatch a crack, eyes going wide as he looked around. He hesitated for a moment before opening it completely, allowing them both to climb out.

Izuku gasped for breath, and then froze.

He struggled to make sense of what he was seeing.

The Commander’s body was everywhere and nowhere all at once, strewn about the chamber in splatters of blood and viscera. There was a pile of clothing where he used to be, saturated in deep red, with bits of flesh and bone clinging to the fabric. Izuku took one step forward, and felt something round and rubbery beneath his shoe.

He picked up his foot and realized it was one of his eyes.

That was the last push he needed. His stomach twisted violently as he stumbled toward the wall and heaved. The ache in the back of his skull came into focus in that moment, as the bile burned his throat. Katsuki was at his side a second later, brushing his hair back and stroking up and down his spine.

As his stomach emptied, Izuku gasped for air. He was going to wipe his mouth with the back of his hand, but it was caked in blood and filth. Izuku realized, with an unexpected surge of anxiety, that he couldn't find a single spot clean enough to wipe his mouth. As the bile dried out his lips, he began to hyperventilate.

"Hey, hey, wait. It's okay," Katsuki murmured, reaching into one of his many pockets. He pulled out what looked like a packet of wet wipes, and coaxed Izuku over to the far end of the room—one of the few spots left that was mostly untouched by the carnage. Izuku slid down the wall as Katsuki kneeled beside him, starting to wipe his mouth. With a different part of the wipe, he gently cleaned the rest of his face. Izuku relaxed slightly as he worked, closing his eyes.

"Don't pass out." Katsuki said.

Izuku sighed, opening his eyes again. He leaned his head back, staring up at the ceiling. For a minute, he was quiet. "We should probably warn the others. I don't know what that power was, but if someone runs into him, it's not going to end well."

Katsuki nodded, and reached for his walkie-talkie. But before he could grab it, the door swung open again, and Katsuki reflexively stood up, spinning around. His wings extended outward, shielding Izuku as someone else walked in. He peered under his wing, saw the man's white and gold uniform. An Acolyte.

Katsuki's palms heated up, sparking to life as he adjusted his stance, preparing to attack. But to Izuku's shock, the Acolyte put his hands up in the air.

"Wait." He said, voice deep and firm. "Please, I don't wish to fight you."

Izuku's eyes went wide. He *knew* that voice.

He forced himself upright, and staggered out from behind Katsuki.

"...Endeavor?"

Chapter End Notes

tfw u think ur opponents powers wont work on u but then they do. just lil oopsie whoopsie

my plan was originally to end the chapter right after the commander said "kill him" because i revel in chaos and the only reason i didn't do it is because i just really wanted to finally introduce best boy, kindred. i love he. well that and to avoid disrupting the pacing too much lol.

anyway, yeeeeeahhhh, fucking graphic violence, graphic suffering, graphic everything. this isn't even the final battle lmao, that's next chapter. but uhhhhh yes. thanks for

reading! if you liked this, pls consider leaving a comment to appease the dopamine overlords

next chapter will be the big one where i think pretty much everything gets revealed and oh boy it’s going to be fucking crazy dude. i hope u guys will enjoy it lol

Links and shit:
Fire Lily Wiki
Spotify Playlist
Song I made for this fic
Twitter Hashtag
Deku's Costume Designs
Other miscellaneous shit

Chapter 20: The Anatomy of Power

Chapter Summary

> Because that was always the issue, wasn't it? Izuku wanted the truth, but he wanted to be happy. He wanted to be enlightened, but he wanted enlightenment to fit into his worldview like a puzzle piece. He wanted to feel like his life meant something. He wanted to be sedated.
>
> He wanted to want things the way they were.
>
> The way things were terrified him to his core.

Chapter Notes

> oh boy

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Endeavor stood across the room from them, keeping his distance, his hands held up. Katsuki glanced back and forth between the two of them, and his stance, though still guarded, relaxed a bit.

“You know this guy…?” Katsuki side-eyed him, his voice low.

“Yeah.” Izuku replied. “He’s Todoroki’s father.”

At the sound of that name, Endeavor seemed to perk up. “So I was right. You *do* know—“ He took a step toward them, and though he was still nowhere near close enough to pose a threat, Katsuki’s palms still flared up, wings spreading out in front of Izuku.”

“That’s close enough, asshole.” He snarled.

Endeavor put his hands up again, backing away. “Again, I do not intend to fight you.”

“Then what the fuck *do* you *intend?”*

“I just want to ask you a question.” He said, voice carefully level. “After that, I’ll leave you alone.”

Katsuki scoffed. “You say that like you’re not the one in danger right now.” He gestured at the bodies scattered around the room.

“Please.” He sighed. “I do not wish to make any trouble for you. I only want to know where Shouto is. Where *my son* is.”

At this, Izuku frowned.

Todoroki wasn’t participating in the invasion. While Izuku had been fortunate enough to get to train under the Originals via the fast-paced Dominion methodology, that was a privilege afforded to him alone. Todoroki’s training, at least as far as Izuku was aware, had only employed more traditional approaches, and thus wasn’t advanced enough to justify his presence during the mission.

He opened his mouth with the intent of saying as much, only for Katsuki to hold a hand up, stopping him before he could start.

“If you want any information from us, you’re gonna have to give us some info in return.”

Endeavor frowned, but after a moment, he acquiesced. “Very well. What is it you want to know?”

Katsuki gestured at the large, circular trapdoor at the center of the room. “You can start by telling us how we unlock the outer part of the hatch.”

After a moment of silence, Endeavor sighed. Slowly, he began moving to his right, stopping in front of the pile of discarded, bloody silk clothing that the Commander used to occupy. He clenched his jaw as he dutifully rolled up his sleeves, and hesitated for just a second more before he bent down and started to pick through it. As he searched, the room seemed to fill with wet, squishing noises that made Izuku nauseous, but after what felt like and eternity, he seemed to find what he was looking for, and stood up straight again.

Endeavor held the object in the air for them to see. Even covered in blood, the slight reflective quality of it made it clear what it was.

A key.

He pointed at the hatch, tilting his head in silent inquiry. Katsuki nodded, and Endeavor briskly moved toward it, crossing half the distance between them before he stopped. He knelt down beside it, slid the key into one of the locks and turned it. The telltale clicking sound seemed to reverberate throughout the chamber.

Standing up, Endeavor backed away once more, cringing as he held his hands out at his sides to avoid getting blood on the pristine white of his uniform.

“They all have one.” He then said. “If you want to get down there, you’ll need all of them.”

Upon hearing those words, Izuku tensed. *“All* of them?”

“Correct.”

Izuku swallowed against the sudden tightness in his throat, the hazy world coming into focus in brief flashes of racing thoughts.

Because fighting the Cleanser was never part of the plan; his ability to manifest divine light made any sort of direct engagement with him tantamount to suicide. And the Violator, though initially excluded purely out of caution, was proving to be just as much of a threat, if not more so. They had a few plans in place in the event that things went south and forced them into combat with either one, but the plans were mostly geared toward escaping the fight—not winning it.

But if what Endeavor was telling them was correct, evading them wouldn't be an option. Even if they managed to defeat all the others, they'd still need to figure out how on Earth they were supposed to fight someone capable of producing what essentially amounted to a *death ray,* or someone who could… well, do whatever the hell it was Kindred could do.

Just thinking about it was giving Izuku a headache—though in fairness, the concussion was probably at least partly to blame for that.

Back in the present, Katsuki was speaking. And he sounded about as incredulous as Izuku felt.

"Fucking *seriously?"* He said. "Why's it gotta be so goddamn *difficult?"*

If Endeavor was bothered by the blasphemous language, he didn't show it.

"When people are put in there," He explained, "It's generally assumed that they'll *stay* down there indefinitely. Removing *anyone*—let alone large groups of people—is extremely rare."

"But that doesn't make *sense."* Katsuki said. "Rarity doesn't justify that much red tape. There's gotta be more to it."

"It really doesn't matter *why* it's like that." Endeavor said, shrugging. "It's just the way things are."

Izuku grimaced, those words conjuring up a sort of uncomfortable nostalgia within him. It echoed a sentiment he was all too familiar with—the idea that the judgement of God justified itself, that all which came of God and the Council was intrinsically righteous by virtue of its origin. It was hard to think Izuku used to feel that way, used to accept the status quo so uncritically.

These days, he could only wonder how many atrocities had been justified through that same sort of logic.

"Well, I've answered your question." Endeavor said. "Now, tell me where Shouto is."

Izuku looked at Katsuki, who glanced back, met his eyes and nodded.

Taking a deep breath, Izuku replied, "He's not here."

For a while, Endeavor was silent. Then, "Are you being honest?"

"Yes." Izuku said. "It's a small-scale mission. Todoroki is still a beginner; it wouldn't be smart for him to participate."

Endeavor frowned. “You Fell after him, did you not?”

“Special case. It’s complicated.” Katsuki waved his hand. “Look, if you don’t believe us, you can use your little lie-detector magic trick and check, but it’s true. He’s probably not even *awake* right now.”

Endeavor was silent for a while, but eventually, he seemed to accept it. He gave a single nod.

“Very well. In that case, I suppose we’re finished here.” He turned around and headed for the door, but just as he touched the handle, he paused. For a moment, he just stood there, as though debating his next move. Then, back still turned, he began speaking again. “I know you won’t listen, but… If you value your lives, you should stop this. Escape while you still can.”

Katsuki’s brow furrowed. “The hell are you talking about?”

“There are variables at play here that you aren’t aware of. This fight is not as certain as you may believe.”

“We’re not stupid.” Katsuki said. “None of us went into this shit thinkin’ it was gonna be a fuckin’ walk in the park or something. But if you think you’re the only ones with tricks up your sleeve, that’s a pretty fuckin’ lethal underestimation, *old man.”*

Endeavor remained silent for a few seconds, and then sighed.

“…Very well.”

With that, he took his leave, the sound of the door opening and closing behind him carrying a sort of finality.

Folding his wings against his back again, Katsuki turned toward him, grabbing his walkie-talkie and rattling off a quick update for the others. Upon receiving confirmation that the information had been received, he directed his attention toward Izuku again and raked a hand through his hair. “Think you can walk?”

Izuku blinked a few times, and then silently reached out toward him. Taking the hint, Katsuki offered his hands to him, and with a quiet grunt, Izuku stood up. Brows pinched together, he tested his balance, walking around a bit. He felt sort of out of it, and his stability wasn’t exactly *great,* but it didn’t seem like an emergency situation. “Yeah, I… I think I’m okay. Just a bit less… coordinated.” He laughed awkwardly.

Katsuki stared at him for a moment, his expression blank. “Yeah, I’m takin’ you to the medics.”

“What?” Izuku tensed. “No, really! I’m fine!” He waved his hands around. “I-I mean, they should be focusing on people who are critically injured, Kacchan. What could they even *do* for me?”

“Make sure you don’t die in your sleep.” He deadpanned.

Izuku opened his mouth, then closed it, looking away. His palms felt clammy; he wiped them on his pants. “I’m just a little bit dizzy, Kacchan. Even with the cracks, the Sloth defense still absorbed most of the force…”

Katsuki stayed silent, looking him up and down.

“And we don’t have time, anyway.” Izuku quietly added. “We need to prioritize finding Bee.”

Eventually, he sighed, leaning back against the cold, stone wall. “Fucking… fine. Just… stay close to me.”

He nodded quickly. Katsuki offered his hand, and he accepted the support, fingers clasped tightly as they crossed the room. But when they reached the hatch, Izuku stopped.

“Deku?”

“The key. We should take it with us, just in case.”

“Oh. Right.”

Izuku bent down, wincing slightly as he pulled the moist key from the lock. He wiped it off on his pants, and was about to put it in his pocket, when he noticed something that gave him pause.

Or perhaps it would be more accurate to say that he *remembered* it.

Endeavor’s words echoed in his mind.

They all have one, he’d said, referring to the Councilmen, presumably.

Except.

“Kacchan…”

“Yeah?”

“There… There are *seven* key holes.”

The statement hung in the air for a moment, Katsuki’s grip on his hand tightening. “Shit.” He muttered. “I mean… maybe God has one of them?”

Izuku bit his lip. “Maybe.”

“Look.” Katsuki exhaled. “We’ll… We’ll fuckin’ cross that bridge when we get to it, okay? There’s no time right now.”

Izuku nodded. And with that, they were off.

Luke and Levi were both still standing when they found them, though they were looking a fair bit worse for wear. Covered in scuff marks and bruises, bandages haphazardly placed here and there—there was a look in their eyes that seemed to say that if they had any other choice, they'd be off somewhere quiet, where they could recuperate in peace.

But of course, they all knew that was never going to be an option, least of all right now.

As they walked, they did so with confidence. Izuku was not completely sure how they knew just where to go. He just trusted that they did.

The halls were eerily quiet, footsteps echoing as they moved across pristine marble floors. As they passed a window, Izuku glanced outside. It wasn't quite sunrise yet, but it was getting close. He figured that by now, most of the Acolytes were either dead, unconscious, or otherwise out of commission. By that metric, Izuku supposed that the mission could be considered a roaring success. But of course, that was only one metric among many, and never had he felt more aware of it than he did now.

Luke had been limping somewhat for most of the time they'd been moving, though if he was in any pain, it didn't show on his face. It was only as they were approaching the stairwell that the effects of his injuries truly showed. He hesitated at the top of the stairs, narrowing his eyes. Levi noticed his discomfort almost immediately.

"Want some help?" He asked, offering a hand.

For a second, it looked like Luke was going to accept it. But then he glanced down at Levi's hands—both covered in bandages—and pursed his lips. Without saying anything else, Luke simply threw his arm out in a move Izuku now knew quite well, attaching an elastic tendril of his soul to the ceiling and swinging from it before shooting another one out. He made his way down three flights of stairs using this improvised monkey-bars-esque maneuver, and landed with only a quiet grunt of discomfort.

The stairs let off right at the intersection of three separate corridors, but they didn't need to guess which one was the right one, as in that moment, there was a loud bang straight ahead, like something heavy had rammed into the double doors at the end of the central hallway.

There was a period of time during which Izuku couldn't hear anything outside of himself, his ears tuned only to the sound of his own racing heart. It seemed to last an eternity, though in reality, it was probably less than two seconds. Two events served as bookends for the moment, the first being the sound of Luke and Levi's shoes hitting marble as they simultaneously launched toward the door. The second one came just after they yanked it open.

It seemed to happen in slow motion. Luke twisted the door handle, pulling it toward him. As the door swung open, yellow light spilled out into the dreary hallway and made the marble floors sparkle—clean, pristine. But not for long.

It was the sound of something soft, heavy and wet hitting the floor that made Izuku listen, and it was the sight of blood splattering and pooling on white marble that reeled him in, like a nightmare he couldn't escape.

He was on the ground. He wasn't moving.

By the time his back made contact with the floor, Luke and Levi were already far into the room beyond, prepared to fight who or whatever stood within. In turn, Izuku and Katsuki both hurried to his side, just as they'd planned.

Bee was pale, his eyes closed, hair wet with blood and sweat. One of his helix-like horns seemed to have broken off, and all along his body were numerous bruises and cuts, some shallow, others deep.

He was still breathing, albeit shallowly. Izuku couldn't imagine that lasting much longer.

Most disturbing, though, were the wounds on his shoulders and lower stomach. It was as though he'd been stabbed with something, but there didn't appear to be anything there, nothing which could cause the flesh to part the way it did.

Then Katsuki dragged him out of the doorway so that he could close it, and suddenly, two silver knives materialized, one sheathed in each wound. It wasn't hard to guess what was going on—that the visibility of the knives was probably related to their distance from the user. He'd never seen anything like it, though. Katsuki opened the door a crack, shouting a quick warning.

Izuku reached for the knife in his shoulder, only for Katsuki to smack his hand away. "Don't." He said. "Leave it to the medics."

Ah. Right. He thought. *Of course.*

Come to think of it, Izuku already knew; when someone got stabbed, it was almost always better to leave the knives in, as doing so helped to decrease the risk of the person bleeding out. But such rational thoughts were hard to keep in mind at times like these, he supposed.

They quickly wrapped the larger wounds, and then Katsuki hoisted Bee up into his arms and took off toward the stairs. Izuku's coordination was impaired, and so he replicated Luke's technique from earlier in order to keep up, swinging from the ceiling, pulling himself toward opposite walls. They reached the nearest medical outpost in under a minute, and were ushered into a room not unlike the one Izuku had found himself in after being captured. Katsuki laid Bee down on a cold, steel table and got out of the way, allowing the medics to do their job.

And all the while, the sounds of explosive commotion below were audible, even three stories up. It was frightening; he had no idea who or what their adversary was. But Izuku tried not to worry about it. He had to believe that between the two of them, they had it covered.

Izuku stood near the head of the table as the medics hurried to tend to Bee's injuries. Katsuki was speaking with a doctor on the other side of the room, lips moving quickly as he answered his questions.

Izuku glanced at the medics surrounding the table, at the grim looks on their faces, and closed his eyes.

And then he heard something halfway between a wheeze and his own name, and startled. He looked down and gasped.

Bee's eyes were open.

His lips were dry and cracked, but moving. He couldn't quite make out the words at first, and he leaned down to listen closer.

"Stop them."

Izuku's brow furrowed, heart leaping into his throat. And something crept up into his mind, something dark and ominous. "Stop who?"

"Luke… Levi." He whispered. "They'll die."

"I… Y-You mean… whoever did this to you—?"

"Too—" Bee coughed—a terrible, strangled sound.

"Sir, you shouldn't talk." One of the medics said. But Bee ignored him, lips forming around unknown syllables as he seemed to have run out of breath. Izuku hastily got closer, until Bee's lips were right next to his ear. He struggled to breathe in, but this time, when he spoke, Izuku could hear the words.

And as he listened, his eyes went wide, a cold, heavy weight dropping in the pit of his stomach. He leaned in closer as Bee struggled to keep speaking, Izuku's panic mounting with every passing second.

"Shit." Izuku hissed, going straight for the door.

"Oi!" Katsuki barked, running after him as Izuku made for the stairs again. He grabbed Izuku by the back of his shirt, the force of his grip causing one of the elastic chords he'd shot out to detach and snap back into place. "The hell d'you think you're doing?!"

"We need to warn them!"

"Warn them about *what?"*

Suddenly, something exploded down below, vibrating the floor three stories up. Katsuki tensed, and if not for his grip, Izuku probably would have fallen over. He stammered as he did his best to relay what he'd learned to Katsuki, and felt his grip on his shirt loosen with every word, color draining from his face. Without another word, they went for the stairs, covering the distance in record time.

Izuku's mind marinated in the implications of what Bee had said.

"He'll let you hit him sometimes…"

Katsuki took the stairs two at a time, speaking quickly into his walkie-talkie, trying to get ahold of them, but getting no response.

“But he’s just trying to wear you down.”

They reached the bottom of the stairs, and could see the door at the end of the central hall—light leaking out around the edges.

“By the time you catch on, it’s too late.”

They both bolted toward the door, but Katsuki got there first. He wrenched the door open. As light flooded the hall, the scene before them came into focus. The room within was a mess of dust and rubble. At the center of it all was a single person, who stood there with his back turned toward them. The lights flickered, and the room filled with violet static. Just before the attack could hit him, the man flicked his wrist somewhere to his right—a subtle move, blink and you’d miss it.

Two things happened almost simultaneously. First, the violet lightning attack hit the man, causing his body to seize up, and as it struck, Luke landed on his distant right.

“He sees the future, Midoriya.”

The knife hit Luke, embedding itself in his left eye, and its invisibility made the sight all the more graphic and visceral.

Izuku felt a sense of impending doom unlike anything he’d experienced before.

“Hidaeriel knows where you’ll be before you do.”

Luke reacted quickly, lightning disappearing as he instantly switched gears, freezing his soul to try to prevent the dagger from going any deeper. At the same time, he reached up and grabbed the handle, yanking it out. His eye was bleeding a lot, and he pressed his palm against it, wincing slightly. Then Izuku smelled something odd. It wasn’t until he removed his hand that he realized, with horror, that Luke had actually *cauterized his own wound.*

Levi landed near the doorway, his back facing them. He was about to launch an attack when Katsuki grabbed his arm, and in his shock, Levi narrowly avoided hitting him. Katsuki spoke quickly under his breath, trying to keep his voice down. As he explained, Levi’s eyes went wide. He spun around again and shouted Luke’s name. Luke looked at the three of them, and in a blink he was there beside them.

But if anyone said anything else after that, Izuku didn’t hear it. Because at that moment, the man turned around, and for the very first time, he saw his face.

And it was like everything else faded away, his vision taking over all aspects of his being. Izuku’s mind reached a crescendo, like something that had been building up for weeks was finally crashing down, and with it, a lifetime worth of experience.

He was four years old, waking from a recurring nightmare in which a winged man’s silhouette hovered at the edge of his bed. He never said anything; he only stared in silence.

A blink of the eye, and he was five. He couldn’t figure out why he couldn’t fall asleep. It was close to midnight when he caught sight of that same winged man, skulking around outside his

window, and ran to his mother's bedside in tears. She checked all around the perimeter of the building, but the man had left no trace of his presence, if he ever was there to begin with.

Six, seven, eight, nine. Sometimes Izuku wondered if the people he met at church really liked him for *him.*

His presence always seemed to draw attention, though he was never sure why. In Izuku, the adults saw a courteous, responsible child, while the other kids seemed to view him with some strange combination of both trust and fear. He was someone they could trust enough to bring them their schoolwork if they were sick, but never enough for them to reveal their secrets to him. Those who followed the rules would revere him. Those who did not would treat him like a pest.

People with authority would often single him out, put him on a pedestal above the other kids.

Izuku was a very lonely child.

He was ten years old the first time he saw a picture of his father—the only one his mother had. It was close up, candid; only his face and upper chest were visible. He asked her where he was and why he left them. She told him he had a very important job.

By the time he turned eleven, the dreams of winged men lurking in the shadows had more or less pattered out, but the nightmares never really ended—they simply evolved. He used to dream of people laid out under fluorescent lights, dark pits, bloody hearts sitting out on steel tables, still beating. Sometimes he'd see a bright flash of light. He learned to associate bright lights with safety—he always seemed to wake up afterward.

Twelve, thirteen. Izuku would think about boys the same way he thought about girls. He wore a rubber band on his wrist. He snapped it every time his thoughts started to wander.

Sometimes, Izuku felt like he could sense things just before they happened. Little things. His mother knocking on his bedroom door. The appearance of a familiar face. People would sometimes ask him to speculate about future events, or even pick out lottery numbers. Izuku was often wrong, but he was less wrong than most people.

At fourteen, he finally confided in his priest about his nightmares, but he told him not to worry. Said it was normal to fear Hell. *Healthy.*

He never brought it up again. The nightmares continued.

When he and his mother moved out to the city, they attended a church on the east side of town. At the center of the front lawn, there was a life-sized statue of a male Angel, and all throughout his high school years, Izuku would go out of his way to exit through the back door if he was alone, or if it was dark. He was far too embarrassed to tell anyone that he did it to avoid seeing the statue. He couldn't figure out how to explain why it made him uncomfortable without sounding pathetic, or sacrilegious.

At eighteen, he left home for college. He moved into a dorm with a boy he would never admit to being attracted to. The boy wasn't religious, but he respected Izuku's faith. He didn't

complain about him getting up at the crack of dawn each Sunday. He was a good friend. He never brought it up, when Izuku would wake from his slumber, screaming in the dead of night.

When he was nineteen, Izuku went on a camping trip with his roommate and a couple of their friends. It wasn't too far out into the wilderness; in fact, there was a convenience store just a thirty minute walk from their campsite. Izuku made the trek there with his roommate, late one Friday night. They were on their way back when it happened—when the flimsy, paper handle broke under the weight of their shopping bag, items spilling out onto the street. Izuku was a little ways ahead, and turned around at the sound of objects hitting the ground. He found his roommate crouching down, attempting to pick it all up.

From there, it all seemed to happen so quickly. Izuku saw a flash of light coming around the bend, but his roommate's back was turned. Maybe it was a trained reaction—bright lights always did calm him down—but in the moment, he wasn't scared. His mind was blank.

His body moved before he could think about it.

He leapt out into the road, shoving his friend as hard as he could. He didn't really understand the feeling of the truck hitting him, and he couldn't recall experiencing any sort of pain. Perhaps, on some deeper level, his body knew there was no point. Pain was information. It wouldn't save him from the situation he was in. It wouldn't stop his skull from smashing into the asphalt.

Consciousness only lasted a few seconds after that. Next thing he knew, he was standing outside of himself.

He looked to the right, and saw his friend laying beside a tree. His eyes were closed, unconscious, but he could feel the life still thrumming within him. He suspected he'd hit his head on the tree trunk, but he didn't seem too beat up otherwise. Izuku hoped that meant he'd be okay.

Izuku wasn't sure how long it had been, when he finally got himself to look down. The truck was gone, and the only light came from the full moon above. It made it a bit less disturbing to see his own body like this, contorted as it was.

Then suddenly, there was a bright light shining from his right, and the whole scene became a lot more visceral. There was a large pool of blood surrounding his head, and beneath the harsh light, he couldn't help but notice how strange it looked. It seemed a bit too dark, somehow, and when he looked closer, he noticed strange, swirling patterns in its expanse.

He remembered thinking he'd never forget that sight.

But as time went on, the light seemed to pull harder at his soul. He went toward it, and the closer he got, the brighter it became, until eventually he was forced to close his eyes, and let the blinding light cleanse his soul and mind, take away the burden of his origin and remake him into something new.

But here, in the present, Izuku was frozen, mind reeling with memories he could barely even process, images thought to be lost to the wind. His first day of school. His first crush. The worst days of his life played back-to-back with the best, overloading his emotions. And all the while, the face of the man before him remained superimposed over his memories.

Everything clicked into place. It was a wonderful, yet overwhelming sort of feeling that seemed to block out all other stimuli, nullify all context apart from that of Izuku's unfolding experience.

Perhaps that was why he did what he did next.

Izuku didn't realize he was moving, and if anyone tried to stop him, his brain didn't process it. Because as far as his mind was concerned, there was only one other person who existed in that moment.

"Father!"

The man tilted his head as he looked at him strangely. His expression showed many things, but recognition was not one of them.

Izuku stopped a few feet away from him, heart pounding in his chest. "It's me, Izuku. You remember me, right?"

There was something urgent in the way he spoke, words tumbling off his tongue, breathless.

The man tilted his head. "You have the wrong man, Demon."

Izuku winced, pulse ramping up as he grew increasingly panicked, like he would cease to exist if this man didn't validate his memories.

"That… that can't be, b-because I didn't remember… well, *anything* until just now, when I saw you!" He insisted. "Um, my… my mother's name was Inko Midoriya. Y-You might not remember me, but… you remember her, right? *Right?"*

For a while, the man just stared at him. And for the first time since he'd seen his face, the voice of reason that lived in Izuku's mind piped up, attempting to speak over the white noise pervading his senses.

It told him to run away. In fact, it was screaming at him, trying to force his legs to move, but they would not budge—compelled by a force he couldn't really understand.

The man had been staring at him just a little bit too long, and though a part of him understood that, it seemed to it had no authority to act.

A second later, the man's eyes went wide with recognition. "Izuku?" He said. "Is it really you?"

Like a massive wave finally crashing into the shore, Izuku began to cry. He nodded emphatically as he sobbed, tears streaming down his cheeks.

The man opened his arms to him. “Come here.”

As Izuku took that first step, someone screamed something at him, but his brain didn’t associate the sound with any sort of meaning. It was all just background noise. Nothing else mattered but the man standing in front of him: the only thing he had left which tethered his identity to the human he used to be—ironically, the least human person he’d ever met.

Izuku all but dove forward, embracing his father with open arms. And the man hugged him in return, strong arms closing around him.

He didn’t feel it, at first. His mind seemed to block it out. He could hear it, though, when the change occurred. It was as though he’d been plunged underwater, but it wasn’t until the man begun to pull away that Izuku actually realized what had happened. As the man stepped back, Izuku’s hands slid along the cool silk of his sleeves, and he gripped the edges as he stumbled forward, arms extending further out and—

—Ah.

There seemed to be an obstruction of some kind.

Izuku fell to his knees, and when they hit the hard floor, it was like it all came rushing back to him. He could feel the blood rolling down his skin, the excruciating pain.

The knife was embedded deep into his back, near the base of his right wing. He tried to breathe in, but found that his lungs were unable to fully expand. And then Izuku felt heat above his head, and looked up just in time to watch his father dodge Katsuki’s flaming fist.

He collapsed onto the floor, blood seeping through his clothing and steadily starting to pool out around him.

Katsuki was at his side soon enough.

“Don’t move.” He hissed, rolling Izuku onto his side. It looked like he was fighting with Luke and Levi again, but all he could see were indistinct flashes of color. His father seemed to be moving faster than before, and Izuku supposed he must’ve caught on. He knew that they were aware of his power, now, and thus he no longer bothered with holding back.

Luke and Levi were both hurt pretty bad.

He wondered how much longer this would last.

Breathing was difficult, and Izuku was getting very tired, very quickly. But just when the world was starting to get dark, a lightbulb in his head flickered on, shining bright in a brief moment of clarity.

He smiled.

Of course.

“Kacchan…”

“Don’t fucking talk, idiot!” Katsuki’s face came into view—an odd mix of emotions, the dominant one being fear.

But Izuku kept talking anyway.

“When he snaps his fingers…” He wheezed, “Hit him as hard as you can.”

The last thing Izuku saw was the image of Katsuki’s confused face suddenly morphing to a look of horrified understanding.

And then everything went dark.

When he opened his eyes next, he found himself in the exact same room, but in a different body. He allowed himself just one second to grin, vindicated, before he raised both hands and snapped his fingers, backing up against the wall.

For a moment, nothing happened. Izuku kept his eyes shut as his body thrummed with nervous anticipation. And then finally, he felt a sudden spike of heat just before a fist connected with his skull. Something cracked, and then he lost his hold over his father’s mind. But instead of waking up as he normally did, Izuku perceived only darkness.

Then, nothing at all.

From the roof of the office building, the cars looked like ants running across a tightrope of a road. The sight of his sneakers hanging over the ledge made him feel irrationally nervous, as though they weren’t tied. As though he could expect them to just fall off his feet. From this high up, someone could easily get hurt. And he didn’t want that.

He didn’t want anybody else to get hurt.

Izuku was fifteen years old, and he had decided that was all he was ever going to be.

He patted at his left pocket, felt the small, folded up sheet of paper. Made sure it was secure. That he wouldn’t need to worry about it falling out.

He was terrified, and the longer he stared at the traffic below, the worse it got. He closed his eyes, took a deep breath.

“Beautiful day out, isn’t it?”

Izuku yelped, eyes snapping open. He looked to his left, and flushed at the realization that he wasn’t alone. There was a man sitting beside him—rather muscular, with blonde hair, blue eyes, and the kind of smile Izuku could only dream of sporting genuinely.

“Y-You…” He stammered. “Wh-Where did you…?”

The man chuckled. “Apologies. I probably gave you quite the scare, didn’t I?”

Izuku swallowed nervously, and just nodded. The man laughed again, and then went silent for a bit.

He sat there beside him, and didn't dare speak. There was a part of him—the rational part—that told him he ought to get away from this man. He was a stranger, after all. He had no idea what his intentions were.

But there was another part of him, one which proved to be stronger, that told him that this was okay, somehow. He wasn't sure what it was, exactly, but something about the man just… put him at ease.

"What are you doing up here, all by yourself?" The man asked.

Izuku hesitated, internally scrambling for an answer. He hated telling lies, but the question left him little choice. "Um… just… enjoying the view. It's… nice."

The man turned and looked at him. And for a moment, Izuku thought he saw something else in that kind smile of his—something somber.

"That it is." He said. "Views like this ought to be enjoyed with company, though."

Izuku gripped the concrete ledge of the building, the tips of his fingers going white. "Well, I… don't really *have* any friends to enjoy it with. No one close…"

The man hummed. "Well, I suppose kids your age aren't exactly known for being, err… their *best* selves." He patted his shoulder with one large hand. "There are certain types of people others just can't really appreciate until they've had time to grow up a little."

At this, Izuku's shoulders sagged forward. The words pulled at a frustration inside of him, something wound up tight around his heart. "…I guess they never will, then."

"Hmm." The man leaned forward a bit, and for a few seconds, he didn't speak. "You know… God of course loves all of us, but sometimes, I think he doesn't communicate that love as effectively as he ought to."

Izuku frowned. "What do you mean?"

"Well…" he said. "God shows his love in subtle ways. Ways you might not notice, if you're preoccupied with other things. For example, God might express his love by, say, making sure a sick person receives the best care possible. But from the perspective of the sick person, those sorts of things don't really stand out as miracles. They'll view the fact that they became sick at all as a curse, and interpret everything after that as just a series of chance events."

Izuku's brows pinched together. "But… if God really loved the person, why *would* he let them get sick *at all?"*

"Well, life can't always be sunshine and rainbows, son! There are always going to be bad days, weeks, months… even *years.* But the night is darkest before dawn, as they say. And it's those periods of darkness that make you really appreciate the light." He paused for a second, then shrugged. "Of course, that's not to say that we can't hope for better, or that you need to

take every hardship lying down. Just that there will always be problems, and God can't always be there to fix them. That'd take the living out of life."

Izuku frowned. Distantly, he could understand what he was saying, could get behind the logic of it. But as things stood, it didn't provide him much comfort.

Izuku stared down at his hands, clenching around the fabric of his pants.

After a moment of silence, the man sighed. "I'm not the best at this." He muttered. "Really, all I'm trying to say is that things *do* get better. It's hard, at your age… The lack of perspective can make it feel as though where you are right now is where you'll always be. But that's just not the case, son. There's a whole world out there." He gestured out at the city. Izuku looked out toward it, at the clear sky. It was late in the afternoon, nearly sunset.

"It's filled with places you've never seen and things you've never experienced." He continued. "And it's not all wonderful, I'll admit. But beauty is more common that you think, son. There are people who will hate you, and people who will love you more than life itself." He paused, placing a hand over Izuku's. "And believe me, I used to be your age. I know it probably feels like it's a million years away, but when you get there, you'll look back and realize it was no time at all."

Izuku didn't realize he was crying until he saw the teardrops hit his pants, soaking into the fabric. The man's squeezed his hand comfortingly.

"And you're going to be an extraordinary Angel one day, Midoriya." He told him, speaking softly. "But that day need not be this one."

He broke down then, shoulders shaking as he sobbed, leaning into the man's sturdy form. He cried for what felt like hours, but was probably only around fifteen minutes or so in reality. It was weird, to do this with a stranger, but in the moment, it didn't matter to him.

Izuku had never been one to tell others when he was struggling. Usually, *he* was the one giving other people advice, if anything. All his life, he'd been taught to think of burdening others with his own problems as though it were some sort of grand sin, and yet here this man was—this complete stranger—offering him comfort. Izuku didn't ask for it. The man didn't need to do it. But he did.

Somehow, the man had seen something in him that Izuku dared not express. It was a catharsis Izuku struggled to think he deserved, but couldn't deny he needed.

Izuku didn't end it that day.

He went home that evening to the familiar smell of his mother's katsudon. After dinner, he returned to his room and tore the note up, shed his clothes and took a shower.

It didn't actually hit him until he climbed into bed that night. But as he stared at the ceiling, he had to wonder:

How did the man know his name?

He awoke to the sight of a bright, fluorescent light that made him cringe, and the cold press of a steel table underneath him. The setting triggered a rather intense feeling of deja vu—it was almost exactly like when he'd woken up after getting captured, albeit with one key difference. This time, someone was holding his hand.

When his eyes adjusted to the light, he turned and saw Katsuki sitting beside him, looking at him with wide, tired eyes.

"Oh, thank fuck." He said, dropping his forehead against the surface of the table.

"Kacchan?" Izuku tried to sit up, wincing at the sudden, sharp pain in his shoulder. "What… What happened?"

"You passed out after getting stabbed." He said.

Oh, that's right, Izuku remembered. It all seemed to come back to him in a rush, then—the Commander and the Acolytes, Kindred and Endeavor. Bee.

His father.

Izuku swallowed roughly. "Did we get him…?"

Katsuki sighed. "Yeah. Yeah, we did." His voice sounded a bit scratchy. "That trick of yours ended up being just what we needed." He paused, eyes drifting away. "Though for a minute there…" He trailed off.

Izuku remained quiet, not asking him to elaborate. He didn't need to. He knew.

"And Bee?"

Katsuki looked back at him again, frowning. "Still unconscious, far as I've heard. Luke and Levi are awake, though." He said. "It's like… half-past seven. You've been out about two hours."

Izuku nodded slightly, and silence stretched between them. Izuku tried to clear his throat, but the action proved to be uncomfortable, and he winced.

After a moment, he tentatively asked, "So… are we in the clear?"

Katsuki pursed his lips. "Not quite. There's…" His brows pinched together. "Well, what do you want first? Good news or bad news?"

Izuku gulped. "Good news…?"

"The Cleanser's dead."

His eyes widened. "We got him?!"

"See, that's the thing. *We* didn't get him."

Izuku blinked. “What do you mean?”

Katsuki sighed, and his volume lowered a bit, as if he were worried someone might be listening in. “None of our guys killed him. We just… found him dead. He was dangling from the balcony outside his tower.” He said, then leaned in a bit closer. “He’d been hung by his own intestines, Deku.”

His eyes went wide. “What? Who would—“ It hit him then, and Izuku tensed. *“The Violator.”*

“Bingo.” Katsuki gave a tight-lipped smile. “Bastard’s killed more Councilman alone than any single one of us Demons has. Who’da thought *he’d* be our biggest ally.” He scoffed.

“But… But does that mean he’s still…?”

“Yep. That’s bad news part one.” Katsuki said. “We don’t even know where the fuck he is. Everyone’s been tiptoeing around ‘cuz they’re all half-expecting him to jump out at them and like, turn their organs into mush or something.”

“That’s…” Izuku swallowed. “If that’s part one, then what’s part two?”

“We still haven’t found the Martyr. Mirko and Aizawa have been looking for him for hours, and the bastard still has yet to make an appearance.” He scoffed. “Pretty ironic, if you ask me. Guess the Martyr’s too scared to come out and actually *be* a fuckin’ martyr.”

Izuku felt a wave of nausea washing over him.

“…Please tell me there’s not a part three.”

“Nope.” Katsuki said. “That’s it. Two Councilman playin’ hide and seek.”

Izuku allowed himself some small amount of relief.

“What’re we going to do?”

“That’s what we’re tryin’ to figure out.” Katsuki sighed. “See, the Martyr’s probably not a huge deal. Once we find him, he’s done, ‘cuz now he’s up against Luke, Levi *and* Mirko. Even with the injuries, it’s no fuckin’ contest. But the Violator?” He scoffed. “We can try to track him down, but like… *then* what? We still don’t know what the fuck his power is.”

Izuku chewed his lip, thinking it over. After a moment, he said, “Maybe we could try talking to him…?”

Katsuki snorted. *“Sure.* Bunch’a Demons tryin’ to talk down one of the most powerful Angels in Heaven. *What could go wrong?”*

Izuku frowned. “I mean… It seems like it could work, maybe? He didn’t seem…” he squinted. “Well, I don’t know. He didn’t seem particularly *malevolent?* At least not towards Demons. I mean, he didn’t come after us when we hid under the hatch, Kacchan. He can’t hate us *that* much.”

“See, but that’s assuming he understands object permanence. Based on how he was acting, that might be more credit than he deserves.” He shook his head and sighed. “I mean… to be clear, I agree it did kinda seem like it might be possible to talk him down, but it’s just… too risky, y’know? We don’t even know what we’re dealing with.”

Izuku swallowed. “So then… what can we do? Could someone from the Sloth team sedate him if they got close enough?”

“Unlikely. Apparently, Councilmen don’t really react too well to that shit. Luke and Levi found out the hard way.”

“Ah. I see.” Izuku muttered. “Well, maybe we could shoot him with a sedative? Like, a dart?”

“Nope. Too much time for him to react.”

“Um. Okay…” Izuku racked his brain. “What about some sort of gas? Something he wouldn’t realize he was breathing?”

“Yeah, that’s kind of what some of the others were thinking, too.” He scratched his head. “The issue is just the logistics of it. Like, we need to track him down, then figure out how to fill the area covertly, while also making sure no one else breathes any of it unintentionally. And it’ll only work indoors, inside an enclosed area.” He sighed. “We’re all working on it, but it’s just… difficult, y’know? It’s like everything we could try on him has so much potential to go horribly wrong. It’s hard to know what the right approach is.”

“I could help you out with that.” The sound of a new person’s voice made both of then jolt, Izuku reflexively trying to sit up, only for Katsuki to immediately plant a hand atop his chest, keeping him down.

Lucky for him, the man stepped into view without him needing to move at all. For several seconds, he just stared at him, stunned.

Because there he was—the fifth Councilman himself. The Councilman of Sacrifice. *The Martyr.*

Speak of the devil, Izuku thought. And had he not been in a potentially life-threatening situation as he thought it, he might’ve laughed at the irony of it.

Time seemed to stand still for a moment, as both of them were too shocked to move. But Izuku could see the gears turning in Katsuki’s head, and after a few seconds, he sprung into action. Katsuki lunged at him, manifesting hellfire around his fist as he aimed for the man’s face. The Councilman ducked out of the way inhumanly fast, and Katsuki’s fist only met the wall that had been behind him.

Izuku blinked, and he was on the other side of the room, his palms held up. “I’m not here to fight.” He said, expression neutral.

“Where the fuck *have* you been?”

He shrugged. “Oh, you know. Trying not to get killed, as one does. But I thought I’d come out and offer you a deal, if you’re interested.”

“Deal?” Katsuki narrowed his eyes. “The fuck are you on about?”

“I heard about your little *predicament.”* He replied. “Kindred trusts me. With my help, you could sedate him without anyone else having to die.”

Katsuki looked at him like he’d grown a second head. “Why would *you* want to help *us?”*

“Well, I wouldn’t be doing it because I *want* to. This isn’t some bullshit ‘out of the goodness of my heart’ situation. I’m offering you a *deal,* not charity.”

“We’re not gonna retreat.” Katsuki said. “We’re here to kill God and destroy heaven. We’re not compromising on that.”

“Good thing that’s not what I’m asking for.”

Katsuki frowned, looking him up and down, and then scoffed. “Then what? You want us to spare you, or something?”

“Oh, I don’t give a damn what happens to me.” He smiled. “You can kill me afterwards, if you want. But I don’t recommend it. It’d probably upset Kindred.”

Katsuki lowered his fists slightly. “Well, cut the crap and tell us, then.”

“I’ll sedate Kindred. I’ll give you both his and my key… if you’ll agree to spare his life.”

Katsuki blinked a few times. “…That’s it?”

“That’s it. That’s all I’m asking for.”

Katsuki lowered his hands, though his expression remained guarded.

“…Why?”

The Councilman hesitated, and as he looked off to the side, something odd passed over his otherwise apathetic expression, something almost *human.*

“Kindred is innocent.” He replied. “He just… got wrapped up in some things. He never even *meant* to join the Council. Circumstances led to him having no other choice.”

Katsuki scoffed. “Given the kinda heinous shit you fuckers get up to with your little experiments, I find it hard to believe he’s *completely* innocent.”

“See, the thing about Kindred is, he was always a bit too busy *being* an experiment to actually get involved with any of the other ones.”

Katsuki looked him up and down. “The hell’s that supposed to mean?”

“Use your fucking brain.” The Martyr rolled his eyes. “The Commander’s been attempting to weaponize his power for decades. I’m sure the results you’ve witnessed speak for themselves.”

For the first time since the interaction had begun, Izuku spoke. “What… What exactly *is* his power?”

The Martyr’s eyes darted over to him. He stared at him for a moment, like he was debating whether or not to respond. Eventually, he took a deep breath. “Kindred’s designated virtue is Humility, as I’m sure you know. In line with that, his power is that he can do anything he doesn’t believe he can do.”

Katsuki frowned. “The fuck? How does *that* work?”

He shrugged. “Essentially, if he attempts to do something that he genuinely expects to fail at, he’ll succeed. No matter what.” He gave a tight-lipped smile. “Whether it’s licking his own elbow or destroying the whole fucking universe, as long as he’s not confident in his abilities, it will happen.”

Silence stretched between them as Izuku and Katsuki both tried to process the information. There was one obvious issue, and Katsuki seemed to realize it at the same time he did. Izuku spoke first. “But… isn’t that a paradox, or something? If he *knows* he has this power, doesn’t that mean he won’t ever succeed?”

“Astute observation.” He deadpanned. “For a sane mind, Kindred’s power would be barely a power at all, because sane people have a consistent understanding of reality and their own abilities. Kindred used to have that. But not anymore. You can thank the Commander for that.”

“So, basically he’s a ticking time bomb, is what you’re saying.” Katsuki said. “Why would we want to keep someone that dangerous alive?”

“Because he doesn’t have to be dangerous. Now that the Commander’s dead, he can finally recover.” He replied. “See, that’s the great thing about his power—technically, anything is possible. You just have to be smart about it.”

Katsuki stared at him for a moment, clearly still skeptical. He opened his mouth again, but the Martyr spoke first.

“Look, we could keep talking about this, but every second Kindred’s awake unmonitored is another dice roll to see whether or not he’ll destroy the fucking universe. You should ask yourself whether these questions are really a priority.”

Katsuki and Izuku exchanged glances. He had a point, if he was telling the truth. *If.* Izuku wasn’t really sure whether or not they could trust him completely, but at least in this particular instance, it seemed riskier not to. He gave Katsuki a small nod, which he returned.

“Alright.” Katsuki sighed. “But if you try anything funny, you’ll be next against the wall, fucker.”

Though the reactions of the others mostly consisted of varying degrees of bafflement, in the end, most seemed to agree that even if Arc (the Martyr's name, which he insisted on being called) wasn't exactly trustworthy in general, he was still probably their best option for handling the Violator as things stood.

When it came to moving around, Izuku found that standing up was the most difficult part by far. Once he was upright, it didn't hurt so bad, as long as he didn't move his upper body around too much. He knew he shouldn't overexert himself, but somehow, it felt more important for him to be there to witness the event. After all, if this went poorly, it might be the end of the world.

So when they got the word that one of the search teams had tracked Kindred down, Izuku forced himself not to think about the pain. He followed behind the rest of the group, navigating through labyrinthian corridors. It was a fairly small group—him, Katsuki, Levi, Luke, and a handful of others, including Mirko, who seemed more than a little disappointed to find that killing Arc was apparently no longer on the menu for the day.

"You're sure you've got this?" Katsuki asked, as they were turning a corner.

Arc stared at him for a moment, and then shrugged. "It's the best chance you have."

The lack of any clear, affirmative answer put Izuku on edge even more than he already was, but he bit his tongue and kept quiet. It was as Arc said. Every moment Kindred remained awake was just another opportunity for him to destroy the world, if he so chose.

They found him in a hallway on the second floor, wandering barefoot across white marble in blue silk pajamas stained with blood, and as Arc prepared to intervene, the others shuffled around nervously.

It was odd to see him like this, knowing what he knew now. Kindred was standing in front of a large window overlooking the courtyard. There were a number of potted plants along the window sill, and he seemed to be fixated on one in particular—a purple flowering plant. He looked at it with childlike curiosity, and touched its petals with a sort of carefulness unbefitting of a young man who allegedly hung a man by his entrails not one hour ago.

Levi had created a veil of vapor around them, bending light around the group, so that he wouldn't see them watching. Taking a deep breath, Arc stepped out from behind it.

"Kindred." He said his name with a soft, gentle voice. Kindred still seemed to startle, spinning around with wide eyes. He visibly relaxed upon seeing who it was.

"...Arc?"

He offered a small smile, and approached him slowly, the needle safely hidden in his pocket.

"I heard you killed the Commander." He said. "The Cleanser, too."

“I… did?” He blinked, brows pinching together, like he had to strain himself just to remember an event that had taken place mere hours prior. “Oh, that’s right, I… did… didn’t I…” he muttered, before turning and looking at the flowers again. He reached out, brushing over the petals with the back of his hand, as though he were afraid of harming it in some way. “I don’t remember these being here…”

“The petunias?” Arc asked, stepping up by his side. “Yeah. They’ve been here for around a year. Almost didn’t survive last winter. Someone forgot to bring them in over night.”

“A year… is that how long it’s been since I was here?”

Arc hesitated, and then sighed. “I… think it’s been a lot more than a *year,* Kindred.”

“Oh…”

Silence stretched between the two of them as Kindred’s arms fell limp at his sides. He was no longer looking at the flowers, his gaze fixated on the ground.

“I’m sorry.” Arc said, his tone gentle. “For not doing more. I… didn’t know how bad it was, at first. But even after I did, it still took way too long for me to stand up for you. I was afraid of the Commander. And you suffered because of it. You deserved better.”

Kindred said nothing in reply, only staring at the floor. After a small eternity, he finally asked, “Um. Exactly how long *has* it been…?”

“…Since you were last free?”

He nodded.

Arc didn’t answer immediately. For a few seconds, he just stood there with his mouth hanging open, like he wasn’t quite sure if telling him was a good idea. But eventually, he answered. “It’s… been about thirty-six years.”

Kindred’s head snapped up, and he looked at him with wide eyes. *“Th-Thirty-six?!”*

Arc gave a solemn nod.

His brows pinched together. “Then… Then everything’s…” he trailed off, words dying on his tongue. “It’s… I mean, I *thought* things looked different, but…”

He started to shake, big eyes filling with tears. He sunk to the floor, pulling his knees to his chest as he cried quietly. Arc sat beside him, but did not say anything. He simply stayed there, gently stroking his back for the few minutes it took for Kindred to speak again.

He peered up over his knees, dark eyes shiny with tears. “D-Did… Did I really kill them…?”

Arc took a deep breath and exhaled. “You did.”

“I… Oh, *god.”* Kindred whispered, face white as a sheet. “But… I didn’t mean to.” His scrawny arms tightened around his shins, nails digging into flesh. “I didn’t *mean to.”*

“No, hey—listen to me, Kindred. It’s okay. Anyone else would’ve done the same thing.” He insisted, voice hushed. “The Commander, the Cleanser… they were both cruel to you. If you hadn’t done it, they would’ve never let you go. You did what you needed to do—got that? No one will blame you for that.”

Kindred continued to sniffle, face buried in his knees for a few more minutes until eventually he glanced up, hair messy, tears staining his gaunt cheeks. He looked at him, dark eyes bloodshot. “Arc… d-do you think I’m dangerous?”

Arc opened his mouth, and it hung there for a moment. “I mean…” he fumbled. “Well, yes. But it’s not your fault.”

Kindred looked away, staring at the ground for a moment before closing his eyes. “Are you afraid of me?”

Arc sighed. “Not… of you.” He reached out, brushing his bangs out of his face. “I could never be afraid of *you.* But…” Kindred opened his eyes. “I’m afraid of what the Commander has tried to make you into.”

He nodded mutely, but did not look at him.

“But it’s okay, now. You don’t have to be like that anymore. The Commander is gone. You won’t need to hurt anyone else.” He said. “And no one else will hurt you.”

Kindred buried his face between his knees again, shoulder quivering as his fragile composure broke once more. Arc scooted closer, wrapping an arm around his shoulders. Kindred leaned into his side.

“There’s… one catch.” Arc said, sighing.

He froze, looking up. “What?”

“I… need to sedate you.”

Kindred tensed up for a second, and then scrambled back. “N-No, *please* don’t!”

“It’s okay!” He waved his hands. “Kindred, please, I mean it—*please* listen! It’s just a temporary measure, I *promise.* Maybe a week, *at most!”*

Kindred reached up, covering his ears, expression hardening. “That’s what they *always* say.”

“But *they* were liars. Have I ever lied to you?”

He didn’t respond, and for a moment it seemed they were in stalemate. Izuku held his breath as he looked between the two, and he knew that things could go either way, from here.

After what felt like an eternity, Arc started reaching out slowly. Kindred flinched back, so he stopped mid-gesture. “I won’t do anything unless you explicitly agree to it.”

Kindred kept staring, his eyes still afraid, though he was no longer completely frozen. He was looking around, fidgeting slightly. Progress. Maybe.

“Here.” Arc slowly revealed the needle, so as not to startle him. “I’ll even let you hold onto this while we talk. Does that work for you?” He held it out for him, offering.

After several seconds, Kindred reached out and gingerly took the needle. Once his had it in his hands, his body language seemed to relax considerably, and so Arc scooted closer again. They were both sitting against the wall, just beneath the window sill. Morning light spilled over them as Kindred quietly examined the needle, turning it over in his hands.

A minute later, Arc sighed.

“Look, I… I know you’ve been lied to a lot, and I really don’t blame you for being suspicious. But things are different now. I mean, I don’t know if you realize this, but apparently, all the other Councilmen are either dead or going to die very soon.”

Kindred glanced at him, frowning slightly. “All of them?” He tilted his head. “Even Zero?”

“Even him.”

“…How come?”

Arc blinked a few times. “You mean… you haven’t noticed everything that’s been going on?”

At this, his face went a bit pink. “W-Was there something I was… *supposed* to notice…?”

Arc smiled—a full smile, with teeth. He laughed softly, which only seemed to embarrass him even more. Arc composed himself quickly. “No, it’s nothing, really. Nothing you need to worry about right now, at least.”

He frowned, but as his eyes drifted back to the syringe, he seemed to become fixated on it once again. He held it up, letting the morning light shine through the translucent liquid, tilting it this way and that.

“Kindred… I know you don’t want to hurt anybody.”

Kindred’s movements stilled, but his eyes stayed glued to the needle.

“…Will I hurt someone if I stay awake?”

He exhaled. “Well, not *intentionally.* But it could happen, yeah.”

His frown deepened, hands lowering into his lap. He stared at the floor again, lip wobbling a bit.

And then, in a voice so soft, Izuku almost couldn’t hear it, he asked: “Will you still be there when I wake up?”

“Of course.” Arc smiled. “And if for some reason I’m not, just give me a minute. I’m probably just taking a piss or something.”

Kindred gave a small, wobbly sort of smile, but it only lasted a second before it decayed back into something sorrowful. “I… don’t want to go to sleep.” He muttered, voice wavering. “But... I trust you.”

And with that, he extended his hand, returning the needle. After taking it, Arc scooted up behind him, syringe poised at his neck. Kindred squeezed his eyes shut.

“Do you want me to count to three?”

“No. That makes it worse.”

“Right.”

Arc paused for a moment, and then quickly jabbed the needle in. Kindred flinched, but didn’t resist, and slowly, the sedative drained into the side of his neck. He seemed to feel the effects almost immediately. Arc sat there on his knees behind him as Kindred sluggishly laid down on his back, head resting on his lap.

“Promise you’ll stay with me?”

Arc smiled, brushing his bangs aside. “I already told you I’d be there when you woke up.”

Kindreds eyelids drooped, and his words started to slur together. “No… I mean… will you *always* be there…?”

This seemed to catch him off guard, his eyes widening a bit. A sad look flickered across his face, and for a moment he seemed dumbstruck.

He opened his mouth to reply, but when he looked down, he closed it.

Kindred was already out.

They made plans to move Kindred to a base down on Earth within the next day or so, but decided to simply place him back in his own bed until the time came. The room was decently kept, but void of any true personality. It felt as though Kindred was not so much a Councilman as he was a permanent guest.

Maybe the term ‘prisoner’ would be more accurate.

The moment Arc laid Kindred down, he instantly shifted back into that same rude, apathetic demeanor he’d come to them with. He turned around and crossed his arms, looking at the rest of them with his nose turned up. Levi ignored him, and took out his walkie-talkie.

“Any updates?” He asked.

A moment passed, and a static voice replied: “Nothing yet.”

He sighed, hooking the device back onto his belt and looking over at Arc.

They'd asked Arc about God's whereabouts several times throughout this whole ordeal, but he never seemed to want to give them a straight answer. The longer they spent searching the building to no avail, the more frustrating it became.

"So," Luke said, clapping his hands. "Now that we're no longer on the verge of complete and utter annihilation… care to tell us where God is?"

Arc scoffed, and crossed his arms. "Don't you have *other* Councilmen tied up somewhere that you can torture for information?"

"Actually, interesting fact—it turns out torture isn't a very reliable means of obtaining valuable information." Luke said, examining his cuticles. "Supposedly, people will say just about anything to make it stop."

"They're all still unconscious, anyway." Katsuki added. "The ones who are still alive, at least."

Arc sighed, taking a seat on the edge of Kindred's bed. He squeezed his eyes shut and pinched the bridge of his nose.

"Look." He said. "I know you're probably gonna keep badgering me about this, but the thing is… it doesn't matter."

Levi frowned. "What do you mean?"

"It means that if your goal is to kill God, you can do that without ever actually meeting him."

Luke raised an eyebrow. "How?"

"The Lacuna." He replied. "Y'know, the hatch out in the western chamber. Once you evacuate it, God will die."

For a moment, no one said anything. The four of them just stood there, exchanging odd looks of skepticism. It was Levi who finally managed to articulate what they were all feeling.

"The problem with just saying something like that is that without context it just sounds like a ridiculous lie."

Arc gave a mirthless laugh. "Believe me, that's nothing compared to the reality of God's whereabouts. If you think that's crazy, I suggest you stop asking questions now. Quit while you're ahead."

Luke just stared at him for a while, his expression blank. "Arc, how old are you?"

"Four-hundred and twenty-one. Why?"

"Just trying to gauge your audacity." He replied casually. "See, when you've lived as long as Levi and I have, you find very little that truly shocks you anymore. Frankly, if what you're

hiding is incredible enough to make my eyes widen even a millimeter, I'll be quite impressed."

"Eye."

"Pardon?"

"Your *eye,* you mean." Arc said, glancing up at the bandages covering the left half of Luke's face.

"Careful." Luke replied, grinning ominously. "Trust me when I say I do not need depth perception to kill you."

Arc stood up. "I've told you everything you need to know." He said. "As far as I'm concerned, we're done here."

Another long pause followed.

"Arc, if I may ask…" Luke then said. "Have you considered seeking a therapist to address your suicidal tendencies?"

He rolled his eyes. "Oh, cut the bullshit. I know there's no version of this situation where I actually survive."

At this, Luke and Levi glanced at each other, frowning.

"That's… not true." Levi said.

"Contrary to what you may think," Luke added, "We actually aren't just here to kill indiscriminately. It *does* matter whether you're willing to help us."

Arc smiled then—a sad, secretive sort of smile. "You don't understand."

After a second, Katsuki groaned. "Fucking hell, this is going nowhere. Let's just start the damn evacuation."

Levi sighed, standing up straight. "That's probably for the best."

Izuku chewed his lip as he watched the last two keys slide into the locks. Katsuki, Luke and Levi all held two at a time, while Izuku held one—key zero, as Arc had called it.

My father's key, he thought, swallowing the bitter taste on his tongue.

All the locks clicked simultaneously as they turned, and the outer ring of the trapdoor twisted before it popped up with a deep *thunk,* like a suction cup being released. They hauled the hatch open, revealing a small area within that seemed to function as an elevator.

Izuku could already tell it was going to take forever to get everyone out.

“Bring some sort of light source.” Arc said, leaning against the wall with a bored look on his face. “Oh, and don’t put respirators on anyone down there. It usually takes around an hour for the gas to wear off, but trust me—you don’t want them coming to their senses anywhere you can’t restrain them easily.”

“How big is this thing?” Katsuki asked.

“I don’t know.” Arc shrugged. “Big enough that it’ll probably take at least a week to clear it all out.”

Izuku nodded, strapping on a respirator. For some reason, they’d been able to find Katsuki’s respirator, but Izuku’s was nowhere to be seen—it was odd, but luckily, there were extras.

The standing area within the hatch had a few mounted lamps on closer inspection, and as they stepped inside, Izuku sighed, leaning against the rounded walls enclosing it.

Katsuki grabbed the switch and pulled it down, and the elevator started to descend. The walls facing outward were opaque, but had enough holes drilled in to see out around them—not that there was much *to* see. Everywhere he looked, Izuku found only darkness.

As the elevator continued down, Izuku eventually lost interest in looking out into the void, though Katsuki continued to stare, albeit absently. It was only around thirty minutes later—just before they reached the bottom—when Katsuki seemed to tense. He was staring outward still.

“What?” Izuku asked quietly.

“Nothing. Just…” Katsuki leaned closer to the wall, eyes narrowing. “I thought I saw something…”

Izuku frowned. “Like what?”

Katsuki hesitated. “Not sure.”

Moments later, the platform reached the bottom, its solid base hitting the concrete with an echoing *clank.* Izuku swallowed the metallic taste on his tongue, hands trembling as the enclosing walls lifted, allowing them to step out. But as he looked around at the halo of lit area surrounding the elevator, Izuku saw nothing but an infinite stretch of smooth floor. He switched on his flashlight, as the others did the same.

When Arc stepped off, Izuku glanced over at him. “Where is everyone?”

Arc moved up beside him, and then pointed his flashlight upward.

Izuku’s eyes followed the beam of light.

And immediately, he felt like all the blood had drained from his body, leaving him tense and cold.

There they were.

Hundreds, probably *thousands* of limp bodies, all hanging in the air, suspended from what looked like fishing lines. Some of them hung mere feet above the ground, others several stories up—and those were just the ones he could see.

Some of them were fitted with elaborate restraints—mouth guards and straight jackets probably designed to keep them from hurting themselves, by intention or by accident.

Others were… less well-kept. Wrists and ankles left bruised and bloodied by their shackles. Extremities sliced up by the razor thin fishing line that kept them suspended. There was one woman whose fists had apparently been clenched so long, her nails had grown right through the backs of her hands.

Most people were kept horizontal and face down. Perhaps to keep them from choking on their own blood, should they bite their tongue.

Izuku's fingers tightened around the flashlight.

"We used to just pile them up down here. Problem is, if you stack too many people on top of each other, the ones at the bottom get crushed. Even with Angels, there's a limit to how much of that they can survive." Arc explained. "This was the compromise, I guess. It lets us use the space efficiently without killing too many of them—or worse, turning them into husks. Also makes it a lot easier to put people in."

It was more than a little strange, to hear him defaulting back to that cold, irreverent demeanor, given what had happened just an hour earlier. Apparently, empathy was a luxury Arc extended to Kindred, and Kindred alone.

As he stared at the bodies, hanging down like bait for some abomination of the deep sea, the beam of light extending from Izuku's flashlight started to shake.

"You're a fucking *monster."* Izuku whispered.

Arc just shrugged. "I know." He told him. "If it makes you feel better, there was a time when this would've horrified me, too."

He finally found the strength to lower his flashlight, tear his gaze away from the graveyard up above.

"No, I… I actually think that makes it *worse,* somehow."

For a moment, Arc said nothing.

"Power changes people."

Izuku was about to retort when a flash of movement in the distance caught his eye. He lowered his own flashlight and turned, finding a dark figure across the way. At the sight of his light, they quickly scooted away. "Hey, wait!" Izuku ran after them. They weren't very fast, so he caught up quickly. "It's okay, we're not going to—"

He gasped.

Sitting before him was a woman wearing a respirator.

Izuku's respirator.

She had black hair and grey eyes that glowed in the darkness, and atop her head sat a pair of antlers that Izuku couldn't help but fixate on for a moment—she was the only other Demon he'd met who shared that particular trait.

"You…" Izuku said. Then it hit him. "Are you the one we set free? The Demon who was under the floor?"

She only looked down at the ground, remaining silent.

He followed her eyes downward, and it was only then that he actually saw that she was cradling someone. Her cloak shifted, slipping off the person's face, and it was like a shockwave running through Izuku's very being. Izuku dropped his flashlight, and at this, the woman flinched away from him, but Izuku didn't have the presence of mind to apologize.

All Might.

Izuku fell to his knees, ignoring the pain in his back.

All Might was tied up, wearing a bizarre outfit that seemed reminiscent of a straight jacket, There was something in his mouth resting between his teeth, presumably to keep him from accidentally biting his tongue. "All Might…" he whispered, and then shouted, "Arc!"

The man sighed. "What *now?"* He asked, exasperated as he moved over, feet dragging along the concrete.

Izuku pointed at All Might. "How long has he been down here?" He demanded.

Arc scoffed. "You think I know how long *every fucking—"*

"How long?!" He shouted, voice shrill, echoing in the vast space.

"Ow!" He covered his ears. "Fucking hell, keep your voice down."

"Tell me!"

"I don't fucking know!"

Izuku stood up, fists clenched, and swung at him, aiming to punch him in the jaw. Arc caught his fist before it could connect, his larger hand wrapping around it and squeezing painfully tight.

"I don't think you want to do that." He said, his tone sickly sweet, even as Izuku winced and struggled to pull his fist away. "If you think that hurts, just imagine how bad it'd be if one of your careless hits actually *landed."*

Katsuki was at his side a second later, grabbing Arc's wrist and wrenching it away. If the move caused him any pain, it didn't show on his face.

"The fuck do you think you're doing?" Katsuki hissed.

Arc smiled—a bitter sort of smile, which was one part open hostility and one part callous apathy. It reminded Izuku of a teenager being forced into a family photo; he was pissed that he even had to be there, and wanted to make sure everyone else knew.

"Self-defense."

"Self-defense my fucking ass." He scoffed. "You forget what kinda situation you're in, asshole? You're on *thin fucking ice."*

"Yeah? And what are you gonna do, *Demon?"*

"Fuck around and find out."

Izuku was trembling, tears rolling down his cheeks. "Why can't you just—"

"—I already told you, idiot!" He hissed. "*I. Don't. Know."*

"But—"

Arc cut him off with a murderous glare, the vein in his temple popping.

Katsuki put a hand on Izuku's shoulder. "Deku—" Izuku fell to the ground and broke down, sobbing over All Might's body. Vaguely, he heard the sound of Katsuki and Arc arguing with one another, but he couldn't make out anything distinct, and didn't really care to, anyway.

But after a moment, Arc came over, stopping beside Izuku's hunched over form. The woman eyed him warily, leaning over All Might to try to shield him from him. "Fucking—*look."* He said. "I don't know, but it *seems* recent."

"H-How do you know?"

"The…" He gestured vaguely at All Might's body. *"Restraints* he's got on. We only just started using those. I doubt it's been much more than a week, if that." He sighed. "Happy?"

It did make him feel a bit better, but he was still unsure. "But you're just speculating…"

"Yeah! 'Cuz that's all I can fucking do, *dipshit!"* He snapped. "If you really need exact timestamps, wait half an hour and check the official records. Stop taking your feelings out on me!"

Izuku looked up at him, glaring. "And why shouldn't I? You're *responsible."*

Arc gave him an incredulous look. "For fuck's sake." He hissed. "Go choke on your boyfriend's—"

Suddenly, Katsuki locked an arm around his throat from behind, restricting his breathing. He reflexively reached up, grabbing at his arm. Katsuki only tightened the chokehold, leaned forward, and spoke in a calm, menacing tone. “Y’know, I heard that promise you made to Kindred. Be a shame if you couldn’t *keep it.”*

He shoved him away just when his face was starting to turn purple. He gasped and coughed a few times, rubbing his throat.

“You’re off the clock, Arc.” Katsuki told him, eyes narrowed. “You can stop being a complete piece of shit, now.” He offered a menacing smile, at which Arc only sneered. With that, he spun around on his heel and headed back to the platform.

When they eventually boarded the elevator again, they had the woman and All Might with them, and as many others as they could fit.

Izuku had been crying quietly for most of the time they’d spent loading up, and continued to sniffle during the ascent. Arc looked at him and rolled his eyes.

“Quit being so damn dramatic.” He muttered.

Izuku’s eyes snapped up to meet his petulant gaze. As he stared at him, he couldn’t help but remember how he’d behaved in the snapshots Izuku had seen in his dreams, the things he’d said.

Izuku was not in a particularly forgiving mood.

And so, holding eye contact, Izuku responded in the coldest tone he could muster.

“Just because you’ve lost the capacity to care about anything but Kindred doesn’t mean everyone else should, too.”

And for a moment, Arc seemed stunned, his shoulders tensing, eyes widening ever so slightly. Izuku knew he’d struck a nerve, but he didn’t care. He just held his gaze with a decisive scowl, until eventually Arc broke eye contact, rubbing the back of his neck as he looked off to the side, glaring at nothing.

For the rest of the ascent, Arc stayed silent.

They arrived at the surface half an hour later, and carefully unloaded everyone into the surrounding area, allowing the medics to examine them. They’d only managed to fit around twenty people on the platform, but fortunately, they had plenty of Pride Demons available to make the most of what they had.

Still, even then, he could tell it was going to take a while.

Izuku was kneeling by All Might’s side when Katsuki tapped his shoulder.

“Huh?”

Katsuki nodded toward Arc, who was heading toward the exit, looking around suspiciously. It seemed they were the only ones to have noticed—most of the others were far too preoccupied.

Izuku glanced down at All Might, and nodded at the woman who knelt beside him. He still wasn't sure who she was, but he knew that he trusted her.

Meeting eyes with Katsuki, he stood up and followed him to the door, peering around the corner just in time to catch a glimpse of red and gold silk disappearing as he turned left at the end of the corridor. Quietly, they tailed him, and for a minute, they were successful. But pretty soon, Arc caught onto their presence and stopped in his tracks, spinning around to give them an exasperated look.

"Why are you following me?"

"You look like you're up to something." Katsuki replied.

"I'm going to see Kindred."

"Oh, really?" Katsuki snorted. "Well, you're goin' the wrong way. You really think we're that fuckin' stupid?"

Arc groaned, raising his fingers to his temples and massaging them in small circles.

"You're gonna go see God, aren't you."

"What I do is none of your fucking business."

"Actually, it is." Katsuki said. "Y'know, just 'cuz you did one thing for us doesn't mean we trust you, Councilman."

"Why do you insist on seeing God?" Arc asked, through gritted teeth.

"Why do you insist on *preventing* us from seeing God?"

"Because it's not necessary." He said. "And frankly, you won't like what you'll see."

Katsuki scoffed. "Oh yeah? And what, you're just *so* invested in sparing our feelings, huh?"

"It's not about your *feelings."* Arc said, brows pinching together in aggravation. "I just don't want to deal with your fucking reactions."

"And how do we know you're not just sayin' that to trick us?" Katsuki fired back.

Arc frowned, staring back at him for a minute, eyes narrowed. There was a moment of silence that seemed to last an eternity, but finally, Arc spoke once again.

"If I take you to see God, will you leave me the fuck alone?"

"That's really the only thing we need from you, so yeah." Katsuki said.

He pursed his lips. “Y’know what? Fine.”

Izuku’s heart hammered against his chest. He started to turn around. “I’ll go get—“

“—No.” Arc snapped, grabbing the back of his shirt. “No one else. Just you two.”

Izuku turned around, frowning at him. “But why?”

“Because I’m not in the mood to get interrogated by a hundred fucking Demons, that’s why.” He said. “I’ll show you two, but after this, you leave me out of it. If the others want to know, it’s your responsibility to take them down there to see for themselves.”

Izuku and Katsuki exchanged looks. After a moment, both agreed.

Arc sighed, turned on his heel and continued walking. “Don’t say I didn’t warn you.”

With that, the two of them proceeded down the corridor, rounding corners and ducking into various twists and turns until they came upon a room with a large spiral staircase. Izuku immediately recognized it from one of his earlier dreams.

In retrospect, he probably should have taken that for the bad omen that it was.

The staircase was long—much longer than a single story. As they descended, they did not speak.

In the room at the base, there were a number of doors, and a single hallway. They walked down the hall until they reached a large, antique-looking door.

And again, it was a door Izuku had seen before. He swallowed the metallic taste in his mouth as that odd feeling overtook him. It wasn’t ominous, per se, but it carried the same air of inevitability. Something was coming, now—something big. And it did not matter what Izuku did, whether he opted to resist. This was a destiny he could not outrun.

Arc pushed an old, brass key through the lock, and it clicked open. He turned the door knob, but stopped short of entering.

“Are you sure about this?” he asked, not even looking over his shoulder. “I mean it. You’re better off not knowing.”

Katsuki clicked his tongue. “Just open the damn door.”

With a sigh, Arc nodded, and proceeded to push the door open.

Izuku stopped breathing.

It didn’t take long for him to realize he’d been here before.

As the door opened, the sound of ocean waves filled the space which was previously dead silent as his vision flooded with red and black. The space beyond the door did not appear to be a logical endpoint. It didn’t feel like a part of the building, or even Heaven.

It didn’t feel like a part of anything at all, really.

But Izuku recognized it all the same.

The sky was just a dark abyss, so devoid of form or light, it left the space below without context. The door opened atop a large boulder, half-submerged in a blood-red sea that stretched as far as the eye could see. But there was no horizon here. There were only places where space existed, and places where it did not.

As they stepped out onto its surface, Arc closed the door behind them, and Izuku could see that, like in his dream, the door was disembodied, appearing to lead to nowhere.

But even *nowhere* was more *somewhere* than here.

As Izuku turned around, he spotted a speck out in the distance, and when he blinked, it was closer. He realized it was the island, at the center of which stood the tree, its branches reaching into the empty sky, like bolts of lightning frozen in time.

For a moment, he couldn’t move. He could only stare at the tree as it subtly breathed. In, out. In, out. In—

—Although, as a human, Izuku had remained steadfast in his faith until the day he died, it'd be a lie to say he never questioned it. And there were a handful of questions he always seemed to return to.

Sometimes, Izuku would catch himself wondering if, perhaps, all religion was merely a formalized expression of mankind’s hubris. There were two contexts wherein those thoughts commonly arose.

Stepping stones began to rise from the sea, inviting them closer. Arc went first, and Izuku second, along with Katsuki.

The first context was depression. Steeping in self-loathing, Izuku would sometimes wonder if he was wrong. How arrogant, it seemed to him, to presume he knew such sweeping cosmic truths. That he had the answers and that he could help others, when he couldn't even help himself.

As he carefully stepped from one rock to the next, Izuku stared down at his feet, framed by stone and blood-red liquid, waves crashing gently against the pathway.

The second context was whenever he was presented with something that called attention to the sheer scale of the universe. There were times where Izuku suddenly found himself hit with a reminder of just how small humanity really was in the grand scheme of things. Looking at a diagram of the galaxy, it was hard not to ask why God should be one way and not another.

There were a lot of different ways to exist. Izuku was quite certain that the human race did not know all of them, or even most of them.

He could still remember how it felt, to touch that red liquid with his fingers. How overwhelmingly potent it was, like a concentrated dose of pure experience. The distillation of

human suffering.

He wondered what it'd be like if he were to fall, be submerged completely. He wondered if his mind would survive.

There was always this tendency—this painfully human *tendency—to think that the fantastical existed as an intuitive extension of our reality. That things beyond the boundaries of our experiences would be extraordinary, yet familiar.*

His toe touched the moist, stone island. He rolled his foot down, put his weight on it, lifted the other foot. One step. Two steps.

And he knew, of course, that these questions had answers. When he came back to his senses, he would remind himself that God created mankind in his image.

They finally reached the other side after what felt like an eternity. Izuku stood between Katsuki and Arc at the base of the tree. For a moment, it was quiet, apart from the hum of the infinite sea.

But the universe was a very big place.

The trunk was slowly expanding and contracting, and the branches reached far into the abyss beyond. Izuku looked down and saw the sap tap hovering over a small receptacle. It was filled with liquid as black as the void above them.

Izuku opened his mouth, but it took a minute before he worked up the nerve to actually say something.

"Where… where are we?" He asked. "What are we looking at?'

Izuku saw from the corner of his eye as Arc turned and looked at him, remaining silent, at first.

"…This is where it all began."

"…Where *what* began?"

Another pause, and then Arc shrugged. "I don't know. *Something."*

"Stop being so fucking cryptic." Katsuki clicked his tongue. *"Speak plainly."*

Arc only offered him a blank stare, his blue eyes tired, sunken in. "I would if I could." He eventually said. "But some things just defy language."

Katsuki scoffed. "Now you just sound pretentious."

Arc's expression did not change, but he continued to hold eye contact long after the words left Katsuki's tongue. "Don't be obtuse." He finally said. "I know you can feel it, too."

More silence. It might've been ten seconds, or ten days. Time seemed to work differently down there, though he couldn't quite articulate why.

Eventually, Arc broke the silence.

"It's bigger than us. That's all I *really* know. And I know that's not a very satisfying answer, but… that's just the nature of these things, I guess." He said. "Man's search for meaning will always come into conflict with the silence of the universe. That doesn't stop anyone from trying, though."

The universe was a very big place, and most of it was empty space, and most of what wasn't was cold and lifeless, and Izuku had to wonder why God made things this way. Why God created this single oasis in this vast, inhospitable wasteland, and damned humanity to search the stars in vain.

Why did God create us this way—so unfathomably alone?

"Over the years, I've grown tired of trying to understand it." Arc continued. "I think it's because of the blood."

"Blood…?" Izuku said.

Arc pointed at the sap tap, where the black substance continued to ooze out.

"You… drink that?"

He nodded. "It has that affect on you, over time. It grants you strength unlike anything you could imagine, but that same strength destroys you. You're not the person you once were, after you consume it. Before you know it, you're barely a person at all. Just… an agent of power."

Izuku looked out at the red sea. "And… all of this…?"

"Drawn from the Lacuna." He explained. "It wasn't always. But previous sources were too unreliable. So we cultivated our own, and made sure to put it somewhere we could control. Since then, we've managed to keep it alive… just barely."

Whenever he found himself feeling that way, Izuku would pray. Prayer usually made him feel better about the questions he could not answer. Prayer let him straddle the line between knowing too little and knowing too much.

Because that was always the issue, wasn't it?

"So then…" Izuku said. "Punishing sinners…"

"It was never *really* a moral thing." He shrugged. "It won't produce blood without a certain level of excess. That's really all that mattered."

"… It was about power." Izuku whispered.

Arc turned to him then, a sad smile on his face. “Has it ever been about anything *else?”*

Izuku swallowed, his throat suddenly tight.

Izuku wanted the truth, but he wanted to be happy.

He wanted to be enlightened, but he wanted enlightenment to fit into his worldview like a puzzle piece.

He wanted to feel like his life meant something. He wanted to be sedated.

He wanted to want things the way they were. The way things were terrified him to his core.

“And before you ask…” Arc said. “I’d stop drinking it, if I could. But that’s the trouble with it… you can’t.”

Izuku stared at the sap tap, which continued to drip lazily. “Where is God?” He whispered.

Arc gave no response.

Izuku clenched his fists at his sides, and repeated, more emphatically, “Where is God?”

“Midoriya.”

“You said you’d take us to him.”

Arc looked at him passively. “Yes.” He said. “I told you I’d take you to see God. And I have.”

Something was slipping between Izuku’s fingers, and he didn’t know what. It filled his body up with panic. He felt he was losing something he might not get back.

He grabbed Arc by the shoulders and shook him. “What the hell are you talking about?!”

Arc gave a tight smile. “See, I knew this would happen.”

“What?” He shook him harder. *“What?!”*

Arc curtly removed his hands from his shoulders. “You know exactly what I’m saying; you just don’t want to accept it. But if you insist on being obtuse,” He pointed at the tree. *“This is God.* Or rather, it’s the closest thing to a God this world has ever known.”

“No.” Izuku shook his head. “No, that doesn’t make sense. The Originals have spoken to God before… before all of this.”

“The person you’re referring to was not God. He was simply the first Host. And he’s been dead for thousands of years.” He shrugged. “Since his passing, Hidaeriel has taken on the role of God, when needed.”

“You’re lying!”

“You don’t have to accept it!” Arc said, raising his voice for the first time. “By all means, come up with whatever rationalization lets you sleep at night! But there are only two options here. Either this is God, or God never existed to begin with.” He gave a sardonic smile. “I didn’t take you for an atheist, Midoriya.”

Was it so wrong, to want to be happy?

Izuku shook his head, tears blurring his vision as he started to back away. He was almost at the shore when Katsuki caught him. *“Deku.”* He said, with a kind of desperation Izuku had seldom heard before.

Was it so wrong, to not want to be afraid?

And in that moment, Izuku felt something inside of him break. For as long as he could remember, he had been taught to think of God as this all-knowing, benevolent man, who created him in his image, who loved him unconditionally. There was a special place in his heart for him, a cavity he’d whittled out ever since he was young.

But this thing that stood before him, colossal and eternal, with its snake-like tendrils clutching the island, leeching off of the suffering of mankind… it didn’t fit. It *couldn’t* fit. But if not God, then what?

Izuku needed something to fill the pit in his heart, because without it, he was empty.

Without realizing, he began to cry, tears slipping silently down his cheeks.

“I knew this would happen.” Arc mumbled.

Katsuki pulled Izuku into his arms. He grabbed at Katsuki’s shirt and gripped it tight, as though it were the only thing keeping him from slipping into oblivion. Then he lay his head against Katsuki’s chest and cried—for how long, he wasn’t sure. He only knew that by the time he managed to pull away, managed to look at Arc and form words, his throat felt so raw, it hurt to speak.

“It’s… it.” He hiccuped. “Does it *know?* What it’s doing?”

“I dunno. Probably. I’m sure it knows a whole lot of stuff.” He shrugged, and looked up at the tree’s many branches. “Possibly everything.”

Izuku choked on a small cry. “Then *why?* Why would it do this?”

“I don’t know. Sometimes that’s just how things are. I guess it’s possible it might have some sort of ethical framework, but if it does, it’s safe to say it’s not one that grants beings like us much moral consideration.”

“B-But that’s so… *cruel.”*

“See, you’re thinking about this wrong.” Arc sighed. “It’s not for any sort of *malicious* reason; it’s just the terms of its existence. Its life relies on the propagation of suffering.” He explained. “You can’t put your morals in conflict with your own existence.”

The words seemed to hang in the air for a moment. Izuku waited for them to sink in, but they never really did. It was all so alien. And part of Izuku wanted to keep rejecting it. Another part wondered how he could have ever expected anything else.

Perhaps one day things would click into place, but that day would not be this one. As things were, the explanation offered no illumination, did nothing to cover up the chasm in his mind where God used to be, much less fill it up. Perhaps it was unreasonable for Izuku to expect that, but then, reason was never part of the equation to begin with.

“Look, just… don’t think of it as a living thing.” Arc said, his tone softened, ever-so-slightly. “In my experience, it’s more productive to think of it as like… a *system,* I guess. A machine.”

Izuku felt cold, his fingertips numb, palms clammy. He looked up at the thing they called God, at its branches extending out into the infinite darkness. The pulsing sensation in the back of his head came into focus as he stared at it, the way its trunk expanded and contracted slowly.

“Will it try to stop us?” Katsuki asked.

Arc was silent for a moment. Then, “No. No, I don’t think it will.” He replied. “In fact, it probably knew you were coming before you were even born. In a strange way, you might say this is all part of God’s plan.”

Izuku narrowed his eyes. “Killing God is part of God’s plan?”

Arc shrugged. “Would it happen if it wasn’t?”

Izuku opened his mouth to reply, but closed it when he realized he didn’t have an answer for that.

He didn’t have an answer for most things, anymore.

Izuku left the chamber with a numbness that seemed to penetrate down into his bones.

Arc’s path diverged from theirs at the first opportunity, as he presumably went off to be with Kindred. Finally alone, Katsuki gently pulled him into a small, empty room that looked like an unused office.

Without another word, Katsuki pulled him close and wrapped his arms around him, rubbing up and down his back, stroking his hair. Izuku thought he’d break down and cry, but the tears never came. He distantly wondered if the piece of him that believed in God was also the piece of him that knew how to express sorrow.

He clutched the fabric of Katsuki’s top, and for a while, neither he nor Katsuki spoke.

After several minutes, Izuku broke the silence. “Did you expect it?”

Katsuki took a deep breath. “No. Not really.”

Another pause.

“Did it hurt you, too?”

“…Yes.” Katsuki said, after a second. “Not a lot, though. I felt something down there. But it was… distant. Like I was watching it happen to a version of me that just… doesn’t really exist anymore. At least for the most part.” He sighed. “And after the way you reacted, it kind of just… faded away. It wasn’t the thing that bothered me the most.”

Izuku pressed his cheek harder against his chest. “I’m sorry. For how I reacted.” He said, voice a bit muffled. “I… I know I should have—”

“—Deku,” Katsuki cut in. “I’ve had over two centuries to process all of *my* shit. You’ve had a couple of weeks. Cut yourself some fucking slack, will you?”

Izuku didn’t respond to that, and for a few minutes, they fell back into silence. Katsuki held onto Izuku, and Izuku held onto Katsuki, as though he were the only thing grounding him in this world.

It felt more true than he was comfortable admitting.

“I feel like I should be crying.” Izuku mumbled. “I mean… I did, in the moment down there, but now I just feel… *empty.”*

Katsuki hummed, fingers combing through his hair. “You’ll probably cry later.” He told him. “Most likely.”

“…How do you know?”

He felt Katsuki shrug. “That’s just how grief usually goes.”

Those words seemed to stick around for a while; hanging in the air, Izuku breathing them in.

Grief.

That’s what this was, wasn’t it? It was grief, just not the usual kind. Instead of grieving the loss of something, he was grieving something that never really existed to begin with.

Grief, he supposed, was always to some extent about a loss of identity. There was a piece of oneself woven into their interactions with the outside world. Whenever parts of the world died, so too would the piece of oneself that existed only in relation to what was lost. Family members who knew you better than anyone. Friends with whom you shared inside jokes. Pets that greeted you a particular way every time you got home. Every loss carried the realization that those special, personal things you shared with those you cared for could not continue. It was just a part of you that didn’t exist anymore.

But God was always like this; Izuku just wasn’t aware. There was no material difference between Izuku’s life before he learned the truth and Izuku’s life after. The world was static. Only Izuku had changed. Somehow, that made it even harder to process.

“What’s the point?” Izuku asked, after several minutes. “What do we even *exist* for?”

“I don’t know. Do you really need to exist *for* something?” Katsuki asked. “Personally, I think it’s fine to just… *exist.”*

“I mean… I *guess,* but…” He trailed off.

Though he had never mentioned it outright, in the weeks leading up to the invasion, Izuku had dreaded this moment. In his mind, the best case scenario had been ignorance. That the Council had been acting alone, without God’s knowledge. After ignorance, the next best thing would’ve been negligence—that God knew, but simply failed to act. Izuku hadn’t wanted to entertain the idea that God had taken an active role in any of this, because down that road were only two possibilities. Either God was well-intentioned but ultimately morally misaligned, or God was just… malevolent.

And up until that moment, that had been the worst case scenario, as far as Izuku was aware. But now?

It would’ve been so much easier if God had simply been evil. At least evil was some he could make sense of on some vaguely human level.

“It just… feels so *pointless.”* Izuku said. “What *reason* is there to live?”

For a moment, Katsuki didn’t respond. He just continued rubbing up and down Izuku’s back in silence.

Then, “Well… is there any reason *not* to live?”

Izuku frowned, pulling back slightly. “What do you mean?”

“I dunno. Just… y’know, maybe there *isn’t* a reason to keep living. That doesn’t mean you *shouldn’t.”* He shrugged. “I think a better question is whether there’s any reason to *die.* Y’know, living’s kinda the default, Deku. If anyone says we *shouldn’t* keep living, I think the burden of proof’s gotta be on them.”

He pursed his lips, and remained silent. After a while, Katsuki sighed.

“Look, my point is: sure. Maybe there isn’t any big, cosmic reason for us to be alive. But we *are.”* He said. “You’re already here, nerd. Might as well make something out of it, right?”

All Might still hadn’t woken up when they finally returned, and though the others did their best to reassure him, Izuku knew by the looks on their faces, the glances they exchanged amongst themselves, when they thought he wasn’t looking.

They were worried.

And Izuku should have been, too.

But as he sat there beside All Might's sleeping form, laid out on a makeshift bed in an isolated room, he found it difficult to feel anything at all. There was something there—a sort of distant, throbbing sensation in his chest. But it didn't feel like it was happening to him. Looking back, everything, from the moment he stepped out beneath that empty sky, felt more like something he'd seen in a half-remembered movie than a legitimate event.

Maybe if he worked hard enough, he'd one day manage to convince himself that was the case.

But here, in this moment, Izuku was numb. He sat in a cold, metal folding chair next to his unconscious mentor, and stared down at his hands in silence. And he felt content to stay there for another day, or another year, perhaps. It didn't matter much to him either way.

The dark-haired Demon was still there, sitting dutifully at All Might's side, opposite Izuku. She still had yet to say anything to anyone. They weren't sure if it was the result of some sort of physical inability or psychological trauma, and if anyone knew her identity, Izuku was not aware of it. Her protectiveness over All Might gave him a hunch, however. She reminded him of the things All Might had told him about his own mentor, and based on the unusual circumstances under which Nana had fallen, it wasn't unreasonable to suspect she might have wound up in such a situation.

As time passed, the tense atmosphere only seemed to mount. There was something inside of Izuku that he couldn't ignore, and it got colder and colder with each silent minute. Whenever he glanced up, he'd find the other Demon staring at All Might intently. He had yet to see the woman blink, much less look away from him.

It'd been well over an hour and a half since they'd extracted him. Arc said it'd take an hour at most, but there they were. The sun was out. Birds were chirping. And for every second that elapsed, Izuku could feel the numbness inside of him spreading out, infecting him. It reached for the chasm where God used to be and asked to be let in.

But just when it was poised to overtake him, Izuku heard a change in All Might's breathing, almost like a gasp, and he quickly looked up.

All Might's eyes were still closed, but when he leaned in, he could discern movement beneath his lids. Various muscles in his face started to twitch—the corners of his lips, his eyebrows—until finally, his eyelids began to flutter.

Izuku stood up so fast the chair slid back and squealed across the floor. He bent over All Might's bedside, his heart racing.

All Might opened his eyes.

He looked up at him, his gaze unfocused at first, and his brows pinched together, as though he weren't entirely sure what he was looking at. Then there was a moment when his brain seemed to kick into gear, and All Might's eyes went wide, darting back and forth between Izuku and the woman.

"…Is this another illusion?"

His voice was scratchy and hoarse from disuse, but to finally hear it again after all this time flipped a switch inside Izuku's mind.

And suddenly, he felt alive again.

Tears welled up in Izuku's eyes. He shook his head at him, lip wobbling.

All Might sluggishly lifted both hands. Izuku took one between his own while the woman took the other, and as he closed his eyes, tears slipped down his cheeks. He bowed his head as his body shook with sobs, only this time, instead of sorrow, he felt only relief.

Finally. Finally.

In that moment, it was as though everything that had happened the past few months crashed into him all at once. The weight of everything he'd learned, all the things he'd seen and all the transformations he'd undergone—it was like he hadn't fully processed it until then. Ever since All Might had gone missing, he'd been subconsciously compartmentalizing everything, ignoring his own vulnerabilities so he could focus on the goal. Focus on saving All Might.

And now that he was finally there, it was all coming back. It was overwhelming, almost too much for him to take, and yet he reveled in it. He wasn't empty anymore.

He felt a heavy hand on his shoulder, and looked up to find Katsuki standing by his side.

"Ah," All Might said. "Katsuki, I presume?"

"That's me." He said, reaching out to shake his hand. "Good to finally meet you. Deku's told me a lot."

"Likewise." All Might replied. "I suppose it's not the most traditional first meeting, but I'll certainly take it. I'm still not fully convinced this isn't another illusion. To think I'd wake up to find my mentor, my favorite student, and his…" He gestured at Katsuki.

"Uhh… permanent accomplice?" Katsuki offered.

"Sure, that works." He said, laughing. "My mentor, my favorite student, and his permanent accomplice."

Izuku giggled, even as he continued to cry. After a moment, he closed his eyes, reaching up to wipe his tears away, but his movements stilled when he felt something touch one of his antlers. He opened his eyes to the sight of All Might looking back and forth between him and Nana, a wide grin on his face.

"Antlers, eh?"

Chapter End Notes

WHELP. lol honestly i'm not even sure what to say. this took a while for me to write bc there were several choices made that i kept going back and forth on, because like. i mean, basically everything gets revealed here. there are some aspects of it that i'm actually not too crazy about, but for various reasons, i kinda just had to accept it. like the fact i basically had to pull a fuckin darth vader oh god. it's wild to think about how much this fic has diverged from the initial outline… all those tiny changes along the way add up lol.

one of the few things that didn't really change from the beginning was god. it was always gonna be a thinly-veiled metaphor. it was always gonna be fucking absurdist nightmare. in fact there are parts in this very chapter that all but directly quote Camus lmao.

I'd like to to maybe do something (possibly as an extra chapter? idk) where i just go through the whole process of writing this fic. maybe talk a bit about what the initial outline was and how it changed, and perhaps clarify a few things. lmk if you'd be interested in something like that i guess lol.

the last chapter is mostly just wrapping things up. It'll be more relaxed and there won't really be a lot of big reveals, but i hope it'll be enjoyable and that y'all will stick around for it lol. After that I think I'll probably write an epilogue or something. I've also started planning my next fic, which will be…. uhhh, well. it'll be pretty ambitious lol. like to the point where i'm pretty sure the fact i'm seriously planning to take it on makes me fucking insane

ANYWAY. as always, thanks so much for reading, and consider commenting if you enjoyed this bc like. i basically put my whole soul into this lmao so uhhh yeah. until next time, my dudes!

Links and shit:
Fire Lily Wiki
Spotify Playlist
Song I made for this fic
Twitter Hashtag
Deku's Costume Designs
Other miscellaneous shit

Chapter 21: Green Light

Chapter Summary

Izuku spent a lot of time down there, in the days that followed.

Chapter Notes

sorry this took forever i became a software engineer lol. anyway this is 30.2k words, fucking christ. hope u all enjoy it, it's pretty chill tbh

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izuku spent a lot of time down there, in the days that followed.

The evacuation was progressing steadily. Luke and the other Pride Demons were spearheading the operation, and if Levi's estimations were correct, they'd have the Lacuna empty within the week. Now, all that remained was the wait.

Izuku sat atop that smooth boulder, suspended in the unfathomable rift in reality which Arc had since confirmed to be the so-called Restoration Chamber.

He stared out across the expanse of the crimson sea, gaze fixated on the tree which currently stood about fifty feet away. The stepping stones were above the water line, as they tended to be whenever he was there—a silent, open invitation. But Izuku stayed put. He could see just fine. There was no reason to get any closer, or so he told himself.

If he were being honest, Izuku would have to acknowledge that a part of him feared the entity before him. But beneath the shadow of his contempt, grief and betrayal, his fear was insignificant.

Still, there was something unsettling about the pathway, something he'd catch himself thinking about from time to time. It was never quite stationary, always ebbing and flowing in regular intervals, like a throbbing artery bulging just above the surface. It was alien, yet simultaneously organic. To walk across it was to feel the pulse of something greater, though what exactly that thing was, Izuku still wasn't sure.

"How long are you planning on stayin' down here?" Katsuki had asked him, sometime later into the day following the invasion. He could never be certain about when. It had become apparent within the first few hours that time didn't quite work the same in the Chamber.

Sometimes it was slower; sometimes it was faster. He wasn't sure of the cause for these temporal fluctuations. They seemed to happen at random.

"Deku?"

"Sorry." Izuku said, shaking himself from his thoughts. "I'm, uhh…" He hesitated, eyes still fixated on the tree. "I'm not sure… really…"

For a moment, Katsuki was silent. Then, he took a deep breath, and came to sit down beside him, leaning back on his hands.

"Dunno what you're hoping to gain from this…" He mumbled. "We already grilled Arc for all the info he had. Doubt there's much more you can learn just from starin' at it like this."

"Maybe." Izuku said. "I mean… I don't know. It's not like I'm expecting it to… to *talk* to me, or something. I'm just…"

And he could feel the weight of Katsuki's stare, even without looking at him. At first it seemed he was waiting for him to continue, but as seconds ticked by, it seemed to drift more towards quiet study. Eventually, he sighed.

"Look, nerd… I know you wanna understand it. But I think there's a point where you gotta step back and just…" He trailed off.

For the first time since Katsuki had come in, Izuku managed to tear his gaze away from the tree. He turned his head slightly, glancing over at him. "What?"

"Well, you know." He huffed. "Y'kinda gotta ask yourself if it's actually *worth it."* The words hung in the air for a moment as Katsuki shifted his weight off his hands, pulling his knees in a bit and leaning forward. He gestured limply at the tree. "'Cuz like—sure, it's possible there's more to this shit, but…" His hands dropped heavily at his sides. "I dunno. Even if you *could* know, would you really want to? D'you think that'd make you *happy?"*

"It's not really about happiness." He said. "It's more like…" His brows pinched together as he struggled for a way to articulate it—this thing that had been festering inside of him ever since Arc first took them there, sometime during the early hours of a yesterday that now felt eons away.

Katsuki waited several seconds. "Deku…?"

Izuku's hands formed fists around the fabric of his pants—a pair of silky pajama bottoms he'd found in the fourth Councilman's bedroom. They were a bit long on him, but the material was soft—and more importantly, free of blood stains.

"It's… not about what I want, I guess. It's more like I just *need* to know." He said. "Even if it's awful. Even if it makes it… hurt more. I think…" He took a deep breath, and exhaled slowly. "I think it's the only way I'll be able to move on."

Katsuki didn't reply immediately, but his gaze never left him. "Y'know," He eventually said. "It's possible there really *isn't* anything more to it. Or if there is, it's shit your brain couldn't

comprehend anyway."

Izuku hesitated, frowning.

"…Sure." He said. "But… well, what's your point?"

"My *point* is," He raked a hand through his hair. "I mean, even if you really *did* know everything there was to know, you wouldn't have any way to know that was the case, right?" He sighed. "So where's the closure? How do you know when you're *done?"*

Izuku opened his mouth to respond, but the words wouldn't come to him. For a time, he just stayed that way, mouth gaped as he awaited the arrival of a clarity that might not exist. He was tired, his exhaustion penetrating each layer of his being, past his bones and into his very existence. His despondency ran deeper than he'd ever thought possible, rooted in a part of himself he never expected he'd need to think about. The feeling was saturating and all-encompassing, almost as insurmountable as the entity that stood before him.

It took several minutes before Izuku managed to respond, and even then, it felt impotent. A weak gesture toward something that vaguely resembled an answer.

"I suppose it's not really up to me, in the end." He said, words tasting bitter on his tongue. "I'm done when it dies… whether I feel ready or not."

Izuku said nothing more, but for the next few minutes—or hours, for all he knew—he sat there stiffly, fingers still clenched around the silk of his pants.

Katsuki did not press him any further.

Though the difference was imperceptible from one moment to the next, it was easy to see from day to day. The crimson liquid which filled the Restoration Chamber was draining, slowly but surely—evidenced by the residual stains running along the side of the boulder on which Izuku was perched.

Most of the time he was alone, but occasionally, Katsuki would join him. Sit by his side and talk with him, about anything and everything. Sometimes their conversations would be completely irrelevant to the place in which they were had. Sometimes they felt almost normal.

Once in a while, Izuku would be joined by someone else.

All Might came in sometime in the morning of the second day, silent as he went to sit beside him. Izuku looked over at him, offering a small, half-hearted smile. All Might was still an Angel, though he now sported dark, static-like marks on his arms and the backs of his shoulders—points where Nana had touched him while he was still unconscious.

"All Might." He swallowed. "Um, how are you feeling?"

"Never been better." He replied, with a grin.

At that, Izuku did a bit of a double take. “Wait, really? But… your injuries—”

“—Have been cared for quite comprehensively.” He cut in. “Admittedly, my back is still a bit sore. Those suspension rigs were not particularly comfortable, I must say.”

“I guess that’s the point.”

“I suppose so. But other than that, I’d say I’ve just about bounced back.”

Izuku nodded slowly. “I’m really happy to hear that…” He trailed off as his gaze returned to the tree again. The gravitational center of his attention.

For a time, it was silent. They both stared at the entity before them with relaxed expressions, but Izuku did not feel calm. His heart was pounding in his chest, his palms clammy as he gripped the fabric of his pants, forming fists that left wrinkles in their wake. There was something he’d been meaning to ask All Might, but he hadn’t gotten the chance until then. The question sat heavily on the tip of his tongue, pressed up against the insides of his lips. He knew he needed to know the answer. He just wasn’t sure that he *wanted* to.

Eventually, Izuku found it in himself to open his mouth and quietly ask: “Did you know?”

He could see All Might turning to look at him from the corner of his eye. Izuku kept his head forward, staring into the once-deep sea of red, now shallow enough that he could just see the bottom.

All Might sighed. “About which part, exactly?”

Izuku shook his head. “Everything.” He shrugged. “All of it. I guess.”

“Right.”

For a while, he said nothing more, and the silence tightened between them like the hairs of a bow, ready to snap at any second. Just as it started to feel unbearable, All Might continued.

“I had no idea about your father.” He said. “I really didn’t. I… felt that you were unique, somehow. But I was never quite sure why. You just seemed… different.” He took a deep breath. “And when you demonstrated your ability to use power without a weapon, my feelings were validated.”

“Wait.” Izuku froze. “Is… Is that why I was able to do that? Because I’m…”

“Eh, I suppose I can’t say for sure… but I doubt it was a coincidence.” All Might said. “Especially considering the fact that, when you think about it, the only Angels typically capable of using magic unarmed are Councilmen.” After a second, he amended, “Well, apart from the Acolytes, of course. But they don’t really count; technically speaking, they aren’t actually *Angels.”*

“But why?” Izuku wondered, and he wasn’t sure who he was asking—himself, All Might, God. “Is it something… genetic? I wouldn’t expect something like that to be hereditary.”

“Speaking as someone who lived during a time when bloodletting was still common practice and whose only knowledge of current medicine is that which he has been able to absorb through a sort of vague, cultural osmosis, it’s safe to say that I am *spectacularly* unqualified to answer that question.” He said, with a hearty laugh. “That said, I think it’s also safe to say that quite a lot of scientific norms fly out the window once God gets involved.”

Izuku gave a slight smile. “Right. I guess that makes sense…” He trailed off.

“As for God…” All Might continued, after a moment. “I can honestly say I did not expect this. Frankly, I doubt anyone could have. There’s being cynical and then there’s… well, this.” He nodded toward the tree. It was now only around twelve feet from them. Izuku didn’t like it, having it so near. It always felt a bit too close to being watched, whatever that meant for a being of God’s magnitude.

He nodded, expression neutral. “I guess you’re probably right.” He said, then bit his lip, pausing before following up. “What *did* you expect, then?”

All Might stared up at the empty, black sky, his lips pursed. He remained silent for a very long time, to the point where Izuku was beginning to wonder whether he’d heard him at all.

“It’s… hard to give a straight answer for something like that.” He finally replied. “I think I, like many people, tended to fluctuate between a couple of theories… Sometimes I felt certain that everything was truly as they said it was. Other times…” He trailed off.

Izuku glanced at him, his brow furrowed. “All Might?”

“I think…” he sighed. “I think somewhere deep down inside, there was a part of me that believed God to be dead.”

Izuku fully turned his head toward him again. “You… really?”

He nodded. “Dead, or at the very least, permanently incapacitated. It wasn’t something I would allow to stay in my head for long, at least not consciously. But it was always there, I think—somewhere in the back of my mind… This little voice that would remind me how much of our world could be explained if it were true.” His brows pinched together. “I… hated how rational it seemed.”

All Might’s gaze fell upon the tree again, and he stared at it as though it were a particularly difficult math problem. After a few seconds, his gaze dropped to his lap, where his hands were folded tightly.

“And when Nana started working under the Commander, I got to see first hand just how power-hungry that man could be. He always struck me as the sort of person who would gleefully throw just about anyone under the bus, if it would help him advance. The kind of man for whom no true God existed apart for himself.” His lips quirked up. “A temporarily-embarrassed diety, if you will.”

At this, Izuku gave a small laugh, barely more than a sharp exhale through his nose. “So you figured they were all like that? The Council.”

“Not necessarily. It was more like… well, he was an example of just how bad they *could* be.” He said. “And of course, I *did* eventually meet some of the others, so I knew they weren’t on the same level, but…” He paused, clasping his hands together. “Well, I guess it always just seemed… rational. The Commander was the prototype that proved the Councilmen weren’t above prioritizing their own self-interest. And, well—I suppose it just made sense to me that they’d try to take God’s place, given the chance.”

Izuku was quiet for a moment, his eyes drifting back, coming to rest at the base of the tree. He noticed that the roots seemed to flex every now and then—probably to pull from the body of fluid surrounding it. After a second, he glanced down at his lap, forcing his hands to relax.

“Why did it turn out like this?”

The question seemed to take All Might off guard. “What do you mean?”

“I just mean… Well, why weren’t they… *prepared* for this? For *me.* That’s the thing that doesn’t make sense to me.” He pulled his knees in closer to his body. “I’m not the first one, um… of my kind. My…” He bit his tongue. “He’s had… a lot of children. Surely by now someone else would’ve demonstrated these abilities.”

All Might hummed. “Well, you have to think about these things in terms of probabilities, Midoriya. It’s true—you’re not the first child of a Councilman, nor were you the first to receive training in secret. But you need to keep in mind that both of these groups are rather small. It’s not unreasonable to think you might have been the first person in the intersection of the two.”

Izuku bit his lip. “Yeah, I guess so…”

For a moment, All Might was quiet. “Well, there’s one other option, as well.”

“What’s that?”

He shrugged. “Incompetence.”

Izuku blinked. “Sorry?”

All Might chuckled and shifted his weight, sitting back on his palms. “Midoriya, there’s…” He faltered, looking up, as though considering his words. “Look,” He said. “I… think that for most of us, we tend to think of powerful people as inherently… extraordinary. But the further up the ladder you go, the more you start to realize that it’s not really the case. There are exceptional people here and there, but… more often than not, the most unique thing about the people in those positions is that they managed to survive long enough to reach them. And that certainly doesn’t count for *nothing,* but it doesn’t count for *everything,* either.”

He was suddenly reminded of something Katsuki had told him, what now felt like a lifetime ago.

“You don’t live in a meritocracy.”

“Well, sure, but…” Izuku frowned. “I mean, it’s not really *about* the individuals, right? It’s the overarching system. That’s where the power comes from, isn’t it…?”

“Yes,” All Might cocked his head. “But the stability of systems like these is far more precarious than most people would think. History has provided many examples of this. Nations have crumbled beneath the force of insurrections carried out by just a handful of people, and even the most prosperous countries could be brought to their knees by, say, a well-organized strike in a critical industry.

“If there’s anything that sets powerful people apart, it’s their knowledge of this. Everyday people tend to think of these systems as facts of life—as fixed as the Earth’s rotation. And people in positions of power do what they can to maintain that illusion, all while quietly making it harder for them to use the tools at their disposal. If labor movements are a threat, they’ll pass legislation to make that sort of organization difficult.”

Izuku swallowed. “But by that logic, you’d think the most oppressive regimes would be the least stable.”

“That’s not the inconsistency you probably think it is.” He said. “Think about it. What kind of government would want to restrict access to information, Midoriya?” He asked, a playful lilt to his tone. “To want to regulate its citizens exposure to new ideas.”

Izuku blinked. “I guess it’d have to be… one where too much knowledge could undermine their power, somehow?”

“Precisely.” All Might said. “If you want to know where a regime’s achilles tendon is, you need only look toward the things they try to keep you from doing.”

Izuku laughed softly.

“Hmm?”

“Sorry. Just… you sound like Kacchan, almost. He always says stuff like that.”

“Oh, really?”

“Well, not *quite.* Kacchan would’ve inserted swears after every other word, and then called me a dumbass, only with the same tone you’d use to call someone ‘darling’ or ‘sweetheart.’” He snorted. “So it’s the same basic idea, just… less profound.”

All Might laughed. “I like that. There’s something oddly charming about it.”

Izuku sighed. “Yeah… I guess I agree. Don’t tell him I said that, though.”

All Might did a gesture, as if to say, ‘my lips are sealed.’

Then suddenly, All Might’s eyes widened. “Ah! Before I forget—Nana wanted me to thank you. She told me you and Katsuki were the ones who set her free.”

“She…” Izuku’s brow furrowed, *“Told* you that?”

“Oh, you haven’t heard? She’s gotten her voice back.” He said. “It was some sort of enchantment, I suppose. It took a fair amount of pestering, but the Martyr eventually explained how to lift it… he was rather rude throughout the whole process, though.”

Izuku laughed softly. “Yeah, he’s not… the *most* pleasant person.”

“Eh,” All Might shrugged. “I can put up with the attitude. He’s certainly been more helpful than any of the others.”

Izuku’s eyes widened. “Wait, you mean they’re still alive?”

“One and Two are.” He replied. After a moment of hesitation, he added, “And, of course… your father is, as well.”

Izuku gulped, suddenly plagued with unease. “I… would’ve thought they’d have, err… *taken care* of them by now.”

“You mean execute them?”

He winced. “Well… *yes,* but…”

All Might smiled. “I’ll admit, they seem a lot more averse to the idea than I initially assumed they’d be.” He said. “They *have* tried exposing them to corruption damage, but apparently, it hasn’t worked.”

“Really?” Izuku raised an eyebrow at first, but after a second, his face fell neutral. “I guess I can’t say I’m *too* surprised…”

All Might hummed. “They’ve been trying to question them.” He said. “It… hasn’t been too successful, from what I’ve heard.”

Izuku frowned. “How come?”

“It’s their powers, mostly.” He sighed. “One and Two’s, at least. The trouble is that there’s not currently any known way to prevent them from using them. It seems that in addition to healing himself, the Healer is also capable of destroying the motivation of anyone who gets close enough. As for the Rejector… well, he’ll simply make you too tired to continue.”

“Okay, but… what about the blood?” Izuku asked. “Surely there must be a way for us to leverage their dependence on it.”

“You would think so. But apparently, their doses aren’t frequent enough for that—at least, not yet. Councilman Five estimates it’ll be at least two more weeks before the Healer becomes desperate enough, and at least a month for the Rejector.”

“Oh…”

“As things stand, the only way we’ve managed to ask them anything at all has been remotely, over an intercom. But of course, there’s very little reason for them to respond, without the direct intervention of someone like Aizawa.”

His shoulders slumped. “I see.”

“And as for your father…”

Izuku tensed. “They’ve woken him up?” His throat felt tight, all of a sudden.

“A few times.” All Might carefully replied. “Lucifer—ah, I mean Luke. Sorry, using that name feels… strange, still.” He winced. “Anyway, Luke tried to hypnotize him into speaking continuously, and it… well, it didn’t go too well.”

“…It didn’t work?”

“It… *sort of* worked, at first.” He squinted. “But apparently he put up quite the fight, and in the end, Luke had to leave after experiencing what has been described to me as, ‘the Niagara Falls of nosebleeds.’”

Izuku grimaced. *“Oh.”*

“Yeah.” All Might mirrored his expression. “So, they’ve decided to shelve the matter for now.”

“…I guess I can’t blame them.”

For a moment, it was quiet. Izuku swallowed multiple times, but he couldn’t get rid of the sour taste on his tongue.

“I’m told…” All Might started, then stopped, an uncertain look on his face.

“All Might?”

He sighed. “I’ve been told that he… wants to speak with you.”

Izuku stiffened. “Is that so.”

“You don’t have to.” All Might quickly said. “In fact, most of us agree that you probably shouldn’t.”

Izuku bit his tongue. “It… probably wouldn’t do much good.”

All Might nodded. “And we don’t really need any information from him, anyway. They’re just questioning him to be safe, in case any futures contingencies emerge that—“

“Wait. That…” He hesitated. “The way you’re talking about it makes it sound like…” His brow furrowed. “Like he’s refusing to speak to anyone but me.”

All Might froze, clearly taken aback. “Damn it.” He muttered.

“I’m right, aren’t I?” Izuku sat up straighter. “He said—“

“—Midoriya, seriously. You really don’t need to do this. The potential gains aren’t worth the distress.”

“Well, if it could be helpful…”

“Midoriya—“

“—I’ll do it.” Izuku interrupted. “It’s fine. I’ll be… fine.” He said. “I can do it. I… *want* to do it.”

All Might stared at him for a while, his brows pinched together. “Are you sure?”

“I’m sure.” Izuku clenched his jaw. “Frankly… I’ve got some questions for him, too.”

And so there he was, standing before the door to the interrogation room, his hand trembling over the handle as he tried to will his heart rate to slow down. Izuku closed his eyes and took deep breaths, but he just couldn’t quite shake the anxiety churning up inside of him.

Long, sturdy fingers closed around his wrist, stabilizing him, and he looked up to see Katsuki staring down at him, concern etched into his features. “Deku, seriously.”

Izuku averted his eyes, looking instead at Katsuki’s hand gripping his wrist. “What?”

He sighed. “You need to ask yourself if you really want to do this.” He said. “‘Cuz if you’re just doin’ it ‘cuz you think it’ll help, it’s not worth it.”

“But it probably *will* help.”

“I don’t care.” Katsuki clipped. “What I’m sayin’ is… if you wouldn’t wanna talk to him even if you knew it *wouldn’t* help us at all, don’t fucking do it.”

Izuku frowned, turning the words over in his mind. After a minute, he took a deep breath, and did his best to exhale his reservations. “It’s okay, Kacchan.” He said, steadier than he’d expected to be. “I’ll be okay.”

Katsuki stayed still at first, but after a few seconds, he released his wrist, fingers dragging across his skin reluctantly. “Shout if you need anything. I’ll wring that fucker’s neck faster than you can blink.”

Izuku offered a small, hopefully reassuring smile. And after taking a deep breath, he quickly turned the door knob and entered the room, before he could lose his nerve. Evidently, the man must’ve been staring at the door before he came in, because he met his eyes almost instantly. Izuku’s jaw tensed as he fought the urge to look away. The heavy door closed behind him, leaving him alone with the man.

Councilman Zero, the Councilman of Compassion. The man who had gotten away with impersonating God for thousands of years.

His father.

His steel restraints clinked against the table as he shifted in place, and as Izuku approached, he was struck by how much resemblance there was. His hair was darker, and he didn’t have

freckles, but anyone who saw them together would have guessed they were related. Izuku swallowed the sour taste on his tongue. It'd been there since his conversation with All Might.

Hidaeriel smiled at him—a wide, toothy grin that made his eyes crinkle up such that it nearly looked genuine. But even then, he could sense that there was something off about him. Something in the way the muscles of his face appeared to seize up beneath his skin, the way his eyes never seemed to focus on him properly. Sometimes, it'd feel like he was looking straight through Izuku, staring into the space beyond. Other times, it'd seem as though he wasn't looking *into* Izuku's eyes so much as he was staring *at* them, independent from Izuku as a person.

At any given second, the man was either seeing Izuku as an amalgamation of parts, or not seeing him at all.

Neither one boded well for the coming conversation.

He allowed himself one last glance at the door, but made no move toward it. Instead, Izuku slowly pulled out the chair on the opposite side of the table and sat down. In response, Hidaeriel strained against the chains around his body, making them go taut as he tested them. Izuku suspected he did it for show. To tell Izuku that if he could, he'd force his way out of the chains, and who knew what would follow from there.

"It's nice to see you again, Son."

Izuku flinched at the sound of that last word off his tongue. He looked up at him, but didn't speak.

"How's your shoulder healing?" He asked, glancing down at it, where the bandage was just barely visible, poking out from under his sleeve.

Izuku ignored the twinge of irritation he felt. "It's fine."

"Oh, really?"

"Yes." He clipped. "But I didn't come here to talk about that."

"Can't a father express concern for his son's wellbeing?"

"You—" Izuku cut himself off, clenching his jaw. He closed his eyes and took a deep breath. When he opened his eyes again, Hidaeriel's smile seemed wider. He was doing it on purpose, because of course he was. "It falls a bit flat when you're the one who caused it, but thanks for your concern, *dad."* He forced himself to say, with no small amount of sarcasm. He pushed on before the man could comment on it. "I'm going to ask you some questions."

"Yes, I suppose you are."

"And I want you to answer them."

"I'm sure you do."

Izuku narrowed his eyes, hesitating for a moment. He shook his head. “What happened to the first host?”

“He’s dead.”

“I’ve gathered that. What I’m asking is how you did it.”

He shrugged. “I don’t see how that matters.”

Izuku sighed. “Well, where did he come from?”

He shrugged again. “From God.”

He blinked. “From—“

“’Host’ is a bit of a misnomer.” He interjected, sounding bored. “He was more like a child, or perhaps an *instance.”*

“An instance of what?”

“An instance of a host, of course.”

Izuku paused, leaning back and pinching the bridge of his nose. “What do you *mean* by that?”

He hummed. “The Host was the interface through which God’s power interacted with us.”

“So like a messenger…?”

“In some sense of the word. One of God’s own making.”

“And why hasn’t there been another one?”

“It would have been quite irresponsible for me to allow that to happen, wouldn’t you agree?” He smiled. Izuku just stared back at him, his brows pinched together.

“What *is* God?” He eventually asked.

“Why, whatever do you mean?”

“You *know* what I mean.”

“No, I’m afraid I don’t. You’ll need to be more specific.”

Izuku opened his mouth, and for a moment, it just hung that way. Finally, he begun to speak again, slow and measured. “God isn’t a person. Not in the way I’ve been taught. You can’t… interact with him.”

“Oh? Can’t you?” He tilted his head.

Izuku frowned. “Excuse me?”

“Izuku…” He said, his tone patronizing. “Did it never occur to you that perhaps God has been interacting with you this entire time?”

“What are you talking about?”

“Oh dear.” He sighed. “Don’t tell me you truly believe that place is *real.* Next you’ll tell me you think God actually *is* a tree.“

Izuku gaped at him for a moment, unsure what to say. “What—“

He sighed again, in this forced, aggressive sort of way. “You know, I would have thought my son would be able to figure something like this out on his own. Then again, I would’ve also thought my son would be above killing his own father, so—”

“Just answer me!” He snapped. “What *is* God? If he’s not the tree down there, then what the hell *is* he?”

Hidaeriel stared at him for a while, his expression something between amusement and threat. “What you’ve seen down there in the Restoration Chamber is not God’s truest form. It is simply the closest form that your brain is able to make sense of.” He explained. “When I say that God has been interacting with you this whole time, that is what I’m referring to. God’s presentation is an intentional act; an approximation of his true being.”

“…Oh.” His brow furrowed as he thought about it. For a few seconds, neither of them spoke.

“Or, maybe he actually *is* a tree, and I’ve been lying to you this entire time.”

Izuku tensed. At first, he didn’t feel anything in response to those words. He was just numb. But slowly, burning irritation bloomed within him, and he had to take a moment to breathe. He didn’t want to give his father the satisfaction of getting him to lose his temper.

After several seconds, Izuku kept his voice steady and asked, “What do you want?”

For the first time, Hidaeriel seemed surprised. “Me?”

“Yes, you, *dad.”* The word left his tongue drenched in venom as he abruptly leaned in, elbows hitting the steel table. “I was told you wanted to talk to me. Is this all you wanted to do? Just sit there and tell lies?”

“I never *confirmed* that I was lying.” He said coolly. “I only said I *could* be.”

“Uh-huh. Right.” Izuku rolled his eyes. “And what’s your endgame, here? What are you hoping to achieve?”

“Nothing in particular.” He shrugged. “I just wanted to see you. Talk to you, at least once, while I have the chance. I’ve always been the sentimental type, you see.”

Izuku scoffed. “Really? And why now? You clearly couldn’t be bothered while I was human.”

“It’s hard work, being God’s favorite.”

“But you’re *not* God’s favorite. Not really.” Izuku said. “You’re just an opportunist. You’re a *parasite.”*

He sighed. “I really was hoping to keep this conversation civil.”

“Civil? *Civil?!”* Izuku said, incredulous. “Don’t you *dare* talk to me about civility. You, of all people! How many people have you personally condemned to eternal suffering, *dad?* Thousands? *Millions?”* He shouted. “Acting polite and formal does not make you *civil.* I can’t even imagine a person *less civil* than you!”

“And I imagine, had they the ability, a gazelle would say the same about a lion.” He replied evenly. “It’s not my fault you’re too caught up in your human perspective to understand the big picture.”

“You think the ends justify the means. That’s what you’re saying, isn’t it.”

“In a sense, yes.”

“And what ends are those? The preservation of all of this? Heaven?” Izuku asked. “Or maybe you’re talking about your own powers. Just how much suffering does it take to fuel those, *dad?* How much misery do you consume every time you want to look a few seconds into the future?” He sneered. “I’d ask if you’ve ever actually stopped to wonder about things like that, but I think we both already know the answer.” Izuku abruptly stood up, chair squealing across the floor with the force of it. “I think we’re done here.”

“So soon?” He cocked his head. “Well, that’s a bit unfair. I didn’t get to ask you much of anything.”

“Why would you need to?” Izuku said, turning his back on him. “You’ve already made it quite clear that you don’t care about anyone other than yourself.”

Izuku made quick strides toward the door. He was halfway there when his father spoke again.

“So, has Beelzebub woken up yet?”

Izuku stopped in his track, muscles going stiff. He didn’t speak, or move at all. His father seemed to take it as an invitation to continue.

“You know, It’s a shame it had to be him. Out of all the disciples, he was probably the one I had the greatest affinity for. Granted, that was mostly because he tended to stay out of everyone’s way.” He sighed. “It made me a bit sad, seeing just how much he’d changed. I did try to stop him, you know. I had expected him to panic and flee, when I told him I was responsible for the attack that killed Mammon. It didn’t seem *like* him to become so… enraged. I suppose the others must’ve worn off on him.

“It’s a shame; had he been smart enough to request backup, he might not have wound up in such a precarious position.”

By the time he'd finished, Izuku's fists were clenched at his sides, nails biting into his flesh hard enough to draw blood. On the surface, his father's tone was kind and conversational, but he could hear the truth of it underneath the veneer. The words were built on a foundation of condescension, drenched in something cruel and cynical and designed to *hurt.*

Izuku took a few deep breaths, and tried to shake the rage.

He's trying to provoke me into responding. Either he's attempting to drag this out by any means necessary, or he sees upsetting me as an end in itself. He thought. *I can't win. No matter what his intentions are, I will not win.*

It was this thought that gave Izuku the strength to move again, his tense muscles making each step robotic. He didn't say anything, nor did he look over his shoulder. He just opened the door and stepped out into the hall.

And out of all the actions he'd taken during the encounter, his greatest achievement was not slamming the door behind him.

The steady beeping of Bee's heart monitor filled the small room. Izuku was standing at his bedside when Katsuki came back, and he turned around just in time to catch the fruit Katsuki tossed him.

"Thanks." Izuku said softly.

"Mm." He nodded, and bit into his embrite as he came to stand next to him. Izuku did the same, peeling the skin off the senvil and breaking off a section, sweetness covering his tongue as he chewed it.

They continued to eat quietly until both of them had finished, and after a minute, Izuku broke the silence.

"What…" He started. "What happens if…"

"Huh?"

Izuku hesitated, chewing his lip. "Just… what happens if he doesn't…" he gestured at Bee's unconscious form.

"Oh." Katsuki grunted. "You shouldn't worry about that right now. If a month passes and he still hasn't woken up, that's one thing, but anything under that's fairly standard shit. It's not that weird for someone to come outta a weeks-long coma and make a full recovery."

"Really?" The thought comforted him, but only a little bit. "Still… what if he doesn't?" He asked again. "What happens then?

Katsuki sighed, and for a good while, he didn't respond.

"There's not really a single answer to that." He then said. "There's… a lotta things that could happen, depending on how long it's been. But it sounds to me like what you're really asking

is whether he'd stay on life support forever."

Izuku swallowed against the dryness in his throat, and nodded, staring down at his feet.

"In that case… well, probably not. But it's complicated, obviously. Ideally, we'd try to get his consent before we… well, y'know."

Izuku's brow furrowed. "How can someone consent if they're in a coma?"

"Some people put their wishes in writing just in case." Katsuki shrugged. "But there are other ways, most of which involve a fuck ton of magic. It's… pretty hit-or-miss, but it can work."

"Right…"

The conversation faded out again, with Izuku staring down at the floor and only occasionally glancing up. Bee's hand lay palm-up on the bed, the IV needle keeping his arm straight. He seemed so much paler than Izuku remembered, the dark circles beneath his eyes deeper. But maybe that was just the fear talking.

He found himself thinking back to the conversation he'd had with Bee, just before the invasion. The way he'd talked about Mammon as though he wasn't really gone. As though he genuinely thought he'd see him again someday.

"…Kacchan?"

"Yeah?"

Izuku hesitated. "Do you think there could be something else after this?" He asked. "Like an… after-after-life."

"Uhh… I dunno. Why?"

"I was just thinking." He said. "I mean, the fact that the original afterlife turned out to be real at least makes it plausible, right…? We already know that souls can persist after death, in another body, another place. If it can happen once, why not twice?"

Katsuki hummed softly. "I guess so. But if there really was a second afterlife, you'd think we'd see some sorta evidence for it. Interactions between humans and Demons were pretty low in peace time, but it was never *zero."*

"Maybe we *have* interacted with them and just don't know it." He shrugged, and finally turned to look at Katsuki. "On the rare occasions when humans crossed paths with Angels or Demons, how often would they have been aware of it?"

"Huh." Katsuki looked up in thought. "Guess you've got a point there." He paused, a small smile tugging at the corners of his lips. "Maybe that's it, then. No endings, just new lifecycles."

Izuku nodded. "We just become something else, go someplace new.

“Spacetime nomads all the way down?”

“Yeah, I think…” Izuku offered a small smile of his own. “I think I like the sound of that.”

The door clicked open in the evening of the second day. Izuku turned around, expecting to see Katsuki standing in the doorway. His back straightened.

“Levi?”

“Midoriya,” He smiled, then ducked under the door frame, stepping into the chamber. He grunted slightly as he dropped to a squat at his side before sitting down, long legs crossed. Even like this, the man still towered over Izuku.

For a minute, Levi just stared across the water, eyes fixated on the tree. He couldn’t tell whether he was deep in thought, or simply zoning out; the bags under his eyes betrayed his lack of rest these past few days.

“Um,” Izuku cleared his throat. “Is everything alright?”

“Hm?” Levi turned and looked at him, head dropping. It was a tendency of his that Izuku had noticed: hunching over when he spoke to others. Probably something he’d learned to do, to compensate for his intimidating height. “Oh. Yeah, nothing’s wrong. We just decided to call it for the night.”

Izuku hummed. “How’s it going?”

“Pretty well.” He said. “We’ve cleared out about a fourth of it. So as of now, we’re on track to be done within the week.”

Izuku nodded, and they both went back to staring at the tree. For a moment, it was quiet.

“How much did you guys really know, back then?” Izuku asked.

Because how could he *not* ask.

Levi didn’t respond immediately, but Izuku didn’t try to clarify. There was something about the man—something baked into the lines of his stature, to the tiny movements of his facial muscles—that told Izuku he knew exactly what he was referring to.

“Not as much as you might think.” He finally said. “We knew about this place, this… so-called room. But none of us had ever been in here, of course. We weren’t allowed.” He paused, looking up at the lightless sky. “I think… Well, I’m *sure* we all had our own theories about it, but it was never discussed. Too taboo, I guess. Even after we Fell, it took a while before any of us were able to talk about it openly. A few centuries, at least. And even longer before any of us could have a productive conversation about it.”

“Really?” Izuku frowned. “Why’d it take so long?”

Levi shrugged. “Depends who you ask, I guess. I think it probably had to do with how suddenly we Fell. Being cast out by God was hard enough to process on its own without all the physical changes.

“And the thing you’ve got to keep in mind is that we were the first Demons; we didn’t know anything. When we got to Hell, it was just a hostile wasteland. No infrastructure. No resources or systems in place to help us navigate the transition. We were just on our own.” He said. “So, the short answer is that it just wasn’t really a priority.”

“I guess that makes sense,” Izuku said, chewing his lips. “But I mean, surely you must have *thought* about it, at least privately.”

“Sure. I thought about it. It’s… complicated, though.” He sighed. “As an Angel, I was pretty deep in denial. I’d always just assumed God kept us in the dark to protect us. Like there was some sort of massive, incomprehensible reality stowed away in this place,” He gestured at the area around them. “The kind of thing that would drive anyone short of a deity insane, if they tried to wrap their head around it.”

Izuku fell silent for a minute, looking out at the tree. *At God,* he reminded himself, as he tended to every now and then. It still didn’t feel right to him. He wondered if it ever would.

“I don’t think you were that far off from the truth.”

Levi gave a small, somber smile. “Yeah. Maybe not.”

Another pause, and then Izuku exhaled. “I remember Kacchan saying something like that about the Depths. Not *exactly* the same, but… similar. This whole idea of things being somehow outside of our understanding.” Izuku laughed softly, humorlessly. “Maybe God and the Depths are cousins or something.”

Levi didn’t reply, at first. After a few seconds, Izuku turned to look at him, and raised an eyebrow at the thoughtful look on his face.

“Wait.” Izuku blinked. “Are you… You don’t *actually* think they’re…?”

“No.” He said quickly. “Well, not *literally,* but… now that you mention it, there’s definitely a common thread there. At the very least, it’s something worth looking at.” A moment passed, and Levi chuckled softly. “Honestly, the more I think about it, the more it makes sense. Frankly, I’m just wondering why we never thought of it before. I guess someone must have, at some point…”

“I don’t see how you could’ve without knowing God’s true nature.”

“Well, sure, but what I’m trying to say is that the Depths probably should have given us a clue, somehow. In retrospect, it seems so obvious, and yet nobody saw it. At least not that I know of.”

“What do you mean?” Izuku’s brow furrowed. “Saw *what?”*

“Other than God, the Depths is the most powerful ‘entity’ we’ve interacted with. The fact that it manifested as something so weird, so outside our understanding of reality, may suggest something about the nature of extreme power in general.

“You know, even after thousands of years, we’re still not much closer to understanding the Depths than we were back then. I guess what I’m trying to say is that, given what we’ve seen with the Depths, it’d almost be weirder if God *was* something we could make sense of.”

“Ah. I see…” Izuku nodded slowly. “Do you really think that, though? I mean…” He cleared his throat. “The idea that there’s something… *intrinsic* about God, or about the Depths, that makes us incapable of ever actually understanding them?”

He hummed. “Well, from a practical perspective, I don’t think it matters. Maybe there is, maybe there isn’t. In either case, I still think we should study things like this. I just think we need to be prepared to fail more often than not.” He said, and paused for a moment, looking up in thought. “There’s a third possibility, though. Something else I’ve considered.”

“…And what’s that?”

“Maybe they just don’t *want* us to understand them.”

“You mean…” Izuku gulped, an involuntary shiver running down his spine. “You think they’re incomprehensible on purpose?”

“Well, again. I don’t know.” He said. “But one of the aspects of the Depths I’ve always found fascinating is how it always seemed… almost *actively resistant* to scientific study.

“You can’t build anything in there. It’s impossible to take photos; even if you bring a light source, the pictures always turn out black. Electronics in general are wildly unpredictable at best, flat out non-functional at worst.

“And if you think about it, it makes sense for it to be that way. You could argue that foreign, dominating forces like the Depths have an incentive to obfuscate the way they work.”

“I can see that.” Izuku nodded. “Part of what makes the Depths so scary is how little we know about it, right? If we knew how it worked, we probably wouldn’t fear it quite as much. It wouldn’t have as much power over us.”

“Right.” Levi said. “And part of that’s because understanding it would make it much easier for us to oppose it. Powerful things are, by definition, difficult to overcome. But once you know how they work, what set of rules they operate under, it might be possible to bridge the gap, if you plan accordingly. But you can’t plan for what you don’t know.”

“So it’s like a survival mechanism.”

“Possibly. Or something like that.” He shrugged. “But again, it’s impossible to say for sure. You know, that’s far from being the only theory on the subject. There are *thousands*. If you’re ever interested, I’m pretty sure the library in Oseryth has an entire section devoted to them.

Macro-Organism Theory, Ecosystem Theory, Superconsciousness Theory, Mirror Theory, Swiss Cheese Theory…"

"Swiss Cheese Theory?"

"Yep." Levi gave a slight smile. "SWT is one possible explanation for why traveling through the Depths is so unreasonably fast. It posits that the fabric of spacetime in the Depths is actually full of millions of wormholes. That's why it's called Swiss Cheese Theory."

"Oh." Izuku said. "Do you, uhhh… Do you believe that?"

"Not really." He shrugged. "There's a lot of problems. If it were true, you'd expect a typical trip through the Depths to consist of mostly normal walking speed, broken up by sudden jumps across long distances. From what we've been able to tell, though, the rate of travel is generally pretty constant throughout."

"Huh. Well, which ones do you believe?"

"I mean, I don't really 'believe,'" he used air-quotes, "any of them. But there are a couple I'm fond of. Macro-Organism Theory is mainstream, and for good reason. That's the one that argues the Depths is a single entity, as opposed to just being an ecosystem. I also like Mirror Theory, but that one's a bit less common."

"What's Mirror Theory?"

"It basically argues that the entire sensory experience of the Depths is all just one big illusion. The 'forest' is basically a manifestation of our expectations, driven by cultural context and collective understanding."

Izuku gulped, recalling one of the things his father had said to him just a few hours prior. One of the things he'd since convinced himself to be a lie.

"Um. My fa—" He caught himself, and cleared his throat. *"Hidaeriel* seemed to be implying something similar about God. That this whole…" His eyes darted around, *"place,* I guess, is just how our brains make sense of things." He paused, then quietly tacked on, "It seemed like he might've been lying, though."

Levi hummed. "Well, for what it's worth, there's actually some evidence to support Mirror Theory." He said. "For one, the fact that nobody else can see or hear your own Depths siren shows that it's capable of shaping your perception without affecting anyone else."

"Huh…" Izuku trailed off for a moment. "But, what does it *want?* Is it just… trying to eat people?"

"Good question." He snorted softly. "It's possible. That's definitely the easiest explanation—that it's no different from any other carnivore, just bigger. But personally, I think that'd be too simple. Especially given what we now know about God—specifically, what sustains God."

Izuku swallowed. "Suffering."

"…Yes." Levi closed his eyes. "If the Depths were merely carnivorous, you'd expect it to go after non-sentient creatures, too, but as far as we know, it doesn't. So as things are, I suspect it's after something more… abstract."

"…Like what?" Izuku asked, his voice hushed, though he wasn't sure why. "Fear?"

He shook his head. "Animals experience fear, too. If it was feeding off a feeling, it'd have to be something more complex. Maybe despair? But… I don't know. That doesn't feel right, either."

Izuku nodded slowly, his mind running through memories of the Depths, both real and fake. The way it seemed to pull at him, baiting him with alarmingly realistic imitations of himself. There was an unsettling sort of edge to it, a threat to something greater than the air in his lungs. Something deeper.

And the word came to Izuku then, drawn from his gut and spilling off his tongue before his mind could get a grip on it.

"Identity."

He saw Levi turn toward him, out of the corner of his eye, his breath catching audibly in his throat.

"Maybe," Levi said, in a way that sounded a hell of a lot like, 'yes.'

At the top of the high tower, there was a sort of announcement system which Izuku had never seen in use, but understood the protocol of nonetheless.

Allegedly, in the past, God—or whoever posed as him—would occasionally use the system to communicate with the inhabitants of Heaven at large. He'd heard tales of it happening, of people witnessing God's vast form materializing in the sky and being so overcome with emotion, they simply fell to their knees and wept. It was thought to be a work of God, in the truest sense. Something holy.

It made it all the more ironic that the first and only time Izuku would see its use was when they were informing the populace of God's demise.

The top floor of the tower was a circular room lined with ornate columns and statues of Angels collecting dust. Izuku entered to find the room packed with Demons, most of whom he'd never met.

All of them were Fallen Angels.

"Ah, Midoriya."

Izuku turned. "Todoroki!" He said, smiling brightly as he pulled him into a brief hug. "How have you been?"

"Good." He said. "I slept almost twenty-four hours yesterday."

“Oh, uhh.” Izuku’s brow furrowed. “Why?”

He shrugged. “I couldn’t sleep until I knew everyone was okay. I guess I was making up for it.”

“Ahh, gotcha.” Izuku said. “Well, you’ve been briefed on everything, right?”

“I have. But I’m kind of…” He trailed off, looking off to the side. “I mean, do you really think this will work?”

Izuku hesitated. He’d asked Katsuki the same question, when he’d informed him of the plan. If he were to be honest, he still wasn’t sure about it all. But that wasn’t a sentiment worth transferring to someone else.

“I think so.” He eventually said. “The goal isn’t really to convince everyone to surrender. It’s to disrupt their ability to organize against us.”

Todoroki gave no indication as to whether or not he thought it would work. He simply said, “I guess they have to find out somehow.”

He swallowed. “Yeah. I guess they do.”

Izuku leaned to the side, peering between the bodies until he caught sight of Luke. He was standing near the platform, the one which would soon project his image into the sky. Standing nearby was Arc, speaking rapidly as he pointed this way and that. Luke mostly just nodded, occasionally stopping to interject a question.

Izuku straightened, taking a deep breath to try and dull his nerves.

A few minutes later, it began.

As Luke stepped onto the rough platform, it began to glow a vibrant green, and one by one, all the street lamps which lit the night in the outer three circles flickered off for a second before coming back on, and Heaven was flooded with green light. The view from the top of the tower faded gradually from the windows, instead replaced by something more akin to surveillance feeds. Everywhere he looked, he saw streets bathed in green, where Angels stood staring up at the sky, eyes wide and jaws slack.

Luke cleared his throat. “Dear Angels. By now, I’m sure you’ve begun to suspect that something is wrong. You’re correct. I regret to inform you that your God is finished.”

Out through the windows, most remained frozen in shock, though the beginnings of panic had manifested in the trembling of others.

“We have taken the liberty of clearing out all the barracks, and if you’re so foolish as to attack unarmed, you’ll find yourself in a situation most unpleasant.” He flashed a charming smile. “Fortunately, your lives need not be in danger. We are not asking for total surrender; we’re only asking that you do not get in our way, and that you comply with our evacuation protocols. If you can do that, I think you’ll soon find yourself in a much better place.

“But of course, I know you won’t take my word for it. That’s perfectly alright. However…” He glanced at the large group gathered around the room. “There may be someone here whose word you *will* trust. If you, or someone close to you, knew a person who Fell, I suggest you pay close attention. Perhaps you’ll see a familiar face.”

With that, he stepped to the side, and the long, spiraling line started to move. The first person stepped out on the platform. It was a youthful blonde woman with tall, twisting horns.

“My name is Maria Barclay.” She said, her voice shaking with nerves. “I Fell about six years ago.”

“And to whom are you reaching out, Ms. Barclay?” Luke asked.

“My old classmates from the second sphere.” She answered. “Hitomi, Jason, if you’re listening… I miss you guys. And you have my word that what he’s saying is correct.”

She stepped off the platform, and another person took her place. This time, no prompting was needed. “Martti Rasva. I Fell three years ago, and am reaching out to my friends, Lucille Sanders, Maya Thomas, and Jeremiah Sutton. I hope to see you three again, and I confirm that he is telling the truth.”

Things progressed with more or less the same format from there on out. Each Fallen Angel would state their name along with roughly when they Fell. They would then call upon those they knew personally, and corroborate Luke’s statements.

The line moved slowly, but steadily, and Izuku found himself glancing at the windows throughout. Things were getting chaotic as more and more Angels flooded out into the streets. Most of them seemed too shocked to react. Others were visibly shaking or crying. In the scenes where the gates between circles were visible, some could be seen pounding on metal, trying to force their way through.

They said it was better they did this now, while the magic was still strong. The doors held firm against the pressure tonight. The same might not be true in a few days time.

Still, it made Izuku nervous. It felt like it’d be too easy for them to simply write it off as an illusion, a cruel trick, using their Fallen friends’ images to lure them into a trap.

“Yeah, but that doesn’t matter. The point is to disrupt shit, sow seeds of doubt.” Katsuki had told him. *“Even if you don’t personally know someone who Fell, there’s a good chance you know someone who knew someone. There’ll always be people who just wanna stick their heads in the sand and deny it all. But doubt is contagious, Deku.”*

Izuku sighed.

Todoroki turned and looked at him over his shoulder. “Are you alright?”

Izuku bit his lip. “Yeah. Just… nervous.”

“I see.” He said. “You could try picturing them naked.” He nodded toward one of the windows, where the crowd was packed most tightly.

This startled a snort out of Izuku. “Thanks, Todoroki, but the public speaking isn’t really what I’m worried about.”

“Oh?” Todoroki said. Then it seemed to hit him. *“Oh.* Right.”

Izuku smiled fondly, shaking his head. He peaked around Todoroki’s shoulder. They were the last in line, and just about halfway through.

A few minutes later, it was Todoroki’s turn. He stepped up onto the platform, and addressed a handful of his classmates from the second circle.

And then it was Izuku’s turn.

He took a deep breath, flexing his wings as he stepped onto the platform and tried to will himself into a confident walk. He stopped at the center, only hesitating for a moment.

“Izuku Midoriya. I Fell…” He hesitated, mind going blank for a moment. He shook his head. “Uhh, just a few weeks ago. Anyway, I’m reaching out to my classmates from the first circle. In particular, Ochako Uraraka, Tenya Iida, and Hitoshi Shinsou.” He took another deep breath. “I can confirm that Luke—Lucifer, I mean—is telling the truth.” He swallowed, glancing over his shoulder, but of course there was no one left behind him.

“Please trust me.” He said, in a voice so small. “I… I know it’s hard, but…” He sighed. “If there’s one thing I’ve learned, it’s how difficult it can be to identify injustice when it’s all you’ve ever known.” He paused for a moment, his eyes fixated on his feet, too scared to look at the windows. “I guess… if you’ve ever felt ashamed for wondering whether this was as good as it gets… I want you to know that it’s not. Better things *are* possible. I promise.”

He faltered for a moment before he began walking again, nearly tripping over his own feet, but doing his best to play it off as he got off the platform, and joined Todoroki on the other end of the room. Still, he didn’t look at any of the windows. He was too worried about what, or who, he might see.

Luke took his place at the center of the platform again, though Izuku wasn’t really listening to what he was saying, only catching the tail end. “And if you still have doubts, there’s one last person I’d like you to meet. Councilman?”

He inclined his head toward Arc, who scoffed, as though profoundly annoyed. He strode across the room and took Luke’s place on the platform.

“As that asshole said, yes, I’m a Councilman. Some of you know me as the Councilman of sacrifice. The Martyr.” He rolled his eyes. “The irony of *me* being the one to survive this ordeal is not lost on me.” He sighed. “Look, I’m not going to sugarcoat this. If you want to live, you should surrender, okay? You’re all gonna Fall soon anyway. Well, if you’re lucky you will.

“See, the thing is, Heaven can’t really exist without God. It’s going to collapse sometime within the next few days. If you somehow manage to hold out and stay here until then, I

honestly do not know what will happen to you. Maybe you'll just Fall. Maybe you'll die. It's impossible to know for sure.

"Anyway, the point I'm trying to make here is that you'd be stupid to try and stick around. I know it probably hurts your pride, but then, pride is a sin. Isn't that right, *Lucifer?"* He turned his head and shot him a glare. Luke only offered him an artificial smile in return.

Arc closed his eyes, pinching the bridge of his nose. "Listen, I don't really give a shit what you do. If you really wanna try and stay here, be my guest. But before that, you should ask yourself what you're dying for. Because if the answer is your allegiance to God…" he opened his eyes then, and looked forward with a bitter smile. "I'm afraid I have some bad fucking news for you."

With that, he abruptly stepped off the platform and made a beeline for the door. As he passed by, Izuku frowned. Arc opened the door, and Izuku caught it before it could close, following him into the stairwell.

"You could've at least *tried* to sound authoritative." Izuku hissed. "Who's going to take you seriously when you act like that?"

Arc stopped in his tracks, a few steps down the spiral staircase. Slowly, he reached up and began massaging his temples. He didn't look at Izuku, or even open his eyes when he spoke.

"Actually," he said, "violating expectations is a *good* thing. Because if this were a trick, they'd expect me to be formal, and they would expect you guys to be smart enough not to act that way while impersonating someone they'd expect formality from. Since I did, they're unable to believe it's a trick. It only makes sense if I'm actually who I say I am."

"Oh." Izuku blinked a few times. "That… that's pretty smart, actually. You planned all of that?"

It was only then that Arc looked at him.

"No." He snorted. "I did it because I don't care what anyone thinks about me, obviously."

Izuku frowned. "Then what—"

"Post-hoc justification." He called back, continuing down the stairs. "If there's one thing being on the Council teaches you, it's how to force your actions to make sense after the fact."

The sound of his footsteps faded into the distance.

The late fourth Councilman's bedroom was a gaudy suite, filled with swirling gold embellishments and jewels embedded in places they had no right to be. It was the sort of ostentatious display that any decent person would balk at, but for as horrendous as it looked, Izuku couldn't deny it was comfortable.

He returned that night to find Katsuki sitting in an armchair, reading a book. He was all dressed up in full combat gear, and looked up when Izuku entered.

“Hey,” he said.

“…Hi,” Izuku replied, toeing off his shoes.

Katsuki set down his book and stood up, slipping his hands into his pockets as he approached. “How’d it go?”

Izuku hesitated. “It’s… hard to say, really. I mean, it looked like everyone was… well, pretty shocked. But I guess it’d be weirder if they weren’t.”

“Yeah, Luke asked me to be prepared to help out, if things get real bad. S’why I’m still dressed like this,” He gestured lazily at his uniform. “He didn’t actually specify what kinda help he wanted, but if he’s askin’ me, I assume it’s the kind where Angels die.”

“That’s… well, probably, yeah,” Izuku winced. “Hopefully it won’t come to that. I guess with the barracks empty, there’s not a lot they can do—not individually, at least.”

Katsuki took a few steps closer. “And how about you?” He asked. “How’re *you* handling all this?”

“Ah. I’m… okay. My heart’s still kind of pounding. But I’m okay.” He bit his lip, looking off to the side as he thought. “I, uh, reached out to some of my friends. I’m not really sure what to expect, or if they’ll even believe it’s me.” He scratched his head. “I guess Shinsou probably will, but that’s mostly because he was sort of in on the situation. At least more than Uraraka or Iida ever were.”

“Oh, yeah. Forgot about *that* bastard.” Katsuki said, in this exaggerated sort of tone that seemed to imply the opposite. “It’s gonna be real fun when *he* Falls. Wonder if he’ll still be callin’ us subhuman pieces of shit when he’s got two horns stickin’ outta his hair.”

Izuku sighed. “He’s not *that* bad.”

Katsuki’s only response was a blank stare that grew exponentially more uncomfortable with every second it was sustained. Eventually, Izuku just had to look away.

“Okay, I know he said some pretty awful things, but he’s not a bad person.”

“Deku, he compared us to vermin and said we were infesting the world.” Katsuki deadpanned. “I mean, he might as well have just said, *‘I want to do a genocide.’”*

“I-I know, and I’m not excusing any of that, but… I mean, that’s what we were *taught,* Kacchan. Shinsou isn’t *uniquely* bad.”

“Are you sure?” He asked. “‘Cuz y’know, some of that shit he said—even *Arc* hasn’t gone *that* far, and being an asshole is kind of his whole thing. Not to mention the fact he’s literally a fucking *Councilman.”*

“Well, Shinsou was getting better! I mean sure, he didn’t change his mind *completely,* but… Kacchan, he helped me escape. He *knew* I was going to Hell with you.” He looked up at him again, meeting his eyes. “He’s not a bad person, he’s just been… misled.” Katsuki opened his

mouth to retort, but Izuku beat him to it. “And again, I know that doesn’t make it *okay* for him to be so horrible! But he can change. He’s *shown* that he can.”

Katsuki didn’t respond, just pursed his lips and narrowed his eyes. Izuku sighed, taking a step closer. He reached out and took his hand, holding it gently between his own.

“Weren’t you the one who said that everyone, even the worst criminals, could get better with the right help? That everyone deserves a chance to better themselves?” Izuku asked softly. “If you can extend that sort of empathy to a murderer, *surely* you can do the same for someone who’s been taught to be hateful.”

And again, he didn’t reply at first. He looked at Izuku, his jaw clenched. After a moment, he pulled his hand from Izuku’s grasp and raked it through his hair.

“He wants to fuck you.”

Izuku wasn’t sure what he’d expected him to say, but it sure as hell was not *that.* It threw him off so much that, for a second, he just stared up at Katsuki, uncomprehending.

“That… *sorry?”*

“Oh my god.” He groaned. “He fuckin’ *wants* you, Deku. How can you *not* see that?”

Izuku flushed. “H-He’s just a friend!”

“Yeah.” Katsuki scoffed. “A friend who wants to fuck you.”

“That’s—“ He faltered, eyes widening. “Wait… is *this* the reason you don’t like him? The *real* reason?”

He looked away. “No.”

“Kacchan.”

“Maybe a little.”

“Kacchan.”

“Okay, to be clear, the dehumanization was *more* than enough.” Katsuki smiled cynically. “Him being obviously in love with you just gave it extra *flare.* Y’know, like rainbow sprinkles on top of a steaming pile of shit.”

“I can’t believe this.” Izuku groaned. “And you’re *wrong,* too! Kacchan, I’ve known Shinsou for a *long* time. It’s not like that.”

“Sure.”

“I mean it!”

“Uh-huh.” He rolled his eyes. “Listen, I may not have been there long, but I know that shit when I see it. That look he got when he saw me touch you?” He snorted. “Yeah, not exactly the kinda look you’d expect if me *hurting* you was his top concern.”

Izuku shook his head. “Whatever.”

“You still don’t believe me.”

“What gave you that idea?” Izuku asked dryly, and then took a deep breath. “Look, can we just drop this? I can see that I’m not gonna convince you either.”

Katsuki hesitated, his mouth open, as though he had much more to say. But eventually, he acquiesced. “Fine.”

“Thank you.”

Katsuki sighed. “Guess it’s probably for the best. I mean this *is* the first night I’ve actually been awake when you got back. I’d rather not spend it arguing about fuckin’ Am—“

“Wait, is that… really?”

“Yeah.” Katsuki raised an eyebrow. “You’re usually down in that damn eldritch fuckscape well past midnight.”

“Oh.” Izuku blinked. *“Oh.* Um. Now that you mention it, I guess that’s… I’m sorry, I know I shouldn’t…” A nervous laugh bubbled out of him. “I guess I’ve been pretty out of it these past few days.”

“It’s fine. I get it.” Katsuki grumbled. “M’not sure how *healthy* it is, but I do at least *get* it.”

Izuku nodded quietly, looking down. Katsuki’s boots squeaked against the marble floor slightly as he shuffled closer, and then he was cradling Izuku’s cheek in his palm, tilting his head up gently. Izuku met his glowing red gaze as he leaned in, and his eyes fluttered shut instinctively as Katsuki pressed his lips to his own. Izuku exhaled through his nose, trying to let go of all the tension that had built up in him in the days since the invasion.

The kiss was gentle and sweet—almost chaste. But when Katsuki finally pulled away, the look in his eyes was anything but. “Bet I could make you forget all about it.”

Izuku shivered, the deep, rasping tone of his voice pouring over him like warm molasses. Before he knew what was happening, he was pulling him back toward the mattress. Katsuki sat on the edge of the bed, and Izuku fell into him, his knees straddling his hips, his arms instinctively wrapping around his neck.

“How about it?” He asked, kissing up the column of Izuku’s neck. “Want me to *distract* you, baby?”

Izuku flushed, heat rushing to the pit of his stomach just from the feeling of Katsuki’s lips on his neck, his deep voice resonating throughout his very being. It was almost absurd, just how

easily Katsuki took him apart. A few rumbly words, and Izuku was already sinking into his embrace, pliant and *easy.*

“That… but aren’t you sort of…”

“Hm?” He pulled back a bit.

“Well, you’re kind of on call right now, aren’t you…?” Izuku frowned. “You need to be ready to fight if they need you.”

“Mm, true. But y’know, if you think about it, having a boner out there might not be the worst thing in the world. In fact, it might actually be an advantage.” He smirked. “I dunno about you, Deku, but If *I* were an Angel, I imagine nothing would make me run faster than the sight of a Demon charging at me with like a massive fuckin’ tent in his pants. Talk about puttin’ the fear of God in people.”

Izuku laughed. “Kacchan, *no.”*

“Kacchan *yes.”* He shot back. “I mean, just imagine it. I’d be like, ‘Behold, the cock that corrupted the devout Angel Dekiriel. I did it before and I’d fucking well do it again.’”

Izuku’s fingers laced through his hair, grip a little too tight. “No, you would not.”

“Well, obviously not to *them.* I meant like, if I could go back and fuck you again that first time.”

“That *better* be what you meant.”

“Are you fuckin’ *jealous,* nerd?” Katsuki asked, incredulous. “Are you *seriously* gettin’ jealous of the victims in this hypothetical indecent exposure scenario?”

Izuku looked away, shoulders scrunching up. “No. But if you’re going to indecently expose yourself, I’d rather you do it for me.”

Katsuki snorted, leaning in until his lips touched his neck. “Oh, I’m about to do a whole lot more than *just* exposing myself, Deku.”

“W-Well, as long as it’s in private, it’s fine!”

“Aww, only in private?” Katsuki crooned, playing up his disappointment. “Well damn, there go my dreams of fucking you in front of an audience.”

His eyes widened. “Kacchan, *what—“*

Katsuki chuckled, low and breathy, and slowly kissed up his neck to his ear. “I don’t think you understand just how much I want you all the fuckin’ time, Deku baby.”

Izuku’s fingers tightened in Katsuki’s hair again, only this time, it was for stability.

“Kacchan…”

He hummed, leaning in again, until Izuku could feel his hot breath on his skin, his lips moving against the shell of his ear. “Think about it. Just fuckin’ bending you over… or maybe pressin’ you up against a wall. Right there, in front of everyone.” He said, large hands sliding down to his ass, slowly groping, squeezing. “I could make you cry. Fuck, I *wanna* make you cry.”

Izuku swallowed roughly, and if he weren’t already sitting down, he was sure his legs would’ve given out.

Then suddenly, Katsuki pulled back. “But hey, if you’re too possessive to cope with that kinda shit, it’s whatever.”

It took a second for Izuku to register what he’d said, but when he did, he scoffed. “You think *I’m* possessive? After all that stuff you said about Shinsou?”

“I dunno. Personally, I think if your significant other is close friends with a guy who constantly fantasizes about cumming all over said significant other’s face, reasonable people can disagree over whether that’s something worth caring about.” Katsuki said. “Meanwhile, you’re ready to go to war if someone sees my dick.”

“Okay, I never said—”

“—It’s five hundred years in the future, and humanity has finally rebuilt.” Katsuki interrupted, grinning far too wide. “Somewhere in the desert, an archaeologist discovers an old camcorder, buried in the sand. On it, there is but one recording. For a split second, it’s there. Blink and you’d miss it: a single, grainy frame of night-vision green, wherein the shadow of my cock is visible. And somewhere deep in the pits of Hell, Izuku Midoriya *screams.”*

Izuku rolled his eyes. “Are you done yet?”

“For now.”

He sighed, looking off to the side. He tried to ignore the way that Katsuki’s hands were still very much on his ass, claws biting into him through the thin material of his pants. “I never said I’d be *upset.* I mean, I guess in a way I would be? But it’s complicated. I don’t think… well, it’s really more—“

Katsuki cut him off with a kiss, slow, deep and decadent. When he broke away, he gave a crooked grin, pressed his forehead against Izuku’s, and finished, “Just a natural consequence of you knowing that I’m yours.”

And for a moment, Izuku felt like he couldn’t breathe. Katsuki’s forehead was pressed against him, pretty, glowing red eyes consuming his vision. If the tower were to crumble then, Izuku was sure he wouldn’t notice.

He opened his mouth to respond, but it just hung there, soundless. Katsuki spoke where Izuku couldn’t.

“Y’know, I never said I *wasn’t* possessive. I know I’m just as bad. Maybe worse.” He shrugged. “But that’s how this works, Deku baby. I’m yours and you’re mine.”

Izuku released a shuddering breath. He felt like he was floating.

“And really, that’s kinda the main appeal of fucking in public.” Katsuki went on, after a minute. “It’s not enough for me to just know you’re mine. I’ve gotta show you off. Make you scream in front of an audience ’til they *get it.”*

“That…” Izuku gulped, trying to ignore the way his cock twitched at the image. “W-Well, some people might say that level of possessiveness is… unhealthy.”

“And my counterargument would be that I don’t care, because it’s hot.” He said, squeezing his ass tighter, pulling his cheeks apart through his clothes. “And for the record, it’s not like I’m actually plannin’ to act on it.” He shrugged. “There’s really only a couple ways to make somethin’ like that happen without violating other people’s rights, and most of them would require an unjustifiable amount of planning.”

That penetrated the haze in Izuku’s mind just enough to make him laugh. “Ah, I see. So it’s a logistics thing.”

“Exactly.” Katsuki said. “Like, sure, there’s always the Amphilux, but it just doesn’t really pack the same punch when everyone else is fucking too, y’know?”

Izuku snorted. “How unfortunate. I guess you’ll just have to settle for holding hands, then.”

“Mm… we can do a bit better than that.”

His brow furrowed. “Could you… maybe elabor—ah!” Izuku released a startled cry when Katsuki abruptly bit him, teeth sinking into his flesh, high on his neck. At first, he tensed up, but once Katsuki started sucking, he quickly melted into his embrace. *“Hahh—Kacchan…”*

Katsuki hummed as he bit and sucked at his skin, about as rough as he could be without tasting blood. Once he seemed happy with the mark, he kissed it, and immediately started on another one, this one even higher on his neck. In the midst of summer, Izuku knew it’d be near impossible to hide it without raising any eyebrows. He also knew that was the point.

But somehow, despite having the ability to foresee the consequences, it still wasn’t enough to make Izuku want to stop him. It just felt too good.

When Katsuki was satisfied with the carnage, he pulled back, smiling as he admired his handiwork. “Now, that should do it.”

Izuku whined. *“Kacchan.”*

He just grinned wider. “Oh, no. I don’t wanna hear any fuckin’ complaints from you, nerd. Not when you’re this fuckin’ hard.” His grip on his ass tightened as he yanked his hips down, grinding slow and filthy between his legs. His breathing stuttered, eyes fluttering at the sensation of Katsuki’s half-hard cock pressing against his own through their clothes. Katsuki subtly rolled his hips up into him, creating a rhythm he could only describe as *excruciating.*

Katsuki leaned in, hot breath against his ear. “Y’want it, don’t ya?”

Izuku whined. *“Please.”*

And evidently, that was all he needed to hear.

In one swift move, Katsuki reversed their positions. Izuku’s back hit the mattress in a way that made him bounce, so he grabbed the sheets to stabilize himself. Katsuki kneeled on the foot of the bed, his form bathed in blue moonlight as he reached for the hem of Izuku’s shirt. He raised his arms, allowing him to pull it off.

Katsuki went for his pants next—another pair leftover by the late fourth Councilman, rolled up at the ankles and held in place by a belt that Katsuki deftly unbuckled, before he grabbed the waistband and started to pull it down. Izuku lifted his hips off the mattress, and a second later they were off.

He was now completely naked, while Katsuki was still fully clothed. Somehow, he hadn’t thought to wonder what that would feel like, hadn’t expected the vulnerability.

Katsuki’s hands snaked under his knees just before he yanked him down the mattress toward him, forcing his thighs to spread open around his hips.

Izuku’s face burned as he felt the full weight of Katsuki staring down at him. For a little while, that was all he did. He stroked his thighs, eyes raking up and down his body, and it wasn’t long before Izuku’s arms started to gravitate inward, in an unconscious attempt to cover himself. Katsuki snatched up his wrists and pinned them on either side of his head.

“Don’t,” he said, pressing his forehead to Izuku’s. “Don’t you fuckin’ hide from me, Izuku.” The sound of his name on his lips made him squirm.

“I… I’d feel better if I wasn’t the only one naked right now.”

Katsuki smirked. “Sorry, nerd. You had a point, though—I *am* kinda on the clock right now.”

“Can’t you take *something* off?”

“Mm… they could call me at any time, nerd. What then?” He explained, but the way he said it, that indulgent, almost patronizing cadence, told a very different story. “Can’t afford to waste time gettin’ dressed.”

Izuku whined.

“‘Sides,” Katsuki went on, “I kinda like it this way, y’know? Makes me feel *powerful.”*

“You’re powerful enough already.” Izuku grumbled, shifting around on the bed. “Save some for the rest of us.”

Katsuki laughed, pulling back a bit, making a show of looking up and down Izuku’s body, really taking it in. “Oh, c’mon. I know you like it too.”

Izuku squirmed. “I have no idea what you’re talking about.”

“I have no idea what you’re talking about,” Katsuki mocked, his tone high-pitched and nasally.

“Kacchan.”

He just laughed again as he descended Izuku’s body, and then, without warning, grabbed his cock and dragged his tongue up the side. The shock of pleasure made Izuku cry out, which he seemed to take as a cue to wrap his lips around the tip and suck. Izuku nearly choked, his toes curling. “K-Kacchan, oh *god.”*

He could’ve sworn he saw Katsuki smirk around him before he began to bob his head at a punishingly quick pace. Izuku’s thighs shook, his fingers gripping the sheets as he lost himself in the pleasure. Katsuki just kept sucking him in deeper, only stopping when he reached the base. Izuku was entranced, both by the sight of Katsuki staring up at him as he sucked him off, and the apparent ease with which he did it. As though it wasn’t even a challenge for him, sucking Izuku down to the root.

Now.

As far as Izuku was aware, he was fairly average. Sure, he wasn’t *big,* but he wasn’t particularly *small,* either. But there was something about the way Katsuki took him in so smoothly, as though it barely took any effort at all, that made him *feel* as though he was. Maybe Katsuki was just more practiced. That was probably what it was. But still, Izuku couldn’t help but fixate on the knowledge that, had their positions been reversed, Izuku would’ve choked long before the halfway point. And yet here Katsuki was, taking it like it was nothing. He couldn’t shake the juxtaposition from his mind.

And perhaps the most alarming part of it all was the realization that he didn’t hate it.

Izuku whimpered and moaned, threads popping around his clenched fists as his mind grew hazy with need. Maybe it was because of the loud, wet, slurping noises, or maybe the feeling of Katsuki’s lips around his cock was just so all-encompassing as to leave him incapable of perceiving anything else. But either way, he didn’t actually notice that Katsuki pulled the bottle out until his slicked up fingers were already rubbing against his hole.

It was right as he was starting to lose control. He tried to thrust up into his mouth, but Katsuki put a stop to it real quick, his forearm pinning his hips to the bed as he simultaneously sunk his index finger into him. He pulled off of his cock with a filthy popping sound, and the cold air on his wet dick made Izuku whine.

“Shhh,” Katsuki stroked his stomach with his free hand, and gently started to fuck him with his finger. “You’re okay. So fucking good, baby. So *pretty.”*

His cock twitched at the praise, and thanks to the position of Katsuki’s head, he noticed immediately. Izuku’s face grew hotter, and he half-expected him to say something. But instead he just smirked, wrapping his hand around Izuku’s dick and stroking tight and slow,

in time with his finger. “That’s right.” He murmured, thumb rubbing over the tip. “My baby takes it so fucking *good.”*

Izuku keened.

After a minute, Katsuki eased another finger inside, gradually fucking deeper until he reached the last knuckle. Izuku mewled, cock pulsating in Katsuki’s hand at the familiar sensation of thick fingers inside of him. It’d only been a few days, but it was a few days too long.

“Good boy,” He praised. “Gorgeous. Fucking pretty Angel *slut.”* He emphasized the word with a rougher thrust, fingers curling inside of him, making him melt. He fucked him open at a steady pace, fingers scissoring a few times before he slid in a third. And all the while, Izuku could only close his eyes as he squirmed and clawed at the bedsheets, messy and desperate.

Katsuki groaned, prompting Izuku to look up at him. The vision he was met with took his breath away. Katsuki was looking down at him like some sort of inscrutable enigma, both incomprehensible and beautiful. The intensity of his gaze startled him, had him clenching around his fingers, red, kiss-swollen lips caught between his teeth.

“So *perfect.”* Katsuki murmured, like a prayer, low and breathy. Izuku flushed again and tried to cover his face, and with his free hand, Katsuki caught both his wrists, clicking his tongue in disapproval. “Oi, what’d I fuckin’ say? Don’t you *dare* try to hide from me, Deku baby.”

“Kacchan,” he complained. Katsuki just leaned down and kissed his red cheeks, giving his fingers one last twist before pulling them out.

Katsuki sat back and reached for his waistband, locking eyes with him as he carefully undid the belt and closure at the front of his pants. Izuku held his breath, fisting the sheets as he watched Katsuki’s hand slide inside just before he slowly—too slowly—dragged his cock out. Swollen red and hard, wet at the tip. Izuku licked his lips unconsciously.

Katsuki stroked his cock languidly. “How’s that for indecent exposure?”

Izuku’s only response was some strangled muttering under his breath, and if someone asked him to repeat himself, even he wouldn’t know what it was he’d said. He was breathing heavier now, watching as Katsuki grabbed the lube and squirted some more out onto his hand, wrapping it around his cock and spreading it.

“Fuck.” He hissed, cock filling out in his hand with every pump. Without thinking about it, Izuku spread his legs even further apart, knees bending to accommodate the stretch. Katsuki smirked, the move clearly not going unnoticed.

“You want my cock, Deku?” Izuku nodded. “Tell me.”

“I…” He swallowed, his mouth overproducing saliva. “I want it. Please.”

“Want what? C’mon, be specific.”

Izuku groaned, covering his face. He spoke before Katsuki could object to it again. “You’re always asking me to tell you what I want. Why don’t *you* tell me what *you* want?”

Katsuki’s hand stilled for a moment, brows lifting in mild surprise. Then, his grin grew even wider, and that’s when Izuku knew he’d made a mistake.

“Don’t mind if I do.” He purred, and with that, he closed in on him, leaning down to press his lips against his ear. His pitch dropped even deeper as he whispered, “I wanna fuck your tight ass. Split you open on my cock, watch you cry and beg for more while I pound you into this mattress. The same mattress a Councilman once slept on—the Councilman of *purity,* no less.”

He slapped his cock against his thigh a few times, leaving the skin wet and shiny with excess lube.

“You have any idea what it’s like for me?” He continued. “How *perfect* you are? How fucking *high* it makes me, every time I remember you’re all mine, *Angel?”*

Izuku grabbed him by the sides of his face, pulling him into a kiss that started off frantic, but soon slowed down into something almost *sweet.* The smooth slide of Katsuki’s lips against his own made Izuku feel as though he were levitating. Everything, from the soft sounds in his throat to the way Katsuki’s thumb stroked his cheek, felt saturated in reverence and adoration.

Then Katsuki was grabbing his cock, pressing the tip against his hole and steadily, *relentlessly* pushing in.

“Ahh,” he moaned, breaking the kiss. “Oh god, yes. *Please.”*

“Like that?”

“Yeah.”

“Yeah?” Katsuki smirked, angling his hips *just so,* his tip rubbing against his prostate as he slid deeper. When he finally reached the base, he paused, pressing his hips against his ass. “Fuck. So fucking tight. Feel so *fucking* good.” He ducked his head into Izuku’s neck. “Never gonna get tired of this,” He said, words laden with more emotion than Izuku was prepared to handle. His breath caught in his throat, and his heart fluttered in his chest.

He reached up and buried his fingers in his hair, pulling him into another kiss as he clenched around his thick cock. It was odd, really—he always seemed to forget how intense it was, having Katsuki inside of him. The sensation was somehow both surprising and familiar each time it happened. He wondered if he’d ever get used to it, if he’d even want to.

Slowly, Katsuki withdrew, pausing for a moment before pushing back inside with a roll of his hips. “Fuck,” He groaned. “Okay?”

Izuku nodded, clutching his hair tighter. “It’s good. I’m good.”

“Oh, you’re *so* good.”

Izuku sputtered, “I—that wasn’t—“

Katsuki laughed, deep and breathy as he slowly started to fuck him. “What, you don’t think you’re a good boy?”

“It’s not—w-well, I don’t… really know what that means?”

“Oh yeah?” Katsuki raised an eyebrow, pressing in deep and pausing, hips rotating against his ass. “And when you say you don’t know, do you mean that in the sense that you *literally* don’t know, right now, in this specific context, or are you actually making a meta-ethical statement about whether it’s possible to have an objective definition for the term ‘good boy’?”

“Um. The first one?”

“Gotcha. Well, right now, in this specific context, a good boy is whatever I say it is.”

“And what is that?”

“You.”

Izuku blinked. “I mean… if that’s the case, it doesn’t really matter what I think.”

“It does kinda trivialize the question, I’ll admit. Oh well.” Suddenly he scooped his hands under Izuku’s knees and folded them against his body, causing his hips to lift off the bed. His pace abruptly went from moderate to fast, and Izuku nearly choked on his own spit, mind going blank. Katsuki released soft little grunts and groans as he fucked him into the mattress.

From this position, he could actually *see* Katsuki’s cock fucking into him, swollen and pulsating and glistening with lube, stretching him out like nothing else.

There was something about seeing it, about having to acknowledge what Katsuki was doing to him, that always did him in, made his cheeks burn hot and his cock leak all over his stomach. Times like these, when he was folded in half and couldn’t look away even if he wanted to, or when Katsuki had him boxed in, keeping him pinned in place while he whispered in his ear, flooded his brain with filth. The intimacy could never be compartmentalized. Couldn’t be separated from him in the same way most other things were. When Katsuki fucked him, he would accept nothing less than his full, undivided attention. And in the most vivid, personal sense, Izuku would *know* what it was to be with him.

And now here he was, watching his cock slam into him, about as long and thick as it could be without tearing him apart. The room filled with the wet sound of Katsuki’s thrusts, the slap of his hips against his ass and thighs, heavy breathing and broken moans of pleasure.

“Kacch—ah!” Izuku cried, his entire body trembling as Katsuki slammed in deep, grinding into him. Everything about Katsuki was big—his body, his hands, his dick, his *presence.* It was so easy for Izuku to feel consumed when he was with him, as though he could wrap Katsuki’s very existence around his own and make a home out of it. He monopolized all his senses, made everything else disappear.

The emotions seemed to sneak up on him.

He started to tear up as he lay there under Katsuki, encompassed in the heat of his body. He reached up and wrapped his arms around his neck, tucking his head into his shoulder, so he could speak directly into his ear. “I love you.” He said. “I wish… I wish I knew how to tell you how much.” Katsuki’s thrusts stuttered to a stop, his breath audibly hitching. “Sometimes it feels like it might crush me.”

When he managed to pull back, he found Katsuki staring down at him, wide-eyed. And just as the embarrassment was about to catch up to him, Katsuki spoke.

“I know,” He said, brushing Izuku’s bangs out of his eyes. “I feel it too. Like a chain tying your soul to mine.”

Izuku nodded, tears slipping down his temples and soaking into the sheets. Katsuki wiped them away with his thumb, and sighed fondly.

“Why’d ya have to go and do that, *huh?”* He asked, barely rolling his hips into him. “Actin’ so fuckin’ cute and shit. Goddamnit, Deku, how am I supposed to call you a filthy whore when you’re lookin’ at me like *that?”*

Izuku laughed, breath hitching when Katsuki started fucking into him again, albeit slowly. “I-I think you’re probably fine as long as you throw in enough terms of endearment to cancel it out.”

“Baby. Sweetheart. Most beautiful *darling.”* Katsuki emphasized each phrase with a thrust. “You’re my precious, filthy Angel whore, Deku. The love of my life. My virtuous little slut.”

“That—*ahhh*—th-that last one’s a bit of a contradiction.”

“I dunno,” Katsuki snorted, slowly pulling out. “I think being a slut’s a virtue. Without sluts, society would crumble.”

Izuku raised an eyebrow. “Is that so.”

“Yeah.” He slammed back in, and Izuku choked on a moan. “I mean, where would I be without you? Pretty sure fucking your ass is the only thing tethering me to this realm of existence.”

“H-How romantic—*Ahh…”*

“Fuck yeah it is.” Katsuki said, speeding up again. “I wanna take you out and show you the world and introduce you to all my favorite things, then bring you home and smack you around and fuck you ’til you forget your own name.”

Izuku wasn’t really listening anymore, too wrapped up in the pleasure of Katsuki slamming into him. He was approaching the edge at a startling speed, and he moaned, wrapping his legs around Katsuki’s body, desperate for leverage to fuck himself back onto his cock. “Fuck, feels so good. More. *More.”*

“You want more?” Katsuki grinned, shifting his grip down to Izuku’s ass, pulling his cheeks apart so he could fuck him even deeper. “That can be arranged.”

He felt the bite of his claws before he realized what was happening. Izuku opened his eyes to the sight of Katsuki slowly shifting, horns extending into ram-like curls, wings gradually emerging through the slits in his combat shirt. And then he felt it, the way he got a bit bigger inside of him. Izuku choked on a cry as he felt himself stretching open even further as Katsuki’s cock grew with the rest of him.

It was more than enough.

Izuku reached for his cock, and he was gone before he could even get his hand properly around it. “Kacchan—!” He cried out, clamping down around him as he came, shooting all over his stomach and chest. Katsuki knocked his hand away and replaced it with his own, stroking him through the high until Izuku grew so sensitive it almost hurt.

He released little moans and whines as Katsuki continued fucking into him, until finally he felt the familiar sensation of his cock pulsating inside of him, the way Katsuki closed his eyes and his hips stuttered just before he sped up, slamming into him rough and deep in his single-minded pursuit of pleasure.

“Fuck, fuck, shit, *Deku—!”* With a groan, he bottomed out inside of him, balls drawing up. His cock swelled up just a little bit further as he came inside him, filling him up with hot, thick cum. Izuku moaned, the sensation spurring a second wave of pleasure.

Katsuki grinded against him hard, as though he could somehow get any deeper than he already was, and his sharp claws dug into his ass. Distantly, Izuku knew he was probably drawing blood, but he had neither the energy nor the will to stop him.

The aftermath found them both panting, breathing in each other’s air. Still inside him, Katsuki leaned down to kiss him, red, swollen lips moving against Izuku’s own. When he finally pulled back, he looked down at him fondly, brushing Izuku’s sweaty bangs aside.

“Love you, nerd.” He said, the deep cadence of his voice sending subtle vibrations through the places where they were pressed together. Izuku felt warm all over, his eyelids drooping slightly as he stared up at Katsuki, a beautiful dream in the pale moonlight.

Izuku hoped he’d never wake up.

When Izuku entered the chamber the following morning, Luke was already there. Izuku adjusted the silk scarf around his neck, pulling it higher and tightening it.

Luke was wearing the same uniform, crisp and clean, as though it’d been freshly washed and ironed. He was kneeling on one knee near the edge of the boulder, and looked back at him as he came in. “Ah, Midoriya. Of course it’s you.”

Izuku frowned. It was always difficult to interpret Luke’s intent, when he said things like that.

“Um, sorry. Did you want me to leave…?”

“Hm?” He raised an eyebrow. “Why on Earth would you think that?”

Izuku sighed, stepping fully into the chamber and shutting the door behind him. “What’re you up to?”

“I’ve been asked to collect a few samples of the… ‘water,’” he used air quotes, “down here, for lab analysis.” Luke pulled out a small vial, holding it up with a gloved hand.

“Oh. Good idea, I guess.” Izuku said. “Uhh, be careful, though. That stuff is—“

“—Concentrated human misery? Yes, well.” He smiled. “That’s what the gloves are for.”

“Ah, right. Of course.”

Izuku went to sit down in his usual spot, looking out across the sea while Luke busied himself at the edge. He remained quiet as he collected the samples, filling up the first vial and placing a stopper inside, before tucking it away in a pouch at his side.

It was strange, if Izuku stopped to think about it. Out of the three originals, Luke was easily the one he’d spent the most time with alone, and yet somehow, it was still awkward. Somehow, he still felt as though he didn’t really *know* Luke.

With the first vial full, Luke pulled out a second and repeated the process. Upon finishing, he slid the vial in next to the first and carefully shed his vinyl gloves into a small waste bag. Luke stood up straight again, glancing over at him. Izuku looked away instinctively, though rationally, he knew there was no reason to do so. This wasn’t one of Luke’s training sessions; he wasn’t going to hypnotize him. Frankly, Izuku wasn’t even sure if it was possible with just one eye.

“It is,” Luke said, startling him. “Eye contact makes hypnosis easier, yes, but it’s not strictly necessary. I don’t think there’s any difference in the effectiveness with one eye as opposed to two, but I suppose only time will tell.”

Izuku hesitated. “I, um… I’m sorry.” He muttered. “I guess I was thinking out loud again.”

He shrugged. “You’re not the first person to ask about it.”

“Well, you’re probably tired of answering it, then.”

“Not any more than anything else.”

“Oh.” He averted his eyes, fidgeting with the fabric of his pants. After a long pause, he said, “Well… good, I guess.”

Izuku kept his eyes fixated on the surface of the boulder, and for a moment, all he could hear was the sound of waves gently crashing against the sides.

“Midoriya,” Luke then said. Izuku looked up and saw him walking his way. “May I ask you a question?”

“Uh, sure. Go for it.”

Luke came to a stop near his side, but remained standing as he asked, “What are you doing down here?”

Izuku should’ve seen it coming, but somehow, he still wasn’t prepared. “Um…”

“Forgive me if that question makes you uncomfortable. I just couldn’t help but wonder… When I heard you’d been spending so much time in here, I was confused. Isn’t it boring?”

Despite himself, Izuku laughed softly. “Well, I guess that’s true, in some ways.” Luke kept staring at him, waiting for him to continue. Izuku cleared his throat. “It’s just… Well, how did *you* react, when you found out the truth?” He deflected. “I know you’ve been down here, but I didn’t really hear anything else about it.”

He shrugged. “It was a surprise.”

“But how did you feel about it?” Luke opened his mouth. “I mean *honestly.”*

Luke hesitated, mouth still open. He closed it for a moment, and looked away. “Right.” He muttered, as though he weren’t really speaking to Izuku. Another pause, and Luke sighed. When he spoke next, his affect was notably flatter. “Frankly, I didn’t feel much of anything, really.” He pursed his lips. “Or rather… that’s not *entirely* true, I suppose. My first impulse was to laugh, actually.”

“…What?”

“Not because it was funny,” he clarified. “I was more so reacting to the absurdity of it. It just seems… well, a bit trite, honestly—almost like something out of a fairytale. In life, the dichotomy between good and evil is seldom clear. And yet somehow, we’ve found ourselves in a situation where we have two choices, and they’re about as close to black and white as anything could be.

“It’s sort of quaint, I suppose. To think that the end of God’s life would be so… morally uncomplicated.” He paused, then tacked on, “from my perspective, at least.”

Izuku hummed, craning his neck to look up at him. “Your perspective?”

“Comparatively. Levi’s is more… tangled up, I think.” As he spoke, he glanced down at him, and did a small double take, as though something had only just occurred to him. He took a seat on Izuku’s right, and then continued talking. “I don’t see much point in that, though. The utilitarian argument makes sense on an intellectual level. That’s good enough for me.”

Izuku nodded. He was really only half-following what Luke was saying, but he opted not to speak on it. After a second, he cleared his throat. “What did you expect to find down here?”

“I don’t know.” Luke said. “I spent more time thinking about ways this could’ve been a trap. I saw no reason to assume God *wasn’t* the man I remembered from all those years ago.”

“Ah.” Izuku said. After another pause, he asked, “What did you think was going on, back then?”

Luke’s response came faster than Levi’s had.

“Personally, I thought he was dying and simply wanted to hide it from us.”

Izuku blinked. “Seriously?”

He nodded. “The term ’Restoration Chamber’ always sounded rather strange to me. It raises the question of just what it was God needed to *restore.* I wondered what would happen if he were to suddenly find himself unable to access it… Death, whatever that meant for a God, seemed logical.”

“Sure, but… why would you think he was hiding it from you?”

“To avoid looking weak, of course.”

Izuku frowned. “Not to avoid worrying you?”

At this, Luke faltered, and after a second, he side-eyed Izuku, a small, odd sort of smile tugging at the corners of his mouth. “Things like that didn’t really… factor into my thought process, back then.” He reached up and began fiddling with the black eyepatch that now covered his left eye, adjusting its position. “I just assumed most people’s behavior could be best explained by asking what they stood to gain from acting the way they did.”

“Like… as opposed to it being a natural consequence of how they felt?”

“Essentially.”

“That’s a pretty strange thing to just assume.”

“I did have a tendency towards… *projecting* my own thought processes onto others, in my younger years.”

Izuku blinked. It took a moment for him to catch onto the implication of that statement. And suddenly, he remembered what Katsuki had told him about Luke, just over a week prior.

“Empathy doesn’t come natural to him, I guess. Apparently, he used to be a real asshole.”

“I mean…” Izuku swallowed. “Don’t we all do that? Try to put ourselves in other people’s shoes?”

“Perhaps.” He was tightening the ties that held the eyepatch in place. “But I would imagine it only works if you engage with the world in similar ways.”

“Sure, but you can’t know that until you’ve gotten to know how the other person thinks.”

“And somehow, that only seems to make it *more* difficult.”

Izuku opened his mouth to retort, but nothing came out, at first. He closed it, and then tried again. “But… shouldn’t it be the opposite?”

“Maybe for the subset of people who think as you do.”

“Right.” Izuku pursed his lips, and for a time, said nothing more. They both stared out at the tree in prolonged silence as Izuku mentally scrambled for some way to keep the conversation going, some escape from the uncomfortable silence. And then, on a whim, he asked. “Have you ever been in love?”

Luke turned and looked at him quickly, clearly caught off guard. And of course, it was only then that Izuku realized how invasive the question was.

“Ahh, um, sorry! I didn’t mean—that was too personal, wasn’t it?”

“Normative social etiquette would certainly say so.”

Izuku flushed.

“…Right. Sorry.”

He shifted around on the boulder, uncomfortable, and for several long seconds, Luke did not speak. He was beginning to consider just getting up and leaving, but he wasn’t sure if it’d make things more awkward or less.

Finally, Luke broke the unbearable silence.

“I don’t know. I think so, probably.”

And then it was Izuku’s turn to be speechless. He stared back at Luke for what felt like an eternity.

“I thought you didn’t—uhh,“ Izuku fumbled. “You didn’t have to answer that if you weren’t comfortable with it.”

Luke gave him a blank stare. “I only noted that your question wasn’t socially acceptable. I never said that I *cared.”*

“Oh.” Izuku cleared his throat. “Right.”

“Why did you ask?”

“I… don’t know.”

“Do you *genuinely* not know, or are you just worried the answer might offend me?”

“I…”

Luke smiled slightly. “So it’s the latter.”

“I didn’t—“

“If it wasn’t, you wouldn’t have hesitated.” He observed. After a second, he sighed. “It’s fine, though. You don’t need to say it. I get it. I know… how I am.” He turned his head away, staring up at the vacant sky above. “And I’m sure you already know who it is, as well.”

Izuku swallowed. “Uhh… and how d’you figure that?”

“Either Bakugou’s told you, or you’ve inferred it yourself.” Luke replied, side-eyeing him. “You seem like the type of person who could do something like that reliably.”

“What type of person is that?”

“The type that starts crying when people are slightly nicer to them than they expected them to be.”

Izuku laughed, awkward and shrill enough to startle himself. Fortunately, Luke didn’t seem fazed by it.

Izuku cleared his throat again. “So what does that mean to you, exactly?”

“What do you mean?”

“Like, what do you think love is?”

“I don’t know.” He shrugged. “I suppose it’s probably the most you can feel toward anyone.”

“Yeah, but what does that look like?”

Luke sighed.

“Sorry,” Izuku said. “Again, I really don’t want to make you uncomfortable.”

“You’re not. If I was uncomfortable, I would leave.” He said, waving dismissively. “Look, the best way I know how to describe it is…” he squinted. “Well, it’s kind of like an obsession. Sometimes it’s more intense, sometimes less so. And sometimes I think it’s gone, but it always comes back.” He paused. “I guess I see it as a kind of loyalty that persists beyond the point of benefit or reason. Like an anchor. Maybe you get distracted sometimes, but somehow, something always brings you back in the end.”

“That’s really interesting.” Izuku said. “So it’s sort of like that person is your home?”

Luke blinked a few times, and then looked at him. “I… hadn’t thought about it that way, but… yes. Yes, I suppose that fits.”

Izuku smiled, and for a moment, it was quiet.

Luke sighed again. “Is this the part where I’m meant to ask you what *you* think love is?”

“Uhh, I mean, if you want? But I think my perception of love is pretty standard.”

He side-eyed him. “Are you implying mine is *non*-standard?”

“Huh?” Izuku hesitated. “Oh. No, I didn’t mean it like that! I just meant—!”

“—You really need to stop falling for that so easily, Midoriya.” He deadpanned. “It’s not fun if you always take the bait.”

“What are you—“

“—Anyway,” He interjected again. “Just tell me so we can move on from this topic.”

“…Okay.” Izuku said. “I mean, for me, love is sort of like… when you care about another person more than you care about yourself.”

“And how does *that* work?”

“What do you mean?”

“If I’m not mistaken, what you’re essentially saying is that for you, love is when you’re ready to die for someone.” Luke said. “But if you *did* die, you wouldn’t be able to continue loving that person, because you wouldn’t exist.”

“Sure, but that’s not really the point.” Izuku said. “It’s more like… you love the person so much that you’d want them to keep living even if you couldn’t be there with them.”

“Right. But if you *both* feel that way, wouldn’t you dying for that person just condemn them to a miserable existence?” He raised an eyebrow. “I’m assuming you wouldn’t want the other person to commit suicide, but if the feeling you’re describing is mutual, isn’t that just the logical end state of things?”

“The hope is that the other person would eventually move on.”

He blinked. “So, you’d be able to move on if Bakugou died for you?”

“Well… no?” Izuku said. “I don’t think so. Or at least, I can’t imagine ever moving on.”

“Hmm.” Luke pursed his lips. “Your version of love seems rather… impractical.”

Izuku laughed. “Maybe… but I think you’d be hard-pressed to find a version that isn’t.”

“That’s—“

The sound of the door opening cut Luke off. Izuku turned around, brows raising when he found Arc standing in the doorway.

“Someone upstairs is asking about you.” He spared Izuku a brief glance before he strode by, the stone pathway rising from the sea as he prepared to cross.

“Oh, really? Um. Who is it?”

“I don’t know. That’s all they said.” Arc said, without looking back. “The only reason *I’m* telling you is because I was on my way down here anyway.”

“…Ah. I see.”

“You should go and find out what they want.” Luke said.

Izuku hesitated, his eyes flitting between Luke and Arc, who was now about halfway across the path.

Over the course of the past few days, he could count the times he’d seen Luke and Arc interact on one hand, but all of them were rife with hostility. Maybe it was a bit silly of him, but Izuku wasn’t entirely comfortable with leaving the two of them alone.

Luke stared at him and raised an eyebrow. “You shouldn’t keep them waiting.”

Izuku took a deep breath, and shook his head. “Right. Of course.” He stood up and headed for the exit, sparing one last glance over his shoulder before he opened the door and shut it behind him.

Once he’d reached the top of the stairs, he was taken to a smaller wing on the east end of the building, and pointed toward a door at the end of the hall. He reached up and adjusted his scarf one last time before he opened the door, entering what turned out to be a small office room, and there he found a person he wasn’t sure he’d get to see again.

Shinsou was sitting near a wooden desk, brows pinched together as he stared at the surface of it.

He glanced up as Izuku came in, eyes lingering for only a second, and betraying no surprise. “Midoriya.”

“Shinsou.” Izuku said, tone betraying his unease. He shut the door softly behind him and cautiously approached, pulling up a chair and sitting down. He noticed that Shinsou had gone back to staring at the desk. “Um.”

“Someone carved the words *‘get fucked Kevin’* into the desk.”

“Oh. Really?” Izuku leaned over to look and, sure enough, there it was. “That’s… weird.”

“Any idea whose office this is?” He hesitated. “Or, I guess, *was.”*

Izuku gulped. “No, I… I’m afraid not.”

“Hmm.”

For a moment, it was silent. Izuku stared down at his lap, twiddling his thumbs as he waited for Shinsou to speak again.

“The antlers are interesting. Never seen that before.”

“Oh.” Izuku stiffened. He was still fully shifted, having grown accustomed to it after all the fighting. But it wasn’t really necessary anymore. “Y-Yeah, um… apparently they’re pretty rare.”

Shinsou stared at them appraisingly. “I think I like them. Makes you look less like a Demon.”

“Ah. I see.”

It was quiet again. Izuku’s palms were sweaty. He wiped them off on his pants, and shifted around in his chair, cringing at the sound of the legs creaking as he did. The longer the silence stretched on, the more anxious he became, and eventually, he just couldn’t take it anymore.

“Do you hate me?” He blurted out.

Shinsou jolted. “What?”

“For Falling, I mean.” His eyes darted around, looking at everything but Shinsou. “For becoming a Demon.”

“Of course not.”

Izuku looked up. Shinsou was frowning.

“…Really?”

“Midoriya, I…” For a moment, his normally monotone voice carried something else, something almost vulnerable. He hesitated, averting his eyes. “I don’t know if I’m even *capable* of hating you.” He finished, the words steady, quiet and controlled.

Izuku felt some of the tension release from his shoulders. “So what *do* you feel?”

“It’s complicated.” He muttered, almost wincing. “With regards to you Falling, though… I guess I’d be tempted to use a line like *‘I’m not mad, I’m just disappointed.’* But honestly, I don’t think even *that’s* true. At least not anymore.”

“…What do you mean?”

He sighed. “A lot’s happened since you left, Midoriya. I’ve been… thinking.”

“The greatest sin of all.” Izuku said, half smiling, trying to release the tension.

“Ha-ha.” Shinsou deadpanned. “Anyway, it’s too much to get into right now. There’s something I wanted to ask you.”

“Oh.” Izuku perked up. “Um, sure. Anything you want, Shinsou.”

Shinsou seemed to hesitate, his mouth hanging open for a bit. And then finally, he pulled the trigger.

“Is it true?” He asked. “Is God really… dead?”

“Ah.” Izuku felt a small pang in his chest, like an echo of heartache. He didn’t answer immediately, because the truth was… complicated, to say the least. But eventually, he resolved to simply be honest about it. “No.” He told him. “God isn’t dead. But he will be very soon.”

Shinsou frowned, tilting his head. “What’s that supposed to mean?”

Izuku sighed, rubbing the back of his neck. “God is… well, he’s dying. I guess you could say he’s… being starved. Slowly.”

“That seems… unnecessarily cruel.”

Izuku laughed awkwardly. “Well, unfortunately, according to Councilman Five, it’s the only way that works.”

“I see.” He said. “And could I… see him? Maybe speak to him?”

“No.” He said, a little too quickly.

Shinsou’s eyes narrowed, almost imperceptibly. “Why not?”

Izuku looked down, fists clenching around the fabric of his pants. “Because you won’t like what you’ll see. I know that probably sounds strange but just… just, trust me, *please.”* He said, words coming out shakily. He paused before adding, quietly, “I don’t want to do that to you.”

Shinsou frowned, but didn’t speak at first, seeming to be considering something. “I appreciate the concern… but I still want to know. I think I can handle it.”

Izuku just stared at him, wide-eyed and nervous.

Shinsou’s frown deepened. And then, in a quiet, uncharacteristically open tone, he asked, “is it really that bad?”

Based on his reaction, the look in Izuku’s eyes must have said it all.

After another long moment of silence, Shinsou spoke up again. “Midoriya… I know the truth hurts sometimes, but isn’t it better to know?”

“No.” Izuku said, harsher than he attended. He softened his tone before continuing. “Normally, I would agree with you. But… in this instance…” he bit his lip as his vision started to go blurry. His fists clenched harder around the fabric of his pants, frustration pulsing inside of him.

He didn’t think he’d feel this way. He thought that after days spent down in the Restoration Chamber, he would have made a bit more progress in processing his emotions—at least enough to have this conversation without breaking down. Apparently, that was not the case.

Izuku wiped his eyes roughly, irritation bleeding into his actions. “There’s nothing you need to know.” He said, jaw clenched. “It won’t do your soul any good, and it won’t make you feel any better. Not now. Not anytime in the future.”

For a long time, Shinsou didn’t speak. When Izuku eventually composed himself enough to look up, he found him staring back at him, his expression unreadable. After some small eternity, Shinsou shrugged and looked away. “If you say so.” He then said. “I guess I’ll just spend the rest of my existence wondering what the hell you’re talking about.”

“Good. It’s better that way. Trust me.”

“I do.”

The words hung in the air for a while, Izuku’s muscles gradually relaxing as Shinsou seemed to have accepted it.

After a minute, Shinsou broke the silence. “Maybe the real God was the friends we made along the way.”

Izuku snorted. “You stop that.” He said, but he was smiling.

More silence.

“So… how much longer, then?”

Izuku took a deep breath, collecting himself, and exhaled. “A few days. I’m not sure what the exact estimate is.” He said. “Things will probably get pretty unstable before it happens, though. That’s part of the reason we’ve been working to evacuate people.”

“That’s—“

Izuku heard the sound of the knob turning just before the door creaked open. “Well, if it isn’t Ambien.”

Izuku spun around and found Katsuki leaning against the doorframe.

“If it isn’t the person who put me in the hospital for a month.” Shinsou intoned.

“Ooh, so I’m a *person,* now?” He raised an eyebrow. “That’s progress.”

Shinsou averted his eyes with a grimace. “I’ve had… a lot of time to think.” He muttered, but his voice was strained, as though there were something trapped down in his throat, struggling to hold the words back.

“Oh yeah?” Katsuki cocked his head. “Warmin’ up to me, huh?”

“No.” He said. “I still don’t really like you, but… now it’s because I find you to be, uhh… distasteful, instead of… you know.”

“An immutable part of my identity?” Katsuki filled in.

“Sure, I guess that’s one way to put it.” Shinsou rubbed the back of his neck, avoiding eye contact still.

“Guess that’s an improvement.” He rolled his eyes. “And I’ll have you know I am an absolute fucking *delight.* Ain’t that right, nerd?”

Izuku hesitated. “I… guess so…?”

“Hah?”

Shinsou smirked. “Sounds like a no.”

“W-Well, it’s just not really… uhh, the word I’d choose? To describe you?”

“Well, pray tell, Deku—what word *would* you choose?”

“Um…” He racked his brain. “I… love… you…?”

Katsuki scoffed. “Uh-huh. That the best you can do?”

Izuku pouted. “I think me loving you is a pretty strong endorsement.”

He snorted, reaching out to ruffle Izuku’s hair. “Guess I can’t argue there.” Katsuki’s fingers closed around the roots of his hair, and he used his grip to pull his head to the side. Izuku made a small noise of discomfort as Katsuki leaned down and planted a kiss on the top of his head. “Love you too, nerd.” He released his hair and turned toward Shinsou. “And you.” He said, pointing at him. “Don’t even think about tryin’ anything on him.”

Shinsou raised an eyebrow. “I’m guessing you’ll kill me if I do?”

“Me?” Katsuki snorted. “Nah. Deku’s more than capable of tearing you a new asshole if he wants to. Hell, by the time I got to ya, he’d probably already be halfway finished sewing your other one shut while you’re bleeding out on the floor.”

The image Katsuki created was so visceral, Izuku felt the urge to recoil from it physically. “Kacchan, *please.”*

“What?”

“Could you just—“ He sighed, closing his eyes for a moment. “Just give us a minute, okay?”

Katsuki hummed. “Alright.” He said, casually running his hand down his neck before heading toward the door. “I’ll be down the hall. Come find me whenever you’re done chatting with your little fascist buddy.”

“He’s not—“

“I’m not convinced.” Katsuki called over his shoulder. “But you’re fuckin’ welcome to prove me wrong, Ambien.”

With that, he opened the door, stepped out, and closed it behind him.

Izuku sighed again. “Sorry about…” When he turned to look at Shinsou again, he noticed his cheeks were dusted pink, and he seemed to be staring at something just below his jawline.

Oh.

Izuku flushed, quickly pulling his scarf up and tightening it like a noose around his neck. “Um, as… as I was saying,” He said, voice squeaky. “Uh, sorry about him.”

“Oh. Um.” Shinsou looked away, eyes a bit wider than usual. “No, it’s fine, but…”

“…Shinsou?”

He shrugged. “I mean, I just… don’t really know what you see in that guy. That’s all.”

“Oh.” Izuku said, taking a deep breath to regain his composure. “Well, Kacchan is…” He scratched his head, looking away.

There were a lot of things he could say about Katsuki. He was clever, funny, strong, devastatingly handsome—but none of those descriptors did any justice to the way Izuku felt about him, after everything they’d been through together.

After a while, Izuku offered a small, fond smile. “He’s just… *Kacchan.* He makes me see things in a way I never could have on my own. He’s kinda mean and… well, he’s *extremely* crass, but… he’s authentic, in a way most Angels I knew just couldn’t be. And he’s optimistic, at the same time. More than you’d think.” He paused. “He makes me feel like better things are possible. And when I’m with him… I feel like there’s nothing I can’t do.”

As Izuku looked up, he saw Shinsou staring back at him, his expression blank, unreadable. He tensed. “Uh, sorry,” Izuku said. “That’s probably more than you were—“

“No, it’s fine.” Shinsou put a hand up. Then, a bit quieter, he said, “I probably shouldn’t have asked.”

At this, Izuku frowned. “What do you mean?”

“Nothing.” He averted his eyes. “Nothing.” He repeated, barely a whisper under his breath.

For several long seconds, neither one of them said anything. Shinsou’s eyes wandered around the room, as though he might find something in the office’s sparse furnishings which could illuminate things in a way Izuku’s words could not. Eventually, he sighed.

“Everyone’s pretty freaked out, you know. It’s chaos out there.”

Izuku winced. “I guess I can’t say I’m surprised after the announcement last night.”

“It’s more than that.” Shinsou shook his head. “They’ve started losing feathers—most of them, anyway.”

Izuku's eyes widened slightly, but only for a moment. "Oh. Um. Yeah, I guess…" He rubbed the back of his neck. "I guess that's probably to be expected."

Shinsou didn't say anything in response, but regarded him quietly, his hands folded in his lap.

Izuku cleared his throat. "Um, how are you holding up, then?"

"Better than most." He shrugged. "Losing feathers doesn't bother me that much."

"Oh? Why is that?" Izuku's eyebrows lifted.

He offered a small smile—the sort that most wouldn't have even recognized as such, unless they knew Shinsou the way Izuku did.

"I guess probably because I've been losing them for a while already." He told him, criminally nonchalant in his tone. He carried on, ignoring the look of abject shock on Izuku's face. "All that changed after last night was the rate I was losing them at."

For a long while, Izuku just sat there, stunned into silence as his brain struggled to integrate this new information into his reality. *Shinsou, losing feathers?*

And here he had been, thinking that Shinsou was one of the most devout among them.

He swallowed against the dryness in his throat, and finally managed to ask. "Since when?"

He hummed, looking up in thought, as casual as ever. "Well, the first time was a few days after I got back from the hospital."

"That long?" Izuku asked, his voice low, scratchy.

Shinsou nodded, and averted his gaze again, his eyes fixating on a corner of the room. The muscles in his upper arms shifted and flexed as he sat there, wringing his hands in his lap. When he finally spoke, it was soft, riddled with uncertainty. "I… I think they might have… done something to me. While I was there. The Acolytes, I mean."

A sharp intake of breath, and Izuku did his best to school his expression. "Yes, I… I think I know what you mean." He said. "They did it to me, too."

It was this statement that brought Shinsou's eyes back to him, widened, and framed by skin drained of all color.

"They *what?"*

"Yes, um." Izuku cleared his throat. "So, I was actually, uh… captured, a few weeks ago. I escaped, but—"

"—You *escaped?"* He gawked.

"Y-Yeah," Izuku laughed awkwardly.

"How?"

"It's…" He squinted. "Kind of a long story. I'll tell you about it later."

Shinsou nodded in agreement, but the look in his eyes showed his mind someplace faraway. It was something like a minute before he broke the silence. "They weren't dreams, were they."

The statement lacked the inflection of a question. Shinsou already knew. He just wanted to say it out loud.

But Izuku shook his head nonetheless. "No, they… most likely weren't." He looked down at the ground. "The Acolytes, um… well, they use illusions—*elaborate* ones—for interrogation purposes. It's similar to how Lust magic works."

"Sorry, *what* magic?"

Izuku looked up again, taking in the bewildered, slightly flushed state of Shinsou's face. *Ah, right.* He remembered. *Shinsou doesn't know about Demonic magic.*

"It's complicated." Izuku said. "I'll explain later?"

Shinsou sighed, seeming a bit exasperated, but he didn't press the subject any further.

"So, what's going to happen, then?" He asked. "A few days from now."

Izuku shrugged. "Honestly, I don't think anyone really knows for certain. I've been told that Heaven will collapse, and everyone will Fall—if they haven't already, anyway."

"And then what?"

Izuku hesitated. "What do you mean?"

"What happens afterward?" He asked. "When everything's over… where do we *go?"*

"Oh. Well, I mean, that's the other reason we've been trying to evacuate everyone. We can prevent Angels from teleporting if they Fall on the surface, which allows us to spread out the influx of people and lessen the burden on the system. But… ultimately, everyone ends up in Hell." He braced himself for a potential bad reaction.

But instead, Shinsou's expression remained calm, and he asked, "What is Hell like?"

For some reason, the question took Izuku off guard. At first, he just sat there, almost as dumbfounded as he'd felt when Shinsou had asked what it was that drew him to Katsuki. And like Katsuki, there were a lot of things Izuku could say about Hell, but not much that felt adequate.

He could talk about the strange, dangerous beauty of its wildlife, or the harsh cut of jagged mountains and volcanoes erupting into the skyline. He could talk about the odd, organic curves of its architecture in cities like Oseryth, or the crystalline skyscrapers of downtown

Erykos. He could talk about the horrors of the Depths, the ubiquitous network of high-speed trains.

Or he could talk about the culture of equality, of radical freedom. The way its society seemed to exist for its own sake, instead of just being a backbone for some overarching, oppressive regime.

He could tell Shinsou that people were happy.

But all of that would come in due time, when the sort of complex questions such statements would provoke could be adequately addressed. There was no need to complicate things just yet.

And so instead, Izuku answered Shinsou's question with a question of his own:

"Have you ever been to Australia?"

The library was quiet in the night.

It'd been roughly two days since he'd spoken to Shinsou, and by then, most of the Angels had cleared out of Heaven, either in accordance with the evacuation orders, or because they simply didn't feel safe anymore, now that the Demons were there.

Up until then, Izuku had avoided venturing outside of the innermost circle, mostly out of a desire to steer clear of the chaos. Now that things had finally died down, it was harder to ignore his curiosity. So he didn't.

Izuku flipped on the light switch, and the overhead lights flickered for a moment before stabilizing.

At first, he just stood there, looking around himself, confirming that there truly was no one there. Izuku took a deep breath and then set off down the nearest aisle.

As he walked, he ran his fingers over the spines of each book, glancing at the titles without really reading them. He chose one at random and pulled it, and at first, the cover didn't seem to react. It was only when he looked closer, eyes narrowing, that he registered the faint glow of the number six.

The book was heavier than the sum of its parts, but much lighter than a level six book should have been.

Sighing, Izuku slid down to sit, his back up against the book shelf. He tried to open the book, and felt a bit of resistance, as though the pages were stuck together. But it was hardly an effort.

Izuku looked at the opening page, reading the title for the first time. *Fear and Trembling* by Søren Kierkegaard.

He set the book down on the floor, leaving it open, and watched as the cover slowly eased back to a closed position, as if pulled along by some invisible force.

Curious, Izuku stood up again and searched the shelves some more, looking closely as he ran his fingers over each one, only stopping when he was greeted with the red glow of the number nine. He peered at the title. *The Rebel* by Albert Camus.

Izuku grabbed the spine and pulled on it. The book resisted more than the other one had, and it was a struggle to get it out, but he managed it eventually. The book seemed a bit lighter in his hands than it had while on the shelf—perhaps around forty pounds. He was quick to set it down.

Knees folded beneath him, Izuku attempted to open the book. For this one, he had to adjust his grip a few times, but once he'd opened it an inch it became easier to push it the rest of the way. He turned to the first page, and noted that the pages themselves were heavy, too. It was a challenge to keep it open, but not an insurmountable one.

Wanting to justify his effort, he decided to try reading some of it.

He was expecting it to be dry and dense—written with that same sort of academic antagonism which gatekept most philosophy from laymen, but the book was surprisingly readable. Or at the very least, he didn't find himself needing to stop after each sentence just to parse the words he'd just read. And where he'd expected time to slow, it instead seemed to fly. Izuku wasn't sure how long he'd been reading when Katsuki finally found him.

"There you are." He said, marching over to him. "Thought you'd gotten swallowed by a book or something."

"Ah, sorry." Izuku said, trying to fold down the corner of the page, and frowning when it seemed to just spring back into place. "Um."

"What're you reading?"

Holding his place with one hand, Izuku half-closed the cover, letting him see it. Upon doing so, Katsuki raised an eyebrow.

"…Camus, huh?" His tone carried an amused lilt.

"Um, yeah. You're familiar with him?"

Katsuki gave a sly grin. "Mm… a bit."

Izuku flushed. "What?"

"Nothing. It's just kinda funny, I guess. In that… 'life imitates art' sorta way."

He frowned. "I'm still not sure what you mean."

"Well, acceptance is the last stage of grieving your faith, right?" He asked. "I guess, for me, reading something like Camus is such an aggressive incarnation of that stage, it almost

doesn't feel… real. It's like something you'd see at the end of a movie, or some shit. Y'know, like that scene in the second *Evil Dead* movie where the guy cuts off his arm, and there's just this shot of him setting down a copy of *A Farewell to Arms."*

Izuku pursed his lips. "I don't think I've seen that movie."

Katsuki raised an eyebrow. "Well, we'll have to fix that, won't we?" He offered a hand, which Izuku accepted, and pulled him to his feet. "Did you wanna take that with you?" He gestured at the book.

"Hmm? Oh." Izuku looked down at it, now firmly closed on the floor in front of him. "No, it's fine. It's too heavy, anyway."

"Well, they'll have it at the library if you decide you wanna keep readin' it."

Izuku nodded, and followed behind him as he strolled down the aisle. Katsuki moved at a leisurely pace as he looked around. "There's more here than I expected, I'll admit." He turned into another aisle and trailed his fingers over the books, pausing when he reached one that was slightly askew. The spine glowed red with the number nine as Katsuki deftly pulled it off the shelf. He raised his eyebrow as he looked at the cover, and as Izuku stepped up beside him, he saw why.

Demon Physiology, it read.

Katsuki pried it open, and began flipping through the pages. He paused when he reached one with a drawing of some kind, and when Izuku looked closer, he realized it was a diagram of some kind. It depicted the outline of a horned person, with the inside shaded bright red. There was a line pointing toward the colored interior, and when Izuku squinted, he realized it was simply labeled *'evil.'*

Katsuki burst out laughing. "Holy fuck." He wheezed. "This is *incredible."*

Izuku stared at the diagram, his brows pinched together. "…Is this supposed to be scientific?"

"Obviously, nerd." Katsuki snorted. "That's how I got to be so big, y'know." He flexed his arms for emphasis. "'Cuz I'm full of evil, obviously. Poke my bicep with a needle and I'll start leaking villain juice everywhere like a goddamn water balloon."

"'Villain juice'?" Izuku grimaced.

"Yeah, y'know. It's that immoral extract, that sweet, sweet, malevolent elixir. Cream of corruption, if you will."

Izuku shuddered. "I feel like I need a shower now."

Katsuki snorted. "If it makes you feel better, I'm pretty sure this diagram is inaccurate. I mean, I'm no doctor, but I have some doubts."

"Really." Izuku deadpanned.

“Well, yeah.” Katsuki scoffed. “I mean, *c’mon,* Deku. Everyone knows evil is stored in the balls.”

At this, Izuku’s blank expression cracked, and he began laughing as hard as Katsuki.

“I’m takin’ this shit with me.” He finally said, snapping the book shut. “Just a little souvenir. D’you think it’ll weigh the same as a normal book, once God’s kicked the bucket?”

“If the power comes from God directly, then probably,” Izuku said. “It’s possible it doesn’t, though. Maybe the reason it’s weaker now is because three Councilmen are dead.”

“I have a feeling those two things aren’t entirely separate.”

Izuku smiled slightly. “Maybe not.” A pause. “Speaking of which… what’s the plan, with the Councilmen? Are we… leaving them here?”

“From what I’ve heard, probably not.” He said. “Since we don’t know what happens to people here if Heaven collapses, it seems safer to just bring them down to Earth with the rest of the Angels. It’s way easier to confirm they’re dead when there’s a body to show for it. Not to mention the fact they might still have information we need.”

“Right. Uh, did Arc say how long it’d be for them…? I know he said it’d be around two weeks for the Healer and a month for the Rejector before they got desperate, but did he mention anything about how long they’d last after that?”

“Not that I know of.” Katsuki shrugged. “Can’t imagine it’d be much longer at that point, though.”

“I guess not.”

Katsuki hummed. “Well anyway, we should probably head back. It’s gettin’ pretty late, y’know.”

Izuku bit his lip. “Five more minutes?”

He rolled his eyes slightly. “Five more minutes.”

After Katsuki, the person that Izuku saw most often was easily Arc. He would drop in a couple times per day, intent on squeezing out as much ‘blood’ as possible while he still could. They never spoke much—or at all, really. Occasionally, they would make eye contact—perhaps offer a slight nod of acknowledgement. But words were few and far between, and conversations simply didn’t occur.

Not until the morning of the fourth day, at least.

Izuku stared across the sea, now barely deeper than the shallow end of a swimming pool, and watched Arc collect the sap. He was always a bit clumsy about it, each session filled with muttered curses and pinched brows. Izuku assumed that the task had been delegated to the Acolytes, before the Demons came in and eviscerated most of them.

Arc crossed the distance without so much as a glance in Izuku's direction, glass vials gently clinking together inside the leather pouch he wore across his chest. Izuku often wondered what the ratio was—how much suffering it took to produce one of those vials. No amount, no matter how small, could justify it in his mind, but in juxtaposing the vast, crimson sea against the minuscule vials of black, Izuku could only assume it to be astronomically large.

It brought the sheer cruelty of it all to the forefront of Izuku's mind in a way he struggled to contend with. It was just so surreal, so absurd in its magnitude. It churned Izuku's stomach, made him want to laugh, scream, and vomit all at once. He didn't know how to react. He just knew that he *had to* react.

And that's where he found himself that morning, sitting on the cool, smooth boulder and staring into space. Feeling the subtle shift of wind when Arc strode by, approaching the door. Izuku heard the doorknob turn.

"How do you sleep at night?"

The area was quiet, unmarred by the sound of the door's ancient hinges squealing, or even that of the doorknob spinning back to its original position. Arc was still there. He didn't say anything, and Izuku didn't turn around to check, but he was still there. His powers did not naturally lend themselves to any method of teleportation, and if Arc didn't remove himself from the situation, then nothing else would. Faith didn't matter. Status didn't matter. Silk and cashmere granted him no significance on a cosmic scale. Arc was still there because he wasn't special enough not to be.

After a tense moment, Izuku eventually did turn around, and was greeted with the sight of Arc's back, his shoulders drawn up, stiff, like a house cat trying to make itself look bigger in the face of some perceived threat.

"How do you live with yourself knowing where it comes from?"

Arc released the doorknob, and turned to look at him, his expression reflecting a sort of numb irritation. "I *don't* think about it. That's how."

"That's your answer? Really?" He scoffed. "How can you just *not* think about it?"

Arc offered a short bitter laugh. "Tell me, Midoriya—have you ever bought chocolate? While you were human, I mean."

"Excuse me?" Izuku blinked. "Where did *that* come from?"

"Just answer the question."

"Why—"

"—Because I will fucking leave if you don't." He snapped.

Izuku's brows pinched together, and for a few drawn out seconds, he just stared at him. "Uhh… I guess?" He finally said. "I mean, probably."

“Oh?” He said, feigning surprise. “Well, it may shock you to know that an overwhelming amount of cocoa production involves either child labor or forced labor. Sometimes even both. Sometimes it’s *forced child labor.* Did you know that, Midoriya? Did you think about it while you ate your shitty candy?” He smiled. “Not everyone *does* know. But a lot of them do, or at least have some vague idea about it. And yet they still buy chocolate.”

“That’s different.”

“No, it’s not. It’s farther away, but it’s not different in any meaningful sense.”

“Except it *is* because I’m not the one *doing it.”* Izuku gritted his teeth. “I didn’t *enslave* anyone.”

“Oh, I know you didn’t enslave anyone. Just like how I didn’t *create* this fucking place.” He made a sweeping gesture toward the area at large.

“But you could’ve *done* something about it! I couldn’t *do* anything! I mean, *what,* you think things would’ve been different if I just didn’t buy chocolate? I’m *one person!* I didn’t have the power to change things. You *did!”*

He scoffed. “What *power?*”

“Fuck you!” Izuku stood up. “You’re a *councilman!”*

“And even if I *did* say something, I would’ve been outnumbered.” Arc crossed his arms. “What the fuck was I supposed to do?”

“I don’t know!” Izuku threw his hands up. “Maybe just… open the damn hatch? Try your luck with a chainsaw?” He gestured back at the tree. “I’m not gonna stand here and just let you pretend your hands were tied. You’re *here.* You’ve been here the entire time. I don’t know what you could’ve done, but it’s definitely more than *nothing!”*

Arc stood there a few feet away, looking back at him, his jaw tight. After a moment, Izuku released a sharp, mirthless laugh.

“If it weren’t for us invading, you’d still be up there, sipping blood in your high tower as though nothing was wrong.” He sneered. “Nothing would ever change.”

Arc held his gaze for a bit longer, and then tore his eyes away, his expression unreadable. It felt like the silence stretched on to eternity. And in this place, for all Izuku knew, it had.

“You’re right.” He finally said. Izuku glanced up and found him looking back at him again. “I probably would’ve just let things continue like this indefinitely. You want to know why?” He asked, and paused before finishing, “because *I don’t fucking care.”*

The statement seemed to hang in the air for a while, Arc’s features hard-set. Izuku wasn’t sure how long it was before he spoke again.

“You know, I *used* to care. But I was a coward. I cared about those people, sure, but at the time, I cared about my life more.” He smiled bitterly. “Now I don’t care about either one.”

“Am I supposed to feel bad for you?”

“No. I know what I’ve done is unforgivable. That’s why I’m going to die for it.” He clenched his jaw. “You know, I didn’t *choose* the title *Martyr.* I didn’t even *want* to join the Council, but I wanted to be safe more than I wanted to be a good person.”

Izuku’s brow furrowed, and for the first time, he felt uncertain. “What are you talking about?”

“None of your fucking business.” Arc snapped. “Frankly, I don’t even know why I’m talking to you. Your opinion of me only matters insofar as you *insist* on annoying me with it.” He turned sharply on his heel, approaching the door. “Just leave me the fuck alone. I’ll be dead soon, anyway.”

With that, Arc pulled the door open, hinges squealing. Then it slammed shut behind him, and Izuku was alone.

Izuku stood in the Restoration Chamber, staring at the tree fifty feet away.

It wouldn’t be much longer, now.

The once-full sea was now little more than a bed of red-tinted mud stretching out to infinity. The stepping stones still protruded from the ground, but no longer served any purpose. Izuku could simply walk across. So that’s what he did.

His shoes squelched with every step he took through the marshy wasteland, careful to avoid touching the sides of the rocks, lest he accidentally come in contact with any residual fluid. Gradually, the ground sloped upward, until eventually he reached the point where the shore used to be, his shoes bumping up against the tips of the tree’s roots. He slowly raised his gaze.

The tree was still breathing, but it was different now. The cycle of expansion and contraction seemed faster, but more shallow, as though it were under duress. Izuku nearly tripped when he felt the roots shift, and looked down to see them stretching—or rather, trying to. The roots strained against the soil, reaching for a shoreline that no longer was. The tendrils swelled slightly as they leeched what little they could from the mud. It wasn’t enough. Izuku could almost feel its pain, there in the way it pulled itself to its limit. It wasn’t enough. Never again would it be enough.

As he stared, he felt the rise of something odd inside of him, a strange sort of contempt, with the bitter aftertaste of something that might have been pity.

All that power, Izuku thought. *All that power, and still, here you are.*

He took a few steps closer, scanning over the trunk, and up at the withering branches, as though searching for eyes. Something to look into, to *connect* to. But there was nothing. The closest thing to humanity which God had to offer was laid bare for him already. Even in a

death of its own design, its body still acted to prolong its survival. Just a second more. One last drop of suffering to quench its unending thirst.

There was plenty to be had, Izuku was sure. If it could extend its roots infinitely through the mud, he could only wonder how long it'd be able to sustain itself. But it couldn't. Despite his father's claim that God's form was merely an illusion meant to make him feel as though he could understand it, it sure did seem to be limiting it.

Then again, who's to say that was where the illusion ended? Maybe none of it was real. The tree, the sea of red, the blackhole sky. Maybe a more advanced being would see Izuku suspended in the midst of some unfathomable space, interfacing with something too abstract to describe in any human language.

It didn't matter. If there was a version of reality where that was the case, it did not concern him. Here, in this moment, Izuku was looking at the writhing body of a weakened God, its limbs outstretched in vain. It was dying. And either there truly was nothing it could do to stop it, or some higher alien instinct was preventing it from trying.

The longer he stood there staring at it, the more the pity seemed to take precedence. He found himself thinking back on what Arc had said, when he first brought them there to see it.

Does it deserve *this?*

He swallowed, throat going tight.

It was hard to say for certain. Izuku used to feel so confident, making assessments about the things that people *deserved.* These days, he wasn't even sure what that meant anymore, to *deserve* one's fate. It felt like an arbitrary judgement, something too entrenched in human existence to apply to God in any meaningful way—though still, he couldn't help but try.

It was true; most beings did not set the terms of their own existence. They did not decide what their needs were, they simply… were. And they could choose to fulfill their needs, or they could choose to die.

He assumed God was the same, in some sense. That it was subject to some sort of biological imperative outside of its own control. And maybe that was wrong. Maybe God *could* control things like that. It was difficult to wrap his head around, but it *would* make answering the question on his mind a lot less… morally difficult.

Because if God didn't choose to operate this way, if it truly had *no other option* but to sustain itself through human suffering… did it still *deserve* to die? Did they have the right to make that choice? Did they have the right to end its life?

Then again, it wasn't as though they were actively killing it. They were simply severing its access to sustenance. There was no moral imperative for them to keep God alive. If God could not sustain itself independently, then… well, that was it, wasn't it?

In the end, they weren't really *killing* God. They were simply… letting God die.

Izuku knew there was some distinction there, something deep and philosophical. But he couldn't put his finger on what it was, and frankly, he was too exhausted to try, even as the questions continued to buzz around at the back of his mind, unrelenting.

Without really meaning to, he found himself shuffling forward, closer and closer, until he was just inches away from its trunk. He raised a hand to it, and let it hover over its bark.

He wasn't sure what he was doing, really. Part of him worried this might be dangerous, though surely if it were, someone would've mentioned it to him by now. And so, shakily, Izuku reached across the distance, and gently laid his palm flat against the trunk.

And then…

Nothing.

Nothing happened.

The bark was rough beneath his skin, though it felt a bit odd to him, as though it were made from something closer to plastic than any organic matter he was familiar with. It wasn't particularly warm, nor was it cold—it seemed to match the ambient temperature of the chamber.

It continued to breathe quickly, in and out, and at his touch, neither the rate nor the depth of its breathing changed in any noticeable way. Izuku let his hand slip, falling limp at his side as a heavy feeling settled in his heart.

He wondered what he'd been expecting to happen. Maybe some sort of telepathic link, some window into God's mind that would allow him to empathize with the alien entity. Perhaps a rush of sensation, not unlike when he'd touched the water, the night he'd visited this place in his dreams. But no, of course that wouldn't be right. The water was a piece of humanity, a shared experience of suffering. God was not human. There was nothing for him to understand.

And as he stood there, it finally started to sink in.

This isn't for me.

Whatever secrets were entwined with the fabric of God's being were not his to know. He wouldn't be able to understand them. And even if he could, it wouldn't matter.

There was no path to enlightenment here. Just an overdue grave.

Just then, he heard the sound of the rickety door squealing open, and turned right as Katsuki popped his head through.

"Hey, nerd. You ready? We should go."

Katsuki took a few steps inside, and he had this look on his face, as though he was expecting to need to fight him on it. Izuku could actually see the surprise on his face when he simply nodded, turned his back on God, and proceeded across the wasteland. He accepted Katsuki's

hand as he helped him back up onto the boulder, and followed him toward the door, stepping through and shutting it behind him.

And in all that time, Izuku never looked back. Not even once.

The encampment was large and permeated by a sense of quiet unease. It was easy for Izuku to want to rush through it, to avoid the stares of the Angels who remained, who looked upon him with mixtures of fear and hatred in their eyes. It made sense, for them to look at him that way. As most of the Angels had Fallen by that point, naturally, the ones still hanging on would be only the most devout.

Izuku set his jaw and kept his eyes forward, making quick strides down the dirt road, only looking away when they passed the small house where the three captive Councilmen resided. Most of the Demons watching over them were inside, hidden from contempt of the remaining Angels. Only one person stood outside, guarding the door: Kirishima. He grinned sharp and wide when he saw them, and waved them over.

“Hi Kirishima,” Izuku said. And once he was close enough, Kirishima reached out and smacked him on the back of his shoulder, making him stumble forward with the force.

“Midoriya,” He said. “Glad to see you’re still in one piece!” He turned to Katsuki then. “You too, man!”

Katsuki just grunted. “Is Arc in there?”

“Uh, sorry—who?”

“Councilman Five,” Izuku clarified.

“Oh.” He said. “No, I don’t think so. I haven’t seen him out and about for a while. I think he’s in the other house.”

“What other house?” Katsuki asked.

Kirishima turned and pointed east. “It’s down the road that way,” he said. “Just around the bend. You’ll see it.”

Izuku offered a small smile. “Thanks.”

“Anytime, man.” He smiled back. “Let me know when you guys are free, by the way. We’ve got lots to catch up on.”

Katsuki answered with a reluctant groan at the same time Izuku chirped, “sure!” And they were on their way again.

Sure enough, they spotted it as soon as they hit the turn at the end of the road—a small cottage quaintly nestled in with the greenery. They entered through the front door to the sparkling sound of wind chimes, and as Izuku stepped inside, he was struck by just how well-

kept it was. It had either been recently vacated, or someone put a lot of effort into cleaning it up.

The bedroom was just around the corner, and as they came in, they found Kindred sleeping soundly in a double bed at the center of the room. It was still quite early, and through the window they could see the first strokes of color running across the mountainous horizon as the sun peaked over the valley.

Two Acolytes bustled about on either side of the bed, their hands busy rigging up some sort of helmet contraption, hooked up to a screen in the corner. They raised their heads as they entered the room, despite their blindfolds remaining in place, but didn't acknowledge them otherwise.

After a moment, Izuku cleared his throat. "Um. What's that for?" He asked.

The Acolytes paused, as though they weren't quite sure if they should answer. Finally, one of them responded.

"To monitor his brain activity." He said. "It's so we'll know when to sedate him again, if necessary."

"Huh." Katsuki said. "So you're really gonna wake him up, then?"

"That's the plan." Arc said, entering the room. The words were muffled by the toothbrush in his mouth. He crossed the length of the room and closed the curtains, before ducking back into the bathroom to rinse his mouth out. He stepped out into the room again, looking at them suspiciously. "What do you want?"

"It's empty." Katsuki said. "How long d'you think it'll be?"

Arc scoffed. "Why should I tell you?"

Izuku frowned. "Why *wouldn't* you? I can't think of a good reason for you to want to keep that a secret."

Arc seemed to tense, as though he'd only just then considered it. He averted his eyes. "Look, I don't know." He sighed. "I have a feeling it'll happen sometime tomorrow morning."

Katsuki raised an eyebrow. "What *feeling* is that?"

"It's hard to explain." He said. "As Councilmen, we just *feel* things. The blood creates a connection, and through that, we can kind of… intuit things like this." He shrugged. "I bet Kindred would be able to tell you with greater certainty. His dosage is significantly higher than mine. Always has been."

"Oh." Izuku said. "Well, I guess we can just stick around and ask him, since you're waking him up anyway."

"Yeah, absolutely not." Arc shot back. "I'd rather not have the first thing he sees upon waking up be two random fucking Demons. We're trying *not* to stress him out, remember?"

Katsuki opened his mouth to retort, but stopped when Izuku tugged on the bottom of his shirt. *Just drop it. It's not worth it,* He almost mouthed. Katsuki sighed.

"Alright. We can respect that." Izuku said.

Arc stared at them a moment longer, his eyes narrowed, betraying skepticism. "Good." He finally said. "Is that all, then? We've got about ten minutes before the anesthesia wears off."

"Oh, um. I mean, I guess, but…" Izuku bit his lip. "Are you sure about this?"

"About what?"

"I mean…" He looked over at Kindred. "That he'll survive."

"Of course I'm not *sure."* Arc said. "But it's possible. At least in theory, he should be able to survive the withdrawal."

"As long as he thinks he can't." Katsuki supplied.

Arc hesitated. "Yeah."

"And what if he chooses not to use his powers?"

"That's… not really something I'm concerned about."

"Why not?" Katsuki frowned. "Seems like a pretty obvious issue."

For a minute, Arc did not speak, though the look of caution on his face served as a shadow for the thoughts inside his head.

"There's more to it, isn't there?" Izuku said. "There's something you're not telling us."

Arc said nothing.

"Arc."

"It's…" Arc raked a hand through his hair. "Well, the thing is, in the past, there's been… cases of him using his powers… unintentionally."

Izuku could see Katsuki going tense at his side.

"He fucking *what?"* Katsuki said, low and dangerous. "And you want us to keep him alive? *Seriously?* Arc. This kid's a ticking fucking time bomb."

"It doesn't always happen." Arc said. "Once he's off the blood, it'll happen less often. Probably."

"Probably." Katsuki drawled.

"Yes, fucking probably!" Arc snapped. "Look, I never said I had all the answers, I just don't want him to fucking *die,* okay?! Is that too much to ask? That you don't fucking kill my—"

He cut himself off, and it was quiet.

“Arc.” Izuku said carefully. “Listen… I know you feel very strongly about this. About him. But this isn’t just about you. If something goes wrong, it affects everyone.”

“I know that. But if you were in my position, wouldn’t you do the same?”

“Personally, I would’ve simply *not* gotten attached to the one guy capable of accidentally destroying the entire fucking universe.” Katsuki said.

Arc glared at him, and Katsuki glared back. For a few seconds, neither of them spoke.

“If this is really that important to you, why don’t *you* take care of him?” Katsuki asked.

“I *am* taking care—“

“No.” Katsuki cut him off. “I mean *after.* If he manages to survive.”

“Hard to do things like that when you’re fucking *dead.”*

“Oh, fuck off. We all know that’s not the only option.” He sneered. “If he can save himself, there’s no reason why he can’t save you too. Why do you wanna die so fucking bad, *huh?”*

“Shouldn’t you be glad?” Arc snapped. “You assholes are always getting on our backs about ‘practicing what we preach.’ Well, I’m doing it.”

“Sacrifice isn’t a virtue in and of itself.” Katsuki said. “It has to be *for* something. A sacrifice without a cause is just a glorified suicide.”

For a long time, Arc remained silent, only the sound of Kindred’s heart monitor filling the space. He opened his mouth to reply, but just then, Kindred began to stir in bed.

“Wha—Whass—“ he muttered groggily. Arc rushed to his bedside.

“Get out.” He hissed. They didn’t move at first. Arc’s head snapped toward them, but where Izuku expected to see fury, he found only fear. *“Now.”*

Izuku moved first, taking Katsuki by the arm and ushering him out. They left to the sound of Arc speaking to Kindred, his voice as gentle as the wind chimes on the porch, blowing softly in the summer breeze.

It was strange, being on the train again. Its subtle vibrations were familiar to Izuku, but the week spent in heaven felt like a lifetime, and somehow, his body didn’t expect to find itself back here again, though mentally he was relieved.

It was around two in the afternoon when they finally returned to Hell, and half-past three by the time they’d packed their things and checked out of the hotel. The train from Erykos to Oseryth was packed, but they’d managed to capture two seats in the corner.

All around them, people sat dozing off or reading, and Izuku clutched his bag closer to his chest. He still had his library books, but after everything that happened, he just couldn't find the energy to read any of them.

When they finally got back to Katsuki's apartment several hours later, Izuku was ready to pass out. He flopped down in bed, and pulled the covers over himself.

"We should shower." Katsuki said, standing over him. Izuku whined, pulling the blankets over his head. "Deku…"

"I'm too tired." He said. "I'll shower tomorrow."

"Well, at least take off your fuckin' *jeans,* loser." Izuku answered with a groan, and Katsuki scoffed. "You know you'll regret it if you don't."

Izuku considered this for a moment, and then, with a tired sigh, he sluggishly pulled back the covers and unbuttoned his jeans, trying to peel them off without having to move too much. It was a surprisingly difficult process, each movement punctuated by tiny grunts of frustration. Eventually, Katsuki just grabbed the top of his jeans and tried to pull them off. Izuku grabbed the headboard to keep from sliding down the mattress, and finally, he was free of them

"There." Katsuki said, tossing the jeans into the hamper. "Isn't that better?"

"Not enough to justify the effort."

"Would've been a hell of a lot less effort if you just got up like a normal person."

"I don't wanna be normal. I wanna be *asleep."*

Katsuki snorted, shedding his own clothes before joining him in bed. He switched off the lamp, and a moment later Izuku felt the heat of his chest pressing against his back. He settled into his embrace and closed his eyes.

"Tomorrow morning, there's somewhere I wanna take you." Katsuki said. "It's not too far from here."

Izuku hummed, barely comprehending his words as he slipped further and further. He felt Katsuki plant a gentle kiss on the back of his neck, and allowed himself to drift away.

The train came to a stop, and Izuku followed Katsuki out onto the black platform. The terrain beyond was rocky and uneven, the horizon pierced by mountains speckled with trees. There was no trail as far as Izuku could see, but he didn't miss the confidence in Katsuki's step when he turned and headed toward the mountain.

Morning light filtered through the leaves in the sparse forest, painting Katsuki's form in abstract patterns that Izuku found himself focusing on as he trailed behind him.

It was tough, at first. The forest was nowhere near as dense as the Depths were, but the ground was covered in a bed of dry leaves that made it hard to judge where you were

stepping, and every once in a while, Izuku would get smacked in the face with a branch. Katsuki apologized every time it happened, but never without a smile on his face that was just a touch too wide for Izuku's liking.

The forest cleared out as the elevation increased, and eventually, they found themselves on something resembling a trail, winding around the mountain. It'd been about twenty minutes at that point.

"How much further up the mountain is it?" Izuku asked, panting slightly.

"Not all the way. We're gettin' pretty close to it now."

"Close to what, exactly?"

"I already told you—you'll find out soon enough."

Izuku sighed, and they walked in silence for a few more minutes. Just as Izuku was about to pester him again, Katsuki slowed to a stop. He turned to his left, squinting as he peered through the bushes and trees that framed the mountain trail.

"Kacchan…?"

Katsuki looked back at him and grinned. "We're here."

And that was all he said before he diverged from the trail, leading Izuku into a patch of dense woods. The leaves and branches seemed to poke out from all directions, stabbing into every patch of exposed skin on Izuku's body. Fortunately, the path through this portion wound up being short. He sighed in relief as he stepped out of the bushes alongside Katsuki, picking leaves out of his hair.

"What d'you think?" Katsuki asked.

"Eh?" He looked up.

It was only then that he actually noticed their surroundings.

They were standing at the edge of a large clearing, and the glow of the morning sun shone through the trees. The area was framed by a border of deliberately placed rocks, and curiously, there was an patch near the center where the grass seemed to be scorched.

And then there were the flowers.

Hundreds, perhaps thousands of small, orange flowers grew throughout the meadow, each as vibrant as a tiny flame.

"Bet you could pick some of these, dry 'em out and make your own tea." Katsuki said, nudging the stem of a nearby flower with his boot. "'Course, there's probably not much point in it now—unless you just like it, I guess."

Izuku turned and looked at him. "Kacchan, you're… is this what I think it is?"

“No, Deku.” He drawled. “I just decided to take you to a random-ass field of flowers.”

Izuku scoffed. “Don’t be mean.”

“M’just joking, nerd.”

“So?”

“Yeah.”

“I see.”

Fire lilies.

Izuku looked at a nearby flower, crouching down beside it. He reached out for it, but hesitated, his hand hovering over the stem as he looked up at Katsuki, who glared at him lightly.

“Are you askin’ me for *permission* to pick a fuckin’ flower?”

Izuku blushed. “Uh. Maybe?”

He snorted. “Nobody *owns* this land, nerd. If you wanna pick a flower, you can just fuckin’ do it.”

Izuku shook his head and sighed, picking the flower from the ground. He moved from his crouching position to sit down in the grass, spun the lily between his fingers a few times before raising it to his nose to sniff it. The floral scent was underscored with notes of ash and something sweet, like burnt sugar. It wasn’t too different from the way fire tea smelled, but the subtleties were more pronounced, and of course, it was much fresher.

Katsuki sat down with a grunt. “That’s from a few weeks ago.”

“Hmm?” Izuku looked up, realizing he was pointing at a spot nearby, where the grass had been scorched clean, and the only plants that remained were the fire lilies. “What were you doing?”

“Just practicing a new technique. I’d offer to show you, but it’d be too dangerous up close. Just imagine, like… a tornado, but on fire.”

“Oh. Um. That sounds…” Izuku squinted, *“intense.”*

“It is.” Katsuki said, leaning back on his palms. “But that’s why I come out here. Always nice to have a spot you can use to practice bigger moves, and it’s basically required if those moves have the potential to go really fuckin’ wrong.” He looked at Izuku. “You can use it, too, if you want.”

He smiled. “Thanks, Kacchan. I don’t know if I’ll be creating any fire tornados anytime soon, though.”

“Yeah, not with *that* fuckin’ attitude.”

Izuku giggled.

“For the record, there’s plenty of easier moves you’d probably still need the space for. Especially if you end up going for something like Pride.” Katsuki hummed. “Which reminds me—have you thought about that at all?”

“Not really.” Izuku admitted. “Honestly, with everything that’s been going on…”

“It probably hasn’t exactly been your top priority,” Katsuki finished.

“Right.” He said. “That said… I’m not sure. I feel like I kind of like them all for different reasons.”

“Mm. Well, you can keep thinkin’ about it. No rush. And technically you could just choose to pursue all at once… I mean, I think it’d be kinda stupid, but if that’s what you wanna do…” He shrugged. “And besides, wouldn’t want you to pick a class before I’ve had the chance to *really* show you the ropes with the *best* class.”

As if to emphasize, Katsuki picked a lily and set it ablaze in his grasp. Izuku watched, half irritated at the needless destruction, half transfixed at the sight. The blackening of petals, the disintegration of leaves. Within seconds, it was but a handful of ash in Katsuki’s hand. He dropped the remains into the grass, brushing off his palms.

“Was that really necessary?” Izuku asked.

“Oh, boo-hoo.” He rolled his eyes. “The fire giveth, the fire taketh away.”

Izuku snorted, Katsuki threw him a smirk, and then for a while, it was quiet. He stared at the small pile of blackened ash in the grass, and his thoughts began to stray.

He wanted to enjoy the moment, and in most ways, he supposed that he was. It was nice, just getting to be there with Katsuki, relaxing in comfortable silence. No responsibilities, no fears. Just the two of them, together beneath the red sky. They basked in the morning sun, and the knowledge that despite everything, they both had survived. Nothing could take that away from them.

But…

Izuku sighed, shifting around restlessly.

“Oi,” Katsuki grunted. “What’s with that fuckin’ constipated look on your face?”

Izuku blinked a few times, and shook his head. “It’s nothing.”

“Deku.”

“Sorry. I want to turn my brain off and just enjoy this, but I can’t stop… thinking.” He bit his lip. And then, in a small voice, he asked, “It’s not over, is it?”

Katsuki's breath seemed to catch, and he didn't respond immediately.

"No." He finally said. "I mean, I fuckin' wish. But shit's just not that simple." He stared into the distance for a second, then closed his eyes. "I imagine a lot of 'em will come around, eventually. Maybe even most of 'em. But the others…" He exhaled sharply. "Well, we've got the upper hand, now. But that doesn't mean it's *over."*

Izuku nodded. "I guess… I guess there's not much they can do, in the short term. Since they won't know how to fight as Demons. At least not for a while."

"That's true. But then there's the Acolytes. Who the fuck knows what'll happen with them, since they *allegedly* can't Fall…" He said. "They've been cooperating so far—*mostly*—but I'm sure they're planning something."

"Maybe Endeavor can help us there."

"Maybe. If he really *is* on our side."

"He's the newest Acolyte. He can't be in *that* deep."

"We'll see."

With that, it was quiet again. He tried to clear his thoughts, focus on his surroundings. The morning sun was warm against his skin. Somewhere in the distance, birds Izuku had never seen were singing melodies he'd never heard.

He picked another fire lily, and twirled it between his fingertips. Then, on impulse, he plucked the head of the flower from its stem. "Kacchan, look this way."

"Hmm?" Katsuki raised an eyebrow as he turned toward him. And with a smile on his face, Izuku leaned in and proceeded to stick the flower in his hair—quickly, before he could protest.

"There." He held his fingers up in a square shape, framing Katsuki's amused expression. "Perfect."

Katsuki scoffed, but made no move to remove the flower. "Yeah? How do I look?"

"Stunning." And he'd meant to say it in a sort of joking, lightly ironic way, but when the word left his lips, the syllables wove together into something deeper, and strikingly sincere. Katsuki held his gaze for a moment in silence, and just as Izuku was beginning to feel nervous, he sighed, shaking his head lightly, and proceeded to pick a flower himself. He leaned in, slotting the lily behind his ear, and grinned.

"Now *there's* a pretty picture. Ya wanna see stunning, look in the mirror.

Izuku snorted, and then they began to lean toward each other simultaneously, as if responding to some magnetic pull. Katsuki's lips pressed against Izuku's in a slow, familiar slide. Like they had all the time in the world. In that moment, they might as well have. He cupped

Izuku's cheek with one warm palm, and when he finally pulled away, he grinned, thumb rubbing circles over his cheekbone.

"What?"

"Nothin,'" he said. "It's just that the color of your hair kinda makes it look like the flower belongs there. Like it just sprouted from you, or something."

Izuku giggled, leaning in to kiss him again. As he pulled away, he exhaled, resting his head on Katsuki's shoulder.

Time passed, and eventually Izuku found himself sitting with his back to Katsuki's chest beneath the shade of one of the trees. They were well into morning at that point, the sun climbing above the trees.

Sometime around morning, Arc had said. And now Izuku couldn't help but wonder.

"…Do you think it's happened yet?"

He didn't need to explain what he was talking about. Katsuki knew.

"Well… if Arc was right, it's very possible. But I dunno. Bet Luke or Levi would have more info. I could contact them, if you want."

"No." Izuku said, a bit too quickly. "No, that's… I'm… honestly not sure if I *want* to know."

Katsuki didn't say anything, at first. His arms tightened around him slightly, head tucking into his shoulder.

"…Do you regret it?"

Izuku startled. "What? No, of course not." He said, and meant it.

Just across the meadow, the tree tops rustled. A small, yellow bird came to land on an exposed branch. One of the birds than sung, perhaps.

"But it hurts." Katsuki said.

"…Yeah." Izuku looked down. "It, uhh… I think it always kind of will." He took a deep breath and sighed. "But I don't regret it. It had to be done… so that things could get better. Honestly, I'm kind of worried about the other Angels. If all of this had happened a year ago, before I'd met you… I can't even *imagine* the kind of despair I'd go through."

Katsuki hummed, chest rumbling against his back. "It's always like that, when the world changes. People always end up gettin' burnt. You can try to minimize it, but you'll never prevent it completely."

Izuku nodded slowly. "And… in the long run, I know less people will suffer. But… right now…"

“It sucks.” Katsuki finished. After a pause, he continued. “Even when you know it’s the right thing, it’s still hard when you’re directly involved. No one wants to be the person who pulls the trigger.”

“But someone has to do it.”

“Yeah.” Katsuki said. “It’s rough. But things will get better, eventually.”

Izuku reached out and picked a flower. He held it in front of his face, blocking out the sun as he twirled it. Like this, it really did look like a tiny flame, vibrant and beautiful. *To think such a thing could grow from the ashes of what came before it…* Izuku brought it to his nose and inhaled a scent both familiar and new.

The sound of chirping caught Izuku’s attention, and he turned to look across the meadow. He found the same bird, now perched near a nest in the hollow of the tree.

“Kacchan, look.” He pointed at the birds.

“Hmm?” Katsuki turned, resting his cheek against the top of Izuku’s head, and his breath hitched slightly.

The mother bird hopped closer to the nest, a worm hanging from her beak. At first, it looked like she was going to feed them, but she never quite got close enough, lingering just out of reach.

Eventually, one of the birds emerged from the nest, inching along the thick branch. But just when the fledgling was about to reach her, the mother retreated, flying down and landing on a lower branch in a neighboring tree.

The young bird went to the very end of the branch, as close as it could get without falling off, and strained forward still, looking around, uncertain.

“Teaching ‘em to fly, looks like.” Katsuki said. Izuku nodded, and watched with bated breath as the baby bird teetered on the end of the branch.

After a minute, the mother flew back up to the branch, and then returned to the lower one, as if to give the fledgling an example to copy. It seemed to have some effect, as the bird soon extended its wings, flapping a few times, like it was testing it out, seeing how it felt.

“Come on, you can do it.” Izuku said, under his breath.

And finally, it happened. In one burst, the fledgling leapt from the branch, flapping its wings clumsily to slow its descent. It landed a bit rough, but didn’t seem injured. The mother bird met it where it was, rewarding its efforts.

“Thank goodness.” Izuku sighed, as Katsuki seemed to relax behind him.

“Wild, huh?”

He nodded. “I don’t know how they’re able to do that from so high up.”

Katsuki shrugged. “Guess they all have to eventually.”

“Still,” Izuku said. “It must be terrifying. What if they just fell? They could get really hurt, or worse.”

“Sure, but if they stayed up there, they’d just starve.” Katsuki said. “It’s a risk, but the alternative’s death. You should understand the thought process better than anyone, nerd.”

“What do you—*Ah.”* It hit him then. *Of course.*

He remembered looking over the flight runway, the ensuing vertigo. The sensation of wind whipping through his hair and clothing, as his wings flapped uselessly in an effort to slow his descent.

It was terrifying in the moment—of course it was. But looking back, Izuku knew that even then, there was some part of him that still held onto hope. Somewhere deep inside, he knew that Katsuki was out there, that he would be there, waiting.

Izuku reached for Katsuki’s hand, and laced their fingers together.

“Falling isn’t so bad if you have someone to catch you.”

Katsuki released a single, soft laugh, little more than a sharp exhalation of air. “Yeah.” He said. “Guess I can’t argue with that.”

Out in the wildlands of Hell, where the arid, rocky terrain met the sparse forests of the East, there stood a tiny town that time forgot. A place where the bombs left the buildings intact yet void of all color, leached away by the sterilizing force of divinity.

Nothing lived in the lost town anymore. Animals and people alike took care to avoid it, for although nothing resided within its colorless bounds, they knew the town harbored a deadly contagion, unparalleled by any virus or bacteria. A sickness that penetrated deeper than flesh, and promised to infect all who walked within. Thus, the town remained there, an overexposed snapshot of a place that once was, serving only to remind all of what had been lost.

Toward the edges of the town, the land gradually faded from white to grey, then grey to brown. Things seldom grew in those areas, and what managed to sprout would usually die in time, as the soil was void of nutrients. It would be several miles in either direction before one found any place where plants could thrive.

And so the lonely town remained quiet, subject only to the sounds of wind and rain. At the center of town square sat a fountain, where rainwater would sometimes accumulate, filling and drying out periodically. It was late in the summer, and the fountain was full, the water still. And then it wasn’t.

A small, yellow songbird had landed at the edge of the fountain, its toes touching the water, making it ripple. It was a young osren, a species native to the Eastern region of Hell. The

osren drank from the fountain, ruffled its feathers and dipped into the water, shaking itself dry before it fluttered up to the peak of the fountain. It sat there for a moment, head turning jerkily as it looked at the town surrounding it, still and lifeless as ever.

The wind blew in from the north, and the bird took flight, soaring through the clear red sky. The sun had risen. It was a new day.

Chapter End Notes

Welp, there you have it. This isn't fully the end, as I've planned an epilogue, but that concludes the main story lol. Sorry this took so fucking long, like I mentioned in the beginning notes, I actually got my first job as a software engineer in late February, and the learning curve was pretty steep. I'm doing better now tho

I wanna take a second to just say thank you to everyone who has stuck with this fic to the end. This story is really near and dear to my heart, and I cannot tell you all how amazing it's been seeing all the fan art and just general enthusiasm. Seriously, thank you so much.

I think I'll probably print this, if the unwieldy word count isn't too much to be bound lol. I just wanna hold it in my hands because this is by far the longest story I've completed lol.

Also, a couple new things. I made a dumb quiz that tells u which one of the original Demons you are. You can take it here,
and if u do, lemme know who u got lol

But more importantly, I made another song for this fic. It's a piano solo piece, and and it's 13 minutes long, with 7 distinct sections, 3 keys and 4 different time signatures. Idk why i'm like this, but I'm really proud of it and I'd love it if y'all listened to it (because i worked rly hard on it lol). There's explanations for each part in the description. You can think of this as a bit of foreshadowing for the next fic I have planned, where original piano pieces are actually woven into the story lol. You can listen to it here!
There will probably be two updates to this fic after this, one being the aforementioned epilogue and the other being a sort of meta "making-of" type thing where I go into the planning of this story, what I would change if I could go back and write it all again, and maybe a bit of extra fun facts. Idk, some people expressed interest in that so yeah lol. The meta section will probably come out before the epilogue, which isn't ideal ordering-wise, but it's easier to write lol

Anyway, I'm sure I've forgotten something, because there's so much that needs to be said, but at least for now, I think that does it. Again, thank you all so much for reading, and consider leaving a comment if you enjoyed it!

Links and shit:
Fire Lily Wiki
Spotify Playlist
Song I made for this fic
Twitter Hashtag
Deku's Costume Designs
Other miscellaneous shit

Works inspired by this one

Fire Lily [Podfic] by TheGreyWych

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!